immemorial (anachronism, book two)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/28511895.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Original Villain Character, He-Man | Adam, Teela (He-Man), Marlena (He-Man), Randor (He-Man), Sorceress of Castle Grayskull | Zoar the Falcon

Additional Tags:
Canon Compliant, Angst, Post-Canon, married Adora and Catra, Space Adventures!, magic!, worldbuilding!, adora and catra being cute and domestic!, this fic will hurt you and i'm sorry, adora is kinda having a breakdown this whole fic but it's fine, Protective Catra, sleep deprivation is kinda a major theme here, chasm is gone ahahahah...unless?, i'll add more tags as things progress okay, definitely read the first book first!!!, includes illustrations, Following tags contain spoilers, Possession, magical potions, Adora and Catra rediscover Eternia, im making up my OWN he-man shit yeehaw

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English

Series:
Part 2 of the chasm saga, Part 6 of the catradora brain rot collection

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by chellethewriter

Summary

All should be well for Adora and Catra. They have successfully escaped from that netherworld between dimensions—defeated the cruel magical entity known as Chasm, and returned Angella to her family. And they are together now, back on Etheria. Safe from Chasm in a universe where peace still reigns.

But regardless of how she tries, or how Catra attempts to soothe her, Adora cannot shake her unease. Images of Chasm and wounded loved ones continue to torture Adora in vivid nightmares, nightmares that cannot be treated or willed away. Nightmares that force Adora to wonder whether Chasm dealt Adora some kind of lifelong curse, back before her escape from Chasm's dreamworld.

And worst of all, even with a dimension of separation between them...Adora cannot quell the fear that Chasm might someday return. Return, and again seek She-Ra's power for herself.

(as promised, the angsty sequel to **anachronism**)

Notes

hi all! welcome back to weekly updates of anachronism (though in this case, the title is *immemorial*). You're in for a wild ride involving magic, space adventures, lots of additional worldbuilding, and—of course—catradora being married! This fic will be pretty different than its predecessor, but hopefully you'll like it just as much! I've written about 60k words so far so hopefully it's finished in its entirety before break ends and is ready to be edited.

THAT BEING SAID....If you want to read this fic, you really, really, **really, need to read anachronism** first! Otherwise, you'll have no clue what's going on. it's definitely a fun fic to read if you like time travel and portal shenanigans and maybe, just maybe, a little dark magic mixed in there.

In other news, I'm also trying something new here in that I'm forcing myself to draw. That means some of these chapters might have some accompanying artwork by me. However, I hate my artwork with a passion so if you'd like to create something of your own, please just let me know, as always.

Anyway, I hope y'all enjoy! Please please please leave a comment or kudos! I've been sick with a stomach bug all week and I'd really appreciate some feedback to read as a distraction.

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1

Laughter slices across Adora's ears—sharper, crueler than the biting edge of a knife. It sounds like a woman's laugh, at first. But no...it's not. It's *his* laugh, monstrous and so damned amused. Adora positively burns with the need to silence it. She can't bear the thought of him winning, of him smiling as he tears her future from her grasp—

And that's when she sees him there. Right there, in front of her. Smiling in that snide, arrogant way he always did, right until the very end. Right until She-Ra blasted him from existence.

But that was another time. Another *timeline*. A safer, happier one. One that Adora will never see again.

Horde Prime stands above her, on a dais. Mocking her, challenging her. Multitudes of green eyes blinking, staring, *taunting*. And there's something Adora needs to do. Something she needs to find, and fix—

With a cry, she lunges forward, jumping clear over the stairs, her feet smashing fissures into the floor as she crashes into metal. Her knuckles stretch white as she twists her fingers into his robe, pulling, yanking him within reach of her weapons and fists and fury—

"Her body," Adora hisses, nearly spitting the words into his face. "Where—is—her—body?"

And vaguely, she knows that she doesn't sound like herself. Not like this; so seething, so fractured.

But there it is again—that horrible, sickening, remorseless laugh. She wants to tear out those vocal cords. She wants….she *wants*—

But there's nothing left to want.

She doesn't wait for an answer this time. Adora already knows—she knows that Catra is gone. Fully, completely, irrevocably gone. There's no point, no point to anything at all. There's only this, this fleeting, sick-sweet taste of revenge—no more substantial than a lone star in a blank sky.

And it's right there, after all. Her sword. Already clutched tightly in her free hand. But it shakes. She can't stop shaking—

With another cry, she drives it forward. Her eyes scrunch shut as she embeds it deep into Horde Prime's chest, pinning him to the nearest solid surface with the impaled tip of her blade. She refuses to look. It's enough to know. It's enough to know that she caused him some measure of pain.

Isn't it?

But then there's that laugh again. Or...something like it. High and amused and something like Horde Prime's, but somehow entirely not. A woman's laugh. Like the one Adora heard, at first, but quickly dismissed.

Her eyes still shut, Adora feels hands curl around her shoulders. She jolts in fear, in surprise, as something leans close, a mouth breathing ice-cold air into her ear—

"One down..." the voice whispers eagerly, and it's like Adora can *hear* the smile creeping across the woman's face. "...and a whole universe to go."

Adora knows that voice. She can't forget. She could never—

Adora thrashes out of that foreign grasp and, with a terrified gasp, her eyes finally tear open—

But it's not….it's not *him*. She doesn't see what she expects when she opens her eyes. She doesn't see Horde Prime impaled upon her sword, unnatural green blood seeping from his wounds. She sees something else entirely. *Someone* else.

Catra. It's Catra, right there, chest heaving as she struggles to breathe. She-Ra's glowing sword piercing through her stomach, the blade surrounded by a growing pool of dark red. Her blue-yellow eyes rolling backward and tears tracking down her cheeks —

But. It can't be Catra. That was Horde Prime. It was Horde Prime, not Catra. Adora saw that. She saw *him*—

But Catra is right there, dying from wounds inflicted by Adora's sword.

"No," Adora chokes out, staggering backward. The sword falls out of her hand, out of Catra's body. And Adora just can't stop shaking her head, pulling furiously at her own hair as though she might wrench herself from her own disbelief. "No, no, no, no—!"

Catra immediately falls to the floor, blood spilling onto the ground, and Adora collapses with her. Desperately, Adora tries to crawl to her. Tries to reach her. Heal her. She can fix this, she can, that's the whole point of She-Ra...but dammit, Catra just gets farther away with every inch that Adora crawls—

"...A-Adora—" Catra rasps, a bloodied hand outstretched. And she needs Adora. Catra *needs* her—

Adora screams in frustration, still trying to crawl. To drag herself across the cold floor. But it doesn't help. Nothing helps. The floor keeps extending—the space between Catra and Adora widening by the second, rapidly unfolding into an ocean of insurmountable darkness,

And, of course, someone's still laughing at her. Laughing like nothing could be funnier than this: Adora's frantic helplessness, her repeated failures to reach Catra, even from a hair's breadth away.

"...Adora…"

Why can't Adora do this? Why can't she reach Catra?

"Adora!"

She can't give up. She can't. Catra is there, right there. Just a little farther—

"Princess Adora!"

With a gasp, Adora shoots to her feet, knocking a chair to the ground with an unholy clatter. There's someone there, beside Adora, hands curled around her shoulders—

She fumbles for her sword, and the weapon takes less than a second to materialize in her hand. On instinct, her arm flies out, the blade poised in a deadly, determined grip as she points it at whoever snuck up on her—

There's a squeal of fright, and a figure stumbles back and tumbles gracelessly to the floor.

"Please *don't* stab me!" a familiar voice begs, cowering slightly. "I'm only trying to help!"

A bead of sweat trickles down Adora's forehead as her eyes sweep the room. Only slowly does she remember and recognize where she is—and who shook her awake.

Adora is surrounded by books on all sides. Cases upon cases of them, each of them neatly kept and carefully organized. Her thighs bruise against the edge of a wooden table, one covered with papers and scrolls and books thrown open upon their spines.

It's George and Lance's library, she realizes. The massive library owned by Bow's fathers. One that is filled, in particular, with infinite pages and artifacts from the First Ones, or other ancient Etherian cultures. Subjects that Adora has been somewhat obsessed with researching in recent days, trying to find…well…

Something to make it all make sense.

She must have drifted off here, reading at the table. It's hardly surprising given Adora's recent circumstances, or the exhausting number of hours she's spent poring over these old books. But falling asleep was hardly her intention.

Frankly, Adora has been trying to avoid sleep entirely. It sounds stupid, she knows, but there isn't much of a choice. Sleep is unbearable, it has been for months. And no one is listening to her despite the fact that there's a clear *solution*—

Though she didn't expect anyone to come looking for her. Or really, she *hoped* no one would come looking for her*.*

"Sorry, Cleo," Adora sighs, lowering her sword from the neck of the Bright Moon guard who Adora has come to know as her unwanted personal babysitter. "You startled me, is all."

Adora dematerializes the sword and outstretches a hand, offering to help Cleo to her feet. Cleo's uniform is all askew, her face covered by the long black horse hairs that normally flow from the back of her helmet, her own red hair all mussed up beneath the helmet itself.

"It's alright," says Cleo, all-too-eager to forgive as she grasps onto Adora's hand.

Easily, Adora lifts Cleo back to her feet, and mere moments pass before Cleo is back to her smiling, overexcited self. Freckled cheeks spread into a childlike grin, wide eyes glinting. "I mean—just wait until I tell my friends that I was almost stabbed by She-Ra! They'll be so impressed."

"She's a trainee," Glimmer told Adora, back when Cleo was first assigned to guard Adora. "*And guarding She-Ra is pretty much the easiest job I can give her right now."*

That was a year ago. Back then, Adora didn't mind Cleo's immaturity so much. They barely spoke, barely interacted. But no one expected things to change so quickly. Suddenly, Cleo has

found herself with much more to do. And Adora has discovered many reasons to resent Cleo's presence.

Adora wonders what else Cleo tells her friends. Does she tell them how She-Ra is now a nervous wreck, slowly losing her mind and unable to sleep?

"Uh-huh," replies Adora, turning around to set the toppled chair upright too. "And what are you doing here, exactly? I mean, no offense, but I left early to avoid being—"

"Is this where you always go when you run off?" Cleo blurts, open-mouthed as she glances between the wide rows of bookcases. Cleo's hand extends to touch one of the books sprawled across the table. "I mean, it's cool and all, but why are you spending so much time in an abandoned library?"

Adora drags the book out of Cleo's reach and slams it shut.

"It's not abandoned," Adora says, and pointedly begins searching for the book's place on the shelves. "This library belongs to King Bow's fathers—they've just been on an archeological dig for the past couple years. They asked Bow to look after it while they're gone but, obviously, he has a whole kingdom to help run, so I offered—"

Adora cuts herself off as she notices that Cleo isn't really listening. Instead, her eyes are affixed to the glow of a tracker pad—the tips of Cleo's fingers tapping against the screen.

Adora snaps her fingers in front of Cleo's face, causing her to start —and forcing Cleo to return her attention to Adora's face.

"How'd you find me, anyway?" Adora demands.

"Oh, that's easy," Cleo says with a wave of her hand. "Catra told me."

Tense annoyance edges between Adora's shoulder blades. "...*Catra* told you?"

Adora thought, at least, that Catra had enough respect for Adora's judgment that she wouldn't send guards after her. That's why she leaves a note for Catra every morning—one that very clearly describes where Adora will be, and when she'll be back. And sure, sometimes she returns later than she originally planned, but Adora really can't afford to lose her train of thought in her research—

The point is...Catra is supposed to trust Adora. And in turn, Adora is supposed to trust Catra to *not* send the Bright Moon guards after her.

Cleo sighs. "She knew you'd be mad."

Adora gives a sigh of her own, arms crossing over her chest. "I'm not mad. I'm just…" Another sigh. "Surprised, I guess."

It's a lie. But even Adora recognizes that Cleo is just doing her job, and doesn't deserve to be on the receiving end of Adora's annoyance. Because, really, it's Catra that she's annoyed with. And Glimmer. And her own damn brain.

And, of course, there's one person that Adora is *most* furious at. But she's beyond the reach of Adora's fury at the moment.

"Catra said that normally she'd let you be," Cleo continues, "but it's just...you've been out for so long, and you're really late to some sort of important meeting in Bright Moon, and everyone was getting worried—"

Wait. Late to *what*?

Adora glances at the nearby windows and curses when she sees the blood orange skies beyond. When did it get so dark outside? Last Adora recalls, morning had just crested the horizon. But now it's like this, with the bookcases casting long shadows and the sun dipping below the treeline…

Cleo must be right. Adora was scheduled to attend some sort of intergalactic conference call *thing* this afternoon. And if the sunset

outside is any indication, that meeting has likely already started.

Which means that Adora has *once again* lost track of time.

Adora pinches the bridge of her nose. Truthfully, it's no wonder why Catra sent someone after her. Adora promised to stay in the library for only a short time. It's likely been hours since she was supposed to be back in Bright Moon.

"I'm contacting Queen Glimmer right now," Cleo says, all assurance, and Adora hears the characteristic beeps of tracker pad feedback. "She's going to teleport you back–"

"Swift Wind is outside," Adora says. "If she's not picking up, I can fly him back—"

Cleo's eyes narrow. She lowers the tracker pad slightly to shoot Adora an accusing look. "Wait. Catra said you walked here."

"It was a tight schedule today," Adora insists. "There wasn't enough time to walk—"

"Queen Glimmer said you're not permitted to ride any horses while you're…"

Cleo trails off. Adora glares at her, hard.

"While I'm what?" Adora demands.

Cleo hesitates.

"While you're...recovering," Cleo decides.

Adora raises an eyebrow, sure that *recovering* is a euphemism for something.

"I'm calling the Queen," Cleo tells her. "She'll teleport you, me, and Swift Wind." Cleo then scans Adora from head to shoe—taking in the sight of her unkempt hair and crumpled clothes. "You really

should try to take better care of yourself, Adora. We're only trying to help you."

Adora nearly laughs because, *right*, everyone is trying to help her.

If only she could stop letting them down.

"—lost three shipments of extremely valuable metal ore. Which, I might add, is the fifth time we've had our shipping lanes attacked in the last two lunar cycles."

Catra's eyes remain trained on the chair to her left, rather than the screen projected at the center of the round conference table. It's an empty chair—one that, according to the promises made by its usual occupant, should have been filled an hour ago.

Still without looking at the portly figure on that screen—namely, ambassador Atric of the Planet Histrion—Catra asks, "Are you sure it's not just pirates? Recent data shows that there's been an uptick in independent piracy in your star system."

"Positive," Atric says fiercely. "Our security measures are far too advanced for the paltry efforts of pirates. No. This had to be Crion and their advanced weaponry—purposely sabotaging our trade so we'll have no means to defend ourselves when they attack our planet."

Crion. Histrion's neighboring planet—and favorite scapegoat. No matter what goes wrong, Histrion always finds a way to blame Crion. And somehow, they always make it Etheria's problem along the way.

(Or, more specifically, they make it She-Ra's problem. Which makes it Catra, Glimmer, and Bow's problem by extension).

"That's a very serious accusation to make," Bow remarks. "There hasn't been an interplanetary war in over five years."

“I’m aware,” says the ambassador—too curtly for Catra’s liking. “But I’m certain it’s inevitable. Crion has been eyeing our territory for centuries—”

“—but they’ve never acted on it,” Glimmer interjects. Her eyebrow raises skeptically at Atric. “And they especially haven’t acted on it during the last two times you contacted us.”

“Well, no,” says the ambassador somewhat sheepishly. “But like I said, it’s only a matter of time.”

The room descends into awkward silence. Glimmer, Bow, and Catra exchange dubious glances, collectively certain that the ambassador is wrong this time too. Just like all the times before.

Sure, Histrion and Crion have a long-standing rivalry—but so do a lot of planets in the universe. And Catra has traveled to Crion in the past—met the people there. She doubts they want to be the planet to shatter the first and only period of widespread universal peace.

“I understand your hesitance to believe me,” Atric continues. “But my people are legitimately concerned. We would feel much safer if…”

The ambassador trails off. Catra’s eyes narrow at him, certain that she’s going to hate his suggestion.

“You’d feel much safer if *what*?”

“If…” the ambassador says slowly, “She-Ra would travel to Histrion and lend her protection to our shipping lanes, for the time being.”

“No,” snaps Catra, instantly. “Out of the question.”

“It would only be for a week or two,” Atric insists. “Not a month, like last time—”

“I said *no*—”

“It would demonstrate to Crion that She-Ra is on our side and ready to defend us should they continue their devious efforts—”

“It would be a waste of time for everyone,” hisses Catra, crossing her arms as she continues staring at the empty chair adjacent to her own. “Especially for Adora. Which is her *actual* name.”

“What Catra is trying to say,” Bow interrupts smoothly, “is that Adora is...dealing with some personal matters on Etheria at the moment. And she’s really not in a position to leave on an intergalactic mission right now.”

“From rumors I’ve heard,” Atric says, “She-Ra has not left Etheria in months. How much longer can her ‘personal matters’ possibly take?”

At this point, Catra’s had just about enough of the ambassador. She reaches forward, prepared to hang up the call—but Glimmer quite literally blocks her hand. Glimmer’s eyes flicker warningly at Catra before they return to the ambassador.

“Wait, what do you mean?” Glimmer asks. “What rumors?”

Atric gives a short huff. “Planetary leaders do talk, you know. And from what I’ve heard, She-Ra has refused nearly every request made of her in the last few months. Everything from charitable appearances, disposal of dangerous magical artifacts, diplomatic affairs...”

Atric gestures furiously at what Catra can only assume to be his own screen.

“Even now, after I was *promised* a meeting with She-Ra, she’s entirely absent.”

Atric’s features twist with distaste, and Catra suspects that, through the screen, he’s staring at *her* in particular—at Catra, the current obstacle to getting She-Ra’s help.

Atric adds, "I would much prefer to negotiate with She-Ra myself, rather than…" He spends an obnoxiously long time searching for a correct word, then ultimately settles on, "...her allies?"

"Wife," Catra says with some outrage—and smugness. "I'm She-Ra's wife. So you can be confident that my answer will be the same as hers."

Or at least that would have been consistently true, half a year ago...but now she has her doubts. Catra knows that things have changed. That *Adora* has changed.

Atric's lips settle into a thin line. "I was promised a meeting with She-Ra. And I have little interest in speaking with anyone else."

"Why?" demands Catra, glaring at Atric through the screen. "So you can try to guilt her into helping y—?"

"Adora is on her way here as we speak," Bow interrupts loudly. "I take full responsibility for the delay. She was doing me a favor and got caught up on the way back—"

A slight lie, Catra notes, but a harmless one intended to keep the ambassador calm. She knows better than anyone that Adora hasn't been visiting the library as a favor to Bow, but rather, as a symptom of a recent obsession.

Atric raises an accusing eyebrow. "So She-Ra can do favors for the King of Bright Moon, but not for the entire planet of Histrion?"

Whoops, Catra thinks. That backfired.

"Well, no. I mean. That's not what I meant—"

Just as Catra again reaches for the button that will forcibly end the call, she finds herself distracted by a familiar sound—a notification from Glimmer's tracker pad. One that causes Glimmer's eyebrows to pull together and a sigh to puff past her lips.

Catra and Glimmer’s eyes meet readily. A silent conversation passes between their connected gazes. An annoyed, grumbling one that ends only when Catra jerks her head, motioning for Glimmer to leave the room, and with a small nod, Glimmer obliges —teleporting away in a flash of pink light.

“And what about this?” Catra hears Atric shriek. “The Queen of Bright Moon abandons the meeting as well? How many more insults must I endure—”

“Calm yourself,” Catra snaps. “You want to talk to She-Ra? Then sit tight and be quiet. Glimmer’s fetching her for you right now.”

And sure enough, within the next five seconds, another flash of bright light teleports a small party of new arrivals into the conference room: Cleo, Adora's personal bodyguard. Swift Wind, She-Ra’s steed. And, finally, Adora—the legendary warrior herself —who sways a bit as she’s teleported into place.

Though Adora doesn’t look like a ‘legendary warrior’ at the moment. Her hair appears half-pulled out of a ponytail, and her clothes are noticeably wrinkled, like she slept in them—which is, of course, an impossibility, given Adora’s circumstances.

Most noticeable of all are the bruise-dark circles around Adora’s eyes. Bruise-dark, yes, but not bruises at all. If they were bruises, Catra could strike back against whoever inflicted them. But those circles are unmistakable evidence of a far more complicated issue: the persistent sleep problems that have tortured Adora for months.

There’s a large book folded between Adora’s arms, clutched tightly. Something that she likely took from the library, and will probably add to an ever-growing stack of books in their bedroom.

“H-hi ambassador Atric!” Adora greets too-loudly, waving as she staggers toward her usual chair: the empty one, beside Catra. “Sorry for the delay. I got held up by—”

Her words are interrupted by a yelp. Specifically, Adora's yelp as she trips over a chair leg and flails toward the ground. Luck and cat-like reflexes are all that save Adora, as Catra barely manages to grab onto Adora's sleeve in time. Her grasp suspends Adora enough to keep her from hitting the floor.

Though Catra doesn't manage to rescue the book. It falls, clattering loudly—causing Adora to jump noticeably at the sound. Briefly, Catra peers at the title and reads, *The Symbolic Artistry of the First Ones*.

Yup, Catra thinks. Definitely another one for the pile.

Adora huffs out, "Sorry," then scrambles to her feet—tearing her sleeve out of Catra's grip in the process. She scoops the book off the floor like it's a valued treasure that she's dropped, rather than a dusty old tome.

Catra raises an eyebrow, watching as Adora flops into her chair and neatly folds both hands on the table in front of her, the book placed face-down at her side. It's an attempt to appear calm and put-together, Catra is sure. But the trembling of Adora's hands reveals otherwise.

Adora turns to the projection of Ambassador Atric. Her smile is brittle.

"Now," Adora says, all forced interest. "What did you want to talk about?"

Catra takes Adora's hand as Atric makes his plea.

Catra can tell that Adora wants to accept—that she wants to feel useful for the first time in many months.

Because, really, Atric is right about only one thing: that She-Ra has not left Etheria in nearly half a year. Every call they've received, every request, Adora has been asked to decline.

Well. *'Asked'* might be the wrong word. They've *begged* Adora not to accept. Begged, again and again. Multiple times a week. Sometimes multiple times a day.

It's resulted in several arguments. Between only Adora and Catra, at first. Then Adora and Glimmer. And then Adora and Bow. And now between Adora and everyone she knows, really.

"*You're in no state to be traveling off-planet,*" they've kept telling her, much to Adora's fury. But Catra refuses to hear counterarguments. Any stranger can see that Adora isn't well, and worse, amidst her exhaustion, Adora hasn't been able to consistently transform into She-Ra.

It's become an intense fear of Catra's in recent days: the idea that some random stranger will try to kill She-Ra, just to say they did. What wannabe tyrant wouldn't want those bragging rights—to say that they defeated She-Ra, savior of the universe?

Adora is in no state to defend herself from anyone, or anything. And sending Adora off-planet—particularly into potential interplanetary conflicts—seems like a surefire way to invite that sort of situation.

"*I can't just do nothing forever*," Adora keeps arguing, like it might change Catra's mind.

"*It's not forever*," Catra always replies. "*Just until we figure this thing out*."

And then, Catra always finds herself brokenhearted by the look on Adora's face—the crumbling of her features when she asks, "*But what if we never do?*"

When Atric asks She-Ra to travel to Histrion, Adora looks at Catra. Her eyes are hesitant, asking. She wants to do this. She wants to help the people of Histrion, even if Ambassador Atric is likely just being paranoid. She wants to help *someone.*

Adora just wants to be seen as useful. Catra knows that.

But truthfully, despite how much she wants Adora to be happy, Catra couldn't care less about Adora being perceived as 'useful.' Adora needs to help herself before she can help anyone else. And so far, taking care of herself has proven a challenge.

Not, of course, that it's really Adora's fault. Catra knows that too, and does her best to remember it.

Adora sees the subtle shaking of Catra's head. *Don't*, Catra's eyes say. *Not this time.* They exchange a silent conversation—Adora, pleading. Catra, refusing.

Finally, Adora's jaw clenches. She's convinced. Disappointed, but convinced.

With a sigh, Adora turns back to Ambassador Atric and says, "I'm sorry but…" Another sigh, deeper this time. "I'm afraid I won't be able to help you right now."

Catra strokes her thumb along Adora's palm, trying to apologize. She doesn't find joy in this—in micromanaging Adora. Normally, she'd take far more pleasure in watching Adora trounce some space pirates—space pirates like the ones that probably attacked Histrion's shipping lanes. But Adora needs rest, more than anything else. And it kills Catra, seeing her strung out this way.

Ambassador Atric begins blathering his outrage. Catra doesn't want Adora feeling worse than she likely already does, so she reaches out and finally, *finally* hangs up the call.

Once the screen goes dark, Adora's chair scrapes against the floor. She stands and heads to the door without a word, shooting some sort of pointed glare at Glimmer as she goes. Though Glimmer pretends not to notice.

"You headed back to our room?" Catra calls, craning her neck to see Adora's face.

Adora nods but doesn't say anything else.

"Okay," Catra says. "I'll see you there in a little bit, alright?"

Again, Adora nods, but still refuses to reply. Her feet seem to drag as she exits the room. Cleo follows close behind—basically breathing down Adora's neck in the way that Catra *knows* Adora hates. And then they're both gone, stomping down the corridor, leaving only Swift Wind, Glimmer, Catra, and Bow sitting around the conference table.

"Well," Bow says with exaggerated brightness, too-obviously trying to stay optimistic, "she took that better than usual!"

"Right," replies Catra, sarcastic. "Because the only thing better than Adora being angry is Adora being resigned."

Glimmer shoots a glare at Swift Wind. "Why are you even here?"

Swift Wind opens his mouth to speak, but Glimmer holds up a hand to stop him. "Wait. Nevermind. Let me guess—Adora convinced you to give her a ride, even though we explicitly told you *not* to let her?"

Swift Wind pouts. "She bribed me with sugar cubes."

"We *also* bribed you with sugar cubes," Catra reminds him. "And you promised us you wouldn't let her go flying."

"What can I say?" Swift Wind says with a shrug. "I'm loyal to only my most recent sugar cube."

Glimmer groans and drops her head onto the tabletop. "Great. I guess that means we'll likely have to revoke Adora's sugar cube privileges too."

"Wait," Bow says. "I don't understand. *Why* isn't Adora allowed to ride Swift Wind all of a sudden?"

Still facedown, Glimmer flaps a hand in Swift Wind's direction. "Last week, while you were visiting your dads on their dig, Adora fell off Swift Wind."

“Midair,” Catra adds, sinking even lower in her chair.

“And from like,” Glimmer says, “forty feet in the air or something.”

“She *fell*?” Bow gasps—shooting to his feet. Eyes widening with concern. “Wha—why didn’t anyone tell me? Is she alright?”

“Of course she’s alright,” says Catra, pointing at the door before rolling her eyes. “You just saw her.”

A moment passes as Bow processes this. “Oh,” he says with some relief, and drops back into his chair. “Right. Sorry.”

“She *did* break a bunch of bones, though,” Catra adds. “But for only like a minute. She managed to turn into She-Ra to heal them but…”

Catra trails off. Nausea floods through her body as she recalls the way Adora’s leg had twisted, the bone bent in all the wrong ways. Adora stifled her tears with a hand as she transformed and healed herself, the leg miraculously setting into the correct position as Catra watched helplessly.

“...it wasn’t pretty,” Catra mutters.

“If Adora had failed to summon She-Ra, she likely would have been really hurt,” Glimmer explains to Bow, finally lifting her head enough to see her face. “And as we all know, Adora’s been having trouble turning into She-Ra lately. So there’s a real risk here.”

Bow grows quiet when he asks, “Why did she fall off?”

Swift Wind glances around like he’s being accused. “Don’t look at me. It’s not like I bucked her off.”

Bow meets Catra’s eyes. “She fell asleep?”

Catra nods. “She fell asleep. Lost her grip.”

“And then tumbled down, down, down,” Glimmer says.

Bow breathes out, “Ouch.”

“Yup,” Glimmer and Catra reply, in unison.

“And have of the treatments been working at all?” Bow asks, directing the question at Catra. “Even a little?”

At this point, Adora has tried almost everything. She’s gone to regular therapy sessions, visited several different healers and sorcerers, and even did some sort of sleep study with Entrapta. They all gave advice, prescribed treatments. But so far, none have been effective in smothering Adora’s nightmares.

Catra shakes her head. “Not as far as I can tell. She refuses to sleep most nights. If she *does* manage to settle down, it’s only ever for a couple hours. After that, she always wakes up in a panic and can’t fall back to sleep afterward.”

“And then she ends up falling asleep at inconvenient times,” Glimmer huffs out. “Like on Swift Wind’s back, for instance.”

Bow sighs. “There has to be something. Something we can do to help her.” He turns to Glimmer. “What about a potion? Sorcerers have potions for everything—stress relief, foot fungus, you name it. Is there something like that to help Adora sleep?”

“We tried sleep potions ages ago,” Glimmer says. “None have worked. If anything, they only seem to make the nightmares worse.”

It’s frustrating, Catra thinks. They’ve tried so many things, so many treatments—only to have each and every attempt fail miserably. Among them, a true menagerie of potions and draughts. Potions to relieve stress, potions to relax the mind, potions to induce exhaustion.

But her nightmares smash through each and every one of them. Some potions, like Glimmer said, even seemed to react badly with Adora’s dreams—causing the nightmares to become more twisted

or terrifying than ever. Almost like they were punishing Adora for trying to silence them.

The truth is that nothing, *nothing*, has been able to keep Adora from waking with a jolt each night. And it's unbearable to see her like that, shooting upright in bed every few hours, lungs gasping and screaming for relief—

It's no wonder why Adora has elected to stop sleeping entirely.

"*I don't even see* her*, anymore*," Adora told Catra, just a few nights ago. Just after Adora's last—and failed—attempt to sleep. Her face was in her hands. Her voice, thick and wavering. "*In the dreams. It's always just...people getting hurt. People I love."*

I don't even see her, Adora said.

Her.

Chasm.



Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra have a conversation.
Catra refuses to get mad.
Adora explains her research.

Chapter Notes

hey all! thanks so much for ~40 comments on last chapter! As always, comments motivate me like nothing else, so if you have anything to say about the fic, please please please keep leaving comments!

in other news, I'm about 75k words into this fic and uh...yeah it's gonna be a long one. I'm wondering now whether it'll be over 100k words when it's done. So. I'll let you know when I have a finalized chapter count. It will likely be 20 chapters or maybe longer and I'm sorry lol.

anyway, i really liked writing this chapter so...enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chasm.

The truth is…Adora wouldn’t be having these nightmares if it wasn’t for *her* , for Chasm.

Six months ago, a portal led Catra and Adora into a plane between worlds. Their goal was simple, but long overdue—they sought to rescue Glimmer’s mother.

Queen Angella had been trapped there, in the plane between worlds, many years before. Trapped by an earlier portal, the one activated during the war. The one that Catra, in her most unforgivable moment, tore through the fabric of reality.

This new portal was supposed to fix that. It was supposed to bring Angella back—right Catra's wrong.

But something went *wrong* with the portal, when they passed through. Rather than find themselves in another dimension, Catra and Adora were flung to a time years before, back before they were married. Back when they were enemies waging war against each other.

Time travel. That's what it was. Somehow, the portal had sent them to their past. Which meant that if they altered their choices—if they changed their past even a little—their entire future together could be compromised.

Convinced that they needed to preserve the timeline as it was, Adora and Catra perfectly relived the worst years of their lives. Pretending to be enemies. Suffering endless defeats and torments and disasters, allowing themselves to be separated and hurt and mind-controlled—

But eventually, Catra discovered that it wasn't real—that the time travel was an illusion. An illusion conjured by *something* there, living in the portal. A magical entity that sought to manipulate them, and trap them in a dreamworld...and used Catra and Adora's own memories to do it.

Catra learned of this, and escaped. Broke free of the illusion. Thrust the entity from her mind, and woke up.

Catra found Angella soon after. And through Angella, Catra learned about her—about Chasm. The entity who conjured all those illusions. And it seemed that, millennia ago, before Chasm had been imprisoned in the plane between worlds...she had been the most feared creature in the entire universe.

But while Catra discovered the truth about Chasm, Adora didn't. At least...not at first. Almost not at all.

Adora remained trapped. And Chasm gladly used her illusions to cut Adora down to her lowest, her most desperate. She forced

Adora to relive her every trauma, convinced Adora that her every action, every ambition was for nothing. And worst of all, she convinced Adora that Catra had died a terrible death—and that Adora was at fault for her loss.

Chasm wanted Adora hopeless, completely hopeless. And Chasm knew that if she convinced Adora to give up...to *break* and let herself die in the illusion…

Then Adora would really die. And Chasm would gain control of her body. Of *She-Ra* .

She almost succeeded too. Catra barely managed to wake Adora in time, thereby keeping Adora from making a deadly sacrifice. But not before Chasm graced Adora with one last torture—a spell that stole some great quantity of magic from She-Ra.

Catra still doesn’t understand what it was for—Chasm's last attack. She doesn't know what Chasm hoped to accomplish, with Adora already aware of the truth and seeking to rid Chasm from her mind.

But it was over, at least. Catra and Adora were free of her. Of Chasm. And they could finally bring themselves and Angella home, to Etheria.

But ever since then...ever since they came back…

Adora just hasn’t been the same.

The nightmares are new, most certainly—they started shortly after Adora’s return. At first, Adora consistently dreamed of Chasm. Of Chasm murdering Adora in increasingly horrific attacks. But over time, the dreams began to change, focusing instead on Adora hurting the people she loves. Killing them in vivid, gruesome ways. And that was even worse, even more terrifying for Adora. Adora just couldn’t stand it, couldn’t stand sleeping. She still can’t —and still suffers days, if not weeks, of wakefulness to avoid such visions.

Catra supposes it's not unexpected. Adora nearly died—nearly lost it all—in a dream. And now, whenever she dreams, she continues to relive those fears...maybe even manifests them in illusions of her own.

Catra can't complain, she knows. Things could be much worse. She could've lost Adora to Chasm permanently—her mind destroyed by Chasm's manipulations. Really, the nightmares are a small price to pay by comparison.

But...it's hard for Catra to think of themselves as lucky when she sees the dark circles beneath Adora's eyes. The exhaustion in her features and the sagging of her shoulders.

Catra's eyes meet Glimmer's across the conference table. They're still sitting there. Still talking, still discussing their options. "Well. There's one potion Adora keeps asking to try. A special one. But Glimmer says—"

"It's a bad idea," Glimmer insists. "The thing she wants—it's not a normal sleeping potion."

"But Adora—"

Glimmer groans and throws her head back. "I can't *believe* Castaspella even told Adora about it. A potion like that...it's too powerful for everyday use. Adora would've been better off not knowing about it at all."

"Wait," Bow says. "What potion?"

" *Essence of Oblivion* ," Glimmer says, half-spitting the name.

Bow blinks. Clearly, he's never heard of the potion before, and Catra can't help but feel a pinprick of jealousy. She wishes she could say the same—wishes that she was as blissfully unaware.

But unfortunately, Catra hears about the potion nearly every day and night—from Adora.

" *If we could convince Glimmer to let me try Essence of Oblivion,"* Adora keeps asking, pleading, only for Catra to shake her head, " *I could finally get some sleep— "*

" *Not my call* ," says Catra, every time. " *If Glimmer says it's too risky, I trust her—"*

"Essence of Oblivion," Bow repeats, as if testing the words on his tongue. "Sounds terrifying. What does it do, exactly?"

"Let's just say it's the universe's most powerful sleeping potion," Glimmer grumbles. "One that Aunt Casta made the mistake of telling Adora about. And now Adora won't stop pestering me for it, even though I've told her how dangerous it is—"

"Well, you're not the only one," says Catra. "She's been asking me too. Trying to get me to talk to you about it."

Glimmer scoffs. "Well, my answer to you would be the same as my answer to her: *No way* . There has to be something safer. A better solution to Adora's problem—"

"I wasn't planning on arguing with you," says Catra, hands raised in a gesture of surrender. "But she's not giving up on it. And if we don't find that *better solution* soon, she'll only want the potion more."

"Maybe we should reach out to doctors on other planets?" Bow offers. "Expand our options? There are lots of really technologically advanced worlds out there—"

"Only if they come to us," Catra says. "If we travel off-planet, I just know that Adora will end up trying to sneak off to Histrion—"

"And they'd have to be very discreet," remarks Glimmer. "The last thing we need is the whole universe knowing that She-Ra is completely out of commission."

"Hold on. She's not *completely* out of commission," Catra protests. "She's just...taking some time to get better. And things will be

back to normal once we figure out how to deal with these nightmares."

Glimmer and Bow exchange a skeptical glance, but don't otherwise argue.

Catra grunts and rises to her feet. "I better go talk to her, then," Catra says, referring to Adora. Her eyes find the chair next to her, now empty again. "Figure out what kept her at the library."

Bow shrugs. "Whenever I ask what she's doing there all day, she just says ' *research* .'"

"I always get the same answer," Catra replies. "Question is... *what* is she researching?"

When Catra walks into her bedroom, she finds Adora hunched at her desk.

The desk, same as always. It's Adora's favorite place to spend the night, or the early morning hours. Mostly because, in the absence of peaceful sleep, Adora must find other ways to occupy herself...and keep herself awake.

And Catra is *definitely* not frustrated to find her bed consistently cold and empty.

(And yes, she knows it's selfish—wanting Adora there, lying beside her, for her own comfort's sake.)

Adora's nose is tipped downwards, practically plunged into the book below. Engrossed in reading, as usual. Though the stack of books on the desk doesn't look any shorter or different in shape (usually the pile ends up toppled over completely if she takes a book from the stack) so Catra can only assume that Adora is reading her newest book. One not yet added to the precarious tower stolen from the library.

Catra shuts the door behind herself, greeting Adora with a gentle, "Hey."

Melog perks up at Catra's arrival. Attuned to Catra's emotions as they are, they immediately slink to Adora's side and nuzzle against her leg, settling into the spot beside her desk chair. Absently, Adora reaches down and scratches behind Melog's ears, but doesn't otherwise reply.

Catra draws closer to Adora. "How was the library?" Catra asks, just trying to make conversation.

And, okay, maybe she's prying just a little. But it's frustrating, not knowing what Adora's doing there every day, tucked between Lance and George's bookcases for hours on end.

Adora still refuses to reply, at first. But then, finally—

"You don't have to do that," Adora says.

Catra blinks. "Do what?"

" *That* ," Adora says again, bitterly. "Coddle me. Pretend that nothing's wrong. You can get mad at me, you know? I mean, I was late to the meeting, for Etheria's sake. I broke my promise—I didn't come back when I was supposed to. So just...just *say it* . Get mad. Get mad at me."

There's another pause as Catra just stands there, unable to do anything but keep blinking.

"But...I'm *not* mad at you," she tells Adora. And truly, Catra means every word.

Adora closes the book with a small thump. She pulls her knees beneath her chin, wrapping her arms around them as she balances her heels on the edge of the chair.

"You should be," Adora grumbles.

Another pause. And then, while fighting a small smile, Catra asks, "Why?"

"Because I'm mad at you," Adora says. "And it'd be easier to be mad at you if you were mad at me too."

Catra tries not to laugh. Instead, she draws closer and closer until she's standing directly behind Adora's chair. Close enough to wrap her arms around the chair's back—and Adora's stomach, which was Catra's intended target.

"Well, that's real inconvenient for you," says Catra, leaning forward until her cheek is pressed against Adora's. "Because I'm not mad at you." She plants a kiss there, on Adora's cheek. "Care to tell me why you're mad at me, though?"

Adora seems to sink lower in her chair. Her voice is small, almost ashamed when she whispers, "Because you sent Cleo to find me."

Catra sighs and drops her arms. Because, *right* . That. Catra knew Adora wouldn't like that. She never likes Cleo following her anywhere, least of all the library—where Adora keeps her activities private from everyone. Even from Catra herself, however much it annoys her.

"C'mon, Adora," Catra begs, each word filled with well-meaning apology. "You said it yourself. You were late, and I was worried. I mean, what else was I supposed to do?"

"I know," mutters Adora. She pinches the bridge of her nose. "I know you were right to do it, and I probably would've done the same thing if the situation was reversed. It's just…"

Catra waits patiently for her to finish. Waiting, waiting but...nothing. Instead, Adora stares determinedly at the book—violently reopening the cover and shoving her face down into the pages. Her nose ends up half-embedded in the spine, she's trying so hard to look like she's concentrating.

It'd even be almost comical, Catra thinks, *if* Adora wasn't using the stupid book to avoid the end of that sentence.

"It's just *what* ?" she presses, again wrapping her arms tightly around Adora's middle—basically begging Adora to say what's on her mind.

Still, Adora refuses to answer.

"Adora," Catra says, more sternly now. "Don't hide things from me."

Nothing.

"Adora—"

"Fine! You want honesty?" Adora snaps, and whirls around in her chair. Her eyes are furious, accusing, but somehow it doesn't feel directed at Catra. "I'm tired of it! I'm tired of being followed everywhere. I'm tired of not being trusted, of everyone looking at me like I'm some sort of ticking time bomb—"

Adora's voice is shrill, faltering, like she can't quite suck in enough air to form her words. There's a thickness there too. Thick, like she's on the verge of tears.

"A-and now Cleo's going to be there, in the library, every damn day," Adora stammers. "Following me. Watching me. Because she *knows* now. Cleo knows where it is, the library. The last place I could go without people staring at me and thinking I'm losing my mind, the only place where I felt useful—"

Catra gapes at Adora, startled by the outburst. "Adora, no one thinks—"

"Don't do that," Adora says, wriggling out of Catra's arms so she can stand, facing Catra directly. "Don't tell me I'm wrong. I'm not. I know I'm not!" She gestures to herself, to her exhaustion-strained features. "I may be tired, but I'm not stupid. I know what everyone thinks of me."

Catra can't reply. Not immediately. Because truthfully, Catra *does* know what Adora's talking about. Rumors do spread—between princesses or planets or just everyday people—and Adora hasn't looked or acted like herself in quite some time. She's frazzled, on edge, and it's clear by those dark circles that she isn't sleeping at all.

But what most people don't understand is *why* . There's a reason why Adora is struggling to sleep, and anyone who truly knows her *understands* that reason.

"You're right. I can't speak for everyone," Catra says calmly. "But *I* know that you're not losing your mind, and so do your friends. And truly, Adora, if Cleo is making you feel this way, like you're being judged, we can always get you a different guard—"

Adora's face scrunches up in misery. "That won't help."

"Okay," says Catra, careful to keep herself calm and gentle. To not rise to Adora's misplaced anger. "If that won't help, then what can I do? Tell me what I can do, and I'll do it."

Adora's lip begins to tremble.

"Nothing helps," Adora exhales, and drops back into her seat, fingers curled white-knuckle around the edge of her desk. "It's just…"

Her head hangs and finally, finally, the tears come. Flooding down her cheeks in messy streams. Catra feels her own heart fracture as she watches Adora struggle to cover her own face, trying to hide her crying—

"I'm *tired* ," Adora sobs, shoulders jerking as the words seem to explode from her mouth. "I'm so damn tired, Catra. I'm so angry and tired and *nothing* helps and I'm sorry—"

"It's okay," Catra says, and kneels to wrap Adora in her arms. She wishes she had something real to offer, to say. A promise that

she'll find a fix to this, to Adora's nightmares...but so far Catra's ideas, all of them, have been complete and utter *busts* .

Catra already made a fairly hollow promise months ago, when they returned from the plane between worlds. She promised Adora that they would be happy—happy, in the way that Chasm never allowed them to be, back in that torturous illusion. But with all these nightmares… Adora has remained far from happy. And Catra hasn't been much help in changing that.

Helpless. Catra has been helpless in the face of these nightmares, just as Adora has been.

Catra clings tightly to Adora. "I know," she says. "I know you're tired. I know it's hard, and I'm sorry."

There are cold-hot tears dripping onto Catra's shoulder as Adora continues to cry. Catra's relieved, at least, to feel Adora sinking into her arms. Relaxing by some small measure within Catra's embrace. But she knows it's not much—that it's not really enough. This small respite is nothing in comparison to a full night's sleep.

"And if you don't want Cleo to find you in the library," Catra continues, searching for any consolation to give, "we can tell her not to follow you there, alright? She follows Glimmer's orders, and if we tell Glimmer to change those orders, she'll have to listen."

She feels Adora nod her head. "I'm being stupid," she mutters, wiping an elbow over her eyes.

"You're not," Catra replies, instantly. She cracks a small smile. "And honestly? Given the fact that you're running on, what, like negative ten hours of sleep? You have a right to be as stupid and angry and tired as you want."

At that, Adora gives a short laugh, one that's mucousy and shuddering.

"And I'm sorry for sending Cleo after you," Catra says. "I didn't want to, believe me. But I really was worried. You were so late—"

She feels Adora nod again. “And I’m sorry for that. For being late,” Adora says, sniffing. “I fell asleep. At the library.”

“Oh?” Catra asks, both eyebrows shooting upwards. “In that case, I shouldn’t have interrupted. Any sleep you can get—”

Adora gives a short laugh—a dismissive one. “No need. It wouldn’t have lasted much longer, even if Cleo didn’t wake me. It was just another nightmare. A bad one, and I think it...it really messed me up, and I didn’t have time to process it—”

Catra pulls away so that she can look at Adora’s face. Her eyes are dull, tear-stained as Catra weaves her fingers through Adora’s hair. “What about?” Catra asks softly—though she’s afraid to know the answer. Asking has never revealed anything comforting in the case of Adora’s nightmares.

Bitterness coats Adora’s every word as she answers.

“Oh, the usual,” she says. “I killed you. Impaled you on my sword.”

Catra watches, speechless, as fresh tears tumble down Adora’s cheeks.

Adora continues, speaking no louder whisper. “And then I couldn’t heal you, no matter what I did. I couldn’t fix it.”

They sit in silence for several moments. And Catra knows that Adora is picturing the dream. Her eyes are fixated on Catra’s abdomen in particular...and Catra can guess where the sword made contact, in her nightmare.

“Well, there’s nothing to heal,” says Catra. She slides Adora’s hand down, until it’s laid out across the side of Catra’s throat, where her pulse pounds. “I’m here. I’m okay. It was just a dream, Adora.”

After that, she lifts Adora’s hand and brings it to her lips, kissing it slow and soft.

"So…" Catra says, letting the word hang and meander. Perhaps too-obviously attempting to change the subject. "I'm really trying not to pry here but… after all this talk about the library, and all the books…" She sighs. "Well. You've really got me wondering what exactly, you've been doing there all this time."

Adora opens her mouth, but Catra holds up a finger to stop her. "And don't just say *research* ," Catra adds. "That's what you always say, and it really doesn't help."

"Oh," breathes Adora, very clearly hesitating. She scratches at her chin. "Sorry. It's uh…it's really just a theory, and I didn't want to tell anyone until I had more evidence—"

"Well, I'm still interested in what it is," Catra says, taking Adora's hands. Staring into her eyes to make her sincerity clear. "You can tell me anything, okay? Evidence or no evidence."

It takes several moments of staring and pleading with her eyes, but finally, *finally* , Adora seems to relent. She exhales hugely and turns back around, clutching tightly to her newest book as she begins combing through the age-darkened pages.

"The First Ones' language is...complex. They have letters, vowels, punctuation—everything that a language like Etherian has," Adora explains."But they also have these...other symbols. Things that can't be broken down linguistically. Things that even *I* can't read. They're idiomatic, I think. Specific to the culture. Symbols that have stories behind them."

Adora lifts up the book, displaying a page that contains a curving, intricate shape that looks like two prisms intertwined.

"For example," Adora says, pointing to the page. "This symbol doesn't have a direct translation. The first time I saw it, I was reading an old First Ones scroll in George and Lance's library, and I was sort of stunned to encounter a First Ones symbol I couldn't read. Most of them come naturally to me. Like breathing, almost. But *not* this one. This one was different. The only clue I had to its

meaning was the scroll itself—some sort of ancient First Ones love story. A romance from their mythology. But when I started searching, I discovered that this symbol appeared in pretty much every scroll that mentioned love or sex or—"

Catra snorts. "So wait. Is this thing some sort of weird First Ones sex symbol—?"

Adora rolls her eyes. "No, dummy. It *also* appears in things that don't have sex at all. I actually think it's just the First Ones' symbol for true love. And I think this symbol is supposed to mean something *more* than just writing the word 'love' in their usual language."

"Oh," Catra says. "Well, that's...that's pretty cool, actually."

Adora nods and shrugs. "So after I found this, I started searching for more examples." Adora turns a few more pages in the book, revealing a strange symbol that looks like a castle. "This is another one. I think it means something like 'glory.' Glory in battle, specifically. Or at least that's where it always appears in context."

"Huh."

Adora inhales deeply and keeps turning pages. "And then...more recently...I found this one."

She reveals another symbol. A sharp-looking one, comprised of connected spirals struck through with lines. It's a little bit unsettling-looking, if Catra's being totally honest. Like the frantic scribble of a child.

In fact...the more Catra stares at it…

The more she realizes that it looks sort of familiar.

But Catra *knows* that doesn't make sense. Catra can't read the language of the First Ones—not in the least, despite how many times Adora has tried to teach her. And she can probably count on

one hand the number of times she's visited George and Lance's library.

"I kept seeing this symbol in scrolls that mentioned different types of misfortunes," Adora recounts. "Natural disasters. Wars. Disease. And at first, I thought that the symbol was just used to represent bad luck. Like...if something bad happened to the First Ones, they'd just slap this symbol on their histories as an expression of grief."

"Makes sense," Catra says, still closely studying the symbol. It's bothering her. The fact that it looks so familiar. She *swears* she's seen it before. She just...she just can't place where...

"But then I realized that the symbol appeared in scrolls that were *about* disaster, yes...but only in the sections that discussed rebuilding efforts or peace treaties or cures," continues Adora. "Which made me think that maybe...maybe the symbol is actually meant to *ward off* further bad luck."

Catra keeps staring. Why, why, *why* does she recognize this stupid thing?

"After that, I contacted a few of our friends on other planets," Adora keeps explaining. "And once I showed it to them, the Star Siblings said that they've encountered the symbol before on a bunch of different planets. It's always the same symbol, and it always means something similar—a symbol to ward off bad energy, or evil spirits, or people with ill intentions—"

Catra's eyes finally leave the symbol, instead resting on Adora's face. "So what does it actually mean?"

Adora stares at her. Her expression is excited, almost triumphant. "It looks familiar to you too, doesn't it?"

Catra's eyes widen. "Wait. You've *also* seen it before?"

"Yeah," says Adora. "After looking at it for long enough, I realized I had seen it pretty recently—in Mystacor. During Glimmer's

induction into the Sorcerer's Guild."

Right. Shortly after the war, Glimmer decided to become a full-fledged sorceress—which isn't an easy feat to accomplish while running an entire kingdom. It took her nearly half a decade to finish the various trainings at Mystacor, and it was less than a year ago that she finally graduated, earning herself a place among the Guild. Though, unlike the rest of the sorcerers (Micah excluded), she decided to remain in Bright Moon rather than Mystacor.

Catra recalls the induction—how long and boring it was despite how happy she was for Glimmer—but she still doesn't remember seeing the symbol. Likely, she was too distracted by the pretty dress Adora had worn to the ceremony, since Catra and Adora were *also* on their honeymoon in Mystacor at that time, and Catra had... *other things* on her mind.

So...why does the symbol still strike Catra as familiar?

Adora keeps recounting her research. "So I asked Micah about it, showed him a drawing. He said that it's a rune that the sorcerers use. One that's inscribed on every Sorcerer's Guild badge upon graduating from their studies."

Memory floods Catra's vision. She remembers conveying a Sorcerer's Guild badge to Shadow Weaver's cell. Catra had never seen it before, never held it, and she'd examined it closely. There were symbols carved all along the back, and she thinks perhaps one of the symbols looked vaguely like the one in the book—

It was on Shadow Weaver's badge, yes…

But that's *not* the only place Catra remembers it from, Catra realizes. She remembers it from somewhere else. A more recent time. A space between worlds. A barren plane where she stood, staring at strange symbols carved into stone. Symbols that whispered warnings about danger, about evil, about *Chasm.*

One of those symbols—the one she touched, her fingers tracing the curves of the carving—looked exactly like the one she's faced

with now.

Suddenly, Catra's not so sure she likes where this conversation is going.

"Why?" Catra demands, her eyes narrowing at Adora.

"Because it's their way of swearing off dark magic," Adora says, all too happy to explain. "That's what the symbol means. It's a ward —a ward against the darkest of magics, against evil, and I think...I think it's what the First Ones used to—"

"No," says Catra. "I mean— *why* are you researching this?"

She stares at Adora, hard, as Adora sets her jaw.

"I think that this symbol is used to protect people against entities of dark magic," Adora says. Her eyes flit down to her hands, refusing to look Catra in the eye. "Entities like Chasm."



Chapter End Notes

adora? obsessed?
no....

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

Catra loses an argument.
Glimmer teases Catra.
Adora throws some cookies into a bush.

Chapter Notes

Another chapter! Y'all...this fic is SO long, I'm at nearly 100k and it has still so much to go...currently clocking in at 20 chapters too. Whoops. Strap in for a long one. I've also learned through writing it that this fic is actually *less* angsty than the last one...but it's def got its angsty moments, so people who like angst will not starve.

Also, I didn't have time to do art for this one. Might get to it later in the week, but last week's art was posted on the previous chapter!

Anyway, please enjoy! There was a dip in comments last chapter, so please remember to like...tell me your thoughts. I'm begging y'all. Even a keysmash will do.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra sighs. “Adora.”

“I mean—it makes sense!” Adora insists. “Chasm is supposed to be old. Really old. She’s been around since before Etheria as we know it, since before Horde Prime or the First Ones—”

“I really should’ve known…” Catra mutters to herself.

“And maybe…” Adora continues slowly, almost like she’s afraid to keep talking, “maybe fear of her is *so* ingrained in the universe that this symbol became known as a ward against all evil, rather than a ward against a specific threat—

“Are you seriously telling me that you’ve been spending weeks, if not months...researching *wards* against Chasm?”

But Adora doesn’t listen. She just keeps barrelling ahead with her theories. “ I thought that...if we all started wearing this symbol, we’d be protected from her—”

“Adora,” Catra murmurs, and her voice sounds strange to her own ears. Teetering somewhere between reassurance and frustration and desperation for Adora to listen. “Chasm is trapped in another dimension, okay? There’s nothing to be...to be *warded* off. She’s gone. We’re safe—”

Adora’s lips press into a hard line. “You don’t know that.”

“But I *do* know that!” Catra tells her, and is startled to find herself nearly yelling. “I mean...I was the one who battled a freaking slideshow of my worst fears to break *you* out of her illusion!”

Adora winces. But Catra won't stop. She gestures to herself, then to Adora.

“I beat her. *We* beat her. And you need to accept that.”

There’s a pause. They sit there, frozen for several moments. Frozen...until Adora’s lip starts to tremble.

And suddenly, Catra is horrified with herself. She shouldn’t have gotten so angry—she knows that. Catra said that she’d listen, that Adora could tell her anything, and here she is, yelling at Adora for telling her the truth—

But Catra can’t even bear to think about it. To think about Chasm returning, reappearing, to inflict more tortures upon them. Chasm promised, after all, to make Adora and Catra miserable for the rest of their days. But she *won’t* , Catra assures herself. Because Chasm can’t come back, she can’t—

Catra closes her eyes and takes a deep breath.

"I-I'm sorry," Catra stammers, grasping for Adora's hands. "I'm sorry, it's just...I need you to accept this, Adora. I need you to accept that she's gone. That we won. That we're here, and she's trapped there—as she should be."

"But I don't," Adora says, with certainty. "I don't believe you. We opened a portal twice. Twice, to the place where she was trapped. Who's to say we won't do it again?"

"Because we know better now," Catra answers immediately.

"Maybe *we* do," Adora says. "But what if someone else does it? What if someone else opens a portal—"

"C'mon, Adora. You remember how hard it was. There's no way—"

"Well, what if another person like Entrapta springs up?' Adora demands. "Someone who's good at science. Too good. They won't know the risk. They'll open the portal, and then what? She'll escape. She'll escape and attack us again, or worse, attack innocent people. Or maybe an alien culture more advanced than ours will try to—"

"Adora," Catra says, trying to muster some laughter. "The chances are so unlikely—"

"I don't care," Adora shoots back. "I don't care that it's unlikely. If there's a chance, *any chance at all* , that I can save someone else from being broken the way I was, then I'll take it! I'll take it as far I can—"

"Broken?" Catra repeats in fearful disbelief. "She didn't *break you* , Adora. You escaped—"

Adora shakes her head fiercely. "But I think she did. I think that's what she was doing, before I escaped. When she stole all that magic from me. I think she...I think she stole my magic, and then she used it to *break* something in my head. Something vital, something tied to sleep—"

“Adora,” Catra says, barely able to suppress her horror at Adora’s words. “You’re not broken—”

Adora begins to pace, her chin clutched in her own hand as her thoughts continue to spiral. “Or maybe she cursed me. That’s a thing in magic, right? Being cursed. Maybe that’s what she did. She cursed me with nightmares, and now I’m doomed for the rest of my life—”

“Adora!” Catra yells, and she grabs ahold of both of Adora’s shoulders, forcing Adora to look at her directly. “You are *not* broken, and you are *not* cursed. Do you hear me?”

“Then how do you explain it?” Adora demands, quickly descending into some sort of panic. “It’s been months, and I’m not getting better. Nothing works. None of the treatments, or potions, or medications. It’s like the part of my brain that controls sleep is just...it’s just *broken* . Poisoned by these nightmares—”

“You’ll get better,” Catra tells her, like a promise.

“I don’t believe you,” Adora says, shaking her head. “I wish I did, but I don’t.”

“We’ll prove it,” Catra says. “We’ll find some sort of cure—”

Adora’s eyes harden. Flinging out both arms, she demands, “ *What* cure, Catra? We’ve tried everything. Everything, except...”

But she doesn’t finish. She just trails off, sighing and receding into herself.

“What?” Catra asks, but she doesn’t even need the elaboration. Adora’s meaning is clear, clearer than blue skies or starlight cutting through space.

“You know what,” Adora scoffs. “The one thing that could possibly help—”

The potion. That's what Adora is talking about. The potion Catra discussed earlier, with Glimmer.

Essence of Oblivion.

Catra is silent for a long time because she *can't* . She can't do it. She can't prove Adora wrong. She can't make Adora believe that Chasm will stay gone, she can't prove that Adora's not broken, and she *can't* help Adora conquer her nightmares.

Nothing's working. Nothing they've tried so far, and there aren't any more options she can think of.

Nothing, except this. This dangerous thing, this *promising* thing—

"I'm begging you, Catra," Adora whispers. "To help me. Help me talk to Glimmer. I know you want to protect me, you both do…" Shakily, she exhales, like she's lowering her breath on a single strand of rope. "But I can't take this anymore. I need *sleep* . Sleep that doesn't hurt me—"

Catra knows that it's supposed to be dangerous. Over and over again, Glimmer has told them that—that the potion is dangerous, too dangerous to try.

But truthfully...

Catra can't do this anymore, either. She can't handle these nightmares any more than Adora can. She can't keep watching Adora's treatments fail, or hear Adora split the night with a scream. It's hard enough seeing Adora like this now, with those trembling hands and shoulders, those sunken eyes and tear-burned cheeks—

"Please let me have this," Adora begs, clutching at Catra's shoulders. "It's been *months* , and I...I can't stay awake anymore. And I can't sleep, either, not when sleep makes me see such terrible things—"

Catra stares at Adora. Stares and stares, struggling to decide. Because, god, how is Catra supposed to make this choice? How can she choose between Adora's sanity and her safety?

Catra makes a strangled noise—some grunt of indecision. "But Glimmer says—"

"So there's a little danger," Adora says, rolling her eyes. "But what's the difference, really? This situation is dangerous on its own. Half the time, I can't turn into She-Ra. I can't ride Swift Wind without falling off. And honestly?" A gust of air puffs between her lips. "It *hurts,* being awake for this long. My head hurts. My eyes hurt. I'm sore and I'm tired and I..."

With a trembling inhale, Adora takes a step forward. Her hands land on Catra's shoulders and grasp them tightly.

"Please, Catra," Adora begs, asking, *pleading* , with her eyes. "Just let me try. That's all I'm asking for. A chance to try."

Catra gulps and tries to look away, because, *shit* , there's no way she can say no with Adora right there, begging with those stupidly pretty blue eyes—even if those eyes are surrounded by dark circles. In fact, the dark circles make it *worse* , if anything. Make it harder to argue —

Catra's stares at the floor. "And you're *sure* that this potion will help you?"

Adora nods frantically.

"Dreamless sleep," says Adora, wistfully. "That's what it does. And that's what I need."

"Wow," says Glimmer, leaning back against the wall and crossing her arms. One of her eyebrows quirks up. "You've really gone soft, haven't you?"

Catra's mouth opens, shuts, then opens again. "I'm not—"

"You *know* it's a bad idea," Glimmer remarks, and for whatever reason, she sounds smug. "The potion. You even agreed with me. And yet, with a few more tears from those big blue eyes—"

Catra stomps a foot. "I am not—"

"The once-feared leader of the Horde, reduced to begging the Queen of Bright Moon for a potion she *knows* she shouldn't be asking for—"

"Glimmer," Angella chides, disapproving. "There's no need to make fun of her. She's obviously upset."

Glimmer rolls her eyes. "Sorry, mom. I'm just teasing."

Catra turns to the nearby table, where Micah and Angella are eating breakfast. She hadn't intended to hold this conversation in front of an audience, but she also didn't want to wait. She went to the Queen's chambers first thing in the morning. She won't admit it, especially not to Adora, but she's worried that *maybe* Adora is right. That Adora really is cursed in some way. And maybe Catra needs someone to tell her that they're both wrong—

But when Glimmer opened the door, she discovered that while Bow was already gone—off to a meeting of some sort—Glimmer was halfway through a meal with her parents. Parents who were far too willing to let Catra plead her case while they eavesdropped and buttered their toast.

"Listen," Catra pleads. "Things have…they've *changed* . I'm worried about my wife, okay? Really worried."

Some of her smugness dissipates, but Glimmer's stare remains unyielding. Sympathetic, but set in her decision.

"We're all worried about Adora," Glimmer says. "But that's no reason to try something this risky. Adora puts herself in danger at the drop of a hat. We both agreed to not encourage that habit. Especially not now, when she's this strung out—"

“If you saw her last night, you’d change your mind,” Catra says. “She was really upset—”

Glimmer’s raised eyebrow seems to climb even higher. “Adora’s come crying to me too. Begging, again and again, for me to give her the potion. But it hasn’t changed my mind. And you’re not going to, either.”

“You don’t understand,” says Catra. “She’s *so* exhausted—maybe even long past her breaking point. And then she started explaining what she’s been doing at the library—”

At that, Glimmer actually looks intrigued. She leans forward a bit, balancing her chin on her hand.“And what *has* she been doing at the library all this time?”

Catra sighs. “Researching,” Catra tells her, only half-mockingly.

Glimmer opens her mouth in outrage. To curse at Catra, presumably.

“Specifically—” Catra continues, before Glimmer can interrupt, “she’s been researching some sort of magic symbol that can ward off ‘ *evil entities* ’ like—”

“Chasm,” Glimmer sighs, and hangs her head. “I had a feeling it was something like that.”

“Huh,” muses Micah, from off to the side. “So is *that* why she showed me that rune? I was wondering what interest she had considering, well, Adora has shown little proficiency with runes. Not that she needs them, of course, what with She-Ra being magical in nature—”

Catra finds herself sharing a slight smile with Glimmer. Likely, they’re both remembering the one time Glimmer tried to teach Adora a rune, years ago. A simple one intended to change the color of one of Adora’s shirts—though Adora’s attempt ultimately caused the shirt to erupt into flames.

Glimmer, Catra, and Bow stood nearby, trying but failing to stifle their laughter as Adora frantically stamped out the small fire.

"I'll just stick to doing magic as She-Ra," Adora sighed, staring defeatedly at the smoldering ruins of the shirt.

And it's strange to Catra, remembering carefree moments like those. Moments before the second portal, before *Chasm* . Catra almost wishes she could go back and warn their past selves of what would happen—what would change, and what they'd nearly lose.

But Catra is also well-aware of the complications of time travel.

"Adora wants everyone to wear the symbol at all times," Catra explains. "Have it carved on something they're wearing like the Sorcerer's Guild does—"

Glimmer rolls her eyes and gives a small groan of frustration. "Oh yeah. Good luck persuading the other princesses to do that—"

"But she's *convinced* that Chasm is going to come back, somehow," Catra says. "And I can't convince her otherwise. Worse, she thinks...she thinks Chasm *did* something to her, back when she was trapped in the illusion. Something permanent."

Glimmer's features twist with confusion. "Like what?"

Catra gulps and does her best to look casual. Unconcerned. Like Adora's words last night didn't make Catra nervous. Nervous, especially, that they might be true.

"She thinks Chasm broke her, or something," Catra says, and barely manages to keep her voice from trembling. "Broke something in her mind, and now she'll never be able to sleep again."

That wipes all amusement from Glimmer's features. She sits up straighter. "Well. She's been to doctors, right?"

Catra nods.

"And they didn't find anything, right? Nothing abnormal in the scans Entrapta did—?"

Catra shakes her head.

At that, Glimmer relaxes a bit. "Well, in that case, I don't know what Chasm could have done, besides just...y'know...scare Adora out of wanting to sleep for the rest of her life, which has basically been our theory to begin with. But Chasm hasn't *physically* sabotaged any part of Adora's brain—"

"Well...Adora has this other theory too," adds Catra. "That even if Chasm didn't physically *break* anything...Adora worries that Chasm cursed her. With magic. A curse that keeps her from sleeping—"

"There's no such thing," Micah interrupts, and Catra whirls around to look at him. He seems amused, almost, by the idea of a curse. Like nothing could be more absurd.

"Curses—they're not real," Micah continues. "They're just tales made up to scare children. There's no real way to make one, though. Not through magic. And besides, Adora *can* sleep, can't she? It's just that she has nightmares that make her not want to."

"Yeah, I guess," replies Catra. "I just...I don't know. I feel like something should've worked by now. Or at least *helped* by now."

She turns to Angella, now. Angella...who has finally started to gain some weight, and looks significantly healthier than she did, back in that plane between worlds. Back in that plane that held Chasm, and all the horrors she could conjure—

"There's no way she's still in Adora's head, right?" Catra asks Angella, and her voice breaks halfway through. "Chasm, giving her these nightmares?"

Angella shakes her head. “If Chasm remained in Adora’s head, she likely would have remained in yours as well—since you were, after all, last to leave the illusion. Have you had similar dreams to Adora’s?”

This time, Catra is the one to shake her head. She has bad dreams on occasion, yes, but that’s just an affordance of her past. She’s suffered nightmares about Shadow Weaver and Horde Prime for years now...but nothing to the degree of Adora’s nightmares.

Still, frigid horror seems to seize Catra by the throat. The suggestion paralyzes her with terror…this idea that Chasm might remain inside them both. Because maybe it’s true. Maybe Chasm is still infecting them, but has chosen to torment only Adora with these nightmares—

“But what if—”

“Besides, what purpose would it serve for Chasm to remain in Adora’s head?” Angella says. “She didn’t succeed in gaining control of Adora’s body. And by now, surely she would have made some sort of move. Possessed someone else. Claimed another body—”

“But it’s possible?” Catra says, horrified.

“No,” says Angella firmly. “Nothing I read in those books suggests Chasm behaves in this way. With her, it’s always the same. She traps her prey in a dreamworld, and convinces them to let go of their bodies. And Adora is *awake* and acting like herself—however distressed she may be.”

“Well, what if that’s not true?” Catra demands. “What if none of us woke up? What if we’re still asleep—”

“You know as well as I do that such a thing is impossible,” Angella says.

Catra is desperate, nearly yelling when she asks, “ *How* ?”

“Because I read a book yesterday,” Angella says calmly. “A book I have never read before. And several other new books before that. And I’m sure you’ve *also* had a few new experiences since you woke up, correct?”

With a jolt, Catra realizes that Angella is right. She’s done what Chasm cannot do for her. She’s learned new things, seen new sights—and not just relived twisted memories from her own head. The obscure sleep-science Entrapta explained to Catra and Adora should be sufficient proof in itself, new and confusing as it was—

Catra takes a deep breath. Calms herself.

“Then what did Chasm do to Adora?” Catra murmurs. “She stole her magic...did *something* to her—”

“She hurt Adora,” Angella answers. “She hurt her deeply, and severely. And I suspect she’ll be dealing with the aftermath for a long time. But I don't think there was any damage beyond the mental or emotional.”

“But she’s so upset,” Catra says. “She’s so upset, so tired, and there’s nothing I can do. Nothing at all.”

Angella stares at Catra for a long time. Examining her face. Her eyes. Studying her deeply and appraisingly.

And then, with queenly authority, Angella turns to Glimmer and says, “You should give Adora the potion.”

Micah spits out his food. Glimmer’s face goes slack with outrage.

“What?” they both shriek, at the same time.

“You heard me,” Angella says, and smirks a bit at Catra—who returns the smile.

“Are you *kidding me* , mom?” Glimmer demands, rushing forward to confront her. “Do you even know what potion we’re talking about?”

“Yes,” replies Angella. “I do.”

“ *Essence of Oblivion* ,” Glimmer all but yells. “That’s what it’s called. Doesn’t that sound just a little too dangerous to you? You sure you want Adora taking sips of that each night?”

“Angie,” Micah says. “It’s basically a coma in a bottle. If Adora takes too much—”

“I understand that it’s the only potion capable of completely silencing a person’s dreams,” Angella replies. “Which sounds like the only thing that might help Adora, at this point.”

“Yes,” says Micah. “But only because it silences *everything* .”

“Temporarily,” Angella corrects.

“Temporarily,” Micah agrees, reluctantly. “But while it’s in effect, it’s basically an off-switch to a person’s brain—”

“Not to mention that once she takes it,” Glimmer adds pointedly, shooting a glare Catra’s way, “there’s no waking her up. Not until the potion runs its course. If there’s some sort of emergency in the middle of the night—a fire, an attack, an attempt on her life—she won’t wake up. Not for hours—”

“Then we shall carefully manage the dosage for her,” Angella says calmly, as if it’s a clear solution. “And we will monitor Adora closely while she takes it.”

“Why are you agreeing with her?” Glimmer demands, gesturing furiously to Catra. “This potion is forbidden for a reason—”

“I have a unique perspective on Adora’s situation, and so does Catra.” Angella folds her hands in her lap. “Chasm’s illusions...they truly push a person to their breaking point. And Adora was trapped within them far longer than either of us. She was tortured mentally and emotionally while there—while asleep. And she won’t grow more comfortable with sleeping if she’s having terrible nightmares each and every night.”

"But, *Mom*— "

Angella shakes her head. "No. What Adora needs above all else...is a good night's rest. And then maybe she'll start to get better, even without the help of the potion. But for now, this may be the only thing that works. The only thing that lets her sleep."

Glimmer gives a mighty groan and drags her hand down her face. "This is a *bad* idea."

"I don't like it either," says Catra. "Trust me. Since the war, I've become the president of the ' *keep Adora from risking her life* ' society. But you didn't see Adora last night. She's truly at her limit, and I don't think she can take much more of this."

Another groan from Glimmer.

"I'm just asking to try it for *one night* ," Catra adds, trying to compromise. "Get the dosage exactly right. Monitor Adora closely. And if it goes badly, we won't do it again."

"If we administer this potion wrong," Glimmer grits out, "there won't be an *'again* .' You realize that, right? Not to mention that it's an incredibly difficult potion to brew, even for an experienced sorcerer."

Catra sets her jaw. "Then I'll make sure we get it right. I won't leave room for any additional risk."

"Oh no," Glimmer says, shaking her head. "You won't be touching the potion at all." She points to herself and Micah. "We'll be handling that, since you're too easily distracted or convinced by a few *Adora tears* ."

Eyes wide in outrage, Catra shrieks, "I am not—!"

"We'll check the dosage," Glimmer interrupts, raising a hand to silence Catra. "And double-check. And triple check. And quadruple check. And probably check a few more times after that, because that's how perfect the potion has to be—"

A pause. Glimmer sighs and crosses her arms.

"And then we'll pray that it's enough."

"Would you like some tea, dearie?"

Adora glances up from her book, only to find Madame Razz smiling back at her. Her nose wrinkles at the smell of the brew, which wafts from the cracked teapot clutched in Razz's hands. Some mixture of mud and sickly-sweet berries, Adora is sure. Though she can't expect anything different from Razz.

"Oh no, that's okay," Adora says, holding up the canister of caffeinated tea that she packed for herself. She's long since learned to pack her own food and drink when traveling to Razz's place. Otherwise she'll find herself choking down stale pies and rock-hard cookies and...well. That tea.

Besides, Adora doesn't go anywhere these days without caffeine on her person, or in her system. Other than literal *fear* , it's often the only thing that keeps Adora awake throughout the day. And the night.

Madame Razz hums in reluctant acceptance and lowers the pot back onto the table. She always takes it as a personal offense when Adora rejects her tea.

"No tea, yet you come to Madame Razz's shack? You're so silly to travel all this way, Adora."

It's taken a long time, but it seems that Razz has finally figured out Adora's name. For years, Razz seemed to always be shifting between the present and the past, thereby helping two different She-Ra's simultaneously—Adora's predecessor, Mara, and Adora herself.

But, of course, all that time-jumping confused Razz quite a bit. She'd always end up mixing up Mara and Adora's names. And she

never had a clear sense of what day it was, or how much time had passed between any given set of moments or days or *weeks* .

But that's changed more recently. She consistently calls Adora by the correct name. And Razz now actually seems to maintain a schedule of some sort, as evidenced by the way she invites Adora to tea every Sunday.

Not that it's Sunday today. Nope. Today, Adora is here for an entirely different reason.

Today, Adora woke up early this morning to head to the library, same as usual—only to discover Cleo there, waiting for her. Sitting at the wooden table Adora had claimed the day before. Ready to guard and watch and *judge* in that obnoxious way of hers.

Evidently, Catra hadn't asked Glimmer to change Cleo's orders yet. Because that was exactly what Adora wanted to avoid, wasn't it? Having Cleo sitting there, staring at her, as Adora sought escape from the world between rows of sprawling bookcases.

So, amidst grumbled curses, Adora grabbed a few books off the shelves, loaded them into her backpack, and immediately sprinted back out.

Cleo tried to follow Adora, sure. But Adora is much better at navigating the Whispering Woods than most—she's had a lot of practice over the years, thanks to various battles and recon missions during the war. She easily lost Cleo within mere minutes of ducking between trees and bushes.

Still, Adora couldn't just wander the Woods all day. Not with a backpack of books weighing her down.

So...she visited the only remaining place that Cleo wouldn't know about.

Here. Razz's shack.

"Just wanted some peace and quiet," Adora says, smiling gently. "Thanks for letting me sit and read here, Razz. You're really doing me a favor."

"No worries, dearie!" Razz beams, and sets a plate of cookies in front of Adora. Cookies that are *definitely* rocks—which Adora once learned the hard way. "You're welcome to visit Madame Razz whenever you want."

Adora nods, briefly grasps Razz's hand, then attempts to return to her reading.

Though it's not easy. Throughout the day, Razz remains a somewhat distracting presence in Adora's periphery—storming all throughout the shack, sweeping and reorganizing so aggressively that she only creates more formidable messes. Not to mention that the smell of Razz's constant cooking (which mysteriously never produces anything edible and almost always results in a blazing fire) pushes Adora closer and closer to nausea.

But it keeps Adora awake, at least. It's truly impossible to sleep amidst this much chaos. The banging of pots and pans, the roar of the occasional fire, the curses Razz screams at some invisible foe name Loo-Kee—

And besides, Razz won't judge Adora's current state—not like everyone else does. She doesn't comment on the dark circles beneath Adora's eyes, or the disheveled appearance of her clothing, or the shaking of her hands. Here, Adora can simply *be* . She can be, and stay awake, and read as much as she wants.

Eventually, though, the sun starts to set, and Adora knows she should head back.

"Thanks for being there, Razz," Adora says, standing—then immediately leans down to press a light kiss against Razz's cheek. "I might end up back here sooner than Sunday. Is that okay?"

Razz couldn't possibly look more pleased at the prospect. "Of course, dearie! Madame Razz loves company." She gasps, as

though excited by a sudden epiphany. “You should bring that sweet wife of yours too.” With a flap of a hand a short chuckle, Razz adds, “She always tells the funniest stories.”

Adora smiles. Razz is probably the only person in the universe beside Adora herself who refers to Catra as ‘sweet.’ But Razz instantly took a liking to Catra upon meeting her. And Catra took a liking to Razz in turn, and takes great pleasure in regaling Razz with stories of Catra and Adora’s antics, back in the Horde. Stories that make Razz squeal with laughter.

“ *I wish more adults in the Horde were like that,* ” Catra once said to Adora, after visiting Razz.

“ *Like what?”* Adora asked in turn, laughing just a bit. “ *Incredibly weird?”*

“ *No* ,” said Catra. “ *Kind* . *She’s just so nice and well…* ” She sighed. “ *I’m not used to it.* ”

“Sure, Razz,” Adora replies. “I’ll ask Catra if she wants to join next time.

With a short pat on Razz’s shoulder and few rock-cookies for the road (which Adora immediately dumps into a bush), Adora is on her way back to Bright Moon. She makes good time—arriving in the castle before sunset, meaning that it’s probably somewhere around a half-hour before when she promised to be back.

Though when Adora arrives in her bedroom, she’s greeted by a somewhat unexpected sight: Glimmer, sitting on Adora’s desk, and Catra perched on the bed, stroking Melog idly.

Their eyes immediately snap to Adora’s face as she walks into the room. Adora blinks at them, confused. They’ve obviously been waiting for her, maybe have been for hours, but Adora can’t imagine why. She’s early, if anything, so it’s not like they should be keeping vigil for her arrival.

“What’s going on?” Adora asks, glancing between them.

She’s unable to keep worry from creeping into the question. It’s just that...Catra and Glimmer just look so *grim* , sitting here like this. Almost like they’re about to deliver some sort of bad news. Adora nearly finds herself fearing for Bow, or one of the other princesses, or any of their other friends—

But Adora’s panic is interrupted by Glimmer, who sighs loudly, shuts her eyes, and *teleports* something into her own hand.

At first, it’s too indistinguishable beneath the glare of Glimmer’s magic—utterly concealed by that glowing pink light. But when the glow fades, Adora sees a tiny faceted vial of some sort—clutched carefully between Glimmer’s index finger and thumb.

Color glints and sloshes within the bottle—some sort of blood-red liquid.

Glimmer gives the bottle a small shake—a flourish, even though it lacks enthusiasm.

“Here it is, just as you wanted,” Glimmer says. “ *Essence of Oblivion* .”

Chapter End Notes

I have a twitter now! follow me @chellethewriter for dumb she-ra jokes and updates about my writing.

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

Glimmer gives Adora some instructions.

Adora gives sleeping another try.

And sleeping brings some...unexpected side effects.

Chapter Notes

Hey all! Another chapter is here. This chapter is actually sorta happy! ...and also really not. Anyway sorry for duplicate notifications, ao3 would not show this fic's update in the index for whatever reason.

Also sorry for not producing art for this chapter either...I'll try to find time to do that this week, but who knows if I'll get the chance with my homework quantities. If someone else would like to do art, though... 👀 that would make me very happy.

In other news, I completed my 100k word goal in a single month for this fic. But unfortunately, it's still not finished. Getting close though. Thinking this fic will be somewhere close to 120-130k. Whoops.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora's eyes widen at the sight of that tiny bottle.

"*Essence of Oblivion,*" Glimmer said.

But could it really be true? Could Glimmer have truly changed her mind so completely?

She stares at Glimmer, dumbstruck, then glances at Catra for confirmation. Catra is already staring back—a small, gentle smile

curving across her lips. One that seeks to comfort, or encourage. And Adora is all too happy to smile back in relief.

"B-but," Adora stammers, returning her attention to Glimmer's anxious eyes, "you said that you wouldn't—"

"Yeah, well," Glimmer huffs, "luckily or unluckily for you, your wife —along with my *mother*, for some reason—refused to take no for an answer. So...I was outvoted. But make no mistake. I still think this is a very, very bad idea."

Adora's vision briefly flits to Catra, in awe that she managed to accomplish this seemingly impossible feat.

"I don't know what to say," Adora says.

"Then use your words to agree to these instructions," Glimmer commands, pointing to the vial with urgency. "You will drink this potion at midnight each night. No earlier. No later."

Adora nods frantically. "Yeah, of course. I promise."

"You will drink every drop," Glimmer continues, "and not ask or attempt to find more. After eight hours, you will wake up. And that's a full eight hours, down to the minute. Once you take the potion, there's no waking until the eight hours are done. Not for anything. You won't be able to wake even if you wanted to."

Adora nods. "I understand."

"Every night, I'll deliver *one* of these bottles. Just one. Do not skip a dose, and do not try to take two doses at once. As a condition for receiving this potion, Catra promised to monitor you for me, so I'll know."

"Okay," says Adora. "I'll do whatever you say. "

"I'm serious, Adora."

“I’m serious too,” Adora replies somewhat impatiently. “Trust me, eight hours of sleep is more than I’ve gotten in months. I’ll do whatever it takes to make this work. I mean that.”

Glimmer exhales deeply, then begins to nod. “Alright,” she says, and lays the vial upon the desk with a small *clink*. “I’ll visit in the morning to make sure you’re alright. Or, at least, to make sure that this hasn’t gone horribly wrong—”

Adora’s face splits into a grin and she surges forward, enveloping Glimmer in a tight hug—one that makes Glimmer groan with the force of her embrace.

“Thank you, Glimmer,” Adora says, pressing their cheeks together. “Thank you so much–”

“Yeah, yeah,” sighs Glimmer, rolling her eyes. “But like I said...I still think this is a *terrible* idea. Like...really, really bad. So if something goes wrong, it is *not* my fault—”

Adora nods again and squeezes more tightly. “Of course. And whatever happens, I’m so grateful, Glimmer. Really, you don't know *how* grateful—”

In a flash of blinding pink, Glimmer teleports from Adora’s arms and reappears at the nearby door.

“Don’t thank me until it works,” Glimmer says, and gestures to the potion, still lying in that delicate vial on the desk. “Remember. Take the potion at midnight *exactly*.”

Adora nods.

“And make sure you’re lying down when you take it.”

Another nod.

“You won’t wake up until eight in the morning the next day.”

“Yeah,” says Adora, squinting. Maybe just a little bit irritated. “The Horde taught math, you know.”

“And make sure you go to the bathroom before that—there’ll be no waking up in the middle of the night to pee, or—”

“Oh my god,” Catra groans, pressing a hand into her own forehead. “She’s got it, okay? Stop nagging her and let her get ready for bed.”

“Sorry,” replies Glimmer, starting to shuffle from the room. “I’m just...nervous, okay?” Glimmer now looks back at Adora, her features softening into a strange mixture of affection, nervousness, and assurance. “Sweet dreams, Adora. Or...I mean...no dreams at all…?”

Adora shrugs. “Yeah, uh. ‘No dreams’ is sort of the point here.”

Glimmer releases a self-deprecating groan, and then— “Alright, fine. No dreams. Have a good night’s sleep, okay?”

And with that, she departs—shutting the door behind herself.

Adora turns back toward Catra on the bed. A glance at the clock on the wall tells her that it’s still early evening...meaning that she still has a long while to wait before she can take the potion.

“Bit too soon to wish me pleasant dreams,” Adora says, approaching the bed. “I mean, I still haven’t eaten dinner.”

Catra’s smile twists into something distinctly mischievous.

“I’m having it sent up to our room tonight,” says Catra. “Thought we could eat it in bed.”

Adora watches as Melog gives a short mewl, then launches themself from the bed—heading to one of the nearby windows. Effortlessly, they slip out into the burgeoning night, climbing down the walls of the castle with the same skill Catra’s always shown—

not that the Bright Moon guards have ever appreciated Catra or Melog's tendency to sink their claws into the architecture.

Adora raises an eyebrow. When Melog leaves so abruptly, it usually only means one thing.

Catra stands—slinks, really—to a spot just in front of Adora. Her hands find Adora's waist, and she uses that grip to pull Adora closer, until Adora's body is flush against hers, eliciting a small gasp from Adora's lips. It's a wonderfully familiar feeling to press against Catra like this, their heartbeats mingling and hammering through the fabric of their clothes.

Adora can't help but laugh as Catra hoists herself onto her tiptoes, struggling to brush her lips against Adora's ear. It's not easy, exactly, given the fact that Adora more-or-less towers over her wife's small stature. But Adora appreciates it nonetheless—immensely enjoying the way Catra *stretches* and *reaches* to find Adora somewhere above her.

"I thought *maybe* I could spend the next few hours tiring you out," Catra whispers, stroking her fingers all along Adora's hips. Which, Adora notes with some amusement, are far easier to reach.

Adora bites her lip. "I actually think the potion's supposed to do that for me. That's why Glimmer said to lie down before I—"

"So?" challenges Catra. Her hands begin to tug on Adora's shirt, lifting it from where it's tucked into her waistband. "There's no reason I can't help."

Adora snorts, and winds an arm around Catra's back. With Adora's recent sleep troubles—and avoidance of beds and places meant for sleep in general—Catra and Adora have shared moments like these far less frequently than they used to. After all, Adora spends most nights at her desk, or even wandering the palace halls. Busy, always, just to keep herself distracted, and far from the temptations of sleep.

It’s something Adora feels guilty somewhat about—avoiding the bedroom whenever she can. Not that Catra’s ever complained. No, if anything, Catra has been far too understanding throughout it all. Always acting like Adora could do no wrong in her sleep-deprived state. Never initiating anything unless Adora did first.

And maybe that frightened Adora too, if she’s being honest. The fact that Catra seemed to consider Adora too fragile, or broken, to touch in the way Catra used to want.

But Adora still wants to. She wants to touch, and be touched. And finally, this potion gives Adora reason not to fear the bed they used to share each and every night.

“You do make an excellent point,” Adora remarks, yanking Catra even closer on the final word. “There’s no reason you can’t help.”

Catra gives a short hum.“Thought you’d agree.”

And then Catra is guiding Adora’s hands beneath her thighs. It’s practiced, the way Adora hoists Catra into her arms—into the air itself—while Catra folds her legs around Adora’s waist. Adora may be tired, but she has more than enough strength to lift Catra like this, and hold her tightly.

Deftly, Adora repositions her arms behind Catra’s back, utterly crushing their bodies together. Catra’s hands, meanwhile, link behind Adora’s neck as they kiss deeply, tongues lingering in each other’s mouths. With her eyes shut tight mid-kiss, Adora finally begins the stumble to the bed. It’s something they’ve done so many times before, and yet, Adora is relieved to even still be capable of it, given her recent unsteadiness.

“Thank you,” Adora murmurs, during the briefest of respites—a gasping breath taken just as Adora’s knees hit the mattress. She rests her forehead on Catra’s. “For talking to Glimmer—”

Catra just reaches up and kisses her again. “Don’t—thank—me,” Catra orders, punctuating each word with another bruising kiss.

It’s evident that she’s just as desperate, just as worried, as Adora is. “—until—it—works.”

The words echo Glimmer’s exactly, but Adora has trouble accepting them in either case. Adora can still hardly believe that tonight might be her first good night’s sleep in months. It’s almost surreal to her now—the concept of falling asleep, staying asleep, and waking up beside Catra in the morning, so long after she first settled down to rest.

But Catra’s also right, in a way. They still don’t know whether the potion will work. And what if Adora’s suspicions are right? What if Chasm *did* curse Adora somehow, or permanently damage whatever part of her brain that controls dreams? Will the potion just trap her in those terrible dreams for eight uninterrupted hours of misery—hours that will refuse Adora the minor reprieve of jolting upright in bed?

It’s a frightening thought—being trapped in her nightmares like that.

Though it becomes increasingly difficult for Adora to fear such things when Catra slips warm hands beneath her shirt

“I can’t wait to wake up next to you,” Adora whispers, low and longing, before she can stop herself. Because, really, she can’t stop looking at Catra. The way she seems to smile as she kisses Adora, the way she utterly arches into every kiss, like no measure of closeness will ever be enough to satisfy her.

And Adora really does miss it. She misses lazy mornings tangled beneath the sheets with Catra, or the soft dozing of a late night, or even the warm, blanketing relief of the midday naps they sometimes shared.

Adora expects Catra’s laugh before it even rings through the bedroom. But it’s a full laugh, a loving and joyous one, and Adora can’t even find it within herself to feel embarrassed.

“God,” Catra snorts, and kisses Adora’s jaw. “All this sleep deprivation has made you corny.”

Adora only returns the laugh and drops herself onto the bed, dragging Catra down with her. She can’t really disagree.

She waits.

Waits minutes. Hours. Centuries. It’s too difficult, really, to distinguish increments of time. Ultimately, that word, *time*, is meaningless to those who have never known the approaching deadline of mortality.

But from the second the potion dribbles down the girl’s throat, to the moment that interfering *brat* of a wife finally drifts off to sleep, forced to abandon her careful, watchful monitoring in favor of her own exhaustion…

She waits.

She waits and waits, until there is no need to wait further. Until Catra has sunk into deep, relaxed sleep. Her dreams, buoyed by sated desire and misplaced hope.

And then Chasm makes her first move.

Cool moonlight seeps through nearby curtains, but doesn’t quite reach the bed. And Chasm can see them. The bed. The curtains. She can see each and every detail of their forms, as well as everything else in her surroundings, with eyes she opens and closes of her own volition.

And it’s something incredible—to actually see and feel and experience a room, rather than view the echo of its appearance. The soft sheets. The glittering ceiling. The gently curving architecture.

Chasm can hardly recall the last time she viewed the world with real eyes, her last host perished so long ago.

She also can't remember whether it feels like anything—the kiss of moonlight upon skin. It's been too long since she had skin to claim at all. Sunlight...she remembers that felt like something. Like warmth. Heat. Burning.

But moonlight? Moonlight, she can't remember. All she has is stolen memories. And if she's learned anything through the millenia, she knows that mortal memories cannot be trusted.

It was almost too much effort to do it—to crawl. To drag herself from that dark, cramped corner of Adora's subconscious, plunging into the wider plane of her whole self. The girl's body, as well as her mind.

But now she's here. Finally, she is here, and in control. Just as she hoped—and planned—to be. Though it took far longer than Chasm anticipated for Adora to convince her friends to administer the potion. It is an old potion, after all. *Essence of Oblivion.* Older than Etheria, even. Old enough for Chasm to still recall what it does...and how to use it to her advantage.

But the dreams were enough, ultimately. To push Adora to her breaking point. To convince Adora to abandon her own mind in favor of this. Silence. Peace.

And a loss of control.

Too often, the girl's waking mind is too loud, too overwhelming, for Chasm to seep beyond it. Sparking and shrieking with emotions and anxieties, all too powerful to quell or overcome.

Such is always the problem with a waking mind—the type of mind Chasm usually seeks to restrain within her illusions, lest she find herself confronted by the frenzied herd of conscious thinking. All those endless, enormous, indomitable thoughts crammed into the cavern of Adora's head, suffocating Chasm with their loudness...

Chasm is powerful, yes. But not powerful enough to destroy an entire mind on a whim. The mortal mind is too willful. Too

stubborn. If something seeks to break it, it will only grow stronger—determined to exist and learn from the threat.

So no. Chasm cannot attack. She can only trick, push, manipulate—and let the minds destroy themselves at her suggestion.

And it was always easy, so easy, to do that within the confines of Chasm's conjured dreamworlds. To hijack her prey's senses, to convince those she trapped to renounce existing, leaving Chasm free to gain control of their bodies.

But another dreamworld is not an option in Adora's case. Not without raising suspicion. Only during the quieting influence of dreams can Chasm even emerge to work her magic—twisting Adora's senses and thoughts without any real means to seize control of them.

Until now, at least. Now, she has found something better than dreams. Now, it is blissfully silent. Like a large hall emptied of a screeching crowd—leaving only echoing walls and haunting architecture. A place free for Chasm to explore, and conquer.

It's like Adora is gone. Completely and utterly removed from the equation, with only Chasm remaining in her place.

Chasm smiles. And miraculously, she feels Adora's lips smile too. She tests the fingers, the toes. Flexing them carefully, allowing herself to grow accustomed to the body she occupies—without the fear of Catra waking and discovering what's occurred.

Hours pass, and sunlight slowly mounts some distant horizon, drowning out the moonlight in its entirety. Which means that the potion is near the end of its use, and Adora's mind will soon emerge from the blanket of full unconsciousness.

So for now, Chasm retreats. She has all the time in the world, after all.

Catra wakes surrounded by an impossible, almost unfamiliar warmth.

Almost unfamiliar. There's an arm slung over Catra's waist, a body pressed into her back. It's been months since Catra has woken to a sensation like this one—this sensation of being wrapped in another's warmth—and *Etheria*, she has missed it.

Excitement shakes all grogginess from Catra's mind. It's certainly Adora's body, curled around hers. And if Adora is still here, still in bed and holding Catra within her arms, then that could only mean...

Carefully, Catra wriggles around within the half-circle of that arm, trying to turn over without being too disruptive. Not, of course, that Adora should be roused by any movement of Catra's—not if the potion is working correctly. The clock's smaller hand is still only about halfway to 8.

But Catra can hardly help this instinct—the instinct to preserve Adora's sleep at all costs. The only thing that overcomes it is the need to see this miracle for herself, so she keeps shimmying, keeps turning over until—

Catra finds herself face to face with Adora. Adora, whose hair has fallen all over her face, and whose eyes have been crusted shut. As Catra watches, Adora's chest continues to rise and fall at a steady, peaceful pace. Like someone fast asleep.

No, not *like* someone fast asleep. Adora is asleep. Asleep, and restfully so. Asleep, finally. Asleep, for the first time in months.

Catra's face splits into a euphoric grin. It worked. She can't believe it worked. After everything they tried, all the treatments and sleep studies and potions, finally *something* worked.

Catra can do nothing but lie there, staring at Adora, as the minutes continue to tick by. Admiring the slackness of her features and body. The tangle of her hair. The now-fading dark circles beneath her eyes.

Only yesterday, those circles were so dark, and growing darker still. But bathed in this morning light, with her eyes closed and lips parted in gentle unconsciousness, Adora is practically *glowing* within Catra's sight.

Absently, she strokes her thumb against Adora's sun-warmed cheek. Adora doesn't react at all, just keeps sleeping—and though the potion's nature still makes Catra nervous...she thinks that so long as Adora wakes, it will be more than worth it.

God, Catra is so damn happy. So damn relieved. She remembers last night, when midnight finally arrived. Adora popped the cork on the vial and downed the potion in a few eager gulps, though her face twisted at the flavor.

"*What's it like*?" Catra asked.

"*Sickly sweet,*" said Adora, features still scrunched up in displeasure. "*And...coppery.*"

After that, though, it took only a few minutes for the potion to take full effect. Adora barely had enough time to arrange herself around Catra before she fell into deep unconsciousness, snoring softly into Catra's neck.

Slowly, the clock's second hand lurches closer and closer to that topmost notch. Closer. Closer. And finally—

Catra watches as Adora shifts slightly, releasing a contented humming noise that makes Catra's heart stutter with affection. Catra has always loved the sight of Adora in bed with her, but this is something different—something akin to a morning years ago, after Bright Moon was rebuilt and they shared their first night ever in this room. She remembers waking, disoriented, to find herself in Adora's arms. But as relief flooded her veins, she could only watch the sweet progression of Adora's waking. The stretching of Adora's limbs, the fluttering of Adora's eyelids as they slowly cracked open.

That was probably the first time Catra had ever woken up before Adora, early riser that Adora is. And this is the first time since.

And sure enough, this instance is just as mesmerizing. Adora's lips part, a small groan escaping as her back arches in a waking stretch. Her eyelids scrunch up a bit, like wakefulness is a sudden and unwelcome surprise. Though she seems to relax a little when she feels Catra's hand against her cheek, and she nuzzles blindly into the touch.

"Hey, princess," Catra greets. "Did you have pleasant dreams?"

Blue eyes finally slide open. Adora simply stares for several moments, blinking as though confused to find herself in bed.

And then her eyes pull wide. Her jaw drops open. She shoots up in bed, practically flinging her arm off of Catra in the process, and Catra can't help but grumble just a bit at the loss of Adora's warmth—

"I slept through the night?" Adora gasps, glancing about the room like it might dissolve at any moment. "Like...the *whole night*?"

Catra smirks. "You sure did."

Adora presses a hand to her own chest, as though trying to still her own heartbeat. "And I didn't…I didn't dream?"

"Well," says Catra, "you're the only one who can answer that question."

A few moments pass as Adora seems to process that. The hand falls from her chest. And then, gradually, Adora's lips spread into a smile. A giddy, disbelieving, utterly relieved smile.

"I didn't dream," beams Adora, shaking her head like nothing could be better than that prospect—the prospect of not dreaming, never dreaming again. Her giddiness is so insuppressible, her whole body seems to be vibrating. "I mean...I was just asleep. Asleep, and then I woke up. And not because I was scared, or

upset but because...well…" She turns to Catra, features softening into deep gratitude. "It was time to wake up."

Adora draws closer to Catra then, face leaning forward until their noses bump. Her excitement feels like a physical presence—an electricity. An energy that makes Adora glow like the magic beacon she truly is.

"And there was nothing?" Catra asks, returning Adora's smile with equal excitement. "Not even a little nightmare?"

Adora shakes her head and keeps smiling, keeps leaning in. Sighing happily, she adds, "It was just...nothing. Complete, *incredible* nothing."

And then, without further elaboration, Adora surges forward, capturing Catra's lips in a kiss that positively *steals* Catra's breath from her lungs. Adora has always been an excellent kisser as far as Catra's concerned, but this is something different. A giddy, dizzying, euphoric kiss with scraping teeth and searching tongue. The likes of which Catra hasn't experienced since they had first made it back from that plane between worlds, and Adora sought to convince herself that Catra was alive, and well, and still hers—

When Adora finally pulls away, Catra can only gasp for air and lie there, brain-addled, for several seconds. "Uh...wow?" Catra rasps, voice unreliable as she seeks to recollect her thoughts. "What was that for?"

"That was a thank you," Adora says, eyes half-lidded with lazy desire. "You said I couldn't thank you until it worked. And it did that. It *worked.*" She repositions herself until she's straddling Catra's waist completely—hovering over Catra with that glowing smile, arms braced against Catra's chest. "I feel amazing, Catra," she laughs, adding, "I think I literally forgot what it was like to exist without a headache."

"Incredible what a full night's sleep can do," replies Catra with a smirk, resting her hands on Adora's waist and holding tight.

Adora laughs again, stroking through the fur along Catra's sides and stomach. Catra gasps as a bit as the hands start to slide teasingly higher, toward her chest.

"So…" says Catra, giggling in a way that is *definitely* embarrassing, but she just doesn't care. She just wants to surrender to Adora's eager touch. "What are you planning on doing with all this renewed energy?"

Adora hums like she's considering the question deeply. It's been too long since Catra has seen Adora like this, all playful and enlivened by the prospect of spending a morning in bed together. "I'm thinking that maybe…" She keeps smiling suggestively as she strokes along Catra's naked sides. "I would try turning into She-Ra...just because I feel up to it…"

Catra's eyebrows shoot up. "She-Ra?"

"Uh-huh," says Adora, and leans down until their bare chests are pressed together, eliciting a groan from Catra's lips. "And then, *if* you're interested—"

"I'm interested," Catra replies, instantly. Blurting the words like they're *leaping* from her throat.

At that, Adora's smile broadens into something downright wicked, something that causes heat to spark and pool in that spot just beneath Catra's stomach.

Between their bodies, Adora's hand finally starts to fulfill some of the promises it made before, with all that teasing. "Good," Adora says. "Because...with She-Ra's help...I was hoping to *completely* and *utterly* ta—"

SLAM.

"Is she awake? Did the potion work?" comes Glimmer's desperate, fearful voice. "Please tell me it worked!"

And suddenly, Glimmer is there. Glimmer is there, in the bedroom.

Catra screams in surprise and *frustration* at this Glimmer-shaped delay in their enjoyment of the morning. Adora, meanwhile, gives a yelp and scrambles under the covers, hiding her nakedness.

"For Etheria's sake!" Glimmer exclaims, catching only a glimpse before she cups a hand over her eyes. "I guess that means she is, in fact, *awake*." And then, grumbling, she adds, "Too awake, if anything."

"What part of *knocking* have you not processed over the years?" demands Catra, pulling the sheet up to cover herself. Truly, it took too long to teach Glimmer not to teleport into their bedroom. This time she used the door, at least—though some warning would have been nice before it slammed open.

Glimmer throws up her arms in outrage but continues looking away. "I told you I'd be checking in on her in the morning! I guess I didn't realize Adora would be trying a deadly potion *in the nude*. Or that she'd spend her first moments of consciousness after it wore off trying to f—"

"Welp, I'm definitely awake!" announces Adora loudly, with a nervous laugh. "And I didn't have any dreams at all. So thank you —"

"And there's no weird side effects?" Glimmer asks. "You don't feel dizzy or nauseous or sleepy?"

"Nope," says Adora with a head shake. "I feel incredible. Better than I've felt in months."

"And you're sure?"

Adora nods. "Positive. And we're both fully covered now, by the way."

Glimmer lowers her hand and raises an eyebrow. "And I shouldn't be like...researching if increased sex drive is some sort of side effect?"

“I mean, if it is,” Catra says, with a smirk in Adora’s direction, “I’m *sure* we’ll manage just fine.”

Which earns her a glare and a swift elbow to the ribs from Adora.

“Glimmer,” says Adora. “I really can’t thank you enough. The potion was better than I even thought it would be. I didn’t dream at all, and I woke exactly when you said I would—”

Glimmer releases a massive sigh. “Well, I’m glad it worked.”

“And…” Adora continues, “can I try it again tonight? I don’t think I can go back to staying up all night. Not after getting sleep again, finally.”

Glimmer nods. “I’ll brew another batch. But the same rules will apply. Take it at midnight while lying down—”

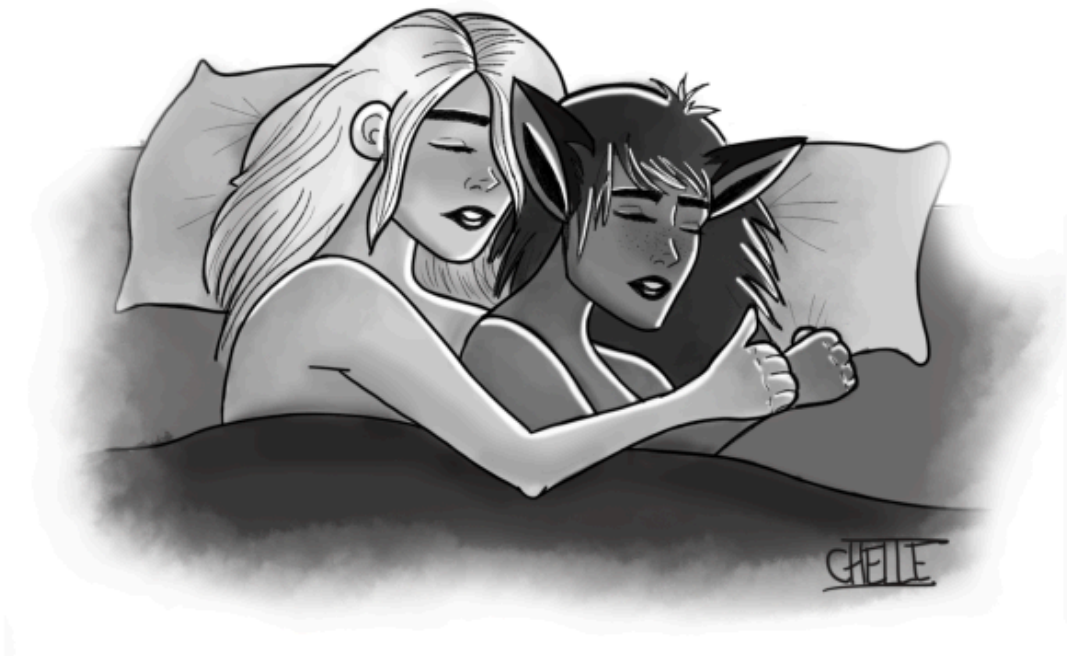
“—wake up at eight on the dot,” Adora finishes, nodding. “Got it.”

“Now would you leave our bedroom, please?” Catra begs, gesturing to the door, then to her wife beside her. “Adora was just about to summon She-Ra to—”

“Oh my god,” groans Glimmer, once again covering her eyes. “I do *not* need the details. I’ll drop off another bottle this afternoon, you freaks.”

And with that and a flash of pink light, she disappears—having finally teleported out of the room.

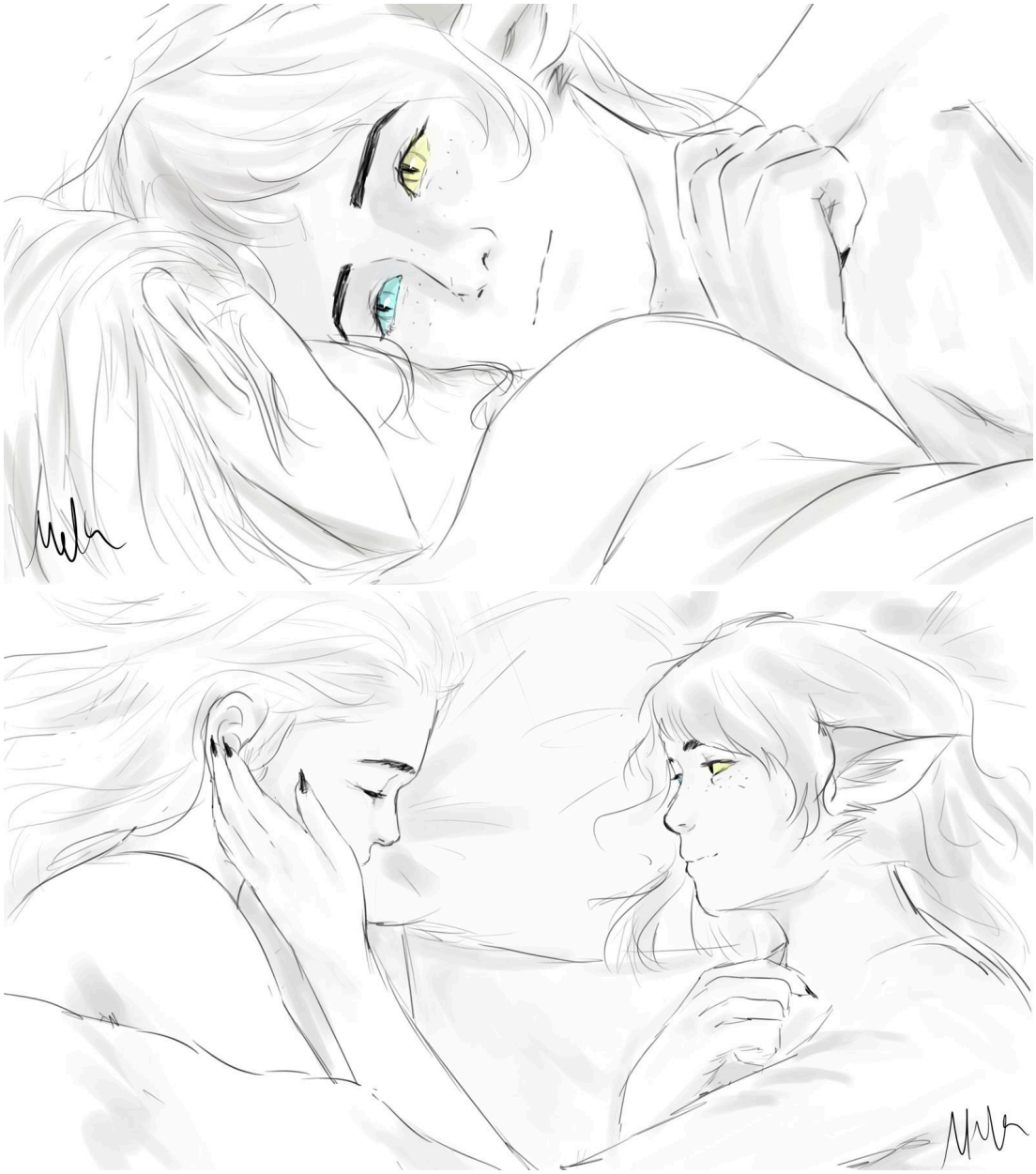
Once she’s gone, Catra tugs Adora back on top of her, smiling impatiently. “Now...what exactly were you saying before?”



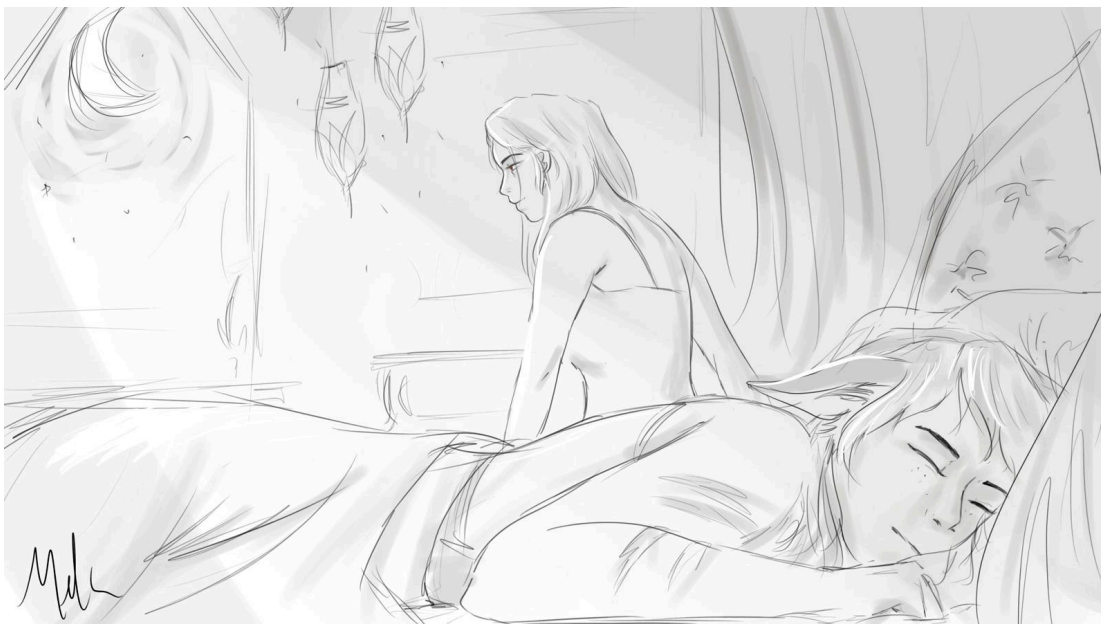
Chapter End Notes

REMEMBER TO COMMENT OR KUDOS PLEASE

also please check out the beautiful art of this chapter by @heycatrqdora on twitter!







Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

Adora gets her shit together (for now).
Catra suggests that they plan a vacation.
And Chasm plans...something else.

Chapter Notes

hey all! thanks so much for over 60 comments last chapter! sorry for the continuing agony but that's kinda my brand now so i'm just gonna roll with it

also writing chasm's voice is very very scary because i haven't written from a villain's perspective in a long time

ANYWAY please remember to comment or kudos because i crave validation constantly and i'm not even a little bit ashamed about it. also i want to create art for this chapter but idk if i'll have the time...i think im improving but i def have a long way to go

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Night falls once more. And with it, Adora's mind again tumbles into some sort of quiet abyss—one that is unfathomable in depth, and empty of everything save an opaque surrounding darkness.

Not, of course, that Adora is aware of such a tumble, or such an abyss. When the potion works its magic each night, Adora ceases to sense or think or feel at all. Instead, she is completely silent. Silent and silenced until those eight hours are complete, and the potion finally permits Adora to wake.

It is in those hours that Chasm finds freedom. Freedom from Adora's deafening thoughts and, more importantly, freedom to occupy Adora's body as if it were her own. Only with Adora muted

by the potion can Chasm maintain control of these eyes, these hands, these legs, and treat them as if they truly belong to her.

By now, she has learned how to leave the bed without notice. She's mastered the careful balancing of Adora's limbs as she lifts them from Catra's body, disentangling their legs, rolling off the mattress in such a way that the bed doesn't shift too noticeably beneath that cat-like *thing* they call a pet.

She steps, barefoot, out of direct view of the bed, coming to stand beside one of the windows. She lifts her hand for what feels like the millionth time, concentrating with all her might on the memories she stole from Adora, the mental instructions on how to summon this form of magic, a form that Chasm herself has never yet experienced—

"*For the Honor of Grayskull*," Chasm whispers, using Adora's lips to form the words—her hand still raised in the air, casting shadows against the moonlight. It's a desperate attempt, she knows, but it's all she has left—

Adora will never take sleep for granted again.

Every morning, she wakes from a night of dreamless sleep—blissful, *incredible*, dreamless sleep. Sleep that holds no nightmares, no misery, no visions of losing the people she loves.

And it's something miraculous—to sleep under the effects of the potion. One moment, she is nodding off to sleep, the moon at its peak in the night sky. The next, she is squinting awake—the eight hours already past, and the sunlight streaming gold through the curtains.

And Adora cannot get enough; she cannot stop reveling in the peacefulness of it all—this sensation of Catra lying beside her, cradled within Adora's arms. This feeling of sinking into bed, into sleep, without the fear that she might sink too deep, and begin to drown.

It takes several days, but slowly, Adora begins to recognize herself again. The dark circles—the ones that pooled around her eyes for months upon months—fade entirely. Her body ceases to feel like such a weight, such a burden upon her legs and shoulders. It's easy, even, to walk and carry herself without those horrific nightmares filling her mind. Lead weights, each and every one of them, now dissolved to nothing at all.

She finally finds the energy to take better care of herself—to detangle her hair, or properly wash and dewrinkle her clothes.

And for the first time in ages, she believes Catra. Adora believes Catra when she leans in close, fingers stroking against Adora's cheeks, and whispers, "*You're so damn beautiful. You know that, right?*"

Because it *is* beautiful to live, to exist, to sleep and wake and enjoy these other moments, the ones where she's laughing with her wife and her friends. No longer does she struggle to turn into She-Ra, or ride Swift Wind. And no longer does she feel so fragile, so on the brink of collapsing into tiny, thoughtless, irrational pieces—so frightened was she that Chasm left nothing of Adora sturdy enough to last.

"You know..." begins Catra one night, over yet another dinner shared in their bedroom. Something that they ordered special from the kitchen over a bottle of wine. "...our one-year anniversary is in only a few weeks."

Adora smirks at her and keeps sipping her drink. "Uh-huh."

"And I was thinking…" continues Catra, winding arms around Adora's middle, "since we've finally got a handle on this dream thing, maybe we could go somewhere special?"

An eyebrow raised, Adora asks, "Where did you have in mind?"

Another night, another failure.

There’s nothing. No matter how many times Chasm utters those ridiculous words, *For the Honor of Grayskull*, there’s nothing. Nothing at all. Not even a spark of glowing magic, or a flicker of power in Adora’s muscles.

Within Adora’s head, she curses. Chasm has attempted this every night since Adora started taking the potion. Attempted, again and again, to summon She-Ra—the glowing sword and immeasurable power—only to fail unceasingly.

Chasm fears that she may have miscalculated. All this time, she assumed that She-Ra was merely a power held within Adora. A weapon to be wielded by some chosen person. And truly, what else was Chasm to believe, when she had never once encountered She-Ra’s spirit here, in the corners of Adora’s mind?

No. She-Ra had to be some thoughtless, soulless thing. A power, and nothing more.

And so long as that was the case...if Adora was merely the vessel that carried and controlled the power that is She-Ra...then Chasm could wrest that control from Adora. Steal it, essentially, so long as she removed Adora from the equation. She could gain control of She-Ra. Gain control of near-limitless strength and power, the likes of which could protect Chasm from any more unwanted imprisonments, defeats, or attempts to obliterate Chasm from the fabric of the universe. Never again would she suffer what she has already suffered throughout the eons of her existence.

But now she fears that her plans—or rather, her means to achieve them—are more complicated than she anticipated.

Her worst fear is the one she suspects to be true. Perhaps when Adora takes the potion, it doesn’t just silence Adora. It doesn’t leave only She-Ra’s power behind, and Chasm’s mind to claim it.

Perhaps She-Ra is tied to Adora in mind, body, and soul. Bonded. Inseparable. One and the same. Enjoined, so that when Chasm

silences Adora, She-Ra is silenced and stifled as well—rendering She-Ra's power irretrievable by Chasm's grasping hands.

Leaving Chasm standing here in the dead of night, in Adora's body. Unable to so much as taste what she worked endlessly to gain.

"We could always just go to Mystacor again," says Catra, reclining back against Adora's desk. She stares, amused, at the veritable conspiracy board that Adora has mounted on the wall—one filled with photos of potential locations, each one accompanied by index cards that describe what each place contains. "I mean, it was great for our honeymoon."

"But that's boring," complains Adora as she pins yet another image to the wall. "We can't do the same vacation spot for every single relationship milestone."

"From what I recall, Mystacor was *far* from boring," Catra says. "For example...the night after Glimmer's induction might have been the best of my life. Do you even still have that dress?"

"What, the red one?"

"Well, the *other, other* red one. The long one with the gold—"

Adora snorts and pins yet another image to the wall. "Oh, that one. By some miracle, yeah, I still have it—considering that you nearly *clawed* through it last time."

Catra bites her lip and pictures the way it looked—that dress. The way the bodice clung tight to Adora's torso, plunging low enough to accentuate Adora's curves while revealing the taut muscles of her back and shoulders. "You should bring it."

Glancing back at Catra, Adora says, "Help me figure out where we're going—someplace that's *not* Mystacor—and maybe I will."

“Fine,” grumbles Catra. She sighs and hangs her head. “So what are the options?”

Adora smiles and steps back, gesturing enthusiastically to various sections on the board. “So this is the planet Castis. It has beautiful beaches and luscious forests—”

“Beaches like...with water? Or with clouds, like in Mystacor?”

“Water.”

Catra wrinkles her nose. “Gross. Pass.”

“Okay,” says Adora, deftly removing that card and photo pair from the board. “Castis is out.” She gestures, now, to an image of a sprawling jungle with vibrant wildflowers. “This is Solea, known for its lovely vegetation—including a billion different species of flowers. We could explore the rainforests—”

“Sounds like a place Scorpia and Perfuma would like,” Catra remarks. “But not so much of a perfect place for us.”

“Alrighty,” says Adora, and takes down that option as well. “Onto the next. What about this place? Nacrilles. It’s a planet covered in snow, which means lots of cuddling by the fire—”

Catra makes a gagging noise. “If I wanted cold, I’d go to the Northern Reach.”

Chasm cannot understand it. She will never have—and never want—such a bond for herself. Chasm would never relinquish herself to another’s mind. Never, ever. So why would She-Ra? Why would something so powerful surrender itself so completely to the whims of another—?

Rage spikes through every particle of Chasm’s being at the very thought.

Because it can't be true. It *can't*. She has devoted too much time, too much effort to securing Adora as a host. She can't now abandon her ambitions in favor of possessing some powerless nearby Etherian.

And there are so many of them, of course. So many Etherians to whom Chasm has spread, due to their encounters with Adora. Though Chasm has done nothing but lurk in their minds for the time being, rather than trap them in her usual illusions. A group of fallbacks, of sorts, while she's been too determined to do this—to trick Adora into relinquishing control of She-Ra.

An endeavor that has now failed miserably.

So what can Chasm do? She cannot let She-Ra walk free. Not when she poses such an enormous threat to Chasm's existence, with all that raw magical power. Even Adora herself has proven a threat, what with her recent obsession with finding wards against Chasm.

She supposes that she could simply trap Adora in another dreamworld, just like the one before. Chasm is still attached to Adora, after all. Still able to smother Adora beneath the blanket of a convincing dreamworld, and an inescapable sleep.

But Adora would be unlikely to fall for it twice. And she would be even more unlikely to let Chasm gain complete control. She'd notice the patterns she dismissed the first time—learn from her mistakes. And if Adora becomes fully aware that she's trapped within an illusion, it would only be a drain on Chasm's magic to keep Adora under her spell.

And that won't even solve the threat that Catra poses, Chasm thinks. Catra and Angella both.

She glances at Catra, still snoring lightly on the nearby bed. Unaware that her wife—or rather, wife's body—has escaped from her embrace.

Catra and Angella pose a...unique problem, one that Chasm hasn't encountered before. Never before had Chasm been weak enough to let two victims slip from her grasp. But ever since Angella and Catra managed to oust Chasm from their minds, Chasm hasn't been able to reattach herself to them. Not like she can with the other Etherians—whose minds she can invade as easily as one might walk into the ocean.

Now, whatever new connections Chasm attempts with Catra and Angella simply...dissolve. Like sand disintegrating beneath the tides. Like the foundation just isn't there, like it just won't support Chasm's power—

It must have something to do with how they escaped her clutches—something to do with how they discovered the nature of her illusion, and thrust Chasm from their minds. Chasm barely managed to hold on to Adora by stealing enough magic to secure and solidify the connection. But Catra and Angella now seem to be resistant, somehow. Their minds adjusted and immune to her attempts to infect them in any permanent capacity.

And Chasm cannot forget, of course, that Catra once successfully chose to reenter Chasm's illusion, with Angella's help. Using Chasm's own spells against her, slipping back into the very illusion designed to defeat Adora completely. So determined was Catra to deny Chasm her victory.

So Catra wreaked utter havoc on that illusion—unable to be stopped or affected by Chasm's power. Immune, in the same way her real body is now.

And Chasm hates that, especially. She hates the idea that she can be overcome, outsmarted. No one should be able to escape Chasm and claim themselves her enemy. And *especially* no one should have that kind of power over Chasm's own illusions.

Chasm supposes she could kill them now, using Adora's hands. Catra and Angella both. It wouldn't be terribly difficult. Adora's body is strong on her own, even without She-Ra.

But that won't defend Chasm from the fact that this planet is filled with sorcerers. Sorcerers who may very well be warded against her magicks, according to Adora's own research—research that Chasm has been avidly eavesdropping on.

Two of such sorcerers live in this very castle, and one even sleeps next to Angella. Which means that Chasm cannot dispatch Catra nor Angella without finding herself trapped by a group of magic-wielders immune to her power—

She needs more power. Power that neither Angella nor Catra nor *sorcerers* can escape. Power that proves, once and for all, that she can't be defeated, destroyed, sent away to some empty place to suffer in purgatory for all eternity—

Chasm needs strength. She needs She-Ra.

But how can she gain control of She-Ra, if she must leave Adora's mind intact?

There must be something, something she can do—

But her thoughts are interrupted by a sharp glare into Adora's eyes. The sun, risen again, but barely just. Which means that Chasm has again run out of time.

Time—the very thing Chasm should never have to fear—has become yet another enemy to worry about.

"So…" Bow says, glancing up at Catra from a stack of blueprints. "Have you decided on your vacation locale yet?"

Catra doesn't look up from her own set of files—namely, a report by the engineers Bright Moon hired to handle infrastructure improvements. So far, these engineers have run severely delayed and over budget—resulting in Glimmer and Bow reexamining their contract.

Catra offered to help determine whether the engineers were being truthful in their claims of "no misuse of funds." Catra, after all, oversaw many different tasks in the Horde, including the engineering of buildings and machinery, so she actually does have some expertise in this matter.

Expertise that tells Catra that something's amiss. With a report this long and filled with so much useless jargon, these engineers surely must be hiding something—

"Catra?"

Finally, Catra shakes her attention from the papers and looks up. "Hm?"

"Your vacation with Adora," Glimmer says, glancing briefly at Bow. "Have you decided where you're going? Adora said you were heading off planet."

"Oh," says Catra, thumbing through the paper stack. "That. We're still deciding, but right now it's between Antares and Sutera."

"Antares?" echoes Bow, smiling in wistful surprise. He leans back in his chair and crosses his arms. "I almost forgot about that place. How long has it been since we visited there?"

"Visited?" demands Catra in amused disbelief. "We were stranded there. And then Adora had to fight—"

"General Sunder. I remember," says Glimmer, then releases a loud snort at the memory. "God, what a *doofus*. Do you remember his armor?"

"Yup," recalls Bow. "And he looked especially stupid when Adora completely kicked his butt."

Another snort from Glimmer, followed by a sigh. "*Classic*."

"Well, Sunder's humiliation aside," Catra continues, "the parts of Antares that we saw, however briefly, were pretty beautiful. So we

thought it couldn't hurt to explore more."

"And what about Sutera?" Bow asks. "I've never even heard of that planet."

"It's small. Smaller than Etheria, even. But apparently there's lots of nice architecture and ruins and places to hike," explains Catra. "The people are really eager to have She-Ra visit, though, so we'd be staying with one of the planet's rulers or something. Which would be pretty fancy, I guess."

"Antares didn't offer something similar?"

"Oh no," says Catra with a scoff. "They didn't seem too eager to have She-Ra back at all. Not after the fight between Adora and Sunder." Catra smirks. "But hey, that'll make it more fun, if you ask me. Being feared by the populace to some degree. I'm kinda tired of the hero treatment, to be honest."

Glimmer raises an eyebrow. "And I'll assume you'll need several doses of Adora's potion for the road?"

Catra shoots Glimmer an innocent smile. "Probably, yeah."

Glimmer gives a sigh—though it's only mockingly aggrieved. "I suppose I could brew up several vials. But you'll have to make sure she takes only one at a time."

Catra snorts. "Trust me. We both know the drill by now. *Essence of Oblivion* is the potion we live by. It's *literally* all that keeps Adora asleep at night."

"Oh—by the way, I mean to ask you," Glimmer begins, smile fading as she sits up straighter in her chair. The way she always does when she's conducting queenly business. "Have you seen Cleo at all lately?"

Cleo. Adora's guard. Catra hasn't seen her—or heard about her—since the night before Adora started taking the potion. And if

Adora hasn't complained about her recently, it can only mean that she's removed herself from Adora's day to day activities.

Catra shakes her head. "Not lately. Though Adora hasn't had much need for a guard. Not now that she's able to stay awake, or turn into She-Ra on command."

"Hmm…" Glimmer flips to the next page of her blueprints. "Weird. She hasn't been showing up for duty the past couple days. "

Bow scratches his chin and adds, "From what I've heard, it's been like that with a few of the guards. Juliet told me that a bunch have been out for the last week. Maybe it's some kind of cold or something?"

"Maybe," says Glimmer, though she doesn't sound convinced. "Or maybe we need to hold a workshop on responsibility. I mean, just because She-Ra's back in commission doesn't mean that they can slack off—"

"Speaking of which," Catra huffs, and throws down the engineers' report—which she finally finished reading. "These guys are *totally* ripping you off. You need new infrastructure people stat."

Glimmer presses her hands to her face and groans.

Bow sighs and crosses his arms. Grumbling, he adds, "Maybe we should take a vacation, too."

Frantically, Chasm searches the collection of memories she stole from Adora. She seeks a detail, any detail, that might offer a solution to her problems—that might provide her with a way to gain control of this power that seems too far outside her grasp.

And somewhere from the murk rises...a memory. One of Adora's most traumatic, it seems. Adora, holding a sword—her first sword. Large-faced. Glinting. Crystalline. The weapon created by those Adora naively calls "the First Ones," simply because she never learned their proper name.

The sword that nearly lifted to the heavens and obliterated the universe. The sword that sought to weaponize and control She-Ra, forcing her to do as the First Ones ordered.

Somehow, they managed that. These "First Ones' managed to craft a weapon that controlled who She-Ra bonded with, and how she used her magic.

A sword that Adora—in resistance to their will—barely managed to smash into pieces. A sword that Adora kept, for some unfathomable reason, all throughout the war with Horde Prime. And one that she keeps even now, tucked away in a box in Adora's closet.

Chasm smirks. There might be hope yet, she thinks.

No. More than hope. An opportunity. One better than she even thought possible.

She stands there for a while, considering. Recalling. Planning. There's so much she doesn't know now, given how much time she spent trapped in that plane between worlds. So much has changed. But surely Chasm knows enough—

The mattress creaks as Catra shifts, an arm thrown out in search of Adora beside her. "...dora?" Catra mumbles, still more than half asleep. Chasm recognizes that she has less than a minute to rectify this before Catra gains any more awareness—less than a minute to climb back into bed and pretend to be Adora, cradling Catra in her arms.

But it's no matter. She has a plan now, at least. One to deal with She-Ra, and Adora, and even Catra too.

And all she needs to do...is find the one thing that Adora refuses to.

Chapter End Notes

i did a shameless plug for my fic lucky jacket in this chapter with the bit that references the planet antares. go read that if you like post-canon space-faring adventures.

and please check out this wonderful art for anachronism by assylamsh on twitter!

until next week!

Chapter 6

Chapter Summary

Catra sees something strange.

Adora changes the vacation plans.

And Catra asks Glimmer and Entrapta some questions.

Chapter Notes

I again failed to create art for this chapter because school is slowly destroying my will to live but what else is new. Maybe I'll have something later in the week, or for next chapter.

Also thank you for helping this fic reach 500 kudos! it's always really difficult to get people to read and interact with sequels so I really really appreciate all the comments and kudos this fic has gotten. maybe one day soon i'll actually have a decided chapter count for y'all, but let's not get ahead of ourselves.

But also please continue to comment!! it's my only source of serotonin during the school year

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A creaking floorboard.

While Catra tends to sleep deeply, her hearing is sensitive—able to detect sounds and frequencies that few other people can.

And tonight, her sleep simply isn’t deep enough to mute her senses. Not since Catra jolted awake from a recent nightmare. It was nothing special; one of her usual stock—a dream involving Horde Prime’s attempt to torture and chip her. Frightening, yes, but not enough to keep her wide-eyed and staring at the ceiling.

She barely opened her eyes before sinking back into some sort of half-sleeping state.

But as Catra drifts into a deeper sleep, and the dream slowly dissolves within her memory...

She hears a creak. The creak of a floorboard.

And so she cracks open a single eye.

From where she lies, Catra can see Melog curled at the foot of the bed, their magic glowing cool blue in the darkness. Asleep. Meaning that they're not the source of the noise, as Catra would normally suspect.

Catra inhales deeply, just as a precaution. She searches the room for any unfamiliar smells—the kind that would indicate the presence of some sort of intruder. Someone unexpected moving about the room. But there's nothing there, nothing odd. Just Adora and Melog, same as always.

Huh. Maybe Catra imagined it. Or maybe the palace is old enough that the floorboards squeak on their own—

But that's when Catra notices that her back is cold. Cold, without the usual warmth of Adora's arms draped around her body, or Adora's chest pressed against Catra's back.

Though it's not entirely unprecedented for Catra to discover herself like this—chilled by the night and deprived of Adora's arms. Catra has a tendency to toss and turn during her nightmares. And sometimes, if she grows too agitated, she'll ultimately yank herself from Adora's warm embrace.

Which leaves her like this. Shivering, and annoyed, with a hand braced out in a searching sweep behind herself, hoping to locate Adora by touch and then simply scoot herself backward.

If Catra really did toss and turn so violently, she can only hope that she didn't accidentally knee or elbow Adora in the process.

Adora is more prone to sleep-fighting than Catra is...but Catra has had a few episodes of her own. And if tonight was one of them, Adora wouldn't be able to complain beneath the potion's influence, and the last thing Catra wants is for Adora to wake up with some sort of mysterious bruise—

But as she searches with her hand, waving it blindly behind herself...she slowly realizes that there's nothing. Nothing to feel. Nothing to touch. Nothing, except for wrinkled sheets and icy blankets. No body, no warmth.

And suddenly, she notices that even Adora's scent is distant. Distant, like she hasn't occupied the bed in some time.

Both of Catra's eyes fly open, glowing blue-and-yellow in the darkness. Her head jerks—neck craning—as she seeks to examine the spot behind her, her thoughts jumbled at the prospect of Adora's apparent absence.

But as her eyes find the untucked sheets, deflated and lying loose on the mattress—completely devoid of a body besides Catra's own—she can only gape. Only *gasp*, with horror broiling deep in her core.

Because, there on Adora's side of the bed...is nothing. Nothing, and no one.

Adora is gone.

Catra's breath skitters. She doesn't understand. It's impossible. Or, at least, it *should* be—

Frantic, Catra's eyes flit about the room. Bouncing off every inch of floor and dresser and tabletop. Nowhere within sight does she find Adora, or any trace of her at all. There's only stillness. Only silence.

As far as Catra can tell, she is completely and utterly alone.

And it doesn't make sense. Adora is under the potion's influence. She can't move, can't leave the bed. So did someone take her? Did someone drag her from the bed while she was unconscious, kidnapping Adora from right under Catra's nose—?

But then Catra hears another sound. A shuffling noise from nearby. Nearby...within the closet, she thinks. The one carved into the same wall that abuts the bed. And *god* it's frustrating—the fact Catra can't see into that closet from this angle. Not without getting up and standing directly in front of it.

Perhaps it's the kidnapper, the one who took Adora—returned to steal something else. Glimmer did say that several guards failed to show up to their shifts. Maybe someone is taking advantage of that. Maybe someone intends to use this lapse in security to hold She-Ra for ransom. It wouldn't even be the first time, much to Catra's frustration.

But Adora is especially defenseless like this, with her mind smothered by the potion until morning—

Catra lies back down—pretending to be asleep. She resolves to ambush this intruder as they emerge from the closet. Catch them off guard and demand they reveal where they took Adora.

As she settles herself back into some semblance of a sleeping position, she leaves one eye squinted open—but only barely just. Just enough to see, but not enough to be seen.

And then...when a figure does *finally* emerges from the closet… passing carefully beneath the doorframe—

Catra realizes that it's not some random kidnapper. It's not even a stranger at all. It's—

Adora?

Adora, walking around. Adora, meandering barefoot toward the bed. She's wearing her usual nightclothes—gray shorts and a tank

top, her hair mussed and pillow-rumpled as it falls across her shoulders.

But that's all Catra can see from this angle. She can't get a good look at Adora's face. Not like this, not without craning her neck.

And for some reason...Catra feels like she shouldn't move. It's a strange instinct. This urge to stay still, stay frozen, for fear of drawing a predator's notice.

But that doesn't make sense either. It's just Adora. Adora, who Catra loves. Adora, who Catra would do basically *anything* for.

But it doesn't matter. Not now. Catra can only lie there—still and squinting—as she feels Adora crawl back beneath the covers. And it strikes Catra as strange—the caution, the steadiness of Adora's movements. Catra barely feels the brush of Adora's skin as she climbs into bed and rearranges herself around Catra, occupying the exact position she did earlier that night, right after she gulped down the potion.

Catra's whole body remains tense with confusion and disbelief. She can't believe it. Can't fathom it. It doesn't make sense that Adora was moving, and *upright*, and *walking around*. Adora shouldn't be able to do that—she shouldn't be able to do anything at all with the potion in her system. She should be unable form a thought, let alone a late-night urge to explore their closet.

So what was that? What *was* that?

Was Adora sleepwalking, somehow? Is that even possible for someone taking *Essence of Oblivion*?

Catra doesn't know. She can't even begin to guess, or understand.

And she can't begin to sleep, either. Not after that. And not after that strange feeling—the feeling that something was wrong. The feeling that Adora was a *threat*, somehow.

"Wait," says Glimmer. She blinks at Catra like she didn't hear correctly. "You saw Adora *what*?"

"Sleepwalking," Catra tells her. "I saw Adora sleepwalking."

There's a pause. A long one, as Glimmer attempts to process Catra's words. One that's wasted, Catra thinks, since Glimmer continues looking just as bewildered when it's over—and continues her confusion even as she crafts her next response, her fingers raised in a pair of air-quotes.

"'*Sleepwalking'* as in...walking around while asleep?"

Catra nods. The movement is short, frantic. Brimming with Catra's impatience. An impatience that only grows with each time Catra is forced to repeat herself.

"But that's not possible," says Glimmer, like it's obvious. And Catra resists growling at the very words.

"I *know* that," Catra replies, each syllable prolonged by her frustration. "Which is exactly why I'm telling you about it. And why it freaked me out so much."

Glimmer raises an eyebrow, and it's clear by her smirk that she's at least *somewhat* amused by Catra's claims—though Catra doesn't share the sentiment. Not in the least. There was nothing funny about last night. Nothing funny about the fear that simmered in Catra's stomach until sunrise finally came—

"Are you sure you didn't dream it?"

"Positive."

"But Catra...it's really *not* po—"

"I know what I saw!"

Catra doesn't mean for the words to escape as a yell, but that's what happens nonetheless. She clamps a hand over her mouth.

Sure enough, when she glances around, several guards and Bright Moon officials are glaring at her. It's a bad look, certainly. Yelling at the Queen. And Catra should really know better by now.

"Sorry," says Catra, now actively choosing to whisper. She clears her throat and leans closer to Glimmer, driven forward by the force of her conviction—and her own need to prevent last night's events from becoming kingdom-wide knowledge. They're in the dining room, after all, and people in Bright Moon love to gossip.

"I couldn't sleep at all afterward," Catra continues, and somehow, she manages to drop her voice even lower. "And the memory was still fresh and...well...*terrifying*, when morning finally did come."

Glimmer shakes her head. "But if Adora took *Essence of Oblivion,* she can't—"

"Move until the potion runs its course? Yeah, I know. Which, again, is *why* I'm freaked out."

Glimmer shakes her head and sets down her coffee cup. "I still think you probably dreamed it."

Catra nearly hisses when she says, "I'm telling you, I *didn't* dream it."

Glimmer makes a placating gesture, but still doesn't appear wholly convinced. And Catra can't stand this, she can't stand being dismissed when she *knows* exactly what she saw. And she especially can't stand not knowing what's happening to Adora.

An exasperated sigh blusters past Catra's lips.

"Is there...I don't know. Any chance that *Essence of Oblivion* has side effects that we don't know about? Side effects like sleepwalking?"

Glimmer scratches her chin. "I mean, maybe? Potions like *Essence of Oblivion* aren't administered very often. Mystacor has a record

of it being used maybe like...three times, *total*, in Etheria's history?"

Catra raises both eyebrows. "So it *could* be a side effect?"

With a shrug and sigh, Glimmer replies: "Well...maybe muscles and nerves can keep firing without the mind working to control them? I can't be sure. That might be more of a science question than a magic question."

Catra hums. "Maybe we should talk to Entrapta, then. See if she has an idea."

Glimmer bites her lip, still considering. "*Or* maybe I didn't make that batch strong enough."

With a head shake, Catra replies, "It didn't seem like she was having a nightmare."

"Maybe the potion was still strong enough to ward off nightmares., but not strong enough to keep Adora from sleepwalking? I mean...have you noticed Adora doing this during any of the other nights she took the potion?"

Again, Catra shakes her head. "Not that I saw. But then again, I could have slept through it. It was only by chance that I happened to wake up, and notice what was happening."

"Well...if she's actually doing it, it's definitely *unexpected*," Glimmer says, an eyebrow arching in curiosity. "What was she doing, anyway? You know. While sleepwalking."

Catra taps her chin, recalling. "She was in our closet, I think. Not sure what she was doing in there—I couldn't really see. But I saw her walk out and just climb back into bed."

"Huh. That's not *too weird*, at least. I'll quadruple check tonight's potion—make sure it follows the brewing instructions exactly. If it doesn't happen again, we can probably assume it was a fluke with how last night's potion was made."

"But…" Catra begins, nervous beyond explanation. "What if it *does* happen again?"

Glimmer stares at her for a long while, clearly unsure how to respond. Because truly, what can they do? Adora can't afford to stop taking the potion. Not now. Not now that it's finally letting her sleep through the night. And besides, is this even worth *stopping* the potion over? Is there truly any harm in letting Adora sleepwalk, even if it's an unexpected—and somewhat unsettling—side effect?

"There you are!" a bright voice calls, and Catra's thoughts utterly dissolve at the words.

Catra turns to see Adora striding into the dining room, smiling broadly. She looks well-rested and beautiful—same as Catra has come to expect, ever since Adora started taking the potion. Her hair curls gently across her shoulders, and her eyes shine in the vibrant sunlight.

And really, with Adora looking like this, it's a miracle that Catra managed to tear herself from Adora's side this morning. She only rose early to speak with Glimmer—to figure out what happened last night. Even despite her habitual late mornings, Catra just couldn't suffer another moment in bed—couldn't suffer another moment of agonizing over the events of the previous night.

It's not long before Adora is standing beside them—still smiling that bright, energetic smile.

"I'm not used to you being up before me," Adora says—and then, as soon as she's within reach, she leans to press a kiss into Catra's cheek. "What was the big hurry?"

"Nothing," supplies Catra quickly. She doesn't want to worry Adora—not yet, anyway. The potion is far too important to her, and Catra is *almost definitely* just overreacting. "Really, I was just hungry. And I couldn't wait for you to wake up because—"

"Right," huffs Adora, sliding into the chair beside Catra. She leans her chin on her hand. "Potion wouldn't let me. Guess that's the price I pay for a good night's sleep."

God, Catra hopes that she's overreacting.

"We still haven't finished eating, though," Glimmer points out, punctuating the words with a quick, conspiratorial glance at Catra. An acknowledgement of what Catra can't currently express through words—that Adora can't know about last night. Not yet. "So we'll still be here a while."

Adora grins as she unfolds a napkin in her lap, ready to start her breakfast. She waves a hand, trying to flag down a member of the kitchen staff. "What were you two talking about, anyway?"

Glimmer shrugs with far too much force. "Nothing important. Just trying to figure out how to detangle the mess that our old contractors left behind."

Adora laughs. "So those guys were actually ripping you off, huh?"

"Big time," says Catra, and slips an arm around Adora's shoulders. "But don't worry. I caught them red-handed."

After a morning of helping Glimmer interview new contractors, Catra returns to her bedroom to a strange but not-so-unfamiliar sight:

Adora, physically removing items from their walls.

Specifically, Adora is removing a hand-drawn diagram that she affixed to the wall within the last week. A table, large but simple in design. One formed of only two rows (one for Antares and one for Sutera) and two columns (one for the pros and one for the cons).

Such is Adora's favorite way to sort out difficult decisions. And if Adora is taking down the table, it can only mean one thing.

"Hey," Adora greets, glancing over her shoulder to shoot Catra a welcoming smile.

Catra returns the greeting, her heart driven to somersaults by the mere sound of Adora's voice. Never before has Catra heard Adora sound so happy, so carefree. Like there's nothing but bright days and peaceful nights ahead.

Adora uses her hands to tear the now-dismounted table into smaller fragments, then stuffs those pieces into the wastebin.

"So I just got off a comm with the royal family of Sutera," Adora continues. Her voice rises *just slightly* in pitch—the way it always does when she's preparing to admit something embarrassing. "And I *guess* there was some sort of misunderstanding when we spoke—"

"Misunderstanding?" echoes Catra.

"Yup," says Adora. "It seems that, for some reason...they think we already agreed to come. And have also started making preparations for our arrival."

Catra's jaw drops. "What?"

Adora scratches at the back of her neck. "I probably mistranslated something, back when I called about *potentially* visiting. And now they're really, really, *really*—" Adora's eyes widen comically on the last *'really'*, like she's overwhelmed by the Sutarians' enthusiasm "—excited for us to come. Though we could still go to Antares if you *really* wanted to. It'd just probably cause a diplomatic incident of some sort."

Catra folds her arms. "Seems like we can't go anywhere without causing some sort of diplomatic incident. "

"Look on the bright side, Catra." Adora steps closer and takes both of Catra's hands, gentling disentangling and uncrossing her arms. Her hands are warm around Catra's fingers. "At least this makes the choice easy."

“Easy, sure,” sighs Catra with a shrug and a mock-scowl. “But I have to admit—I was kinda looking forward to being a nuisance on Antares again.”

Adora gives a laugh of her own. “I’m sure you’ll have plenty of opportunities to be a nuisance on Sutera too.”

And Catra watches as Adora keeps laughing. Laughing, freely—in the way that makes a bubble of joy inflate in Catra’s chest—as her hands rise to clasp Catra’s shoulders, her thumbs rubbing slow, tender circles into Catra’s skin.

“But really, Catra,” Adora murmurs. “If you don’t want to go to Sutera, we can figure something else out. I just figured it was simpler to...I don’t know. Go with the flow on this one.”

Catra gapes at her, surprised by this development. Adora has never been the type to go with the flow. She *always* plans. And sure, maybe Adora doesn’t plan very well (strategy is Catra’s specialty, after all), but she always, *always* has a plan, no matter how terribly thaat plan goes wrong in the end.

Adora just isn’t...spontaneous. She never has been. And though Catra has never been bothered by that fact, it’s also sort of nice to see this change. To see Adora reduce her white-knuckled grip on the reins, if only by a fraction.

And besides, Catra didn’t have much of a preference between the planets, even before this update from Sutera. She’s more interested in time alone with Adora than anything else. The rest is just noise, just details.

So, with a sigh, Catra nods.

“Well. I thought we’d have more of a choice than this. But I *suppose* we’ll have just as much fun on Sutera, if we put our minds to it.”

Adora’s smile seems to broaden. “We definitely will. And—”

Catra watches as Adora steps closer to their shared closet—the one there, beside the bed—and clasps both hands around the door handles. With a small flourish, she flings open the closet doors—revealing a pair of suitcases, already unzipped and half-filled with clothes.

Catra's smile falters as she suddenly recalls last night. She pictures Adora emerging from that same closet, even when the potion should have rendered her immobile. Moving cautiously, almost, toward the bed, and slipping between the covers as though she never left.

Catra wonders if *this* is why Adora was rummaging in the closet. Was she packing in her sleep, or something of the like? Sleep-packing? Is that even a thing?

But then again...these suitcases look far too organized to be packed by someone largely unconscious. Only Adora—fully awake, perfectionist Adora—could fold a pair of pants that neatly.

"—the good news is that they're basically ready for us any time," Adora continues enthusiastically. "I have a ship lined up for us to take too. And Glimmer told me that she's almost done brewing the vials of potion I need for the road. So really, all we need to do is finish packing, and then we could probably leave by…" She gives a nonchalant shrug. "...tomorrow night."

"T-tomorrow night?" Catra stammers, eyes pulled wide in surprise. Because truly, *this* is far more spontaneity than Catra ever thought possible from Adora. "But are you sure you want to leave so soon?"

Adora's nod is serious and certain. "We haven't left the planet since...y'know. The incident in the portal. I think it's about time we went somewhere—saw something new."

Catra just stares, still too stunned to properly respond.

Adora's smile shrinks a bit. Not *disappearing*, exactly, but...growing softer. "I want to move on from all of this stuff,

Catra. The fake time travel. The thing with Chasm. The nightmares. And I think a healthy change of scenery will really help."

She outstretches a hand, reaching for Catra's. An inviting, awaiting gesture—but not a forceful one.

"But again...if you're not ready, I'm totally okay to wait. I know this is all pretty sudden."

It's easy for Catra to take Adora's hand, just as she usually does. Entwining their fingers. Tracing the edges of Adora's palm. They've held hands since they were children, after all, and sometimes Catra thinks it feels more natural to hold Adora's hand than it does to let her own fingers hang by her side, loose and cold and lonely.

But that doesn't mean Catra is confident in this choice.

Because Adora is right—this decision *is* sudden, and unexpected, and Catra might not be ready to leave Etheria. Not yet, anyway. And not for the reasons Adora might think.

Catra is frightened. She's frightened about what happened last night. About what it means, or whether it might happen again. And she's not so sure it's a good idea for them to leave the planet before they know more about this *sleepwalking* thing—

But Adora is standing there, smiling at Catra like nothing could possibly be wrong in the entire universe. And Catra just can't find the bravery to voice these fears to her, nor the cruelty to tell her *no*—to deny her this change in scenery she craves, and deserves, so much.

"I'm...not a very fast packer," Catra mumbles, refusing to meet Adora's gaze. "So I don't know if I'll be ready in time."

"Oh yeah. I realized that." Adora gestures to one of the suitcases. The one that presumably belongs to Catra, since Adora definitely

doesn't own enough outfits to fill two large bags. "That's why I maybe...*sort of*...kinda...started packing for you."

Catra rolls her eyes. "Of course you did."

"I can unpack it if you want!" Adora is quick to assure. "But I thought it would be *helpful* to give you a head start—"

Catra walks over to her suitcase to examine Adora's progress thus far, and immediately notices something unexpected—a dark red suit, the one from Princess Prom all those years ago, is neatly stacked at the top.

"Seriously?" Catra laughs, and lightly kicks the suit with her toe. "You packed this old thing?"

"Well, sure," mutters Adora with another shrug, and Catra notes that she sounds oddly defensive about it. "It matches the dress you wanted me to pack. So I thought it made sense."

"Sure, it matches," Catra agrees. "But I don't even think it *fits* anymore. I mean, it's been years since I last tried it on."

Adora's voice seems to recede in on itself. "Well, it should still fit. Especially considering that I took it to a tailor to make sure—"

Catra turns to gape at her, wildly amused. "You took it to a *tailor*?"

"Just to make sure it would still fit!"

"Wow," remarks Catra, all smugness as she leans back against the wall of the closet. "You must really like that suit."

"What?" demands Adora. "Like I said: it *matches* the dress."

Catra can only laugh at her. "And since when do *you* care about things matching? No offense, Adora, but fashion isn't exactly your strong suit."

"Fine. You know what?" Adora sets her jaw and again places both hands on her hips. "I admit it. I love that suit. I *love* it. That suit was basically my sexual awakening, back when you first wore it. And I know you feel the same about that dress from Glimmer's ceremony, so really, I think it's only fair—"

Still laughing, Catra surges forward and clamps her hands over Adora's, using her grip to pull her wife within proper reach of her lips. What results is a slow, hungry kiss—one that Adora quite literally sighs into, the tension from Catra's teasing practically melting beneath Catra's touch.

It lasts for some immeasurable quantity of time, that kiss, and only grows hungrier with each passing moment, quickly descending into movements of tongues and hips and hands. Catra barely manages to find enough breath to say, "*God*, If I knew the suit worked you up this much, I would've worn it a lot more often.."

Adora laughs into her mouth, then moves downward to kiss Catra's throat. Against the skin of her neck, Adora whispers, "There's nothing wrong with saving a good thing for a special occasion…"

"And are you sure you want to leave tomorrow?" Catra asks, working furiously to bar all nervousness from her own voice. Which is especially hard to do with Adora's lips working their magic, forcing all coherent thought to evacuate Catra's brain—

She feels Adora nod. "Positive."

"Really, really sure?"

"Catra," Adora says seriously, pulling away to stare directly into Catra's eyes. "I'm sure. Really, really sure. I want to go somewhere new with you. And I don't want to wait."

"Aren't you coming to bed?"

Catra glances back—at Adora, behind herself. Adora is already nestled beneath the covers, staring at Catra expectantly. Her latest bottle of potion is already clutched between her fingers. Even from here, Catra can see the way Adora thumbs over the cork. Ready to pop it open, drink, and *sleep*.

"It's almost midnight," Adora adds. "And I'm pretty tired from all that packing."

Nodding, Catra replies, "I will soon. But...not yet"

Adora only raises an eyebrow.

"I'm a bit too wired to sleep right now," Catra claims, swaying a bit on her heels. "Thought I'd go for a quick walk."

"You're not nervous, are you?" Adora asks, her features softening. "About leaving tomorrow, I mean?"

Catra shakes her head fiercely. "No, I'm not. I'm just...antsy, is all. Not ready to sleep just yet." Somehow, she musters a playful smile. "As nice as it is to cuddle with you, sometimes I want to stay up a bit later than midnight."

"Okay," says Adora, like she understands, and returns the smile. "I'll probably be asleep when you get back, then."

Though she doesn't yet intend to climb into it, Catra walks back toward the bed. She bends herself over it, cupping her hand behind Adora's head as she leans down, dropping a kiss right between Adora's eyebrows. Then her nose. Then both her cheeks. Laughing, Adora gives Catra a light shove toward the door.

"Alright, alright," Adora says. "Go for your walk. I'll still be here when you get back."

"Promise?" Catra jokes, starting to walk away. Or, at least, she *intends* for it to be a joke...but as she envisions the events of the previous night, she suddenly wonders whether it will be enough. Will the potion—or the promise—be enough to keep Adora in bed,

or will Catra return to the sight of Adora wandering around the bedroom yet again?

"Well, I kinda have to be." Adora gives the potion a little shake. "Seeing as this will keep me from going anywhere."

"Right," says Catra. "That's how the potion works, after all. No moving after drinking."

An uneasy pause settles between them. As it progresses, Adora only seems to grow more confused, and Catra, more nervous.

"Seriously, Catra," Adora urges her, breaking the silence. She makes a shooing motion with her hands. "*Go*."

"Got it, got it—" Catra says, and turns back toward the door—striding forward, finally, with the intention to actually leave. "See you in a bit."

"No I won't!" calls Adora, in reply. "The potion, remember?"

"Right," mutters Catra yet again, her teeth gritted only slightly as she turns the corner to leave the room. "The potion."

Because the truth is...Catra doesn't really plan to go on a relaxing walk.

"Hey," Catra greets, half-whispering into the tracker pad. "Sorry for calling so late. I had some...uh...*sudden* developments on the whole vacation thing, and turns out we're leaving tomorrow. So the issue became sort of urgent."

She glances at her surroundings. Catra doesn't know why she's so nervous about being caught. Currently, she sits in an abandoned conference room—one that's completely dark, save the single lamp. One that Catra lit solely to illuminate her face for the camera.

It's not like Adora is going to barge through the doors and discover this call. The potion should *technically* keep her in bed (or that's at least what Catra hopes). And even if it doesn't, what could Adora possibly grow angry about? The fact that Catra is *once again* worried about her well-being, and trying to seek help on her behalf?

But Catra just feels altogether...on edge. Like something is about to go wrong.

She just can't identify *what*.

"No problem, Catra!" comes Entrapta's voice from the other line. Through the screen, Catra can see Entrapta's pink hair waving an eager greeting—and a wide grin spread across Entrapta's cheeks. "I wasn't planning on sleeping tonight, anyway. I'm running several simultaneous experiments, and really, I can't afford to miss a second of observation—"

Catra blinks. "I mean, Entrapta, you *should* try to get some sleep tonight. Even just a little—"

Entrapta flaps a hand. Or rather...her hair. "Oh, it's nothing to worry about—though I appreciate the concern. I slept a full twenty-four hours yesterday to prepare. And sure, my circadian rhythm will be a bit disrupted, but we all make sacrifices in the pursuit of science—"

"Uh-huh," Catra agrees, slowly. "And speaking of circadian rhythms…"

"Oh, right!" Entrapta beams. "You mentioned something about Adora sleepwalking–?"

Catra nods. "So Adora's taking this magic potion. It's basically designed to completely silence the brain during sleep. Prevent dreams. A 'coma in a bottle' is what Micah called it…"

Something explodes just off-screen, but Entrapta doesn't so much as flinch. "Right."

"But the other night...after Adora took the potion...I woke to discover her sleepwalking. Which is supposed to be *impossible* under the effects of the potion. And so, I need to know how that's possible."

"Well, why are you calling me?" Entrapta asks, seeming genuinely confused. "Magic potions aren't really my area of expertise. Have you asked Glimmer?"

"Of course I have," replies Catra. "But Glimmer didn't know. This potion—it's really rarely used. Which means that they don't have a good idea of its side effects. So I was hoping I could get your input. You don't know a lot about magic potions, sure. But you know a lot about science and the brain and all that stuff."

Entrapta scratches her chin with a strand of hair. "Hmm...well. If this potion really *is* a 'coma in a bottle,' like you described...then sleepwalking should be impossible. That's why you don't see many people in comas moving around. In fact, when people are in comas, there's no sleep-wakefulness cycle or anything of the sort."

Catra pulls the screen closer. "Sleep-wakefulness cycle?"

Entrapta grins. "Believe it or not, science doesn't actually *know* what causes sleepwalking, or dreams. There are theories, of course—and boy, do I have plenty of them! But one thing's pretty clear. There's a sleep-wakefulness cycle. Stages of sleep. And it's in these different stages of sleep that dreams—and sleepwalking—occur."

"Okay," Catra says slowly, feeling like, for the first time in her life, she might actually understand one of Entrapta's explanations.

"Now the real question is whether there's still a sleep-wakefulness cycle when Adora's taking this potion. If the potion only targets dreams, it's possible that she could, maybe, still manage to sleepwalk. But it's far more likely that potion targets the cycle as a whole—meaning no dreams, no sleepwalking."

“Alright,” Catra nods. “So how do we know which one the potion targets?”

Entrapta shrugs. “No idea! Like I said, I’m no expert in magic potions. Only science.”

Exasperated, Catra groans and thrusts her face into her hands. “There has to be something. Some way for us to figure this out.”

“Well...I *suppose* we could do a brain scan on Adora while she’s under the potion’s influence. That might help us identify whether any part of the sleep-wakefulness cycle remains intact.”

“But I don’t have time for that,” Catra sighs, and begins to rub at her own temples. “We’re leaving *tomorrow*. And if this becomes a problem—”

Entrapta gives an empathetic grimace. “Truthfully, Catra, I doubt it’s anything to worry about. Sleepwalking is pretty common, and fairly harmless in most cases. So unless Adora is doing dangerous things like driving vehicles or wandering towards open windows while asleep, I really don’t see this as a reason to cancel your trip.”

Sighing, Catra says. “I know. I know it shouldn’t be a big deal. It’s just…” She makes a sound—some strangled cross between a scoff and a gasp. “I just got a really bad feeling about it, last night. Like it was something dangerous. And not in the sense of *wandering toward windows* or *driving vehicles*. But like...it was something unnatural, almost.”

Entrapta pauses, considering Catra’s words and nodding.

But then she claps her hands together, causing Catra to jump. “Well, rest assured—sleepwalking is very natural, and really nothing to worry about. I could lend you some additional readings on the subject if you think that’ll help you get more comfortable with the idea. For example, my favorite paper on sleepwalking is ‘*The Neuro-Mysteries of Somnambulism—*”

Catra's attention on Entrapta's words rapidly diminishes as she launches into a description of the paper—as well as the paper's predecessors. And suddenly, Catra wishes she were back in bed, enclosed in Adora's arms. Because, really, if even *Entrapta* thinks that Catra is overreacting about this whole sleepwalking thing, she probably is doing just that—overreacting.

Maybe she should just say her goodbyes and head back. Back there, to Adora, and fall asleep looking forward to their impending vacation—

But sound utterly *smashes* back into focus as Catra hears something. A loud noise from outside—her ears perking in response to it. To that...clattering. A dissonant, metallic impact followed by a heavy sort of thud. A strange sound to hear—especially at such a late hour.

Entrapta is still talking eagerly, now pulling up some sort of diagram that's far too difficult to read on the small screen. Catra ultimately has no choice but to shush her, ears straining and searching for more. Searching, in particular, for some evidence that such a loud noise is nothing to worry about.

But there's nothing. Only silence.

For a long while, Entrapta sits there, quiet, as Catra continues staring at the door and listening. Full, long minutes pass before Entrapta hisses, "What's wrong?"

"Not sure yet," Catra replies, whispering in turn. She stands soundlessly—refusing to so much as let the chair scrape against the ground. "But I heard something. I'm gonna go investigate."

Entrapta gasps in giddy excitement. "Oh, I *love* investigations. Please keep the comm open, I wanna see—"

Catra shakes her head. "Sorry, Entrapta. I'll call you back."

Entrapta's protest is cut off mid-sentence as Catra hangs up the call. The tracker pad continues glowing eerily as Catra abandons it

on the table, its radiance casting odd shadows as Catra approaches the door. Her movements are steady, cautious, as she presses her ear against the door itself.

But there's nothing. Not a sound.

And for some reason, that doesn't strike Catra as a comfort.

Slowly, Catra presses down on the handle—and releases it just as gradually, working open the door like she's unwrapping a fragile gift. Somehow, she manages to drag it open without so much as a creak—though she doesn't pull it wide. Not completely, anyway. She merely passes through the smallest crack she can, noiselessly slipping into the hallway beyond.

She expects an empty hallway. Or rather, an empty hallway populated with a guard, as most hallways in the Bright Moon palace are at night.

And that's exactly what she finds once she exits the room.

But it's just not how she envisions it. Not at all. Because that guard—the one guarding this hallway—appears to be crumpled on the ground. Face-down, collapsed, with their robes strewn out like broken wings, and their spear fallen to the ground by their side.

And Catra can perfectly imagine it. She can perfectly imagine how the sound she heard was produced—the way the spear clanged shrilly as it fell, producing that dissonant clattering. And the way the guard's body *thumped* as it hit the floor.

Catra approaches tentatively, at first.

"Hey!" she calls to the guard. "Are you okay?"

But she knows the guard is not. Anyone could see that, laid upon the floor like they are—

The lack of response is Catra's invitation to draw closer, and keep drawing closer. "I need some help over here!" Catra calls, frantic,

to no one in particular. Hoping, desperately, that some sort of palace doctor will emerge from thin air. "I think this guard is hurt!"

But she hears no one moving—no one coming. It's like everyone—the entire palace—is fast asleep.

Everyone except Catra.

She sprints, then, to the guard's side. Falling to her knees beside them, legs squealing across the marble floors. Her hand fumbling and shaking as it travels to their neck, searching for a pulse. She's relieved to find one—a steady thumping beneath her finger. Meaning that the guard is alive, at least. Just unconscious.

Though lying face-down surely isn't helping them.

And so, Catra grabs hold of the guard's shoulders, pushing and *pushing* them to the side in hope of turning the guard over on the ground. It takes considerable effort—this guard isn't light, and Catra hasn't been maintaining her strength with enough care. But eventually, she does it. She pushes over the guard, and rolls them onto their back.

"I could really use some help here!" Catra keeps yelling, hoping that someone will hear.

Catra takes a moment to yank the guard's uniform out of their face. The long, horse-hair plume. The rumpled robes. And then, finally, in an effort to more fully identify what's wrong, Catra shimmies the helmet from the guard's head—revealing the features beneath.

And it's a normal face. One that Catra has seen before, one that she recognizes, though she can't recall the guard's name.

But there's something *there*, on the forehead. Something that makes Catra gasp and drop the helmet to the ground, resulting in yet another unholy clatter.

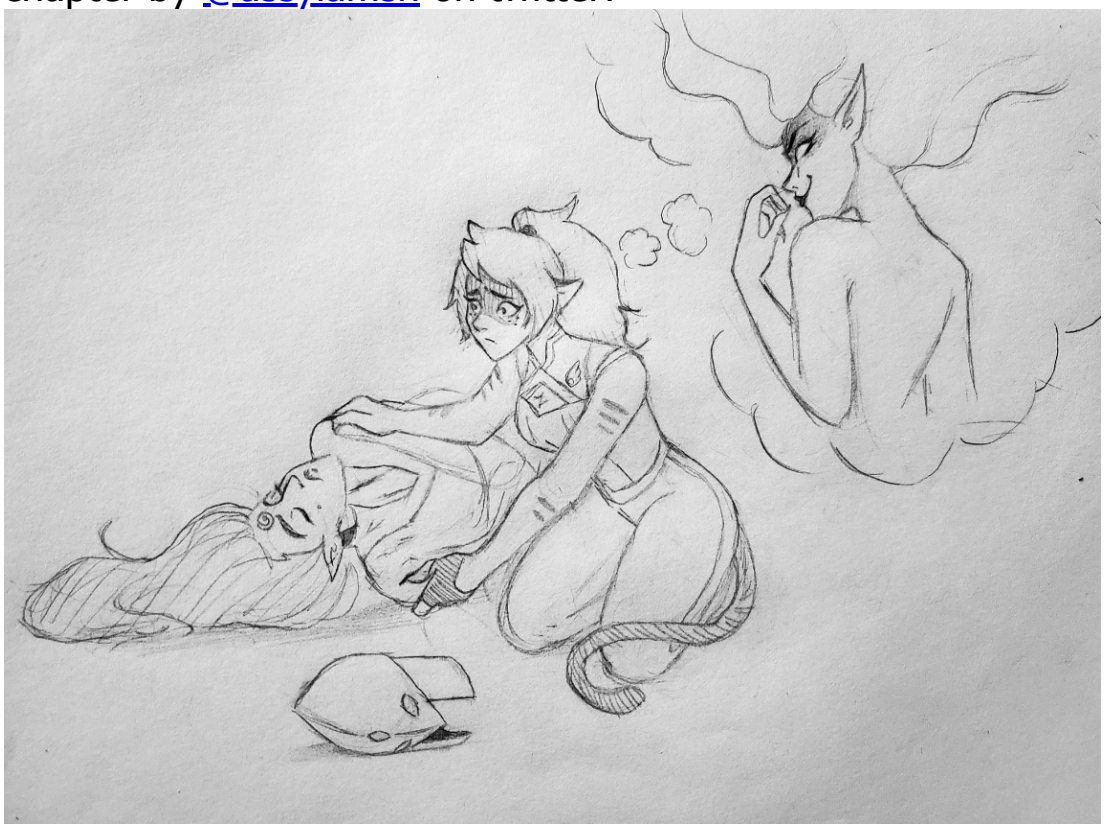
Because there, on the unconscious guard's forehead...

...is a glowing, red spiral.

Chapter End Notes

anyway! hope you enjoyed the last couple happy but tense chapters! because that's gonna be the last bit of happiness for a while :)

also please enjoyed this absolutely gorgeous art for this chapter by @assylamsh on twitter!



Chapter 7

Chapter Summary

Catra goes for a run.

Adora takes a fall.

And Chasm makes a mistake.

Chapter Notes

hey all! welcome to chapter 7 of immemorial. prepare for pain and good times.

I actually had time on Monday to do a colored drawing for this chapter! I'm sorry if it's mediocre I'm trying to get better lol.

Also y'all should check out this amazing song ehj made for this fic! and also you should check out ehj's fics because they're equally amazing.

Anyway, please enjoy! Remember to leave a comment and/or kudos or else i don't know what the hell is going on.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra scrambles backward—sliding, crawling on her palms. Only vaguely does she register herself gasping and screaming herself raw. Hyperventilating, even. She can't be entirely sure. Her senses have narrowed to that single spiral, glowing so faintly in the dulled lamplight of the hallway. Impossible, but there all the same. Taunting Catra with its hungry, irremovable glowing.

Because it's *not possible*. It's not possible for that spiral to be there. For it to be working, for it to have pulled that guard under its spell—

But it's there. It's there, unquestioningly so. And Catra doesn't understand. She beat Chasm. She *beat* her. Which means Chasm can't be here, she *can't*—

Without another thought, Catra finds herself rising to shaky feet and *running.* Running, furiously, down whatever hallways she can find, turning blindly through forks and bends and corridors.

All throughout her sprints, she sees new details that add to her horror—more bodies sprawled, unconscious, upon the ground. Guards. Groundskeepers. Other members of the palace staff. All of them, lying as though peacefully asleep.

But Catra knows otherwise. Can *see* otherwise, even as she runs. She can see it on the guards who aren't wearing their helmets, or the cleaning staff who lie slumped on their backs.

The spiral. Chasm's spiral. Glowing there, on each of their foreheads—

Has Chasm infected everyone? Everyone in Bright Moon?

Catra is shaking. Shaking, uncontrollably. This is a nightmare, it must be. Because Chasm couldn't have—she couldn't have come through the portal. She can't be here, in Bright Moon. Catra and Angella cast her out of their heads. And Adora—

But she finds herself breathless as another spike of fear skewers through Catra's spine.

Adora.

If Chasm is here...then that means—

And again, Catra finds herself running. An endless barrage of footsteps carrying her unstoppably forward, toward her own bedroom. The bedroom she shares with Adora.

As she sprints faster, *closer*, she sees people in the distance. A group of them. Guards, it seems, judging by their outfits—

gathered outside of Catra's bedroom door. They're not unconscious like the rest, Catra notes with some relief. Which means that Catra's not entirely alone here, in wakefulness—

Still moving forward, Catra waves a hand. "Hey!" she screams, loud enough that her throat prickles. "Don't know if you've noticed, but we're *under attack*!"

The guards turn to her, drawing their weapons at Catra's words. It's a frightening thing to hear, Catra is sure, if they haven't yet noticed the unconscious people strewn all over the castle floors. But they need to know. And so does anyone else who's still awake.

Catra slows herself, skidding to a stop directly in front of them. They're guarding the door completely. Blocking it with both their bodies and their weapons.

"I need to get Adora," Catra says, staring up at the guards pleadingly—even trying to angle herself between them. "Chasm might have—"

But before she can finish her sentence, Catra feels something utterly *smash* across the side of her face. Something hard as metal, and just as bitingly cold.

Dazed by pain, she has no choice but to stumble backward, and then, when her balance fails her, fall onto her hands and knees. Some mixture of blood and drools dribbles out of her mouth in her shock, and her head throbs in time with her frantic heartbeat.

What...what *hit* her?

Catra glances up at the guards, tears blurring her vision. One of them has their spear outstretched, almost like…

Almost like she just finished swinging it. Swinging it—at Catra.

"W-what are you—?" Catra slurs, vision still hazy from the impact. Her muscles tremble as she attempts to hoist herself back to her

feet, stumbling as she nearly finds footing again—

Only for another guard to move forward and kick Catra in the stomach, knocking Catra right back to the ground.

"Ah, ah, ah," the guard chides. "No need to get up just yet, Catra."

And Catra...Catra *knows* that voice. Its highness. The too-loudness of its every word.

Catra looks up again, tears pricking at the corner of her eyes. From beyond the distortion of those teardrops, she thinks she recognizes that guard. The dimpled cheeks. The bright eyes and red hair poking out from the shadows of the helmet.

Cleo.

But there's something different about her, somehow. She's standing differently. Taller, almost arrogant. And her voice...her voice is *especially* different. Maybe not in overall sound, but in intonation. Again, filled with a sort of arrogance that Catra doesn't recognize.

At least, not from Cleo.

"You know, after all that mental grappling in that netherworld," Cleo's voice muses, too-clearly gloating as she circles Catra, her spear still outstretched and ready to strike another blow, "I really expected you Etherians to be some high quality-stock. Smarter, more willful then most."

Cleo reaches up and tugs her helmet from her head, instead balancing it between her hip and her arm. The face beneath is smiling wickedly, smiling in a way that Catra recognizes—but not from Cleo.

"But this one?" Cleo's voice continues, gesturing briefly to her own body. "This one's mind...I broke like a twig. Didn't even last a day in one of my illusions."

Catra's eyes pull wide from where she kneels on the floor.

"C-Chasm—" she stammers, unable to hold enough breath in her lungs to speak louder than a shuddering murmur.

Cleo's smile broadens. "Hi there, Catra. Been a little while, hasn't it?"

Chasm. Chasm is here. She's here, and infected Cleo.

No. Not just infected her. Chasm killed her. She *killed* Cleo, breaking Cleo's mind somewhere within one of Chasm's illusions…

Which allowed Chasm to do this. To take control of Cleo's body, claiming Cleo as a host. In fact, Chasm is likely in control of *all* these guards, having broken their minds and replaced them with Chasm's own dark magic.

And with a sinking horror, Catra realizes that all these Bright Moon guards—the ones standing here, apparently awake—must be dead. *Dead*. With Chasm just pulling the strings on whatever remains.

God, Catra should have known. She should have realized the second Glimmer mentioned the number of guards who failed to show up to work. And she especially should have known when Glimmer mentioned that Cleo was missing. Cleo, the guard with the most direct contact with—

"*She spreads like a disease.*"

That's what Angella said, about Chasm, back in the plane between worlds. And that's exactly what Chasm did upon arriving here in Etheria. She spread to everyone—everyone within their vicinity.

The door to Catra room's slides open with a short creak. Catra's head swivels, watching the threshold with wide, terrified eyes as a figure emerges, smoothly shutting the door behind itself. Striding from the shadows of the bedroom and into the brightness of the lamp-lit hallway.

And of course, Catra recognizes that figure. Recognizes every feature on that face, every curve and angle of that body. She'd know it anywhere. Do anything, and everything, to keep it safe and hold it within her arms—

But there's also something wrong. It's moving differently, that figure. Walking differently. And when it moves casually to Cleo's side, a box clutched in its hands, Catra doesn't recognize the expression on that face at all.

"Adora—?" Catra gasps.

Blue eyes flash in Catra's direction, colder than Catra has ever seen them.

"Adora isn't home at the moment," replies Adora's voice—but somehow not. More confident. More cruel.

And now there's a triumphant smirk spreading across her lips, so foreign upon Adora's face.

"And I'm afraid she won't be back for a while."

It's over, Catra thinks in a daze. Really and truly over.

Because Chasm has Adora. Chasm has *killed* Adora.

And for how long has Chasm been in there, pretending to be Adora? At what point did Adora give up? Because Catra thought...she thought she *saved* Adora. She thought that Adora refused to sacrifice herself. And then Adora thrust Chasm from her mind, same as Catra and Angella did—

But clearly…

Clearly Catra was *wrong*.

Catra is too horrified, too *shattered,* to move when Adora—or rather, Chasm—hands off the box to Cleo.

She's wearing an outfit that Catra has never before seen on Adora. A long-sleeved black shirt and pair of red leggings—something of Catra's, she thinks. Not that Chasm would care enough to respect which of the clothes in the closet actually belong to Adora.

Chasm hums as she cracks Adora's knuckles, rolls Adora's neck, and then approaches Catra with an unfamiliar, predatory grace.

But Catra still can't do it. She still can't move. Not even when she sees Adora's leg pull back, then surge forward again—driving yet another bruising, bone-cracking blow into Catra's stomach.

Catra screams and falls to the side, gasping for air. Clutching blindly at her stomach and the welt that is surely forming there, in her abdomen.

"It really is wonderful. Living here, in the real world," comes Adora's—no, *Chasm's*—voice.

Chasm-Adora begins to circle Catra, just as Cleo did. And just as a vulture might too, but with far more hunger and violence in her every movement.

"Last time we fought, you were protected, weren't you? You knew that the illusion couldn't hurt you."

Another kick flies out—this time striking Catra's ribcage. Catra can do nothing but *shriek* and curl in on herself, tears streaming from her eyes. At least one of her ribs must have shattered beneath the blow.

"I bet you're wishing for that illusion now," mocks Chasm with a high, gloating laugh—one so unlike Adora's usual laughter, Catra can hardly believe it came from Adora's mouth. A laugh filled with malice and hate and conceit.

Chasm-Adora squats down just a bit, elbows balancing on her spread knees. She doesn't drop fully to the floor, only sinks

enough to look Catra in the eyes—curled up on the ground as Catra is, gasping for air.

And truly, Chasm must be reveling in this sight. Catra, at Chasm's feet. Laid low by this beating—and by losing Adora.

Adora, Catra thinks, agony spreading through every particle of Catra's body. And not just from the broken rib. That broken rib...that's nothing. A distraction, really, from the true torment at hand.

What's irreparable is this—this gaping, widening hole in Catra's chest, beneath the ribcage. The one that Adora occupied, and now never will again. And Catra can't understand it. She can't understand how an emptiness can feel worse than an impalement, or an absence worse than a crushing weight—

She remembers speaking to Angella, back in the plane between worlds. Asking what would happen if Chasm succeeded in convincing Adora to sacrifice herself.

"*Adora's mind really will perish*," Angella said quietly, nearly whispering. "*And Chasm will be all that's left in her place.*"

Which means Adora really is gone. Somehow, Chasm managed to trick Adora in another illusion—managed to destroy Adora's mind despite Catra's best efforts.

Or worse...maybe Chasm *did* actually succeed during her first attempt to destroy Adora's mind, and tricked Catra into thinking otherwise.

Horror crushes Catra's insides more than Chasm's attacks ever could. When was the last time Catra actually talked to Adora—the real Adora? Did Adora even come back through that portal at all, or was Chasm just pretending that whole time?

And god...what does that even mean? Has Catra been living a lie for months, sharing a bed with a monster wearing Adora's face?

But there were so many moments...moments where Catra could have *sworn* it was Adora there, lying beside her—

Pain and confusion swirl within Catra's mind, paralyzing her. And throughout it all, Chasm simply sits there, staring at Catra. Enjoying the show as Catra struggles to recover her breath.

Though eventually it must grow too boring for her. For Chasm. Because soon enough, Chasm is preparing to stand, humming as she rises to her feet—the movement smooth as silk and not at all *Adora*. She even runs a hand through Adora's hair as she reaches full height, shaking out the strands like they belong to her, and always have.

And somehow, the image fills Catra with an irrepressible rage. She can't let Chasm do this. She can't let Chasm claim any part of Adora. Because if Adora is gone, Catra would rather bury that body herself than let Chasm walk around, pretending that it belongs to her—

"But you see, I'm *done* with illusions now," Chasm gloats, nudging Catra's abused ribs with Adora's toe.

A sound escapes Catra—some cross between a grunt and growl. One that simmers somewhere in the back of Catra's throat. Both hands clench into fists at Catra's sides, the claws slicing into her own skin and drawing pinpricks of blood.

"And now...when I hurt you..." Chasm pulls back her foot yet again, preparing to beat another bruise—or broken bone—into Catra's side. Her lips—Adora's lips—spread wide into a sadistic grin. "The damage is very, very real—"

Chasm's foot hurls out again, but this time Catra is ready. Catra's hand shoots forward—curling around the ankle before the attack hits its mark, redirecting the momentum to the side.

Chasm gives a surprisingly Adora-like yelp as her foot is pulled out from under her, causing her to be yanked to the ground in a graceless heap. Catra is fast—vicious—as she lunges atop of her.

Atop of Chasm, in Adora's body, pinning her ankles and wrists to the ground.

And Catra is truly a snarling, wild thing—ignorant to the blossoming pain in her own body as she bares her teeth and lifts a clawed hand, prepared to strike down. *Forcing* herself to strike down. She wills her vision to narrow to the throat, and only the throat, so that she can't see what was once Adora's face. So that she can finish this, just as Adora would want her to—

"I wouldn't do that if I were you," Chasm warns, still so *frustratingly* amused. "She's still in here, you know. Adora."

Catra freezes—the claw suspended in the air. Her chest heaves as she stares at Chasm in disbelief.

"Try to hurt me, and you'll only hurt her," Chasm continues. "And I'll still walk away, free as anything. Safe and sound in another body."

Catra stares, unable to process the words. "W-what are you talking about?"

But it's too late. There are fingers wrapping around Catra's arms now, hoisting her to her feet. Pinning her wrists behind her back. The hands of the guards, Catra can only assume, yanking Catra off of Adora's body. She fights them, of course—screaming, scratching, clawing. But they don't have much of a reaction to pain.

"Enough of that," snarls Chasm, using a tone of voice that Catra has never once heard from Adora's mouth. She watches as Chasm stands and raises Adora's hand, using it to draw some sort of glowing red rune in the air.

When the rune is complete, Catra feels her hands tugged together, something *burning* against the skin of her forearms. Gasping in pain, Catra glances down to see some sort of magical cord around her wrists—glowing with the same red light that emanated from the rune itself.

Catra can't move her hands at all. Not so long as that cord is binding them together. They're numb, completely numb to feeling and Catra's attempts to move her fingers.

"That's better," Chasm-Adora says with a short laugh. "That cord is unbreakable. Unbreakable, of course, unless I cut it myself."

Chasm approaches Catra, once again smoothing out Adora's hair in that way Catra has never, *ever* seen Adora do. Watching it makes Catra feel vaguely nauseous.

"You know, you really are *so* frustrating, Catra," Chasm says, leaning down to Catra's height as they stand there, face-to-face. "Here I was, planning to strangle you in your sleep tonight. But aren't you lucky, choosing to go on a walk instead?"

Disgust fills Catra at the very thought. Of lying in bed with Adora, only for it to be Chasm. Chasm, who only wishes to wrap her fingers around Catra's throat and *squeeze*—

"Strangle me?" Catra demands. "Why go through the trouble? Why not just knock me out like everyone else?"

Chasm shrugs. "Your guess is as good as mine. It seems you're...oddly resistant to my sleeping magic, these days. You and Angella both."

Blinking, Catra asks, "*What*?"

Another shrug. "Like I said, it's quite frustrating. Though I *suppose* you'll make a suitable hostage instead." Chasm gives Catra's cheek a not-so-comforting pat. "Glimmer is far more likely to cooperate if it's *you*. And besides, why risk a potential host when I can risk someone useless instead?"

Catra growls deep in her throat.

But Chasm appears anything but frightened. Instead, she shoves Catra forward, making her stumble—but only at first. Catra scrambles to correct her balance, snarling, snapping at Chasm's

hands. But the guards (or rather, their bodies) are quick to react. Pointing their spears at Catra's back and prodding her forward. Forward, it seems, toward Glimmer's room.

"Glimmer?" Catra repeats, utterly lost. "If only me and Angella are 'resistant' to your magic or whatever...why would you need to convince Glimmer of anything? Shouldn't she be asleep?"

Chasm just scoffs. And only then, while staring at Adora's face—so twisted by Chasm's cruelty—does Catra realize the truth. Catra remembers what Adora told her, back when she showed Catra that book from the library. The symbol that looked like a set of spirals struck through with lines—

"*I think that this symbol is used to protect people against entities of dark magic,*" Adora told Catra. "*Entities like Chasm*."

"Adora," Catra murmurs, stunned that Adora managed to do that—that she managed to piece together the truth from so many scattered pieces of information. "Adora was right. That symbol *is* some sort of ward against you. And because Glimmer has a Sorcerer's Guild badge—"

"She's immune, and therefore, still able to wake," Chasm admits, rolling her eyes. "It seems that Adora is not *wholly* brainless when she puts her mind to research."

Catra smiles triumphantly, so damn *proud* of her wife—though guilty that she shamed Adora for conducting all that research. If Catra had listened, they might have been able to protect more people—

As they keep walking, Chasm grins and gestures to an unconscious groundskeeper. "Not that being awake will do Glimmer's kingdom much good."

And it's then that Catra realizes. She realizes that Chasm never would have revealed that ward to Catra—never would have willingly discussed her weaknesses with anyone, or anything. Especially not a symbol that could render the Etherian populace

immune to Chasm's possession, since it would've directly interfered with this, with Chasm's plans—

Which means that *couldn't* have been her. That could not have been Chasm, talking with Catra in the bedroom that night.

It must have been Adora. Adora, figuring out the truth. Adora, still alive and herself.

Which means that if Chasm did something to break Adora's mind, it must have been recent. Something within the last few weeks, or maybe even in the last few days—

And Adora really was right the whole time. About the symbol. And about Chasm returning someday—

"But I don't understand," says Catra. "What could you possibly want from Glimmer?"

"Hmm," hums Chasm, tapping at Adora's chin. "It's less what I want from Glimmer, and more what I want from Adora."

"But you already *have* Adora's body," Catra hisses, wishing she could claw out Chasm's eyes as she says the words. And wishes even more that those eyes *weren't* Adora's perfect, stupidly pretty eyes.

"As much as I wish that were true," Chasm sighs, "it's *not*. Not yet anyway. I still need more of the potion."

"The potion…?" Catra echoes, still not understanding.

And then Catra remembers Adora's sleepwalking. It should have been impossible for her to do that—to sleepwalk while under the potion's influence. The potion should have silenced Adora's mind entirely.

But if Chasm was there, still attached to Adora's body…

Perhaps Chasm is what remains when the potion is in effect.

"*Essence of Oblivion*," Catra mutters, now uttering the name like a curse. "That's how you're controlling her body. When she takes the potion, it's basically the same as what you tried to do to her, when you tried to trick her into sacrificing herself—"

"Again, not quite true," Chasm corrects, treating each of Catra's realizations like they're the buzzing of some annoying gnat. "What I do to my victims is quite permanent. The potion, on the other hand, is temporary. Or...at least it is at the dosage Adora takes—"

"But that's why you gave her all those nightmares," Catra gasps, hope blooming deep in Catra's chest. "You couldn't break her in your dream world, so you did this instead. You tortured her with those dreams until she had no choice but to use the potion—"

"Yes, yes," Chasm says with a dismissive wave of her hand. "I'm sure this is all groundbreaking information for you."

"So Adora *is* still in there," Catra cries, barely managing to stifle a sob of relief. "She's still there, and she's okay—"

"For now," Chasm says, and Adora's eyes glint with a malice that Catra has never seen before. "But tell me, Catra—has Glimmer told you what happens when someone takes too much *Essence of Oblivion?*"

Catra's lips press into a thin line. She knows. Dammit, she knows. And now she's even more frightened about what, exactly, Chasm hopes to confront Glimmer about.

Chasm's smile grows wider—sharper, sharp as a blade—as she sees the realization dawns on Catra's face. "The effect becomes permanent."

"Glimmer won't make more potion for you," Catra snarls, writhing within the grip of the guards' hands. "She'd rather die. When the eight hours are up, you're finished—"

"Oh, there's no need to be dramatic," Chasm says. "She's already brewed all the potion I need." She shoots Catra another smirk.

"You were, after all, planning to stock up before your vacation."

"No," Catra refuses, pulling her wrists against her bindings. "I won't let you—"

"I'm afraid you won't have much of a choice," Chasm remarks, "Seeing as you're a hostage and all. And neither will Glimmer, if she wants you to live—or to see dear King Bow awake ever again."

Bow, Catra thinks, terrified. She hadn't considered Bow. He won't be protected like Glimmer and Micah are—

"Thanks to all the magic and misery I've absorbed from Adora, my attachment to him—and all these Etherians—is quite solid. Unbreakable. Which means there will be no more escapees like you, Catra."

"And what exactly is the point of all this, Chasm?" Catra demands. "Why do you want Adora's body so badly?"

Chasm raises one of Adora's eyebrows. "Isn't that obvious? I want She-Ra. I want power."

"And yet here you are," Catra hisses. "In control of Adora's body...with no sign of controlling She-Ra at all."

At that, all amusement fades from Chasm's features in favor of sneering annoyance. A touchy subject, evidently.

"Yet another thing I will soon control completely," Chasm says, voice taut with forced calmness, "as soon as I have all the pieces I need."

"Uh-huh," mocks Catra, exaggerating her skepticism. "Now you tell *me*, Chasm...can you still remember the memories you stole from me?"

Chasm scoffs but keeps walking forward. "I don't forget anything, ever."

"Well, in that case," says Catra, stopping in place—causing the guards' bodies to stop with her, and their spears to prod at her back. It's not long before Chasm—or really, Chasm within Adora's body—is a considerable distance ahead. "You should remember that I'm a *terrible* hostage."

The guards keep prodding but Catra doesn't move, even despite the slight pain of the spears boring into her skin.

"Keep moving, Catra," Chasm-Adora grits out, waving her forward. "I won't hesitate to kill you if you prove too—"

And that's when Catra *charges*. Charges, directly forward, yelling as she does so. She's too fast for the guards—too fast for most people, really, as she surges toward Chasm, right in front of her, using the distance between their bodies to build a sizable momentum—

Sorry, *Adora*, Catra thinks desperately. *You'll thank me for this later.*

And then she's crashing into Adora's body, knocking her to the floor. Chasm screams in frustration, writhing beneath Catra's weight—but not before Catra manages to wrap her bound arms around Adora's shoulders, comforted only by the fact that Adora won't feel this at all—

Chasm's indignant cries are muffled as Catra covers Adora's mouth and nose with her paralyzed hands. It helps, even, as Catra's hands are numbed to the feeling of Chasm's biting and struggling.

I'm sorry, I'm sorry, I'm sorry, Catra chants in her head, but knocking Adora unconscious is all Catra can think to do, given the circumstances. And since she'd rather not cause Adora head trauma of any kind, her only remaining option is to cut off oxygen flow long enough for Adora to pass out.

Catra sees Chasm trying to raise Adora's arms, hoping to cast another spell—but Catra, ever-so-flexible, rolls them over and wraps her legs around Adora's torso, effectively pinning Adora's

arms to her sides. A trick she's learned in the many sparring sessions she's shared with Adora over the years, and one that works nearly every time.

The guards within Chasm's control can't cast magic against Catra, not like this. Their spells would only hit Adora, buried under Adora's body like Catra is. So instead, they sprint forward, pointing with their spears. Seeking to stab Catra and free Adora's body from Catra's suffocating embrace.

But it's not enough. It's not enough time to knock Adora unconscious—the guards have sprinted too close already, their spears raised and poised toward Catra's body.

There's no choice. Catra will have to do something else. Something risky.

And so, as one of the guards stabs down, Catra very carefully releases Adora—contorting both their bodies to the side as she lifts her hands, angling them so that the spear tip passes clear through the glowing cord, and then embeds itself in the floor.

They all freeze. Catra. The possessed guards. Chasm, in Adora's body—sucking in great gulps of air, her eyes wide with outrage.

"Uh oh," Catra taunts, smirking at Chasm. "Looks like you cut the cord."

And then Catra yanks the spear from the ground, taking the weapon for herself.



Chapter End Notes

POV: Chasm-Adora looking down at you as she kicks your ass

(also that drawing is the reason for the boob window/no boob window poll on twitter lmao)

also more amazing art from @assylamsh!!!!





Chapter 8

Chapter Summary

Catra plays a game of hide and seek.

Chasm starts some fires.

And Adora tries a new potion.

Chapter Notes

ALRIGHT FOLKS!! Chapter 8 is here. I hope y'all enjoyed the inherent scariness and sexiness of Chasm-Adora last week. And thanks for over 50 comments, i hope the wait for this chapter wasn't too agonizing lol.

I didn't have time to draw any art for this chapter, so if someone else would like to draw art, i would not be opposed 👀

Anyway! Let's see whether Adora can be saved, shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra was doing well, at first. She caught Chasm off guard. She broke free of her restraints. And she snatched a weapon for herself.

And in most fights, that'd be enough to secure Catra's victory.

But Catra never realized—or really, never experienced firsthand—just *how good* Chasm is at magic. Magic, not just in the form of illusions. But magic like the sorcerers cast—runes and spells of immense power, the likes of which Catra has never seen before.

And the more bodies Chasm controls...the more power she has. The more spells she can cast simultaneously, using her hosts' hands to draw as many runes as she needs.

The guards' hands. *Adora's* hands.

The spear isn't really much help, in the end. Catra only manages to knock out one of the guards—striking the stolen spear across their skull—before the rest of them collect themselves. And with Catra no longer shielded by Adora's body, Chasm is free to release her full magical fury against Catra.

And boy, is she *furious*.

Each of the guards trace runes in the air. Runes that glow with that same red energy, and transform into various deadly obstacles. Tongues of fire, shards of ice, metal spikes that appear from nowhere at all. Catra can do little but yelp and dodge, trying her best to reach Adora's body despite the onslaught—hoping to somehow grab hold of her, and trap her until the potion releases Adora from its clutches.

But Chasm knows exactly what Catra wants. As soon as she is released, Chasm scurries Adora's body behind the other guards—hiding her from Catra's view, and blocking Catra from any possibility of a rescue. Not with such an unconquerable wall of magic obstructions in Catra's way.

Chasm continues to fire spells at Catra. Spells that bore holes into the nearby tapestries, or burn scorch marks all along the walls. The hallway where they stand is in utter ruins—the windows shattered and emptied of glass, all paint melted and scratched and chipped away. It's really a small miracle that Catra has yet to receive more than a few minor burns or cuts.

"Come out, Catra!" Chasm yells, using the voices of the full group of hosts to speak the words in unison. Catra shudders at the eeriness of it—shuddering, in particular, at Adora's voice, mingling so seamlessly with the others.

Currently, Catra is crouched behind some statue—using it as a shield as Chasm casts another fire spell. A river of pure *inferno* parts around the stone, and Catra screams at the heat and the

light, overwhelmed by its intensity, curling in on herself in her attempts to avoid any stray flames. And Adora...Adora is still far out of reach, and she's really not sure if she can take much more —

The flames stop. Catra stands there, frozen, catching her breath. Everything has gone unsettlingly silent.

But then Catra *feels* something touch her ankle.

Catra glances down and shrieks. Because there, curling around Catra's leg, is some sort of dark tendril—one similar to those Shadow Weaver used to conjure, in her efforts to frighten Catra. And Catra can't stand it. She can't stand it touching her. She needs it off—

But just as Catra scrambles to free herself, the tendril tightens, tightens *hard.* Hard enough to bruise. She has no time to act further before the tendril is *yanking* Catra out from behind the statue—thrusting her into the air while Catra's joints scream in pain.

Catra yells and thrashes as she hangs there, upside down, the spear falling from her hand with a clatter. Her limbs flail in their helplessness, the grip on her ankle too tight to be broken.

And it feels terrifyingly familiar, finding herself trapped and suspended like this. She recalls a moment years in the past, when she was nearly dropped into the screeching maw of the Heart's Guardian—a hideous, multi-tongued creature that intended to devour her.

But this is no Guardian. This is Chasm, using dark magic to generate this creature of whirling tendrils, and pull Catra into the open.

From upside-down, Catra can see Adora's body walking through the group of guards. Her hand is outstretched as she maintains a glowing rune, manipulating the symbol with her fingers—a smirk

twisting the corner of her lips with every motion. Chasm is controlling the monster with Adora's own hands.

And *of course* Chasm used Adora to cast it. Chasm would never resist the chance to add another layer to Catra's torture.

Chasm clicks her tongue. Or really, Adora's tongue.

"An admirable effort," Chasm remarks, though her tone suggests that she feels otherwise. "But a waste of time."

Catra keeps thrashing, keeps fighting. "Glimmer will *never* give you that potion."

"So what?" Chasm asks. "Do you really think that will stop me?" She tips her head back and laughs. "The potion is a *convenience*, you stupid girl. If not now, if not *Essence of Oblivion,* I'll find some other way to gain control. There's no way out of this. For you, or Adora."

Catra opens her mouth, prepared to snarl some other insult—but she can't come up with one. Not with so much blood rushing to her head, or so much panic stiffening her muscles and freezing her thoughts.

"And now..." Chasm continues. "Now I think that you're simply not worth the trouble—"

The guard to Adora's right starts casting a new spell—one that Catra has come to recognize as a fire rune. The same rune Catra has dodged so many times in the last several minutes, but won't be able to dodge this time. Not like this.

Catra gives one last thrash against the tendril holding her, but knows there's no real hope in escaping. More likely than not, that guard is going to barbecue Catra on the spot—

"Goodbye, Catra," says Chasm, in Adora's voice. And Catra can't stand it, she really can't. She shuts her eyes, not wanting to see Adora like this—

Catra expects to be burned alive.

What she doesn't expect is to *drop*, suddenly, the tendril inexplicably releasing Catra's ankle so that she falls to the floor. And it's a graceless fall—one that has Catra rolling and gasping as the air is knocked from her lungs, a fiery heat blazing somewhere above as the spell is directed to the space that Catra no longer occupies.

Something...something must have cut through that *thing*, that tendril—

"Catra!" a voice yells. One that she recognizes to be Micah.

Catra opens her eyes—only to have them blinded just as immediately by a bright pink light. Light that fades, revealing Glimmer kneeling at Catra's side—dressed in her pajamas. Catra doesn't even have time to exclaim Glimmer's name before Glimmer clasps hands around her shoulders, enveloping Catra in that same pink light as they're both teleported away.

Catra isn't teleported far—just to the next corner, where she and Glimmer are concealed behind a wall.

Catra is still breathing heavily when she notices that Angella is there too, clad in a robe but otherwise wide awake.

Immune, Catra thinks. Angella is immune, somehow, just like Catra—even without a Sorcerer's Guild badge to protect her.

"We heard all the noise," Angella says. "And when we exited our rooms to discover everyone asleep, we knew—"

From beyond the wall, Catra hears the explosive noises of magic meeting magic—fire meeting water, ice meeting fire, metal meeting stone. Evidently, Micah is on the other side trying to fend off Chasm by himself. But even he cannot ward off so many magic-casting bodies at once—

“Somebody tell me what’s happening!” Glimmer demands, frantic, her hands still squeezing Catra’s shoulders. “Why is everyone asleep? Why wouldn’t Bow wake up? And *how the hell* is Adora casting spells?”

There’s a pause. Catra’s lip trembles, her whole body still shaking from what just occurred. She was mere seconds from disintegrating within that inferno—

Angella drops to her knees in front of Catra.

“That’s not Adora, is it?” Angella asks softly, features tense with dread.

Catra manages to shake her head. “It’s Chasm,” she says. “Chasm’s controlling her body.”

A pause as Angella’s eyes widen. And then—

“How?”

“The potion—” Catra explains, the words becoming half-jumbled as she struggles to string them together. “Chasm was still attached to her. And the potion...It’s...basically clearing the way for her, for Chasm. And until Adora wakes up—”

“So she’s still alive, in there?” Angella asks, with some relief. “Adora is alright?”

This time, Catra nods. “But she won’t be for long,” Catra says. “Not unless we trap Adora here. The guards...they’re *gone*, but we might still be able to save Adora. We *need* to save Adora—”

Angella sets her jaw, eyes sparkling with determination, then turns to Glimmer. “We need to help your father,” Angella says stiffly, and begins walking toward the corner, prepared to turn it—

“Wait!” calls Glimmer, reaching for Angella’s arm and holding tight. “I don’t understand. How is Chasm doing this? How did she gain control of Adora?”

“There’s no time to explain fully,” Angella says. “Not yet. But what you need to know is this: Adora is possessed by Chasm. And if we fail to capture her, we might lose her forever.”

“And what about Bow?” Glimmer demands, whole face twisted in terror. “What about the others?”

“Bow should be fine, for now,” Catra assures her, finally finding her voice. Her proper voice. Because *god*, if there’s anyone who knows how Glimmer feels right now, it’s Catra. “He’s fine, and so is everyone else sleeping under Chasm’s spell. But the guards in there—” She jerks her head in their direction. “They’re goners.”

“Then what do we do?” asks Glimmer. “I can’t believe I’m the one saying this, but we need some sort of plan. I don’t really know what we’re dealing with—”

“Chasm is *really, really* good at magic,” Catra says. “Better than anyone I’ve ever seen. Better than Micah—better than maybe any sorcerer in the whole universe.” She smirks at Glimmer. “But she doesn’t have power like yours.”

“So...teleporting?” Glimmer says.

Catra smirks. “Teleporting.”

Angella and Catra emerge from their hiding place. Directly in front of them is Micah, struggling to maintain some sort of stone wall produced by a magic rune. He’s groaning, one eye scrunched shut in concentration, his every limb shaking with the strain of the spell.

And it’s no wonder why. Catra can hear some sort of *roar* on the other side, like something is seeking to drill past the wall. There’s even a small group of cracks on the surface of the stone. Fissuring, and growing wider.

Chasm, making her way through. Inevitable as ever.

"Can't...hold this…" Micah grunts, glancing at Catra and Angella from the corner of his open eye, "...much longer…"

"Don't worry," Catra says. "Your daughter is on it."

And then, on cue, a bright pink light positively *glares* from the other side of the wall—flashing through the cracks with such intensity that Catra must temporarily avert her eyes. The roaring ceases. She hears a cry of frustration, and a triumphant grunt of Glimmer's—

"Drop the wall!" Catra orders, and from the corner of her eye, she can see Angella getting to work—sitting on the floor as she completes the task Catra asked of her.

Micah does as requested. The wall dissipates into thin air, and Micah collapses to his knees—gulping great breaths of air as he seeks to recover his strength.

With the wall gone, Catra can finally see what's happening on the other side. The group of possessed bodies—Adora included—are clutching at their eyes. Blinking, frantically, as they attempt to see despite the temporarily blinding effects of that bright light.

Glimmer is teleporting between them, her staff materialized in her hands. She smacks it across the heads of two of the guards, hard enough to send them sprawling to the ground with the loud clang of metal on metal, thereby leaving only two guards—and Adora—remaining.

But mentally, Catra urges Glimmer not to waste her time.

"*First, you need to get Adora*," Catra told Glimmer, just mere moments ago. "*That's the priority.*"

"*And then…?*" Glimmer asked.

"*Once she's out of commission, it's just a matter of picking off the rest."* Catra looked down and sighed. "*Do what you need to them. Chasm killed them already—they won't feel anything else.*"

And finally, Glimmer approaches Adora—letting her staff disintegrate again as she turns. She outstretches her arms toward Adora's shoulders, prepared to grab hold so she can teleport away —

But even with failing vision, Chasm senses Glimmer coming. Chasm-Adora utterly *shrieks* her outrage, refusing to be captured. She throws up her hands, frantically tracing a rune in the air.

Glimmer must recognize what rune it is, because she retreats—teleporting from sight. And not a second too soon. A circle of fire *explodes* into being around Adora, a violent protective measure to keep Adora from being touched.

"Micah!" Catra calls, urgently. She points to Adora and makes a flowing gesture with her hands. "Water!"

And somehow, he seems to understand—nodding quickly and staggering to his feet with a wavering, "On it!"

His fingers tremble as they trace another rune, but it's enough. From the symbol springs a jet of water—one powerful enough to shoot across the hallway and douse the flames, as well as knock Chasm-Adora off her feet, a garbled scream ripping from Chasm's throat as it makes contact.

Micah groans as he generates a few more streams of water, each of them directed at the guards who are slowly regaining their senses. They, too, are knocked off their feet—buying Glimmer just a little more time to pull Adora from Chasm's clutches.

"Glimmer!" Catra cries, knowing that this opportunity won't last much longer—and hoping, desperately, that Glimmer will hear her.

And she does. Catra watches as Glimmer teleports directly *on top* of Adora, landing so suddenly and violently that Chasm can do nothing but exhale sharply. Glimmer's hands are ready for any further attempts to cast spells, perfectly placed to wrap around Adora's wrists and hold them steady.

"Sorry, Adora," Catra hears Glimmer mutter—evidently enjoying her fight with Adora as little as Catra did.

And then, with another flash of light and a scream of Chasm's outrage, Glimmer is teleporting herself—and Adora—away.

"Angella?" Catra calls, glancing at the former queen—who is still seated on the ground, staring determinedly at the floor. She sees Angella give a short nod without shifting her gaze, so Catra can only assume that she's ready—

And then Glimmer is teleporting into the space directly in front of Angella—but only for a split-second. She releases Adora, but doesn't let herself hit the ground. Instead, she teleports herself to the spot beside Catra.

Leaving Adora to fall, alone, onto the ground.

Or rather... onto the entrapment rune that Angella drew in that spot. One that activates a cylinder of impenetrable magic all around Adora's body, rendering escape impossible.

It's a spell the princesses have used many times in the past. It was used against Shadow Weaver, once upon a time. Then Double Trouble. Then several other random prisoners, once Catra joined Adora in Bright Moon.

And now, against Chasm.

Chasm-Adora shoots up immediately, yelling in frustration and banging her fists against the walls that surround her. She glances down at her feet, scowling, then directs her glare to Angella—sitting just outside the magic boundary.

"*We'll need someone to cast a spell to trap Adora*," Catra told Glimmer. "*A good one. Chasm will do anything to escape*."

"*I can do that,*" Angella offered, interrupting. "*I've been working on my rune-casting since we returned. I can do this.*"

And now, Angella smirks at her handiwork. The entrapment spell completed, and executed perfectly.

"My magic has really improved since we last saw each other," Angella says, just a tiny bit gloating—her eyebrow raised in a challenge. "Wouldn't you agree, Chasm?"

Chasm merely snarls and pounds against the wall.

"Uh, guys?" comes Micah's voice. "We're not finished yet."

Glimmer and Catra turn, only to see what remains of the possessed guards standing upright—what used to be Cleo, box still in hand, and one of the other younger guards. Their hands are raised, perfectly poised to cast more destructive spells.

Glimmer immediately sprints forward, standing at her father's side. Both of them, ready to cast any necessary counterspell to fend off Chasm's attacks—

But ultimately, no attacks come. Instead, when the guards finish tracing their runes, pure and impenetrable *darkness* engulfs the guard's end of the hallway—cutting off all view of what they're doing, or where they are.

"No!" Catra gasps, staggering forward—but Angella catches her arm, holding her back. "Wait—"

But it's too late. By the time Glimmer and Micah fire off a light spell to cut through the darkness, there's nothing left. The guards—all of them, even the unconscious ones—are gone. Just an empty floor left in their wake.

There's a thump from behind Catra, followed by a gasp from Angella. One that sends pure ice plunging down Catra's spine.

Quickly, Catra spins around, her muscles coiled—prepared for some sort of attack from behind.

But there's nothing, no one to fight.

That sound—it was just Adora. Adora, falling to the floor, her legs collapsed and body sprawled. Eyes shut tight, her chest rising and falling in deep sleep. Dropped to the ground like a puppet with her strings cut.

"Chasm must have relinquished her control," Angella says, looking at Catra with a stunned sort of relief. "She must know that it's over."

"But it's not over," Catra says, voice wavering. She wants to cry. To sob, to go to Adora and pull her into her arms, utterly relieved that she saved her, and just as horrified that she *didn't*. She didn't save Adora enough, not nearly. Not yet. She didn't save her back there, in the dreamworld. And she didn't save Adora now.

"As long as the potion is in Adora's system, we have to keep Adora in there," Catra says, voice raw from all her recent yelling. "Chasm could take back control at any time—meaning that this could just be a trick to get us to release her. As for the others—"

She turns back to the other end of the hallway, now empty.

"They're trying to escape," Catra mutters to herself. And then, louder, to the others— "We need to catch them. Kill them, even, if that's what we have to do. The guards are gone. And the more their bodies travel, the more people Chasm will infect."

Glimmer nods. "I'll teleport through the hallways—"

Catra grabs Glimmer's arm. "No. The rest of us will search. First, go find the extra vials of Essence of Oblivion you made."

Glimmer blinks. "Why?"

"That's what she planned to use to kill Adora," Catra says. "And she still might try."

Glimmer swallows hard. "And what...what do I do with it?"

“Burn it,” Catra says. “All of it. Throw it into the nearest fire.” Her eyes find Adora, still unconscious on the floor. “We’re not letting that stuff near Adora again.”

Adora wakes sore beyond belief.

Even with her eyes still closed, she can feel fresh bruises all along her back, her sides, her knees. And god...what is she lying on? Certainly not a bed, with that rigid surface—and that smooth, almost stonelike coldness. Coldness that puckers Adora’s skin into goosebumps.

Adora normally wakes curled in bed—curled with Catra—warm and comfortable *without* mysterious injuries peppering her body. Not like this. Not crushed against...is this some sort of *marble*?

Where the hell is she?

Uneasiness and pain grind her teeth together as she slowly, *slowly*, opens her eyes.

She groans as light floods her vision. And when her vision *does* fully return to her—blurred colors and shapes forming into distinct images—she’s greeted by a truly bizarre sight.

It seems that Adora is, in fact, laid out upon the floor. Specifically, the marble floor of a palace hallway. Surrounding her on all sides is a transparent layer of pale magic, glowing dimly. It imbues everything in the surrounding room in cool blue, making even the rays of sunlight spearing through the windows look more blue than gold.

Shattered windows, Adora realizes with a jolt. Every window in the hallway is shattered—the glass strewn in jagged shards across the ground.

Adora lightly kicks her heel against the magic that surrounds her. Her foot bounces, unable to pass through. It’s solid, that wall, and Adora is trapped—though *why* she is trapped remains a mystery.

And when Adora looks down—observing the entrapment rune she's seen sorcerers cast several times in the past—she realizes just how trapped she is.

With another glance up and beyond the wall, Adora spots several figures kneeled or cross-legged on the ground. Micah and Angella, it appears—their heads in their hands. Bodies slumped in exhaustion.

And Catra. Who is upright, and awake, and watching.

Adora can only stare at Catra in horror. At the bruise that has nearly swollen Catra's eye shut. Or the burns and cuts along her arms.

"She's awake," murmurs Catra, placing her hand upon the surface of the magical wall directly in front of Adora. "Eight o'clock. Same as usual."

At that, the rest of the group rouses themselves—raises their heads to stare. Adora returns the stare, though with far more bewilderment. Her breath quickens to a panicked pace.

"What...what happened?" Adora asks. "What am I doing here?"

Angella rises to her feet and approaches. She, too, outstretches a hand to place on the surface of the magical prison. Though unlike Catra, when Angella makes contact, the magic walls dissolve into nothing—righting the room back into its usual colors and freeing Adora from its confines.

Not that Adora moves. Not at all. She is too disoriented, too confused—

"Adora—" says Micah, also scrambling to his feet. He reaches into a pocket and pulls out a small vial—one identical to the vials Glimmer uses to store Adora's *Essence of Oblivion.* though it's filled with an unfamiliar liquid. Something different, something clear as water.

Some other potion, she assumes?

"I need you to drink this right now."

"What is it?" Adora asks, squinting as sunlight bounces off the vial, stabbing directly into her eyes.

"There's no time to explain," Micah says. "Just trust me."

Adora glances at Catra, who nods encouragingly. And then, without further questions, Adora outstretches her hand. Micah pops off the cork as he hands the bottle to her, making it easy for Adora to simply tip back her head and drink.

She gags. It's so bitter, she nearly spews it out. But with everyone watching, she fights the urge.

Once she swallows, she sits there, breathing heavily. Waiting for that terrible flavor to leave her mouth. There are tears in her eyes when she looks back up at Micah, questioning. "What was that?" She glances around, at all the terrible destruction—and leans forward to touch the purple bruise discoloring the skin beneath Catra's fur. "And what happened? And wha—"

She gasps, unable to move further forward. The pain in her back is too much to bear, too much to fight against. She has no choice but to stifle a whimper and rescind her hand, leaning back down on the floor.

"W-what happened to me?" Adora manages, near-begging for an explanation.

Catra, Micah, and Angella share a glance. A nervous one. One that makes Adora's stomach turn from where she sits.

And, then, finally, Catra looks back at her.

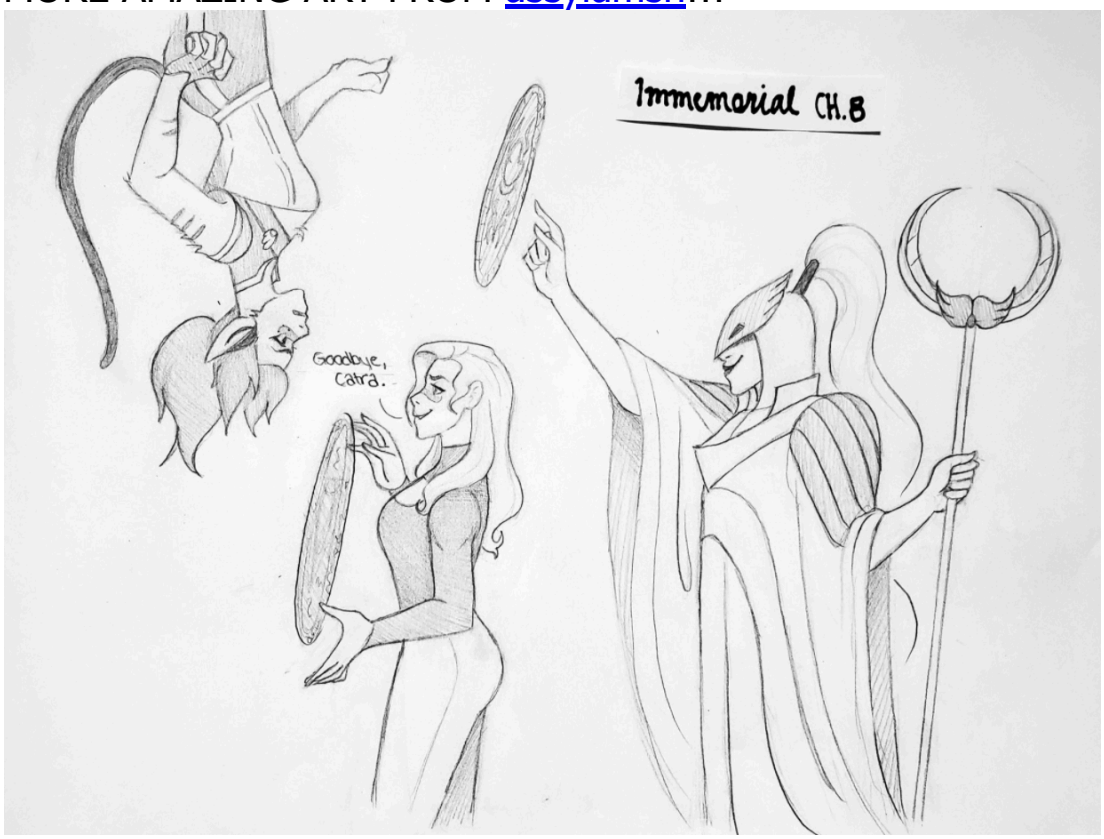
"Chasm," Catra says with a sigh. "It was Chasm."

Chapter End Notes

im sure adora is gonna have a good time with this information!!!

anyway please remember to tell me what u think by either commenting or dropping a kudos!!

MORE AMAZING ART FROM assylamsh!!!




Immemorial CH.8
Chasm...
"It was CHASM."

Chapter 9

Chapter Summary

Adora learns the truth.

Someone cries on the bathroom floor.

Adora and Catra make a plan.

Chapter Notes

well!!! shit's really hitting the fan, huh?? the good news is that im almost done writing immemorial, so I'm hoping it'll be uh...29 chapters? 30 chapters? idk yet, but hopefully something close to that. Sorry for how long it's gonna take for post it all lmao.

anyway, also gonna plug more incredible music but the amazingly talented ehj!! she made a newer version of oblivion (a song inspired by this fic from adora's pov) and another untitled song from catra's pov. Go check those out, but also check out her awesome enemies with benefits fic!!!

also i did not have time to make art for this chapter because my group project for school continues to be a disaster. pray for me.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

As they explain what happened, Adora cannot move.

She cannot speak. She cannot think. She can only sit there, numb to everything except the feeling of some molten, frigid thing being poured into her veins, into her stomach, her ribcage. Something that freezes and scalds all at once, leaving her with no organs save a brittle spine, on the verge of shattering.

Throughout it all, a chant starts in Adora's mind. Mindless, and repetitive.

What have I done?

"We didn't catch her," Micah says. "She left behind two of her possessed guards to slow us down, and, well...it worked. While we were fighting, the rest—three of them—escaped. Cleo, Drew, and Blake. Or their bodies, anyway."

What have I done?

"They took our ship," Catra adds, in a quiet, shaking sort of voice. "Meaning that they'll have lots of supplies for any intergalactic journey they want."

The ship. The one Catra and Adora are supposed to be taking today, to Sutera. Packed full of food and water and whatever else they were going to need for their several day-journey.

And god, the thought of that vacation seems like an absurd dream. Especially now, with Adora trapped in this waking nightmare. Perhaps it was lucky, even, that Chasm chose to attack last night—lest Adora infect yet another innocent planet with Chasm's nightmares.

What have I done?

"G-Glimmer and Bow?" Adora manages to ask. Her stomach utterly *roils* with nausea as she poses the question—bile rising high into her throat, scorching it with foul-tasting acridity.

And truly, she feels sick. Faint. Skin crawling, head buzzing—like her whole body has emptied and refilled by flies and maggots.

And that's all she is now, isn't she? The host of some horrific parasite. Chasm's gateway into this dimension, *infected* as Adora was and still is—

"Bow is under her spell," Micah says with a sigh. "Glimmer is with him right now. She's awake—and was crucial in rescuing you, even. But for now, she wants to stay by his side."

Adora can only gulp down more bile.

What have I done?

"And they're all like that, aren't they?" Adora demands, and truly, her voice feels too massive for her own throat, it is so inflamed and thick with tears. "Everyone in Bright Moon. Everyone I've so much as *walked past* is infected with her—"

"Not everyone," Catra says calmly. "The sorcerers should all be safe. Angella and I are...immune, somehow. And Micah says he has a way of breaking the spell for a lot of Chasm's victims."

Adora's eyes snap to Micah's face, her brows raised in hopeful pleading. And truly, such a thing is Adora's only hope. Her only hope to get Chasm *out*, out of her head, out of her body—

"Well, what is it?" Adora pleads. "If there's a way to break the spell, we need to—"

Micah shoots Catra a pointed glare. "Catra misspoke—or misheard me. We don't yet know of any *real* way to break the spell. At least, not in the way you want. We can't break the connection to Chasm once it's fully formed."

Adora thrashes her head from side to side, on the verge of an explosion of tears and screaming that she can hardly restrain. "Then what—"

"What I can do," Micah says, "is temporarily limit her effects. She can only affect her victims when they're asleep. That's what her spell is, really. A very strong sleeping rune. Not as strong as *Essence of Oblivion,* but still powerful. A powerful sleeping rune combined with equally powerful illusions."

Adora clutches at her elbows, vaguely aware that she cannot stop shaking. "Then—what—is—there?" she hisses, teeth gritted. "What can I do? Please—"

A pause, as Micah stares at her. And it's clear by his pinched features that he fears for her. Pities her, even. "You already did it," Micah says. "All things in magic have their opposites. Good and evil. Chaos and order." He gestures to Adora. "Even She-Ra and Chasm represent opposites, of sorts. And so...most potions have their opposites too."

He kneels in front of Adora, picking the vial she emptied off the floor. "The potion you just drank is called *Essence of Eternity*," Micah says. "It is the sister potion of *Essence of Oblivion*, and just as powerful. But—"

"It shall keep you awake, rather than make you sleep," Angella completes for him. "We know better now, about *Essence of Oblivion*. But a problem still remains. We fear that, so long as Chasm is attached to you—or anyone else, really...she can still use her illusions and sleep spells against you at any time. Worse, she could siphon magic from you—"

Adora's eyes widen. Anticipating her panic, Angella softens her voice and holds out her hands in a placating gesture.

"Please understand that she won't get full control of your body—not like last night. She'd need *Essence of Oblivion* to do that, or a victory in crushing her victim's will. But...her magic can still render you as comatose as you were there, in the plane between worlds...when you were suffering beneath her illusion"

"You'd be left defenseless," Micah continues. "And vulnerable to her illusions—or a siphoning spell—just as before. But she can't control the body of someone who's fully conscious, nor can she access She-Ra's magic without your permission while you're fully awake, and able to deny her. So really, the solution is to keep her from casting a successful sleep spell. And the only way to do that is to use this potion—" He raises the vial again. "*Essence of*

Eternity. The only potion capable of preventing sleep entirely, even under the effect of the most powerful sleep spells. Even if Chasm did manage to sneak you *Essence of Oblivion*...taking this potion would cancel out the effects of both potions. It is that powerful."

Angella nods. "We've contacted the other sorcerers, and we think we can brew a sufficient quantity to wake most of the populace up. She can still feed off people's misery...but other than that, she'll have no real effect on them."

"But if I'm drinking this potion…" Adora murmurs, staring determinedly at the floor as the tears come, inevitable. "If any of us are drinking this potion...then…"

"There's no sleep," Catra whispers back, barely loud enough for everyone to hear. "No sleep, at all. Chasm-caused or natural or otherwise."

There's a pause as the news sinks—or really *stabs*—it's way into Adora's mind.

"It's not sustainable," Micah says, sighing yet again. "Not at all. But it will work as a temporary solution, until we find some way to defeat her. Defeat Chasm."

"Well, you don't feel tired, right? When you take the potion?" Adora asks, desperate for some good news. She even manages some sort of deranged, trembling laugh—one that bubbles from her throat entirely without her permission. "Because honestly, if that's the case, I probably should've been taking this stuff a long time ago—"

Micah shakes his head. "It does nothing except keep the drinker awake. You'll feel just as tired. Just as exhausted. But no matter what you do...you will not sleep. That is its purpose."

Adora stares at him, then at the vial clutched in his hand. She's frozen again now. All traces of laughter gone. "So that's it, huh?" Adora whispers, her lips trembling so uncontrollably that she can

hardly speak. “There’s no way to get rid of Chasm, no way to get her *out* of me, and now I can’t even sleep if I try, and neither can anyone else—”

“Adora,” Catra says, leaning forward to touch Adora’s shoulder.

“Don’t *touch* me!” Adora shrieks, frantically scooting away, out of reach. Because Adora can’t stop looking at that, either. The bruise on Catra’s face. It never would have happened if it wasn’t for Adora. Adora is poison now, pure poison, and she’s destroyed this kingdom she worked so hard to save, and hurt the people she’s sworn to protect—

And god, she feels...she feels *disgusting*. She really can’t escape it—this buzzing, this crawling of her nerves. It’s like she can sense the vibrations of Chasm’s laughter reverberating in her skull. Taunting her. Ripping out whatever remains of Adora’s sanity. Working to crush Adora’s mind and insert herself in its place.

Catra presses her lips together but doesn’t say anything else—only backs away, carefully retracting her fingers.

“I-I *don’t* understand,” Adora gasps, pulling her knees to her chest. Sobs begin to tear their way from her throat. “You and Angella. You’re fine. You’re *immune*, even. But I’m not. She’s still in here. I never got rid of her and I still can’t—”

“Adora,” says Angella gently. “It’s not your fault.”

Adora just shakes her head and scoffs at that, that obvious lie. Of course it’s Adora’s fault. There’s no one else to blame.

“Chasm was still weak when Catra and I discovered her illusion, and forced her out of our heads,” Angella explains. “By the time you realized, that simply wasn’t the case anymore. She had stolen too much power. Stolen power from you, especially.”

Micah nods. “And sometimes that’s the nature of magic. Sometimes, when a spell is shattered so completely, it cannot be recast. There is magic in every person. Magic that can adapt—

grow stronger, resistant. Strong enough to fight off powers that it *knows* to be a threat."

"But not me," murmurs Adora, refusing to look at any of them. "I wasn't strong enough. I'm still not."

Sighing, Micah pleads, "Adora—"

"I wasn't strong enough," Adora repeats, more forcefully. "I wasn't strong enough to wake from Chasm's spell on my own. Not when I should have. And whatever magic is inside of me—it's not strong enough to break her control. And it's not strong enough to protect anyone. Not my wife or my friends or myself or—"

Adora presses a shaking hand into her own forehead, gasping for air. Catra is saying her name again, Adora can hear it, vaguely. But she can't. She can't answer. And she can't be comforted because it's the last thing she wants. She wants someone to scream at her for being so foolish, she wants fury to validate her own outrage with herself. And they just won't do it. They won't give it to her—

Wordlessly, she staggers to her feet—determined to ignore the screaming pain in her muscles and that gentle call of her own name. She can't stay here. She can't stay here, drowning in the gazes of the people she failed.

And so she runs. Stumbles, really, down the hallways, fast but not quite fast enough. Tears fly out behind her as she goes. And there are bodies, in her periphery, the whole way there. Unconscious people who were rendered that way because of Chasm—because of Adora.

Because Adora isn't—and never has been—strong enough.

For a long time, Adora is left alone—just as she wants to be. She goes to her bedroom, the only private place she can think of.

Or really, the only private place where she cannot infect any more innocent people. She cannot go to the library, her usual escape.

After all, what if George and Lance return and—

But wait. Bow visited George and Lance at their dig only a few weeks ago. Adora infected Bow, which means that Bow probably infected them in turn. Spreading Chasm to their minds. Meaning that even *they* aren't safe, somewhere across the world. Adora managed to ruin their lives from thousands of miles away.

Adora also can't travel to Razz's shack, not without infecting—

But then, with a suffocating horror, Adora realizes that Razz is likely infected too. She had far too much contact with Adora. All those visits and tea dates...and Adora didn't realize. She didn't realize just how dangerous her own presence was, and now, poor Razz is likely trapped in one of Chasm's torturous illusions—

Adora has ruined everything. Everything, and everyone. Every safe place she has, every person she loves. There is nowhere to go, nowhere safe. She can only stay exactly where she is. Here, where she cannot cause any more damage.

And still, Adora hates being here too. She hates being in her bedroom. Her bedroom, where Melog is asleep—same as all the rest. Infected, because of Adora, and unable to be roused from their slumber. Curled up on the bed as that horrible spiral symbol glows atop their forehead.

Adora sobs at the sight of them and staggers to the bathroom, locking the door behind herself. She leans her back against it—against the door—and allows herself to slide down, down, *down* to the bathroom floor, where the granite cools her skin. Where she can make herself small, and pretend she's not a threat to every living thing she encounters.

She tucks her knees beneath her chin and attempts—struggles—to breathe. It's difficult. To breathe, to inhale and exhale without some sort of sob forcing the air from her lungs. It's even more difficult to forget that Chasm is here, somewhere. Somewhere in Adora's mind. Irremovable and unconquerable as the fear that

crushes Adora down here, toward the ground, and maybe lower still.

Adora doesn't know what time it is when she hears a soft knocking at the bathroom door. She has not moved in hours, and there's no window here, in the bathroom. She can only guess that the sun has likely set by now, day giving way to night—and bringing Catra with it.

Adora doesn't reply. She doesn't want to speak. Where can she even begin if she tried—

"Adora," comes Catra's voice, from the other side. "I know you're in there."

Again, Adora refuses to answer.

"Can you let me in please?" Catra asks with another gentle knock.

Nothing. Adora says nothing. She doesn't want to respond, doesn't want to stand, doesn't want to do anything except sit here and hopefully, *disappear* before she wreaks any more damage—

"Adora," Catra begs. "I need to pee. Seriously, can you just unlock the door?"

A pause.

"Are you seriously going to make me walk all the way downstairs to take a shit, Adora?" Catra says, and Adora can almost picture Catra standing out there, beyond the door. Her arms crossed and her foot tapping impatiently. "I might not make it. And really, I will never live it down if I end up shitting my pants—"

Adora rolls her eyes. Obviously, she doesn't want *that*. But Adora is still grumbling and annoyed and halfway crying when she scoots over to the wall besides the door. Her arm stretches upward, reaching for the lock and flicking it open with a thumb.

Catra must hear the click. Because slowly, the door creaks open, revealing Catra grasping the handle just beyond. Adora only shoots Catra a glance before affixing her eyes to the floor, so sure and embarrassed is she of her own appearance. Surely, she must look like a wreck. Still dressed in whatever stupid outfit Chasm put her in. Cheeks streaked with tears. Shoulders shaking and arms coiled tight around her knees.

"I'll go. Let you do your business," Adora says with a sniff, and begins shifting—intending to stand.

But she doesn't get the chance. Not before Catra sits down beside her there, on the floor. Shutting the door behind herself and leaning against it.

"No need," Catra says, scooting backwards as Adora watches her warily. Her head dips back, balanced on the smooth wood. "I kinda lied about the 'needing to shit' thing. Sorry."

Adora meets her eyes, but only to shoot her an indignant look.

"What?" Catra demands. "I knew it would get you to open the door, okay?" And then, more quietly, she mumbles, "Even if I had to humiliate myself in the process."

And Adora can't really help it—the small ripple of laughter that pulses through her chest. It's not unwelcome, exactly, just...strange. Adora didn't really intend or expect to laugh at the moment. But she also can't believe Catra threatened to *poop her pants* to convince Adora to open the door.

"That was childish," Adora says, though she doesn't really mean it. She speaks the words into her own knees—the words muffled by the fabric of her pants.

Catra shrugs and scoots a few inches closer to Adora. "Yeah, I know. Sorry. I just...wanted to join the party."

"Party?" repeats Adora with a scoff.

“Yeah,” says Catra. “The crying on the bathroom floor party. I figure we’re both entitled to it, at this point.”

And again, Catra scoots closer—mere millimeters separating their bodies now. Catra whole attention is devoted to staring at Adora. Staring, like she wants to reach out. Staring, until she asks, “Do you still not want me to touch you?”

Adora makes a noise—some cross between another scoff and another sob. “Why the hell would you want to?” Adora demands. “Knowing that *she’s* in here, somewhere. Probably watching us as we speak.”

“Because I don’t care,” Catra says. “I mean...obviously, I *care*. I want her gone too. But she’s not going to stop me from touching you, or holding you, if that’s what you want me to do.”

Adora sits there for several moments, silent.

“And it *is* what I want to do,” Catra adds. “I want to hold you, same as always. I love you no matter what.”

Adora tilts her head up, finally. “Even if I’m responsible for all of this?” she asks. “Everyone who got infected, pulled under Chasm’s spell—”

Catra squints. “What do you mean?”

“I should’ve never come back,” Adora breathes. “I was stupid to think she was really gone. I should’ve known, I saw her smirk. Felt the way she pulled all that magic from me. I should’ve stayed behind, in the portal—even if I wasn’t sure. That way, I wouldn’t have hurt anyone. She would’ve infected me, and no one else.”

Catra listens, lets the words hang—her expression impassive. And maybe that’s the agreement Adora needs. The acknowledgement of Adora’s failure that Adora wants so badly—

“Do you really want to play the blame game, Adora?” Catra replies, terse. Voice emptied of softness. “Because I can do that

too. I'm just as responsible as you are, if not more."

"Come on, Catra," Adora scoffs. "We both know that's not true."

"Oh yeah?" Catra challenges. "Fine. Here we go. Let's go back to the war, shall we? When I pulled the switch that opened that portal. The first one. The one that trapped Angella. If I hadn't been so stupid—so selfish and hurt—Angella never would've been trapped. The second portal, never opened. None of us would've ever even *met* Chasm."

Catra inhales deeply, the breath trembling as it fills her lungs. Adora, meanwhile, can only stare. Stare, because *this*—blaming Chasm on Catra—has never once crossed Adora's mind. It's always been Adora at fault. Adora, the big screw-up. Adora, the fumbling hero. She's never considered anything otherwise, never even thought about Catra as anything other than one of Chasm's victims.

And how could she think differently? How could she blame Catra for something that happened so long ago, something that she's regretted and apologized for a thousand times—

"And thinking that…" Catra continues. "Thinking that *destroys* me. You're the person I love most in the whole world, and she's *hurt* you. Hurt you in the most unimaginable ways. Over and over again, she's hurt you, and it's my fault."

"She's hurt you too—" Adora objects, gesturing to the blue-purple contusions that swell all along Catra's face. "She did this. And she made you relive all those terrible moments in the past—"

"Yeah," says Catra with a shrug, and looks down at the floor. "That sucked. But watching you suffer is worse, Adora."

Adora's brows pull together. "You know I feel the same way when it's you, Catra. Watching you get hurt...there's nothing I hate more."

"Of course I know that," Catra says, turning her head to look at Adora more directly. And Adora is somewhat surprised to see Catra cracking a smile. "I love you. And you love me. Which is why, even if you told me to do otherwise, I would have dragged you—kicking and screaming—back through that portal with me. I wouldn't have believed Chasm was still there, infecting you. I wanted so badly for you to be safe—for us both to be safe, and together—I refused to believe she was anything but *gone*."

And there's another pause as Adora considers that, too. That if Adora stayedbehind, in that plane between worlds...it would have broken Catra's heart. Broken Adora's heart, too. After everything they went through in that dreamworld, they both wanted nothing more than to return home.

But still. Adora shouldn't have done it. She shouldn't have risked the safety of so many innocent people—

"You wouldn't have succeeded," Adora half-jokes. "In getting me through the portal, I mean."

Catra raises a skeptical eyebrow. "Really? Is that what you think?"

Adora nods. "If necessary, I would've turned into She-Ra and physically *tossed* you through the portal to get you to leave me behind."

Catra laughs. "You should know better than to underestimate me like that. I can still beat you in a fight, when I put my mind to it."

"One kiss, and your brain short-circuits," Adora reminds her, biting her lip not to laugh. "That's all I'd have to do. A kiss, and a throw."

Catra snorts loudly. "Shut up. You're just as easily distracted."

And then they're both laughing there, on the floor, at the mental image of it. The image of Catra dragging Adora through the portal, bringing her home despite any insistence to stay. Or Adora

tossing Catra back to Etheria instead, determined to protect the world.

And it's strange that they're laughing at it, Adora thinks. At this impossibly sad thought, this alternate timeline where Adora never made it back. Because she can't stand it. Adora cannot stand the possibility of staying behind, separated from Catra forever. Even if such a choice would have kept Etheria safe.

And somehow, she's grateful that it's not true, even with this chaos raging all around her. She's grateful to be here. To be home, with Catra.

It's a horribly selfish thing to think, she knows. But it's really the only comfort Adora has. And is that really wrong? To be glad that she wasn't left behind? To be happy that she hadn't *again* been forced to play the role of sacrifice?

"But you know what?" Catra asks. "I have enough terrible things to blame myself for. Really, I do."

"Catra—"

Catra holds up a hand—a plea for Adora to let her finish. And Adora does. She lets her, shutting her mouth to listen.

"And frankly?" Catra continues. "I'm tired of it. I've got enough to be sorry for without taking the blame for Chasm's *bullshit* on top of it. We didn't ask her to torment us. We didn't make her infect everyone in Bright Moon. She did that. She chose to do all of that to us, and I'm not gonna give her the *satisfaction* of blaming myself for it. Not anymore."

She extends a hand, reaching for Adora—but not actually touching her without her permission. A flat palm awaiting Adora's palm atop it.

"I'd much rather focus on kicking her ass all the way back to that prison dimension," Catra says, eyebrows raised in invitation. "What about you? Think you're feeling the same?"

She hesitates, at first. Because it's hard. It's really hard to let go of it—this fantasy that she might have changed her circumstances. That she could have been better. It makes her feel...in control, somehow. This idea that when things go wrong, it's by *Adora's* hand that they fall.

But Catra is also right. All this misplaced blame…it won't help them stop Chasm. It won't heal all the people that Chasm has hurt.

So Adora lifts her hand, and places it within Catra's—mustering a small smile in response. She curls her fingers, intertwines them with Catra's, pressing their palms tightly against each other. "Okay," she says. "Okay."

Catra smiles. "I have a plan," she says, scooting forward even more, somehow. She takes Adora's other hand in hers. "I'm immune to her, somehow. And so long as you take that potion...she can't *really* affect you."

Adora nods. She wants to help. She wants to do *something*—

"I'm gonna go after her," Catra says. "We can't wait for her to break any more minds—can't let her kill any more innocent people. So I'm gonna go after her, capture one of her existing hosts, and bring them back here. And I thought that maybe...maybe you could vanquish her the same way you did Horde Prime. Erase her with your magic, same as you did for him."

Adora blinks. "Will that work?"

Catra shrugs, answering, "Dunno. But we can try. I figure if it works for one big bad, it will probably work for two."

"And are you sure you can do that on your own?" Adora asks. "Micah said she's really powerful. Able to cast all sorts of magic spells—"

"I'll be okay," Catra tells her with a smirk. "I went toe to toe with you, didn't I? Kicked your butt a whole bunch of times. I think I can handle one lousy dream demon after taking down She-Ra—"

Adora laughs, and gives Catra a nudge—intending it to be playful. But it's beyond her control, in the end—the pained breath that Catra sucks in as a result, high and gasping. The sound instantly ceases Adora's laughter. One look at Catra's face reveals features scrunched up in pain.

"Catra," Adora whispers, scooting away slightly as Catra wraps an arm around her own side. "W-what did I—"

"It's nothing," Catra manages, very clearly swallowing an even greater cry of pain. "Just some bruises—"

Adora shakes her head and, very carefully, reaches out toward the hem of Catra's shirt. Her fingertips very carefully clutch at fabric, and only that, as she gently lifts the shirt up. Rolling it just below the chest—

Adora clasps a hand over her own mouth. What she discovers there, on the side of Catra's torso, is a horrible patchwork of dark bruises. Purple, almost black in their darkness, and swollen beyond imagination.

"Oh Catra," Adora gasps, her fingers hovering over the injury but refusing to touch. "Did I do this?"

Catra bites her lip and shakes her head.

"Catra," Adora says, more sternly now.

"Alright, fine," admits Catra with a groan. "Your foot *might have* broken one of my ribs. But I think it was just one. And obviously, you didn't actually have a say in the matter."

"*Shit*," murmurs Adora. And truly, she's horrified. Disgusted by the very idea that her foot—or really, any part of Adora's body—inflicted such a terrible injury against Catra.

And then she's outstretching another hand, toward Catra's face. Fingertips barely ghosting over the bruises that swell there too. "And what about this?" Adora asks, tears brimming in her eyes. "Did I do this too?"

Catra shakes her head, but this time Adora senses that it's honest.

"No," Catra replies. "That was one of the guards. Clocked me real good, huh?"

Adora swallows hard, muttering, "I'll say."

And finally, Adora's hand comes to rest on Catra's cheek. The intact one—the one unmarred by such tender bruises. She cups it gently, stroking a thumb over that soft, thin layer of fur.

And then Adora is closing her eyes, summoning her magic from that place deep inside herself. She pictures Catra's bruises fading, disappearing. The rib setting back into its proper place—

"Don't—!" Catra exclaims, swatting Adora's hand away.

Adora opens her eyes, confused. "Why wouldn't I—?"

But Catra is grabbing both of her wrists, eyes pleading. "It always drains you, when you heal people," Catra says. "And you're going to need your strength. Especially if you're not going to sleep again any time soon—"

But Adora just shakes it off, laughing softly as she again lifts her hand—cupping Catra's cheek. "And you're gonna need to be healed if you're gonna go toe-to-toe with Chasm."

"Adora—"

"Catra—" she replies, in the same tone. Adora's eyebrows pull low over her eyes, all features drawn in determination. She draws closer, breath ghosting over Catra's skin—eyes shutting again in anticipation of the healing magic. "Let me do this, okay? Let me fix this."

She waits for permission. And then, finally, she feels Catra nod.

And Adora once again reaches deep inside herself, searching for the magic to right all things. The bruises, the burns, the cuts. The broken rib and the black eye. She hears Catra gasp in relief, senses the glow as the magic spreads from Adora's body into hers.

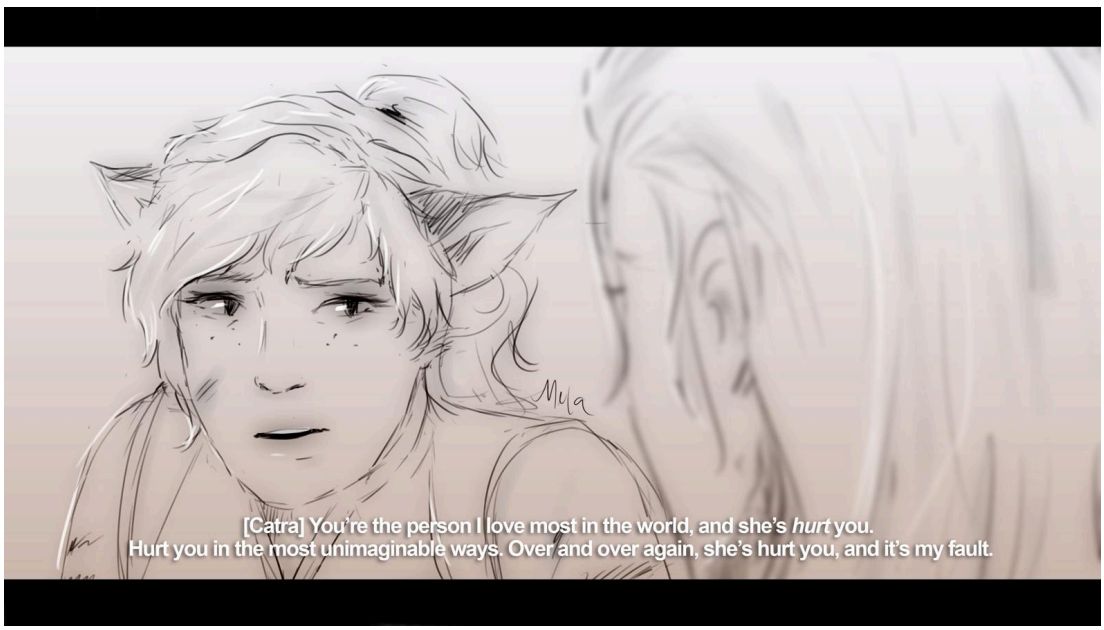
And yes, it's tiring. It's so damn tiring to do this. There is no exhaustion comparable to the one that sets in after Adora successfully heals someone. Not even the exhaustion she experienced in all those weeks awake, tormented by nightmares.

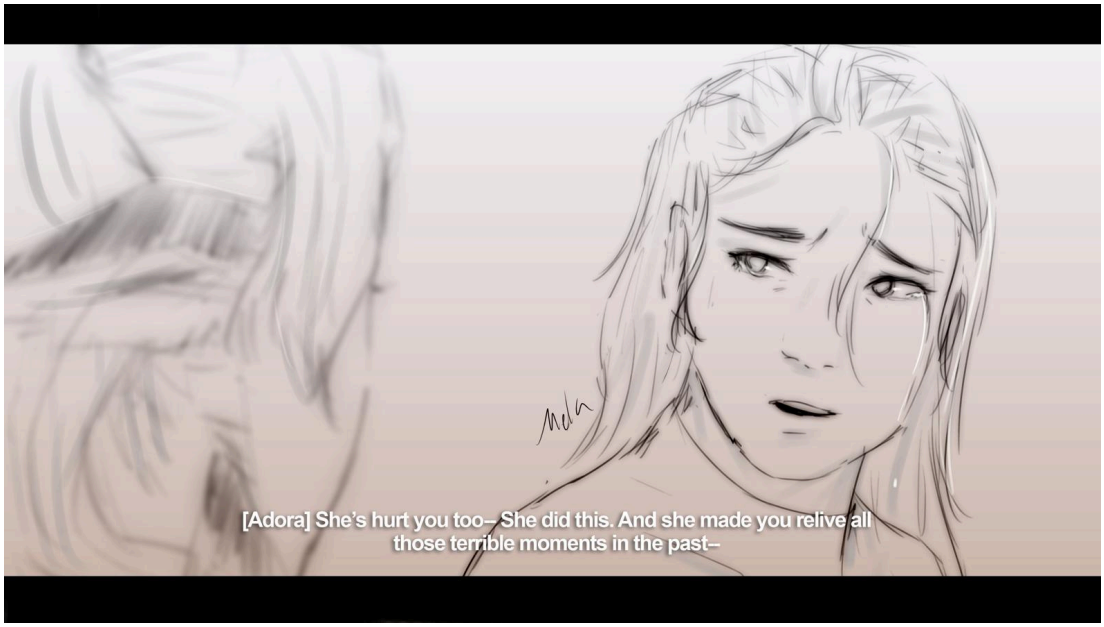
But for Catra, she'll do it. She'll do it over and over again, no matter how many times she must. No matter what it takes from her in the process.

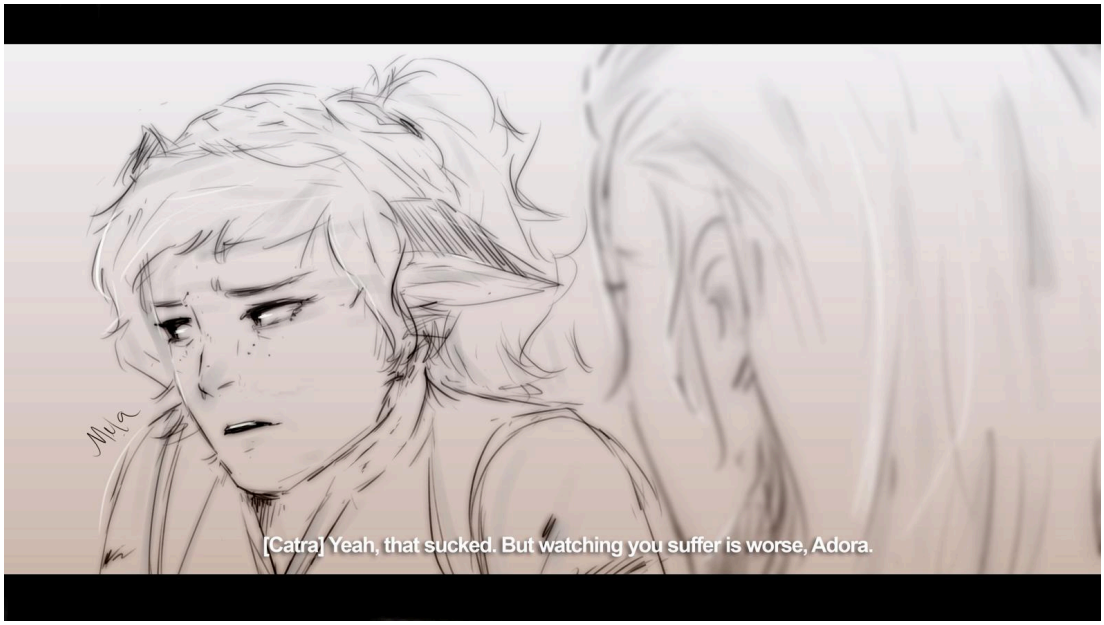
Chapter End Notes

i loved writing this chapter, so let me know if you liked it too!

@heycatrqdora drew some more gorgeous sketches of scenes from this chapter!




[Adora] She's hurt you too– She did this. And she made you relive all those terrible moments in the past–


[Catra] Yeah, that sucked. But watching you suffer is worse, Adora.

Chapter 10

Chapter Summary

Chasm wastes a perfectly good bottle of water.

Bow wakes up.

Adora loses some socks.

Chapter Notes

so i've had kinda a shit week. so again, no art of mine to give for this chapter. luckily, @heycatradora made some lovely art of last chapter! So definitely go check that out.

Anyway, if you haven't seen...this fic is now slated to be 30 chapters. I'm writing the last chapter right now. The chapters could be one more/one less depending on edits i make but right now 30 is a solid promise. Yes, I know 30 chapters and 160k words is a lot to read. It's also a lot to write in two months and I'm still not sure how the fic ended up this long but...here we are.

Anyway, I hope you enjoy this chapter!! And I also hope you stick with me until the fic's completion.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

From within the spaceship, Chasm stares out at the stars. It’s been millennia since she last saw stars. Stars, in space. Their soft, twinkling glow. Their sharp, isolated warmth, each one poking small perforations into the cold blanket of night.

She saw nothing back there, in the prison dimension. She had no eyes by which she could see. Only the brief glimpses of stars she stole from Catra and Adora’s memories, after they first stumbled into her path.

However beautiful the sights, she cannot stay here for long. Down there, on Etheria—the very planet that floats just below them—Adora and her friends are scrambling to wake the people who might help them. Help them pursue Chasm, in particular. If given enough time, they might venture into the wide expanse of space, and find Chasm sitting here...waiting for them.

That cannot be allowed to happen. Not yet.

Besides. Chasm knows the place she must travel to.

The problem is...such a place may no longer exist. Or, at least, it may not exist where she last *remembers* it to exist. Adora's memories tell her that a great deal has changed since Chasm was shoved into that prison dimension. Countless planets destroyed by that would-be conqueror of the universe, Horde Prime. Horde Prime claimed to Adora that these people were gone, *destroyed*, or so he believed.

But if Adora is here...and one of them…

Then they must be out there, somewhere. Even if the planet that once housed them is gone. From what Chasm recalls of that world...the people were nothing if not resilient.

She has one of her other bodies—another guard, the one named Drew, she thinks, though it's hardly relevant anymore—collect a bottle of water from the supplies that Adora and Catra packed, back when they expected to use this ship for vacation travel.

As soon as the bottle is placed within Cleo's grasp, Chasm pours the contents across the floor. Pours it carefully, into the same spot, so that a reflective puddle of water pools across the ship's metal floor.

Chasm uses Cleo's hand to trace a rune across the water. Angling and outstretching Cleo's finger carefully, as she might not be able to cast the spell twice.

A spell like this...it usually involves a set of particular ingredients. But the magic she has tucked away from She-Ra *should* be a sufficient substitute, able to power the spell in absence of magic-imbued ingredients—

Bow is the next person to receive a vial of *Essence of Eternity.*

Adora is there, when Micah tips the vial of liquid into Bow's mouth. Watching, her hand enclosed in Catra's, as Bow swallows the potion in his sleep. Worried, despite herself, that the potion will not work. That Bow will remain asleep, forever and ever, simply because Chasm deemed it so.

But within a few minutes, Bow is waking. The symbol fades from Bow's forehead. Fades, like a speck of blood wiped away with a thumb. And relief nearly sends Adora toppling to her knees.

Groggy eyes crack open, and a gaze darts around in startled confusion.

"Whoa," exhales Bow, upon seeing Glimmer, Catra, Angella, Micah, *and* Adora all clustered around his bed. "I just had the *weirdest* dream."

Glimmer gives a relieved sob and throws her arms around him, hugging him tightly.

Meanwhile, Adora and Catra only exchange a glance. They can imagine what kind of dream it was. A repeat of the past, perhaps. Or maybe Chasm chose to make it more twisted. An alternate reality where things are close to how they truly are, but wrong in some crucial detail—like it was for Adora when she was convinced that Catra had died on Horde Prime's ship.

They don't ask, though. They can only hope that it was more pleasant than what they themselves experienced. It's going to be the last dream Bow has in a while, if the potion works as expected.

And given Bow's successful rousing...they can only assume it will.

Which doesn't bode well for Adora's sleep schedule either. She herself just drank her second dose of the potion—a sufficient quantity to last twenty-four hours, Micah told her, several more than Essence of Oblivion's meager eight.

"*Though it's the same deal as the other potion,*" Micah said, as she choked down the clear contents of that vial. "*Too much at once...and sleep will evade you for the rest of your life. This is the absolute maximum that a person can take at a time.*"

"What's going on?" Bow asks, still staring, wide-eyed, over Glimmer's shoulder at the number of people surrounding his bed. His breath is somewhat suffocated from the force of Glimmer's hug. "What are you...er...all doing in here?"

Adora sighs and reaches for Bow's hand. Somehow, despite Glimmer's grip on him, he manages to wriggle one of his arms from her embrace, and place it within Adora's grasp. She holds it tightly, trying to not cry. Trying, with even more difficulty, to refrain from apologizing frantically for this—for his condition, for Chasm's spell on him.

But that was Chasm, Adora reminds herself. *Chasm did this. Not me*.

"We have a lot to explain," Adora sighs. "And even more to do."

"She was sort of just...meandering in space for a while," Bow says. He presses several buttons on a console, thereby activating a holographic projection at the center of the conference table. One of the nearby star systems. The stars, and there, just outside Etheria's orbit, a glowing red dot—

Chasm. Or rather, an indication of Chasm's ship.

After the war with the Horde, Etheria built itself a small fleet of spaceships so that it could open trade with neighboring planets.

The kingdom of Bright Moon alone has ten spaceships to claim—a small number, and a precious one.

Which is exactly why Bow and Entrapta outfitted the ships with trackers. Trackers that would tell everyone here on Etheria where each ship is, and where each ship is headed, should the navigational systems be activated.

Entrapta was one of the people present during Adora, Angella, and Catra's return from that plane between dimensions. So she, like most people, wasn't spared from Chasm's spell. Few of the princesses were, close with Adora as they all are. And it will take some time to distribute the potion to all of them, as well as to their kingdoms.

Entrapta. Perfuma. Scorpia. Mermista. Frosta. Sea Hawk. All of them, forced under Chasm's spell. All of them, beyond Adora's reach until that potion finds its way past their lips.

And what awaits them after that isn't pretty, either. Sleepless nights. One after the other, until some indefinite moment where Chasm will hopefully be vanquished.

They're lucky to have Bow awake and well-rested, at least. He is just as capable of operating the ship's tracking technology in Entrapta's absence.

"It seems like she was waiting for something," Bow says, staring at that red dot. "For what, I'm not sure."

"So wait—is she still in orbit?" Catra asks, leaning forward in her chair. "Because if she is, that'll make things easy."

Bow shakes his head. "She was...up until several hours ago. But she set a destination this morning, and quickly took off afterwards."

The projected diagram changes. The red dot is now moving through space, shooting past various star systems and nebulas and Etheria-knows-what-else.

“Should I even be here?” Adora asks nervously, glancing at Catra from the corner of her eye. “If I know we’re tracking her, she’ll likely know as well.”

“There’s no point. If she has access to my memories, she already knows,” Bow reminds her. “I helped design this system, remember? The good news is that she can’t remove the tracking. Entrapta and I designed it that way. If they disable the tracking, they lose the navigational system. So she’ll have to let us follow her if she wants to go anywhere.”

“But it’s also something to be wary of then,” Angella says. “If she knows pursuit is unavoidable, she will certainly plan a trap for whoever follows her.”

“I’ll keep it in mind,” Catra mutters.

And still, that prospect frightens Adora—the prospect that Catra plans to battle Chasm without her. Especially after Adora fully viewed and healed Catra’s injuries from last night. Chasm inflicted a lot of damage—and she likely won’t hesitate to do it again.

“She set a course for a planet called Lenaria,” Bow remarks, reading off the screen. “Very far away.”

“What’s on it?” Adora asks.

Bow shakes his head. “As far as I know, nothing. According to our records, it was completely *decimated* by Horde Prime. There’s no life there at all. And no colonies have sprung up since then.”

“Then why would she be interested in it,” Micah muses “if there’s nothing there of note?”

“Maybe she’s trying to hide?” Glimmer offers. “We did give her a pretty good fight.”

“She still won,” Catra reminds her. “She got away, even if she didn’t get Adora. And really, that’s all she needs to do.”

“There has to be some reason she’s headed there,” Adora says, folding her arms and jerking her head in the direction of the hologram. “Something we’re missing.”

She looks to Catra then, placing a hand on her shoulder. “You said you talked with her, back when…” Adora trails off, gulps, and tries again. “Back when she was in control of my body. Did she give any clues as to where she was headed, once she had the *Essence of Oblivion*?”

“She didn’t give much information about her larger plans,” Catra replies. “Just that she wanted control of She-Ra. But...it was weird. She had control of you, but didn’t seem to be able to transform. And she got seriously ticked off when I mentioned it.”

Glimmer leans forward in her chair. “Ticked off, as in...more than usual? I thought this lady was supposed to be awful all the time.”

Catra shakes her head. “She’s awful, yeah. But Chasm is usually too arrogant to let herself get mad. Only when you say something that really gets under her skin does that veneer start to slip. Like when I kicked her out of my head, back in that dreamworld, and she was actually forced to. She wasn’t strong enough to keep herself attached back then...and in this case, she couldn’t control She-Ra. Not the way she wanted to.”

“Well, I guess there’s some sort of silver lining to this,” mutters Adora. “She wanted She-Ra, but all she got was control over me.”

Catra scratches her chin. “She told me that she’d have control of She-Ra *soon*, though. ‘*As soon as I have the pieces I need*.’ That’s what said.”

“What pieces, though?” Angella asks, and Adora doesn’t like it. She doesn’t like the way Micah, Glimmer, and Angella all exchange alarmed glances.

“*The Essence of Oblivion*?” Adora suggests. “If she got me to drink enough to make the effects permanent, maybe it would’ve given her control of She-Ra—”

Glimmer shakes her head. “That’s not how it works. Drinking too much of that potion will make the effects permanent, yes...but there’s nothing to indicate that a higher dosage will actually change the *effects* themselves. And if the existing effects of the potion weren’t enough to give Chasm control of She-Ra—

“Then she must have been after something else,” Catra finishes for her. “Something different.”

Adora stares at her hands, contemplating. She doesn’t understand why Chasm would bother trying to control her if She-Ra wasn’t part of the deal. Adora is good in combat, sure. But not good enough for Chasm to confront Glimmer in the hope of getting more *Essence of Oblivion*.

And what other ways would there be for Chasm to gain control of She-Ra, if not that same potion?

“Maybe she didn’t know,” Adora realizes, finally. “She spent months trying to force me to take that potion, even when she had already spread to all of Etheria. And even when I *did* take it, she didn’t act for so long. She bided her time. Maybe she *expected* the potion to give her control of She-Ra, but all she got was control of me.”

“Well,” Catra says with a grin in Adora’s direction. “Props to you for wasting the bitch’s time for so long.”

Shrugging, Adora says. “I guess I always assumed that She-Ra just sort of...inhabits me. Lives in my body, alongside me. It’s why I’ve always referred to her as something separate from me. Talking about her like she’s something other than myself.” Adora gestures to her own head, at the thoughts within. “And maybe that’s what Chasm thought too, because of my memories. She thought She-Ra was just something that I had. Something she could take. But maybe...maybe that’s not it at all. Maybe, ever since I shattered the sword, she’s a part of me. Part of my mind, or soul, or whatever. Which means that if I don’t exist in my body, then neither does she.”

Adora smiles, triumphant, despite the circumstances.

"Which means that Chasm will never, ever get her."

Angella smirks just a bit. "It must have been quite frustrating for her to realize that. To realize that there are better ways in which magical beings can find a place in this world."

Adora is tempted to return the smile. Tempted...until she sees Catra in her periphery. Catra, whose whole body has gone rigid, and whose eyes have pulled wide.

"Wait," Catra says, reaching for Adora's wrist. "You said...after you shattered the sword. What was it like before that—before you started turning into She-Ra like you do now?"

Catra is staring at her. Staring, pleadingly, like this might be the most important piece of information in the whole universe. And that stare alone renews the dread in Adora's stomach, reclaiming it after that brief respite—that brief relief produced by the knowledge that She-Ra will never belong to Chasm. Gone now, replaced by something equal part menacing and nameless.

"The sword was different," Adora says slowly. "When I transform now, it comes from a place inside of me. But before...everything came from the sword. My weapons. My transformation. My magic. I needed the sword to do anything. It…"

Adora swallows hard, then finishes—each word more unsteady than the last.

"It controlled her. It controlled She-Ra."

There's a pause as everyone stares, silent.

And then, when Catra finally interrupts the silence, Adora is startled by the rasping horror in Catra's voice. One that Adora has ever heard when Catra has been ill, in the past. Her words slurred and stuttering beneath the tumultuous throes of nausea.

“And where is it now?” Catra manages. “The sword?”

Adora glances around, examining the faces at the table. They’re all staring at her like she has said something awful—like she predicted that the universe will *explode* tomorrow, with each galaxy careening into shattered stars and fiery smithereens.

But Adora...Adora hasn’t said anything they don’t already know.

“It’s in pieces,” Adora says, after another difficult gulp. And truly, it’s like there’s something there, in Adora’s throat. Something thick and unmoving and *painful*.

“And *where* are the pieces?” Catra asks, insistent. But in a way that suggests that she doesn’t wish to know at all.

“I…” Adora inhales shakily, too aware of everyone’s eyes, each pupil like a needle boring into her skin. “I kept them. In a box. A box in the closet. Buried, really. I haven’t opened it since the war but I...I couldn’t bring myself to get rid of it, but—”

Catra shuts her eyes, her grip on Adora’s wrist nearly tightening enough to bruise. Her voice is taut, barely above a whisper, when she says, “Chasm had a box, when she left.”

Adora stares.

“Something she took from our room,” Catra continues. “And she was rummaging in our closet the night before. I saw her. I...I thought you were sleepwalking. But now…”

No.

No.

Did Chasm take—?

Did Chasm take the Sword? The original one, the one Adora nearly tore herself apart to break, to *stop*?

The one that nearly forced her to obliterate the universe?

Adora feels something snap inside of her. Some feeble wire of calmness, of hope. Something that drops Adora into some great cavern of terror—one with no discernible end or bottom.

"I-I should've…" Adora slumps back in her chair, both palms pressed her temples. "I should've *destroyed* it. Years ago, I should've…" She gasps, and her vision is overcome by a glare of tears. "But I kept it. I kept it, and now she has it. God, I don't know what I was thinking—"

Catra unclenches her hand from Adora's wrist, instead using it to rub some shaking semblance of a soothing circle into Adora's back. "You didn't know," she murmurs, again trying to shift the blame from Adora's shoulders. But god...how is Adora supposed to remain blameless for this? This complete and utter lapse in judgment—

"Before we jump to conclusions," Micah interrupts, "We should make sure it's really gone. And if it is…"

"So that's what she's going to do?" Glimmer asks, horrified. "She's going to rebuild the First Ones' sword? The one that nearly *destroyed* the universe?"

"She doesn't have another option," Angella replies grimly. "Except what she has been told to work, in the past. And from Adora's memories, she must have discovered this last contingency—"

"Well, you could shatter it again, right?" Bow says, forcing a smile in Adora's direction. "I mean, You did it once—"

"Only because Light Hope helped me," murmurs Adora. "She let go of her control just long enough for me to break the sword. And Chasm…" Adora shakes her head. "She won't do the same. Control is all she wants. She'd never give me that chance."

And even with Light Hope's help, it was difficult. Difficult beyond description, beyond imagination. Adora has already relived that

moment recently, thanks to Chasm's illusions. Relived the immense, impossible struggle of thrusting that sword down. *Down*, despite how the First Ones' programming compelled it up, into the air, the energy swelling in the runestone and pulsing in anticipation of its own destructive power, burning the blood from Adora's veins—

She can't do it again. She can't.

And truly, there's no comfort she can provide—no assurance she can offer. She can do nothing except watch Bow's smile fade into horror. The same horror that is mirrored on every other face in the room.

Catra grunts and scrapes her claws into the table. "Then there must be something there, on Lenaria," Catra says, glancing at the screen. "Something that she thinks will help her build the sword anew. Something that we need to keep her from getting."

Adora shuts her eyes and drops her head into her hands. "Because that will be it," Adora says numbly. "She'll get exactly what she wants. She-Ra, as her weapon. She-Ra, forced to destroy whatever Chasm pleases."

Adora doesn't curse very often. It's an occasional thing, really. Something Catra has only witnessed during Adora's most intense outbursts of rage. For instance—when someone (other than Glimmer) refers to Catra as *Horde Scum*. Or when some intergalactic diplomat makes a much-unwanted pass at Adora. Or during the previous night, when Adora attended to Catra's remarkably gruesome injuries.

But really, nothing could have prepared Catra for the utter *barrage* of curses that erupt from Adora's mouth, just as Catra returns to the bedroom. She sputters every known curse in the Etherian language, and even adds a few swears from the various alien dialects she's taught herself over the years.

It's easy to follow the bellowing trail of curses to the closet. The closet, where Adora stands amidst the aftermath of a typhoon. Or, at least, that's what it looks like. Every box and knickknack and bin has been utterly upended and dumped upon the floor.

The result of the search for the sword, Catra can only assume.

Adora is still cursing when Catra approaches. Catra holds her tongue, poising quietly against the frame of the closet door as she observes. What's strange is that Adora doesn't really appear to be searching anymore. In fact, she seems to be tearing clothes off long-untouched hangers, or pulling old shoes from strange crevices.

It takes several moments for Adora to notice her. When her eyes finally pass over Catra's figure—quickly, at first, without any real awareness, followed by a snappish, startled return—she yelps loudly and drops the clothes piled in her arms.

"Catra!" she gasps, clutching at her chest. Her tone quickly grows stern. "Don't do that! You scared me."

"Sorry," says Catra. "Didn't want to interrupt. You seemed pretty...y'know. Focused." She crosses her arms and jerks her head toward their mess of a closet. "I take it you didn't find the sword, huh?"

Adora presses her lips tightly together as she shakes her head, evidently swallowing some sort of sob—or perhaps another stream of curses. "No," she grits out. "I didn't. I found nothing but *junk*."

In her rage, Adora kicks a cardboard box, resulting in its toppling and the spilling of its contents. A collection of She-Ra toys, evidently. One that some planet had decided to produce and give to Adora as a gift, for some reason. Not that Adora had much use for them.

"Yeah," says Catra, eyes the spilled toys with some disdain. "We really should've cleared this thing out more often."

Adora merely shakes her head at the mess and recollects the dropped clothes from the floor. And it's strange, Catra thinks, that Adora is leaving so much of the mess as it is, and only focusing on clearing a select few items.

Catra sighs. "Why did you keep that sword, anyway?"

And she can tell that Adora does not like the question by the way she freezes in place, whole body gone still—barely shifting to even breathe.

"I mean...it's not like it worked anymore," Catra continues, even though she knows she probably shouldn't. "And I know you don't exactly have good memories of the damn thing. So why keep it? Why not melt it down into nothing, just like we did with the Horde's junk?"

Long moments drag past before Adora so much as moves, let alone speaks.

"I don't know," Adora says, finally, with a small shrug. "I'm sentimental, I guess."

Catra just hums. She's not convinced by that explanation—not in the least. Adora is sentimental, sure, but only about certain things. Like keeping their wedding clothes neatly packaged in the closet. But like Catra said...it's not like Adora keeps much from her days in the Horde.

So she doesn't understand why Adora would keep something that caused her so much pain.

Adora returns to her rummaging. Though this time, Catra notices that she's shoving the clothes into a small duffel bag.

"Wait a minute," Catra grumbles, and pushes herself off the doorframe. She places herself directly in front of Adora, hands on her own hips. "What do you think you're doing?"

"I'm packing," Adora informs her, with a pointed thrust of a t-shirt into the duffel bag.

Catra grits her teeth. "If you are, it better be for a *logical* reason, like wanting a divorce. And not—"

"I'm coming with you," says Adora, like it's non-negotiable, and shoves yet another shirt into the bag.

Catra shakes her head like it's absolutely out of the question. "Adora—"

"Why do you think I've been cursing so much?" Adora demands. "I mean...on top of all the other shitty things she did, she *also* stole all our half-decent clothes!"

"*Adora*—"

"We should've never loaded our suitcases onto the ship," Adora continues furiously. "Because now we're probably *never* going to see that suit again, let alone any of my favorite socks—"

"Are you seriously hung up on that suit right now?" Catra hisses, reaching for Adora's shoulders and holding them tightly. She looks Adora directly in the eyes when she says, "Adora—you're not coming. We agreed that I'd go after her, and bring her back here for you to deal with."

"Well, I changed my mind."

Catra's nostrils flare. "Why?"

"Because it doesn't make sense!" fumes Adora. "Especially now that we know she's heading to a vacant planet, which means I won't run the risk of infecting anyone if I go—"

"What do you mean, *it doesn't make sense*?" Catra demands. "It makes a lot more sense than what you're planning, what with you needing to take *Essence of Eternity* every day just to keep from falling back under her spell—"

"That's exactly why I need to go, Catra!" Adora argues. "With every day I stay awake, the harder it will be for me to summon She-Ra. So if you want me to be able to *vanquish Chasm* or whatever, we need to capture one of her hosts as soon as possible. And it'll take half as much time for me to just *go with you* than drag someone all the way back here."

Catra searches for a retort—a reason why Adora's plan is unsound.

But the problem is...it isn't. It actually makes a lot of sense. It would take less time for Adora to vanquish Chasm as soon as they find her, rather than wait for Catra to return to Etheria with one of Chasm's hosts. That's simply a matter of easy mathematics, one that can't really be disputed.

And Catra *hates* that.

"Besides," says Adora. "Chasm is really powerful. Too powerful for you alone, and there's no one else to go with you. The other princesses are all still asleep, and the sorcerers need to stay here and brew enough potion to wake the rest of the population."

"Angella could —" Catra begins, but even she knows it's a weak argument.

Adora scoffs and steps closer to Catra, leaning down as if issuing a challenge. "Angella isn't combat-trained, and has very limited magical power now that Glimmer's queen. Face it. You *need* me. I'm the only one whose magic compares to Chasm's and you know it. And so does *she*."

She. Chasm. Because of course Chasm knows that—it's the very reason why she wants She-Ra under her control.

Adora is staring at Catra expectantly, both eyebrows raised. Like she's just waiting for Catra to question her, or raise a counterargument.

And it's stupidly, obnoxiously attractive to see Adora win a debate so completely. But it's just as frustrating that *Catra* is the one she's winning the debate against.

And in the end, Catra really has only one counterargument left to give.

"And what if she wants you to come after her?" Catra says, taking a step forward of her own—her face mere inches from Adora. "What if this is a trap? What if she's already repaired that sword, huh? What if you're the last piece she needs and you're just handing it over to her—?"

"It probably *is* a trap," Adora concedes, but looks no less determined. "But if there's a chance I can beat her before she infects anyone else—or torments more victims into becoming her new hosts...then fine. I'll take that risk."

"And what if *I'm* not willing to take that risk?" Catra counters. "What if I want you here, where it's safe?"

Adora sighs and reaches for Catra's hands. A warm and gentle weighing of Catra's fingers in Adora's palms.

"She's coming for me sooner or later, Catra," Adora murmurs. "I might as well face her on my terms. While I still have some traces of sleep in my system, and full control of She-Ra."

Catra makes a small sound of protest. A whine, almost, but far more furious. "I just don't want to see you get hurt again."

Adora manages a smile and leans in closer. "I'll be okay. And with any luck...Chasm will be the one getting hurt."

"I hope you're right," is all Catra can say in response as Adora's lips draw closer and closer. Closer and closer, until they're barely parted from Catra's at all. And it's hypnotizing, the rhythm of Adora's breath as it puffs across Catra's mouth, and Catra wants to taste it more than she can express—

“It’s really annoying,” Adora murmurs, absently. More like she’s talking to herself than to Catra. But even with her eyes half-lidded and her attention fully occupied by the shape of Adora’s lips, rather than the words they form, Catra can’t resist asking anyway.

“What?”

Adora continues hanging there, suspended, over Catra’s lips. Her mouth a stormcloud of heat and mist and *electricity.* “How much I’d rather kiss you than argue with you.”

Catra breathes out a short chuckle. “Yeah. Can’t really argue about that, either.”

The words have hardly left her lips when Adora’s finally descend, sweeping Catra into thunder and rain and wind in the form of mingling, gasping breaths, exchanged between them.

Chapter End Notes

> Please remember to comment/kudos if you haven't! It will give me a much-needed dose of serotonin after my shitty week.

Chapter 11

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora head into space!

Chasm has some things to say.

And Bow notices a problem.

Chapter Notes

hey y'all! thanks for tuning in for another chapter. I've been so busy I'm literally just a walking pile of sleep deprivation so again...no art. I might just have to give up on my dream to illustrate this fic for the next few months.

In other news...please remember to comment!! Last week I saw a pretty big drop in comments, which can be kinda disheartening. Please keep in mind that when I say comments are all that keep me posting, I really mean it. My life is an endless cycle of schoolwork and part-time work rn and the feedback would really help.

In other *other* news...ehj wrote another song based on imemorial. This one's based on adora's bathroom breakdown scene from two chapters ago, so I highly recommend checking it out! It's really great.

Anyway, enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It takes them two whole days, but Glimmer and Micah manage to brew enough potion for Adora, enough to keep her awake during her travels. Two weeks' worth, specifically. No more. No less.

It's all they can do, given the circumstances—and with how many others still lie asleep, in need of the potion. If Catra and Adora's

trip takes longer than those two weeks...Adora will have little choice but to make herself vulnerable to Chasm's magic. She can only hope that Chasm won't choose to act, or that Catra will be in a position to bring her back to Etheria, where more doses of the potion might await her.

"Promise you'll carry me back home if Chasm knocks me out again?" Adora asks Catra, half-joking, half-serious.

"Promise," replies Catra, with a squeeze of Adora's hand. And Adora notes with some surprise that Catra doesn't seem to be joking at all. "We're coming back here, princess. The both of us."

It's frustrating to pack, what with most of Adora and Catra's belongings loaded aboard the ship that Chasm stole. But they'll have to make do with some of their more ill-fitting or uncomfortable or (to Catra's displeasure) unstylish outfits. And comparable replacements to any other necessities they would otherwise plan to bring.

With the potion made, and yet another ship packed and ready to go...there's little else Catra and Adora can do but say goodbye.

Micah, Glimmer, Angella, and Bow—the majority of the still-waking people in Bright Moon—gather around the ship as Catra and Adora prepare to leave. Somehow Micah and Glimmer look even more exhausted than Adora or Bow do. A surprising development, considering that they're among the few people still capable of sleep, free of Chasm's infection as they are. They've simply been brewing the potion non-stop, producing vials upon vials throughout the morning and night.

Adora hugs each and every one of them before she departs. "We're going to fix this," she tells them, over and over, despite how much Adora herself wonders if it's even true. But they all nod like they have every confidence in her, like there's nothing to doubt, and maybe that makes Adora just a little bit more confident in their chances.

Bow hugs Adora tightest of all. "Look," he says, arms curled firmly around her back. "If you ever need someone to talk to, while you're out there—remember that you're not the only one staying awake. You can comm me at any time, especially during the night." He releases her only so that he can shoot her a smile. "We could both use the conversation."

Adora nods and tucks her face into his shoulder for just a little while longer.

"I'm going to fix this," she says again. And really, that's all she can think to say. All she can think to do. "You'll be sleeping through the night in no time."

At least, that's what she hopes for him. And for herself.

Though her tolerance for sleep deprivation is better than most, Adora already feels the weight of her own wakefulness—the pressure behind her eyes, the throbbing of her temples. It's been two nights without sleep now, and she knows her symptoms will only worsen from here. And with every passing day, she grows more aware of how her grip on She-Ra might start to slip, so dependent is She-Ra on Adora's concentration—

"We should probably get going," Catra says, softly, with a hand placed on Adora's shoulder. "We're already a few days behind her."

Adora gives one more nod, and Bow releases her.

"Good luck," he says, and the rest of the group echoes the same sentiment—wishes for their success, and from Glimmer, a request that Chasm receive some sort of punch on Bright Moon's behalf.

"Anything that makes her hurt," Glimmer says with a small shrug. "And I'll be satisfied."

Angella's face remains devoid of amusement, though.

"Remember what I said," she warns. "Be wary of traps. Chasm is adept at setting them. And whatever she has planned, I doubt it's

something you'd wish to set off."

Adora and Catra both agree to heed her warning, exchanging the briefest of glances as they both recall the conversation from two nights ago.

"*And what if she wants you to come after her?*" Catra demanded. "*What if you're the last piece she needs and you're just handing it over to her—*?"

Adora shuts her eyes and takes a deep breath. Whatever Chasm has in store, she'll simply have to face. There's no avoiding it.

And then Catra is extending her hand. Extending it for Adora to take as they both climb up the ramp that leads to the ship's hatch. She grabs on readily, her fingers clinging tightly to Catra's as they journey up, and forward. Beyond the hatch and into the cockpit, settling themselves into the twin pilot's chairs that face outward, toward the clear shield of the hull.

"You ready?" Catra asks, as her fingers inch toward the controls. The ones that will activate the navigational systems and send them hurtling toward the space beyond, where Chasm sprints toward her inexplicable destination.

"Positive," says Adora, holding Catra's gaze steady as she utters that single, perhaps slightly dishonest word. But it seems to convince Catra enough. She flips whatever switches necessary to bring the ship glowing and beeping and *roaring* to life. And then, after clearly enunciating their destination to the ship's artificial intelligence, Catra and Adora watch as anti-gravity technology gently hoists them from the ground.

Though all gentleness fades when combustion flares in the booster rockets, sending the ship screeching past the horizon and the atmosphere and the planet's orbit. And then they're there, finally, floating among the stars, each one zipping over the hull in lines of white.

"*Takeoff complete*," the AI drones, once they're at a stable—namely, faster-than-light—speed. "*Arrival on Lenaria in approximately three days*."

Adora sighs. Three days. Nearly a quarter of her supply of potion.

She can only hope that defeating Chasm is easy, once they arrive.

They sit there for hours, simply watching the stars slice lines through the air (or really, lack thereof) around the ship. Strings of shining white pulled taut over their eyes and tugged away just as quickly.

Adora could probably watch the stars forever. Or, at least...she *hopes* she can watch the stars forever without getting tired of it. Because it's highly likely that she'll spend far too much time out here, on the main deck. Wasting away the hours that she would normally devote to sleep.

She worries, though. Worries that the sight will grow old far too quickly.

So when Catra stands from her seat and stretches—yawning widely, open-mouthed and incisors bared, in the way that only Catra does—Adora knows that it must be time for bed. Or, really, time for bed for any normal person *not* under the influence of *Essence of Eternity.* Adora has been ready to sleep since two days ago, though she has remained robbed of the chance.

Catra rests a hand on Adora's shoulder. "I'm gonna sleep for a bit, okay?"

Adora nods and shifts, preparing to stand. "I'll join you."

Catra watches her skeptically. "Well...uh...I hate to be the one to remind you, Adora. But you can't exactly join me in sleeping."

"Of course I know that. I figured I could...I dunno…" Adora rubs at the base of her neck. "Try meditating or something. Perfuma

always raves about that, about meditating. And I figure it's better than nothing."

Catra hardly looks convinced.

"If I spend too much time wandering the deck, it's going to get old real fast," Adora huffs out. "There's just not enough space. So I'll try this for a night. See if it works."

"Alright. Fine," sighs Catra and she begins turning toward the corridor leading to the sleeping quarters. "We can try it."

Though she's soon spinning around again, and pointing a not-so-compromising finger in Adora's face.

"But don't try to like...start a conversation or anything," Catra adds. "I really want to sleep."

Adora scoffs. "Yeah, well. So do I. But I won't bother you, if that's what you're worried about. And besides—" Adora smirks and grabs Catra's finger, gently enclosing it within her fist. "You hate how cold space is. You'd miss me if I wasn't there."

Catra snorts and yanks her finger out of Adora's grasp. "Let's go, then," she says, gesturing for Adora to follow. And she does. Walking closely behind, taking Catra's hand when she reaches out for Adora behind herself.

"I *did* miss you, you know," Catra murmurs, just as they reach the sliding metal door that conceals the small compartment that will serve as their bedroom.

"When?" asks Adora with a small laugh. "In the few seconds I was walking behind you?"

"No," hisses Catra, with an enormous roll of her eyes. Though her features are quick to soften afterward. She releases Adora's hand to cup her face, stroking over her cheeks with her thumbs. "When you couldn't sleep, I meant," Catra continues. "When you spent so much time at your desk, or walking the halls, or at the library—

trying to stay awake. I missed you. I missed having you beside me."

Adora places her hands over her wife's hips, leaning forward until her lips are pressed firmly against Catra's. An insistent reminder of a kiss, one to tell Catra that Adora is here, and not going anywhere.

Though it doesn't progress into anything deeper, not tonight. Catra is tired, and Adora can tell. And if at least *one* person aboard the ship can actually get some sleep, Adora knows she'd best let Catra do that. Without Adora keeping her up any later than necessary.

Instead, Adora merely climbs into the cot behind Catra. She arranges herself upright. Upright, so that she does not experience sleeping limbs or soreness...but not so rigid that Catra cannot curl up her in her arms. She outstretches her legs and reclines just slightly, creating an ideal space for Catra to nestle herself within, head leaning against Adora's stomach.

She strokes Catra's hair for a long while. Listening to Catra's rumbling purrs, and watching as Catra slowly drifts to sleep. Adora can't help but smile a little as Catra's breath smooths into a relaxed rhythm. Catra's face, too, becomes something entirely different in sleep. All traces of Catra's scowls or snark disappear, instead revealing someone who almost looks calm and collected. And therefore not very Catra-like at all.

Though the longer that Adora sits there, with Catra in her arms, the more that Adora longs to sleep. Her eyelids are anchors, pulling her down. Heavy and oversized in their sockets. And she's so comfortable here, in bed like this.

But still, despite Adora's immense tiredness, sleep never truly sweeps Adora away. It simply sits there in her periphery, too far out of reach. And Adora knows that she shouldn't complain about that. That's the point of the potion, after all. To keep her awake, and free from Chasm's influence.

So instead, Adora shuts her eyes, and tips her head back. She struggles to recall the breathing exercises that Perfuma taught her so many times before. The meditation tactics that Adora definitely should've paid better attention to.

So she does what's simplest. She keeps her eyes shut, and breathes. Breathes, over and over again, as slowly as she possibly can. Inhale. Exhale. Repeat, with each breath like the soft, languid rocking of a boat at seat.

Adora doesn't know how long she sits like that, meditating. Or trying something like it. Trying to empty her own head of thoughts and fears. She wishes to simply exist, here, in this body, floating with nothing to trouble her.

That's what she pictures, at least, until Adora hears...something. A laugh, it sounds like. A mocking, quiet laugh—almost like the echo of someone beyond the walls of the room. But of course that doesn't make sense. They're in space and completely *alone* on this ship.

But Adora can't be dreaming, either. Not with the potion in her system. So what—

A hum. And then, louder—

"Taking a rest, are we?"

It's a whisper still, but very clearly *a voice*. And not Catra's—Adora would know Catra's voice anywhere, at any volume or with any arrangement of words—

Adora's eyes fly open, searching the room for the source of that voice.

And worse, Adora thinks that she already knows. Has already identified—

And there, perched against the door, watching with evident, pupil-less amusement, is the figure, the face, the *person* that Adora

hoped to never see again.

Or, well, Adora *hoped* to see that person, but only in a certain context. She hoped to findone of Chasm's hosts and capture them. She hoped to watch She-Ra's magic obliterate Chasm from that host. But if she's seeing Chasm like this, in her true form—with her red skin and near-glowing white hair and bony edges—that can only mean one thing…

Adora must be trapped in another illusion.

But...she doesn't know how. Adora has been taking the potion, just as instructed. So she couldn't have fallen asleep.

Could she?

She glances down at Catra. Catra, who is still lying in Adora's arms, asleep and purring softly as Catra dreams. And Adora can only wonder—is this Catra fake? An illusion, along with the rest of the ship?

Chasm releases a low chuckle and unsticks herself from the door. She approaches the bed like mist oozing across the ground.

"Oh, *do* calm yourself," Chasm smirks. "You're not trapped anywhere. You can break free at any time."

"Then, what—"Adora tries to say, but realizes that her mouth isn't moving at all, even though her voice rings loud and clear throughout the room.

A glance down reveals that Catra hasn't so much as stirred at the sound of Adora's voice either. She just keeps sleeping soundly, like there's nothing—and no one—to be worried about.

Even though Adora can see someone to be *very* worried about, right in front of them.

"I'm merely...paying you a visit," says Chasm too-pleasantly, looming closer and closer within Adora's vision. "It seems that, so

long as you sufficiently calm your thoughts, there is a way for me to navigate that shrieking maze you call a mind—”

Adora shakes her head. “You’re not...You’re *not* going to control me.”

And again, she’s stricken by how loudly the words echo, even without her mouth opening to utter them.

“Not at the current moment, no,” she replies, perhaps slightly aggrieved by the admission. “You’re meditating, yes, but you’re not unconscious. Which means that I have just enough sway to conjure *this* illusion for you—” Chasm gestures to herself. “—so that we can speak more directly with one another. Nothing you say will leave the confines of this illusion that we share.”

“I don’t *want* to speak with you,” snarls Adora. “And I never will.”

Chasm only smirks and folds her hands in front of her lap. “Never is a long time, dear girl. An eternity, really. Something that you cannot comprehend.”

“And why, exactly, do you want to speak with me?” Adora demands. “You’ve spent months trying to permanently shut me up, after all. So why have you decided *now* that you want my opinion on anything?”

Chasm makes a clicking noise. A sound of pity as she looks down at Catra, still sleeping peacefully in Adora’s embrace—an embrace that now tightens as Adora seeks to protect Catra from this monstrous presence that lingers over their bed.

“Well, who would have thought?” asks Chasm, with a smile at Adora. “It seems that even Catra can appear peaceful, when she puts her mind to it.”

Adora only grips Catra with renewed force, shifting both their bodies in the hope of shielding Catra from Chasm’s sight. A useless hope, Adora knows, since Chasm can see whatever Adora does. But Adora cannot think of anything else to do.

Catra gives a short whimper at being moved, but only curls herself deeper into Adora, sighing contentedly as she does.

"You truly love her, don't you?" Chasm asks, seeming almost amused by the concept. "You'd do anything for her?"

"Yes," says Adora, through what sounds like gritted teeth—though her mouth remains unmoving. It's no use lying about it. If Chasm has access to Adora's thoughts, she'd easily glean how Adora truly feels about Catra. The lengths Adora would go to keep her safe.

"Good," says Chasm, as though pleased by the answer. "Then surely you will want to act in her best interest, hm? Surely you want to protect her?"

"From you, most of all," Adora mutters, but that only makes Chasm laugh.

"Oh, by all means," Chasm says, "it's a worthy thing. To want to protect those you love from monsters like me."

Chasm leans in close—uncomfortably so—until Adora can see every pore on Chasm's bright red skin, her eyes blank and glistening despite the near-darkness of the room. "So I'm giving you a chance to do that. To protect her," says Chasm, with a gentle smile. Gentle, as the layer of cloth that might conceal a knife.

Adora only stares, clutching at Catra like she might be yanked away at any moment.

"Surrender yourself," Chasm says. "Submit to my instructions, and I will leave her unharmed."

Adora sets her jaw. "And if I don't?"

"Then, in time, she will suffer for your mistakes," Chasm replies, voice low and menacing in its promise. "That, I can personally guarantee."

For a long time, Adora can only sit there, frozen and staring. She hates this. She hates that she can't even meditate without Chasm invading her mind, plucking her thoughts directly from her head. Worse, invading Adora's vision with her terrifying appearance. An appearance that she is using to threaten Catra—threaten her *directly* to Adora's face.

She wants nothing more than to make Chasm pay. To reach out with She-Ra's hands, and strangle her into nonexistence. Or even better...utterly *disintegrate* Chasm in the same way she did to Horde Prime, blasting her apart in a ray of light.

Adora knows that none of that will work here, and now. With Chasm standing here as no more than a vision in Adora's mind.

"*Not—a—chance*," growls Adora, despite the inexplicable tears that spring to her eyes. Each word is drawn-out, and brimming with fury. "I'm *done* falling for your tricks."

Chasm merely raises an eyebrow, which only serves to infuriate Adora more. Because Chasm clearly doesn't believe her. She thinks that she'll use Adora just like before, just like she's done so many times in the past, and that there's nothing Adora can do to stop her.

But that's not true. It's not true anymore, Adora will make sure of it—

"I'm not doing anything you say, anything you want, *ever again*," Adora nearly yells, her own voice reverberating, disembodied, all across the room. "In fact—"

She leans forward slowly, careful not to disturb Catra as she does.

"I'm the one *you* should be afraid of," Adora tells her, with the most confident smile she can muster. "You've only messed with my brain. You've never faced me here, in the real world, before. Never faced She-Ra in the flesh. And when you finally do…" Adora takes a deep, trembling breath. "I'm going to make you very, *very*

sorry. For hurting the people on Etheria. For hurting Angella, and Catra, and *me*—"

Chasm releases a laugh, high and disbelieving. "And how, exactly, do you plan to make me sorry, *oh-mighty-She-Ra*?"

Adora swallows, hard. "I'm going to wipe you from the face of existence. Just like I did to Horde Prime."

"Horde Prime?" Chasm laughs, like it's the name of some amusing jokester, rather than the name of the worst tyrant the universe has ever known. But then it changes, her voice. Morphing into something akin to a snarl. "What makes you think I'm *anything* like Horde Prime?"

And then she's growing larger, taller, in Adora's vision. Hunching over their bed like some great predator, with its prey cornered and helpless beneath her.

"Horde Prime was feeble. Mortal," Chasm hisses. "A creature kept alive only by the breadth of his own arrogance and an army of funny little machines. But me?"

Her hands reach down, fingers nearly brushing over Adora's cheek —but, of course, Adora feels nothing in the illusion. Though she shudders regardless.

"If I were so easily vanquished by your magic," Chasm taunts, "then why am I still here, cozy and safe within the confines of your mind? I am bound to you, same as all the others, same as those I possess more completely. So do it. Vanquish me. Destroy me and be done with it."

Adora only gapes, stunned by Chasm's words. Could it be true? Could destroying Chasm be that easy—as easy as reaching within herself, and using She-Ra's magic to dissolve Chasm from her mind?

She's never applied that sort of magic to herself before. But maybe…

Adora inhales deeply, and shuts her eyes. She summons her magic. Magic, from that place deep inside herself, all while picturing a pure, bright light within her head. A light that finds Chasm, in some dark corner of her mind. Finds her...and dissolves her into nothing at all. Nothing but red dust and a resounding screech.

And then she sits there, in awe that it worked. In awe that Chasm would reveal the truth to her—

But all hope and relief vanishes as Adora hears a laugh—a loud one—and a voice whispering back to her, within her head

"*You know as well as well as I do that you're not strong enough*," Chasm snarks. "*But feel free to keep trying*, *and tire yourself out*…"

And, for a moment, it's like she can still *feel* Chasm there, within herself. Attached as though by some magical chain. One that feels permanent, unbreakable. It thrums with power. A thrumming in rejection of Adora's futile attempts to destroy it, and the creature that created it.

Adora shakes her head fiercely, fighting the urge to release a scream of frustration. Why couldn't it be easy, for once in Adora's life? Why couldn't it *work*?

"Adora!" a very un-Chasm-like voice yells, one that startles Adora with its realness. "What the *hell* are you doing?"

Adora's eyes open. While Adora was unable to rid Chasm from existence, she is relieved to discover that Chasm has disappeared from the room. She sees only Catra here, between her arms.

Catra, who is squinting up at Adora with a look of outrage, a hand raised to shield one of her eyes from some great light.

Adora blinks. Wait. What great light…?

It's only then that Adora realizes that she's taller than usual. Somehow, during her attempt to vanquish Chasm, Adora must have accidentally transformed into She-Ra. And now she's glowing, glowing too brightly. Glowing brightly enough to yank Catra from sleep, rendering her unwillingly awake and half-blinded by star-like levels of light.

"Sorry," Adora murmurs, and immediately detransforms. The light fades to nothing as she sinks back into her normal self. "I didn't mean to."

"What do you mean, *you didn't mean to*?" Catra demands, sounding relieved to finally lower her hand. "What exactly were you trying to do, this late at night?"

For a long while, Adora doesn't answer. Which only makes Catra more curious and bewildered.

"Adora," Catra says warningly. "Can you please just tell me so I can get back to sleep? I won't be able to otherwise."

Adora sighs. And then, finally, she admits: "I was talking to Chasm."

All grogginess fades from Catra's features, at that. She sits up, propping herself up on her hands so that she can look at Adora more directly.

"What the hell does that mean?" Catra demands.

Adora shakes her head. "I tried meditating. And I guess if my mind's relaxed like that, she's able to open some sort of communication line between us. An illusion where we can talk to one another...but not one where she can trap me, since I'm not really asleep."

In her horror, Catra's eyes expand to the size of moons. "And you *let* her?"

“I didn’t realize what was happening, at first,” Adora protests. “And she was trying to threaten me, scare me, and I wanted to scare her back—”

“That sounds like a *really stupid* thing to try, Adora,” Catra argues. “You shouldn’t give her any amount of control over you, not for anything—”

“It wasn’t control,” says Adora, indignant. “It was just...her trying to manipulate me.”

And it sounds stupid, even to Adora’s ears. Because *obviously* that’s another form of control, even if Adora didn’t quite grasp that in the moment—

“And so you turned into She-Ra?” Catra asks in disbelief. “To fight her, despite it being an illusion?”

“Well…” begins Adora. “I told her our plan. And—”

“You *what*?” Catra screeches.

“To threaten her,” Adora insists. “And besides, it’s not like she doesn’t already know, with Chasm being in my head and all—”

Catra rolls her eyes. “Still—”

“And then she told me that, if that’s our plan, I should be able to vanquish Chasm from my own mind in the same way. In the same way I did to Horde Prime. She said the bond between bodies she’s possessed and those she’s infected is the same. So that’s what I was trying when I...y’know. Got all glowy. I was trying to get rid of her for good.”

Catra stares, silent and appraising, for several moments. She’s rendered frozen by the new information, and it’s clear to Adora that her mind is hurtling at highest momentum—full attention devoted to dissecting and examining each of Adora’s words, and Chasm’s by extension.

And eventually, with a hesitant sort of excitement, Catra asks, "And did it work? Did you get rid of her?"

Adora shakes her head, disappointment spilling across her features—twisting her mouth and knitting her eyebrows together. "She was just making a point, I think," Adora mutters. "She wanted to prove that what we're planning...it's not going to work. And that she's not even worried."

Catra puffs out a heavy breath. "Well, I wouldn't really expect anything otherwise."

Adora slumps. "So that's it, huh?" she says, defeated. "Our one plan, out the window."

"No," refuses Catra. "That's not what I meant. Our plan might still be sound. In fact...if Chasm went this far out of her way to keep us from trying the plan, it probably means that it's a good one. All I meant is that...well...she'd never tell you anything that could be used against her. So obviously she wouldn't tell you how to kick her out of your head."

"Are you sure?" Adora asks, skeptical. "Because she seemed...she seemed so sure. So confident."

"It was an illusion, Adora," Catra reminds her. "Chasm can appear however she wants. However *confident* she wants."

But still, Adora cannot convince herself of that fact. Because really, what is the difference between someone possessed by Chasm and someone infected by her, except that Adora still has a mind to call her own? Chasm should be able to vanquished in either case, attached to her victims like she is.

So Adora merely bites her lip, trying to hold in some desperate outburst of *what if* or *maybe we should*—

But Catra is again cupping Adora's cheeks, stroking against them with her thumbs. "Promise me you won't talk to her again," she whispers. "Please."

Adora almost laughs at that. “Like I wanted to talk to her in the first place.”

But that’s when Catra shoots her a look, one that Adora isn’t entirely sure she likes. One that declares, quite plainly, that Catra thinks Adora is lying. That she thinks Adora *wanted* to have that conversation, that she *wanted* to discuss those awful things with Chasm, and have herself tricked so completely—

“Alright,” says Catra, finally. She places both hands at Adora’s shoulders, shoving her down just slightly. “Now settle back down, dummy, and let me get some sleep.”

Nodding, Adora repositions herself on the mattress. Upright again, but still at the perfect angle for Catra to cuddle against most comfortably. And cuddle, Catra does, sinking deeply into Adora’s body with a sigh. She turns onto her side, cheek pressed against Adora’s belly.

“If she interrupts your meditation again, or whatever,” Catra grumbles as her eyes slide shut, “wake me, and I’ll tell her a few things that will wipe that confidence right off her tomato of a face —”

“Right,” Adora laughs, and scratches behind Catra’s ears—trying, desperately, to forget the way that Chasm threatened Catra, regardless of all of Catra’s bravado. “I’ll do that.”

“Goodnight, Adora,” murmurs Catra.

“Night, Catra.”

The days on their journey to Lenaria dwindle at a shockingly slow pace. It feels eternal, almost. How long they’ve spent on this ship, and how long they will continue to spend. Like the space around them is timeless, cyclic, a place where they travel in circles that carry them nowhere at all.

Adora occupies herself as best she can. For fear of another visitation from Chasm, she has again decided to avoid the bed at night, instead opting to occupy the deck. The deck, where she can call Bow over the comms, and keep herself distracted by conversation. Catra even pretends to not be bothered by Adora's voice, late at night. Though Adora suspects she is just as frightened by Chasm's "conversation" with Adora, and is just as wary of letting it happen again.

It's an uneventful journey. The ship keeps going, the stars keep sprinting past, and Adora stays awake throughout each night, her eyelids weighing heavier with every passing second.

It's uneventful, at least, until they receive a frantic comm from Bow.

"Uh, guys?" comes Bow's voice, from a hologram projected from the ship's main console. "We've got a problem."

And of course *that* gets their attention, worried as they are about the situation back home. Catra and Adora crowd themselves around Bow's holograph, eyes wide and breath held as they await bad news—another person losing themselves in Chasm's grip, perhaps, their mind destroyed and their body fully possessed by Chasm. Or maybe there's insufficient potion to distribute to everyone who needs it—

"Chasm just arrived on Lenaria," Bow says. "But her signal...it's cut out. She's disabled the navigational systems."

"Oh," Adora and Catra breathe, simultaneously. They were expecting a far worse update than that.

"If we already know she's on Lenaria," Catra says with a shrug, "then really, there's no problem. We'll just track her down there, same as planned."

"No," says Bow, almost panicked by their nonchalance. "That's still a problem. A very big problem, because Lenaria is *huge.* And with

the navigational systems disabled, I won't be able to pinpoint where she's landed."

Again, Catra shrugs. "Still, I think we'll be okay. The planet is devoid of life, right? We'll just scan the surface for living organisms, and that should basically lead us right to Chasm's doorstep."

Bow gives a grunt. "I still don't like it," he says, over the comm. "If she's turning off tracking, she must be planning something. A trap—"

"Or she's desperate," says Catra, crossing her arms, "and just doing whatever she can to throw us off her scent."

"Still," says Bow. "Be on your guard. How much longer until you arrive?"

"Another full day and a half," says Adora, the number basically memorized, she has been counting it down so desperately.

Bow's brows pull together. "Then she'll have lots of time to prepare—to set traps—even if the tracking isn't a part of it. I'd expect trouble, if I were you. Lots of it."

Catra only smirks. "Do we ever expect anything else?"

Once landed upon the barren stretch of soil called *Lenaria*, Chasm uses her bodies to collect supplies from the cargo hold.

It's a punishing environment out there, by all appearances. And mortal bodies have such an obnoxious number of needs—food, water, shelter. It is a fortunate thing that Adora and Catra loaded this ship with such abundant supplies. Suitable sustenance for a romantic getaway, Chasm thinks with a derisive scoff. And now yet another tool to keep Chasm's plans in motion.

Though for the time being, the plan is merely to *wait*. Wait...and hope to be followed, when the time is right. When the pieces have

fallen into place.

Though she cannot wait here. Here, she can be found. Not by Adora, perhaps. But by *her*. The one person in the universe who can help Chasm...as well as the one person who poses Chasm the greatest risk.

So Chasm leads her bodies out into the world. Far from the ship, as far as these mortal legs will carry her.

She can feel the magic of this place, pulsing in the distance. A transplanted magical heart, of sorts. One that advertises—and attracts—magic of great, ancient power.

Magic is magnetic, in a way. Sources of great magic draw other sources of great magic. Even as she walks, Chasm can feel it tugging at her, begging her to investigate. Begging her to find that magic, and take it for herself.

Though Chasm knows better than to follow. She knows what waits there, alongside that magic. *Who* waits there. And she can't risk revealing herself too soon, no matter how desperate she is to know, to *learn*, to demand answers. Chasm would hardly be welcomed in that place, and she can't step foot into that tower until she knows more—

Adora, on the other hand…

Why would Chasm confront the magic of this world...when Adora could simply do it for her?

Chapter End Notes

PLEASE LEAVE ME COMMENTS IM ACTUALLY BEGGING Y'ALL NOW

Chapter 12

Chapter Summary

Catra gets a new outfit.

Adora tries to find something.

And She-Ra punches a mountain.

Chapter Notes

hey y'all! welcome to another chapter!

first off, I'd like to thank everyone for getting anachronism to 3k kudos! that's wild and i've never had a fic with that many kudos before so thank you. I'd also like to thank everyone for the comments last week, it helped me through a shitty day where I was feeling very depressed about my writing. I'd love if we could keep up that level of comments for this chapter as well!

so now things are getting v plotty (as if they weren't plotty already) so buckle in for some *events* in this chapter! i didn't have time to draw anything...but i hope someone out there will draw something from this chapter. I won't spoil what scene i hope gets drawn but...you'll read it soon enough.

Anyway, hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"*Attention*," blares the ship. "*We will be in orbit of planet Lenaria in five minutes. Prepare to emerge from hyperspace*."

After a single shared glance, Adora and Catra plop themselves into the pilots' seats, strapping themselves in for the ride. Adora

drums her fingers against the arm of the chair, counting the moments until finally, *finally*, they'll arrive at Lenaria.

Lenaria...where Chasm is hiding.

Adora gasps when the ship finally lurches, slowing itself down, the stars streaking like wind-blown ribbons outside the hull, rather than sparks utterly *shooting* across their vision. And then, after the ship continues to lurch and slow and drag itself to a manageable speed, the stars outside settle themselves into stable dots, rather than movement-blurred lines.

And there, directly in front of them, is the planet Lenaria.

At first glance, it's not much to look at. A sphere of barren brown rock, as far as Adora can tell, with no oceans or greenery or ice to claim. Just rock, empty rock everywhere, sun-scorched by a too-clear atmosphere and a nearby star.

"Let's start scanning the surface," says Adora. "Figure out where Chasm went."

Nodding, Catra begins pressing buttons on the console, calibrating the ship's sensors to detect signs of life. The chemical byproducts of respiration, or out-of-place heat signatures. Adora keeps her eyes fixated on the planet itself all the while, studying it as though she might spot Chasm from this distance. But obviously that's impossible from literally thousands upon thousands of feet above.

Though when Adora hears feedback from the console—namely, a resistant beep of some kind—she turns her eyes back to Catra with a confused, "Something wrong?"

Catra glances up at the planet, face slackened by bewilderment, and then back down at the console.

"Looks like there's some sort of planetary interference," says Catra. "I can't detect anything. Not even atmospheric makeup. It's basically frying all our sensors—"

Adora exhales sharply. “You don’t think Chasm…?”

Catra shakes her head. “I don’t know. It seems like a lot of work to cast a spell that messes with everything in orbit—even for her.”

Adora’s eyebrows climb toward her forehead. “So you think it’s the planet *itself* causing this?”

Catra shrugs. “Dunno. But without the tracking on Chasm’s ship, we’re pretty much screwed in terms of tracking her down. Maybe that’s why she went here. Because the planet would hide her presence.”

Shaking her head, Adora says, “Yeah, but so would a planet full of life. Not to mention that she’d have a lot more potential hosts.” She turns back to the planet; scrutinizes that rocky, jagged surface. “So why here, of all places? Why this empty planet?”

“Maybe it reminds her of her last home,” Catra grumbles, with just the barest edge of humor in her voice. “If that landscape is anything to go by, it looks a lot like the plane between worlds.”

“Well,” says Adora, shifting in her seat. “We don’t have any other options, and I don’t have enough potion to waste more time. Let’s land. And hope we get lucky and stumble across her.”

Catra gives a frustrated puff of air. “I don’t like this.”

But nonetheless, she punches her fist against the button—the one that will push them past the planet’s atmosphere, and allow them to start the landing process. Adora continues to tap her foot impatiently as they angle down and down further, the ground looming larger and more detailed with every roar of the rockets.

And then, finally, their speed relents, and the ship rights itself—the floor flattening beneath Adora’s feet. Anti-gravity technology keeps the ship hovering just above the rocky terrain outside. Hovering, at least, until Catra turns off the engines.

With a short jolt, the ship drops to full landing position. Perched on the rock, landing stilts embedded deep into the ground.

Catra then looks at Adora. "What do we do?" she asks. "I can't detect whether the atmosphere is safe."

"I could turn into She-Ra?" Adora offers. "She can survive in any atmosphere. Or no atmosphere at all, really."

Catra shakes her head. "If your exhaustion interferes with your transformation, you could fall back to your usual form and end up breathing poisoned air. We shouldn't risk it."

Another uneasy sigh blusters past Adora's lips. "Then I guess we'll wear suits, for the time being."

"But if the atmosphere really *is* bad, and Chasm so much as nicks one of our suits—"

"Then we won't give her the chance," replies Adora, already unbuckling herself from her seat. Her footsteps are determined and eager as she marches toward the nearby cargo hold, where their spacesuits are held. She glances at Catra behind herself and gestures with her eyes to the door, beckoning Catra forward.

Catra is still grumbling when she, too, unbuckles herself and joins Adora where she stands. It's only when they're standing side by side that Adora slides open the door. The light flickers on automatically, revealing the full inventory of the ship's emergency supplies.

Adora makes a noise of displeasure when she sees them: the suits, haphazardly hung over a pile of spare parts. They're not Catra and Adora's usual space gear. Those other suits—which were personalized for them by Entrapta, and therefore constructed to be both stylish and durable—are still trapped aboard Chasm's ship, with the rest of their favorite belongings.

These suits, on the other hand, are exceedingly puffy, and likely too big for Catra to even move in comfortably. Worse, they appear

to be covered in some harsh metallic sheen, one that reflects light like a mirror. It's gaudy and hideous and just so damn *bright*.

Adora has never cared much about fashion or colors. But suddenly, she finds herself wishing desperately for the matte purple metal that Entrapta uses to construct her suits. These ones are very clearly meant for emergency situations only, where being spotted would be a key factor in a stranded person's survival.

"So much for sneaking up on Chasm," Catra mutters. "She'll see us from a mile away."

Adora's scoff of agreement is quickly swallowed by the hollow stretching of metal sheets and the crinkling of metal-coated, fabric joints. Pulling on the suits is a veritable chore, one that takes more valuable time than Adora is comfortable with.

Catra finishes sealing Adora's suit, and then Adora returns the favor—securing their oxygen tanks and checking the integrity of the various seams across the suit. The last step before tugging on their helmets is placing a connected set of communicators into their ears, so that they can speak to one another if the atmosphere cannot carry sound.

Finally, with the helmets in place, they are both fully dressed and protected against any breed of poisonous air. Though Adora cannot help but bite her lip at the sight of Catra positively *swimming* in her suit, blue-yellow eyes just barely high enough to peer through the helmet's glass.

Though, evidently, Catra can see enough to shoot an irritated glare at Adora's barely-suppressed amusement.

"It's not funny," Catra hisses. "I can hardly see, let alone move—"

"Sorry, sorry," Adora says, despite how she struggles to stifle another giggle. "It's not funny, you're right. It's just...it *looks* funny, is all. You're so small—"

"Ugh," grunts Catra, shoving Adora out of her way. "Shut up. Let's just go down there and get this over with—"

But Adora can't help but keep giggling, especially as Catra basically *waddles* her way to the hatch, so oversized is that suit around her body. It's a struggle, even, for Catra to reach out and attempt to hit the button that unlocks the hatch. She can only swipe blindly at it since she really can't see anything below shoulder-height.

After striding over to meet her, Adora grins broadly and then, with far too much satisfaction and ease, she flicks a thumb across the button.

The hatch hisses open instantaneously.

Catra clenches her fists—enclosed in too-large gloves—at her sides. She looks at Adora, releases a wordless hiss, and then sends herself marching down the ramp. Adora laughs quietly to herself as she follows.

It's not long before they find themselves standing on the rocky surface, boots pressing perfect imprints into otherwise undisturbed dirt. It's unsettling, even. How right Catra was about this planet's similarities to the plane between worlds. It's less *gray*, certainly, what with that bright sun in the sky, casting golden light on every available surface. But it's just as barren. Just as rocky.

Adora shivers at the thought, a strange chill going up her spine.

They walk forward, heads swiveling to examine the surrounding landscape. And of course there's nothing in sight. Nothing but distant canyons and mountains, nothing to indicate a sign of life.

And oddly enough, Adora finds herself shivering again. Shivering, in a way that she's never really felt before. Like there's some strange hand on her shoulder, or cord tied around her stomach, resting against the base of her spine. Tugging, pushing her forward.

And the more she examines it…the more she realizes that it's *not* a cold feeling. Not like she originally thought. It's something quite the opposite. Something that burns through her spine in the same way that cold might. Sharply. Bitingly. Sinking deeper than a surface burn, and embedding itself beneath her skin. Warmth mistaken for cold simply because of its intensity, and the way it seems to *push* and *pull* against Adora's body.

So, not a chill but...a spark of heat. The low simmer of a flame, one that tugs Adora forward, inexorably. Like there's a specific path forward it wants her to follow, one that will lead her to even greater warmth.

But that doesn't make sense. Not unless it's Chasm's doing. Chasm, trying to maneuver Adora into a trap.

"So what now?" Catra asks. "We just walk the surface of the whole planet in the hope we find her?"

Adora squints as that strange *heat* guides her vision, focusing it on some distant, specific point. Some valley, it seems like, one bordered by thick walls of rock. Though she can't see anything else, can't identify any reason why she might be drawn there.

Catra catches Adora staring and her eyes narrow in concern. "What's wrong?"

If this feeling is Chasm's doing, it will most definitely lead them into a trap. But then again, as dangerous as a trap might be, triggering one might be their only means of actually finding Chasm. Their other options are slim, what with their tracking and scanners disabled.

And that's what they want, isn't it? To find Chasm at any cost?

But this warmth...Adora thinks it doesn't *feel* like Chasm. It's not that looming, threatening presence that Chasm creates, like a pair of cruel eyes watching from within Adora's own head. It's something else. Something powerful, she thinks, something primal.

Something *magic*.

Adora keeps scrutinizing that distant point on the horizon. "Let's get back on the ship," Adora says, "and fly in *that* direction."

"What?" asks Catra, utterly confused as she follows Adora's gaze, and grows perplexed when she finds nothing worth pursuing. "Why?"

Adora searches for a reason that won't sound crazy.

"I don't know," Adora says, finally. Her body shifts uncomfortably within her suit. "I just have a feeling."

"A feeling?" Catra scoffs, like it's not enough.

And it's a familiar feeling too, Adora realizes. That warmth. That heat. Though normally it comes from *within* Adora. Pulled from some place deep inside her. Pulled, to summon She-Ra.

But here, it surrounds her. Suffusing the path in front of her, leading her forward like she's attached to a string, one tied and tugged.

"Magic," Adora says. "I feel magic, in that direction."

"Magic?" echoes Catra. "Like...Chasm?"

Adora shakes her head. "It's magic but…I don't think it's her. If she felt like this, like this raw magical power…" Another head shake. "I would've noticed it before. Sensed it, in the plane between worlds, after I woke up. This is something different." She gulps. "This magic...I think it might be *why* Chasm is here."

And that, finally, seems to be sufficient reason to convince Catra. "Alright," she says, struggling to turn herself around in that too-large suit. "Let's check it out, then."

Catra begins climbing the ramp, evidently expecting Adora to follow her, but Adora reaches out and catches her arm. "Wait," she

calls. “I need to be out here, so I can feel where it’s coming from. I couldn’t feel it from inside the ship.”

Catra raises an eyebrow. “What? Are you gonna run to keep up with the ship? Because, hate to tell you this, Adora...but you’re not fast enough to do that.”

Adora rolls her eyes. “Of course not,” she says, then holds out an elbow—where a set of electromagnets are installed, placed there to help spacefarers cling to their ship while making emergency repairs. “The hull’s as good a place as any to sit.”

Catra’s eyes widen. “You’re out of your mind.”

Smirking, Adora says, “Just fly low and slow. Oh—and make sure you don’t hit anything. You might end up hitting me too.”

She releases Catra’s arm. Without even bothering to argue—but most definitely grumbling incredulous complaints into the communicator—Catra scurries up the ramp.

Or really, she scurries the best she can, in that loose behemoth of a suit.

The roar of the wind is near-deafening through Adora’s microphone, but somehow Adora still manages to respond to Catra’s comms.

“How’re you holding up, princess?” Catra asks. She’s flying manually, which is kind of fun, if she’s being honest—weaving between canyons and enormous rock formations and mountains as she attempts to cling close to the ground, as Adora requested. Though it’s a lot less fun knowing that one wrong swerve could utterly *crush* Catra’s wife.

Truly, this might be one of Adora’s stupidest ideas yet.

“*Well enough, I guess!*” she hears Adora yell back, evidently trying to be heard over the wind that thunders in her ears.

Catra glances out of the ship's window to see Adora's back pressed into the hull, electromagnets clinging to the metal for dear life. Still there, same as she has been for the last ten minutes or so. But Catra still worries that *something* will swoop out of nowhere and yank her from the ship's flank.

"Should I keep going on this trajectory, or start trying to make some turns?" Catra asks, nervous that they're somehow losing their way.

A pause, as Adora contemplates. She's likely watching the horizon, trying to feel if they're in the right place, and headed in the right direction.

"*Bear—right!*" Adora calls, enunciating each word so that Catra can hear it clearly. Catra's hands at the controls are deft and ready. She swerves, just barely—not enough to cause Adora to fly off, not in the least. But still, she turns, and now their ship is pointed at something worth noting. A cliff of some sort, the sharp, jagged face of the tallest mountain in view.

"*There*!" Catra hears Adora call, through the communicator. "*I think that's where it's coming from*!"

Catra squints at the cliff. Though it's more interesting than the rest of the terrain, it doesn't seem to boast any evident magical properties. As far as Catra can tell from this distance, it just looks like more rock, same as any other.

"If you say so, princess," mutters Catra, knowing better than to question Adora wherever magic mumbo-jumbo is concerned. She simply keeps the cliff within her sights as she drops more pressure on the accelerator. Not too much, of course, with Adora attached to the hull. But enough to speed their sluggish-seeming approach.

Soon enough, the cliff is directly in front of them, and Catra is forced to let up on their momentum. She slows the ship, hovering and circling for a place to land. It's a steep mountain, one more suitable for climbing than hiking. It takes far too long for Catra to

locate a ledge large enough to accommodate the breadth of the ship. A place to land, if nothing else.

As soon as the ship is set down, Catra rushes out to help Adora—though she arrives a bit too late, slowed down by her efforts to put her suit back on. By the time she emerges, Adora is already wrenching herself from the hull and shrieking toward the ground. She lands in a thick clump of rock and red dust, dust that flies into the air like debris after a meteor strike.

"*Shit*," Catra exclaims as she rushes to Adora's side. "Why the hell didn't you wait?"

Luckily, Adora seems more-or-less fine. "Sorry," she breathes, then scrambles to her feet, head swiveling from side to side. She nearly knocks Catra over with her desperation to keep going, keep *searching*. "It's just that...the magic. It's so close. We're practically standing on top of it—"

"Okay, well," Catra says, struggling to keep up with Adora as she walks forward—finding herself face-to-face with the steep cliff face. "Finding the magic isn't really our biggest priority here. I mean, it would be nice. But remember—we're looking for Chasm first and foremost."

Adora nods and hums her agreement, but doesn't acknowledge Catra's words more than that. She places her hands on a set of rocks in front of her, as though testing to see if they'll support her weight.

"Adora?" Catra asks. "What are you doing?

"There's no way we'll climb over this thing. Not in these suits," Adora murmurs, seemingly to herself. "But we need to find a cave or a crack or *something*—"

Catra gapes at her in shocked outrage. "Adora, *what* are you even talking about?"

“The magic, Catra. I think it’s on the other side. Just beyond this wall.”

“And your plan is to have us climb until we miraculously find a crack or a cave to lead us inside?” Catra demands.

Adora doesn’t answer. She just continues staring at the cliff.

“Sure,” Catra scoffs. “When I’m not in this ogre suit, I’d be down to climb anything. But I can’t climb a ladder in this damn thing, let alone try rock-climbing—”

Adora sighs and clenches a fist. Carefully, she knocks it against the wall of rock. And Catra is surprised to discover that it’s hollow-sounding, that knocking. Like the space beyond the wall is empty.

“Then I’ll have to try an alternative,” Adora mutters.

And really, Catra should have realized what was happening before it was too late.

Because a moment later, in a blink of an eye and a flash of golden light, it is not Adora there, wearing that metallic spacesuit—but She-ra, in her pristine white uniform with golden accents. She-Ra, crying out, raising a fist and thrusting it into the stone wall ahead of them. She-Ra, backing up and conjuring a shield to protect Catra as rocks rain down from the sky, the wall collapsing and crumbling like a sandcastle blown apart by a hurricane.

Catra closes her eyes as stinging dust rises in a heavy mist all around them. She doesn’t open them for a long time. Not until rocks cease to fall with heavy clatters and thunderous rumbles.

There’s silence, save the hiss of dust.

And when Catra finally opens her eyes, it seems that She-Ra is gone, disappeared just as quickly as she arrived. It’s Adora there again, beside Catra. Adora, still holding her conjured weapon—that shield—but once again wearing that hideous spacesuit.

Adora glances around to confirm that it's safe, lowering the shield only when she's sure that the rocks are still and stable.

When she does, Catra makes a horrified sound and gives Adora a hard poke in the chest.

"A little *warning* would have been nice!" hisses Catra, in awe that Adora would even *attempt* to do such a thing without asking first.

"Sorry, sorry!" Adora apology is frantic as she dematerializes the shield. "I wasn't...I wasn't really thinking, I guess. I just *knew* I had to get past that wall. Get past, no matter what."

"Seriously, Adora," Catra demands. "What has gotten into you? You're acting really, really weird, and frankly?" Catra sighs deeply. "You're scaring me. Scaring me more than the stuff with Chasm does."

At that, Adora freezes. She turns to Catra with a look of utmost guilt—and Catra automatically knows that Adora hasn't meant to scare Catra. She's just so caught up in...*whatever this is* that she's lost nearly all regard for most other things. And to be fair, Adora made it her first priority to protect Catra when the rocks started falling.

But still. Catra doesn't appreciate being kept out of the loop. Or being forced to follow without a proper explanation.

"I'm sorry," Adora says, more seriously. "I should've told you. And we should be moving slower, at a more cautious pace. It's just that…" She makes a frustrated whine of a sound. "The closer this thing gets, the more I *need* to know what it is. I can't explain it. There's a pull, one unlike anything I've ever felt before."

Catra exhales deeply. "It's...it's okay. It's just...you're making me feel sort of dragged along here. So a little more explanation before you *smash* things would be appreciated."

Adora nods. "Yeah, of course. Sorry again."

Catra places her hand on Adora's shoulder. "Like I said. It's okay. Just...slow down a little."

Adora is nodding again, and just as Catra musters a small, forgiving smile, she notices something strange just beyond Adora's shoulders. A colorful glow of some kind, one that wavers and pulses through the mist of dust, painting the air itself in pale blue.

It's coming from within the hole She-Ra punched, Catra realizes. A light beyond the stone wall, enclosed within some sort of hidden cavern.

It's not long before Adora notices Catra staring and turns to follow her line of sight. She gasps as she spots that pulsing blue light.

"That must be it!" she exclaims. She looks directly at Catra when she asks, "You good to go in?"

Catra nods. "See. That is a *proper* discussion about our plans."

She lets Adora take her hand and guide her forward, into the dark opening torn open by She-Ra's fist. It's a little difficult to keep up with Adora downright *sprinting* toward that blue light, and moving isn't exactly easy in this stupid suit. Not to mention that there are still rocks for Catra to trip over, if she's not careful.

But nothing in the universe seems capable of slowing Adora down, not now. The blue light is deeper within the cliff than Catra thought possible, at the end of some lengthy stone corridor that seems to continue forever.

Though that seemingly-infinite corridor is no match for Adora's eager, almost desperate speed. Catra is dragged along until the light looms larger and larger until it's *everything*, all over every wall and inch of ground, suffusing everything in its glow.

Catra is forced to shield an eye with her hand, it is so bright. She can't see what lies ahead—can't see what is producing the light. And there's a sound...some sort of humming. Waves and waves of energy vibrating the pebbles beneath their feet.

But Adora doesn't seem bothered by the brightness. She stares directly ahead, her jaw hanging open in surprise.

"What is it?" whispers Catra, still unable to see.

"It's some sort of...wall," whispers Adora. "A wall, made of pure magic. It's so bright, Catra—"

"Then *maybe* you shouldn't look directly at it?" suggests Catra, muttering while she still struggles to even turn her face in the direction of that bright glare. Though Adora doesn't appear to hear her—

"Wait!" says Adora, looking down. "There's something here, just in front of it."

Adora stumbles forward, toward whatever it is she's seen, and crouches down in the dirt.

Catra is relieved to direct her eyes down, where the light isn't quite so blinding. Though she doesn't understand why Adora is so excited by this *thing* on the floor. It doesn't look like much, from what Catra can tell. A typical crack in the rock floor.

"This is a symbol," Adora insists.

"What do you mean?" says Catra, kneeling down beside her. It looks just like some cracks, as far as Catra can tell. Sure, it's a little geometric-looking, with some lines and circles that could *maybe* give the impression of belonging to a written symbol. But it looks just as much like an accidental crack—one born of age and wear upon the stone—as it does some piece of script.

Adora shakes her head. "No," she says. "I know this one. It says something. A word—"

Catra blinks hard. A word?

Wait...if this symbol is, in fact, a word...a word that only Adora can read, while looking like nonsense to everyone else…

Then that could only mean—

"This word means *lock*," Adora whispers reverently as her fingers trace the cracks in the stone. "A lock...to go with this barrier. And if it really is what it says—"

Catra can only watch, dumbstruck and silent, as Adora traces a new symbol beside the existing one, her finger dragging fresh lines through the dirt. Catra doesn't recognize the symbol she's carving either. But she has a good enough guess at what it means —

Adora finishes her drawing with a small flourish—a final dot, pressed into the ground with a thumb.

"There," says Adora, with a satisfied smile at Catra. "*Lock*, meet *key*."

At first, nothing happens. They merely sit, crouched on the ground, waiting for something to change with Adora growing more disappointed-looking with every passing second, eyebrows pulling together as her hope diminishes, bit by bit—

"Maybe it wasn't a symbol, after all," Catra says, with what she hopes appears to be a carefree shrug. "Maybe it was just a crack, naturally formed—"

But that's when the blue light begins to *flicker*. It flickers once, twice and then…

The light—the wall—glows so brightly that Catra and Adora must both shut their eyes. It's brighter than anything they've seen before, just pure light at its absolute brightest, bright as a star, bright enough that Catra can see it through her eyelids, turning her vision to pale pink—

And then, just like that…it's *gone*. As far as Catra can tell with her eyes closed, the light has been entirely extinguished, her eyelids trapping nothing but darkness.

She hears Adora gasp.

“Uh...Catra?” Adora whispers directly into Catra’s ear. A hand—presumably Adora’s—grasps at her arm. “We’ve got a problem.”

Catra squints open one eye, hesitant.

Only to see the light replaced with a squadron of heavily-armored soldiers, glowing weapons poised directly at Catra and Adora’s bodies—and the suits that protect them from a potentially poisonous atmosphere.

Chapter End Notes

Don't we all love a good cliffhanger? Good times

Also if no one draws annoyed Catra in the oversized spacesuit I will be heartbroken

PLEASE REMEMBER TO COMMENT AND/OR KUDOS

Chapter 13

Chapter Summary

Adora gets shoved against a wall.

A surprising discovery is made.

And Catra makes a deal.

Chapter Notes

hey all. some kinda sad but hopefully not too sad news. this fic is going to go on hiatus for the month of april. i hope y'all can forgive me for this, but i've been too busy between work and school to properly edit the parts of the fic not yet posted. I need more time to ensure that the story i'm delivering is the best it can possibly be.

also i hope you can trust that i WILL be back. the fic is finished, it just needs some sections rewritten. im hoping to start posting again on Saturday, May 1st.

anyway, please enjoy tonight's chapter. since the comments for this chapter will probably be all the ones i get for a while...i'd really appreciate if you could leave a bunch.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Surrender yourselves!” barks one soldier as they shove some sort of glowing sword into Adora’s face.

At first, Adora panics. Are these the now-dead Bright Moon guards that they’ve been chasing? The ones controlled by Chasm?

But no...their armor—it’s different from the white-and-purple armor that the Bright Moon guards are required to wear. Instead, this armor is constructed from what appears to be a silvery-blue metal. Metal that gleams in the same way a gemstone might.

And more importantly, Adora doesn't recognize a single face among the group. These faces, half-enclosed in simple metal helmets—they all belong to strangers.

Adora is still too bewildered to fight back, or properly fear for her life despite the sharp, likely searing sword's edge that hovers so close, threatening to tear holes in her spacesuit. The suit that acts as the only barrier between Adora and a potentially deadly atmosphere.

Adora, at least, could turn into She-Ra to survive even the most punishing environments. But Catra might not have the same luck, should these soldiers prove willing to attack—

Though the soldiers aren't wearing any sort of protective gear besides their armor. There are no breathing tanks, no heavy-duty helmets to protect their faces or lungs. And they look similar, these soldiers, to the humanoids back on Etheria. So could that mean that the air is safe to breathe?

But a far more intrusive thought invades Adora's mind. Because, really, the atmosphere doesn't matter, not in the grand scheme of things. The fact that there are people here at all presents a terrible problem. If Adora comes into contact with anyone, anyone at all besides Catra, Chasm will spread. And keep spreading throughout the galaxy—

No. But this planet was supposed to be empty, completely empty —

From her periphery, Adora can see Catra throwing up her hands in a gesture of surrender.

"We don't want trouble," Catra says calmly, hands still raised. "We're just...explorers. Trying to see what Horde Prime left behind, after he destroyed this planet."

Not a lie, but not the whole truth either. Catra knows better than to reveal too much about themselves to potential threats. If they can surprise these attackers with She-Ra, all the better.

Catra nudges Adora to surrender, and quickly she does—mimicking Catra's posture of raised hands. Though she doesn't want to surrender to a group of strangers without knowing more about who, exactly, she is surrendering to—

"W-who are you?" Adora stammers. "I don't understand—"

"Who *we* are doesn't matter," snarls the soldier, the same one that ordered them to surrender in the first place.

As Catra and Adora stand with their hands raised, the rest of the squadron fans out and surrounds them. The weapons remain perfectly held and balanced as they move, the sword tips poised and aimed at the most vulnerable points in Adora and Catra's suits.

The same soldier—some sort of officer, Adora thinks, judging by the ornate armor adorned with medals—grabs Adora by the back of her suit and yanks her from Catra's side. Roughly, they shove Adora against the nearest wall and bind Adora's hands behind her, eliciting a pained grunt.

"Adora!" Catra calls, and Adora can tell from her tone of voice that she's prepared to fight—claws likely itching to emerge from their sheaths.

Adora does her best to crane her neck. She searches for Catra's face behind her, and for the briefest moment, they make eye contact. Adora's gaze is pointed, pleading. A nonverbal urge for Catra to stand down despite the way Catra's fists clench at her side. Adora can't risk Catra tearing her suit, no matter how breathable the air might seem—

And Catra does, to Adora's relief. She stands down, fists unfurling at her sides and shoulders slumping in forced calmness.

"The question is...who are *you*?" the soldier demands, grinding Adora's helmet into the sharp, rugged wall at her front. "And how did you manage to open the gateway?"

“My name is Adora,” she manages, and jerks her head in Catra’s direction. “And that’s Catra. We’re just travelers, like she said.”

The soldier hums like they don’t believe her.

“Your friend said you were *explorers*,” the soldier emphasizes. “Not travelers.”

Shit, Adora thinks.

The soldier digs their elbow into Adora’s back, further compressing Adora between the metal plates of her suit. “And more importantly...you didn’t answer the second question.”

“Ack, I don’t know!” grunts Adora, and truly, with any more pressure, Adora’s oxygen tank might burst. “I mean...it wasn’t exactly hard. The thing said *lock*, so I guess it just made sense to write *key—”*

The soldier exhales sharply. “You can read *and* write the language?”

The grip on Adora’s wrists tightens.

“Keep that one here,” says the soldier, gesturing to Catra with an elbow, as she yanks Adora from the wall. “I’m bringing this one to the city for interrogation.”

“City?” repeats Catra. “What city?”

Adora, meanwhile, only hears one thing: that these soldiers intend to separate them. That they intend to keep Catra here while Adora is whisked off to some distant, mysterious place. “Wait—” she gasps, tugging at the soldier’s stiff grasp. “You *don’t* want to do that.”

The soldier just scoffs and looks to another member of their squadron. “Someone help me take off these stupid helmets. I want the ability to shut them up, if necessary.”

From the edge of Adora's vision, she sees soldiers reach for Catra's suit, clearly intending to tear the helmet from its seal—

"No!" shrieks Adora, and she feels magic surge within her veins, swelling in a protective fury and sparking her blood aflame. "Don't *touch* her!"

She feels herself growing. Growing in size, in power. Her muscles coil, her legs expand, and there's magic, magic everywhere. Radiating from every pore and breath from her lungs. Her skin burns so bright that even she can hardly handle the glare.

She tears her wrists from the soldier's grasp, breaking the hold like it's floss that binds her, rather than living hands. And just as quickly, she's shifted the positions—instead shoving the soldier against the wall, held in a truly unbreakable grip. The soldier gives a high cry as their cheek hits stone.

"I don't want to hurt you," Adora grits out. "But if you hurt us first, I won't have much of a choice—"

She glances back, at the other soldiers. Trying to ensure that Catra is okay. But while Catra appears totally fine—impressed, even, by Adora's protectiveness—the soldiers are staring like they've been slapped clear across their faces. Staring open-mouthed at She-Ra, as if she is the ghost of someone long-dead has returned to them.

"It…" one soldier flounders. "It can't be—"

"She-Ra…" one of them whispers, awed. "But how—?"

"Who are you people?" Adora demands, releasing the soldier who attacked her. She shoves them forward and points her sword at their back. "And I suggest you answer me—*without* picking another fight you won't win."

The soldier is sent stumbling from the force of She-Ra's shove—but only for a moment. They quickly catch themselves, their weight well-distributed between their front and back feet, with

arms outstretched to retain balance. The posture of someone practiced in combat, Adora thinks. Not some poorly-trained lackey.

The soldier makes a sound. Some sort of scoff, but far more disbelieving.

"Don't worry," the soldier chuckles. "I'm not foolish enough to pick a fight with *She-Ra*, of all people."

There's no real humor or admiration in the words, Adora notes. Only derision.

"So you've heard of me," says Adora. With her other hand, she gestures for Catra to join her. Catra takes far too much satisfaction in sidestepping the guards—irrepressibly smug as she quite literally *leaps* over their lowered weapons to reach Adora's side.

"Of course I've heard of you," says the soldier that Adora just shoved. They turn around slowly, smiling icily as they face Adora directly. "My people *made* you, didn't they? Not that you repaid them kindly for it."

Adora's eyes widen, and the grip on her sword just barely wavers. "What did you just say?"

"You are mighty brave to return here," the soldier glowers, "after you abandoned us for over a thousand years. Abandoned us when we needed you most—"

"What do you mean, here?" Adora interrupts, free hand flinging out to her side. "What is this place? And what did you mean when you said that—that your people *made* me?"

The soldier stares wordlessly for several moments. And then, finally—

"You really don't know?" the soldier asks, stunned. She stares so expectantly at Adora's—or rather, She-Ra's face—that Adora finds herself shifting uncomfortably. The soldier speaks as though Adora

should know, as though it should be obvious. But it's not. As far as Adora knows, this is an abandoned world. One expunged of life and left expunged ever since.

The soldier laughs in disbelief, taking Adora's silence as confirmation. "If you don't know what this place is, then how is it that you are here?"

Adora and Catra exchange a glance. A wordless discussion as to whether they should reveal their true reasons for being here, on Lenaria. Catra's hard stare tells Adora to reveal *some* key details, but not everything. They don't want to disclose information that can be used against them—especially when these soldiers still seem a far cry from trustworthy.

"We're tracking a fugitive from our homeworld," Adora explains. "She fled here, and we're simply hunting her down."

The soldier raises an eyebrow, one that's far too skeptical for Adora's liking. "And what world do you hail from?"

"Etheria," says Adora, and means it fully. She doesn't care to reveal her true origins to this person, or to anyone else. And truthfully, Adora hasn't really considered herself a First One since…

Since Adora first learned the truth about her ancestors.

The soldier laughs. Laughs, hysterically, with both arms clutching their stomach and their body doubled over.

Adora chooses to wait for them to finish, but Catra refuses to share that patience. Mere moments pass before Catra grits out, "What's so funny?" A sure sign, if any, that Catra is ready to scratch this person's eyes out.

"It's just...ha! There's no such place," the soldier says, shaking their head. "Not anymore. Not since She-Ra herself destroyed it."

What do they mean, *She-Ra destroyed Etheria*?

Recent nonsense with Chasm aside, Adora is fairly certain she *saved* Etheria. Saved it from the Horde, and freed its magic.

And yes, Adora essentially brought Chasm to Etheria—something that suffocates her with regret—but there's no way someone all the way out here, on Lenaria, could know about that. The situation on Etheria is being kept highly confidential.

So what in the *universe* is this person talking about?

"What is this place?" demands Adora again. "Who are you? If you don't start answering my questions soon, I—"

The soldier shakes her head like she still cannot believe that Adora is real, and here, and demanding questions of her.

"I am Teela," says the soldier. "Daughter of Duncan, Man-at-Arms. Captain of the Eternian Royal Guard."

That word—that single word, *Eternian*—rings like a bell within Adora's ears, reverberating within her head, within her ribcage and veins and smaller still, at the atomic level.

Eternian. That's what Teela said.

That word—*Eternian*, *Eternia*, whatever the form—has pervaded so many First One ruins and scrolls that Adora has largely learned to dismiss it. It was a place, supposedly. The texts made that clear. But the scrolls and hieroglyphics always spoke of it so distantly, like it was some strange paradise within their mythology, she didn't think it was real. Certainly not a real place, with a real populace.

But here Teela is, undeniable evidence to the contrary. A living member of the fabled *Eternians*.

"Because that's where you've finally returned, *She-Ra*," says Teela, sneering the name like one might utter a curse. "To Eternia. Or at least...what remains of it."

"I can't believe you agreed to this," Adora mutters to Catra, as they're led deeper into the cliff's tunnels. She speaks only from the corner of her mouth, half muffling her words so that only Catra can hear."We should've run away the second they told us who they are—"

"They're your people, Adora," Catra hisses back, speaking just as quietly and privately. "And Teela said they might be able to help us. Besides, aren't you at all curious—?"

"*If you come with us willingly,"* Teela offered. "*I shall take you to my superiors. I imagine they'd want to know of your return."*

Adora only scoffed in disbelief. *"And why would I agree to that?"*

"Because, in exchange, I shall help you find your fugitive," Teela said. "This planet is shielded from all searching technologies except our own. If you wish to have even a prayer of finding this fugitive of yours, you'll need our resources."

Adora opened her mouth to object, but before she could, Catra interrupted.

"*Sure, fine*," Catra said with a flap of her gloved hand. "*Take us to them. The sooner the better."*

Adora could only glare at her wife, made speechless by some arresting combination of outrage and disbelief.

Teela smiled.

"*Good*," was her reply, made while striding forward. Striding, marching, until she had walked past Adora and Catra entirely, into a nearby cave. One that must have been hidden by that blue wall of energy, now laid bare by Adora's attempt to disable it.

Just as she was about to turn a corner, Teela turned back to Catra —a small smirk creasing her lips. "*And you may remove your helmet, Etherian. The air is safe to breathe. And you'll hardly look ready to greet royalty, dressed like that."*

Royalty, Adora thought numbly. They were being taken to see royalty.

But Catra wasted no time in releasing a sigh of relief. Her hands quickly came to rest at the neck of her suit, twisting and tugging to yank the helmet off. Adora watched her warily all the while, worried that Teela might be lying. Lying, to trick Catra into suffocating.

But when the helmet came off, Catra continued breathing as normal, and has continued breathing that way since—much to Adora's relief.

Though Teela still has yet to claim even a shred of Adora's trust. Sure, the air is safe to breathe. But these *Eternians* may very well still plan to kill them in some other horrific way.

But Catra doesn't seem to share Adora's wariness, not in the least. If anything, Catra seems eager to follow Teela into the tunnel, leaving Adora with no choice but to chase after her, with the rest of the soldiers just behind.

Trapping us, Adora thinks, with a glance at those same soldiers, who remain in close pursuit. Marching obediently through the rocky terrain like each wall and turn and stumble-inducing stone is memorized and familiar.

"I can't *afford* to be curious, Catra," Adora argues, whispering. "Not only is it risky to let ourselves get led into this *super-obvious* trap...but I'm a risk to these people. I've likely already infected them with Chasm—"

Catra shakes her head. "I wouldn't be so sure," she says, and points to the back of Teela's armor, illuminated in part by She-Ra's own glow, combined with the glow of the soldiers' swords.

Adora follows Catra's finger to discover a set of symbols carved there, into the metal. Many of them are strange. Unrecognizable. Though some, at least, appear to be regular words in the First

Ones' language. The word *leader*, for instance, drawn ornately upon the metal.

A few of the more obscure ones—the ones without direct translations—suddenly return to Adora in memory. She sees one symbol she identified earlier, the one that means 'glory in battle.' It's the same as it appeared in those books she found in the library. *Symbolic Artistry of the First Ones*, *Military Conquests of Etheria's Ancients,* and the many other relevant scrolls George and Lance collected.

And then there's one that is utterly seared into her memory, she spent so long staring at it in books, scrolls, screens, surfaces, and whatever else she could get her hands on. So pervasive was this symbol throughout Etheria, and the universe itself. A set of spirals struck through with lines—

The ward against evil—against *Chasm*. Etched into the surface of Teela's armor, just like all the others.

Catra knocks She-Ra's hip with her elbow, and Adora glances down to see Catra smirking at her. "Go on. Say that you told me so."

Adora shakes her head. "I don't want to tell you *I told you so*. All I want to do is get out of here—"

Catra rolls her eyes. "You're the one who led us here, Adora—"

"I didn't know what I was leading us to," Adora tells her, frantically. "And now that I do—"

"You want to waste your one chance of learning more about your people?" Catra demands, gesturing pointedly to Teela's armor, and the symbols that adorn it.

"It's a waste of time for us to do this," Adora insists. "Chasm is still out there, somewhere. On this planet. And every second we spend with these people, she's likely gaining more ground, and everyone back on Etheria is suffering—"

“And what are we gonna do, Adora?” Catra demands as they keep walking. “I don’t have a way to find Chasm, and neither do you. This planet is too big for us to sweep on our own. Which means that if we want to find Chasm before your potion runs out, or before people on Etheria really start to hurt, this is our only option.”

Adora grumbles because...well. She hates that. She *hates* that this is their only option. They’ve wasted so many days on their journey here, and would waste many more searching the surface without the use of the ship’s scanners. They really can’t afford to waste more time, especially if there’s a faster alternative to be found.

But she doesn’t like this, either. She doesn’t like offering herself up to Teela, to be led wherever she or her so-called *superiors* please. Even if it might be Adora’s only chance to learn more about Eternia.

Frankly, Adora could do *without* the chance at all. Adora has little interest in learning more about these people. Her people, according to Catra. Adora’s people. Though it’s been years since Adora has thought about them in such a way. Beyond her research of their language (which was fuelled by her desire to protect her loved ones against Chasm more than anything else), Adora hasn’t been curious about the First Ones’ culture since many years ago, when she first discovered her own origins.

But knowledge of Etheria’s past—and Mara’s demise—cured her of that curiosity rather quickly.

“Besides,” adds Catra, beneath her breath. “If Chasm traveled here, it can only be because she wants something from them. Your people. Maybe she’ll need their help to repair the sword—”

“Or maybe,” counters Adora, “she knows that this will distract me. Throw me off her scent.”

“We’re nearly there,” calls Teela, without turning around. Catra and Adora freeze, mouths snapping shut at the interruption. “Prepare yourselves to enter our capital city—Eternos.”

And sure enough, when Adora squints, she sees daylight ahead, painting the approaching corridor gold rather than the dark red half-darkness that surrounds them now.

It’s not long until they reach it—the maw of the cave. It’s a small opening, Adora notes. The part of her brain trained by the Horde realizes that it’d be easy to defend should someone try to invade. The cave could be easily collapsed and sealed without much damage to the larger cliff, or the supposed city that lies beyond.

The light stings Adora’s eyes just a little as she ducks out from under the cave. As her eyes adjust, squinting and blinking to right themselves, she sees strange colors and shapes within her vision.

Wait—no. Those are not illusions of tired eyes, misadjusted to the light.

Those are buildings constructed of pure crystal.

All around her is some sort of...caldera? Yes, that’s the word, Adora thinks. A caldera. A deep crater scooped from the earth, its inner surface utterly covered by numerous buildings, most nestled onto the crater’s steep, circular slopes, with a few less-precariously sprung from the flat surface of the crater’s middle.

The buildings are of every shape and breed. Tiny houses, large mansions, shops and marketplaces. There are other landmarks too. Small reservoirs of gleaming, crystal-clear water, and several parks of some kind, each dotted with strange-colored vegetation that Adora cannot identify.

And there, at the center—atop the flattest plain—is the largest building of all. An intricate tangle of tall crystal spires, each nearly tall enough to rise above the highest wall of the crater. With its size and many towers, Adora can only assume that it is a building of some importance. A castle, perhaps.

A *crystal* castle, she thinks, with a bitter sort of amusement.

Though it is different from the one Adora has known, back on Etheria. The one created to house Light Hope and help in She-Ra's training. Not that the castle, or Light Hope, did Adora much good in the end.

Still, Adora finds herself breathless from the castle's lovely, almost ethereal architecture. It paints the floor of the crater in swathes of rainbow light, reflected and refracted through the castle's prismatic walls.

Though Adora notices that there's one tower unlike the rest attached to the castle. One constructed of ancient-looking gray stones, all piled and grouted atop one another, with some massive gargoyle—one shaped like a large-toothed monster skull—carved into its base. A tower whose components were clearly laid by hand, rather than magically grown or sprung from the ground, like the other crystal spires appear to be.

It's incredibly out-of-place—like a pair of muddy work boots worn alongside an elegant ball gown—but attached to the castle nonetheless. Adora can't make sense of why it's there, or what it's supposed to be used for. But she feels that same tug from before, drawing her toward the tower. And Adora knows it must be the source of that intense magic—

"Whoa," Adora hears Catra breathe.

She turns to see Catra looking up at the sky, her back bent backwards to get a better look. Curious, Adora follows her line of sight—craning her head toward the sky above...and the sight that greets her prompts Adora to release a gasp of her own.

Above the crater is a strange distortion—one that surrounds the entire city. It's like the sky is blurred, almost, by some enormous bubble hanging above their heads. A colorless film.

Adora's eyes sweep the bubble, searching for some patch of clear sky. She finds nothing. No gap in the distortion, no wavering of its

power. Though the blurriness does seem to emanate from that strange stone tower—the one attached to the castle. That's where the blurriness appears thickest, funneling from the tower's tapered roof.

"It's a spell to hide the city. One that renders us invisible to eyes and sensors alike," Teela says, having noticed Catra and Adora's joint fascination. "As well as keep the population inside our borders."

And, of course, that last part gets Adora's attention.

"And is that what you plan to do with us too?" Adora demands. "Do you plan to trap us here?"

Teela only scoffs. "What, and pick a fight with She-Ra?" she asks, clearly mocking. "Like you said. I should not pick fights I cannot win. Besides…"

Teela descends a step—the first of a long staircase, one that Adora had yet to notice, what with the beautiful landscape in front of her.

"You might have your own reasons for wanting to stay."

Adora blinks. "And what is that supposed to mean?"

Teela beckons them forward. "Follow me, and you'll find out quickly enough."

And Adora has little choice to oblige, lowering herself step by step down that enormous staircase.

"So none of you...Eternians…" Adora hesitates before saying the word, still in shock that it belongs to a group of real people from a real place, "...have left this city before?"

She-Ra's long legs allow Adora to easily keep pace with Teela, but Catra falls behind just slightly, her movements slowed by her

oversized pants—a remaining piece of the bulky suit she has yet to fully remove.

"All except one," says Teela, "but that was a long time ago. And I think they've since returned."

"I don't understand," Adora says, her eyes still sweeping the landscape in awe. "How is this place even here? All the First Ones are supposed to be gone—"

Teela releases another scoff. "First Ones?" she repeats, like the word is something foolish. "That is an old name for our kind. And hardly a true one—at least, not anymore. We called ourselves that because we thought we were the first to combine magic and technology. But there were others who came before us. And those who came before them. We are simply *Eternians* now...named after our homeworld."

Teela shoots Adora an odd glance. An appraising one.

"And you say you are Etherian, yes? Born and raised there?"

Carefully, Adora replies, "Yes."

Humming, Teela says, "Well, if Etheria is still alive and well, I can't imagine many traces of our people still remain. Though I find it strange that She-Ra's power transferred to an Etherian. According to our histories, that power could only be bestowed upon one of my people. An Eternian."

Adora shakes her head. "Your people designed a sword to trap and control She-Ra," she accuses. "A sword that I destroyed. And once it was gone, She-Ra was free to bond herself to whoever she pleases."

"And so she chose you?" Teela asks.

"She-Ra was always Etheria's champion," Adora says, and she can't help the aggression that sparks within her own voice. "The *Eternians* were the ones who tried to make her into a weapon—"

“Yes, well,” Teela interrupts, dismissive. “She certainly got her revenge on us, didn’t she? She could not defend us when we needed her.”

“And what did you expect her to defend you from?” Adora asks. “Horde Prime said he destroyed your people.”

Teela stiffens at the mention of him—Horde Prime. Though it does not dissuade Adora from asking her questions.

“How did you escape him?” Adora asks. “He said that he wiped all *Eternians*, or whatever you call yourselves— ”

“Escaped him?” Teela echoes.

She spins around to face Adora directly, forcing everyone to stop in her wake.

“Do you really think we’d be here, relegated to this barren wasteland, if we escaped him?”

Adora stares, open-mouthed. She doesn’t know what to say—mostly because she doesn’t know what Teela means. Clearly, the Eternians escaped Horde Prime, considering that they are still here—with their civilization alive. But they’ve clearly lost *something*. Lenaria hardly seems the paradise that the First Ones scrolls described when mentioning Eternia.

But that’s all Teela says as an explanation. She merely turns around and keeps descending the steps.

Chapter End Notes

> see y'all on May 1st! by then i'll be graduated and hopefully suffering less. remember to leave comments if you can!

Chapter 14

Chapter Summary

Adora asks some questions.

Teela gives some answers.

And the group has a chat with royalty.

Chapter Notes

oh boy, immemorial begins again! welcome back from the hiatus, it's been a while!

I'm literally moving apartments this weekend so I'm busy as hell, but I *should* be officially graduating this weekend if all goes to plan!

and check out the first chapter of my she-ra anniversary big bang fic, *where we wander, where we conquer*, which is a canon divergent story where catra and adora are exiled to the crimson waste together post-season 1. It includes some really rad illustrations from windbloom, so definitely give it a read

anyway, please enjoy this chapter (and the other fic, if you read it)!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"When we enter the city, expect to attract a great many stares," Teela warns. "She-Ra is well-known in our histories. And it has been thousands of years since anyone last laid eyes on her."

Catra snorts. "Psh, what else is new? She-Ra would attract stares no matter what."

Teela glances behind herself again—this time, at Catra. "And who are you, exactly, Catra of Etheria? And how have you found

yourself traveling with She-Ra?”

Catra gives a shrug, then a smirk in Adora’s direction.

“If anything, She-Ra is traveling with *me* , not the other way around,” Catra jokes. “Couldn’t stand the thought of me leaving her behind, I guess.”

Teela blinks but keeps walking. “I do not understand your meaning.”

“We’re married,” Adora explains, curtly. She doesn’t really want to explain details of her personal life to these total strangers. Strangers who may or may not be kidnapping them. “Catra is my wife.”

“Ah,” says Teela, finally understanding. She glances back at Catra with a deepening interest, then at Adora again. It’s a smirking sort of look, one that Adora can’t make sense of. And one that Adora definitely doesn’t like—especially from someone who’s practically a stranger.

They reach the final stair not long after, disembarking onto some sort of gleaming path—paved with what appears to be marble, though it’s far less slippery than Adora would have expected. It almost clings to their feet as they walk. They stand between buildings now, most of them shuttered with their yards free of pedestrians, though Adora still glances around—nervous to be seen, and judged. Teela seems to have little love for She-Ra, and Adora has a bad feeling that the rest of the populace will share that sentiment.

“Please,” Adora says, now reduced to begging Teela for answers. “I don’t know anything about the history of this place. How did you end up here, on Lenaria? Did Horde Prime drive you from your home?”

Teela sighs deeply before answering. And then, without turning around, she says, “For thousands of years, he was our greatest enemy. And for most of that time, we kept him at bay. Our

weapons were imbued with magic—something he was not equipped to defend against. But the more we crafted magic into the weapons, the more we drained the universe of that power. Most of our magic sources ran out. And when they did, Horde Prime picked off our colonies one by one. Destroying each place we had settled."

Her shoulders tense with agitation. "Etheria—the planet you claim to hail from—was supposed to be our last hope. Our last source of untapped magical potential. But it was lost to us, along with the last She-Ra. Destroyed, we were told, by She-Ra herself. And so Horde Prime descended on our last colonies until, finally, he descended on us."

Adora gulps. "And what happened when he...descended?"

"He sought to lay waste to Eternia," she says. "The real Eternia. The original one. We were able to open a portal large enough to transport our capital, Eternos, to another planet. This one. Lenaria. A colony Prime had already destroyed and would not pay further attention. We took the soil, the buildings, the water, the plants, the people…"

Her fists clench at her side.

"But we could not save our homeworld. Not entirely. Not without letting Prime know that some portion of our population had survived."

Adora can only keep walking, after that. Silent and lost. She feels as though she should express some sort of condolence for such a tragedy.

But she also recalls what happened to Melog, to Etheria, to Mara. And she remembers the destructive power of the Heart of Etheria —the irreparable damage it could wreak, the planets it could senselessly destroy—and she finds herself unable to summon the words. She knows she should, she *knows* . But what does she

really owe to these people who took so much from so many people, including Adora herself—?

And worse...Adora fears what they might still do. If what Catra said is true, and Chasm needs the Eternians' help to repair the sword, they may very well deal Adora a killing blow—

"That must have been hard," is Catra's careful reply, and Adora can sense that Catra is watching her. Watching Adora's expressions, studying her emotions. She must see and know that Adora is struggling with Teela's information.

"It is ancient history now," Teela says, shaking her head. "We make the best of what we still have. The ground we stand on is still Eternia. It has simply been…" She shrugs. "Relocated."

"He's gone now, you know," Adora murmurs, since it's the only consolation she can muster. This bond over a shared, now-defeated enemy. "Horde Prime."

Teela's eyes widen in disbelief—though she is quick to shake her head and regain her composure. The information must be new—and unexpected.

"I...I did not," she stammers. "We are not..." A sigh. "We are not *permitted* to know what happens beyond our walls."

"Well...he is," replies Adora, voice low and matter-of-fact. "He's gone. Gone for good."

There is a long pause, the sound filled with nothing but steady footsteps and the subtle shifting of metal armor. Many long minutes pass before Teela says, "I am... *glad* to hear it."

Another pause. And then, an addition—

"What took him, in the end?"

"Magic," replies Adora, and that's all she allows herself to reveal. She doesn't wish to disclose further details—the existence and

destruction of the Heart, and She-Ra's hand in Horde Prime's ultimate destruction. Adora doubts that she'd even be able to recount such events without sounding accusatory toward Teela and the rest of her people.

Because Etheria's problems all started there, didn't they? At the Heart, at the *weapon* constructed by the First Ones.

As they continue walking, they enter a few crowded city streets. Strange floating roads filled with odd machines that hover in the air, ones that remind Adora of the Horde's old skiffs. And, like any city, there are walkways filled with people. People who find themselves frozen and dumbstruck by the sight of She-Ra's towering, glowing figure—their jaws hanging open as she strides past.

They study her, and she studies them in turn. She notices that they wear plain clothes rather than the armor that Teela does—though they too have symbols drawn across the backs of their shirts. Many of these symbols vary, as far as Adora can tell—the word *scholar* , the word *healer* , and then more symbols that Adora cannot decipher. Symbols without translations, symbols likely specific to Eternian culture.

But no matter how the rest of the symbols vary...the ward against Chasm is present on the back of every shirt and bodice.

Teela notices the way Adora's head cranes, trying to read the letters scrawled across the backs of the pedestrians.

"It's a part of our culture," says Teela. "The things we deem important about ourselves—about our identity—we write upon our backs, for the world to see and appreciate."

"And what about that symbol?" Adora says, pointing to the one she knows—the ward against Chasm. "Everyone seems to wear it."

Teela nods. "The Sorceress says it wards off bad luck," she explains, just as Adora expects. "Bad luck, and bad magic. So of

course everyone wears it.”

Adora raises an eyebrow. “The Sorceress? Who’s—”

But then whispers begin to crowd Adora’s ears, wafting from the bodies that surround them on all sides. There are eyes that accompany those whispers. Hundreds of them, all boring into Adora’s skin, the fabric of her clothes, the plains of her face.

“She-Ra— ”

“It must be some sort of fake—”

“Do you really think someone could fake that height, or that glow?”

" She-Ra has returned— ”

" She-Ra!”

“So now she finally returns—?”

Adora angles her head down, battling a vicious blush as she affixes her gaze to the ground. She’s never really enjoyed the attention she receives as She-Ra, positive or otherwise. And she especially worries that the Etherians’ awe might soon be replaced by intense outrage. Teela did imply that the Eternians felt betrayed by Mara’s actions. There’s no reason to assume that Adora will remain spared from whatever mistrust lingers in Mara’s wake.

A pair of soldiers assume Catra and Adora’s flanks. Teela and a remaining soldier, meanwhile, hold the front and end of their little procession. A protective barrier, of sorts. One that Adora is suddenly grateful for, though she’d prefer to not be faced with this situation at all. She merely supposes that, if Eternians *do* choose to attack, she’d rather have some protection than none.

But she still refuses to trust Teela and her crew. Wherever they’re taking Adora and Catra...Adora suspects that trouble will follow

close behind. And even if there *isn't* trouble...Adora is sure that Chasm's capture will be inevitably delayed by this unwanted foray into Adora's homeworld. Home city. Whatever.

Adora has a fairly good guess as to where they're being led. She's only proven right when Teela points at that very location, glancing back at Adora and Catra to make sure they're paying attention.

"We're heading to the Royal Palace," she says, extending a hand toward the crystal towers in the distance—and that odd tower made of stone. "Apologies for the walk. Normally, we'd use a Wind Raider—" Teela gestures to one of the hovercraft floating overhead. "—but we sent my squadron's transport to retrieve reinforcements, and it has yet to return."

"Reinforcements?" Adora repeats, accusingly—so sure is she that these 'reinforcements' will somehow be used against Catra and herself.

"Standard procedure," Teela explains. "We add additional guard whenever someone lands on the planet. When someone gets as close as you did to one of the few entrances...we send for reinforcements. Just in case there's an attack."

"So that's why you were waiting for us," realizes Catra.

"We're forbidden to reveal ourselves to outsiders," Teela says. "Except in extreme cases, like yours. If you hadn't opened the gateway—or revealed yourself to be She-Ra—we never would have been introduced."

Adora can't help wishing for that alternate timeline, just a little.

And it is, in fact, a long walk. A long walk in which Adora—or rather, She-Ra—is on full display for the entire Eternian populace. She can feel a thousand pairs of eyes scrutinizing her, judging her. Wondering, especially, why or how she came to be here, and surely expecting a good reason or explanation.

But Adora doesn't have one. She doesn't have a good reason to be here, and frankly, she wishes that she weren't here at all—

And she continues to wish that, right until she reaches the ornate front doors of the palace.

And truly, it's the most enormous set of doors that Adora has ever seen (and Adora has visited a great many palaces and grand buildings in her life). Even to She-Ra, with her eight feet of height, they are colossal—the size of a home on their own, shut tight and steadfast against the outside world.

Each door is guarded by more soldiers. At least ten of them per door. Their posture straightens to something decidedly *defensive* upon Adora and Catra's approach. Though the guards are far from calm and collected, if their wide-eyed, slack-jawed gaping is any indication.

"By the Goddess, captain!" exclaims one guard, evidently speaking to Teela and only Teela as they clutch tightly at a spear. "What in the Darklands is this—"

"She-Ra," Teela explains, with a small shrug and a thumb over her shoulder, pointed at Adora, "apparently returned."

"I-I—" The guard's eyes seem utterly fastened to Adora's face as their hands tremble uncontrollably. "I can't let her through. Surely, you know that. She could break the royals to pieces—"

Teela places a hand on her hip. "Like we could stop her from doing that, if she wished. Move aside, Crux."

"B-but…" the guard continues to stammer. "What is she doing back here? If my memory serves me right, She-Ra imploded when Etheria did—"

"Apparently not," says Teela with a sigh and a glance at Adora. "I'm sure she has much to explain, this She-Ra. And I'm sure the King and Queen will be eager to listen. So move aside, and let us pass."

The guards stand there, listless, for a long while. Murmuring among themselves and shifting their feet.

"We do not have all day," Teela growls. "I am your commanding officer. Let us through. *Now* ."

That, at least, seems to shake the guards from their stupor. They scramble forward, practically tripping over themselves in an effort to clear the path while one guard motions wildly to some distant tower. An indication that the doors should be opened, Adora can only assume.

And open, the doors do. Though if the creaking of the hinges is any indication...they must not open very often.

Once the doors creak fully ajar, the guards press their backs against them, lining the path. Each soldier stands rod-straight with their heads dipped down into a small bow, creating a series of faceless helmets rather than people.

Though Adora does not fail to notice their spears, still gripped tightly in their hands.

The split doors reveal a true cavern of crystal—high-ceilinged, wide, and carved to utmost smoothness. The walls are just as prismatic on the inside as they are on the outside, though somehow they're not transparent enough to allow Adora to see *through* them.

"Finally," grumbles Teela as she beckons Adora and Catra forward.

Adora is too aware of how her shoes *clack* across the floor. A smacking, percussive sound produced by her boot's metal heels, one that echoes across massive ceilings and reverberates between crystal walls.

The hall extends and extends, a larger room than Adora ever thought possible. At the end is a set of tall-backed, gleaming

chairs. Two of equal size, set prominently atop a dais surrounded by polished stairs.

There's another dais beside it, one that's raised off the ground but considerably shorter. It, too, houses a chair—one identical in style to its two neighbors, but also smaller in size.

Thrones, Adora thinks. Seats for royalty.

Adora has seen many before, back on Etheria. Though she has never sat in one. She is only an honorary princess, after all, with no real kingdom to rule. And that's how she prefers it.

All chairs are empty, to Adora's relief. Though there is someone there, standing beside them. Someone who watches Teela's approach with utmost attention and, if Adora is not mistaken, just a little bit of exasperation.

A man, it seems. A man adorned in armor that is even more complex and ornate than Teela's.

"Teela," the man thunders. "What trouble have you brought to the King and Queen this time?"

"I do not bring trouble, father," calls Teela in reply, arms outstretched in gesture to Adora behind her. "Trouble comes to me. I simply make it known."

Catra and Adora are brought to a stop several feet in front of the empty throne—and the man who lurks beside them. Adora feels him glance up the length of Adora's body, examining her like some biological oddity that has suddenly dropped into his lap.

"Are you sure it's really She-Ra?" the man demands. "And not some pretender? A gifted illusionist, perhaps?"

"If she is a fake," says Teela, "then she has remarkable strength, indeed. She reversed her capture in seconds—broke my grip like it was nothing." She looks at Adora for a moment, then returns her

gaze to the man ahead—her father, evidently. "And you can feel it, when she stands close. Magic rolls off her in waves."

Teela pauses. Scowls. Then adds, muttering, "Only in Tower Grayskull have I felt anything like it."

Adora recognizes that word, *Grayskull* . It was the name of Mara's squadron, the one that defected from the First Ones and sought to destroy the Heart. They sacrificed themselves to save Etheria and the wider universe. And sometimes, when Adora transforms into She-Ra, she still utters her pledge to that squadron's honor. Out of respect for them.

She didn't realize that Grayskull was a real place—just like she didn't realize that Eternia was one too. It seems that despite Adora's understanding of the First Ones' language, she still has much to learn.

She's just not so sure that she wants to know, if the cost is what she suspects it is.

Teela's father gives an aggrieved sigh. "And I suppose I should fetch the royals to discuss She-Ra's return?"

Teela nods. "That would be nice."

"And should I bother dragging Prince Adam to this affair?" the man continues, an eyebrow raised at Teela. It somehow seems like he is challenging her.

That name, *Prince Adam* , seems to send a jolt of annoyance through Teela's body. She crosses her arms and stomps a foot. "If the Prince can behave—and stay silent and seated—then he is welcome to attend. Better to keep him where I can see him, and stop him from causing trouble."

The man nods. "Very well. I shall return shortly."

And then he's off toward some distant hallway, speed-walking so quickly that his heavily-armored body appears angled forward.

Once he is gone, Teela turns back to Adora and Catra, her arms still crossed over her chest. With a jerk of her head, she says, "My father, Duncan. Man-at-Arms and advisor to the King and Queen."

"Ah," says Catra, drawing out her words in a particular way—a way that most certainly means trouble. "So that means this job of yours...it runs in the family?"

Teela's eyes narrow at Catra. "What are you implying?"

"Nothing," says Catra, with a yawn that likely comes across as overly flippant. "It's just pretty common, is all. Kids following in their parents' footsteps. We've seen it a lot throughout our travels."

Teela takes a near-threatening step forward, one that prompts Adora to place herself between Teela and Catra, an arm outstretched protectively.

"I was not *given* this job because of my father," hisses Teela, enraged eyes utterly *burning* into Catra's. "I earned my title despite how people doubted me. Earned it, through hard work. I started at the lowest rank and worked my way to the top. I was *entrusted* with this position, because I was most capable."

"Alright," says Catra, hands again raised in a mock gesture of surrender. "Take it easy there, *Teela* . I was just making an observation."

"She didn't mean anything," adds Adora. "We just...Catra and I grew up in some pretty rough conditions, on Etheria. Family dynamics are still kind of a new concept for us."

Teela shakes her head, and with it, some of the rage seems to shake from her body. "It is no matter," she says, turning away from Catra with a huff. Though she continues to speak, saying, "You can't be expected to understand any piece of my life, let alone the complexities of my relationship with my parents."

“Fair enough,” agrees Adora, with just the barest edge of uneasiness.

Teela clears her throat and stands, perfectly poised, at the foot of the two large thrones.

“When the royals enter the hall, you will bow,” orders Teela. She doesn’t so much as glance at Adora and Catra as she issues the command. “Failure to do so will be considered a sign of great disrespect.”

“Yeah, yeah, got it,” replies Catra, with an eye roll. “We’ll bow nice and low. Right, Adora?”

Adora can feel Catra turning her head, watching Adora’s expression with a raised eyebrow. Catra expects her to agree, after all, and so does Teela. They expect her to bow to these royals—to demonstrate that she is at their service, and that she bears no ill-will toward Eternia’s rulers.

But what if it’s not true? What if Adora *doesn’t* want to bow to them, after everything? After these people experimented on her planet, and sought to use Mara, then Adora, as weapons of mass destruction? What if she maybe, just maybe, she *does* bear ill will?

Maybe... *maybe* she wishes to fight them, each and every one of these heavily-armored Eternians, to avenge Mara’s sacrifice. Maybe she wants to fight them, or flee from them. Maybe she’s afraid that they will again create a weapon that seizes control of She-Ra—

But Catra is here. Catra is here, and vulnerable to attack. Adora cannot risk her life in pursuit of a fit of rage, or a flight driven by fear.

And besides...all those things—with the exception of Adora’s conflict with Light Hope—happened thousands of years ago. And even Light Hope was an outdated product of the distant past. An AI that was never properly updated or shut down. Adora knows

that the Eternians have likely changed significantly since then, and that she should not assume so much—

But she can't shake it. She can't shake her distrust. They must be what Chasm is after by coming here. And what if they help her do it, what if they help her repair the sword?

"Adora?" Catra says with a nudge of her elbow. "Did you hear what Teela said?"

Curtly, Adora nods her head. "Yes, I heard," she agrees, albeit reluctantly. "I'll bow, if necessary."

Catra shoots her a questioning look, clearly surprised by the terseness of Adora's answer, but doesn't force Adora to elaborate. Instead, she merely returns her hand to its previous position—wrapped tightly around Adora's.

And that's when they hear it—the swell of some strange instrument. A horn of some kind, Adora thinks. But one far more haunting than one Adora's ever heard before. There's no equivalent sound on Etheria, not as far as Adora can remember.

Even though there's nothing to bow to, not yet, Teela immediately drops into a bow. Adora and Catra exchange a glance. A wary one. Then they're both dropping to a single knee, their heads dipped low.

Adora strains her eyes upward, watching as a group of figures emerge from a door. A hidden one—one that Adora failed to notice until now, nestled behind the two largest thrones. But now she sees it. Sees how it opens, birthing three sets of feet into the chamber.

Adora keeps herself bowed but vigilant as two figures settle themselves into the pair of larger thrones. She can't see anything but their feet—the way they climb the steps and turn into their sets, fabric swooshing around their ankles.

The third set of feet hesitates, though. Adora can see and sense them hovering, staring, cemented in place just ahead of her. Eyes likely gaping at She-Ra from above where those feet stand.

"So it *wasn't* a joke?" someone whispers. Likely the owner of that third set of feet. "It's really her?"

"Sit, Adam," chides a woman's voice. One that leaves no room for argument.

There's no answer. No movement. The owner of those feet remains in place, staring at Adora—or rather, She-Ra—with rapt attention.

"Adam," comes the woman's voice again, and it's more demanding than before. "Sit *down* ."

There's a grumble. A pause. But eventually, those feet retreat, taking their place at the height of the third dais. The owner of the smallest throne, evidently.

"Rise, all," a different voice orders, stern and commanding.

Teela straightens. And truly, there is no better exemplification of that word— *straightens* . Her posture could not be more perfect. Her shoulders are shoved back, her knees are locked and feet slightly spread beneath her to maintain steady, military-style balance.

Adora and Catra are far less stiff in their movements. They gradually lift themselves to their feet, gazes slow to rise in examination of the royalty ahead of them.

On one of the larger thrones is a study-looking man—bearded, with a thick jaw and light brown hair, a brow cocked in curiosity above a twinkling blue eye. His outfit is striking; red robes and white cloak draped over his shoulders. Though the red is hardly visible beneath the *enormous* medallion that covers his chest, glinting a nearly blinding gold. It matches perfectly with the crown atop his head—also oversized. Also shining to the point of excess.

The woman beside him wears a matching crown and medallion. The Queen, Adora assumes—an intimidatingly beautiful figure by even the most cursory of glances. Tall. Lean, but fit. She appears more calculating than curious, with a stern brow and shrewd eyes that watch Adora and Catra with apparent suspicion.

The Queen's hair is golden. Golden, in the same way Adora's is, but it's far more elegant. In fact, Adora is rendered truly envious of the way Queen's hair weaves and braids delicately through her crown. Adora's hair has always been too uncooperative to be woven into such a style—any style at all, really, with how limply it hangs across her shoulders.

The Queen crosses her legs and leans forward with interest, elbow balanced on the knee of her own green robes—which draw a stark contrast to the King's blue and red ones.

And then, of course, there's the last figure. A young person reclined in the third smaller chair, their legs draped over one of the throne's arms. *Prince Adam* , Adora recalls Teela and Duncan mentioning. And this must be him. This must be the Prince. He is similar in appearance to his mother. Tall, but lean. Blonde hair long and loose over his eyes.

Despite his casual posture, it's clear that he's somewhat starstruck by She-Ra's presence. His stare is wide-eyed, his smile is beaming. The face of someone surprised, but excited. Adora can guess as to why. If the creaking of the front door is any indication, the royal family must not be frequented by visitors. And it can't be every day that a figure as towering as She-Ra strides into their halls.

Adora wonders what she is supposed to say to these people. Should she explain her situation? How Etheria was attacked, and now she will require Eternia's help to track down the attacker? Should she even bother mentioning that she herself has been infected by Chasm...or is that irrelevant, considering that the whole city seems to be immune?

“Queen Marlena and King Randor,” Teela says, beneath her breath. “You will refer to them individually as ‘ *your highness* .’”

Adora hardly has time to make the mental note before the queen begins to speak.

“So...it *is* true,” the Queen says, and Adora realizes that the commanding voice came from her. The Queen. “She-Ra has returned.”

“Yes, your highness,” Teela replies. “It was she who opened one of the gateways into the city. That was why we raised the alarm earlier. She-Ra and her companion disabled our defenses.”

“ *Wife,”* Adora hears Catra mutter, but it’s not loud enough for anyone else to hear. Adora resists a smile in response.

“And how is that possible?” the Queen demands, then adds an appraising glare in Adora’s direction. “The histories say that She-Ra was lost when Etheria was destroyed—”

“She actually *claims* to be from Etheria,” Teela explains, and there’s a suggestion in those words...one that Adora isn’t sure she likes. “Born and raised there. Which means that the planet was not destroyed, after all. Isn’t that right, She-Ra?”

Adora clears her throat, then answers, “Yes. That is correct.”

“And clearly, She-Ra—or at least, her power—was also saved from destruction,” Teela continues, with a gesture at Adora’s face. “She lives on in you. An Etherian. She even claims that She-Ra’s power became hers without the help of our people’s sacred sword.”

“Well, yes,” says Adora. “I don’t need the sword to turn into She-Ra. The Sword of Protection has been destroyed—”

“Don’t be modest,” Teela says. “Weren’t you the one to destroy the sword? You said so yourself.”

Adora shoots Teela a perplexed look. She doesn't understand how the information is at all relevant. "Well...yes. I destroyed it. I had to—"

"That's interesting, don't you think?" Teela asks. "Since, according to legend, the Sword of Protection will only appear to a chosen *Eternian* champion. And since you claimed to have been the one to destroy the sword...that means you must have known an Eternian, to find the sword in the first place."

Adora freezes. She really, really, *doesn't* like where this is going. She was hoping for a simple introduction. A more-or-less innocuous discussion of Adora's past, and a plea for help in locating Chasm. Nothing more.

But she didn't anticipate this...this *interrogation* .

"Which would be impossible with our entire populace here—cut off from the rest of the universe."

"Captain Teela," interrupts the Queen, tone disapproving. "What exactly are you implying? I was expecting to greet our guest, not interrogate her—"

"But...then we must consider how she opened the gateway," Teela adds. "You were able to read or write our language—something that no one but an Eternian is able to do."

"By the Goddess," complains the Prince, with a roll of his eyes. His head flops back in his chair. "You are just making excuses for your faulty security, aren't you? So she got past the gateway. Big deal."

"Adam," the King warns. "Do not disrespect Teela in such a way."

"What?" Adam demands petulantly. "She doesn't hesitate to criticize me. And now, when she's screwed up her guard, I can't return the favor?"

"I have not *screwed up* my guard," Teela seethes. "And you'd do best to listen to me, Prince Adam, for this issue concerns you

most seriously."

Adora grabs Catra's hand and begins tugging her toward the door. "Maybe…" Adora stammers, voice hushed to a whisper that she hopes only Catra can hear. "Maybe we should just go—"

Teela points to her, fuming, "Do not move, She-Ra. I am not yet finished."

Adora stops in her tracks. She doesn't want to start a fight, but she also doesn't want to stick around for whatever *this* is.

"And you're going to try to stop me?" Adora asks, an eyebrow raised in challenge.

"No," says Teela, with a forced calmness. "But you will regret leaving nonetheless."

Catra makes a noise of outrage. "Was that a threat?"

"No!" exclaims Teela, arms outstretched to her side. "I am not threatening anyone, nor am I making excuses."

She storms up to Adora, then. Stopping only when they stand mere inches apart. Catra hisses at Teela's approach, her muscles tensing to lunge to Adora's defense, but Adora stops her. With the swipe of a single arm, she pushes Catra behind herself, out of Teela's view. Adora is more than capable of defending herself—and Catra—against a single soldier.

Teela cranes her neck to meet Adora's gaze, so superior is She-Ra's height. And they're so hard, Teela's eyes, as they bore into Adora's. Hard and determined to find answers.

Though Adora notices that there's something else there, besides that hardness. A desperation. A hopefulness. A *triumph* .

"You are not really an Etherian, are you?" demands Teela. "Tell the truth. What is your birthplace?"

Adora sets her jaw but does not answer.

"Teela," calls the Prince. "Leave the woman alone, for the Goddess's sake—"

But Teela ignores him—doesn't even spare him a glance. "This is more important than you know," she whispers to Adora, nearly begging. "You must tell the truth."

"Why does it matter, if I'm not?" replies Adora, after a pause that reveals more than she'd like it to. "Etheria's my home. It always has been."

"It matters more than you understand," Teela is quick to respond. "So tell me... *where* ? Where were you born?"

Adora swallows hard. She can feel the King and Queen watching her, examining and dissecting her every word and facial expression. They hardly seem inclined to force Teela to stop now, with their curiosity so piqued by *whatever* it is that Teela's implying. Only Adam appears at all sympathetic to Adora's plight. He stares furiously at Teela...though Adora can tell, beneath the smothering weight of his concern, that he is just as intrigued by what Teela seeks to reveal.

"I...I don't know where I was born," Adora says finally, a blush spreading across her cheeks at the admission.

And that *was* the truth, up until today. Up until today, she had no idea where the last pocket of First Ones—or rather, Eternians—were hidden.

"But no," Adora continues. "I'm not Etherian by birth. I was...brought there. Brought, by a portal."

And for the first time, she allows herself to picture it. A portal torn open here, in Eternos—perhaps even within one of the quaint homes they passed on their way here. A portal that captured an infant Adora from her crib and sent her tumbling to Etheria, into the arms of the Horde.

Teela’s lips quirk as she spins around, facing the royals once again. She is smug now. Irrepressibly so. It practically oozes from her skin, that smugness.

“Your majesties,” Teela says. “I believe fate has intervened on our kingdom’s behalf. By some miracle, what we thought was lost has now been discovered. The planet Etheria. The mighty She-Ra. And, most importantly of all…”

She gestures to Adora with a small flourish.

“...The only person in a thousand years to go missing from our lands, ” Teela says. “Your daughter. The stolen princess of Eternia.”

Chapter End Notes

please remember to leave comments!!

Chapter 15

Chapter Summary

Randor gets a scratch.
Adora and Catra climb some stairs.
And the Sorceress receives a blood donation.

Chapter Notes

Hey all! Another update down. Warning for some mention of **blood in this chapter.**

Also I'm going to have to post the next chapter in two weeks. I'm sorry for the delay, but I'm exhausted from finals/graduation/moving/unpacking and need more time to edit. I know we just came back from hiatus but my busyness really has not let up. My big bang fic will update as planned next week, though—so read that if you miss me too much lol.

Anyway, please enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"*Shit*."

It is Catra who says it. Too loudly, perhaps, loud enough for Adora to hear quite clearly, and certainly loud enough for the royals to hear as well.

And Adora doesn't like the way Catra is staring at her. Wide-eyed and disbelieving, almost like she doesn't recognize Adora at all. Because truly, nothing could hurt more than that. The idea that Catra—the person who knows her best in all the universe, the person she's known since childhood—could suddenly view Adora as something foreign and incomprehensible.

It was bad enough the first time, when Adora learned she was a princess. When she learned she was destined for the sword, for

She-Ra, after a lifetime of being brainwashed to hate princesses.

But to go through it again…

It can't be true. It just can't. Out of all the people in this hidden city, out of all the families and homes, how is it that Adora managed to come from this one? From royalty. From the rulers of the very people who have caused her adopted home so much pain, so much war and destruction. From the very people who wanted to use Mara and Adora as weapons. Weapons, fired on a whim regardless of the potential chaos they could wreak, or the objections that Adora or Mara themselves might have raised.

"I—" Adora gasps, head swiveling between those varied sets of eyes, all trained so intently upon her face. "There must be some mistake. Some mix-up. Because I'm not...I'm not *that* kind of princess. I'm just…"

The words evaporate in her lungs. She doesn't know what she is anymore. She knows she *wants* to be Etherian, and only that. But the implications of her origins always reemerge somehow, no matter how much Adora stuffs them below soil dotted with wildflowers, or shoves them into some distant, decaying corridor of her past.

"I'm She-Ra," she says, halfway exhaling the words. "And maybe I'm one of your people but we shouldn't...we shouldn't just *assume* that I'm your daughter. That's just..." She releases a strange, stilted spasm of a laugh. "...that's just *absurd*, if it's true. Because really, what are the chances?"

"Considering that only one person has gone missing from Eternos in the last thousand years," Teela says, with clear annoyance at having to repeat herself. "Quite high, I'd say."

Adora scoffs, unable to even *process* those words. Her brain feels like it's in utter free-fall, plummeting toward a rocky and bone-shattering end. "I mean...what even happened to your daughter,

anyway?" Adora asks the King and Queen—and pointedly not Teela. "It could just be coincidence, really—"

"She disappeared," says Teela, calmly. Despite how Adora prayed that she would not answer. "For a long time, we thought that someone snuck into the palace and stole her from her nursery. My father was but a palace guard at the time. He told me there was no trace of an intruder, no sign of entry or escape. It was like the princess had simply *vanished*. Into thin air. It remained one of our people's greatest unsolved mysteries."

Teela smirks yet again.

"Unsolved...now solved. Little did we know that she *did* vanish into thin air. Or rather...into a portal."

Adora shakes her head wildly. Because it can't...it *can't* be true.

But there's no stopping it, the weight of Teela's suggestion. Bearing down upon her as the King and Queen rise to their feet. They move slowly. Zombie-like, almost, their eyes affixed to Adora like she's reversed death before their eyes. And while She-Ra can heal many deadly injuries, she cannot do that. At least, not as far as Adora knows. She cannot reverse death.

Unless she counts this. Being discovered alive, after a lifetime of being missing to these strangers. Strangers who will now expect her to call them family.

They approach her, the King and Queen. The King's eye has since lost its curious twinkle, and the Queen's features have been stripped of their shrewdness. She no longer appears so calculating, so cunning. Instead, they wear matching expressions of shock and...something like *hunger*.

"This is not how you truly appear, is it?" the Queen asks. Nearly demands. "I am tall, but surely I could not produce a child *this* tall."

Adora gulps and shakes her head. When she does, she feels the rippling of the long hair produced by her transformation—hair that looks so much unlike her own. She wonders if it will disappoint them—her usual appearance. It's so plain, so unextraordinary compared to She-Ra's ethereal beauty—

"I want to see you. The real you," the Queen says. And it's so commanding that Adora almost feels compelled to do it—to do as the Queen says. But she's also too paralyzed by fear to move, let alone use magic.

"*Please*," the Queen adds, likely as an afterthought. One brought about by Adora's inability to move, mistaken for refusal.

This time she nods, rather than shakes her head. It's a bad idea, probably. Letting down her defenses. Letting She-Ra fall away in favor of her far less-imposing self. But she's not cowardly enough to deny the Queen this, especially when she sounds so desperate to see, to *know*.

And who knows? Maybe the King and Queen will need nothing but a short glance to determine that she's not theirs, not theirs by any stretch of the imagination—

Adora inhales deeply and shuts her eyes. Beneath her eyelids, she can see the flash of her own transformation. Though it's a de-transformation this time. A reversion to her true self, however unimpressive it may be.

Her first sight upon opening her eyes is the King and Queen recoiling. Recoiling, like she is something startling and revolting.

At first, she is horrified. Horrified and confused by this reaction. Adora may have her insecurities...but she's confident enough to say that she's not *that* ugly, not ugly enough to warrant this kind of behavior—

But then she realizes that she's still in her spacesuit. The oversized one, with the bulky helmet. And really, it must be nearly impossible to get a good look at Adora like this.

So Adora reaches up and tugs off the helmet, trying to maintain some semblance of grace or steadiness as she *yanks* and *yanks* at the veritable fish bowl over her head. It releases her with a loud pop, and finally, Adora can drop the helmet to the floor and reveal her face.

She shakes out her ponytail, all-too-aware that she doesn't look her best. Even without the hideous spacesuit, Adora's eyes are sunken into her skull, she is still so tortured by exhaustion.

The Queen inhales sharply. One of her hands hovers close to Adora's face, as though she wishes to touch it. But Adora doesn't give her the chance. She flinches away with a small noise—one that might just be a whimper, she's ashamed to admit.

And maybe it's an offensive thing to do—to flinch from the touch. But Adora can't help it. She doesn't want to be touched by these people, especially not now. All she wants is for the King and Queen to declare, emphatically, that Adora is not their child, so that Adora can continue her life in ignorant bliss of her ancestry—

"You do…" the Queen begins, but is forced to clear her throat as her words catch on nothing at all. "You do look like him. Like Adam."

Adora glances at him—at Adam. He doesn't approach in the same way his parents did, but he still rises to his feet. Watching, from a distance, with barely-repressed awe and excitement painted across her features.

Distantly, she notes that they *are* similar. Adam's features. Same limp blonde hair. Same blue-gray eyes. Same lean but muscular build. A perfect combination of the King and Queen's features, really.

It's not something that Adora wants to see. And especially, it's not something that she wants to see *in herself*.

The King is the one to clear his throat this time. And Adora is somewhat stunned to hear him speak for the first time. His voice

is low and bellowing—maybe even raspy with what sounds like disuse. It seems, even from this short encounter, that the Queen does most of the talking.

"We cannot know for sure," he says. "She may be ours. But she could also belong to some small population of survivors—perhaps a faction from one of our colonies."

"That's a really good point," Adora agrees, quickly. Desperately. "I could just as easily be someone else's daughter—"

"We must take her to the Sorceress," the Queen replies. She seems to be talking exclusively to her husband. "She will reveal the truth, even if no one else can."

Adora blinks. "The who?"

But they refuse to spare a moment, nor an explanation. The King and Queen place hands at Adora's back, guiding her forward—toward the hallway where Teela's father disappeared—despite how Adora digs heels into the ground.

Adora stammers, "W-wait—"

"Hey!" calls a voice, "Both of you, stop!"

Adora glances over her shoulder to see Catra yanking the King's hand off of Adora's back—and not gently, either. The King is forced backward, staggering, his hand reddened by shallow scratches.

Belatedly, Adora notices that Catra's claws have unsheathed themselves from her gloves.

The Queen releases Adora and spins around with a gasp. The King, meanwhile, can only gape at Catra. Gape, like Catra has violated some sacred law. And really, Adora can only assume that Catra has. It surely must be forbidden to manhandle the King.

The Queen inhales deeply, posture straightening with the inflation of her outrage. Her jaw is tight, almost unmoving as she demands to Catra, "Who do you think you are?"

"I'm She-Ra's *wife*," snarls Catra. "And I'm not letting you take her anywhere she doesn't want to go."

At this, the Queen's features seem to slacken in shock.

And it's touching, that Catra is trying to defend Adora in this way. Especially with the recent discovery of Adora's heritage, and how that seemed to shake Catra to her core only moments ago, leaving Adora wondering if she had again pushed Catra away with this extra potential layer to her identity.

But doing this…

It's also an invitation for trouble.

"Catra—" Adora says warningly. And not because she wants to go with them, or because she objects to Catra announcing the nature of their relationship. It's because Catra shouldn't *purposely* try to piss off the monarchy. It wouldn't be the first time She-Ra has been forced to plow through an army for something like this—an attempt to rescue Catra from her own tendency to *insult* royalty. Glimmer might tolerate her teasing, but few other monarchs do.

The King and Queen whirl on Adora, their eyes pulled wide. "You're married?" they both gasp, in an indignant sort of way. Like someone should have informed them of this crucial fact from the very start.

"Uh…" Adora clears her throat. "...yes?"

A moment passes in which they simply stare at her. Then at Catra, with a look that's not at all disapproving, really. But more...appraising. Scrutinizing. Like they're studying Catra as they see her, but also measuring her against some nonexistent rival.

"Her name is Catra," Adora adds, in a small voice. As that might somehow improve the opinion they're doubtlessly forming about her.

And then the King and Queen resume staring at Adora again. And beneath the pressure of their gaze, Adora finds herself scratching. Scratching nervously at the base of her own neck.

"Look, I don't really know if She-Ra was allowed to marry, back in the day," Adora says. "But things have changed. She-Ra has changed, especially, and I love Catra—"

The Queen lays a hand on Adora's shoulder—a grasp of tightly coiled fingers that dig into Adora's suit. Her eyes beg, *insist*. "Please. We must take you to the sorceress. We deserve answers at the very least. We all do."

Adora hesitates. Her eyes find Catra beyond the King and Queen's crowding, but the look they share is little help. Catra's eyes voice their support, whatever Adora chooses. But they don't have an answer as to what Adora *should* choose. Nor do they offer a suggestion.

Then she glances at Teela. Teela, whose eyes are so different from Catra's. For one, both eyes are of the same color—pale gray, like the thick droplets of a stormcloud. For another, they seem to have a clear opinion on the matter. She wants Adora to agree. And worse...they tell Adora that, should Adora refuse, she will find herself without Eternia's help when locating Chasm. Which is something that she—and Etheria itself—cannot afford.

Adora puffs out a breath.

"I'll go," she concedes.

But only because she must.

They walk for so long, Adora nearly loses track of time. Her concentration becomes lost in the endless crystal hallways, her

mind dulled by the fact that each corridor is essentially identical to the last. Adora wonders whether they're being led into a maze—one that intends to trap them within its depths, never to escape.

Given what Adora knows about the First Ones-slash-Eternians...it really wouldn't surprise her.

Though, eventually, Adora is relieved to discover a change in scenery. Their crystal surroundings give way to solid stone walls. A startling change in color, as well as in lighting.

The tower, she thinks, recalling the massive stone spire that she spotted on the way in. That must be where they're headed. To that section of the castle constructed of stone, out of place as it was. To the section of the castle that felt...different. Primeval, almost.

This is where that strange distortion originates—and where this so-called *Sorceress* resides.

And where the magical pull is strongest. Strong, like the tower is some immense celestial body, and Adora is towed forward by its demanding gravity. Adora can't really explain it, but she senses that magic is truly like that. Bound by laws of physics, just like planets and stars are. Systems of energy and elements and nothingness.

It must be something like a star, Adora thinks. This tower. It must be a star among planets and moons and meteors. She's never felt anything like this, save the magic at the Heart of Etheria itself. A pulsing, captivating force of nature.

Eventually, they reach a stone door, one roughly carved from a wall of the same material. It's carved so haphazardly that entering and exiting must have been an afterthought of the person who first constructed it. Like the architect, in a fit of panic, hacked through the stone with an axe—and declared it a sufficient entrance and exit.

Still. Despite its crude appearance, it looks to be a heavy door to open, and an even more difficult door to break down. A suitable protection for whatever lies beyond.

Protection appears to be quite the priority for this section of castle. There are a dozen guards that stand positioned just outside the tower entrance—and not idle guards, either. Well-trained guards, considering how they stood at attention even before the King and Queen walked into view.

"State your business," one guard orders, barking the words.

"The Royals ask an audience of the great Sorceress of Castle Grayskull," says the Queen. "It is a matter of utmost importance."

Adora expects the soldier to merely nod, and let them pass. Perhaps even open the door for them.

But he doesn't. Not immediately, anyway. They all stand there, waiting in awkward silence for what feels like too long. The moments seem to pass like thick sludge across Adora's eyes. Because, truly, is there anything more unbearable than this? A moment shared with her *maybe*-parents, where there is nothing to say, and nothing to do.

Adora drops Catra a questioning glance, unsure of what, exactly, they're waiting for. She insisted that Catra come with them here, to *Tower Grayskull*—as King Randor and Queen Marlena called it. Adora was simply too nervous to be separated from Catra in such a foreign and confusing place.

"*I want to come!"* Prince Adam protested, shortly after Adora agreed to visit the sorceress. He took an eager step forward. "*If she's really my sister—*"

"*You will stay here*," Teela argued, sternly. She grabbed him physically by the arm, holding him back. "*You will learn the truth in due time. Besides, the Sorceress hates to be crowded."*

"*But—"*

"And she especially hates children," Teela added, beneath her breath. Though Adora suspected that everyone could hear the insult.

It was, however, enough to keep Adam in the throne room, grumbling and glaring at Teela as Adora, Catra, the King, and the Queen departed in search of answers. Adora glanced back at him as the doors shut behind her—briefly noticing how similar his expressions are to her own. Their expressions of annoyance, in particular.

The guards outside that stone door remain unmoving. Unmoving, and silent. The door still tightly shut. What could they possibly be waiting for, Adora wonders?

Though she soon receives her answer in the form of a harsh grinding noise. Adora looks to the door and to her surprise...it seems to be sliding open of its own accord. Gradually tugging backward in an arc, one that will soon bring it perpendicular to the wall.

She realizes now that there don't seem to be any hinges. Just stone. Incredibly heavy stone, a weighted slab that opens without hands to push it from its frame, or hinges to ease its movement.

Magic. That's really the only explanation for this. This door that opens with the shove of invisible arms.

The guard peels themself from the spot in front of the door and gestures for the other guards to do the same. They do. Copying their leader, they split their detail at the center, exposing the door to be opened and surpassed.

Beyond the door, Adora sees only a staircase. One hewn from the same gravelly stone as everything else. Though she can't tell how wide or how far the staircase goes. Only that it's there.

The Queen nods in appreciation, then strides forward, lifting her robes in anticipation of the steps. The King does the same,

though with an expectant, beckoning glance in Adora's direction as he goes.

Catra and Adora exchange another skeptical glance, and then, with a shared shrug, they begin to follow close behind—still half-annoyed that they haven't had the chance to change out of their bulky spacesuits, which will surely become a pain as they climb any number of stairs. Adora reaches for Catra's hand as they begin their ascent, holding it so tightly that she's half yanking Catra up the stairs with her. Catra, thankfully, doesn't complain. She just moves forward in an effort to stay close to Adora's side.

They both wince when the door slams shut behind them, thrust back into place as though someone shoved their whole body against it in an effort to trap them.

But, of course, no one did. No one is purposely trying to trap them, Adora reminds herself, despite how her blooming panic insists otherwise. The door moved of its own accord. Just like before. Moved by magic, and made loud by its immense weight.

Magic that refuses them the option of turning back.

"No big deal," Catra mutters beneath her breath, loud enough for only Adora to hear. "Wouldn't be a proper adventure without big scary doors trying to trap us someplace, would it?"

Adora snorts, knowing that it's true.

The staircase is steep, spiral, and seems to travel in endless circles leading upward. Adora recalls how tall the stone spire was, and fears that they'll be heading all the way to the highest level. It's a climb that Adora would never *dream* of making in a spacesuit this bulky.

Adora suddenly wonders why such a technologically advanced culture—one that has hovercrafts flying about—can't produce an elevator. They were common enough, back in the Fright Zone.

And Adora's fear is ultimately proven right—the King and Queen are headed all the way to the top, with no evident intention to take breaks. Adora considers herself quite fit, but even she is panting a bit when they reach the highest step. A step that leads them to the threshold of yet another stone door, shut tightly ahead.

Though this one is slightly different. Much like the backs of the many Eternians Adora has encountered, this door is covered in written symbols. Carved, even. There's so many of them too—more than she can hope to count, or recognize.

Though she identifies the ward against Chasm among the throng. A spiral, struck through with lines. Just like the rest.

The Queen lays her knuckle against the door, then gives a single resounding knock.

There's another pause. One that again feels...contemplative. Like the person on the other side is deciding whether it's worthwhile to let them in.

Though when the door opens, it doesn't behave like that other door on the first level. Instead, it seems to fade. Fade, in color and opacity, as though she's now looking at a ghost of a door rather than one cut from real rock and stone.

Adora is still gaping in wonder when the Queen walks *through* the closed door. Through it, as though it is intangible. A mere projection before her eyes. The sight pulls a gasp from Adora's lungs, and she's still not quite prepared when the King seems to pass through the door as well, as if it's nothing.

Adora stands there, hesitating, even though she knows that she's awaited on the other side. But she just can't move forward. Not yet. What if the door randomly becomes solid again while she's halfway through? What if it cuts Adora in half?

But then Catra is there, smiling and nudging her encouragingly. When Adora fails to move, Catra continues holding onto Adora's

hand as she herself steps forward, guiding Adora forward as well. It's ultimately Catra who ducks through the door first and, attached to Catra's hand as she is, Adora has no choice but to take a deep breath and follow, lest she and Catra be separated—

Adora should really be used to this sort of magical mayhem by now. But even she is stunned by the door, and what lies beyond it—a sprawling, domed room, with a ceiling covered in sparkling depictions of what appear to be stars and planets, rendering the space something akin to a planetarium.

A planetarium, yes. But also a library of some sort, Adora thinks. The room is made almost *cozy* by the filled bookshelves that line the walls, stacked to overflowing with thick, leather-bound books and fraying scrolls tied with silk ribbons.

The bookshelves cover every inch of wall, save a relatively small space reserved for a single open window, one that overlooks the whole city of Eternos with a breathtaking, expansive view of the landscape. A golden telescope sits beside the window, glinting enticingly in the sunlight—though Adora doesn't know what anyone could see through it, with that magical distortion blocking all view of the sky.

There are various instruments too, placed on shelves and side tables and writing desks, all the furniture mismatched and seemingly stolen from different places and eras. Wooden shelves, stone tables, crystal desks...

And there, at one of those desks, sits a person.

Adora can see only the person's back, at first, turned as they are from the door. But they're there all the same, seemingly engrossed in their writing, which they conduct carefully with ink and paper.

From the corner of her eye, Adora sees the King and Queen give a short bow.

“Greetings, great Sorceress,” says Queen Marlena. “We’ve come to you with an important inquiry.”

“Yes,” says the person—the Sorceress—in an airy sort of voice, though she continues to write without turning around. “It seems you have. And you’ve brought guests.”

Adora shifts uncomfortably where she stands.

“And who are these guests you’ve brought to me?” the Sorceress asks, a curious eyebrow raised in Catra and Adora’s direction.

“They’re…” the King begins, but trails off almost immediately. He stares helplessly at Catra and Adora, then at the Queen. It is only now that Adora realizes that she never told him her name. She’s hardly told him anything, except that she is She-Ra. And potentially his daughter.

“Oh dear,” the Sorceress says, halfway chiding him. Chiding the King, as though that’s somehow allowed. “You haven’t even asked their names?”

Adora stares as the woman rises from her chair, standing slowly and gracefully, like she has infinite time to complete the movement and would prefer not to rush.

And then she turns to face them.

She’s an older woman, yes, but no older than the Queen. Not yet overcome with wrinkles. But her age makes her stark white hair—white as snow, white as Chasm’s hair—rather inexplicable. Beautiful would be one way to describe her, Adora supposes, with those delicate features and tall, well-postured stature. But Adora is bothered by the fact that the Sorceress seems somewhat...familiar. Though where Adora has seen her before, or who she looks like, Adora cannot place.

What is especially striking is the collection of silver laurels perched atop the Sorceress’s head, just above her ears. While Adora is largely indifferent to jewelry or fashion, Adora isn’t sure she likes

the effect of all that silver in this case. Those pale laurels only seem to drain more color from the Sorceress's complexion. A complexion which is already exceedingly pale, almost like she has never left the tower and walked beneath the warm glow of a star —

Wait. Those are not laurels, Adora realizes with a start. *Feathers*. A strange headpiece constructed of silver feathers, seemingly plucked from a bird and coated in metal.

Those feathers seem sewn into the Sorceress's robes, too. They sit upon her shoulders, hang from her arms, extend from the hem of her clothes. Adora can't help but think that she looks like a bird of some kind, roosting here in this ancient tower. Inhuman in more ways than Adora can really identify.

For a long time, the Sorceress watches and examines Adora in turn. Though there's a detached, faraway look in the Sorceress's eye. Like she's watching Adora here, but also watching something in some distant dimension or universe. A black hole or a supernova, maybe. But definitely not something occurring on this planet.

"Care to tell us your names?" the Sorceress asks, gently.

"I'm Adora," she says. And, with a jerking gesture at Catra with her free hand—the one not currently grasped tightly around Catra's fingers—Adora adds, "and this is Catra."

Neither of them bow. Adora isn't sure if they're supposed to. The King and Queen did, but it's not like anyone's giving them instructions here—

The Sorceress gives a short bow of her own—a subtle tipping of her head. And Adora guesses that she probably should have bowed back when they first entered, or when she told the Sorceress their names. So, scrambling, she tips her head—and Catra is quick to copy the movement.

“As wonderful as it is to meet new people,” the Sorceress says, turning to the King and Queen, “It is against our laws for outsiders to enter our city. So how, and why, have these two arrived in my tower?”

Adora is about to ask how the Sorceress identified them as outsiders. But then she realizes that, between the spacesuits and Catra’s very *not-Eternian* appearance...it must be rather obvious.

The Queen clears her throat and steps forward. “Sorceress,” the Queen says, voice low with urgency. “We have reason to believe that she...this *Adora*,” she gestures to Adora with a shaking hand, “is our *daughter*.”

The Sorceress’s eyebrows shoot up. “The long-lost princess?”

She whirls back around to face Adora directly, seemingly gliding across the floor to inspect Adora more closely. She taps her chin as she draws close. Too close, even. Adora finds herself sinking down as the Sorceress nearly *bends* over her, as though attempting to examine the pores of Adora’s face. Her focus is far from distance this time. It’s laser-like, almost stinging in its intensity.

Adora likely bruises Catra’s hand with the force of her grip.

The Sorceress glances back at the King and Queen. “She certainly resembles you both. But that’s hardly enough to make her your daughter. Not with certainty, at least. What leads you to believe she’s yours?”

“Supposedly she can read and write our language,” the Queen says. “But she claims she grew up on Etheria.”

“Etheria?” the Sorceress asks. “Etheria was destroyed long ago.”

“Apparently not,” says the Queen, evenly.

“It wasn’t…” Adora swallows. Then begins again. “It wasn’t destroyed,” Adora continues. “It was just moved. To Despondos.”

The Sorceress and the Queen both fall into stunned silence. But then, after seemingly composing herself, the Sorceress says, "If a planet exists in Despondos—an empty dimension—it is hardly different than it not existing at all."

Adora clenches a fist. "Yeah, well. Etheria was sent there for a good reason."

To keep the Heart of Etheria away from you, she wants to say. But knows that it will only cause her trouble.

"She says that a portal brought her to Etheria," the Queen says, and there's an edge of frustration in her voice. Like she's demanding that they focus on *this*, on confirming whether Adora is her daughter. "Which would make sense, since our daughter…"

"Disappeared from her crib," the Sorceress murmurs. "Yes, I remember. And if she was in Despondos…" She taps her chin in further contemplation. "That would explain why she could not be located by magic. Magic cannot span dimensions. At best, it can only cut openings between them."

Again, Adora finds herself shifting uncomfortably, only to have Catra weave her arm through Adora's—reconnecting their hands and pulling their bodies closer together.

The Sorceress glides away, heading toward one of her many bookshelves. She immediately settles on a bookshelf that's only partially lined with books, replaced instead by instruments and knickknacks that Adora cannot identify. Though one object is easily recognizable, on that shelf. A large bowl carved from the same stone that comprises the tower itself.

Adora initially expects the bowl to be too heavy for someone as thin and pale as the Sorceress, but is startled as the Sorceress lifts it with relative ease, conveying it smoothly to one of her many mismatched desks.

Adora can only watch as the Sorceress pulls more objects from side tables and shelves—bottles of strange liquids and dried

plants. The Sorceress's concentration on her work is unflappable as she tips quantities from each bottle into the bowl. Pouring and pouring until it is filled with a swirling, steaming, *glittering* mixture that nearly sloshes over the bowl's sides.

A potion. Even Adora can recognize that.

And Adora continues watching as the Sorceress draws a rune over the potion's surface. It's not a rune that Adora knows, but the Sorceress is practiced and quick as she draws it—creating lines of glowing blue light across the surface of the liquid.

Adora expects the Sorceress to keep adding to the potion. Which means that Adora is wholly unprepared when the Sorceress outstretches a hand in Adora's direction, demanding that she approach.

"I need one last ingredient," the Sorceress says. She doesn't look at Adora as she says the words. "A droplet of blood."

Adora feels Catra tense beside her, her grip tight on Adora's arm. A part of Catra likely assumes this to be some sort of trap. And maybe she's right. Asking for a droplet of blood feels pretty strange—and also pretty dangerous. But Adora is somewhat comforted by one thing: that none of their past enemies were polite enough to *ask* for Adora's blood. They were more intent on taking it against her will, likely with weapons to aid them.

"Why?" asks Adora. She's still not exactly keen on donating her blood to some mysterious potion.

"This potion will allow me to ascertain whether you're being truthful about your origins," the Sorceress says. "And whether you're truly the missing princess that the King and Queen believe you to be."

Adora hesitates. She doesn't...she doesn't even *want* to know. And she's not sure that she wants this Sorceress to know every detail of Adora's origins, either.

"Just a tiny prick," the Sorceress says, lifting a small needle that must have been hiding there, beside the bowl. "I need only the smallest droplet to learn the whole truth."

Not, of course, that Adora has anything to hide. She *is* telling the truth about herself—about where she grew up, and what she knows about herself. She's by no means trying to sneak into the royal family. In fact...she wishes far more fervently that this little blood test proves Teela wrong. She wants to move on with her life without the King and Queen staring at her like *this*—like they are right now. Gaping at her like a dead woman returned to life.

And if it's the only way to get Teela's help...if it's the only way to find and catch Chasm before she does further harm—

"Fine," says Adora, and pulls herself from Catra's grasp. Determined to simply get this over with. "I'll do it."

She strides as gracefully as she can to that spot beside the Sorceress.

As soon as Adora tentatively places her hand within the Sorceress's grasp, cold fingers wrap around it. Despite the Sorceress's apparent frailness, her grip is stunningly tight. *Painfully* tight, even. Adora finds herself straining against the hold as the Sorceress steadies Adora's hand. Steadying it enough to pull the needle close...and prick the needle tip into the pad of Adora's index finger.

Adora winces just slightly as blood beads at the spot. She's still tense as the Sorceress pulls her hand over the bowl and, as they both watch with rapt attention, a single drop of blood drips from her finger into the potion below.

As soon as the blood splashes ripples into the potion's surface, the rune on the potion reappears—glowing bright purple instead of its previous blue.

Adora stands there, watching, as the rune fades. It is almost immediately replaced with her own reflection, staring back at

Adora from the surface of the liquid.

Wait. Not her reflection, Adora realizes. It looks like her but...it's someone different, someone familiar.

Queen Marlena. That's who Adora is seeing, in the reflection. Queen Marlena holding a pair of newborns in her arms, with King Randor leaning over her, admiring the children. Adora's stomach roils with nausea at the sight, sure that it must mean what she feared to be true—

And sure enough, she sees the image shift, the liquid rippling to display one of the babies in a cradle. Alone, in a room. Fast asleep. Adora can only watch in horror as glowing purple light lances through the room, cutting a hole in the bed right beneath the sleeping child's form. Adora gasps as the child falls through it, disappearing from sight and sinking into the void below—

Again, the potion ripples. When it settles, Adora sees Hordak carrying the child to the Fright Zone. More rippling. More images. Shadow Weaver deciding to raise Adora. Adora's first meeting with Catra, back when they were so very young. The struggles of her rigorous childhood training in the Horde. And Adora can't stand it. She can't stand seeing these pieces of her life again, not after living them. Not now that she knows what they all mean.

And worse...the Sorceress is watching it too. A thumb pressed to her lips as though she's watching a video on a digital screen, rather than a replay of Adora's whole life through a potion. Her only consolation is that, besides Adora herself, only the Sorceress seems to be able to see it. This projection of Adora's past. Though Adora doesn't trust the Sorceress with her history any more than she trusts the King and Queen with *anything at all*.

The images continue to shift. Shifting and reflecting Adora's life, one significant moment after the other. Being named first in the Horde's training. Being promoted to Force Captain. Stealing the Skiff. Finding She-Ra's sword. Meeting Glimmer and Bow while simultaneously losing Catra. Attending princess Prom, finding

Light Hope, winning the Battle of Bright Moon, journeying to the Crimson Waste, opening the portal, staging a rescue on Beast Island, activating the Heart of Etheria, Horde Prime's arrival, fighting a mind-controlled Catra, struggling to liberate Etheria, and then...destroying Horde Prime.

And god...she hoped to never relive such events again. Not after Chasm's illusion already put her through so much. But here they are again, approaching the cusp of Angella's rescue. And how long will it be, exactly, until she's forced to re-experience the horror of those illusions through this potion? Can't they stop? Hasn't Adora's identity already been confirmed?

But the Sorceress is still watching intently, like her attention could not be swayed for any price.

After that, she sees a few more milestones—more peaceful ones. Rebuilding Bright Moon and the rest of Etheria, Adora's intergalactic adventures and visits to other planets—

At this rate, Adora's trip to the plane between worlds will be shown any moment now. They're already at Catra and Adora's engagement, then their wedding, their honeymoon, and okay, that's *private*—

And worst of all, there Entrapta is—claiming that she's discovered a way to rescue Angella. Little did they all know that Chasm would come along for the ride, no matter how they tried to rid themselves of her. And Adora can't take it, she can't relive the mistake of entering that portal, and she especially can't have the Sorceress watching her, judging her foolishness—

With a cry, Adora thrusts out a hand and knocks the bowl off the tabletop—sending the potion flying. It spatters on the floor in a sticky-looking mess, but Adora doesn't care. The outburst stopped the magic, at least. Stopped the Sorceress from seeing what happened when Adora entered that portal.

Though it doesn't stop the outraged look that the King and Queen give her, however much the Sorceress seems unfazed.

"I said you could learn the truth about my origins," Adora says, her chest heaving with fear and outrage. "I didn't say you could watch a magical replay of my whole life."

There is a pause in which no one speaks. The Sorceress merely regards Adora wordlessly and passively, eyes flitting from Adora's feet to the top of her head. Adora stares her down. She's not sure what else she's supposed to do, what she's supposed to say. *If* she's supposed to say anything at all.

"So is it true?" the King demands, smashing through the silence. "Is she our daughter?"

The Sorceress gives a short chuckle. "She is more than that," she says and gives another tip of her head—another bow, this one accompanied by a triumphant smile. "She is She-Ra, Princess of Power. Slayer of Horde Prime and Savior of the Universe."

At that last part, the King and Queen's jaws drop open. And Adora can guess why. Eternia has been isolated for a millennium. If Teela did not know that Horde Prime was dead, the King and Queen were likely equally ignorant to his demise.

And equally ignorant to the cause of his death. Namely, Adora. *She-Ra*. The hero they thought they lost. The *daughter* they thought they lost.

"But yes," the Sorceress continues with a nod to the King and Queen. "She is the princess. She is your daughter. There is no hiding that fact."

But Adora wants to do just that. She wants to run. To *hide*. To disappear.

Chapter End Notes

adora: ma'am i would like to return my parents to the parents store

anyway, remember to comment please! give me some motivation to unpack my last few boxes! Next update will be Saturday, May 22nd at 6:30pm EST. Sorry again for extending the wait, I promise my life is just extraordinarily busy right now.

Chapter 16

Chapter Summary

Catra reveals some insecurities.

Teela explains Eternian royalty.

And Chasm refuses to tell Adora what she wants to hear.

Chapter Notes

hey all! welcome back to immemorial! we return to yet another chapter of adora and catra's (not really) fun adventures on Lenaria/Eternia!

also, just as a PSA since some real awful people seem to have found this fic—if you're a terf, get the fuck out of here. i would block you if i could but ao3 doesn't have that feature. my writing is absolutely not for you and i think you're terrible! so literally get out before i fucking chase you out :)

everyone else, hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora cannot ignore the guards positioned just outside of her quarters. They're there for her protection, the King and Queen would likely claim. But Adora knows that there's a dual-purpose. That the guards would likely try to stop Adora from leaving, if she tried. The King and Queen...they'd try to force her to stay, to do as they want, and She-Ra might not be able to fight them while protecting Catra at the same time—

The King and Queen. That's the only name she'll tolerate for them. Because Adora can't...she *refuses* to accept that they're her….that she's their—

Adora slams the door shut behind herself. Her hand fumbles for some sort of locking mechanism, frantically flipping the first and only lock she finds—a small latch attached to the door handle. It's a flimsy thing, but effective. She even yanks on the door a few times to make sure it's secure, the crystal hinges jangling and shrieking with her pulls. Shrieking, yes, but not giving. It doesn't open, thankfully. Not even under the stress of Adora's better-than-average strength.

Though, as soon as it's locked, Adora recalls that the guards will likely have a key. One that they can use whenever they deem necessary, whenever they please. And the last thing she needs is any of these people sneaking up on her when she leasts expects it —

Luckily, Adora has a few tricks of her own. She closes her eyes and summons a new lock, one materialized using She-Ra's magic. She affixes it carefully—wedging it between the door and the frame to keep the door closed even if the other lock is keyed open.

Once it's installed, she takes a step back, a sharp breath pulsing from her lungs. Hands on her hips, she vaguely considers whether she should barricade the door with something—some furniture, perhaps. Piled against the door to bar against all forms of entry. But that seems a bit over-the-top, and Adora doesn't want to have to remove that barricade each time she actually needs to open the door for something.

Not to mention that it would make Adora seem awfully paranoid. Which she is *not*. She is definitely not that, not paranoid.

Turning, Adora sees Catra shuffling further into the room, finally shimmying herself out from what remains of her tattered spacesuit.

"So…" mutters Catra, nose tipped downward. She refuses to meet Adora's eyes as she peels off layer upon layer of space-durable material. "You're a princess."

Catra's everyday clothes are revealed as the suit falls to the floo of polished crystal. The same crystal that seems to coat every surface of this strange castle, and this bedroom is no different. Even the somewhat excessive collection of furniture that adorns this room—the desk, the vanity, the dining table, the wardrobe—all of it, sculpted from crystal.

Only the plush bed and a twin set of arm chairs seem to be constructed of fabric. They're comfortable-looking, at least. Though Adora doesn't plan to stay long. And, obviously, she doesn't really plan to sleep while she's here.

When the meeting with the Sorceress was over, Adora and Catra were escorted to a room in the palace. A place to retire, the King and Queen said, though it was still suspiciously early in the day to do that. And somehow, she doubts that the royals actually expected them to sleep. They likely anticipated that Adora and Catra would need time to process the recent news, in private.

And of course, Adora figures that the King and Queen required the same opportunity for themselves. The same opportunity to discuss the revelation of Adora's identity. She can only imagine what they'll talk about. How much of a disappointment Adora is, perhaps, compared to whatever daughter they pictured for themselves—

Not that Adora actually *cares* about what they think of her.

But the King and Queen promised that a meal would be brought to their bedroom. So in the meantime, Adora and Catra were invited to relax, freshen up, and prepare for the following day. Though what the following day is supposed to entail, Adora has no idea. All she can hope is that it involves searching for Chasm, and little else to do with the royals that she is, by some sick twist of fate, *related to*.

With the rest of the suit effectively stripped, Catra sinks onto the bed to tug off her boots.

"And not like...a princess in the sense of like...She-Ra," Catra continues, still muttering to herself. "But like. A princess-princess. With a kingdom to rule, and everything."

And it's obvious, too obvious, that this information has upset Catra. Her ears are flattened against her head. Her eyes are downcast. And they've been that way for a while, ever since they emerged from the Sorceress's tower. The confirmation of Adora's heritage is unwelcome, evidently, by Catra. And Adora doesn't know what to do. She doesn't know how to apologize for this, for something so far outside her control—

Adora gulps. She, too, begins to strip off her spacesuit. She's quick and trembling as she half-tears it off herself, so desperate is she to be free of it and beside Catra there, on that bed.

Catra still doesn't look at Adora as she does that—as Adora frees herself from the suit. Her eyes are focused instead on the tipped-over boots on the floor. The ones that she pulled off only moments ago, but is still fixated on.

"L-look," Adora stammers, half-leaping out of the suit's pants and tossing them elsewhere, to the spot near the door. "I didn't...I didn't know. I couldn't have."

"Of course you couldn't have," Catra laughs, though it's hardly humorous. She cups one of her own hands beneath the other. "It's just…" She sighs. "It's just so fucking typical, huh? You're princess of the First Ones. Or the Eternians or, whatever—"

Adora shakes her head. She's not. She swears she's not, she doesn't know anything about these people, these people who took so much from Etheria, so much magic and peace and safety, all for their own gain. Adora doesn't want anything to do with them—

And yet, how can Catra ever look at her the same? Adora can't even look at herself the same. She's always been one of them, one of the First Ones, but she never knew *this*. She never knew that she was descended from their rulers, their royalty. And how

can she not be blamed for all the terrible things they've done? The terrible things done to Mara, to her Squadron, to Krytis, to Etheria, and to so many other planets throughout the universe?

Even Horde Prime referred to them as *tyrants*, for Etheria's sake. Horde Prime, the worst tyrant of all—

"Catra," Adora says, and falls to her knees just in front of Catra. She reaches for Catra's hands and encloses them within her own. "I'm sorry. I didn't...I wish it wasn't true. Really, I do. I don't want anything to do with these people, not after everything. Especially not after the Heart and Mara and Melog—"

And there they are, unbidden. Tears. Rapid streams of them, spilling, unstoppable, down the contours of Adora's cheeks. A sob spasms its way through her chest before she can stifle it. She sees Catra jolt, as though surprised by the sound.

Scrubbing frantically at those tears, Adora gasps, "I didn't want to know. I didn't want to know any of this. I wanted nothing to do with them, and now...now we're here, and they expect me to be their stupid *princess* or whatever, but all I want is for us to run far away from here, and never look back—"

Her vision blurs with her crying, so she's startled to feel, rather than see, Catra switching the placement of their hands so that Adora's hands are enclosed in hers.

"Adora," Catra says, softly. "Calm down. It's okay."

But Adora only sniffs and keeps going. "I understand if you don't want anything to do with me." A scoff, strangled and disbelieving. "Even I don't want anything to do with me, if this is who I am—"

Catra releases Adora's hands and instead cups her cheeks. "Adora," she says more seriously. "You being related to these people doesn't change *anything* about how I feel about you. And it doesn't change anything about you, either. You're Etherian. That's where you grew up, that's where you call home. And if

that's who you want to be, then we'll forget all about these people and move on."

Adora struggles to see, blinking and blinking those tears out of her eyes. "Then why…? You seemed so mad—"

"I wasn't mad at you, dummy," says Catra. "I'm just...annoyed, I guess. At myself."

"What?" asks Adora, flinching with the force of her surprise. "You haven't done anything wrong—"

"And neither have you," says Catra, with a small laugh. "It's just that...well…you were already the princess of all princesses back on Etheria. She-Ra. And now, apparently, you're this too. Princess of Eternia. A princess with people to rule. You've got to be one the most important people in the universe, right? And I'm just…" She gestures to herself. "Me. Some girl you met by accident. If it wasn't for that portal, I'd be out of my mind to think you'd even *look* my way—"

"Catra," Adora says, and this time, she's the one stroking her hands against Catra's cheeks. "That's not true."

"But it is," says Catra. "I mean, I doubt I'm who your parents would want as a daughter-in-law. What can I even say about myself? I once worked for the Evil Horde and tried to kill you? My accomplishments kinda stop there."

At that, Adora laughs. "That's *so* completely false, and you know it. You helped save the universe, for one. Brought the universe to peace by helping destroy Horde Prime. And then you helped return magic to planets all throughout the universe too. You're an invaluable advisor to Glimmer and the other princesses. And, of course—" She balances her forehead beneath Catra's. "You've saved me, time and time again. From Horde Prime. From Chasm. From the wild assortment of weirdos we've encountered, during all those visits to different planets. I wouldn't be here at all if it wasn't for you."

“And what if your parents disapprove of me?” Catra asks, and Adora can hardly believe that she’s worried about such a thing. As far as Adora is concerned, the more disapproval they receive from the people here, the better.

“I don’t care what the *King and Queen* of Eternia think,” Adora replies, each word clipped and pointed. “All I know is that I love you, and if those royal snobs so much as look at you funny, that’s all the more reason for us to fly away from here, and never come back.”

Catra scoffs. “Still doesn’t change the fact that you’re kinda out of my league.”

Adora smirks. “Out of your league? Are you kidding? You’re the smartest person I know in the whole universe. Not to mention gorgeous. If anything, you’re out of *my* league.”

At that, Catra laughs—loudly, and disbelievingly. She laughs for so long that Adora feels some of her anxiousness evaporate, lifting itself from her shoulders and dissipating into the air above. Adora swims in the sound of that laughter, memorizes it, as she leans down to kiss Catra’s knuckles. Her lips linger on each one as the laughs slowly dissolve into sighs.

Catra smiles broadly. “Is that really what you think?”

Adora raises her head and nods, her expression mirroring Catra’s exactly. “Oh yeah. Honestly, I don’t know how I managed to score a wife this perfect.”

“I think it’s a bit obvious,” replies Catra with another shrug. She tips Adora’s chin up with a finger. “But okay. Sure. You’re a beautiful, perfect warrior princess, and I’m the smartest woman in the universe. I suppose I can live with that.”

“Yup,” says Adora, triumphant. “And obviously we were *meant* to be together, if that portal brought me to you.”

Catra rolls her eyes but leans forward. “God, you are *such* a sap —”

Their lips meet. A mere brushing of lips at first, one that reminds Adora of the stroking of Catra’s fingers. Light, and comforting, with just the barest tease of Catra’s tongue and teeth, retreating behind her lips. Though Adora so desperately wants to deepen it, to crush Catra into the bed and steal her breath right from her lungs. She’s nearly about to do it, nearly about to wrap one arm around Catra’s back and the other behind her knees and simply rolls themselves across the mattress—

Knock. Knock.

Catra makes a noise. Some nonverbal urge for Adora to stay put, and ignore the guest just outside their door, waiting. And though Adora complies, she knows that the person won’t be delayed for long.

And sure enough—

KNOCK, KNOCK, KNOCK. Louder, and more urgently this time.

And, as predicted, Adora and Catra are forced to part, exhaling air and half-formed curses into each other's mouths. It’s clear that this guest won’t wait, or better yet, leave them undisturbed. So if they’d like to return to their current activities, they’ll have little choice but to answer—

Adora stands and, after dusting off the knees of her pants, she strides to the door. With a mere thought, she dissolves the lock she conjured, and a flick of her finger is all it takes to unlatch the second one.

She pulls the door open. And there on the other side is Teela, waiting with a hand on her hip.

Adora raises an eyebrow. “I don’t suppose you’re bringing dinner?”

“No,” replies Teela. “But I do have an important delivery.”

She punctuates the sentence by pulling a strange cart into view—one that hovers above the floor in the same way the vehicles outside hover above the ground. It’s stacked with a few boxes and bags. *Adora and Catra’s* boxes and bags, Adora realizes, upon recognizing the crate of potion doses among the piles.

“Your belongings, as requested,” says Teela, as she ushers the cart into their room. “We’ve secured the ship that brought you here. It’s stored with the rest of our vehicles, should you need it again.”

Adora crosses her arms. “*When* we need it again, you mean?”

“Well,” says Teela, with a far-too-innocent shrug, “I’ll admit—I’d prefer if you stayed.”

“Why?” demands Catra, with narrowed eyes. “Why would you bother doing any of this? Accusing Adora of being some long-lost princess, forcing her to admit to it—”

“Is it so wrong to want to reunite the royal family?” Teela wonders. Again, too innocently to be trusted.

“It is if the princess didn’t *want* to be reunited,” Catra snarls. “You tricked us. You basically ambushed Adora. I want to know why—what’s your big agenda? Why were you so desperate to prove that Adora is your long lost princess?”

“I didn’t trick you,” Teela says. “I pushed you in the right direction, perhaps. But my word holds true. I will help you find your fugitive as soon as we are able. I was merely fulfilling my duty by returning a member of our people to her rightful home—”

“This *isn’t* my rightful home,” Adora grits out. “This place...we’re here by accident. Or maybe we led her on purpose as a distraction, I don’t know. But back there...”

Adora points to the door, and what lies beyond it, down some distant hallway. The throne room where the King and Queen—her parents, supposedly—preside.

"You weren't being some charitable do-gooder, reuniting me with my family. You were making a point. You were smug. Pleased with yourself. *Why?*"

Teela merely stands there, staring, for a long time. But then, with a calculating sweep of her eyes over Adora and Catra both, she seems to relent. Seems to drop the selfless guard act, in favor of telling the truth.

"I do not wish Prince Adam to take the throne," Teela says. "He is lazy. Reckless. And is likely to sow more chaos than he solves."

Adora's eyes widen. It sounds treasonous, what Teela is saying. Expressing such adamant disapproval for the designated heir to the throne. She wonders, almost, if they should be whispering.

"And what makes you think that?" Adora asks.

If anything, Adam has proven the most likeable of Adora's relatives thus far. He was the only one who refused to pressure her, the only one who refused to *interrogate* her. So, by Adora's standards, Adam remains far more trustworthy than Teela.

"I am the Captain of the Guard," explains Teela. "I grew up around him. Ever since he was a child, he complained of his future as king. Never once has he wished for his fate. And he made that known in his teenage years, and now his adult life. He is constantly playing pranks, sneaking out, stealing our vehicles. He is consistently late for official functions, and he has no respect for our traditions—"

"Not gonna lie," Catra interrupts. "This is only making me like him more."

"He is likable enough, as a person," Teela huffs. "But he would make a terrible king. And I know that firsthand, as the person

required to defuse whatever pranks he arranges, or repair the vehicles he crashes—”

Catra snorts. “Dunno. A prankster king sounds pretty fun to me.”

“The rules of our culture are clear,” Teela continues. “Only royal children can claim the throne as the next ruler. The first born has the greatest claim, and is eligible for rule as soon as they are married. But, obviously—” She gestures to Adora. “You and Adam are twins.”

Twins. Adora never pictured herself as a sibling to anyone, let alone a twin. Up until several years ago, she probably didn’t even know what a twin *was*, the Horde had brainwashed her so.

But Teela’s meaning is now clear. Because Adam and Adora are twins...they were likely born at the same time. And therefore, they have equal claim to this throne that Teela cares about so much.

Adora grunts her annoyance and folds arms over her chest. “And let me guess...you want me to be Queen instead?”

“You would be a far more respectable ruler,” says Teela. “You are clearly a seasoned warrior and leader—”

Adora shakes her head. “You said it yourself. These people don’t like She-Ra. Not after what Mara did.”

“That won’t matter,” Teela insists, and steps closer. Her face is alight with hope, one that strikes Adora as terribly misplaced. “There is a rumor that’s spreading, overheard from the King and Queen. They say you slayed Horde Prime yourself. Is that true?”

Adora hesitates, nearly afraid to answer in fear of Teela’s reaction.

“It is true, then,” Teela exhales. “You did kill him. That’s why he told you we were gone. And that’s how you knew that *he* was gone. Gone for good. You were the one who vanquished him, the greatest enemy to our people.”

“It wasn’t just me,” Adora argues. “It was Catra, too, and many of my other friends, back on Etheria. We all worked together to destroy him—”

“All the better,” Teela laughs. “In the event of twins, only one may take the throne. And the factor that determines which twin takes it...?” A hand flies out, in Catra’s direction. “Is Marriage. Our law requires that royals be married before they rise to the position of King or Queen. We consider the power too great for one person alone.”

“Whoa, whoa, whoa—” Catra says, waving her hands. “Listen...don’t bring me into this. I’m retired from *commanding* anything—”

But Teela cannot be stopped, not even by Catra’s objection. “The fact of the matter is that you are married, and Adam is not. Which means that you can take the throne, and Adam can do as he pleases, sparing us of his reign—”

“I don’t *live here*, Teela,” Adora retorts. “I don’t have any claim to any throne.”

“You should do what’s best for your people—”

Adora can *feel* her volume inflating, threatening to evolve into a scream. She doesn’t want this. She doesn’t want to stay here, doesn’t want to rule anyone. All she wants is to capture Chasm, stop her, and leave this place. “You are not *my people*, okay?”

For too long, Teela watches her, saying nothing. Her lips pressed into a thin, almost nonexistent line. There’s an expectation there, in Teela’s eyes. One that suggests that she anticipates an apology.

But Adora has none to give. No apology, no excuse. She means her words. She does not belong here, and has no intention to stay.

“I hope you change your mind,” is Teela’s stiff response, once the silence grows too unbearable. She spins around, turning her back

to Adora like she's executing some powerful combat maneuver, shoulders cutting through the air as she strides toward the door.

Though she stops there, hand lingering over the door handle. "I will be the one to rouse you tomorrow morning. You will eat breakfast with your family, and then I shall aid in the tracking of your fugitive."

Adora squints at her. "And you're still willing to do that? To help us?"

"Like I said, I will remain true to my word," Teela answers. "Even if you disappoint me, with this attitude of yours. Forgive me if I continue to hope that you rise to your destiny."

"Please don't hold your breath," Adora says. "Way too many people have tried to tell me what my destiny is. I don't need another perspective."

To that, Teela doesn't have a reply. She simply throws open the door and exits, pulling it closed behind herself like one might thrust a weapon into a sleeping body.

And Adora can only wish that she never found this place. Birthplace or not.

Their meal has been delivered to them (thankfully, not by Teela, after that last encounter). After it's finished—though Adora doesn't have much of an appetite, and finds herself rather repulsed by this strange First Ones food—they attempt to call Bow and Glimmer back on Etheria. They're frustrated to discover that the call cannot go through. All transmissions swallowed by the Sorceress's magic, Adora can only assume. In the hope of keeping Eternos hidden.

Adora knows it must be terrifying, back home. Their friends must be desperate for news about Adora and Catra's progress. And because of this place...because of the Sorceress...Adora can't even provide that. She will have to leave them in the dark about

what's happening until Chasm is defeated, and they leave this place.

Or...if they fail to defeat Chasm…

What will they think, back home? Will they assume that Adora just abandoned them to their fates, after ruining their lives so completely?

But *no*, Adora tries to remind herself of Catra's words. She needs to stop blaming herself for Chasm's actions. Chasm led them here on purpose. She knew this place would render Adora isolated, frightened, *overwhelmed*.

But *how* she knew about this place…

That is another question entirely.

Without much else to do, Catra begins preparing herself for bed. Adora, meanwhile, downs another vial of potion. Her eyes scan the box of remaining doses. Nine left. No more, no less. Never has time seemed so finite as when Adora stares at these remaining bottles.

Now changed into pajamas, Catra walks to the bed and untucks the covers. She stands there for a few moments. Then, with a flashing look at Adora, she says, "Are you planning to spend the night in bed, or elsewhere?"

Adora can detect the *want* in Catra's voice. She wants Adora there, lying beside her in that bed—one that will likely feel unfamiliar and strange beneath their bodies. And Adora wants it just as much. To hold Catra. To curl up at her side, with legs tangled and arms flung haphazard over torsos and chests. Protecting each other, even in sleep.

But she can't. Not tonight. Tonight...Adora has something she needs to do. Something that Catra will likely disapprove of.

But Adora has questions. Questions to ask, and things to assert.

“I wish I could,” Adora says, and sinks into the nearest chair. A desk chair, specifically. One that’s somewhat uncomfortable, formed of pure crystal like it is to match the accompanying desk. “But I’d only be too jealous of you, getting to sleep. I’d do anything to just shut my eyes and…” She exhales deeply. “...escape this place.”

Catra can’t quite hide her disappointment—the flattening of her ears and the forced nodding of her head—but she doesn’t argue. “Alright. You can wake me if you need anything, okay? I won’t mind.”

Adora smiles and gives a nod of her own. “I know.”

Catra climbs into bed, hoisting the covers over herself and settling onto her side. She switches off a lamp on the bedside table, and without it, Adora’s desk light is all that remains in terms of illumination. A weak, cool glow from a narrow bulb.

But Adora can still sense Catra watching her, from the bed. Not yet able to sleep. And Catra has never had much need for light, after all. She can see as well in darkness as she can in a bright room. Such is the benefit of her unique senses.

“Do you think these people would help Chasm repair the sword?” Catra whispers, interrupting the short but weighty nighttime silence. “Or do you think she plans to trick them, just like she tried to trick us?”

Adora shrugs. “She could be tricking us right now. This could all be a distraction. Maybe she’s fled the planet already—”

Adora hears the rustle of hair against fabric—the sound of Catra shaking her head, even while lying against the pillow. “No,” says Catra, resolute. “She’s here. She’s here, and she’s plotting something. We need to ask Teela to help find her, yeah…but we also need to find whatever it is that allowed them to make that sword in the first place, and destroy it.”

A sigh blusters past Adora's lips. "They might not like that idea. The Eternians."

"For the good of the universe," Catra mutters, "they'll have to do it. By now, they should know better than to control magic that doesn't belong to them."

She hears Catra turn over, the mattress creaking just slightly. "Goodnight, Adora. Try to relax, okay?"

Adora nods. "I will. Sweet dreams, Catra."

She hears Catra give a short laugh. "The sweetest dreams, actually. Of me, utterly *ravishing* you in that dress Chasm stole, and vice versa."

Adora snorts. "Maybe when we catch her, I'll make that dream a reality."

"Promise?"

"Promise."

Catra gives a pleased hum, and she somehow sounds more determined than ever. "Chasm won't know what hit her," she whispers contentedly, and rolls over.

And that's the last thing Catra says, before her words are replaced by gentle snores. Snores, rather than purrs. Purring is reserved exclusively for the nights that Adora shares the bed with her. Something that Adora does not wish to do tonight, for fear of doing what she did last time she tried this—for fear of waking Catra within her arms.

Adora shifts in the desk chair, trying to make herself comfortable. If she's going to do this, she must be completely relaxed. Her mind emptied of worries and thoughts—quieted, so that terrible things are free to slither from the dark corner they occupy, in Adora's mind.

Terrible things like Chasm.

She shuts her eyes, breathes deeply. Over and over again, she breathes deeply, focusing only on the rise and fall of her own chest and the white noise of the surrounding room. Her focus narrows to Catra's snores, in particular. Their rhythm, their unique sound. She lets them lull her into peace, just as they have in the past, whenever Adora has struggled to sleep.

Though she won't be sleeping now. Beneath the influence of *Essence of Eternity,* meditation is all she can accomplish. But that should be more than enough to do this, to speak with—

"*You rang*?" whispers a voice, the words oozing across Adora's hearing—pouring directly into her ear. It makes Adora shudder.

She opens her eyes. And there, floating directly before her, is Chasm. Red skin glistening in the low lamplight. White eyes and hair near-phosphorescent in the half-darkness. Adora notices, vaguely, that she has no appearance of legs. She floats in the air like mist, limbs concealed in a cloak of darkness that fades into her surroundings.

"I thought Catra warned you against seeking me out," smirks Chasm. All arrogance, just like always, with that cruel smile spread across her lips. "And yet, here you are. I thought you'd be better at keeping your wife's trust."

"I want to know how," Adora grits out. "I want to know how you found them—the Eternians."

And this time, she's prepared for the way her voice projects, even without the movement of her lips to accompany it. Her words echo into the room as though carried from some hidden speaker, thrust into sound without any evident source.

It's a strange affordance of the shared illusion. But it's one that will keep Catra asleep, at least.

Chasm gives a close-mouthed laugh, like the question is quaint, and all too predictable. “As much as I would like to pretend that it was some sort of miraculous feat, finding this place…”

She appraises the nearby bedroom, her not-quite-eyes jolting about in an effort to examine the different articles of furniture. “It wasn’t exactly hard. Really, all it took was a simple location spell.”

Adora’s jaw clacks shut in surprise. Finished with her examination of the bedroom, Chasm spins around and shoots Adora a mocking pout. And obviously, she knows that Adora wants to hear otherwise. Like she knows that Adora wishes it was difficult—nearly impossible, even— for Chasm to find the planet that houses Adora’s people.

“Oh dear.” Chasm rests a hand on her own collarbone. “You were hoping for a better excuse, weren’t you?”

Adora’s fists clench, at her sides. “I don’t know what you’re talking about.”

Chasm huffs a large, aggrieved sigh. “It’s no use hiding things from me, you know,” Chasm reminds hers. “I’m in your head. Whatever lies you tell to yourself, or to me…” Another laugh. “They just make the situation more embarrassing for yourself, with the truth so easily gleaned from your own memories.”

Adora still doesn’t respond. Even if she wished to, she wouldn’t know what to say.

“Come now, sweet girl,” Chasm says. “It’s no use pretending. You had access to magic—to sorcerers. You could have asked Glimmer or Micah or Castaspella to cast a location spell at any time, if you wanted to find this place.”

Adora purposely looks away, toward the floor.

“But you didn’t,” Chasm says. “You refused to. Just as you refused to throw away that sword. So afraid were you, of letting go. Afraid

of letting go of this fear of who you are, and who you were born to—”

“I’m not afraid,” Adora insists, but it sounds like a lie. Even to her own ears. And surely it must sound like a lie to Chasm’s, with Adora’s truth so close within her reach.

“Of course you’re not,” laughs Chasm, sarcastic. “I’m sure all brave heroes act as you do. They keep boxes of broken metal to keep themselves terrified of who they are.”

“It was a reminder,” Adora insists. “That the First Ones couldn’t be trusted. Every time I even thought about finding them, I knew all I’d have to do is look at that sword, and realize that I shouldn’t. That I should stay as far as possible from these...these monsters —”

“And what are you,” Chasm asks, “if not princess of the monsters?”

Adora shakes her head fervently. “I won’t be.”

“Teela likely won’t give you a choice,” Chasm says. “And neither will the King and Queen. You know that, just as I do. You can defend yourself, certainly. But nothing will keep them from taking Catra hostage—from threatening her, just like I did.”

Adora glances at Catra, still fast asleep in bed, then returns her attention to Chasm’s grinning sneer.

“I won’t do what they want,” Adora swears to herself. “And I won’t do what you want, either. I’m going to keep you from repairing the sword. There’s no way in the universe I’m letting you anywhere close to what you’re looking for.”

Chasm makes a tsk-tsk noise. “How inconsiderate,” she complains. “Especially when I did you the great service of reuniting you with your family. For you mortals, that’s all that matters, isn’t it? Carrying and leaving a legacy through blood? Through family?”

“They’re not my family,” Adora argues. “And you...you’re going to lose. No matter how many fears you pull from my brain and make real, no matter how many traps you set, no matter distractions you push into my path, I’m going to stop you.”

“You only brought this on yourself, you know,” Chasm says, and Adora hates it. She hates the mocking gentleness in Chasm’s voice. “If you had only dealt with the sword earlier...dealt with the sword, and its creators...you’d have nothing to fear from me beyond a few bad dreams. And you’d have a family to claim, rather than fear.”

“And what do you know about family?” Adora demands. “You’re an unfeeling monster—”

“Monster, perhaps,” Chasm concedes, with a small shrug. “But unfeeling? How I wish that were true.” She mists closer to Adora, arched over her in that intimidating, predatory way of hers. “You know nothing about me, do you? Nothing about what’s been done to me throughout the centuries.”

Adora stares, mouth slightly ajar and muscles tense. Of course she knows little about Chasm’s long, perhaps eternal history. No one does. Only Angella, who read so many books about Chasm in the plane between worlds, might understand the events of Chasm’s past. But all Adora has ever known is that Chasm is old, and incorporeal, and powerful, and *feared*. A being of pure magic unlike any other.

“No, you most certainly do not,” Chasm hums. “Perhaps you should ask her. You, of all people, should understand what it’s like to suffer without a choice in your destiny. And perhaps then you will not be so quick to judge me.”

It takes too long for Adora to parse those words. And during that time, Chasm begins to retreat, fading into the darkness as though being swallowed by it. Leaving the illusion, bit by bit, and severing Adora’s ability to communicate with her in the process.

Adora squints. “Ask who?”

“The Sorceress, of course,” whispers Chasm, as the last wisps of her red skin begin to dissipate. “She knows a great deal about my suffering, I’m sure.”

And then she’s gone, leaving Adora alone in a silent room. Silent, save the sound of Catra’s snores, which continue uninterrupted.

Chapter End Notes

see you next week, same time same place! remember to comment!

Chapter 17

Chapter Summary

The royals have an awkward family breakfast.

Catra, Adora, and Teela plot to defeat Chasm.

And the Sorceress answers some key questions.

Chapter Notes

hey all! sorry for posting so late, i had a busy day today and only just got home now.

we're onto another chapter of adora and catra's adventures on Eternia...and we've also got a few more bombshells left to drop!

also, forgot to thank everyone last week for helping get this fic to 1k kudos. Even more impressive, I think, is the number of comments this fic has had so far, and gets every week. Please keep it up! It means the world to get feedback.

anyway, hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Breakfast is a painfully awkward event.

The royal family is seated alone in a large dining room. One with an absurdly large crystal table, its surface utterly piled with what Catra *assumes* to be food, though none of it is familiar. Her only knowledge of First Ones' cuisine comes from dinner last night, as well as her short time on Mara's ship—though those rations likely don't compare to what's served to Eternian royals.

Still. Throughout her life, Catra has traveled to plenty of planets with strange foods. She has a strategy: take one of each of the

items that smell the most appetizing, nibble at bit, and then take more of the best-tasting dishes.

She sits beside Adora, across from Prince Adam. He, at least, smiles at them consistently, and pleasantly. The same can't be said of the King and Queen, who occupy the opposite ends of the table. They continue to exchange pointed glances with one another. And when they're not doing that, they're staring at Adora with frightful intensity.

Adora shrinks under their scrutiny. It's clear from the renewed dark circles beneath her eyes that Adora's exhaustion is starting to take a more significant toll on her. It's now been nearly a week without sleep for Adora, and though she's more accustomed to all-nighters than most, she can only stave off symptoms of sleep deprivation for so long.

She's somewhat distant and vacant during breakfast, more focused on poking at her food with a fork than she is on answering Adam's questions—which are numerous, and frequent. He is the primary driver of conversation, as the King and Queen have evidently elected to remain silent and staring.

"So you must have flown a ship to get to Lenaria," says Adam, all excitement and barely-suppressed good humor. Catra is startled by the color of his eyes, which are the exact same gray-blue as Adora. Not a common color in the least. "What's that like?"

Since Catra was fortunate enough to sleep a few hours last night, she steps up and answers—especially when it becomes clear that Adora has no intention to do so, with her attention so devotedly focused on the strange collection of glowing berries on her plate

"What's what like?" Catra asks. "Flying to Lenaria?"

"No," says Adam. "Space, in general."

Catra raises an eyebrow. "You've never been to space?"

Not, of course, that Catra can really judge that. Catra's first trip into space was a little over five years ago. Before then, Etheria was trapped in Despondos, and there wasn't exactly much to explore beyond the surface of Etheria itself.

But Eternia obviously has the technology, and the surrounding planets. So why is traveling through space such a foreign concept to someone like Adam? The heir to the throne should likely know more about surrounding cultures, if only for diplomacy's sake.

"We're forbidden to leave the planet," huffs a suddenly-petulant Adam, his chin drooping into his hand. "The thought was that if we revealed our presence to outsiders, they would lead Horde Prime to our door. So we stay in our little boring bubble."

Catra hears Adora make a sound. A scoff, almost. Though there's a strange assent to it, like she agrees with that forbiddance—the Eternians' choice to stay hidden from the rest of the universe. And knowing Adora, she probably does.

"But I wish to see the wider universe," says Adam. And then, more quietly, but just loud enough to be heard, "I wish I was not Eternian at all."

"Adam!" exclaim the King and Queen, in unison. An outraged exclamation, though not a surprised one. Judging by their tone—and Teela's complaints from last night—Catra can surmise that Adam must make such a wish rather often. Often enough that his parents have tired of it.

"What?" demands Adam, from his parents. "Most young people do, you know. No one wants to be stuck in the same place forever. And besides, what's there to brag about, except having lost a war and ruined half the universe?"

"You're not that young anymore, Adam," Marlena argues, eyes narrowed at her son. "It is time that you made peace with who you are, and act like an adult."

“Better yet,” the King interjects. “Act like a *prince*, for once. And show your heritage some respect.”

There is a tense silence, after that. One that leaves Adam sitting with his chin balanced upon his knuckle, and his eyes affixed the table’s surface.

Catra is almost startled when Adora speaks. Especially after such a long and decided silence.

“We’re twins, right?” she asks. “So you’re close to 26, right? Like me?”

The question is directed at Adam, who blinks a bit at the sound of her voice—so new is it to him. He watches as she very pointedly twirls some food onto her fork, then shovels it into her mouth. Her eyebrows raise and, with a full mouth that is *definitely* un-ladylike and childish, she remarks, “That seems plenty young to me.”

Her half-chewed food is on full display as she says the words, and Catra stifles a snort.

And then he’s smiling again, at Adora. Blue eyes shining in the same way hers do, when she shares a quiet laugh with Catra or one of their other friends. The gleam that usually accompanies an inside joke.

After that, Adora is less resistant to Adam’s questions, and actually joins Catra in answering them. And he certainly has plenty of questions. It seems that Adam wishes to know every detail of Adora’s life. Every detail about a universe beyond Eternia, really.

“Our childhoods were...complicated,” Adora explains, when Adam asks what it was like to grow up on Etheria. “An offshoot of the Horde—one started by a stranded clone named Hordak—tried to establish an empire on our planet. An empire situated in an area called the Fright Zone. Young orphans like me and Catra—” She drops a hand on Catra’s shoulder. “We were raised as soldiers for

Hordak. Trained to conquer the rest of Etheria, and fight off the rebellion staged by the princesses who ruled the other kingdoms."

Adam's eyes widen, troubled as he is by this information. And from the corner of her eye, Catra can see the King and Queen stiffen as well.

"That's terrible," Adam murmurs. "How did you escape?"

"I found the sword. She-Ra's sword," Adora says. "That's why I was brought to Etheria in the first place. An old computer program made by your people—Light Hope—she was programmed to activate this thing called the Heart of Etheria. the ancient superweapon you guys apparently planned to use against Horde Prime. But she couldn't do it without a First One."

"A First One?" Adam repeats, confused. And Catra recalls what Teela said about that name for Adora's people. That it was outdated and arrogant. Perhaps it's old enough that Adam has never once heard it.

Adora shakes her head. "An *Eternian*, I mean. The sword was programmed to only be used by an Eternian. So Light Hope opened a portal and stole one. Stole *me*." She sighs. "And then one day, she sent me the sword."

"And how did the sword help you and Catra escape this...regime...you were forced to join?" asks Adam.

Adora and Catra share a meaningful glance. It's still a difficult topic to discuss—their separation during the war, the battles they waged upon each other, and the mutual suffering that occurred as a result.

"I met people, when I found the sword," Adora says, each word slow and carefully selected. "Good people. Princesses from one of the rebel kingdoms. They showed me that the Horde was wrong. And they convinced me to defect. I became a rebel instead."

Of course, Adam's eyes slide to Catra. He is too curious to ignore the omission of Catra's backstory.

Catra gulps, then says, "I wasn't so...open-minded, okay? I stayed with the Horde for a long while. Adora and I were best friends before she found the sword. But her defection hurt me a lot. When I took it personally, we became enemies on opposite sides of a war. Enemies, until Horde Prime attacked our planet. And I decided to finally join the rebellion."

Adam smirks. "And fall in love with your once-enemy, evidently."

Catra laughs a bit and takes Adora's hand, beneath the table. "Yeah, well. I was kinda in love with her since we were kids. I guess there's a fine line between it—hating someone and being in love with them."

"Not to mention the inherent sexual tension of like...trying to defeat and outsmart each other," mutters Adora, with a mischievous flick of her eyes in Catra's direction.

Catra lightly kicks her beneath the table and shoots a nervous glance at Adora's parents. Though it's no use—however much Adora sought to quiet herself, the King and Queen have nonetheless heard Adora's addition. The King clears his throat loudly, while the Queen merely shakes her head.

But Adam doesn't seem to notice. Instead, he sighs deeply—seemingly overcome by envy.

"Your lives sound so interesting," says Adam. "Much more interesting than here, anyway. Nothing ever happens here."

And Catra is a bit stunned by that statement, really. She can't believe that someone would *wish* to live the trauma that Adora and Catra did. All the fights, the tortures, the manipulations. Sure, there was action and adventure involved...but none of those adventures ended happily until Horde Prime's final defeat, and Catra and Adora's reunion.

Wasn't it only half a year ago that Adora and Catra were miserable, convinced that they were trapped in a repeat of their past? Apart, and forced to re-commit their most terrible acts of war? They could hardly stand it. Every day, they prayed that their friends would rescue them. And only upon discovering that it was an illusion—an illusion conjured by Chasm—did they feel any relief.

Catra finds her gaze drawn to the nearby windows, her eyes searching the distant horizon.

Chasm...who is still out there, somewhere. And planning to take control of She-Ra with the remains of the original sword.

How she plans to do it, Catra doesn't know for sure. But she suspects that the Eternians will play some vital role in Chasm's plan, whatever it is.

"Trust me," Adora says, interrupting Catra's fearful contemplation of Chasm's intentions. Adora's voice is grim and ragged as she speaks, and Catra imagines her own voice would sound similar, if she were forced to respond to Adam's wistfulness. "Interesting lives have their costs. Living a boring life is far safer, in the long run. Even if the stories aren't as exciting."

"Maybe," says Adam with a shrug. "But I would still like to meet the love of my life on the battlefield. That sounds awfully romantic."

"Oh dear—" interrupts a voice. "Is his highness now planning to start a war in the name of love?"

Catra turns to see Teela striding into the dining room, her helmet clutched beneath her arm. It's the first time that Catra has seen Teela with her face fully exposed. Her features are surprisingly delicate for someone so muscular and combative by shape and personality. Though Catra now recalls, vaguely, that Teela must have inherited her red hair from her father. She remembers the color from their brief encounter with the Man-At-Arms yesterday.

Teela rolls her eyes and places herself, standing, beside the Queen's chair. "How very original of you, Prince Adam. I'd implore you to pick a method less likely to result in innocent lives being slaughtered."

The Queen chuckles, "He is certainly being melodramatic today, Teela. I fear Adora's tales of grandeur have gone to his head." She cranes her neck to look at Teela more directly. "What brings you to our breakfast, Captain?"

Teela nods at Adora and Catra, across the table. "I'm here to collect the princess and her wife. They requested my help in tracking down a fugitive that had fled to Lenaria. That was how the princess arrived at our doorstep in the first place."

"A fugitive?" The Queen hums. "Well. This fugitive likely thought the planet was abandoned, correct? I'm sure they'll be quite surprised to find themselves within our capture."

"Yes, my Queen," Teela replies. "They'll soon learn better."

The Queen waves her hand. "Very well. You are excused, Adora."

At that, Adora tenses noticeably. Clearly, Adora didn't realize that *needed to be* excused to leave the table. Her movements are stilted and forceful as she shoots to her feet, throwing her napkin on the table as she shoves her way out of her seat.

"Come on, Catra," Adora says, giving Catra's arm a light but fleeting tug as she begins marching from the room, her teeth clenched tightly together as she walks.

Teela conveys them to a distant room within the castle. One that's not unlike the war room in Bright Moon. Though it's some cross between that and Entrapta's workshop in Dryl. Adora notes that there are projections everywhere—onto the walls, the floors, the tabletops. And there are many of those. Many tables and chairs, some of them occupied by Teela's fellow guards. Guards who

seem to be monitoring a great many security checkpoints, or other locations of interest.

Though when Teela leads Adora into the room, their responsibilities fall away in favor of this new, higher priority: the opportunity to look up, and stare at Adora. Stare openly, and then keep staring until Adora feels a cold fist of discomfort close around her spine.

Certainly, they know that she is She-Ra. She wonders if that's all they know. Have they yet heard that Adora is their long lost princess, ridiculous as it is? Or have other rumors spread just as readily? Do they look at her and see Horde Prime's slayer?

Adora would prefer to be known as the latter, rather than the former.

"I did not call a break," Teela barks to the guards when their staring drags too long. "Back to your work."

And then, as though broken from a trance, the various guards' drop their attention and return to their previous tasks. It's suddenly like Adora isn't really in the room at all.

Teela beckons them forward, toward a large table at the center of the room. The largest table, in fact, round and crystalline like the rest of the furniture in the castle. When she approaches, a large hologram of the planet—Lenaria—is projected above the tabletop, hovering in the air like some enormous glowing ornament.

"Now," says Teela, arranging herself around the table as Adora and Catra follow suit. "Tell me about your fugitive."

Adora and Catra trade hesitant looks. It's unclear how much, exactly, they should reveal. It could be especially dangerous to reveal that Chasm wishes to reactivate the sword. Adora is worried about how Teela would react to that—this potential opportunity for the Eternians to regain control of She-Ra's power.

But she also doesn't want to put the Eternians in danger by concealing too much information. Chasm is a threat to everyone and anything, regardless of whether she can possess the populace. From what Catra described, her ability to cast spells is just as powerful as her ability to infect minds.

So...best to tell the truth. Or something close to it.

"She calls herself Chasm," Adora explains. "And she's not exactly *one* fugitive...but several."

At this, Teela raises a curious eyebrow.

"She's a magical entity. An ancient one, one who was trapped in a plane between dimensions, but recently escaped. She has no real body. She's just a spirit, really. And her main ability is infecting people's minds—attaching herself to them like a parasite, and then feeding off their misery and fear to make herself more powerful."

Teela's eyes widen. "Should I be concerned for my people? Should I raise some sort of alarm?"

"No," says Adora. "That symbol you all wear—the one that looks like a collection of spirals covered in lines—it's a ward against her. People can't be infected with her so long as they wear it. Which everyone here seems to do religiously, so that's good."

"On Etheria, though," Catra interrupts, "that wasn't the case. She infected pretty much everyone. And when she infects someone, it's pretty awful. She casts a sleep spell on them, and then tortures them with these terrible dreams. Illusions she conjures to break her victims, usually constructed from her victims' own worst memories."

Teela brings a hand beneath her own chin, still-processing this, admittedly, *unbelievable* development. "And what exactly happens when she breaks them? Her victims?"

Adora swallows. “They die,”she says. “Or, at least, their minds do. And Chasm gains full control of their bodies when she’s rid of them.”

She sees Teela’s lips part in horror, her gaze finding Adora’s across the table—searching for some loophole or other consolation. “But...the people on Etheria?”

“Most of them are fine,” Adora assures her. “For now, at least. We have a way to wake her victims—keep them from falling under her spell. But it doesn’t remove her attachment to them. We need to catch her, and use She-Ra to destroy her for good.”

Teela’s eyes narrow at Adora. “But you and Catra do not wear the symbol. How are you not infected?”

A pause, as Adora’s eyes find Catra’s. Catra wears a worried look, one that’s quickly smothered.

“Catra is immune,” says Adora, with a wave of her hand. “She managed to shatter Chasm’s spell before she was powerful enough to forge a full connection. Apparently, if you break her spell that completely, it can’t be cast again.”

“And you?” Teela urges.

“What about me?”

“How have you avoided infection?”

Adora hesitates. How can she begin to explain that she *is* infected? That she drinks a potion every night to counteract Chasm’s magic, and keep herself awake and free of Chasm’s influence?

Not that she’s *entirely* free of that influence, either. Chasm can still watch her every move from behind Adora’s eyes. She’s likely watching right now. Watching, as Adora scrambles to find Chasm somewhere on this barren wasteland of planet.

And that's not to mention that conversation from last night—

"She-Ra keeps me immune," Adora says, and she pointedly ignores the expression Catra makes in response—blinking eyes and furrowed brows. Aware of the lie, and questioning why Adora deemed it necessary. "And that's beside the point, anyway. The point is that she killed a few guards on Etheria, and that's how she escaped our planet. In their bodies, on a stolen spaceship. Specifically, *our* spaceship. Catra's and mine's. The one we took here was a loaner."

Teela nods. "And is there anything else I should know?"

"She's a powerful sorcerer," Catra says, one hand rubbing idly at her arm—the place where Chasm's spells created varied cuts and burns, back when she was in control of Adora's body. "Very powerful. Your guards need to be prepared for a serious fight."

"Not just that," adds Adora, with a sigh. Eyes closing as she gathers the resolve to say this, and accept whatever consequences might arise. "We believe she's here for a reason, on Eternia. Though we didn't know that reason until we discovered the city here."

Teela freezes, expectant of it. The reason.

"We believe she wants to reconstruct the Sword of Protection," Adora says. "She wants to control She-Ra's power, on top of her own. And by reconstructing the sword, she can do whatever she wants with that power. Give it to whoever she wants. And force them to destroy whatever she pleases."

Catra nods. "Whatever you people used to create the sword in the first place...we need to find it, and destroy it. For good."

Shaking her head, Teela says, "I do not know of such a thing. The manner in which we created the sword has been lost to us for centuries. Only the Sorceress has that knowledge. And after so many of our people were killed because of She-Ra's…" She glances at Adora warily, then seems to choose her words more

carefully. "...*change of heart*, she swore to seal such knowledge away."

"Yeah, well," Catra huffs. "We need to make sure that *knowledge* stays sealed away." Her gaze joins Adora's yet again. "We should probably ask her. And likely increase her guard."

"You should also increase your perimeter guard," Adora says, pointing to the projection of Lenaria, and the area where Eternos should be. "She's going to try to sneak into the city. I know it."

Teela chuckles. "Do you think I have not already done so, when you mentioned that you were seeking a fugitive?"

She presses a series of buttons on a nearby console. At her touch, a collection of blue dots appear on the planet's projection.

"These are the guards I have stationed there, at the perimeter. Triple our usual amount. And considering that Princess Adora broke through our gateway lock so easily, I have disabled it for the time being. The gateway will now only permit specific guards to pass through, with their identities verified by magical recognition of the Sorceress's own design. In the meantime…"

Teela presses more buttons. And this time, the blue dots are exchanged for a single red one.

"Our sensors detected this. A different ship, one that landed a few days before yours. But as I mentioned yesterday...we do not reveal ourselves unless visitors draw too close to our city. You'd be surprised how many people visit abandoned planets like this one. We'd hardly want to interact with every one."

"That's gotta be her," Adora says, so focused on the dot that red sears into her eyes. "Chasm. Biding her time."

"We'll send a squadron of guards to the place she landed," Teela says. "I'll prepare a team as soon as possible. I'm a little concerned that we can't detect life forms to go with the ship, but

if this *Chasm* is as good a sorcerer as you say, she could be casting a concealment spell of her own."

"I'll go with you—" Adora begins, but Teela raises a hand to cut her off.

"The King and Queen would disapprove of me sending you into a fight so soon, especially when you just returned to them."

"I'm She-Ra," Adora insists, indignant. "I'm more than capable of holding my own in a fight. "

But Teela only shakes her head. "As are we. But if you truly insist on going, I don't think I can stop you. I'll prepare a squadron."

"When do we leave?"

"As soon as possible," replies Teela. "But first…" She sighs enormously. "I *suppose* we should visit the Sorceress and seek information on how Chasm might be able to reconstruct the sword."

"And she's the only person who could possibly know?" asks Adora, dreading another unsettling encounter with that strange Sorceress in the tower. "There's no one else we can ask?"

"No one," says Teela, with another sigh. Like she, too, would avoid the Sorceress if she could. "The Sorceress was the one who created the sword, thousands of years ago."

Adora tenses with fear. "She *what*?"

Teela waves a dismissive hand. "It's...complicated. It was the Sorceress, yes. But also a *different* Sorceress."

Blinking, Adora replies, "I don't understand."

"Probably would be best if we let *her* explain," Teela grits out, uttering the word *her* like it's some sort of curse. She presses a button on the nearby console to turn off the projection at the

center of the table—the light dissipating into a million scattered pixels before fading into nothing. She then turns back to the door, head jerking in an invitation to follow.

"Come, princess. Let us hope that she agrees to talk to you. She doesn't speak to just anyone, after all."

Adora bristles at the way Teela says that word, *princess*. It's almost mocking, and altogether too similar to how Catra has used it in the past. Only Catra is allowed to call her that. And obviously, Adora knows that she's *technically* a princess in more than one sense of the word, but still. It's the tone that matters.

But Adora knows it's not worth the argument. "Come on," she grumbles to Catra. "Let's go talk to the weird Sorceress."

For the second time in two days, Adora and Catra climb the numerous stairs that lead to the top of the stone tower. The only significant difference in this climb, however, is Teela's presence.

Teela, who hesitated at the door at the bottom of the stairs. Almost like she couldn't believe that the door opened for them—and worried that it might slam shut in her face.

She doesn't look any more pleased about this climb than Adora and Catra do. She keeps her eyes trained on the steps, and the steps only, as though that might allow her to ignore all other aspects of her surroundings.

When they reach the door at the height of the stairs, Teela moves aside—gesturing for Adora to give the knock that announces their presence. Adora shoots her a questioning look as a result. She's still very much a stranger in this place, and certainly doesn't feel comfortable barging into the Sorceress's...*abode*...without warning, or at least someone that the Sorceress is more welcoming toward.

"The Sorceress only speaks to *important* individuals," Teela mutters. "Royalty, yes. But Captain of the Royal Guard? Not so

much."

Her bitterness is thick, palpable. An acrid coating over every word.

Adora doesn't question Teela further. With a raised hand and unsteady feet, she approaches the door. She raps her knuckles once against it. Hard, and resonantly. Just as she saw the Queen do yesterday.

She's equal parts relieved and unsettled when the door again ceases to be solid—fading in color until it appears transparent before them. This time, at least, Adora is a bit less nervous to step through it. Though she whirls around to ensure that Teela and Catra follow closely behind.

"Princess Adora," calls that airy voice. "You have decided to visit me yet again." A delighted sort of hum. "And you've once again brought guests."

Once Catra is safely by her side, Adora turns to face the Sorceress—who sits in a chair, a book folded in her lap.

She looks no different than she did yesterday. Still eerily pale in both hair and complexion. Still dressed in those white robes, the ones covered in those strange metallic feathers. Feathers that glint in the odd almost-torchlight of the room. Though Adora can't really identify the source of that illumination, save for that slim window between the bookcases.

The Sorceress raises an expectant eyebrow. She's waiting for Adora to explain why she's here.

Adora gives another enormous swallow, then says, "We have questions for you, Sorceress. Several of them."

A smile spreads across the Sorceress's lips. It's not quite soft, not quite sarcastic. It's not quite anything at all. Somehow, that smile is as emotionless as a blank face—a smile that fails to touch the Sorceress's eyes or crease her cheeks. And as she stands, that

empty smile bobs upward with the rest of her. Carried as any hollow ornament would be.

"I live to serve Eternia, princess," the Sorceress says, with a tip of her head. A bow. "And if that means serving its royals, I will provide any aid I can."

And Adora still isn't really comfortable with that either—with being one of Eternia's royals. But if it will permit her access to the information she needs, she can't afford to complain.

So, with glances at Teela, then Catra—as though asking for their permission to proceed, but receiving no clear answers—Adora clears her throat and begins to speak.

"The Sword of Protection," Adora says. "The one that once controlled She-Ra...Teela says that you were the one to create it. Is that true?"

The Sorceress hesitates. "In a sense...yes. I did. But I also did not."

Adora makes a disbelieving noise. "And what does *that* mean? How can you do something yet *not* do something?"

"Well," begins the Sorceress. "You should know something of my nature, wielding She-Ra as you do. A She-Ra of six thousand years ago helped us win a war against the planet Paothea. But responsibility for that feat would not fall to you, as She-Ra was hosted by another, at the time."

Adora inhales sharply. "You're...you're like me?"

"The Sorceress of Castle Grayskull has watched over Eternia since time immemorial," she says. "She is a being of pure magic. One who occupies a single, willing host. I am one of such hosts. There were thousands more before me, and hopefully, there will be many more after me."

The Sorceress gestures to Adora, a movement that starts at Adora's feet and ends at the crown of her head.

"And while She-Ra passes power from host to host...the Sorceress primarily passes *knowledge*. Knowledge of magic, of her past lives, so long as she limits herself to Castle Grayskull."

"Castle Grayskull?" Adora repeats, glancing around. "But the King and Queen said this was *Tower* Grayskull."

The Sorceress nods. "Surely, you must have noticed that this tower doesn't quite match the rest of the architecture. It was severed from a larger castle, back on Eternia. We did not have time to save the whole building before Horde Prime arrived, so we preserved only this section." She gestures to the stone walls that surround her on all sides. "The Sorceress's sanctuary."

"Why?" asks Adora, as she searches the tower for some special attribute—something to make it worth transporting across the entire universe. There are interesting objects stored here, certainly. Books and instruments and that lovely-looking telescope, which continues to gleam in the window's streaming sunlight. But she can't identify anything special about the tower itself, or the stones that comprise it.

"Outside this tower, the Sorceress is powerless," the Sorceress explains. "Every stone in this tower is enchanted with runes, ones carved at the very center of the stones themselves. Runes that, when combined, render the larger tower a conduit for magic—the very magic that sustains the Sorceress's spirit, as well as the protections that secure what remains of Eternia."

Stones, Adora thinks. Stones that act as conduits for magic.

"So what you're saying is…" Adora replies slowly, her head still swiveling to take in the full sight of the room, "this whole tower is...a *runestone*?"

The Sorceress gives yet another emotionless smile and nods. "The first runestone. And until recently, until you revealed that Etheria

and She-Ra had escaped destruction…we thought it was one of only two remaining runestones in existence."

"One of two?" interrupts Catra. "What was the other one?"

The Sorceress hesitates, her lips parted. And it becomes immediately clear to Adora that the Sorceress has made a mistake—that she has said more than she intended. It's the first crack in the Sorceress's composure that Adora has seen. "I'm sorry but... I will not speak of such things. For the sake of my people."

Adora and Catra exchange a glance. The knowledge that there's another runestone here, in Eternos...it's hardly a comfort. Especially considering what the runestones back on Etheria were used for (namely, activating the Heart of Etheria).

If this *other* runestone is anything like the one used to control She-Ra, it should be destroyed—just as the Sword of Protection was.

But they have greater priorities. Namely, ensuring that the Sword of Protection *stays* destroyed.

"So a past host of the Sorceress created the Sword of Protection," Adora recounts. "What are the chances that someone could do it again?"

The Sorceress stares at Adora for a long time, as though searching Adora's face for additional buried meaning. "Why would you ask such a thing?"

Sighing, Adora says, "I destroyed the Sword of Protection, back on Etheria. Shattered it. But an enemy of ours recently stole the pieces of the sword and then fled here. We think she's planning to rebuild it and use it to control She-Ra."

Silence persists for too long, after that. The Sorceress continues to stare intently at Adora—though there's a strangeness to it. Like she's not looking at Adora at all. Adora would even guess that the Sorceress is examining her at the atomic level. Looking at her as

though she's a fascinating, perhaps frightening grouping of protons and electrons, rather than a person with thoughts and feelings.

It's several minutes before she finally tears her eyes from Adora's face. Instead, she sinks into a chair and perches a hand below her chin.

"The ability to create runestones was exclusive to our people," the Sorceress explains. "Only our people developed that knowledge, by studying this—" She gestures to the tower. "The runestone that we possessed since the dawn of time. The magical entity known as the Sorceress willingly chose to bind herself to this tower. But several thousand years ago, we learned that the same process could be applied to other beings of magic—whether they wished to be bound or not. We could have their power at our disposal, so long as we drew the correct runes and constructed a runestone from suitable materials."

Adora shakes her head frantically. She doesn't want to hear this—she *shouldn't* hear this. Chasm could be listening at this very moment, and gleaning ideas from the Sorceress's words.

"Stop!" exclaims Adora, more urgently and forcefully than she even intends. "I don't want to hear the awfulness of how you did it! I just want to know whether it can be done again."

The Sorceress flinches at Adora's volume, and Adora finds herself blushing in shame when she hears the *click* of the Sorceress's mouth snapping shut. Like she's refusing to speak further, until Adora apologizes.

She feels Catra's hand smooth over the top of Adora's back—an attempt at comfort. Nervously, she even sneaks a look at Teela, expecting her to be livid at such a disrespectful outburst. But Adora is stunned to see that Teela looks almost...amused. On the verge of laughter, even. Though Adora cannot imagine why.

“I’m...I’m sorry,” Adora stammers. “I didn’t mean to get that angry. But this information—it’s important.”

“Who exactly is this enemy of yours?” the Sorceress demands. And Adora is somewhat startled to hear that all airiness has utterly *vacated* the Sorceress's voice, replaced by a stern hardness. And a concern.

Adora draws in an enormous, shaking breath.

“Chasm,” Adora says. “She’s called Chasm. She’s a magical entity like She-Ra, and like the Sorceress. But she doesn’t wait for a willing host. She *takes* bodies, destroying the minds of her hosts in the process.”

She doesn’t miss the way that the Sorceress tenses, her eyes nearly bulging in surprise.

“Chasm,” the Sorceress repeats, murmuring the name like a curse beneath her breath. “How did she escape?”

“You know of her?” Adora asks.

“Of course I know of her,” the Sorceress says. “I was one of the magicians who helped imprison her.”

Chapter End Notes

adam: am i not ALSO entitled to an enemies to lovers arc????

anyway, please remember to comment! also gonna plug my crimson waste au one more time. The last chapter of that is gonna be posted next week, so make sure to catch up if you haven't!

Chapter 18

Chapter Summary

Teela has an argument with the Sorceress.

Adora seeks out the ship that Chasm stole.

And Chasm sends a message.

Chapter Notes

ok so. im sorry for not updating yesterday. i don't have a good explanation, i literally just forgot. if my writing has somehow led you to believe that i have any braincells at all, you would be mistaken.

better late than never though! here's the next chapter of immemorial...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"*You* helped imprison Chasm?" Adora asks, skeptical. "Or did one of the Sorceress's past hosts do that?"

The Sorceress shakes her head. "We are not all like She-Ra. She-Ra is unique in that she only transfers her power to her hosts, and takes little interest in having a consciousness of her own. I, on the other hand…" The Sorceress places a hand on her chest. "The *Sorceress*...passes a mixture of knowledge and power. I have the memories of every incarnation of the Sorceress who preceded me. Which means I remember Chasm's imprisonment as if it were my hands that cast the rune."

"Wait…" Teela interrupts. "You have encountered this fugitive before?"

"She is more than a fugitive," the Sorceress says, never taking her eyes off Adora's face. "She is a monster. An entity of the darkest

magicks, and a parasite on the minds of every living thing. It is said she was born from nightmares themselves—the cruelest impulses and fears of living things throughout the universe."

Her eyes narrow at Adora in accusation. It's clear that she blames Adora for Chasm's presence here, in this dimension. It's the kind of blame that Adora had longed for only a week ago, when she wanted to take responsibility for Chasm's attack on Etheria. But now the blame is unwelcome. Especially when Adora is Chasm's longest-suffering victim.

"How did she escape her prison?" the Sorceress demands.

"A portal was opened," says Adora, as calmly as she can manage. "People went in. When they came back out, she was attached to one of them. They didn't know—"

And it's strange, of course, to speak as though she's referring to strangers other than herself, when she was the very person who went through that portal and found herself infected. When she was the very person who walked Chasm out of her imprisonment.

A muscle jumps in the Sorceress's jaw. "And you say she is after She-Ra's power?"

Adora nods. "By reconstructing the sword, and controlling her with it."

Shaking her head in dismay, the Sorceress says, "Chasm tortured the universe for centuries. The effort we went through to isolate her hosts, destroy them, and then send her last remaining host into an empty dimension—it is not something easily replicated."

"She hasn't been able to spread beyond Etheria yet," Catra says, near-growling with defensiveness on Adora's behalf. "We've distributed wakefulness potions to counteract her illusions, back on Etheria. And because everyone here is protected by wards, she hasn't really had a chance to gain hosts beyond the three she took from our planet."

“We followed her here because we hoped that She-Ra could vanquish her,” Adora says. “I’ve done it in the past, to Horde Prime—”

“She is not Horde Prime,” says the Sorceress. “She is dark magic incarnate. And magic cannot destroy magic. It can only change it, reshape it, *move* it .”

Adora releases a strangled noise—some broken-sounding intersection between a cry of despair and a groan of frustration. She did not come all this way only to *now* realize that their plan was doomed from the start. And yes, Adora knows that she should accept this—that there was always a possibility that Catra was wrong when formulating this plan. But she hoped with every fiber of her being that Catra was not—

“Then what can we do?” Catra asks, desperately. “There must be something.”

“There is only one thing to do,” the Sorceress says. “You must bring her here, and allow me to transport her back to her prison dimension.”

“But she’s already escaped from there once,” Adora protests. “She could just do it again—”

“We must pray that she doesn’t,” says the Sorceress. “And pray that I have sufficient magic to tear open a portal across so many dimensions. The last time, I had many sorcerers to help me. But now that we have grown so resentful and deplete of magic, I am the last sorcerer on this planet. And I do not know that I have the strength.”

A silence envelops the room in its entirety. Adora can hear nothing but the sound of her own breathing, the rush of air into her own nose and the rustle of fabric as her chest heaves up and down.

“So what is our plan?” Teela asks. “For capturing this...Chasm?”

“You must kill all but one of her hosts,” the Sorceress says. “And then bring the remaining one here, to me. Then we shall hope that I can transport her elsewhere, where she can do no harm. She is too dangerous to stay here, among living things. ”

“And what about all the people back on Etheria?” Adora demands. “They’re still infected!”

“I am sorry to say that I cannot help them,” the Sorceress says, lips flattened into a grimace. “If they continue drinking the wakefulness potion you described, they can have some semblance of a peaceful life. But they should never again travel beyond their planet, except to those places where the population is warded against her.”

“That’s unacceptable!” Catra hisses. “There has to be something else. A better solution—”

“The better solution,” the Sorceress says sternly, over-enunciating each word, “was to leave her trapped within her prison. But now we must sustain the consequences for failing to maintain that safeguard.”

Adora shakes her head. “No,” she says, voice scraped raw by the utter rush of refusal, of *denial*, flooding through her body. “There has to be something else. We can’t let our people go sleepless, trapped, for the rest of their lives—”

“And what about the sword?” Catra demands. “You still haven’t answered our question. If she gets that, it’s game over!”

“Only I know the correct runes to repair or create a runestone,” the Sorceress declares. “So no. Chasm should not be able to repair the sword. Not without my help. And I assure you, I am well-warded against her control.”

“And what if Chasm already knows how?” Catra asks. “She’s an ancient entity too. Maybe she learned how to create runestones a long time ago, just like you did—”

The Sorceress shakes her head. “When we imprisoned Chasm, the Tower was the only runestone in existence, and we hadn’t yet studied it—hadn’t yet transferred it into smaller constructions like gems or, in the case of She-Ra, *weapons.* It is as I said. Only I possess the knowledge to repair a runestone.”

Catra grabs at Adora’s arm, forcing her gaze in Catra’s direction. She sees a flared sort of concern in Catra’s eyes. An urging. A promise. And Adora knows what it means, even without the aid of words to explain.

Even if they *do* bring Chasm here, for the Sorceress to transport away...they cannot let the pieces of the sword reach the Sorceress. They cannot let the sword be repaired by the very person who first constructed it to be used as a weapon of universal destruction.

“So that’s it?” Adora demands. “My people are doomed? Is that what you’re saying?”

The Sorceress’s face is impassive. “Not doomed but…” She sighs. “Their outlook is far from ideal. I am sorry.”

“No,” hisses Adora. “If you were sorry, you’d do more! After everything Eternia has done to Etheria...the Heart...we owe it to them to fix this! To help them, to fix this mess you swept into a pocket dimension, and not just *abandon* them—”

And with that, she turns her back on the Sorceress, marching to the nearby door. She hears Catra scoff and follow her, equally outraged to hear her home—Etheria—disregarded so completely.

But she doesn’t hear Teela’s footsteps in pursuit. Instead, she hears a voice. A quiet one. A disappointed murmuring.

“Is that really all you have to say to me?” Teela demands in that hushed voice. Adora can just barely hear it from where she stands, at the Tower’s threshold. “Not even a greeting, or a goodbye? Not even a hint of acknowledgement—”

Adora turns to see Teela confronting the Sorceress, her knuckles curled tight around her helmet. It's a surprising sight, to be certain—one that makes Adora's eyes widen. Teela hardly seems the type to question authority. And it's apparent that this Sorceress is an important figure to the Eternians.

But Teela could not possibly seem more disapproving. The Sorceress, meanwhile, does not react to Teela's demands. She only remains impassive as ever, and resistant to answering.

And it's only while looking at both of them—Teela and the Sorceress, their faces near-perfectly adjacent—does Adora realize just *who* the Sorceress reminded her of, back during their first meeting.

Teela. The Sorceress looks like Teela. Their features are remarkably similar in structure. And those eyes, so pale gray and colorless on their faces...Adora has never seen a person with that eye color before, let alone two.

Teela barks out a scoff of her own, then spins on her heel. "I don't know what I expected," she mutters to herself, eyes attached fixedly to the floor.

Though she's stopped in her tracks by the Sorceress's eventual response, called over the length of the room.

"I am only doing my duty," she says. And somehow, it sounds like a mantra. "Surely, you of all people understand that."

Teela stands frozen for a few weighty seconds. But then, with a thrashing of her head and a dismissive noise, she's pushing past Catra and Adora into the stairway. Determined to both lead the way...and lead them far away from the Sorceress.

And for once, Adora is all-too-happy to follow Teela's lead.

Throughout the ride to the landing site—the place where Chasm set down the ship she stole—Adora cannot stop sneaking glances

at Teela. And that's probably the very reason why Teela maintains a determined regard for the horizon, and the horizon alone, thereby refusing to meet Adora's eyes.

Of course, Adora cannot really blame Teela. Though she supposes it is a bit ironic, considering that Teela herself pried so viciously into the matter of Adora's heritage.

"*What was that about?"* Catra asked once she, Adora, and Teela had fully descended the tower's staircase.

"*Surely you can see the family resemblance,*" Teela snarled as she continued marching herself away from the Tower and the woman who resides at its peak. "*I should not have to explain*."

"*You're her...you're her daughter?"* Adora stammered. "*You're the Sorceress's daughter?"*

"*She wasn't always the Sorceress*," Teela grumbled. "*Once, she was simply my mother. But that is the curse of people in my family, I suppose. We are always the Sorceress's favorite hosts."*

"*I don't understand,"* said Adora, struggling to keep up with Teela's ever-increasing, ever-more-frustrated momentum. *"Was she unwillingly made to be the Sorceress's host?"*

Teela shook her head and laughed. Though it was entirely humorless, that laugh. A slap, more like, in its abruptness and ferocity. "*Oh no. It is considered far too great an honor to host the mighty Sorceress. My mother welcomed the chance—even if it meant leaving her whole family behind. Even if it meant leaving me behind, to lock herself in that tower of hers*."

"*She can't leave at all?*" Adora asked, softly.

"*No*," said Teela. "*Not without endangering the Sorceress's spirit. She is stuck there until the day she dies. Not, of course, that she seems to mind. She seems quite happy to be free of us*."

And Adora could not exactly argue, nor offer assurances. She saw firsthand how the Sorceress utterly ignored Teela's presence during their visit. And as Teela said, it would not have killed the woman to have greeted her own daughter, or at the very least acknowledge her presence.

"She'll never get her hands on me, though," Teela muttered, seemingly to herself, all self-control swallowed by her rage. "*She'll have to find some other suit of flesh to occupy, for I will not be it. I am not such a fool, nor am I so cruel to those I love. I will be a Royal Guard until my dying day, no matter how she begs me to host her—"*

Adora and Catra could only follow, eyes colliding in expressions of joint worry, as Teela continued to seethe down that hallway.

And now they are here, sitting aboard the vehicle that Teela once called a Wind Raider. Squeezed onto benches alongside the dozen Royal Guards who agreed to accompany them on this trip to find Chasm. The Lenarian landscape whizzes across Adora's vision, mountains and rock formations rising before her eyes, then tumbling beneath the horizon line.

She's not even sure if this is the right choice. Obviously, Chasm must be caught. But Adora still refuses to believe that the best solution is to simply send Chasm back to that prison dimension. They need to discover a way to *defeat* Chasm, really defeat her, not just trap her. Destroy her, ideally, so that she can no longer infect the people on Etheria...as well as Adora herself.

"I feel bad for making fun of her," Catra whispers, into Adora's ear. It's barely audible above the wind roaring around them.

Adora doesn't need to ask who. The direction of Catra's gaze reveals it well enough. Teela. Catra is talking about Teela. Teela, who sits at the nose of the vehicle, face turned to the landscape in resistance to any prying stares.

“I joked about her dad getting her job for her,” Catra continues. “I didn’t realize...about her mother...and then about how the Sorceress likely wants her as the next host—”

“Like you said—you didn’t know,” Adora replies, hand curling around Catra’s. And it’s inordinately small within Adora’s grasp—Catra’s hand. She transformed into She-Ra before the Wind Raider left its docking station, hoping to be prepared for any potential attack. The guards gawked at her, of course, as she underwent the glowing metamorphosis. The one that stretched her limbs, coated them in muscles, and made every particle of Adora’s skin glow with magic.

But beneath that shimmering embrace of She-Ra’s power, Adora was struggling to summon that magic from deep within herself. With every passing hour of wakefulness, her mind grows more muddled. A thick sludge of anxieties and tiredness which Adora must slog through, in order to accomplish what must be done. Even now as Adora watches their journey, the sunlight strikes her as a punishment. One that sears a red-hot headache behind Adora’s eyes, a headache that blossoms and grows like a balloon filled with lead.

During the initial transformation, She-Ra flickered several times before Adora managed to grasp proper hold of her. Now, Adora must devote too much of her attention to keeping her here, spread across Adora’s veins, rather than retreating to that hidden abscess of magic within herself.

“And besides,” Adora whispers to Catra, smoothing a thumb across Catra’s jaw. “You weren’t the first to make assumptions. She made plenty about us.”

“I guess,” says Catra. “Still. I should know better than to assume by now. Just because people live differently than we did, growing up...doesn’t mean there weren’t other sources of hurt.” She sighs. “The Sorceress is no Shadow Weaver. But I know from first-hand experience that it sucks—feeling like you mean nothing to someone who’s supposed to be your family..”

“Well,” says Adora, in a voice that sinks low in sympathy, “I hope that they can figure things out someday. There’s probably more to the story than Teela realizes.”

“I don’t know,” says Catra, skeptical. “The Sorceress seems pretty messed up to me. Wouldn’t exactly surprise me if she was just *that* cruel to her kid.”

“People can surprise you,” Adora reminds her, with a nudge of her shoulder. “I mean...I bet you never thought that you’d be friends with Angella, back when we were cadets in the Horde.”

“No,” says Catra. “I guess not.”

“At attention!” a voice barks, interrupting Catra and Adora so thoroughly that they both start—shoulders jumping several feet in the air.

Teela’s voice, per usual, in that commanding tone she loves so much. Though there’s a distinct growl of agitation to it now. One that wasn’t there before their trip to the Tower. Her eyes sweep over every member of the guard, lingering on Catra and Adora before she says, “We’re nearly at the landing site. Everyone should be on the lookout for ambushes. Be on the defense at all times.”

Adora and Catra nod their assent. With a mighty mental push, she tries to shove that heavy fog of exhaustion from her brain, seeking instead one final strand of clarity for herself.

And sure enough, in the distance soon appears a metallic dot. A dark geometric shape against the backdrop of a thousand jagged, golden rocks. Adora recognizes it immediately as the ship Catra and Adora packed for their trip to Sutera.

And the ship that Chasm stole.

One of the guards pulls out a small device. A crystal of some kind, one that projects images into the air. A map of the surrounding areas, it seems like, though Adora cannot be totally sure. All she

knows is that crystal looks a lot like the First Ones technology she found back on Etheria, particularly the kind within the Crystal Castle.

"Not detecting any nearby life forms or weapons," the guard says. "The area seems clear, Captain."

Teela hums as though unconvinced.

The Wind Raider whizzes closer and closer to its destination, the ship an increasingly looming presence in Adora's line of sight. Their approach is eerie. A tense wait for something to go wrong—for something to attack. But nothing does. There is no movement, no sound, save the vehicle's engine as it hurtles forward through the air.

Adora expected a trap. Chasm should know that they're coming, after all.

She wanted Chasm to know that they were coming.

And finally, they are braking, inertia dragging them forward as the engine grinds into slow, idle vibrations. The rocks and mountains cease to move at such a rapid pace, instead stagnating on the horizon as though they're painted there.

And there, only a few feet away, is the ship. Still. Dark. Silent. Nestled into the rocks as though trying to become its own type of rock formation. Forgotten to man, extension to nature.

In that moment, Adora loses sight of all patience—her time is far too short and dwindling by the moment. She plants one hand on the railing that surrounds the deck of the Wind Raider and, with a thrust of her arm, she hoists herself over it. Her feet pound deep imprints into the dirt when she lands.

"She-Ra, wait," Teela warns, just as Catra complains, "Adora!"

The soldiers are scrambling after her, clattering as they seek their gear beneath their seats. But Adora cannot do it. She cannot wait.

If Chasm is in there, Adora must capture her *now*, before it's too late.

And if Chasm isn't in there...then they'd better seek clues as to where she went. Adora finds it highly unlikely that Chasm would remain on the ship, easily discoverable and trackable as it is. She's far too smart.

But there might be clues, at least.

Even with She-Ra's long legs, Adora is half-jogging to the ship's ramp, which is already extended and burrowing into the dirt. She reaches it quickly with little regard for the guards (and Catra) clamoring after her. She can face Chasm alone, if necessary. Here, in the real world, Adora holds all the power.

She climbs the ramp, feet smacking metallic echoes into the ramp beneath her. Once at the top, she merely lays a hand on the hatch door. It is programmed to recognize her, after all. This was Catra and Adora's designated *vacation* transport, fully packed before Chasm made herself known and snatched the good majority of their belongings.

A glowing green outline traces her hand, then disappears—recognizing and welcoming her. As internal hydraulics whir to pull open the hatch, Adora sucks in a breath—going near-cross-eyed with concentration as she tries to summon her sword. It takes one, two, three tries, each one flickering like a transmission half-shattered by asteroid interference. But in the end, it sticks. The sword is solid and glowing within Adora's hand, ready to cut through any obstacle.

The hatch widens for Adora. And truly, the ship appears to be some enormous, yawning face—a growling maw into a dark cavern.

And that's the first thing Adora notices. That all the lights within the ship are off.

Adora ventures inside, sword held high and glowing to light her way. Catra, meanwhile, gallops to the base of the ramp. Her voice is half-swallowed by the metal as she calls, "Adora! You should've waited!"

But the sword isn't necessary, in the end. The lights flicker on in response to a moving presence, just as they're programmed to do. Adora can immediately see and sense that there's nothing and no one here, within the ship. The air smells stale. Untouched. Like the engines have not been activated in days. The floor is spotless save a thin layer of rock dust—a result of not having the ship pressurized, or its air filtered.

Interrupting that layer of dust is, for some reason, a wide puddle of water—spread across the floor in a reflective sheen.

Adora steps around the puddle as she stomps toward each of the ship's rooms. The cargo hold, the sleeping quarters, the bathroom. All are empty in their entirety, with no one left hiding behind shower curtains or beneath beds.

Abandoned. The ship is entirely abandoned.

Adora has returned to the main deck by the time Catra enters, still breathing heavily from her sprint to catch up. Adora doesn't greet her, though. Not immediately. Right now she is too focused on starting the ship and examining its logs.

At the press of abutton, the ship's computer blares to life. There's a few seconds devoted to a reboot. But once that's done, once the AI is asking Adora for her query, it tells her what she needs to know.

"*Ship was last active four days ago,"* the AI declares. "*No use of hatch door has occurred since then, after departure of pilots.*"

Adora puffs out a disappointed breath.

"So she's gone?" Catra asks, sounding unsurprised. She utters the words just as Teela and the rest of the guards file into the ship,

craning their necks for a thorough look around.

Adora nods.

"*Attention*," the AI says, almost as an afterthought, *"Pilots requested that a message be delivered to any party that activates the ship. Would you like to hear the message?"*

Adora and Catra's eyes latch onto one another, and immediately, Catra's expression mirrors Adora's own. Brows pulled low over narrowed eyes, jaw tense with concern. Her question is likely the same as Adora's: what kind of message could Chasm possibly leave for them?

The guards, too, have frozen where they stand. Teela's head cocks to the side, one ear tipped toward the ceiling in interest. She doesn't seem nearly as uneasy as Adora and Catra do. But then again, Teela has never actually seen Chasm in the flesh. Or...lack thereof. And she certainly hasn't experienced Chasm's frightening talent for manipulation.

Clearing her throat and willing her shoulders not to shake, Adora orders, "Play it."

The words aren't as loud, or as confident, as she wishes they were.

A silence persists for a few moments as the AI processes Adora's order. But then the crackle of audio fills the room.

"*Hello all,"* a voice greets. Cleo's high and vibrant voice, Adora recognizes, though it is notably twisted by Chasm's arrogant lilt. "*Hello especially to you, Adora and Catra."*

From the corner of her eye, Adora sees Catra mouthing, "*What does she want?"* Adora can only shake her head, equally lost.

"*I am leaving this message in the hope that we can act...civilly...toward one another,"* continues Chasm, over the speakers. "*And I am giving you all a chance to avoid immediate*

bloodshed. Princess Adora, otherwise known as She-Ra, will surrender herself to me."

"Like hell," snarls Catra, instantly. And it's truly that—a snarl. With bared teeth and claws unsheathed, Catra's fingers twitching with the urge to *scratch*.

"*In addition, the Sorceress of Castle Grayskull will provide me with her knowledge of runestones,"* Chasm adds. "*She's already aware of what I wish to know. I should not have to elaborate further on what I seek from her.*"

"The Sorceress will never agree," Teela scoffs, a hand resting on the hilt of the sword that hangs on her hip. "She has protected that knowledge since the dawn of time itself."

"Failure to comply with these requests will, of course, result in death and destruction," Chasm says lightly, like the thought only excites her. "*But I am nothing if not efficient, and it would be faster to simply ask for what I want, rather than take it by force."*

"She won't," mutters Adora.

"*But I'm still perfectly willing to* take*, if that is what I must do. No matter the cost.*"

The words echo through the main deck of the ship, reverberating off metal from all sides. Only with the ending click of the microphone does Adora realize that the message has ended—leaving everyone in glacial silence.

Though the threat still hangs in the air, absent all sound. Menacing as a thunderstorm.

Chapter End Notes

yeah, sorry y'all. catching chasm isn't gonna be that easy. seems sorta like she has a plan in progress 👀👀

please remember to comment!

also, if you haven't heard, i finished writing/posting *where we wander, where we wander*, a canon-divergent fic where adora and catra were both exiled to the crimson waste at the end of season 1. go read if you haven't and let me know what you think!

see you next week (hopefully on time)!

Chapter 19

Chapter Summary

Teela strategizes.

Adora's headache worsens.

Adam tells a story.

Chapter Notes

Hey all! Sorry this is a bit late, my life is chaos lately! But here's the new chapter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A quick perusal of Adora's memories reveals what Chasm needs to know. That the ship has been discovered. Her message, listened to. And the extended search for Chasm and her hosts will soon begin, just as Chasm expected it to.

She hoped Adora and the Eternians would cooperate. But she never raised her hopes so high as to *expect* it.

"*We will send a team out here,*" Teela says, to Adora and Catra both. "*They'll collect this ship—dock it alongside yours to prevent Chasm from escaping out from under our noses.*"

"*Any chance that we can remove our belongings from the cargo hold*?" Adora hears Catra ask. "*Chasm did steal a lot of our stuff*."

Teela shakes her head. "*It'd be best that we formally scan the ship for clues. We have forensics teams that can look more closely at that puddle of water on the floor, or check for any other out-of-place features of the ship—*"

"*But we'll eventually get everything back, right?*" Adora presses. And Chasm gives a roll of Cleo's eyes as she realizes that Catra

and Adora are *both* still ridiculously concerned with retrieving the suit and dress that Chasm accidentally stole when she took the ship.

"*Yes*," sighs Teela. "*Everything will be returned to you, once we properly examine the ship.*"

Well...Chasm is happy to return it to them. For however short a time.

"We'll have to search the planet the old-fashioned way," Teela says, hand slowly increasing pressure on the Wind Raider's accelerator. She yells above the mixed roar of the engine and wind. "We'll send out teams for reconnaissance. Have them scope out the entire planet, if that's what it takes. And send out more troops when she's located."

The ship proved totally devoid of clues. There were a few meaningful details, Adora supposed. The fact that some of the ship's emergency supplies had been removed from the cargo bay. Tents, non-perishable foods, jugs of water. It was apparent that Chasm intended to camp somewhere out in the Lenarian desert.

But with several days' head start, she could be miles away by now. And heading in literally any direction. They'll need to search every potential hiding place—every gap between rocks, every flat plane of sand, every shadow behind a boulder—within a near hundred-mile radius.

The Eternians, at least, have the Wind Raiders as an advantage, while Chasm won't have anything besides the feet of her hosts. But that's still an excessive amount of ground to cover.

"And how long will that take?" Adora asks, taking the briefest respite from gnawing on her own bottom lip. "Not long, right?"

Teela shakes her head. "There is much to search, Princess Adora. I cannot make promises in terms of timing."

“Catra and I...we can’t stay for long,” Adora insists. “We’re running out of time.”

“Then we will have to continue the search in your absence,” Teela replies. “Perhaps it’s for the best. If this *Chasm* is after you, you should likely remove yourself from the planet where she’s currently hiding.”

Growling, Adora replies, “I don’t run from threats.”

“It’s not running,” Teela says, in a tone that sounds too much like *pity* for Adora’s liking. “It’s simply...making Chasm’s life more difficult.”

“No,” says Adora. “I need to be here, when she’s found. The sword that she stole...I need to make sure that it’s located, and destroyed.”

“Then let us hope that we find her sooner rather than later,” Teela says. “She has now raised a threat against my people, and that is not something I take lightly. I will find her. It just might take time.”

“And Catra and I—” Adora says, hand slipping into Catra’s, “we can help. We can go on reconnaissance missions. Search until we —”

“No,” Teela interrupts, firm in her refusal. “Like I said earlier, we shouldn’t risk dropping you directly into Chasm’s hands if she seeks you. My soldiers are well-trained. We’ll find her, even without the *mighty* She-Ra’s help.”

And of course, Adora doesn’t appreciate the sarcasm. She-Ra is likely the only one capable of challenging Chasm’s immense magical ability. She-Ra’s magic is some of the most powerful in the universe, even without the use of spells.

And so, Adora protests, “No way—”

But she's silenced by Catra. Catra, who exchanges her hold on Adora's hand for a firm grasp on Adora's arm.

"Adora," she murmurs, with a small shrug in Teela's direction. "She has a point. And you yourself said it. We're running out of time. We shouldn't waste it arguing."

Catra's focus on Adora's face is fierce, pleading. Adamant.

And really, it's not just *time* that Catra is talking about. Not really. It's energy. With every day spent searching for Chasm, Adora loses another day to sleeplessness. To mounting exhaustion. And if Adora fails to conjure She-Ra during some future fight with Chasm…

"We should try to rest and relax as much as we can," Catra adds. "That way we're good and refreshed when we find Chasm, wherever she's hiding. As good as we are in a fight, I don't think we're any better than these guards in terms of scoping out the landscape. If anything, we're a lot worse, considering that we don't know the area."

Adora grumbles out some sort of non-committal response, instead choosing to glare out at the landscape. A landscape that soon gives way to a tunnel, one that's dark and humming as they weave through its bowels, drawn to some distant blue light.

It's not the cave from before—the one Adora and Catra entered Eternos through. Teela showed them that there were several different entrances and exits, some more convenient than others. Adora and Catra managed to discover a particularly well-concealed one, back when they first arrived. But there were far easier tunnels to access.

Like this cave, for instance. The Wind Raider simply passes through the correct crevice in the rock and, before long, it's hovering just outside that same blue wall of energy. The one that conceals all of Eternos within its borders.

"Please, Adora? For me?"

The magical border recognizes the guard's identities immediately. And this time, Adora is prepared for the blinding flash of light when the gateway opens. She closes her eyes, muttering, "Fine," so that she will not have to look Catra in the eyes when she concedes. "We'll let the guards handle the search. But the second she's found…"

She opens her eyes. Catra's gaze awaits her, replete with the blue-yellow determination that utterly captures Adoras attention. "We go to her. And we beat her. Just as we've always planned."

Adora's headache worsens considerably by the time she returns. There's a weapon there, thrust into the flesh behind Adora's eyes. It pulses and pounds and *throbs* with every jitter of Adora's heartbeat, the pain made worse by those long hours in the sun-scorched Lenarian desert. Intense light was surely not a help to the simmering migraine she already had.

As her head continues to ache, Teela brings Adora and Catra back to the guards' headquarters. It's the only place Adora really wants to be—but Adora also figures that she probably should not stay. Teela very clearly intends to strategize—she wants to establish a way to locate and track Chasm. And if Adora overhears her plans, allowing Chasm to overhear by extension...

They'll be sabotaged. Trapped. Outsmarted and circumvented, potentially.

Adora cannot risk that. But she can't resist staying away, either. Not at first. Adora needs to know *some information* about how Teela plans to proceed. If Teela captures Chasm while Adora is left unaware, Teela could sneak the stolen pieces of the sword back to the Sorceress. And She-Ra could find herself under the First Ones' control yet again.

She doesn't know what to do. Doesn't know which is more important—catching Chasm by surprise, or keeping an eye on the Eternians. So for now, she stays. Though she swears to herself

she'll leave if Teela starts to reveal information that Chasm should not know.

Though this small attempt to glean information is ultimately *interrupted* by Adora's so-called responsibilities as a royal. Catra and Adora are halfway through a conversation with Teela when Adam strides into the room and settles himself beside them.

He merely hovers there for a long while, back reclined against the nearest wall. Watching, listening without a word to offer. Teela pointedly ignores his presence, but it's clear by the stiffness of her muscles that she wishes him gone.

Finally, he clears his throat—effectively slicing his way through the discussion with that single, scraping noise. Adora, Catra, Teela, and dozens of other guards all spin around to glare at him.

"Apologies," he says, in a haphazard way that suggests he isn't sorry at all. "I'm here to offer Princess Adora a tour of the palace."

Adora begins to shake her head, an excuse poised on her lips—but finds herself speechless as Teela shoves her forward, toward Adam. Adora's head snaps around to glare at her—at Teela—only to see the flicking of Teela's eyes toward the door. An urging, however silent.

Teela wants Adam gone for the sake of her own concentration. And if getting rid of Adora is necessary to accomplish that, so be it. Her harsh glare doesn't give Adora much of a choice.

"The princess would be happy to accompany you," Teela answers for her.

Adora glances at Catra, then—a nonverbal plea for Catra to come with her—but Catra shakes her head in refusal. "I'm gonna stay and help Teela finish arranging these reconnaissance teams, okay?" Catra says, apologetically. "I'll take a tour some other time."

Adora's mouth falls open in outrage. Outrage, fed by Catra's betrayal. Is Catra seriously leaving Adora alone during some forced moment with Adora's alleged "family?"

Catra shoots her yet another apologetic look. Her message is clear. *We can't risk you being here anyway*. Adora should avoid knowing more than she absolutely must, and Adam provides the excuse that Adora needs to avoid key details.

Adora knows it to be true. But she still doesn't enjoy accepting it.

"Fine," Adora grumbles, stomping her way to the door and hardly waiting for Adam to follow. "Let's go on a tour."

It is nothing particularly exciting. He shows her several conference rooms that belong to royal advisors, the chamber that houses Eternia's parliament, and the religious temple within the castle—the one devoted to the Goddess that nearly all Eternians worship.

The architecture is beautiful, of course...though it was nothing Adora had not seen before. It bears no significant differences with the rest of the castle. In fact, the temple looks a great deal like the Crystal Castle back on Etheria. Though there are far more sculptures and murals of the Goddess here, rather than She-Ra.

As they meander throughout that temple, Adam begins to explain the Goddess's origin to Adora—something that Adora is wholly disinterested in. He likely assumes that, by growing up on Etheria, Adora hasn't heard much about the Goddess. But George and Lance's library contained plenty of scrolls on her, and how she supposedly came to be Eternia's greatest deity.

"Then the Goddess battled her way out of the pit of snakes," he recounts, as Adora looks on in boredom. "Carving herself armor from their scaly hides—"

"And then she used that armor to do battle with the fearsome demons that plagued Eternia," Adora recites, recalling the exact words from a particular scroll of George and Lance's library. "She

won the battle. Established the First One—or *Eternian*—culture. And here you all are today."

Adam raises both eyebrows. "So you do know the story?"

Adora sighs, then nods. "The First Ones left a lot of scrolls on Etheria. I was born able to read them, and then wasted far too much time doing that."

Adam gives a nod of his own. "They say that the goddess created our language, and blessed our people with the ability to read it from the day they are born to the day they die."

Adora shrugs. "Yup. I've read that one too."

"And did you read that, according to our histories, the Goddess was the one who created the magical spirit of the sorceress? Created, as a protector of our world."

Again, Adora shrugs. "I didn't read that, no. But I find it unlikely. If the Goddess created the Sorceress...who created She-Ra? They're both entities made of magic. And we don't have a Goddess, back on our world."

"Our histories always said that the Sorceress was created to organize and focus magic throughout the universe. That meant harnessing the power of entities like She-Ra, or He-Man, or—

Adora steps back and blinks at him. "There are other magical entities you harnessed besides She-Ra?"

Adam scoffs and shrugs. "Well. Not me, personally. It was a long time ago. I think there used to be a great many magical powers that our people held. Though we exhausted most of them, in time."

"Those entities were controlled against their will," Adora argues. "Forced to become weapons."

Adam raises a hand in surrender. "I am not arguing otherwise. I am simply recounting history for you. I understand what you mean, about She-Ra being controlled." And then, muttering to himself, he adds: "I know something of what it's like to be trapped, and forced to do as you're bid, regardless of what you want."

Scoffing in disbelief and just a bit of indignance, Adora says. "No, you don't. Not really."

"Well—"

"No," says Adora. "You don't know. Catra and I...we were raised as soldiers in a war machine. We were told that if we got sick, we were better off dead. We were punished for any mistake, slip up, tactical error or shred of enjoyment we stole for ourselves. We were expected to die for Hordak on the battlefield, and only that. And later...when I was She-Ra…"

Adora clutches at her elbows, recalling the fiery, lead-weight of magic flowing through her veins.

"The Sword of Protection turned me into a conduit for the planet's magic. I had to hold a thousand years' worth of magic inside my body—feel my nerves set on complete *fire*—and keep it there, or else risk destroying the whole universe with that power. If I hadn't shattered the sword, it would have obliterated everyone. And maybe destroyed myself too."

Her jaw is tense when she looks up at Adam next.

"You're an Eternian who doesn't want to be Eternian," Adora says sternly, and drops her arms to her side. "And sure, you can't travel through space in the way you want. You're obligated to your duties as a prince, however much you hate them. And while that sucks for you...that doesn't mean you're *controlled*. Not in the ways that truly matter."

A pause from Adam, as he studies her face with quiet fascination. And then—

"You're right," he agrees. "I shouldn't have said that. There are far worse things than being stuck in one place, however boring it is."

Adora sighs, grateful to find him agreeable to her point of view, rather than defensive about the matter. Seeking to change the subject, she says, "So who exactly do your mythologies say created She-Ra, if not the Goddess?

Adam gives a hum, like he finds the question intriguing. "I don't know. But then again, I'm hardly a big believer in the Goddess myself. Though I do think she makes for some interesting stories." He smiles at Adora. "Perhaps Etheria is a goddess in her own right. Our histories said the planet seemed to be *alive* with magic, back when we could still access it. Maybe Etheria created She-Ra to protect herself."

Nodding, Adora says, "I've been all across the universe. There's no place quite like Etheria."

And it is true. Even now, Adora finds herself longing for it. She longs for the lush forests of the Etheria landscape, the vibrant wildlife. The gleaming castles and lovingly-constructed villages. And more than anything, she wishes for her friends. Bow and Glimmer. The other princesses and Sea Hawk and Swift Wind and Razz...they're all so far away. Their distance from her is a physical pain, almost. Much like the pain that throbs from behind Adora's eyes.

More painful, though, is the memory of how she left them. With everyone but the sorcerers and Angella infected by Chasm, left under Chasm's spell. By now, she hopes that everyone is awake—taking *Essence of Eternity* to keep themselves safe. But she knows that the sleep deprivation must be as torturous to those back on Etheria as it is to Adora now, with this constant ache resonating through her skull.

She wishes she could leave Eternia, leave space, and just go home.

But she can't face them. She can't face anyone until Chasm is captured, and forced to relinquish her hold on Etheria. How she will do that, Adora still doesn't know. But she'll have to figure out *something*.

"You'll forgive me for still wishing that I could travel through space in the same way," Adam says, with a wistful sigh. "I long to know more about the wider universe."

"Maybe when you rule Eternia, you can change the rules for yourself," Adora offers. "See the universe without anyone to stop you."

"If Teela gets her way, I won't be ruling Eternia at all," Adam counters, with a strangely amused side-eye pointed at Adora. "She hopes the job will fall to you. The married twin as you are."

At that, Adora finds herself momentarily speechless. She hoped that Adam wasn't aware of Teela's plotting against him, treasonous as it sounded. Surely he can't be happy that Teela thinks so little of him.

And truly, Adora has no interest in coming between Adam and the throne. The last thing she wants is to be ruler of this place—

"Teela can't always get what she wants," Adora says, firmly. "I don't plan on being queen. I don't even plan to stay here for long, if it can be avoided."

Adam chuckles, much to her surprise. "I imagine that few people in the universe would shy away from an opportunity to rule an entire kingdom. How frustrating it must be for Teela."

Adora's brows fly upward in bewilderment. "You're not angry at Teela?"

He shrugs. "Why would I be angry at her?"

"She's basically plotting to help an outsider steal your throne," Adora points out. "That seems like a perfect reason to get angry."

And again, he only laughs. "You're not an outsider, though. You're my sister."

Adora's jaw clacks shut at that, trying to swallow the insistence that she's *not* his sister. At least...not really. Not in any way that matters. She didn't come here to find a family, let alone accept a place within one. She came here to fight Chasm and that only. She has all the family she needs back on Etheria.

But she knows that saying such a thing will only upset Adam, as well as the rest of her hosts. And whether or not she agrees with the current plan to deal with Chasm, she needs Teela's help to locate her. They'll never find her in time otherwise.

So instead, Adora stays quiet and examines the floor.

"And besides," Adam says, "Teela is not my enemy. Part of the reason she does not wish me to be king is because she knows I do not *wish* to be king. I never have."

"Still," says Adora. "Doesn't it bother you that she doesn't think you're capable?"

"Maybe," he says, cocking his head. "But I haven't exactly proven myself to be capable. I'm not like you, anyway. I'm not *She-Ra.* I haven't ended wars, or defeated Horde Prime—"

"You know about Horde Prime?"

"Rumors travel quickly here," Adam says. "We're stuck in a tiny bubble of life on a barren planet. Almost nothing interesting ever happens. That is—until *you* arrived. And since Horde Prime was one of our people's greatest enemies…" He smirks. "That particular rumor garnered a great deal of attention.

"I'm not here to garner attention, or whatever," Adora mutters. "And I'm not here to rule anyone. I didn't defeat Horde Prime to prove myself some great leader—if I didn't destroy him, he would've gone on to hurt more people."

“Still,” Adam says. “My experiences can’t compare. I know nothing of what it’s like to be a true hero. And trapped as we are here, I wouldn’t even know what it takes to protect my people from an external threat. You have far more useful experience in that department.”

He must sense Adora’s mounting protest, because he raises his hands in a placating gesture.

“Not, of course, that I would wish such an experience for myself,” he adds, pointedly. “But you can’t deny that those experiences have made you more qualified to lead.”

“I don’t want to lead,” huffs Adora. “I don’t want to do anything except grow old with my wife and my friends and fight the occasional space pirate. Whenever I’ve led people, it’s only because I had to, to protect Etheria—”

Adam just grins at her. Grins, mischievously. “The talk of a true leader. Very humble. Say that enough, and our people will be begging you to take the throne.”

Adora makes an outraged noise. “Do you seriously *want me* to take your throne from you?”

The grin broadens. “If you become queen, I can do whatever I want with my life. I’ll no longer have Teela or my parents pressuring me to be better. And I can devote myself to other endeavors. Perhaps I will become a musician. Or an artist. Or maybe I’ll just continue making messes for Teela to clean up.”

He pats Adora on the back, causing her to flinch at the sudden touch. Though he retracts his hand as soon as he sees her reaction.

“And who knows? Maybe if I’m lucky, I’ll also fall in love. Most men in this city are too intimidated to date a future King. Take that responsibility from me, and I think I’ll be far better off.”

“And, what?” Adora demands. “You’re going to force me to become Queen?”

He scoffs. “Of course not,” he tells her, shaking his head. “I’m not a hypocrite. I won’t force you to do the very thing that *I* don’t want to do. But…” The word hangs, suggesting that Adora will hate what he says next. “I *will* hope that you change your mind. You do have greater claim to the throne, after all, married as you are.”

“I’m not going to change my mind,” Adora declares, like it’s an oath. “All I want, more than anything, is to go home.”

“Then what’s keeping you here?”

“Chasm,” Adora says. “The fugitive that Catra and I came here for. We definitely didn’t come here to become the rulers of some planet we know almost nothing about.”

“You could learn,” Adam offers.

“I don’t want to.”

“Why not?”

“Because I don’t want to lead the people who nearly destroyed my planet, as well as many others,” Adora hisses. “Is that a good enough reason for you?”

That, of course, leaves Adam speechless. It takes several moments for him to gather himself as Adora storms away, back toward the entrance of the temple. She hopes that the rest of the tour will be largely silent.

The headache reaches its peak during dinner. A dinner that Adora is sharing with Catra, Adam, the King, and the Queen. Adam is trying to be friendly again—asking all sorts of questions of Adora and Catra both, while the King and Queen stare on in quiet fascination. It seems that both of them are still too stunned by

Adora's very existence, and therefore, unable to hold a proper conversation with her.

Though this time, Adora cannot tolerate any questions from anyone. Or at least...not for long. The smell of the food only roils Adora's stomach, which was already made nauseous by that increasingly pounding headache. And the bright lights of the dining room, coupled with Adam's booming voice, certainly aren't helping matters.

She's barely taken two bites of her meal before she decides she cannot take it anymore.

"I'm not feeling well all of a sudden," Adora says, in a wavering voice. Her legs tremble beneath her, and truly, Adora hates it. The last thing she wants to seem in front of these people is *weak*. "I think I should just go back to my room."

Prince Adam appears genuinely surprised and concerned. The King and Queen, however, do not seem to share his sympathy. The Queen's eyes narrow, their sharp and calculating edge returned. And the King leans forward in his chair, both eyebrows raised. They don't seem to believe her, for some reason.

"I thought She-Ra cannot fall ill," the Queen muses. "Shouldn't her powers protect you from your affliction?"

Adora doesn't have an answer for this. She-Ra is talented at fixing most bodily injuries, sure. But never once has She-Ra proven capable of alleviating Adora of exhaustion or headaches.

But her head pounds too viciously for Adora to summon a coherent explanation. She's lucky that Catra is there. Catra, who stands and speaks to the queen with careful diplomacy.

"She-Ra is good at healing physical injuries," says Catra. "But she doesn't do so well with migraines. No one knows what really causes them, right?"

The Queen only hums, but nonetheless, waves Adora toward the door—inviting her to leave with a pointed, "Rest well, Adora. We hope to see you recovered by tomorrow."

Adora grits her teeth at that, her scream of outrage only restrained by that awful, incessant headache drumming behind her own eyes. She knows better, in this case, than to argue or throw a tantrum. Her brain can barely handle the noise of Adora's own heartbeat, let alone some other shrieking outburst.

But she shouldn't need the Queen's permission to leave. And she shouldn't be made to feel *guilty*, or like she's the subject of suspicion, simply because she claims to feel ill.

Catra's hand is warm on Adora's back as she's gently guided from the dining room and led back to their quarters. Adora can barely keep her eyes open throughout the entire walk back. Though sleep, of course, is not a worry. Not while *Essence of Oblivion* still pulses through her veins. It's the light itself that she can barely handle, reflecting and refracting across the castle's crystal walls and floors.

Once there, she promptly extinguishes all light sources and collapses onto the bed. She has little choice but to curl into some sort of pathetic ball shape, her head clutched between her arms. As though the bracing of her own muscles might protect her from the onslaught within her own head.

"Ugh," she groans, face buried in the covers—thereby muffling her voice. "I want to take a nap *so* badly."

"I know," says Catra, as she scoots herself into the bed—filling the space beside Adora, nestling herself into the curves of Adora's body. "You will soon. We just have to keep it together until Chasm is caught."

Headaches like these must be familiar by now, to Catra. They happened often enough to Adora during all those months of Chasm-induced nightmares. Her headache was persistent back

then, and worsened at particular intervals—leaving Adora to do nothing but this. The option to curl up on a soft surface and pray for the pain to disappear.

Catra always tried to keep Adora company, just as she is now. And Adora is inexpressibly grateful for the way that Catra coaxes Adora onto her back, arranging her shoulders between Catra's own arms. She's grateful for the coolness of the water that Catra tips into Adora's mouth And she's even more grateful for the gentle circling of Catra's fingers, which massage pain from Adora's temples.

But without the ability to sleep—not even for the briefest of hours or moments—Adora doesn't know how a headache this severe can ever go away. Her body is practically *screaming* for some respite. A moment of shut eyes and peace and *thoughtlessness*.

But it's impossible. Rest, *sleep*, is impossible, unless she risks yielding control of her own mind to Chasm.

And she actually considers it, for a moment. What if she stopped taking the potion for a short while? What if she simply gave up? Not forever, of course, but just for a few hours. Chasm might place her in another illusion, sure. But Catra could make sure that Adora wakes up. She could allow Adora to achieve a full night's sleep for herself, then use a fresh vial of *Essence of Eternity* to rouse Adora from Chasm's spell—

But then Adora remembers the risk. The risk that she'll see something truly awful while under Chasm's influence. Something crafted to break Adora, and give Chasm control.

She could try to fight it, yes. Adora can tell herself that she won't be fooled twice.

But is it true, that claim? Chasm nearly killed her the last time Adora was trapped in her illusions. She nearly convinced Adora to sacrifice herself. And what if, in those few hours of sleep, she

makes Adora live yet another lifetime of tragedies? Tragedies that drive her toward yet another deadly fate?

What if—?

KNOCK KNOCK.

It's loud, that knocking. Too loud. Like meteorites striking the planet, rather than a knuckle rapping across the surface of a door. Adora merely groans and turns over, seeking distance from the noise. She's not getting up to answer the door. Not now, not ever —

KNOCK KNOCK.

When the knocking persists, forcing Adora to whine her displeasure, Catra is forced to attend to it. She is careful as she disentangles herself from Adora, laying Adora's head gently upon the pillow before slinking over to the door, feet padding silently on crystal. Though her mouth is not silent, not entirely. She's grumbling in annoyance, and amidst it, Adora just barely catches the words "*Teela*," and "*Chasm*."

But when Catra unlatches the door and swings it open, that's not at all what she finds on the other side.

"Prince Adam?" Adora hears Catra say, her voice pitching high in its confusion. "What are you doing here?"

It's a painful effort for Adora to open her eyes, but she just manages to do it. The light from the exterior hallway utterly glares into Adora's eyes, though it cuts the familiar silhouette of someone standing there, just beyond Catra's figure.

Adora's vision is blurred by pain-induced tears, but she thinks it *is* him. Prince Adam is here, at her door. Craning his neck to get a better look at Adora, still curled up on the bed as she is.

"I want to help her," he says, pleading. "Adora. She really did look unwell at dinner..."

"I don't think…" Catra trails off, then sighs. "I don't see how there's much you can do."

"She's my sister," Adam pleads. "At least let me *try* to help. I've brought supplies—"

Adora attempts to squint her eyes open again, curious to see what, exactly, Adam has brought to help her. But she can't. Her head hurts too badly to focus her vision that acutely. She can only shut her eyes and wonder what Catra will do. Adora herself is in no position to argue—no position to deny Adam, or accept him.

She can't summon the resolve to even *tell* Catra what she wishes —that Adam should be shooed away, and sent far from this bedroom. That Adora wants to be left in peace with Catra and no one else.

But it's evident that Catra cannot read Adora's mind, in this case. Adora hears Catra give another mighty sigh and then...the squeaking of the hinges as the door is pulled open wide, permitting Adam to enter.

"Thank you," he says to Catra's terse humming in response.

Moments after, Adora detects the faint thump of approaching footsteps. Adam's footsteps, she is sure. Catra is always silent when she walks, perfectly graceful as she is.

And then, a sound she cannot quite identify. A dragging noise, followed by a clacking. The shifting of weight and the sinking of a body. She opens her right eye just enough to see Adam at her side, having pulled the desk chair to a spot adjacent to the bed.

"Hey, Adora," he greets with a smile, blue eyes twinkling. Blue eyes that Adora has seen often enough, reflected in a mirror's surface. "How are you feeling?"

She merely groans and squeezes her eyes shut, turning over onto her *other* side now, facing the door and away from Adam. The last

thing Adora needs is a *sibling* to annoy her while she's feeling at her worst.

The last thing she needs is a sibling in general.

"I brought some compresses from my parents' quarters," he whispers, having finally caught onto the fact that Adora needs *reduced* volume, if he's to stay here. "They get headaches often enough. I don't know why they expected you not to, She-Ra or not."

She cannot protest as he lays one of such compresses across Adora's forehead. And that's what she wants to do, at first. Yell. Deny. Protest. Demand that he leave, and take his compresses with him. She doesn't want the Eternians' help beyond the help Teela is providing in capturing Chasm.

Though as the compress touches her skin, she finds that attitude washed away. It feels good, that compress. It's cool ocean water compared to the explosive, *burning* magma that churns within her own head.

Adam pats her shoulder. "I have a bad feeling it runs in the family."

She flinches at his touch. Family. He's referring to her as part of his family. The royal family of Eternia. The same Eternians who built a the Heart of Etheria and killed Mara—

"You're not..." Adora mutters, before she can stop herself. Covering her face with her hand as she insists,"...you're *not* my family."

And in other circumstances, she'd know better than to say something so hurtful. But her head is pounding too loudly, and Adam's presence is too damn overbearing. She doesn't want a stranger seeing her this way—curled in on herself, paralyzed by pain, so vulnerable and helpless and…

Weak. She feels so weak like this. Like one loud noise or bright light might shatter Adora into a million cowering pieces.

And she especially doesn't want the Eternians to think that she's weak enough to be manipulated, used. Just as she was manipulated and used by her so-called "people" in the past.

She expects Adam to grow angry. To stand and leave in a huff. To snatch back his compress and storm out with mutterings of Adora's ungratefulness.

But he doesn't. He merely sighs.

"Yes," he says. "I understand. Mother and father are hardly the most pleasant of people. Their expectations are absurdly high toward everyone they meet. You should not take it personally. "

She hears him release another scoff. A derisive one.

"But really...what can you expect of rulers of a half-destroyed empire? They're desperate to control whatever they still can. Not that it will make us matter again, in the grand scheme of the universe. And not that we *deserve* to matter."

Adora shakes her head. "That's not it," she manages, though that *is* partially it. She doesn't like the King and Queen, doesn't like how they treat her. They're hardly the loving mother and father that she pictured for herself, back when she was first told that she hailed from a planet *other* than Etheria.

But now she's beyond such fantasies. She doesn't care about having a mother or a father. More than anything...she just doesn't want any part of the First Ones' legacy. She wants to be free of the stain they left on the universe.

She turns over and again squints open an eye at him.

"I don't want to be one of you," she hisses. "I don't want to be an *Eternian* or a First One, or whatever else you called yourselves while you were poisoning my planet—"

It takes too much—arguing like this. She feels Catra sink down onto the bed beside her, a hand laid over Adora's shoulder to calm her. But she can't be calm. Not about this, even if he hates her for it.

But Adora is surprised to see him nodding his agreement. Nodding, despite how her words weigh with accusation and barely-restrained disgust.

"I understand what you must think of us," he says, though his eyes are affixed to the hands that lie in his lap. "Our people...we have a shameful history. We don't like to talk about it much—we like to claim instead that Horde Prime drove us to our worst deeds. But we all know the universe was probably better off without us. It is no wonder that you do not trust us."

He sighs again, the breath deep and lingering.

"But I hope you can trust that I don't mean you harm."

Adam reaches down and begins rummaging within his pocket. After a few moments, he pulls out a strange trinket—a golden medallion attached to a metal chain. There's a rune carved into the medallion's face, though Adora can't guess what it means. Especially in this state.

"When I last crashed one of Teela's wind raiders," he begins, with a slight smile, "I broke several bones and gave myself a rather nasty concussion. The Sorceress gave me this—an amulet. Amulets can allow spells to be carried by someone other than the caster. She gave me this amulet to ease the pain. I found it helped quite a bit. It might also help you as well."

Adora blinks, then glances up at Adam in fear. "Will it put me to sleep?"

He raises an eyebrow, clearly confused by the question—and why Adora would be so afraid of sleep. "Ah...no? Not that I remember. Its sole purpose is to reduce pain, and even then, it doesn't remove it completely. Only makes it more bearable."

“Oh,” Adora whispers, and sinks back down into her pillows. “Okay.” She outstretches a tentative hand, allowing Adam to gently drop the amulet into her grasp. A part of her is wary still, of what it might do. But it can’t be worse than what Adora was already considering—letting Chasm trap her in an illusion.

And that’s all it takes. Touching the amulet, holding it. Once it’s there, nestled in her palm, the pain lessens considerably—muted to a dull ache, rather than the hammering of some large mallet within her skull.

It *is* more bearable, just as Adam said.

She exhales in relief, blinking tears out of her eyes. Tears of gratitude that she’s not entirely sure she should feel. From his chair, Adam smiles softly at her. An encouraging—but not demanding—sort of smile.

And it’s hard to resent him. Especially like this, when he’s only trying to be kind to her. Especially when Adora remembers that Adam was born into Eternia’s aftermath, just as she was. And has equally minimal interest in being a part of it, just as she does.

“I know you do not wish to be Eternian,” he says. “Nor do you wish to be part of the royal family. Believe me, I understand. But…” He shrugs and shoots her a small smile. “I have always wanted a sister. Someone who can *also* give my parents a hard time, besides just me.”

Adora snorts. “Trust me. I don’t plan on following their rules anytime soon.”

“Good,” smirks Adam. And with the clap of his palms on his knees, he rises from his seat. He’s careful to restore the chair to its previous location at the desk.

“Feel better, Adora,” he says as he approaches the door. “Try to get some sleep, if you can. Exhaustion is a major cause of most headaches.”

Adora doesn’t answer, just nods from the bed. She cannot hope to *begin* to explain her situation.

“And goodnight to you, Catra.”

He waves his goodbye, then leaves Catra and Adora alone in their room—the door shut tight behind him.

“Huh,” says Catra, worming her arms beneath Adora’s back and over her stomach. “That was nice of him.”

“Yeah,” says Adora, quietly. “It was.”

Chapter End Notes

> Also if you saw the new He-Man show trailer just know that I made Adam a twink first!!!
>
> Anyway please remember to comment! yes adam is gay no you will not change my mind, don't yell at me about it.

Chapter 20

Chapter Summary

Adora summons Chasm for a chat.

Teela receives new orders.

And Chasm decides to tear up some fabric.

Chapter Notes

Hey all! You'll notice that this is posted way earlier than usual. My weekends keep being pretty busy so I have to post when I have the time.

We're officially two-thirds through this fic! Only ten chapters to go! (Though I may add an extra one once I get to it). But yeah! Hope you enjoy! Things are gonna be picking up a lot from here on out.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

When the headache fades to something almost manageable...when Catra falls fast asleep, cradling Adora in her arms…

Adora shuts her eyes and clears her head. Willing herself to be calm, and focused only on Catra's breathing from that spot beside her. A body of warmth pressed into Adora's sides and curled around her torso, in a fruitless but loving attempt to keep Adora safe from this. From Chasm's infection of Adora, and the steps Adora must take to overcome it by using that potion.

But Adora is not safe. And she—and the rest of the Etheria—never will be. Not until they accomplish what they came here to do.

She does not wait to be spoken to. She keeps her eyes closed and simply assumes Chasm is there, knowing that Chasm is listening

regardless of whatever Adora does.

“Why are you doing this?” Adora whispers within her own mind. Her mouth remains unmoving as she forms the words, just as it always does in these illusions. The ones she occupies with Chasm in these rare moments of meditation. “You have a body. Several, in fact. So why are you doing this? Why do you need She-Ra, or the rest of Etheria?”

“I would settle just for She-Ra,” Chasm whispers back. And it feels as though she’s whispering it directly into Adora’s ear.

“You’re not answering my question,” Adora hisses. “You have bodies to occupy. Not to mention all the magic and misery you already stole from me. So why keep doing this? Why keep attacking, why keep trying to get control of me?”

“You are still *so* shortsighted, my dear girl,” Chasm says. “What, pray tell, happens when my bodies die of old age, or some other cause? Where am I supposed to go?”

Adora doesn’t answer. She wishes Chasm would go nowhere at all —never claim another body, and disappear from the fabric of existence. But she knows that’s not how it works.

“Even now, you’re thinking it,” Chasm says. “I’ll have to infect another person—break another mind. Take their body for my own. Or else cease to exist on the physical plane in any way that matters.”

“Is that really so bad?”

Chasm laughs softly. “It is a living death. To exist, yet not. To hear and see the universe without being able to speak and touch for yourself. I am undying, and eternal. And without a body to hold me, I am in constant agony.”

“I don’t feel sorry for you,” Adora tells her. “Not after everything. Constant agony is what you deserve.”

“I wouldn’t expect you to,” Chasm says, with yet another laugh. “But surely, you understand that I want better for myself. A *body* for myself, even when these bodies die, as all moral bodies do.” Chasm sighs. “And, of course, any body that I take will have a family. A family that will grow enraged by my taking of their loved one. They will hunt me—seek to take that loved ones’ body from me. Most will not succeed. But some might get lucky, and kill the body that holds me. Thereby robbing me of yet another vessel.”

“As you should be,” Adora retorts.

“But don’t you see?” Chasm asks. “With every body I lose, the more I must take. To defend myself. To ensure that I do not find myself lost and disembodied—”

“You don’t *have* to do anything.”

“I did not choose to be this way, you know,” Chasm tells her, more seriously than ever before. She sounds firm, genuine. Without even a hint of that arrogant, mocking lilt. “I simply am. Born from dark magicks without a choice. I have a right to existence just as everyone else, even if my existence comes at the expense of another—”

“There must be ways for you to exist without tearing lives apart,” Adora says. “I know you. I know that you take pleasure in hurting people—”

Chasm scoffs. “After millennia of being deemed a monster by the entire universe? Yes. I take joy in my revenge. You have no idea, do you? What’s been done to me throughout my life. The prisons I’ve been sent to, the tortures I’ve endured. Every person I’ve ever encountered has sought to destroy me—”

“It’s no excuse for what you’ve done to me,” Adora says. “I didn’t know anything about you when I went into that portal. And yet you tried to break me into pieces. You nearly broke me in ways that I...I don’t think I’ll ever truly fix.”

"I did what I had to," Chasm mutters. "And when I have She-Ra within my control...I'll cease to need to worry. Once I have She-Ra, no one will dare attack me again. I'll have too much power to be sent away, or attacked. Even better...I'll have the ability to heal any vessel I please. And a near-endless supply of magic off of which I can siphon. I'll be protected, finally. Kept unbothered by the Sorceress, or you, or Catra, or any other meddlers who seek to hold me down—"

"So that's really why you want her so badly?" Adora asks...then gives a disbelieving laugh. "You want her because you're a coward. You're afraid of being sent back to that prison dimension, all by yourself. So you think She-Ra will keep you safe."

"I am not a coward," Chasm hisses, indignant. "I am merely protecting myself."

"Protecting yourself at the expense of others?" Adora says. "Yeah. That's the *exact* definition of being a coward."

"And you're not a coward yourself?" Chasm demands. "Hiding behind She-Ra for any sense of worth? Lashing out at your family in some pathetic attempt to distance yourself from their crimes?" Chasm laughs. "If you were smart, you would take Adam and Teela up on their offer. You would rule your people. Take responsibility for their actions, and shape them into something better."

Adora presses her face into Catra's shoulder, as though trying to hide from Chasm's voice. But of course, it's impossible. She was the one who summoned Chasm here, to ask these questions.

"And obviously, you cannot go back to Etheria," Chasm says. "Not now that you've failed them. Not now that you've doomed everyone to a sleepless existence. It's probably best you stay here, accept your place as Queen of the First Ones—"

"*You* doomed everyone!" Adora near-shrieks. "Not me!"

She glances at Catra in nervousness...but obviously, she does not wake. These words...they are only yelled within the confines of an illusion. One trapped within Adora's own head and nowhere else.

"We are both cowards, then," Chasm whispers. "But the difference is...I will have control of She-Ra when this is all over, and you won't. That, I promise."

Adora shakes her head, though she is careful to avoid disturbing Catra. "You won't—"

"Perhaps I will *again* make you an offer you don't deserve," Chasm whispers. "Surrender She-Ra and the Sorceress's knowledge to me, and I will free everyone on Etheria. And that's what you want, isn't it? To be your people's hero? To go home? If I have She-Ra, I'll have little need for so many other attachments to potential hosts."

And that offer, at least, renders Adora somewhat speechless—and tempted. She hates the Sorceress's plan so much, and is so desperate to rescue the Etherians she left behind…

"I will spare both you and Catra, of course," Chasm says. "As well as any other friends you request of me. I will revoke my connection to you, as well as that to any other you wish."

Adora is slow to process the words. The conditions of Chasm's offer. This offer to ensure the safety of everyone that Adora cares about—including Catra, and Adora herself—at the mere expense of She-Ra...

She thinks it might be worth it. Because, really, how is Adora's bond to She-Ra worth more than the lives of *everyone* on Etheria? It can't be. It's *not*.

But then she realizes what Chasm could do, with She-Ra's power at her disposal. She could destroy countless civilizations, countless lives. And surely, she would try, even despite these claims of only wanting to protect herself. Chasm is not as innocent as she pretends. She seeks power to fuel her own magic. And what

better way to fuel dark magic than to wreak fear-inducing havoc with She-Ra's own blade?

And besides. There's a distinct obstacle to any agreement Adora might make.

"The Sorceress will never give me that knowledge," Adora tells her. "Not even if I begged her."

"You should try to be more persuasive, then," Chasm hisses at her. "She is not as fearless as she pretends."

And that's the last thing Chasm says for a long time. The silence in her wake is cold and almost vibrating with menace.

Slowly, Adora realizes that Chasm must have ended the conversation—dissolving the illusion. She's had enough of Adora's accusations and questions, evidently.

Adora lies awake with Chasm's words echoing in her ears. The mutual accusations of cowardice. The ultimatum. That final entreaty to be more persuasive with the Sorceress—which was likely a suggestion to demand the Sorceress's knowledge. And perhaps do it alongside the threat of She-Ra's blade.

But beyond that ultimatum...Adora truly doesn't know what to do. She can't let the Sorceress send Chasm back to that prison dimension—not without first curing the Etherians back home. But there's no way to do that. Not as far as Adora can tell.

And so, within Catra's arms, Adora begins to cry.

The next morning brings yet another awkward breakfast—as well as some rather unwelcome news.

Catra isn't fully awake yet—she's not accustomed to being roused so early. The royals eat breakfast only an hour or so after sunrise—long before Catra would normally wake back on Etheria. Only Adora would approve of rising so early, morning person as she is.

But Adora, of course, didn't sleep at all. She's bleary-eyed and miserable-looking as they're led down the hallways, escorted by guards to the dining room. Catra even worries that the redness and puffiness in those eyes...it might not only be from exhaustion.

It looks like Adora has been crying. But Catra can't be sure—not when Adora spent so long showering this morning (an attempt to scrub away the tears' evidence, Catra expects). And not when they were ushered to breakfast before Catra could properly ask about it.

"Adora," the Queen greets, as soon as Catra and Adora stumble into the dining room.

Catra chooses to ignore that she did not receive a similar greeting. Not that it was much of a greeting to begin with. It was simply an utterance of Adora's name—a roll call, if anything.

It rubs Catra the wrong way. But then again, everything about the King and Queen rubs Catra the wrong way. The hungry way they stare at Adora, the way they seem to ignore that she's a person deserving of their respect, rather than just some empty body they can claim as a daughter…

It's no wonder that Adam wants a partner-in-crime in ribbing his parents. The King and Queen could use some more healthy rebellion from their children, if anything.

But unfortunately, Adam hasn't arrived yet. His chair is noticeably empty. And Catra hadn't realized how much Adam's presence defuses the tension in the room. Not until now, when Catra and Adora must suffer the King and Queen entirely by themselves.

Adora only grunts in response to the Queen's greeting, not even sparing the Queen a glance as she sinks heavily into her chair. Catra sits a bit more carefully, perching herself onto the seat rather than dropping herself into it as she begins examining the food laid across the table.

Catra serves herself—spooning whatever she liked from the previous morning onto her plate. But when Adora shows no inclination to take food for herself, she merely switches their plates (an empty one for a full one) and then repeats the arrangement of her plate again, so that they both have meals in front of them.

Adora blinks as though startled to find food in front of her. And then, with a whispered apology and thanks to Catra—to which Catra nods—she begins to eat.

"Adora," the Queen says again, though with more aggravation. She clearly doesn't appreciate being denied a 'Good morning,' or some other polite response to the way she called Adora's name. "We have some news for you, dear."

And that, of course, makes Catra and Adora both stiffen. The sick-sweet way she says that word, '*dear,*' only serves to remind Catra of the way Shadow Weaver used to utter her own little terms of endearment to Adora, back when she tried to coax Adora into doing her bidding.

Adora's grasp is bone-white around her fork. And Catra knows that Adora is likely thinking the same thing—remembering the same thing.

"The King and I were thinking that it'd be a wonderful idea," the Queen says, smiling with intense pleasantness at Adora, "if we hosted some sort of celebration in honor of your return."

Catra and Adora's eyes meet—communicating wordlessly. One thing is clear in this silent conversation: that the Queen's idea isn't at all wonderful. It's likely a waste of time, if anything. And Catra knows better than anyone that Adora's so-called 'return' to Eternia...It's not something Adora wishes to celebrate at all. Especially since it came, and continues to come, at such a high cost.

“I...I don’t think,” Adora begins, eyes latching onto Catra’s in barely-restrained panic. “I don’t think that’s such a good idea.”

“Nonsense,” says the King. “Everyone is incredibly eager to meet you. You are the talk of the city. And we believe it’s time that you acquaint yourself with more members of the populace, and learn to mingle with more people of great importance—”

“What are we talking about?” interrupts Adam, as he strides leisurely into the room. The King and Queen grimace at him as he enters, evidently offended—but not at all surprised—by his late arrival.

And Catra begins to wonder if it’s a rarity for Adam to attend breakfast on time. Perhaps his punctuality yesterday was fuelled only by his curiosity about Adora—the sister he claims to want so much. Teela *did* complain quite furiously that Adam is irresponsible. A complaint that the King and Queen seem to share, judging by their reaction to his arrival.

As he slides into his seat, Adams smiles and tips his head at Adora and Catra. It’s a warmer greeting than the Queen gave, at least. One that’s warmer, yes, and empty of expectation.

“Your mother and I were suggesting,” the King says, each word slow and pointed—demonstrating how much the King must despise repeating himself, “that we host a celebration in honor of your sister’s return. Much of Eternos is excited to get to know her —”

“Of course they are,” laughs Adam, as he begins pouring himself a pink-colored drink from a crystal pitcher. “Nothing ever happens here. It’s no wonder that people want to meet Eternos’s first newcomer in a thousand years.” He raises his glass to his lips and, just before drinking, he says, “but that does not mean we should parade her around like she’s a spectacle.”

He makes eye contact with Catra. Catra shoots him an exasperated look, and he gives the slightest of nods—like he

understands that *this* is the last thing that Adora or Catra would want. Especially after last night's conversation with him, during Adora's migraine.

He's trying to argue against the celebration for their sakes—Catra's and Adora's. And Catra would be lying if she claimed she wasn't grateful.

"Not a spectacle!" the Queen protests. "A celebration. Our people spent years mourning the loss of our princess. They deserve the chance to celebrate her return, at least—"

"How can they mourn someone they didn't even know?" Adora interrupts, with the barest suggestion of a scoff behind the words.

All heads turn to her. That tentative voice from before—the one Adora initially used to warn the royals against this celebration—is gone. Exchanged for adamant disapproval.

"I was a baby when I went missing. I probably didn't have much of a personality to miss."

That, of course, drops a weighty silence onto the room. Adam looks to be on the verge of laughter. The Queen's eyebrows climb all the way toward her hairline. And the King gives a disapproving grunt.

But Adora ignores them all, however comical their expressions. Instead, she continues watching the movement of her own fork across her plate.

"I'm just saying," Adora adds, carelessly. "It's not like this was some glorious return, or anything. I only came here to capture a very dangerous fugitive...and I…"

Catra watches as Adam struggles to catch Adora's attention, shaking his head subtly, but frantically. Catra is behaving similarly—grabbing tight to Adora's sleeve. Urging her to abandon her next words. Adam, like Catra, must realize what Adora plans to say—and just how dangerous it will be.

But that doesn't stop Adora, exhausted as she is. Exhausted, in particular, by what the King and Queen's demand of her.

"...I don't plan to stay, once we catch Chasm," Adora finishes, firmly. "I have responsibilities back on Etheria. And I don't know much about being a princess—a princess of a kingdom, that is—anyway."

Catra drops her own head into her hands. She knows that, in her periphery, the King and Queen's faces have slackened with shock and outrage. Adora should know better than to expect that the King and Queen will accept Adora's words with any semblance of grace.

Instead, they are cold and wordless for the rest of breakfast. Truly occupied in glaring at Adora, as though she's done them some great personal offense, rather than just expressed her intentions for the future.

A future that does not involve them. The King and Queen. Adora's biological parents.

Even Adam doesn't dare to speak for the rest of the meal.

"I was just trying to tell them the truth!" Adora insists, stumbling to keep pace with Teela as Teela half-marches, half-sprints into the security room. The one Adora and Catra were brought to when they first told Teela about Chasm—the one with all the projected screens and tables. And the one over which Teela presides, as Captain of the Royal Guard.

It wasn't long until Teela heard about Adora's little declaration at breakfast. She dragged Adora and Catra from their bedroom, insisting that they needed to *discuss* these new developments in Adora's travel plans.

"Oh yes," replies Teela, "and what an *offensive* truth it was. Surely, you knew how the King and Queen would react."

Teela's eye roll is audible, even though Adora remains facing her back in her attempts to catch up. Catra, especially, is near-jogging to keep up, as Teela and Adora's legs are longer than hers.

"In my book, *lying* is more offensive," Adora tells her. "I'm not going to pretend that I'm their long-lost princess, here to stay forever. I'm not. As soon as I find Chasm and *defeat* her...I'm going home. Whether they want me to or not."

Teela's fists clench at her side. "And that's it, then? You're simply going to leave us with Prince Adam as our future king?"

Adora scoffs. "And is that really such a bad thing? Frankly, he's one of few *nice* people I've met since coming here."

"And I suppose I'm not included in your list of nice people?'" Teela laughs, mockingly. Though it's more of a derisive spasm than a laugh.

"Not right now, you're not."

"A '*nice person*' will not necessarily make a good ruler."

"On Etheria, we'd disagree," Catra interrupts. And it's clear by Catra's tone that she's thinking of Perfuma, or Scorpia. Two people who are defined most by their kindness and willingness to stand up for what's right. All in Perfuma and Scorpia's kingdom seem happy to Adora. She's never heard a complaint raised against them. So who's to say a ruler needs to be anything but nice, or kind?

"And besides," Adora says, "Adam doesn't want to be king, either. And why does he need to be? Why can't you find someone who actually wants the job—?"

"Because disrupting our royal line is a surefire way to introduce chaos to our kingdom!" Teela hisses, as if the answer could not be more obvious. "Our people have been uprooted—forced to abandon most of our ways of life, as well as our planet. Outside of

the Sorceress's continued existence, the royal line is the only connection to our past that our people can still claim."

"That doesn't mean it's better than something different," Adora says. "If Adam feels like nothing happens here...nothing ever changes here...then maybe it's about time something did! Maybe it's time for a change—"

"Yes," says Teela. "And that change should have been *you*."

"Me?" says Adora, blinking.

"Yes, you," Teela argues. "You are perfectly poised to bring us into a new age—an age that reconnects Eternia with She-Ra, with Etheria, with other planets—and yet you deny that for us! You insist on abandoning us, and abandoning your family—"

"She's not abandoning anyone," Catra says. "We never promised to stay. We didn't even come here with the intention of finding Eternia—"

"Then it was destiny, perhaps," claims Teela.

"Destiny?" echoes Catra, rolling her eyes. "You've *got* to be kidding me. It wasn't destiny at all. It's Chasm, trying to figure out how to control She-Ra. This is the only place in the universe where she can find that knowledge—"

"You say that as though it is not part of destiny's plan."

"Oh, would you *shut up* about destiny!" yells Adora. And she can't help it. She can't help herself as she begins throwing something close to a tantrum, wishing to stamp out Teela's words like they're the sparking start of a wildfire. "I don't care. I don't care what people say 'destiny' wants from me—"

"Is that so?" demands Teela.

"Yeah, it is!" fumes Adora, stepping closer to Teela—trying to appear intimidating and, most importantly, *certain*. "Because I'm

done with it. I'm done being told what my destiny is. I'm done giving up what *I want* for what other people claim they need from me."

"And do you not *want* to find Chasm?" demands Teela.

"Of course I do, you know that."

"Then why are you so determined to sabotage yourself?" asks Teela. "You just told the King and Queen that you will leave as soon as she is caught."

"So?" asks Adora.

"So," hisses Teela, glancing around and lowering her voice. And Adora is startled to realize that Teela is attempting to say something in confidence. "As Captain of the Royal Guard, I am required to follow the King and Queen's orders. Which means..."

She glances meaningfully at Adora and Catra, willing them to understand her meaning even without a proper explanation. But Adora can't grasp it—not at first. What do the King and Queen's orders have to do with finding Chasm?

But Catra releases an incredulous breath. "They've asked you to delay your search, haven't they? To keep Adora here as long as possible."

Teela nods subtly and solemnly.

"What?" demands Adora, and lowers her voice accordingly. "Are they seriously *that* selfish?"

"They were not present for our discussion with the Sorceress," Teela says. "I do not think they understand the threat Chasm poses. They think I am just being paranoid, and they see no harm in slowing our search."

"And you're just going to *listen* to them?"

"I have no desire to do so," Teela insists. "Believe me, I have no desire to let a fugitive like this *Chasm* walk free for so long. The Sorceress made it clear that she must be captured. But I cannot refuse an express order from the royal family—"

"Well, I'm part of the royal family," Adora claims, frantically, as she gestures to herself. "And I'm telling you to keep searching for Chasm—"

Teela tips back her head and laughs. "So now you wish to be part of the royal family?"

"This isn't funny," Catra hisses. "We don't have time to wait around—"

And Adora knows that, obviously. She knows that they're running out of time. Seven days of potion remain—and if they fail to find a way to free Adora from Chasm's infection...she'll need three of those days to return to Etheria.

"I don't claim it is funny," says Teela. "What I claim...is that you have made an error. Regardless of whether you intend to stay—"

"Which I don't—" interrupts Adora.

But Teela holds up a silencing hand.

"I said, *regardless*," she hisses, "you must go tell the King and Queen that you've changed your mind. That you intend to stay for some extended period of time. Otherwise they will do everything within their power to delay us."

"I'm not going to lie," Adora protests.

"And she's not very good at it either," adds Catra, grumbling, and Adora won't even disagree. It's the truth.

"Well, you'll have to make it convincing," says Teela. "It's clear to me that you're adamant about leaving. While that disappoints me greatly, I'm not so selfish that I wish to keep you from capturing

Chasm. And if that's still your goal, same as mine...you'll do as I suggest."

"But—"

"Now if you'll excuse me," Teela says, dismissive as she spins around, turning her back to Catra and Adora both. "I have to call back several of the search parties I sent out—order them to return. As the King and Queen have demanded, should you not fix this."

"This is ridiculous," complains Adora. "I tell them I'm not staying and, what? They decide to ground me like a teenager, take away my privilege to *hunt a dangerous fugitive?* What is wrong with them—"

"They lost their daughter, and never recovered from that loss," Teela tells them, tersely. "And now, when they're on the precipice of losing her again...they're unwilling to let it happen."

"They don't even know me," argues Adora.

"And perhaps that only enrages them more," Teela says, shooing Adora away with her hands. "And perhaps if you rectified that, we can continue our work. But until then, my hands are, in fact, *tied*."

And now Adora is the one clenching her fists. Clenching her fists and storming away, dragging Catra across the room from her, and far from Teela.

Adora doesn't want to stay. But she can't afford to lose track of Chasm, either.

"Just received new orders!" one of the soldiers yell, waving some sort of glowing communicator in the air.

Another soldier—one clad in silvery-blue armor adorned with a single pair of red and green medals—snatches the communicator from the other soldier's hands, lowering it to read. They *humpf* at

the words displayed there, evidently displeased. Then they thrust the communicator into the chest of the other soldier.

"Looks like we're getting sent back," says the soldier. "Captain's orders."

"Already?" says the first soldier. "But we haven't even finished scoping this sector."

"Doesn't matter," says the other, and begins waving to the other meandering troops who stomp over the Lenarian soil. "We're getting called back!" they yell, loudly. "Pack it up!"

An officer of some kind, evidently.

Good. Chasm will likely need one of those.

An invisibility spell isn't hard. She's been watching this group for some time. Them, and the rest of the soldiers the Eternians deployed. The reconnaissance squadrons, or whatnot. Each meant to track down Chasm herself, somewhere between these sprawling valleys of rock.

Not that they've been stealthy enough to avoid her notice. Their little machines and mouths and feet are so very loud. Whenever one group comes close to crossing her path, she merely turns her bodies invisible and waits for them to pass by—though not without first monitoring them closely. Monitoring their habits. Their weapons. Their numbers. Watching but not confronting.

But they have come dangerously close to discovering her here, at her temporary encampment.

Chasm cannot afford to lose her bodies here—not without an alternative to possess in the meantime. If a weapon does, in fact, cease the life functions of one of her hosts, it could lead to a near-catastrophic course of events. She could very well find herself without a physical form since everyone here is warded against her control.

They’re warded, yes.

But only for now.

This group of soldiers is the smallest. Only five total. Five who, by all appearances, seem rather poorly trained—especially given how loudly and gracelessly they moved during a *reconnaissance* mission, of all things. She heard them coming from miles away. And since they are, after all, the smallest and most vulnerable group she’s seen...

She needs to act. Act *now*, especially if they are preparing to retreat. This may be Chasm’s last chance—

They’re distracted, at least. Distracted as they pack up their belongings into one of those hovercraft that the Eternians use. And Chasm is here and unseen…

Her ability to infect them—force them to sleep—might be compromised thanks to those wards at their backs. But the ward will not protect them from less specific magicks. *Brute force* magic. Magic that conjures oceans, or fires, or monsters, or other agents of destruction. They are spared from her control. But they are not spared from her physical attacks.

And now that she's in the real world...Chasm has been craving the physicality of violence.

While killing them might be entertaining...she thinks it’s best just to capture them. Secure them. There’s no need to damage a set of perfectly good potential hosts, after all. And that *is* the purpose they will serve, with time. These Eternian soldiers who know so little about who, exactly, they have been ordered to hunt. Who have been made weak by the Sorceress’s decision to hide their history—and their magicks—from them.

The soldiers do not see the glowing rune that Chasm carves into the air. They are too distracted in mounting their vehicle to immediately notice that deadly rune, the one that conjures a monster of grasping tentacles—an embodiment of dark magic,

made real and vicious. It splits the ground with its power, flailing limbs bursting from the underworld like a writhing, living explosion.

They scream, of course. But none have the presence of mind to flee. No. Some freeze in surprise, like deer before a predator. Some draw their weapons, thinking themselves brave.

But the weapons hardly save them, in the end. They don't grasp their blades tight enough to maintain hold of them—especially not when the summoned monster grabs them by their ankles, or wraps its tentacles around their torsos.

Within moments, they are all trapped. Trapped and writhing within her spell...though their efforts to squirm free are useless. Some attempt to scream for help, to cry for mercy. But Chasm merely conjures more tentacles to place over their mouths, effectively silencing them.

Not that anyone would hear either way. By now, all search parties should be on their way back to Eternos—far away from here, and traveling farther by the second. Teela's new orders ensured that. And with knowledge of such orders transmitted through Adora, Chasm is fully able to take advantage of this little...change in plans.

It's not long until the soldiers are completely confined and secure within the grasp of Chasm's monster. It's only then that she allows her invisibility to fall away—her bodies shimmering back into color and shape, thereby revealing themselves to the wide, terrified eyes of those captured soldiers.

Though they regard her bodies with far more confusion than fear. She doesn't blame them, really. The Bright Moon guards aren't all that terrifying in appearance—especially when compared to the writhing, magic-summoned monster nearby. Not to mention that Chasm only managed to break the least hardened of the Bright Moon guards—none of which were very intimidating.

But these Eternian soldiers will soon learn to be terrified of Chasm, regardless of her form or appearance.

Chasm strides up to one of the soldiers. The youngest one, by appearances. The one that was notified of the soldiers' new orders via tracker pad, and called to their superior to verify them.

The young soldier trembles within the hold of Chasm's magical monster.

"Now...let's get acquainted, shall we?" Chasm says.

She manipulates the rune that floats there, near-attached to her fingertips. The monster responds to every change in the rune—bringing the soldier closer, its grip shifting and splitting to suspend and hold the soldier by their arms and legs, rather than their torso.

The monster shifts until the soldier hangs, fully captured, with their back turned to Chasm's body. The soldier whimpers as Chasm runs her fingers over the silvery-blue armor on the soldier's back. It's a solid backplate, one that cannot be torn away easily. Which means that Chasm might be required to exert more effort than she originally planned.

Still. She might as well get started. She has plenty of power at her disposal. All those miserable bodies back on Etheria, not to mention Adora's endless desperation...

It's practically a buffet of power.

One of Chasm's other bodies steps forward, conjuring a new rune on the soldier's back. A swirl of fingers and lines that results in a glow that envelopes the entire backplate. Chasm watches it glow brighter and brighter until finally, it dims. Dims to nothing, revealing that the silvery-blue metal has now become...see-through. Like the metal has converted to colored glass, one that allows Chasm to see the shirt beneath.

And it is true, what Adora saw in that city. The Eternians really do cover themselves in symbols and runes.

And *that* rune is there, in particular—the one that protects people from her infection and control. It's the same rune that all these soldiers wear, though they're fortunate enough not to understand why it is necessary.

They're also just as ignorant to the rune's limitations—otherwise they would be more careful. If only these people understood that the rune is little more than a deterrent. A first defense. And not one that will last, if Chasm is truly determined.

And Chasm is more determined than *anyone* to get what she wants.

Chasm extends a hand and reaches through the armor. Yes, *through*. The spell she cast makes solid objects *insolid*. It is a rune commonly used to walk through barriers such as walls, or doors that refuse to be opened.

Though in this case, there is no need for Chasm to take another step. She only needs to reach out a hand. Only needs to reach for the shirt that sits beneath that armor.

Once she secures her grip around it, she carefully tugs at the corner of the fabric, straightening out its wrinkles so that she can see the rune more clearly. It's there, in the right corner, though she cannot touch it. She knows that from experience—that it burns her hosts to the touch.

One of her other bodies hands her a knife. A component of the survival kit that Chasm stole from the ship that brought them here. It's a small knife, nothing particularly deadly. An instrument intended for cutting bandages and food, most likely. But it will serve Chasm's purposes just fine.

And so, careful to avoid burning Cleo's skin, Chasm reaches out her hands...and begins to slice the rune away.

All protections fail, eventually. Chasm has lived long enough to know that as fact.

Chapter End Notes

Please remember to comment!

Chapter 21

Chapter Summary

The Queen makes a deal.

Adora and Catra read a book.

And Chasm tries a new (old) look.

Chapter Notes

Alright, alright! Things are continuing to pick up in immemorial in this chapter, and it's only gonna get more intense from here. Hope you enjoy!

Also, just as a heads up, I might be posting late/early next week. I have plans so I'm not entirely sure when I'll get a moment at a computer. But the next chapter will go up sometime next weekend.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Where is the King?” Adora asks.

And it’s something embarrassing—how much her voice trembles. But after so many hours of sleeplessness and disappointment and anxiety...Adora just cannot keep her voice from wavering like this. It is beyond her power now.

The Queen merely sits behind her desk, eyes focused on Adora’s face as her hands occupy themselves with other things—idly stirring a nearby cup of tea, tapping perfectly-rounded nails upon the tabletop.

Her hair is still piled into those intricate braids around her crown. Adora cannot help but stare at her, wondering if this woman is but a reflection of how *Adora’s* reflection will look, in the coming

years. It is not a bad way to age, certainly. Though Adora could do without the cunning, calculating knife's edge in those eyes.

"He is off doing…" the Queen flaps a dismissive hand, "Kingly duties, or whatnot."

"I wanted to speak with both of you," Adora says. Though it is a lie. Truthfully, she would prefer not to speak or *see* either of them ever again, but Adora has little choice in the matter. Every minute that Teela's forces spend here in Eternos instead of *out there*, searching for Chasm…

It's wasted. Utterly wasted.

So Adora is here. Ready to beg for the Queen to change her mind, however much it might make Adora's teeth grind together.

"Speaking to just me will more than suffice," replies the Queen.

Adora raises an eyebrow. "He can't make time for his own daughter?"

The Queen cracks a smile, though it is hardly pleasant. The curve of a scythe, perhaps. "What a cruel thing to say. I'll have you know that my husband wants nothing more than to get to know his daughter." Her smile falls. "But you don't seem to want to occupy that role. *Daughter.* In fact...it seems you are itching to leave. And never return."

Adora sighs and hangs her head. "Look. I know. I'm…" The word hovers on Adora's tongue, struggling to leave it. "I'm *sorry*. It's just that...I don't really *know* any of you. And I'm worried about catching this fugitive. But I didn't mean to cause you any offense. It's not that I don't want to get to know you—" (the words taste sour on Adora's tongue, since they are so obviously another lie) "—it's just that I'm in a rush. We're on a deadline to get back to Etheria. I have four days to find Chasm, and if I don't, something catastrophic will happen—"

“Did you know that I wasn’t in love with your father when I married him?” the Queen interjects. Like it’s an entirely normal thing to say.

Adora’s jaw drops just a little. She can hardly make sense of the question. And she certainly needs extra time to process that singularly confusing word—*father*.

But the Queen barrels forward regardless of Adora’s apparent bewilderment.

“He was smitten with me, certainly,” the Queen adds. Her eyes search Adora’s face in a strange way, like she’s locating traces of her own reflection in it. “But I hardly knew him.”

“Why are you telling me this?” Adora manages, finally. “We were talking about something completely different—”

“I accepted your father’s proposal because I knew one thing to be true,” the Queen says, raising her index finger as though counting down. “And it is a lesson you must learn as well.”

The Queen leans forward. Adora resists the urge to push back her chair.

“Every relationship is a give and take,” states the Queen, in a half-whisper. “Husband and Wife. Son and Mother.” Her eyes flash. “Mother and Daughter.”

Adora swallows hard.

She is thankful when the Queen finally leans back, providing Adora with some much-needed space.

“I married your father despite not loving him because I *knew* that I would make a good Queen. I knew that I was built to lead. I knew I could return our empire to glory and raise a future generation of fine rulers. So. I gave Randor my love, and he gave me a kingdom.”

Adora withholds her comments about how little she cares about the empire being returned to its *former glory* or whatnot. She has to, no matter how much she wants to spit them in the Queen's face. She needs the Queen to restore Teela's previous orders. More than anything, more than satisfaction, she needs that one favor.

"Even Adam knows such rules," says the Queen, with a huff. She balances her chin on her hand. "While he takes far too much after his father—a romantic with no clue how to rule properly—he knows that for every reckless joyride he attempts, he must spend equivalent hours studying to become king. A give, and a take. You on the other hand…"

She points to herself.

"You seek to use my resources. Take advantage of my hospitality. And in return...you offer nothing. Nothing but contempt for us, your parents. And a refusal to serve your duty to your people. All take, no give."

"I-I," Adora stammers, searching for an explanation. An excuse that won't show just how far that contempt extends. "I don't have a choice. Like I said, I'm on a life-or-death kind of deadline here —"

"The funny thing about deadlines," the Queen interrupts, "is that they end. If we help you catch your fugitive, this deadline of yours will be over. And you should have more than enough time to serve your family and people. But you…" She shakes her head in dismay. "You seek to leave and never come back. A family reunited, torn apart again. You must know how that hurts us—to be used."

"I'm not—" Adora starts, but again she is lying. It's true, what the Queen says. She is using them. Using them to find Chasm.

It's the best option Adora has. But it doesn't necessarily make it right.

“So what should I do?” Adora asks, eyes affixed to the desk. “What do you want me to *give* in exchange for Teela’s help?”

The Queen smiles yet again.

“While I love Adam dearly...” the Queen says, with a sigh. “Such a sweet boy, good-hearted to a fault...he is still too adventurous. Still too reckless to be King. And while I think he *might* mature someday…” She looks Adora up and down. “Having She-Ra as our Queen would represent something much more important to our people. A return to greatness. To *power*. Adam cannot give us that.”

“So that’s your deal?” Adora says, incredulous. “You want me to be queen?”

The Queen doesn’t say anything further. She does not even nod.

And Adora cannot believe it. Truly, she can’t. She thought Teela was a bit fanatical in her claims about Adora’s destiny, but it’s something else if the *current* Queen believes the same thing.

And Adora doesn’t want to do it. She doesn’t want to be Queen. She doesn’t want to restore glory to the Eternians who nearly *destroyed* everything that Adora cares about.

“I won’t make a good queen,” Adora insists. “Really, I promise you that. Royalty is very different on Etheria. And I don’t know anything about Eternian culture. I spent my whole life on another planet, for Etheria’s sake—”

“Then let us make a more appropriate deal, for now,” says the Queen.

And there’s something different about the smirk she gives now—one that suggests far more mischief than Adora thought the Queen was capable of. A plotting smirk. And a slightly cruel one—one that shows just how much she wants to watch Adora bend to her will.

"If you want Teela's help in catching your fugitive, here is what you will do."

Catra waits outside the King and Queen's study.

That was where Adora was sent when she inquired after the King and Queen's location. Her parents' location, more accurately. Not that Adora prefers to think of them that way.

Though she might need to pretend, for the time being.

Catra doesn't appreciate that she was asked to wait outside. She'd prefer to be by Adora's side when she confronts her parents, but she understands Adora's need for boundaries, in this case. The need for whatever happens behind those crystal doors to *stay* behind closed doors, a decision made between her and the people who claim to want to know her. As much as Catra wants to be part of this discussion...it's not really her place. And if Adora wants Catra to know, she'll surely tell her.

And besides. Catra can't really promise that she'll treat Adora's parents with any sort of proper respect. Not after this shit they're pulling with Chasm, by having Teela retract her troops.

She just hopes that Adora doesn't agree to anything stupid. Like staying longer than they're supposed to.

When the door to the study slides open, Catra immediately detaches herself from the wall and strides forward. Adora marches from the room, fists clenched and shoulders tense—though her face betrays more resignation than anger.

"Hey," Catra greets, and immediately reaches for Adora's hand. "How'd it go?"

Adora sighs and begins walking away, dragging Catra behind her as she goes down the nearby hallway—presumably toward their bedroom. Catra doesn't question it. It's clear that she wants to get

out of her parents' immediate vicinity, as well as out of their potential earshot.

Once they're a significant distance away, Adora releases another blustering sigh.

"It went...fine," Adora grumbles. "But not as well as I wanted it to."

"Did they agree to let Teela send the search parties back out?"

"Yes," says Adora. "But for a cost."

Catra's brows shoot up. "A cost?"

They stop walking, and Adora instead chooses to guide them toward the nearest wall. A wall that she slumps against, her head pressed forcefully against crystal.

"I agreed to let them have their celebration," Adora says. "Provided that they do it...quickly. You know...before the potion runs out."

"Did you tell them about the potion?"

"How could I?" Adora says with a scoff. "No. All they know is that we have a deadline to get back to Etheria. I mean...if they found out I've been infected by Chasm, who knows what they'd do? Probably lock me up or something. And then use it as an excuse to keep me here forever."

A pause. And then—

"Is that why you told Teela that you're immune to her," Catra asks, quietly, "rather than tell her the truth?"

Another scoff. "I don't owe Teela the truth."

"But still," Catra says. "It might be useful information for her to know. Especially since anything she tells you, Chasm might

overhear."

"We've been careful," Adora protests.

"We could be more careful."

"They don't need to know, *okay*?" hisses Adora, and Catra is somewhat startled by the ferocity with which she says the words. "I don't need them to know that I'm vulnerable. The second they do, I'm sure they'll find some way to use it against me."

"Adora," Catra says seriously. "Your parents are being pretty terrible, I'll admit. But I don't think they're plotting to do whatever it is that you're thinking—"

"After what they ordered Teela to do, do you really believe that?" Adora demands, and her eyes are stunningly hard. The eyes of someone convinced, and unwilling to be dissuaded. "Because I can't. I can't believe that, I can't trust them at all."

Another tense silence. One where Catra can't exactly disagree...but also one where Catra *wants* to. She doesn't want Adora to feel this way. Like she can't trust her family. After all, Catra has never met her own biological family. She's fantasized about it a bit, in sparse moments over the course of her life, and she always hoped it'd be a happy reunion of some kind.

She suspects that there was once a time where Adora *wanted* to know her family. Know them, and connect with them, and love them. And though that changed after the truth about Light Hope and Mara was revealed...she doesn't want Adora to do *this*, either. Live in fear of her own parents. They've experienced enough fear of parent-like figures in the Horde, all those years ago. Neither of them should have to suffer that again.

"So you agreed to this celebration thing," Catra says, purposely shattering the silence—wanting it to dissolve into something more comfortable, even if it requires a sudden change in subject. "That's not so bad, at least."

Catra arranges herself at Adora's side, leaning into her warmth as well as the wall. It's only by craning her neck that she sees the barely-contained fury in Adora's features.

"Yeah, well," Adora huffs. "That wasn't everything. They made me promise something else."

Catra freezes where she stands. "And what, exactly," she begins slowly, "did you promise?"

Adora swallows visibly.

"They're gonna let us go back to Etheria, once Chasm is dealt with," Adora says. "To make sure the planet heals properly. But they want me to come back, afterward."

Catra blinks. "For how long? *Forever?*"

Shaking her head, Adora says, "Probably not forever...but they *do* want me trained to take the throne. Turns out that they don't have much faith in Adam either, and if he doesn't get his shit together soon...they'll likely want me to replace him."

"And you're going to?" Catra demands, horrified.

"I didn't promise that I'd be queen, necessarily," Adora sighs. "I just told them I'd come back. And do whatever stupid training they want me to. I think they're hoping that I'll like being royal so much that I'll just agree eventually. It's just…"

She sighs again, trails off. Catra waits patiently and, when she fails to continue, nudges Adora with a shoulder. "It's just what?"

"It feels a lot like the Light Hope stuff," Adora says. "Where I didn't get a choice. Where I had some stupid *destiny* thrust on me, one that I didn't want, and one that even ended up being *dangerous* to everyone I cared about. I don't like not having a choice."

Catra raises a hand to Adora's arm, stroking it softly with the pads of her fingers. "If you don't want to be Queen, they can't make you be Queen. You've learned a lot over the years. You know better than to be manipulated. And even if it's what's best for them, they need to respect what's best for you. Besides—" Catra shrugs. "Once we have Chasm, it's not like they can hold anything else over us. You're She-Ra."

"Still," Adora says. "I *try* to keep my promises. You know that."

"Yeah, well," Catra gives another shrug. "If they're basically extorting you to make these promises...they're not really promises at all."

Catra winds an arm around Adora's back and guides her away from the wall, steering them toward the bedroom. "Now...what exactly is this stupid 'celebration' going to entail?"

Adora chuckles as they begin to walk, leaving the King and Queen's study far behind them. "A ball."

Gagging, Catra says, "A ball? Seriously? For once, I want these planets to come up with something original—"

The wind raider roars over the desert surface, spewing dust in its wake. After days of wandering the planet's surface by foot, it's a welcome change—this speed. The feet of Chasm's hosts were blistered, well-worn. And while she doesn't feel their pain the same way they once did...she is forced to acknowledge the impediment that injured feet cause, in terms of speed.

But now traveling the desert is fast, easy. The Wind Raider carries them forward with unstoppable, mechanical power, conveying her onward with little damage to her new hosts' feet and legs.

And since the old hosts would never make it past the gates…

Chasm simply left them behind, for now. The bodies won't survive in the desert. Not without food or water. Chances are, they'll be

dead in a matter of days. But now that they've exceeded their use, she has little concern for what becomes of them—the old hosts, as well as the couple of soldiers who failed to break in an efficient manner.

She put her full power into the illusions she tortured the soldiers with. The infected Etherians, however distant they are, have provided much inspiration after so many years living on a war-ravaged planet. From their memories, she could conjure illusions of unimaginable horrors for these soldiers—deadly injuries and monsters and losses of loved ones.

Adora and Catra's memories, in particular, have proven effective in breaking other potential hosts. Most people cannot stand a moment in Catra and Adora's shoes—a second of the many tortures they've endured throughout their lives. And though Chasm always tweaks Adora and Catra's memories to suit the potential host she's targeting...the pain is always the same. And it's almost always too much.

She'd use the soldiers' own bad memories, normally. But these soldiers have had little to complain about throughout their lives. They have few truly frightening memories to be used.

Though Chasm supposes she cannot complain. Their coddled lifestyle has made Chasm's goals remarkably easy to achieve. The soldiers here have little tolerance for pain and grief. They have lived isolated for so long—isolated from war and devastation—that it does not take much for Chasm to break them to pieces.

Though two of the soldiers managed to hold out, and resist. The two that she left behind. Excusing their absence might be...complicated. She has considered many lies to tell. None of them are particularly convincing.

But it's no matter—mortals are always absurdly unobservant. And Chasm has what she needs. A new group of hosts...and a means to enter the city.

The solders' memories, combined with Adora's, are enough to teach Chasm how to operate this vehicle, as well as navigate back to the city from where it originated. She pushes down on the accelerator with practiced ease, shooting them past open desert into a steep, downward-sloped tunnel. One that swallows them like the mouth of some great beast—a mouth coated in teeth that take the form of jagged stalactites and stalagmites, each strange structure illuminated only by the lights affixed to the Wind Raider.

Though there's a clear path, one empty of all sharp obstructions, laid out just ahead of them. The Wind Raider maintains that path for a long time. So long that Chasm grows impatient, furious that Adora's memories, as well as the guards', assured her that the trip would be short when that seems far from the truth. These tunnels seem long and winding and infinite.

Oh, how Chasm curses the mortal inability to properly *observe* one's surroundings.

But finally, the darkness gives way to that scalding blue light—one that stabs bright daggers into the eyes of Chasm's hosts.

The gateway to Eternos. The gateway which can only be bypassed by those magically recognized by the Sorceress's magic.

And though the soldiers aren't exactly *conscious* anymore...the wall won't know that. The magic is likely attuned to their blood, or other features of their mortal forms such as their face or eyes. Perhaps the guards' armor is enchanted to be recognized.

Regardless...Chasm is guaranteed a way through. An Eternian body is all she should need.

She braces herself—as well as her hosts. Arranging their figures into natural-looking postures. As the soldiers have informed her through their memories, she averts her eyes from the glowing blue wall as they approach. Knowing that as soon as they are close enough to pass through, the wall will—

And sure enough, with an eruption of bright blue light, the gateway falls away—revealing an entrance. A break in the magical wall. The border has recognized the guards—or really, recognized their bodies—thereby granting Chasm access to the city.

And bringing her one step closer to what she seeks.

A smile stretches across Chasm's face as they slip beyond the gateway, zipping down yet another winding tunnel. One that soon opens up into a wide docking station, or garage of some sort, the structure carved directly from the earthy underground and illuminated by glowing crystal lanterns that appear somewhat out of place, hanging from the ceiling like glistening blue teardrops.

The walls are lined with more Wind Raiders. Hundreds of them. Maybe even thousands. Many of them appear hooked up to machines, presumably to be refuelled. And there are more soldiers milling about, seemingly packing supplies onto some of the vehicles—though they don't look pleased to be doing so.

Chasm maneuvers her own Wind Raider into an open spot along the wall. She is in the process of shutting off the engine when one of the other soldiers staggers up to the foot of the vehicle, yelling "Oi! Where have you been? You were called back over a day ago!"

The soldiers' memories tell her that this soldier's name is Trome. A burly man, with thick facial hair. And an officer that, unfortunately, ranks above any of the soldiers that Chasm currently occupies.

She arranges her own soldier's face into an expression of grief.

"Sorry, Lieutenant," she says, in the soldier's voice. "We've had a rough time getting back on time. Our Wind Raider broke down. Took a long while to fix it."

Trome glances between the soldiers crammed onto the vehicles, his eyes narrowed in suspicion. Counting with his eyes, judging by the jumping of his pupils. "You're short two men," he observes, with some alarm. "What the hell happened?"

“Like I said,” Chasm continues, assuming the best air of innocence she can muster. “Our Wind Raider broke down. We sent soldiers off in every direction to look for a fellow reconnaissance team. Most of them came back. But two…” She shakes her host’s head. “They must have wandered too far. We waited for them for over 24 hours—circling the nearby area on the repaired raider—but…” She lets grief drag her host’s voice down low. “...We eventually had to head back.”

Trome grunts in displeasure, lightly bouncing his fist against the face of the wind raider. “We’ll send out a search party. Captain’s sending us all back out anyway—looks like the King and Queen changed their mind about She-Ra’s *fugitive*.”

Trome begins to turn away with another grunt. A dismissal, evidently.

But Chasm can’t afford to have her hosts sent out with the other troops. She needs to be here, in the city. She has much to do. Many people to see.

“Sir!” Chasm calls. “We’ve been trapped in the desert for over 24 hours with almost no supplies—no water, and no rest. We lost two of our people. My men and I...we could use some recovery time before we head back into that wasteland.”

Trome shoots them a glance from over his shoulder, one thick eyebrow raised.

He grumbles something incoherent to himself, then waves a hand.

“Fine,” he says. “You can man the communications center instead —stay in the city.”

With a smile from her host, Chasm nods her head and replies, “That’s much appreciated, sir.”

Trome just grunts his response. Grunts, and turns back around. He chuckles to himself as he continues walking away, yelling,

"Lucky you, getting to stay in the city. You'll probably get to try the buffet at the Princess's fancy-schmancy ball."

"Planning on it," Chasm mutters, smirking to herself.

"Oh, you are *so* going to regret this," Adam says.

Adora's leaning over the railing of the balcony—one attached to Adam's room. She watches as the royal staff scrambles to organize a lavish party in the courtyard below, assembling tables and chairs and other ornate decor and furniture. All of it is seemingly constructed of the same crystal that comprises the castle walls.

There are so many chairs. So many tables.

Which means there will be *so many* people in attendance. Hundreds, even—hundreds of Eternian strangers that Adora fears more than she'd care to admit.

The thought of all those people watching her—gawking at her like she's a bizarre oddity, or worse, a traitor returned—fills Adora with a distinct sense of nausea. Not to mention that they'll all be talking, asking her questions, examining her for flaws despite Adora's truly *exhausted* state, the bags beneath her eyes weighing heavy and dark…

She doesn't think she can stand it.

"I know," sighs Adora, finally tearing her eyes from the courtyard to instead meet Adam's gaze. And it's still startling—to see the color of her own eyes reflected so completely. "But I didn't have much of a choice. This is the only way the King and Queen would agree to help."

"Yes, well," Adam folds his arms. "Talk about a brutal punishment. I've been to many of my parents' 'celebrations' throughout my life. They're always painfully boring."

Boring is more than Adora even hopes for. At this point, she expects this little event to be downright *torturous.* Filled to the brim with people who despise her, or worse, expect too much from her. She doesn't want any part of it, and yet...

"Yeah, well," adds Catra, slipping a hand into Adora's. Adora nearly forgot Catra was there, she was so overwhelmed by the sight of the party planning below. "We've attended plenty of shitty diplomatic suarees. This is just another one. No biggie."

Adora barely summons a smile—a fragile one, directed at Catra in thanks for her attempt to soothe Adora's mounting panic—and then turns back to Adam.

"The party's supposed to be tomorrow," Adora says, and the very concept makes her nervous. Four days. That's all the time Adora has left. She's since had to sacrifice all notion of returning to Etheria before defeating Chasm, since that would take three days that Adora does not have. If they find Chasm in time, Adora will have to defeat her here, on Eternia.

And if she doesn't find and defeat Chasm by then...Adora doesn't know she'll do. She supposes she could ask the Sorceress for more potion—she's likely more than capable of producing it, famed magician that she is. But Adora will have to explain her situation—and that she lied about being immune to Chasm's power.

Adora will have to explain that she's weak. Vulnerable. Easily manipulated.

And since the potion takes time to brew...she might have to humiliate herself sooner rather than later.

Adam sighs hugely. "Well. That won't change the issue at hand. Our parents expect me to teach you our customs for the ball. That's why I invited you here." He gestures to his balcony, and the room that lies just beyond a pair of transparent crystal doors.

“Is that why you called us here?” Catra asks. “I thought you were just inviting us to spy on the ball setup.”

Shaking his head, Adam says, “Eternos is a place of deep-rooted tradition. As a member of the royal family, our parents expect you to behave according to our customs.”

Catra’s eyebrows fly up in disbelief. “And you’re saying she should?”

“No,” says Adam, and crosses his arms. “Normally, I’m the universe’s greatest proponent for giving my parents a hard time. But Adora doesn’t have much of a choice, if you want to catch your fugitive. As you’ve recently learned.”

Adora gives an annoyed grumble, but neither Catra nor Adora argue further.

Adam reaches for a leather-bound book on a nearby side table—one that Adora hadn’t even noticed was there. Or, if she had, she merely assumed it to be a piece of the balcony’s decor. A coffee-table book, perhaps—though somewhat smaller in size on account of the table, as well as the book.

Adam splits open the book midair and flips it out toward Adora, so she can see the contents scrawled across both pages.

“This book chronicles how our government works,” Adam says. “Now...you mentioned reading much in terms of recovered books and scrolls, back on Etheria. But I highly recommend reading this regardless. Our government has changed quite a bit since we moved here, to Lenaria. It’s actually exceedingly interesting. But more than that, it will help you understand the roles of the many people that mother and father introduce you to...and how you should treat them.”

Adora doesn’t answer, just nods shakily—the flavor of bile burning in the back of her throat. The idea of being introduced to so many strangers continues to frighten her. Certainly, she’s been paraded over a great many strange planets over the years, thanks to her

role in defeating Horde Prime. But most of the time, people are interested in She-Ra, not Adora. And it's easy to be confident around strangers as She-Ra.

But She-Ra is just a detail to these Eternians. They wish to see Adora. Adora, the spectacle of all spectacles. The missing princess now returned. The princess who, according to many hopes, will someday become queen of Eternia.

And to be expected to present herself this way—her true self, exposed in more ways than she would ever want, and yet uniquely smothered by this requirement to *behave* from the King and Queen...it's too much. Even without the added obstacle of Adora's intense exhaustion.

Adora's tiredness is just barely manageable, thanks to the amulet Adam lent her—the one she wears tucked beneath her shirt. It reduces the throbbing pain in her skull and eyes...but existing is hardly a pleasant experience right now, even with the amulet's help. She imagines it will only make her conversations tomorrow even more torturous.

Though she suddenly finds her attention on Etheria, rather than Eternia. How long has it been since she last talked to Bow, or anyone else back home? The magic on Eternia prevents all communication with the outside world. Is everyone alright? Has anyone else been lost to Chasm's illusions, or are they all simply exhausted and miserable, just like Adora is?

She wishes she knew. She wishes she could talk to them.

Though her thoughts are soon interrupted. In a single startling motion, Adam snaps the book shut, spins it in his hand, and extends it to Adora—forcing her attention to the book, and nothing but.

She puffs out a breath and reaches for it, fingers brushing over leather that seems new only in appearance. Only upon touching

and holding it does Adora realize that the book is well-read—the spine loose and creased by a multitude of readings.

"Is this your copy, or is it from some sort of library?" Adora asks.

"Mine," says Adam. "I've had that book since before I learned to read. Along with many other books on governing."

Adora raises an eyebrow at Adam. "I thought you didn't like that stuff. Being King."

His expression becomes a mirror of hers. "I don't."

"Well," Adora says, and waves the book in her hand. "The amount of times this has been read says otherwise."

Adam hesitates, staring at the book somewhat slack-jawed. It seems he's never considered this—his interest in the book, and the reasoning behind so many repeated readings.

And then, after a series of empty moments, Adam finally shrugs. "I said I don't want to be King," Adam tells her. "But that doesn't mean I'm not interested in helping my people. Making their lives better. I just...well...I think it's interesting how we make laws, change rules."

"But being King isn't interesting?" Adora asks.

Adam gives another shrug. "I don't like it—this concept of making decisions without regard for what others might want or need. I mean just look at my parents." He releases a bitter laugh. "They claim I'm immature, but whenever they fail to get what they want, they throw a tantrum. Or attempt to barrel through whoever opposes them."

Adora scoffs in empathy. Yes, she's certainly seen that firsthand.

"So no," Adam says. "I don't want to rule Eternos. At least...I don't wish to rule in the way my parents do. Or how the Sorceress does, however benign she claims to be. And besides—"

He shoots Adora a playful smirk.

"You've certainly done your research too," Adam remarks. "You practically recited our histories back to me when I gave you that tour of the castle. Seems to me like you've read quite a lot about our people. Enough to memorize a great deal of information."

Adora's cheeks burn in unbidden shame. "Yeah...well…" she mutters, fingers straining and curling around the edges of the book. "It was interesting, is all. Learning about an ancient culture that I, supposedly, was a part of." She sighs. "But it was just as scary as it was interesting. I wanted to know but I also…" Another sigh. "I wanted to distance myself from where I came from. And while I was reading all those old scrolls, I got to learn more about where I came from, while still pretending that place was long gone."

"But now that you've arrived here," Adam continues, "things are a lot more complicated, right?"

Adora nods. "There's no pretending that here. Especially if I'm forced to pretend to be a princess—a real one, not just She-Ra."

"Well," says Adam. "Speaking as a real prince, there's not much to pretend. You are a princess regardless of how you behave. To be a cruel royal—like our parents—is a choice. And takes considerable effort. Frankly, it must be exhausting."

Adora laughs at that, and Adam taps at the cover of the book. "You should get reading," he says. "The more you know, the easier it will be to make conversation with those who speak with you at the ball. Best to do it now when I can answer your questions."

She's just about to spread open those pages, ready to oblige, when Catra drops unceremoniously into Adora's lap—smirking that signature troublemaker smirk. Adora isn't sure which, exactly, forces the air from her lungs—the sudden pressure of Catra's weight, smashed into her body, or the pure electricity of *that look*.

“Sorry to interrupt the sibling bonding,” Catra says, arranging herself so her back is pressed into Adora’s chest—the perfect position to see whatever Adora is seeing. Namely, the book. “But I’d also like to do some reading too. I’d rather know what’s going on if we’re forced to talk politics.”

Adora just snorts and brushes a few strands of hair from Catra’s face. “Fine,” she tells Catra. “But...you can’t read First Ones writing. That might pose a bit of a problem.”

Catra just hums and places her hands over Adora’s, guiding the book to *open* beneath her fingers. “Then you’ll just have to read it to me,” she says, smiling. “And besides. Seems like there’s lots of pictures.”

Adam groans and rolls his eyes in an enormous circle. “By all means,” he mutters. “Keep reminding me that I’m miserably single.”

A shapeshifting spell is hardly difficult.

It’s an illusion, same as any other. A trick of the light. A bending of color and shape to suit whatever Chasm wishes.

It’s not difficult to send one of her bodies to some hidden place—a dark corner, a poorly surveilled meeting of hallways, one left largely untraveled by other guards or members of the palace staff. The communications room hardly notices the departure of a single solider, distracted as they are by their responsibilities—namely, relaying messages between reconnaissance teams out there, on the planet’s larger surface.

Those teams search far and wide for something that sits just beneath their very noses: Chasm who is here within the castle. Occupying the bodies of a small proportion of guards, while the rest of the guards are none the wiser.

The only reason that some more *inexperienced* magicians may struggle with a shapeshifting spell is that it requires perfect

knowledge of the subject's appearance. Every fiber of hair, every fleck of color in the person's eyes. The shape of the muscles and placement of blemishes and freckles.

Most people are not observant enough to examine and memorize those details. But that, of course, is what Chasm *excels* at. Illusions based on reality, on details. The unreal, conjured from the real.

She summons the image she requires in her mind. It's not difficult. She has so many memories to pull details from, after all. The guards' memories, from gawking—disbelieving eyes that caught only glimpses. The memories of the Etherians, starstruck and besotten as they looked upon their savior. Catra's memories from her time in the plane between worlds, each memory so extensive and intimate, populated by a strange mixture of longing stares and furious glares and adoring gazes.

And then, of course, there's Adora's memories themselves. The memories gleaned from dissatisfied glances in the mirror, or any other reflective surface.

Chasm nestles her host into that dark, unnoticeable corner—stitching together the memories like puzzle pieces. It will be exactly right, down to the last detail. The last eyelash, the last scar, the very last stray piece of hair.

And so, with the trailing of fingers middair, and the glowing outline of the rune, the body of her host—an unimpressive guard clad in armor—morphs into someone slightly shorter, someone clad in a simple shirt and pants, someone with sandy blonde hair and deep circles beneath her eyes.

Chasm examines her new form, checking it for errors. Only when she is fully satisfied with its completeness does she stride down the corridors, seeking a path that will allow her to arrive from the correct direction.

It’s not long before she approaches a set of additional guards, their glowing weapons crossed over the door. A part of Chasm wishes to appear confident, unfazed—striding forward like the entire palace belongs to her. But that would not be accurate to Adora herself.

So instead, she slumps her shoulders. Refuses to make eye contact with the guards. Mutters, “excuse me,” as she reaches that spot just ahead of the guards. Jerking her head to indicate a desire to be let through.

The guards don’t hesitate in the least. They pull apart their weapons, leaving Chasm free to push open the door and slip into the bedroom beyond—the faintest noise of weapons clattering together, reunited, behind her.

Of course they let Chasm through. These are the princess’s quarters. And by all appearances….Chasm is Adora. She-Ra, and Princess of Eternia.

As soon as Chasm is inside and out of sight—the door shut tight—she returns to her usual posture, eyes sweeping the room that now surrounds her. It appears exactly as it does in Adora’s memory. And Adora’s memory should be sufficient to find—

There, on the nightstand. A wooden box, the lid askew. And within it...tiny glass bottles filled with clear liquid. Four of them, to be exact, with several more empty bottles strewn across the surface of the nightstand.

The supply of *Essence of Eternity*.

A smile spreads across the face of Chasm’s host. Too easy.

She gathers all four bottles within her hands and then, with triumph, she carries them to the nearby bathroom—the one attached to the bedroom itself. One by one she uncorks the bottles and allows their contents to dribble down the drain, an acrid smell rising as the potion itself falls into irretrievable sewage. But she doesn't empty them. Not completely. She merely needs to

diminish the dose—and therefore, diminish how long the potion remains in Adora's system.

Within moments, she has four half-empty bottles of the potion.

Though of course that would be too obvious a change, even to someone as oblivious as Adora. So Chasm runs the tap, refilling each of the half-empty bottles to fullness. Diluted fullness, but fullness all the same. She recorks them, shakes the contents together, but leaves the tap running for several moments—seeking to dissolve the smell with clean water. Only when she is certain that the smell is faded does she turn it off and proceed to dry off the bottles, so narrow were their mouths to the wide spray of the sink.

Of course, even when dried off, the bottles don't look as they should. Water is always cloudier than a potion like *Essence of Eternity,* and certainly far thinner in texture. Though the most obvious difference would be the muting of the once-bitter flavor.

But that's nothing a few spells cannot fix, Chasm thinks. Just another illusion to conjure, another rune to trace.

She issues them one by one, those spells. A spell to clear the particles from the water. A spell to thicken the liquid. A spell to add a biting, bitter flavor that mimics the potion's original taste. There might be subtle differences, Chasm admits, since the mortal mind is so very terrible at recalling the exact composition of *flavor*, which only makes Chasm's job more difficult in replicating taste...but she very much doubts that Adora will notice.

Finally, the bottles have been emptied and refilled with convincing replicas of the original potion, now at half-dose. The last step is the most important. A recorking spell, to make it appear as though the bottles have not been opened since their original sealing.

It's satisfying—to watch those corks squeeze back into the necks of those bottles. And it's especially satisfying when she gathers up

all four sealed, pristine bottles and carries them with what *appear* to be Adora's hands.

Now all that's left is to place them back within Adora's box, where Adora will expect them to be. She walks back to the nightstand and carefully deposits the vials into the prior positions, meticulous in arranging them in the exact way they were before—

Chasm stiffens. There's a noise, from outside. Approaching footsteps and shuffling from the guards. She shoves the vials back into the box and spins around, momentarily searching for Adora, some distance away. Chasm's connection to Adora informs her that both Catra and Adora remain in Prince Adam's room. Not here, thankfully. Because Catra or Adora's arrival at this moment would seal Chasm's failure—

So who…?

Chasm is still standing frozen and startled when the bedroom door swings open. A figure strides into the room—one carrying a large set of fabric pouches laid across outstretched arms.

Chasm recognizes the figure from Adora's memories, as well as the memories of the other Eternian guards. The armor. The medals. The scowling but otherwise delicate features.

Teela.

She doesn't expect this room to be occupied, judging by the way she jumps upon seeing Chasm—or rather, Chasm *transformed* into Adora—standing beside the bed.

"Adora," Teela exclaims, struggling to maintain hold of the heavy load in her arms. "What are you doing here? I thought Adam was tutoring you—"

Chasm nods quickly. "Yes," she says in her best imitation of Adora's voice. Voices are *also* transformed by shapeshifting magic…though copying the exact intonations and fluctuations in pitch is far more imprecise and inaccurate. She'll need to be

careful regardless. “I was...I just needed to grab something real quick.”

Teela’s eyes are appraising and suspicious. “Adam suggested he tutor you for a reason. You should take it seriously if you want the King and Queen to continue helping you.”

Chasm nods. “I know,” she says, in Adora’s voice—trying to appear defensive, just as she’s supposed to. “I really haven’t been here for more than a few moments.”

Teela simply gives a grunt—the kind that suggests that she doesn’t believe her—and begins spreading the fabric pouches across the bedspread.

“What are those?” Chasm asks, unable to restrain her own curiosity. She steps closer for a better look at the items that Teela is setting there, on the bed. There’s a large pouch—one essentially the size of a person and roughly the same shape, though thinner in depth—and then two smaller ones at roughly the sizes of shoeboxes.

“Your clothes for the ball,” Teela says, straightening once said *clothes* are deposited from her arms.

Ah, Chasm thinks. That makes sense. Teela is carrying garment bags.

“Royal garb is...complex…” Teela continues. “But the Queen has requested that you be dressed properly for the occasion. That means wearing formal robes,” she gestures to the largest garment bag, “royal medallions,” a hand flies out toward one of the shoebox-sized bags, “and a crown, as befitting for a princess.”

Finally, Teela points to that last bag—where said crown surely resides.

Chasm grimaces in the way Adora most definitely would, should she listen to Teela dictate her fashion choices.

"Please don't start an argument about this," Teela huffs, seeming exhausted by the very prospect. "The Queen has requested these robes *explicitly*. She won't tolerate it if you dress any other way. I know you probably don't approve but…" Teela sighs. "It's just for a night."

Chasm grunts like Adora would—a grunt of annoyance, but concession—and crosses her arms. Tell merely nods in response. "In the meantime...I'll let you know if my soldiers find anything. We have a great many reconnaissance teams out scoping the surface as we speak. I'm sure we'll find this *Chasm* soon."

Chasm resists the urge to smirk. Instead, she just gives another nod.

"Good," says Teela, giving her own nod of acknowledgement. "Hopefully, I'll see you soon with news. If not...I'll see you tomorrow, at the celebration."

And with that, Teela turns on her heel and leaves, shutting the door behind herself. The robes she delivered remain on the bed. When Adora eventually returns—returns for real—she will not understand how they arrived there. Though Chasm supposes their sudden presence provides a self-explanatory message.

For now, Chasm will have to simply hope that Teela and Adora do not encounter each other. And if they do….she will have to hope that Teela does not attempt to remind Adora of this conversation.

Chasm waits several more minutes before she emerges from the bedroom, heading back to a dark corner where she can transform back into this host's usual appearance. The guards suspect nothing. They don't say a word to her as she depart, so convinced are they of her identity.

But behind her, she leaves four twelve-hour doses of *Essence of Eternity*. Enough to keep Adora awake...but only for a short period of time. By midday the potion's effects will start to diminish, then disappear entirely.

And after that...the real fun will begin.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading! Please remember to comment, and see you sometime next week!

Chapter 22

Chapter Summary

Adora is late to the party.

Catra arrives at the ball.

And Chasm sets her plans into motion.

Chapter Notes

here's the new chapter no time gotta go bye

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After a full day of studying Eternian culture, Adora is in no mood for further complications to her situation here, in the palace. But the discovery of a set of garment bags sprawled across her bed thoroughly *shatters* the meager sense of calm that she had.

It isn't until she opens the garment bags that she truly grows furious. Within the packaging are robes of rich, dark green. A color that normally wouldn't bother Adora—because, who knows? It might even be a flattering color to wear. But then she considers that it will match the Queen's robes perfectly.

Every time Adora has seen the Queen, she has been clad in robes of green. They're different sets of robes each time, of course. But Adora suspects that it means something in the realm of Eternian royalty.

And it sends a clear message, in Adora's mind. Wearing these robes...it will broadcast that Adora will someday become Queen.

Something that Adora has no real intention of doing.

"It's not hideous, at least," Catra says, lifting the robes between her fingernails. "I mean...really, you could be forced to wear

worse."

"I don't want to be forced to wear anything," Adora says. "And I especially don't want to wear anything with...with…" She struggles to find the correct word, and eventually settles on, "*political implications*."

"It's just for a night," Catra offers, trying to calm her down. "And wearing the color green isn't a promise—it's not a contract that demands that you need to take the throne. For all you know, it could be tradition that queens and princesses wear green—"

Adora shakes her head. "I don't want to do it. I don't want anyone to form expectations that I can't deliver on."

Catra sighs. "Adora. It's *okay* not to meet expectations sometimes. Especially when those expectations go against what you want. They can't force you to be queen someday. But refusing to wear these robes...it'll likely start another fight with your parents. One that will interfere with capturing Chasm right now, when we're running out of time." She gestures to the crown and medallions, also pulled from their fabric sheaths. "All this stuff seems to be pretty official. I don't think any piece of it is optional."

Adora merely shakes her head again, refusing to listen. "I need to talk to Teela," she grumbles, marching toward the door. "See if I can wear something else."

It's not long before she's seething at one of the guards, demanding that Teela be sent to Adora's room for a *talk*. It takes too long for Teela to arrive, after that. Adora is left pacing and tapping her foot, standing between the abutments of the door frame as the guards shift awkwardly in presence of her obvious rage.

Teela is still approaching when Adora begins to yell, her arms crossed over her chest.

"I am *not* wearing those robes," Adora says. "You could've at least warned me that I'm being expected to wear something like that

—”

Teela blinks, fully taken aback. But then her eyes narrow in suspicion. Though Adora isn’t entirely sure what could possibly be suspicious about what Adora has just said—did Teela really think that Adora would be *okay* with this?

“What do you mean?” Teela demands. “I told you about this earlier. And we both agreed that dressing as the Queen requests is the best way to continue searching without her interference—”

“No, I didn’t,” argues Adora, with a scoff. “I never agreed to wearing *matching outfits* with the Queen.”

This statement, at least, seems to reduce Teela’s suspicion—since she rolls her eyes like she should have expected as much from Adora. “It’s tradition,” Teela hisses. “Princesses and Queens wear green. Kings and Princes wear red and blue.”

Adora glances back at Catra, who is already broadcasting the words *I told you* with that smug look of hers.

Whirling back toward Teela, Adora says, “That’s stupid. I mean, they’re just colors. They shouldn’t mean anything, let alone whether I’m a princess or a prince—”

Teela holds up a hand. “Like I said earlier—doing this will keep the Queen happy. Because if the Queen is unhappy, she’s more likely to stick her nose in our search. And is that what you want? To lose your chance at capturing Chasm all because of a set of green robes?”

Adora falls silent, jaw clamped shut. At her side, both hands curl into fists.

“That’s what I thought,” Teela says. “It is a pair of robes, not the end of the universe. Besides. If you wear something else, something untraditional, it will only draw more stares. More attention. And given your reluctance to hold this celebration in the

first place, I was under the assumption that you wanted to avoid all unnecessary attention."

"Of course I do," Adora says. "It's just that...these robes...the crown and the medallion...it all makes it seem like I'm someone I'm not."

"They are simply *clothes*, Adora," Teela replies with some exasperation. "They are not a magical sword. They do not have the power to transform who you are. If you wish to become a member of the royal family, only you have the power to enact that transformation. The robes are just a formality. I beg you to simply wear them and save us some trouble."

And with that—and another disapproving roll of Teela's eyes—Teela is spinning on her heel and stomping away, back toward the communications room that Adora surely pulled her from.

And now that she's leaving...Adora has little choice but to deflate. Deflate, and allow shame to drape over her shoulders, weighing her down.

She knows that Teela is right. That the robes mean nothing of importance. And worse, with that argument, she likely pulled Teela's concentration from their top priority—finding Chasm before Adora runs out of time.

The remaining guards clear their throats. Shuffle their feet. It must have made them quite uncomfortable—watching a royal bicker (or really, *tantrum*) to their superior officer. What must they think of her—the very royal that all of Eternos is supposed to be celebrating, utterly flailing at the idea of wearing the color green.

Adora should have just kept her mouth shut and made do with those ridiculous robes. So what if she's matching with the Queen? Adora is She-Ra. These royals cannot force her to do anything, not really. They cannot force her to become Queen, to become one of *them*.

Though apparently they can extort her into donning clothes she doesn't wish to wear.

"C'mon," Catra says, with a squeeze of Adora's shoulder. "I'm gonna get ready for bed. And you should take your potion before it wears off."

Adora hesitates at the door for a moment longer, then nods. It's just one party, she tells herself. One party. One stupid set of robes and one night of mingling with the Eternian populace. However annoying it will be, Adora has certainly faced far worse—savior of the universe and protector of Etheria that she is.

Hasn't she?

Why does the presence of her biological family add a unique layer of awfulness to this—one that has her wishing, almost, for Horde Prime? Or maybe even Chasm herself, so long as it's combat on Adora's terms.

"C'mon," Catra says again, an arm wrapping behind Adora's back. She guides Adora back inside the room, closing the door with her free hand as they distance themselves from the hallway—and the guards that occupy it. "Let's go."

Catra changes into sleep clothes while Adora sinks onto the edge of the bed. She reaches, without looking, for one of the bottles of potion—and is somewhat startled to find her hands grasping at empty air.

After staying so many days on Eternos, she's learned to grab at the bottles by muscle memory. But not this time. This time she has to reach a bit farther; search with her hands.

The bottles have moved. Not far but...they're definitely different. Perhaps they shifted by accident?

Or perhaps Teela decided to snoop in Adora's business while she was delivering those robes, Adora thinks. Maybe she picked up

one of the bottles, trying to determine what, exactly, Adora has been drinking each and every night.

Normally, she'd be worried about being poisoned by someone like Teela—someone with access to Adora's quarters. But that'd be truly counterproductive to Teela's goals. She does, after all, want Adora to become queen. And Adora cannot be queen if she is dead.

She plucks up a single bottle, pulling it close for thorough examination. She lets the lamplight spill over every facet of the vial, noting that it is uncracked. Unblemished. Filled to the brim with the cork still in place.

Likely not tampered with beyond being moved, Adora thinks. But it's annoying nonetheless.

"I think Teela snooped through my potions while she was in here," Adora grumbles to Catra, working the cork off the bottle in the meantime. "The bottles...they weren't where I left them."

Catra scoffs and continues tugging on a loose shirt. "Teela, snooping? Hardly a surprise if you ask me." She shoots Adora another *I-told-you-so* kind of look. "And I *did* tell you to hide the potion somewhere less obvious. I know this room is guarded, but I don't trust these guards any farther than I can throw them."

"If it's not somewhere obvious, I'm afraid I'm going to forget to take it," Adora reminds her.

Now properly dressed for sleep, Catra climbs onto the bed—crawling on her knees to wrap both arms around Adora's middle. She dips her chin over Adora's shoulder. "They're okay, right? The potions?"

Nodding, Adora says, "I think so. They're not cracked or anything. And the cork was still there."

Was, because Adora has finally popped the cork off the bottle in hand. She flicks it onto the nightstand and holds the vial up to eye

level, giving the liquid within one last inspection. It's clear. Viscous. Just as it's supposed to be.

"That's good at least," replies Catra. "Better take it, then. Before time runs out completely."

Adora agrees, knowing that she's likely being paranoid. She raises the bottle to her lips, then tips it back into her mouth. She's relieved, somehow, to discover that it's just as disgustingly bitter as usual. Same as always in the way it oozes down her throat and drips into her bloodstream.

Adora smacks her tongue and lips, trying to rid herself of the flavor. She definitely kept the potion in her mouth too long, trying to check for differences in the taste. But she couldn't find any. That bitterness was, and remains, overwhelming. Just as it was the first time.

Shrugging to herself, Adora drops the empty vial onto the nightstand—beside all the other drained vials. Too many drained vials, really, when compared to the three remaining full ones.

Only three days. That is how much time she has left before Adora must either find Chasm, and defeat her...or Adora must reveal the truth and ask the Sorceress to brew more of the potion.

She'll expose herself as a liar if the latter option comes to pass...so she'll continue hoping for the first one.

Catra gives Adora an insistent tug, dragging her down, toward the bed. Urging her to lie back.

"Cuddle with me," she half-demands, half-coos. "It's been a long day of learning about Eternian government and customs and whatnot. We deserve to relax a little."

"A long day, huh?" Adora echoes, skeptical, but nonetheless reaches for the nearby lamp—fingers fumbling with the switch that ultimately extinguishes the light on Adora's side of the bed, leaving them in complete darkness. Not that Adora really *needs* to

see, with Catra's vivid warmth pressed into Adora's side. "You fell asleep halfway through that book. I was reading for like twenty minutes before I realized you conked out."

"I like the sound of your voice," Catra says, and curls deeper into Adora, legs weaving and entwining with hers. "It's relaxing."

Adora just hums.

"You okay to lie down like this?" Catra asks, quietly. "I know that it's not...y'know. As comfortable as it usually is. Since you can't sleep."

"I'll be okay," Adora says, and worms an arm beneath Catra—to hold her more tightly. "Like you said. We deserve to relax. And besides..."

She presses her lips against what she assumes is Catra's forehead —though she can't be entirely sure in the darkness.

"The potion should keep me awake."

The next morning starts, well….not exactly *fine*, but the same as Adora would expect. Adora is exhausted, same as always from another night without sleep, but the amulet that Adam provided continues to combat any serious pain from headaches or eye strain.

The palace, meanwhile, is bustling with final preparations for the ball. As soon as Adora and Catra leave their room, they're utterly clobbered with the scent of a thousand different dishes being cooked at once—the soon-to-be food for the celebration, in various processes of birth in the Eternian kitchens. It makes Adora simultaneously hungry and homesick—the food smells good...but the cooking from the Bright Moon kitchens would smell infinitely better, if her memory serves her right.

Bright Moon. Glimmer. Bow. It's been so long since Adora last talked to them, thanks to the way the Sorceress's magic blocks all

off-planet communication. They must be so worried about Catra and Adora both—left utterly in the dark about their whereabouts, or wellbeing. And Adora is just as concerned about the state of things back home. Surely sleeplessness must be aggravating the populace by now—

"Excuse me," some harried member of the palace urges, weaving around Adora as she continues staring blankly down the hallway just outside her room. There's an enormous collection of flowers in the person's hands, one that seems difficult to carry. Though these flowers are unlike anything Adora has seen before—they're entirely formed of crystal. Which leaves Adora to wonder if anything in this palace is naturally grown.

Catra wraps an arm behind Adora's waist. "Better get some breakfast," Catra says, a thumb rising to rub soothing circles into Adora's shoulder. "It's gonna be a long day."

Adora sighs in agreement. It certainly will be.

The King and Queen are not present at breakfast. Only Adam sits at the table, picking at what appears to be *something* like a bowl of cereal. There's a wider bowl—one for serving—at the center of the table as well. Likely where Adam retrieved his meal.

"Mother and father send their regards," Adam says, upon their entry. "They've taken breakfast in their study today. Too many last-minute plans for them to make, unfortunately. But they'll see you at the ball tonight, so they figured you would not mind."

Adora merely shrugs. She is only relieved to find them absent, and dreads seeing them at all later.

"What is this?"Adora asks as a subject change, hand angled toward the serving bowl.

"Dry breakfast," says Adam, wrinkling his nose. "Something already made from the palace cupboard. The kitchens are fully occupied preparing food for tonight, as you probably smelled on your way here. I'm sure the King and Queen received something

more lavish but…" He, too, gives a shrug. "I'm not the King and Queen."

Adora scoops some dry breakfast (which truly seems to be cereal, judging by texture and shape) into a bowl. It's a welcome return to some form of familiarity—something similar, at least, to what she knows from back on Etheria—before later tonight, when Adora will be fully assaulted by the strangeness of Eternian culture.

Catra does the same, and sits beside Adora. The atmosphere in the room feels several tons lighter without the intolerable weight of the King and Queen's eyes, watching Adora and Catra's every move.

Adam's eyes sparkle with concern from across the table. "How are you feeling?" he asks.

"Nervous," Adora says, and it's honest.

"That's alright," he tells her. "Honestly, the easiest way to get through tonight is just to smile and nod. If people ask you questions, answer them vaguely and change the subject—ask about what they do for a living. People love to talk about themselves more than they love to observe a spectacle, however spectacular the presence of She-Ra, or the return of the missing crown princess, may be."

Adora is once again stunned by how much Adam seems to know about navigating these sorts of political events. She knows, of course, that much of that strategy comes with practice. He has been a prince his whole life. But part of it, Adora suspects, comes from a desire to know, to excel.

Adora was much like that back in the Horde, when it came to studying the princesses. She wanted to win. She wanted to be the best. She wanted to prove herself. And obviously Shadow Weaver didn't encourage Adora in any of the right ways...but Adora

always had a certain ambition to help people, to change the world for the better, regardless of Shadow Weaver's teachings.

And maybe, deep down, Adam also wants to be the best king he can be. Not that anyone ever made the proper effort to encourage that, or him, in general.

After breakfast, Adora and Catra once again visit Adam's room, where they can continue to watch the final preparations for the ball from the balcony. The courtyard is almost fully decorated now—a sparkling wonderland of crystal and light that will surely grow more luminous come nighttime. She sees tables upon tables of plates and cutlery, fountains that will surely be for drinks, a marble-smooth swathe of floor for dancing—

Adora blinks, a sudden wave of exhaustion washing over her—utterly decimating her ability to process the sights before her. Her eyes grow particularly heavy. Like they're formed of metal weights, rather than something organic.

Catra must see Adora sway a bit in her chair, and diverts her eyes from the courtyard below—expression morphing from indifference to intense concern. "You okay?" she asks.

Nodding, Adora steadies herself. Wills her eyes back open. "Yeah," she says, and demands that the word be true. "Just...stressed. Which doesn't really help things, does it?"

As the opening hour of the ball grows closer, Adam offers to help Adora dress properly for the ball, as she's never worn Eternian robes before—and especially hasn't worn Eternian *royal* robes. Adora is still reluctant about wearing anything that she hasn't picked out for herself, but reminds herself of what Teela said. That it's not worth the argument with the King and Queen.

They head back to Adora and Catra's quarters. Once there, Catra and Adam sit in the nearby bedroom while Adora dresses in the bathroom. She's frightened to discover that it's suddenly a terrible effort to even stand upright, to even pull her body through that

swathe of thick fabric. She feels as though she's moving through tar, each thought and movement as sluggish as honey dripping off a spoon.

How is she supposed to carry conversations with Eternian socialites when she can hardly dress herself?

It feels like an eternity before she's finally ready to emerge. Adora granted herself only the briefest of glances at the bathroom mirror before she left it behind, but Catra's reaction to her appearance confirms her suspicions. The furrowing of Catra's brow and the twisting of her lips tells Adora one thing, the same thing the mirror told her—that Adora does not look like herself at all.

Green isn't a color Adora wears very often. It looks strange on her. Foreign, almost. And beyond that...the style of the robes...they're just not anything Adora is used to, and certainly not something she would wear of her own accord.

Catra can tell, of course. She can sense the discomfort radiating off Adora in such enormous waves. She's practically a supernova of awkwardness.

Adam doesn't know any better though. He tells her that it fits perfectly, and that she looks great—as if that's a comfort, rather than a source of shame. He helps her affix the royal medallions to the front of her robes. It's definitely not a configuration she would understand on her own—all the loops and pins and locks that attach the medallion in place. Adam's hands are practiced, though. He secures the medallions with ease.

The last piece is that crown. The final insult to injury—the unequivocal proof that Adora is Eternian royalty, however much she might try to escape that piece of herself.

Unlike the robes and medallion, the crown does not 'fit perfectly,' and even Adam knows better than to lie to her about it. It appears out of place, a bright figment of gold laid atop dull, limp strands of sandy blonde. A treasure washed up on a rocky shore,

waiting to be collected and brought somewhere that values its worth.

Adora often wears some sort of tiara as She-Ra, but She-Ra has far better hair than Adora does. And in the few occasions that Adora has worn tiara-like hairpieces back on Etheria, they're always delicate. Small. Modest. This crown is enormous by comparison—a heavy wreath of gold interlaid with crystal-formed gems. Wearing it makes Adora's neck ache, muscles straining as she fights the crown's gravity. And it probably shows, given Adora's slumped, fatigued posture.

"I used to help mother braid her hair," Adam offers. "She has the same issues—as do I, really, but my crown better suits my hairstyle. I can weave the crown into your hair like mother wears it—"

"No," interrupts Adora, adamant and terse. "It's fine as is."

And truly, she could care less about how the crown looks. She's going to disappoint these people either way. Her eyes are so heavy, her thoughts so muddled. There's no possible way that Adora will be able to hold a coherent conversation with a single Eternian at this stupid party.

And Adora really *shouldn't* care that she's going to disappoint them. So why does she? Why does she care? It's nothing. She's not staying in this place, and she's not going to be their princess, let alone their Queen.

Adam is taken aback—concerned, even—by Adora's fierce insistence. An eyebrow raises in skepticism. "Are you sure?"

"Positive," snaps Adora,. "The worse the crown looks, the better. I don't want anyone here getting used to seeing me in it."

Adam opens his mouth to reply...but must ultimately think better of it, because his mouth snaps shut only seconds later.

“Well. In that case,” Adam says, “you are now officially dressed for an Eternian ball. How do you feel?”

“Tired,” Adora says, because it’s the truth. She’s so tired. She’s tired beyond expression. Her body is utterly *demanding* sleep and she cannot give it, not while taking *Essence of Eternity*.

Adam’s features soften. “Did you get any sleep at all?”

Adora scoffs but doesn’t answer. She forgets, sometimes, that she never told Adam about her condition. That she’s been infected by Chasm, and takes a potion to keep Chasm from trapping her within a sleep spell. A potion that bars all sleep, magically-induced or otherwise.

The lack of answer is easy enough for Adam to interpret though. “Ah,” he says, with an empathetic nod. “That little, huh?”

Again, Adora doesn’t answer. Not really. Just sighs and glances at Catra, who is staring back with an equally worried expression.

Adam reaches out to place a hand on Adora’s shoulder. Adora is too tired to even react...but she doesn’t find the gesture unpleasant. Or unwanted. It simply is. A comforting gesture from someone who genuinely means to comfort.

“Look,” he says. “If you feel overwhelmed...or simply tire of talking to someone, just call me over and I’ll take the conversation off your hands.” He shrugs. “Most of the court doesn’t like me, anyway. Many of them will leave the conversation if I join. And if they don’t, I can carry these conversations just as well. You can just stay silent and listen, if that’s what you’d prefer.”

Adora hesitates, then nods her gratitude. “Yeah,” she says, and each word feels like cotton in her mouth. “Yeah, I think that’d help.”

Smiling, Adam says, “Good,” and claps Adora on the shoulder. A congratulatory gesture rather than a comforting one. “The ball starts in a couple hours. Mother and father expect you down in

the courtyard by sunset. Any later, and she might assume you've been assassinated and send guards after you."

"What I wouldn't give to be assassinated," Adora mutters to herself. And while it's a joke—Adora isn't quite desperate enough to give her life to get out of tonight's affair—she would give *quite a bit* to somehow worm her way out of the obligation.

Adam doesn't appear to hear it, but Catra does. She snorts.

"Well...I believe my job is finished here," Adam says, and gives Adora a short pat on the back. "You are dressed. Ready to make your appearance. And you look like a proper Eternian princess."

Adora makes a disgusted noise and sinks onto the bed, beside Catra—likely rumpling the robes that have been so carefully arranged around her figure. Adam quirks a sympathetic smile at her annoyance.

"I'd best go help greet guests as they arrive," he says, and begins inching toward the door. Though his gaze remains on Adora. "Remember: sunset. The Queen won't be happy if you're late."

Adora nods.

Sunset. A matter of hours.

"Good," Adam tells her, as he slides beyond the door. "I'll see you soon, at the ball."

Catra weaves her arm through Adora's as he slips into the hallway, and out of sight. Adora, meanwhile, feels as though her head is filled with lead weights—and she cannot tell if she should blame the crown or the exhaustion that throbs behind her eyes.

Adora fiddles with the amulet beneath her robes. It's supposed to help her with headaches, with pain. And that's what this is, isn't it? Another headache induced by Adora's sleepless nights?

And yet, it's different. While there's pain there, within her skull (there always is, when she is *this* sleep deprived) it's not quite the migraines she suffered before Adam gifted the amulet to her. It's not an ache, or a sharp epicenter. But rather...a heaviness. Adora's mind feels as though it weighs a thousand pounds. Her limbs, too, demand stillness. Each and every particle of her body screams to simply be laid upon a bed, and washed away by sleep.

A glance at the nearby window reveals the sun dipping below the city skyline. And for the first time, Adora realizes that beyond her first walk through the city, she never had the chance to truly explore Eternos. All she's ever seen is this damn castle and the empty Lenarian landscape beyond the city borders.

It's just barely sunset. Just barely, so Adora feels no particular rush. The very idea of rising to her feet fills Adora with dread.

But Catra nonetheless stands and stretches, roused to her feet by the expectation of their arrival down there, in the courtyard.

Catra is wearing a suit—a simple navy blazer/trouser combination with a silver dress shirt underneath. One of her more formal outfits reserved for diplomatic events. It was a good thing that they managed to recover so many of their stolen belongings from Chasm—otherwise Adora isn't sure what Catra would have worn.

Adora stares blankly at Catra. She looks so beautiful, so handsome. Her hair wrestled into that lovely loose ponytail, her jacket elegant and finely-pressed across her shoulders and legs. She is lithe and freckled and lovely and everything anyone could ever want.

More than anything, she looks so *in control*. So confident. She looks as though she could be running the whole universe, and doing it with ease. And while Adora loves the more-chaotic look of some of Catra's other outfits (namely, the suit from Princess Prom, with those torn trousers and loose bowtie, *ugh*), this suit boasts its own perfect magnetism. It always does, which is why Adora

always finds herself distinctly flustered at their various diplomatic events.

Adora, meanwhile….

Adora doesn't feel worthy to even stand beside Catra, wrecked and disheveled as she feels.

Catra outstretches a hand toward Adora. "C'mon," she says, with a soft smile. "Let's just get this over with, okay?"

Adora just stares at it—at the outstretched hand. She knows she should take it. She knows it's better to face this stupid ball head-on, rather than continue to dread it.

But she just can't summon the resolve. Not yet. She can't force herself to her feet, down that hallway, and further down, into the courtyard. Not like this. Not when her whole body feels like it's dissolving into some sort of quivering, liquid mass.

"Just…" Adora begins, fingers curling into the bedspread. "Just give me a few more minutes, okay?"

Catra's features soften—pleading. Her hand remains outstretched in that open invitation. "Adora...we're gonna be alright down there. I promise."

"I know," says Adora. "It's just...I'm not feeling well, all of a sudden. And I need a little time to...I don't know. Collect myself."

"You don't feel well?" Catra echoes. "What's wrong?"

"Nothing," lies Adora. "I'm just...nervous. And I think a few more minutes will help."

Several moments pass in which Catra simply examines Adora—likely studying her, searching for evidence that Adora is diminishing how she truly feels. But Catra likely knows that even if Adora is lying about *how* unwell she feels, it will not change that Adora needs this time. And that Catra wants what's best for her.

But then, slowly, she begins to nod.

"Okay," says Catra. "Do you want me to go downstairs without you? Explain that you'll be down in a little while?"

Adora doesn't exactly want to be left alone. But she also doesn't want the Queen to send guards to fetch her, only to discover that Adora curled up on the bed, searching for even the barest trace of energy to emerge from her room. It'd be too humiliating.

"Yeah," Adora says, nodding. "I'd really appreciate that."

Still nodding, Catra replies, "Okay."

She leans down, takes Adora's face between her hands, and presses a tender kiss into Adora's forehead. Adora holds her there for a second—layering her hands over Catra's to keep her in place. But she knows just as well as Catra does that they cannot stay this way forever.

So Catra pulls away. But Adora still isn't ready for that either. To be left alone. One of Adora's hands flies out and curls around Catra's wrist, temporarily tethering her to Adora. And it really strikes Adora, then. How much Catra has done for her, over and over again. She relived her past for Adora, reentered Chasm's illusion for Adora, nearly got herself killed while fighting Adora when she was possessed.

And now she's here, on Eternia, steadfast at Adora's side, as Adora struggles to find her place—a place that she doesn't even want—in this sick and twisted version of a family. Here, despite Adora being irritable and distracted and sluggish, thanks to the potion-induced sleeplessness.

"I just want you to know," Adora murmurs, and is startled to find tears springing, unbidden, to her own eyes, "that I don't know what I'd do without you. Here, or anywhere. If it weren't for you...I'd...I'd just be so *lost*."

Catra's expression collapses beneath an added layer of concern. "Adora—"

"I mean it," Adora says, thickly. Not that Catra seems to doubt her at all.

And suddenly, she's crying. Crying, fully. In a way that will only humiliate her once she goes downstairs, with her cheeks and eyes left so red and blotchy.

"You're all that's keeping me sane right now and I…" Adora is stammering, each word breaking and half-formed as it tumbles from her mouth. "I love you so much. And I'm sorry I've put you through so many horrible, ridiculous things. This stuff with my family...it's my problem, not yours—"

But Catra merely scoffs and shakes her head. Her other hand gently disentangles Adora's fingers from her wrist, then quite literally kneels to bring them to her lips—kissing them gently, mouth peppering kisses along each individual fingertip.

"We're a team," says Catra. "And nothing about your exhaustion levels or your family is going to change that, okay? I love you. And I know that you—and our friends—are never going to be safe until Chasm is gone. So this is as much for me as is for you."

Adora nods. But still, it's hard to accept. It's hard to accept that anyone would want to put up with so much strife, just for Adora's sake.

"Now as much as I want to stay here and listen to you sing my praises as a wife," Catra continues, "I really need to tell the Queen that you're going to be a little late." She raises an eyebrow. "Unless you've changed your mind?"

Shaking her head, Adora says, "Not yet. Just...just a few more minutes."

Because, *god*, if anything, the crying has made matters worse. Adora's eyes feel heavier than ever. And her face must be such a

mess, her emotional state an obvious wreck, tear-soaked cheeks and bloodshot eyes—

"Okay," says Catra, with a warm smile. "I understand."

And with that, she releases Adora's hand fully, and finally. Catra throws a kiss over her shoulder as she strides dutifully toward the door, her eyes never leaving Adora's face.

At the threshold, she calls, "If you're not downstairs in a half-hour, though...I'll come get you myself. Guards or no guards. I'm not spending that long with your family by myself."

"Alright," replies Adora, with a small laugh. Though it's the largest she can muster. "A half hour. I'll be there."

The door opens, then prepares to close. "Love you," Catra tells her.

"Love you too."

A click, and Catra is gone—the door shut tight behind her, and while Adora cannot hear Catra's soundless footsteps, she knows that they must be receding. Heading down that hallway, then down the palace steps, and then out, into the courtyard. Where the King and Queen's guest will be waiting.

Adora flings herself back onto the bedspread with a grunt. Will it be worse, she wonders? Heading down that hallway, that staircase, by herself? All eyes will be on Adora, and Adora alone.

Eyes. Adora's eyes are so heavy. They might as well be anchors seeking purchase in a shallow ocean.

And Adora is so comfortable here, in this room. Alone. Free from stares and judgment, laid out upon this bed without a care. Well. Except her dread of theball.

She yawns. Yawns big, and long. The kind of yawn that pops every muscle in Adora's face.

And that's the last thing she feels before her eyes fall shut, and sleep descends upon her.

When Adam sees Catra, and Catra alone, arriving in the courtyard, his smile turns to something brittle. Not disingenuous, exactly. But something panicked however he might try to hide it.

Catra feels the eyes of every Eternian attack her as she enters the room. She doesn't *try* to attract their attention, not in the least. In fact, she dips her head down and practically speedwalks down the stairs, each foot dropping over the other in a mechanical descent.

But still. Catra sticks out. Even more than Adora would, missing princess that she is. At least Adora resembles these people. Catra cannot claim the same, and the Eternians have taken particular notice. Eyes sweep over Catra's ears and tail with interest.

Beyond that...Catra simply isn't dressed like the various Eternians milling about. Robes seem to be the primary form of Eternian formalwear, which means that, on top of everything else, Catra's suit doesn't match this unspoken dress code.

Adam offered to have her fitted for a pair of Eternian robes. Catra refused him, but maybe that was a mistake. She is an oddity, for certain. And whether or not these Eternians will react kindly to that...Catra can't be sure.

Still. It wouldn't be the first time. Catra was out-of-place back on Etheria too—she's never met anyone who looks like her. Not in the Fright Zone, not in the Princesses' kingdoms. George and Lance claim there are records of her people—the *Magicats*, they claimed—but no one can remember seeing them in the flesh.

And she can't remember them, either. Her family. Her people. All she remembers is the Horde—growing up there with Adora, squirming beneath Shadow Weaver's thumb.

And that's part of why Adora's family makes Catra so furious. Catra would give...well...maybe not *anything*...but quite a lot to

learn more about her own family. Catra has fantasized about how this maybe-family would behave. She's imagined that they'd love her unconditionally; claim to be proud of her despite her faults. Maybe she'd have siblings to joke around with, or pull pranks on—

It's nothing special, that fantasy. It's probably what every orphan in the Fright Zone imagined.

Which means that Adora must have done some imagining too. And Catra doubts that she imagined what she's found here: domineering parents, parents who endlessly seek to control Adora in the same way so many people back on Etheria did.

The thought makes Catra scoff. Any other family in the universe would be tripping over themselves to learn that they're related to Adora. Yet for these people it's not enough. They're trying to shape her into something that she is not, and has no desire to be.

And this ball is the culmination of that. A pointed attempt to force Adora into a specific set of behaviors, of clothes...and roles. They're trying to force Adora into the role of a true royal.

And Catra isn't sure what that will mean for herself, as Adora's wife. Catra has no more urge to be Queen than Adora does. And she somehow doubts that she's the type of Queen the Eternians imagined, if these stares are any indication.

But Catra is accustomed to stares, at least. On Etheria. Here, on Eternia. Or on other planets throughout Etheria, where she is deemed strange in contrast to a variety of alien traits.

She ignores those prying eyes as she strides right up to Adam.

"Where is Adora?" he asks. His teeth are gritted—but not in anger, Catra notes. Rather, they are gritted in the same panic that crystallizes his smile.

"She needs another half hour," Catra says. "She's not feeling well."

Adam glances nervously at the Queen, who stands with the King at the far end of the courtyard. All in all, it's a beautiful celebration. The courtyard is a lush, gleaming wonderland of crystal and greenery, and the Eternians' various robes only add to the sprawling sea of color.

"Mother won't be happy," Adam mutters.

Catra folds her arms. "It's only thirty minutes," she hisses. "I've seen parties delayed for far longer."

"But—"

Catra raises a silencing hand. "If your mom has a problem with it, she can go through me. She'll be lucky if Adora comes down those stairs at all."

Adam's eyebrows fly up. This time, his nervous glance is directed at the surrounding Eternians—who meander about, carrying overly-loud conversations and seeking hors d'oeuvres off buffet trays. It's almost impressive how they manage to find time to gawk at Catra too, amidst such a busy schedule of activities.

"But you are *sure* that she's coming?" Adam says. And Catra can tell that he's worried. Worried about disappointing his parents, as well as this enormous group of guests—all of which expect, and anticipate, Adora's presence in this courtyard.

Catra's hands tighten around her elbow. "Yeah, of course. She just needs a little extra time to get ready."

Chasm searches for a mirror. Surprisingly, there are few of them in the guards' quarters and bathrooms. So instead, Chasm walks the hallways of the palace. Most have been left empty due to the celebration downstairs, where most of the other guards are concentrated.

Two of her hosts are still down there, keeping eyes on Catra. If Catra changes her mind and decides to head back to the bedroom

she shares with Adora...Chasm's plans could quickly unravel. Catra must be kept there, in the courtyard for the time being. Until the time is right.

But so far, all has been going to plan. A smile spreads across her face, insuppressible in light of recent conquests. She can see Adora in her mind's eye, sprawled on the bed, a red spiral carved into her forehead by lines of glowing magic. Her robes are splayed out around her like she's some fallen bird with great green wings. Adora didn't even suspect that her potion was weakened. Weakened enough to leave her protected for only twelve hours, rather than the full twenty-four. And once those twelve hours were up…

Adora was left defenseless.

Chasm will grant her a dream, soon enough. Another illusion to welcome her home to Chasm's dreamworld, escapee that Adora is. But right now, Chasm has greater priorities. A plan to enact. And knowledge to glean.

Chasm only needs one of her hosts for this next part. A single host, subtly broken from the rest of the flock to explore these empty palace hallways. The rest see Catra there, in the courtyard, exchanging glares with the Queen. She doesn't appear to be leaving anytime soon. Which means that it's the perfect time for Chasm to act.

Finally, she finds a smooth swathe of crystal—one that should reflect Chasm's host perfectly. Chasm will need to examine her appearance carefully if this next part is to work correctly.

With Adora finally asleep, tucked peacefully beneath Chasm's usual sleep spell...it should be easy enough to peruse her memories, and better yet—

Steady fingers trace the familiar rune into the air. It glows briefly before Chasm finds herself enveloped by light—enveloped by an illusion. To anyone else's eyes, the guard's limbs would appear to

shrink, their body twisting, hair sprouting from their head. But of course, none of it is real.

Gray-blue eyes, slightly distorted from the crystal, stare back at Chasm. She has clad herself in the robes Adora was required to wear—the green ones that mimic the Queen's. But Chasm knows that, if this plan is to succeed, she'll need to do *more* than simply look how Adora is supposed to look. Everything is contingent on Catra reacting in just the right way—

So Chasm traces another rune. Beneath it, the green robes give way to layers of fluttering red silk, a neckline of golden metal forming from thin air and attaching itself to a cape of crimson gossamer that drapes proudly over Adora's shoulders.

An outfit plucked from a memory. One that Catra is certain to remember.

Chapter End Notes

please, please, please remember to comment!

Chapter 23

Chapter Summary

Adora gets some sleep.

Catra and Adam see something unexpected.

And Chasm puts the "gaslight" in gaslight gatekeep girlboss

Chapter Notes

hey all! sorry (or you're welcome) for posting early again but i have stuff to do tonight.

welp. only 7 chapters left now. The end is getting nearer and nearer. super wild that i've been writing/editing/posting this fic since like...november of 2020? kinda unbelievable.

anyway, enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora wakes to Catra nuzzling her cheek, with sunlight burning bright beneath Adora's eyelids. She hums and shifts, curling deeper into Catra's warmth. Catra's touch is so warm and soft, Adora just wants to dissolve into it—

"Hey, sleepyhead," Catra murmurs. "How are you feeling?"

Adora's eyes squint open. Catra's face fills Adora's vision—a toothy, mischievous grin splitting her mouth, glowing blue and yellow eyes softened by the brilliant daylight that streams past the nearby curtains. Adora is cushioned on all sides. By blankets, by pillows, by Catra herself. Warm and loved in every conceivable way, nestled in this bed she shares with her wife, in a palace she shares with her friends. Truly, Adora can't imagine a better paradise.

But...something isn't quite right. Adora just woke up. Woke up, from sleep. And isn't Adora...isn't Adora *not supposed* to fall asleep? She can't remember why, but there was surely a reason—

Catra's brows pull together. "Something wrong?"

Adora just blinks, unsure how to respond. Images flash behind her eyes. Recollections, surging like a tide in a storm, flooding away any remaining sliver of warmth and comfort that Adora could still claim. Last she remembers, she wasn't here on Etheria. She was elsewhere. Another universe, another planet, another *palace*.

And she wasn't supposed to fall asleep. She *shouldn't* have been able to fall asleep, so long as she was...she was taking that potion, *Essence of Eternity*—

Adora jolts, trying to spring upright in bed, but Catra wraps both hands around Adora's shoulders. Pinning her down, but in a playful, gentle way that would otherwise make Adora melt if she didn't feel such dense panic ballooning within her chest. Catra braces herself over Adora, still smiling with that intense promise of mischief.

"Catra—" Adora exclaims as she sinks deeper into the bedding, buried beneath Catra's weight like she is. "Something's not right. We're not supposed to be here."

Catra makes a clucking noise—an expression of sympathy—as she leans down and presses a kiss into Adora's jaw. "Princess," she says, the word muffled against Adora's skin. "I think you just had a nightmare."

"What?" Adora says. "No! It was real. Or at least...I think it was —"

Catra gives a half-hum, half laugh, and pulls herself up so that she can examine Adora's face more clearly. "What was this one about?"

“No, Catra,” insists Adora, shaking her head. “It was real. Chasm infected nearly everyone on Etheria, and you and I...we had to find Eternia, or what was left of it, anyway—”

“Chasm?” Catra echoes. And not in the way Adora has come to know—with Catra growling the name, cursing it by tone alone. But this time...Catra says that name, *Chasm*...like it’s unfamiliar. Foreign. Like it’s something that she’s never once heard before.

“B-but,” Adora stammers, “you’ve gotta remember Chasm, Catra. After everything she did to us—”

“Who?” Catra asks, blinking and shaking her head. “Adora...I know you have some pretty vivid dreams sometimes, but we’ve never met anyone named *Chasm*. What kind of name is that, anyway—”

Adora gives a head shake of her own, though it is far fiercer. “No. Catra, don’t you remember going into the portal to find Angella, and getting stuck in the dreamworld—?”

“No?” says Catra, clearly bewildered by the account. Catra relinquishes her tight grip, sitting back on her knees. Her smile is both adorably and *frustratingly* amused. “And what do you mean, *I went into the portal*? There hasn’t been another portal since the war.”

A shaky exhale pours between Adora’s lips. “But...there *was* a portal. I got stuck, and you came in after me—”

Catra chuckles. “As much as I love rescuing you...I’d be lying if I took credit for that.” Catra’s fingers reach out to stroke Adora’s arm. “Adora...I think you were just having a nightmare. A really, really vivid, complicated nightmare. But a nightmare all the same.”

“But—”

But then Catra is pouncing on Adora, nipping her ear and burying Adora beneath Catra’s warm, lithe body. “It was just a dream,

Adora," Catra whispers, directly into Adora's ear as she kisses and scrapes her teeth along its shell. "*Relax*."

It's more of an order than a plea. And Adora wants to believe it. Truly, she does. She just want to let Catra kiss her way down Adora's body, then nap and laze the rest of the day away.

But Adora can't. Something is wrong. Adora shouldn't be here. And this…

Adora fears that, somehow, this isn't real.

"It's been over a half-hour," Adam says. He fires another glance in the Queen's direction. It's clear by her rigid posture and even more rigid jaw that she's unhappy, and growing more impatient by the second. It's somewhat funny and unsettling, Catra thinks. How similar Adora and the Queen look when outraged. Their eyes pull wide in the exact same shape, and their jaws assume the same sharp angles.

On Adora, though, the look is endearing. On the Queen, it's just plain frightening.

But perhaps the Queen is a bit entitled to her anger, at the moment. Adora did promise to attend this party on time. And so far, she hasn't made the slightest appearance. She must still be in their bedroom, likely trying to scrub away any remaining evidence of tears. Or worse, Catra worries that she's too anxious to even emerge.

Catra sighs. She hoped that Adora would be on time. That she wouldn't have to travel all the way upstairs, to their room, and fetch her in the same way the Queen itches to. But now—

The courtyard falls largely silent, suddenly. All conversation is reduced to whispers and gasps and shuffling fabric as bodies turn in a particular direction. With how everyone is behaving, Catra would guess that someone has died at the center of the dance floor. But surely there would be more screaming—

So Catra really isn't sure what's happening, at first. Only when Adam taps her shoulder and points, an entirely new form of panic flushing all throughout his face, does she find the opportunity to learn. Learn, with reluctance. She's not entirely sure what could warrant that kind of reaction from Adam, but she's certain she won't like it.

With another sigh, she turns, seeking the trajectory of Adam's finger…

Only to discover Adora walking down the steps to the courtyard.

But Catra's jaw falls open nonetheless. She expected Adora, yes. But she expected Adora as Catra saw her in that bedroom, in those green robes that made her look so much unlike herself, and that oversized crown which seemed to bow her head.

But Adora looks entirely different now. Rather than the green robes, she is wearing a dress.

No. Not just any dress. She is wearing *the* red dress, the one from Glimmer's induction into the sorcerer's guild. Catra's favorite dress of Adora's. The one that Adora and Catra agreed should be saved for special occasions. A dark red dress with a scooped neckline and golden accents, the gown flowing and swirling around Adora's feet, a gossamer cape of silk seemingly floating out from over her shoulders.

Rather than the crown she was provided with, Adora wears a small circlet of gold at the top of her head. A delicate but elegant addition. It gleams with every step down those stairs, a metallic flicker amidst carefully arranged strands of gold.

Truly, it's uncanny how beautiful she looks. It seems all evidence of crying and exhaustion and *frustration* has disappeared from her appearance, leaving only this strange but lovely echo of a day long since past.

But as happy as Catra is to see Adora looking like...looking like *this*, Catra recognizes the problem this poses. The Queen

requested that Adora wear the customary robes and crown. And now…

Now it looks like Adora is being purposely impertinent. Which means that the Queen might be tempted to revoke her help. Or really, Teela's help in finding Chasm.

And besides—what could have possibly possessed Adora to dress like this? While the other Eternians might feel differently, Catra certainly does not see this little event as a special occasion. At least not in the positive sense of *special*, with Adora practically forced to attend.

So why would Adora wear an outfit that means so much to Catra —to the both of them—amidst such a, frankly, *traumatic* backdrop?

When Adora descends the final step, the crowd splits for her like a river meeting rocks. She appears to be even more of an oddity than Catra does. The dress is Etherian in every aspect of its design—sparkling, gaudy, beautiful. Whereas the Etherian robes are all streamlined collections of colored fabric—ones occasionally adorned with medallions or other odd pieces of jewelry. But with the simplicity of their colors and patterns, it's evident that beauty is very clearly *not* the primary feature of Eternian robes. Not when compared with Adora's dress, anyway. The difference is...striking. Striking to everyone, including Catra.

It's a struggle for Catra to tear her eyes from Adora's approaching figure to sneak a glance at the King and Queen.

Even from here, Catra can tell that the Queen's rage has utterly *spiked.* Her face is near-white with outrage, her lips pressed so tightly together that she hardly appears not to have lips at all anymore. The King, meanwhile, is shaking his head in disappointment, thick brows pulled low over his eyes.

They're not happy. And that's the problem, isn't it? Attending this ball...the whole point was to keep the King and Queen happy. To

appease them.

Would Adora really throw that all away for the chance to wear this one stupid (but beautiful) dress?

Adora finally reaches Catra's side. Upon reaching her, she weaves an arm through one of Catra's, latching onto Catra in a grip that seems strangely detached. They're holding onto each other, yes. But Adora's arm is arranged in such a way that she's barely touching Catra at all.

Adora is smiling too. Smiling, at Catra. But it's in a manner that strikes Catra as unsettling. The smile is too wide, too gloating. Catra doesn't think she's ever seen Adora smile like that before. But then again...maybe she has? It's vaguely familiar. She just can't recall where from.

"How do I look?" Adora asks with a small giggle, her eyes flashing on that last word. *Look*.

Catra's throat goes dry. In all honesty, Adora is gorgeous. Just drop-dead beautiful. She always is, but this dress has a particular effect on Catra. It hugs Adora's body in all of Catra's favorite places and accentuates so many of her muscles. Particularly the muscles of her shoulders and back, which are left exposed by the sleeveless design—as well the gossamer cape that purposely arches and plunges around Adora's back.

"You look…" Catra begins, but isn't sure how to complete the sentence. Especially since it makes *no sense* to Catra—why Adora would be dressed this way here, now.

"Adora," interrupts Adam, voice strained by concern and urgency. "I thought you wanted our parents on your side."

Adora fixes him with an eyeroll—one that evidences how little she cares. "It's just a dress," she argues, easily, with an exaggerated shrug. One that only draws more attention to the dress, focusing all eyes in the courtyard on Adora yet again. "If they have a problem with it, that's no fault of mine."

“But don’t you want to catch your fugitive?” insists Adam. “I agree that it shouldn’t matter. But doing this…” He shakes his head, then throws another nervous glance at the now-incensed King and Queen. “It’s like you’re purposely trying to spite our parents.”

Adora’s eyes flash. “Maybe I am,” she tells him, smirking.

Adam’s jaw falls open just slightly. Catra’s does the same. Just a little while ago, Adora was resigned to doing as her parents said. She made that choice for the sake of Etheria, if nothing else. But now…

Adora jerks her head to the center of the courtyard—where a largely empty dancefloor lies. There’s music playing, but it’s unlike anything that Catra has heard before. Just a set of beats and odd musical swells.

Adora’s hand seizes Catra’s and begins tugging it in that direction, toward the dancefloor. “Come on, Catra,” Adora says, an eyebrow cocked. “It’s a ball, isn’t it? Let’s dance.”

Catra doesn’t even have the presence of mind to protest. She merely stumbles in pursuit.

And then they’re there, on the dance floor. One of only four couples there at the moment. On instinct, Catra places her hands at Adora’s hips. Adora, meanwhile, slings her arms behind Catra’s neck, leaning in close. But somehow it’s wrong, just as Adora’s smile was. Usually, when Adora and Catra dance together, Adora seeks closeness like a person seeks warmth near a fire—nestling in close, for the sake of wanting to be near Catra. But this is different. This is Adora leaning, cutting into Catra’s space, like it’s her express wish to steal as much space from Catra as possible, rather than share it.

“Are you okay?” Catra asks, all-too-aware of the numerous Eternian eyes affixed to their swaying bodies.

With a nod that’s far too good-natured for Catra’s liking, Adora replies, “Why wouldn’t I be?”

She grins. When Adora normally grins, it's goofy-looking. Maybe even mischievous. But that mischief always suggests something sweet, or fun, or *funny* at the very least. This grin...it's so, so different. And so, so wrong. It's a grin that belongs to someone else, someone who enjoys watching something squirm and die beneath their shoe.

And besides, that question...Catra has plenty of reason to believe that something is wrong. Last time she saw Adora, Adora was still recovering from a bout of crying. But now...now she's absolutely radiating confidence. And while Catra loves to see her wife confident…

This isn't right.

"But what about Chasm?" Catra hisses to Adora. Because Adam, on the other hand, *was* right. He was right about what this dress will mean for them, for Adora, for Etheria—and for Chasm. If the King and Queen's fury is any indication, they'll be very unlikely to continue offering Adora help in her search for Chasm.

Help that they desperately need, as each day passes.

"If you piss off your parents—" Catra continues.

"I'm She-Ra," interrupts Adora with yet another smirk. "I'll find Chasm with or without anyone's help."

Catra gives Adora an unconvinced hum. Adora just keeps smirking as she guides Catra into some sort of spinning turn. Her movements are forceful, unrelenting. Like she's dragging Catra across the dancefloor, rather than dancing with her.

"By the way," says Adora. "Have you seen Teela this evening?"

Catra raises an eyebrow. "Teela?"

"I have something I need to ask her," Adora explains. But Catra doesn't appreciate the vagueness.

“What do you need to know?”

Adora makes a *tsk-tsk* sound. “I’m afraid the question is for Teela, not for you.”

Catra can feel every muscle in her face hardening. Why would Adora need to keep this question secret from Catra? And why would she be asking it to Teela, of all people? The person Adora was arguing with yesterday?

“She’s over there,” says Catra, pointing with her head toward the King and Queen across the courtyard, on that raised platform. Teela is fully-armed beside them, clad in armor. Guarding them, no doubt. But she is not alone. A man stands opposite her, on the other side of the King and Queen.

Teela’s father, Catra thinks. Man of Arms. But their encounter with him was so long ago, Catra cannot be sure.

“But I wouldn’t recommend talking to her right now,” Catra says. “She’s probably pretty pissed at you. The same probably goes for your parents.”

Adora’s smile crystallizes into something more brittle. Brittle, in the way ice can shatter into more dangerous shards. “Maybe you’re right,” she says, and gives a little laugh. One that raises the hairs on Catra’s arms. “Let’s just keep dancing for now.”

“What was the point of all this, then?” Catra demands, trying to swallow an inexplicable anger and uneasiness that continues to rise like bile in her throat. “I mean...why agree to the ball and the dress and *everything* only just to throw it away now—”

“Maybe I just changed my mind,” Adora replies, eyebrow quirked yet again. “Have you ever considered that?”

It’s easy enough to pull Teela from the King and Queen’s side.

Chasm sends one of her other hosts to do it. One of the guards that's still tasked with manning the communications room. They make their way to the courtyard, then the dais where the King and Queen stand, with Teela beside them.

It's easy enough to have the guard climb the stairs. Climb, and then shuffle to Teela's side, leaning in close to her ear. Teela is a bit surprised to see them—this host that Chasm has chosen—but they hardly appear to be a threat. Teela trusts her soldiers. Trusts them too much, perhaps.

And that will prove to be her mistake now.

"Captain," Chasm says, in her host's voice. A hushed voice, one that is meant to be kept from the King and Queen's ears. Not that they are paying much attention, with their rage so focused on Chasm's illusion of Adora, and Adora's apparent dismissal of all the King and Queen's favorite traditions. "We have a problem."

Teela's expression grows hard. Her eyes flit between the guard, Adora, and back again. A wordless complaint about just how many *problems* Teela is dealing with at the moment, with Adora so blatantly ignoring Teela's advice and requests and efforts.

"What kind of problem?" Teela murmurs.

"Technical issue in the communication center," the host replies. "We lost access to one of our systems."

"So fix it," hisses Teela between her teeth.

"We need administrator access," Chasm lies. "And that's you, Captain."

Teela releases an enormous sigh. "Of course you do," she grumbles, and side-steps her post. "Take my place," she orders Chasm's host. "I will go fix the issue. Then I will return."

Chasm's host nods their assent, easily sliding into Teela's place as she makes her way down the stairs.

“Teela?” calls someone’s voice.

Chasm’s host looks up to see the Queen glaring at Teela—and glaring hard. Evidently, she noticed Teela’s impending departure and is not pleased about it. “What’s wrong?” demands the Queen, like she too expects another disaster in a long sequence of catastrophes.

“Small technical issue,” says Teela, calmly. “But something easily remedied. I will return shortly.”

The Queen makes a discontented noise. “Very well. When you return—” she turns back to the dancefloor, where Adora and Catra continue to sway. Adora’s silken red-and-gold dress appears to be a noticeable island amidst the sea of robes.

Feeling the desire to sow a little chaos, Chasm has her illusion of Adora spin herself and Catra around, then fire off a gloating smile directly at the Queen. Just for good measure. Just to irritate the Queen even more.

“...I’d like to speak with my daughter,” the Queen grits out, to Teela.

Chasm resists the urge to smirk.

“Of course, my Queen,” says Teela, with a small bow. And then she’s descending the stairs, leaving Chasm’s host standing in her place—pretending to guard the King and Queen.

It strikes Chasm how easy it would be—to simply kill the King and Queen right here, right now. She is stationed directly beside them. Within distance to touch, to maim, to *murder*. These precious little royals who think themselves so powerful, so in control. In control enough to think that Chasm poses no threat, and that their city is beyond her reach.

It would serve them right, even. Adora tried to warn them of the dangers that Chasm represents. But they didn’t listen. Instead, they directed their efforts to this misplaced attempt to control

Adora. This attempt to turn Adora into this...long-forgotten princess. One that she has no idea how to be, and will never become.

Never, because Chasm will have true control of Adora—and She-Ra—soon enough.

Chasm could kill them. She could kill the King and Queen. She could kill anyone here, really.

But, alas...that wouldn't serve her goals very well. If anything, it would draw too much attention to herself. Not that these Eternians can pose Chasm much of a threat—they've long abandoned their magical roots. Most of them have never seen magic beyond that which spreads from the Sorceress's tower.

And even the Sorceress will be unable to challenge Chasm, soon enough.

So Chasm leaves her host where they've been stationed—beside the King and Queen. Pretending to be obedient. Protective.

Chasm has already dispatched two of her other hosts—moving them from their security posts in the courtyard. With everyone so focused on Adora...no one noticed two random guards making their way to the door.

And with the guards so concentrated on the palace's exterior, as well as the courtyard...almost no one is guarding the palace hallways.

The hallways where Teela is walking alone. Right where Chasm needs her to be.

Adora hasn't been talking much.

And that's what strikes Catra as particularly strange. Whenever Adora and Catra attend parties like these—regardless of whether they're comfortable or uncomfortable or just downright awkward

—they always talk, at the very least. They talk to each other. Crack jokes about their circumstances, or exchange mutual worries.

But Adora does none of those things now. As they dance across the courtyard over and over again, Adora merely keeps smiling with unsettling calmness. Smiling, at Catra. Like Catra is the mouse that Adora is about to catch between her teeth.

And Catra, as one could probably guess...doesn't much like thinking about herself as a *mouse*, of all things.

"Are you sure you're okay?" Catra asks, eyes narrowed. "You're acting really weird."

Adora merely raises an eyebrow and tugs Catra a bit closer. Catra never thought that being so close to Adora would make her uncomfortable...but this level of closeness feels like the proximity of an attack, rather than an embrace. "Am I?"

"Yes," says Catra, resisting the instinct to grit her teeth. "You are."

Adora's smile broadens into something beaming—and somehow even more unsettling "Sorry," she says breezily. "I suppose I just want to make the best of the situation."

"Making the best of this situation," Catra grumbles, "would've been just going to this party without making a scene. Or better yet, not going to the party at all. But you're definitely making a scene. And honestly?"

She tears her hands out Adora's grasp, taking a step back. "I don't really want to dance anymore."

Normally, when Catra behaves in any way like this, Adora's reaction consists of an apology. Or maybe an attempt to ask what's wrong, or specifically, what Adora has done wrong. And though sometimes that bothers Catra just as much—since Adora is often too quick to blame herself for any cause of Catra's distress—Catra is startled to discover the *lack* of such a reaction right now.

If anything, Adora looks amused. Amused by how annoyed Catra is.

"Fine," says Adora, folding her arms. "I should probably get going, anyway."

Catra stares. "What do you mean, *get going*?"

Shrugging, Adora says. "Oh nothing, really. I just need to go back to the room. Forgot something."

"What did you forget?" asks Catra. Because she can't imagine what Adora would possibly need. It's too early for her to take her daily potion, after all. So unless Adora has changed her mind about her outfit—

Adora merely shrugs again, then places her hands on her hips. "It's no big deal, Catra," She swipes a hand across one of her bare shoulders, left exposed by the dress. "I just need to grab a shawl is all."

Catra can only keep staring. Adora is the type to wear shorts in a snowstorm. There's no way that she's *cold* in a courtyard like this —one filled with people, and one that is relatively sun-soaked with the late afternoon still casting long shadows.

But Adora doesn't wait for her answer. She just gives a little wave, calling, "See you in a bit!" and then strides over to the stairs.

It doesn't make sense. None of it, nothing about Adora's behavior, makes any sense. Catra understands that Adora was nervous before, and nervousness can produce all sorts of strange mannerisms in a person, but this? This complete shift in demeanor, in confidence, in mannerisms? It doesn't make sense.

And there's a fear that Catra has...one that she hopes is untrue. One that should be impossible, really, considering that Adora has been taking her potion according to schedule—Catra has monitored that herself.

And it's not like the city itself is vulnerable, thanks to that protective symbol that the entire populace wears across their backs. Chasm couldn't have snuck Adora any doses of Essence of Oblivion while they weren't looking. And besides...Micah said that Essence of Oblivion and Essence of Eternity cancel each other out. There shouldn't be a way for Chasm to gain control of Adora.

But still. Catra worries. Nothing about this feels right. Nothing about *Adora* feels right.

She hesitates for only a few moments.

A few moments, before she decides to follow.

Catra is kissing Adora, planting her lips all along Adora's throat and her neck and her collarbone, trailing her warm mouth across every available inch of Adora's skin, each movement of mouth and body like the pulsing of a heart.

Adora's heart, perhaps, which pounds in her ears. Pounding, pounding, like waves growing restless amid a burgeoning storm.

Adora knows that she shouldn't be here, in Bright Moon. Adora is supposed to be on Lenaria. On Lenaria, searching for Chasm, more-or-less trapped within that hidden city of Eternos, relocated there from its original location on Eternia.

But Catra says that Adora imagined all of it. That it was all a dream. The portal. Chasm. Lenaria and Eternos.

Adora has experienced her fair share of vivid dreams, but none so complex as what rests within her memory about the portal, about the dreamworld, about Chasm herself. Those memories must be real. Real, in absolute contrast to what lies before Adora now.

Which means that this bed, this room…

It *can't* be real. It has to be an illusion of some kind.

But how? Adora was supposed to be immune to illusions, thanks to Essence of Eternity—

"Catra," Adora calls, insistent. She squirms beneath Catra's roaming mouth. "Listen to me!"

But Catra doesn't listen. She simply continues to map Adora's skin with her lips, ignorant to Adora's protests. And that's something Catra would never do, she'd never ignore Adora like that—

But that's the worst part, isn't it? That it isn't Catra at all.

"Chasm!" Adora exclaims, furious. She shoves this 'Catra' off of herself, wriggling out from beneath Catra's weight until she's free, sprawled out on the bed with arm curled around herself. "*Enough*! I know it's you! I know this is a dream!"

For several seconds, there is nothing. No response. Catra simply stares at her, blinking. But not like before. Not like she's surprised or concerned by Adora's behavior. Instead, it seems like she's merely...paused.

And then laughter fills the room. A tumbling, high, cruel laugh that Adora recognizes—and despises—instantly.

"Must you be so ungrateful?" Chasm's voice taunts from all directions, causing Adora's head to swivel in search of Chasm's actual face. "I was trying to be nice, for once."

Catra—or really, the illusion of her—fades from existence, from her spot on the mattress. Which leaves Adora completely alone in the bed, cowed against the headboard, fingers digging into nonexistent sheets.

Alone on the bed. And alone in this place, in this dreamworld. Just as Adora always feared she would be.

Alone, with the exception of one other.

Chasm manifests from thin air, blood-red skin gleaming, white teeth and hair practically glowing. She seems to suck daylight from the bedroom with her arrival, wearing the night as a cloak instead. One that envelopes everything within sight. Covering it with...not exactly an opaque darkness, but a translucent layer of it.

Pupiless eyes stare down at Adora from a massive height. Chasm has rendered herself far taller and larger than any normal person. And the grin that splits her large, imposing face...is positively *beastly.*

"Welcome back to my world, Adora," Chasm greets. "I told you. No amount of potion could keep you from me for long."

Chapter End Notes

also, i posted this on twitter but i wanted to share it here too: there will be **no sequel** after immemorial. this is the last book in the chasm saga. so for better or worse, chasm's story will be ending here.

you know the drill lol, please remember to comment!

Chapter 24

Chapter Summary

Adora struggles to adjust to her surroundings.

Catra makes a startling discovery.

Chasm confronts the Sorceress.

Chapter Notes

sorry for posting a day late! i was running around all day yesterday and didn't have access to a laptop to post.

anyway, hope you enjoy! six chapters left...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora must be walking at an inordinately fast pace. When Catra climbs the stairs that lead from the courtyard, she sees no trace of Adora. The hallway is empty—and so are the cross-corridors. Empty, save a guard on patrol. But Catra wouldn’t expect anything otherwise.

Catra can only assume that Adora has actually returned to their bedroom, just as she said she would. In fact, it makes no sense—the fact that Catra thought otherwise. It was honestly just a feeling. A sense of wrongness based on the general *weirdness* that Adora has been displaying all night, one that led Catra to believe that Adora was lying about where she intended to go.

Perhaps it wasn’t a lie at all.

Though that doesn’t explain why Adora was acting so strange about it.

Maybe Catra should meet Adora there, in the bedroom. It might be worthwhile for Catra and Adora to have a private discussion

about what's going on—and why Adora is behaving and dressed the way she is. Better to have a conversation in their room instead of the ballroom. Their *private room*, where it won't be ogled and dissected by a thousand nosy Eternians.

Sighing, Catra begins traversing that hallway—tracing Adora's steps back to the bedroom. How Adora has managed to go from exhausted beyond expression to disconcertingly confident within the span of a half hour, Catra cannot guess.

It's almost like she's a different person. Almost like she's...

But that's not possible, Catra assures herself. Not while Adora is taking the potion. And besides...*she* wouldn't be so obvious, if she had somehow wrested control of Adora without Catra noticing.

Chasm would know better, wouldn't she?

Chasm is prepared when Teela turns the corner. A corner exactly halfway between the courtyard and the communications room—far enough away from both locations that sound will not carry if this encounter becomes...violent.

Teela is certainly surprised to find her path blocked by the pair of Chasm's hosts—the ones that met her here from the courtyard. The ones that Chasm positioned in this very spot, waiting for her.

Her confusion is splashed all across her face. She recognizes Chasm's hosts individually—knows that they're supposed to be manning the courtyard, not patrolling the hallways. Which makes their presence baffling to her.

And given the silence with which they stare at her...Chasm imagines that such a presence is intimidating as well.

"What are you doing?" Teela demands, composing herself somewhat frantically. Seeming calm and in control seems to be Teela's whole personality, Chasm notes. She refuses to change that now, even in a near-abandoned hallway...and even when

confronted by a potential threat. “Why have you abandoned your posts?”

What she doesn’t realize is that one of the hosts has already partially cast a rune—one that needs only a flick of the finger to be completed.

And so, with that flick, a tentacled monster springs from the floor—conjured from the spell. Teela hardly has the time to widen her eyes and inhale a gasping breath before the appendage has wrapped around her arms, her legs, her mouth—effectively immobilizing and silencing her.

She struggles, but of course that does nothing to help her. Chasm has a particular talent for this spell. Especially now that she’s had so much recent practice with it, thanks to Catra and all these warded Eternians.

Truthfully, Chasm has had far too much need for physical spells lately, rather than her specialty: spells that manipulate the mind.

Though she’s enjoying tormenting Adora’s mind at the moment, within the confines of that dreamworld. Not that Adora believes it but...distressing her is enough reward in itself these days. Especially after all the trouble Adora and Catra have put Chasm through.

It’s not long before the third host joins them in the hallway—the one that was disguised as Adora. Chasm allowed the illusion to fall away as soon as the host had left the courtyard. Catra was following her, and Catra couldn’t be permitted to follow Chasm here, to this ambush. Not yet.

The third host very calmly steps up behind Teela’s squirming, squealing, panicked figure. Teela likely thinks of herself as brave, Captain of the Guard that she is. But it’s likely that she’s never seen magic like this before—dark magic, monstrous magic. The Sorceress has kept these Eternians very sheltered indeed. And

such magic can be a terrifying sight to those who have never set eyes upon it.

This is also practiced now—peeling off the back of Teela's armor and finding that accursed symbol sewn into the bottom right corner. Teela stares at her host with wide-eyed betrayal as Chasm does the deed, rendering Teela as vulnerable as anyone else.

Chasm uses the guard's very own spear to cut through the fabric.

Armor. That's all the symbol is, really. Armor that can be removed.

Adora wishes that she sounded more confident, more fearless. But even within the dreamworld, her voice is trembling. Devastated.

"How did you do it?" she demands. "I was taking the potion. I was *safe*—"

Chasm chuckles—a low, gloating rumble in the back of her throat. Or...whatever constitutes a throat here, in this nonexistent dreamworld. A dreamworld that persists in Adora's mind, and nowhere else.

"What?" Chasm asks, as if Adora is nothing more than an overconfident child. She towers over Adora, angling her face down in a patronizing grin. "Did you really think that some stupid little symbols and magic spells would keep me out of the city?" Another laugh, louder this time. "A foolish mistake, most definitely. I've been around since time immemorial. I can outsmart anyone, and anything. And it's certainly no difficulty for me to cut a shirt from someone's back, if that's all that stands between me and what I want."

"But the potion—" protests Adora.

"Ah yes. The potion," mocks Chasm. "All I needed to do was alter the potion a little—turn it into a half dose, rather than a full one—and within hours you were vulnerable. You didn't suspect anything because...well..." Chasm hums. "You thought that I couldn't get

into the city. That I couldn't get past a few guards and a small magical barrier."

Chasm's smile broadens until Adora can see each and every one of Chasm's sharpened teeth.

"But that was your mistake," Chasm adds. "Like I said. Very little can stop me for long."

"The bottles I thought Teela tampered with…" Adora murmurs to herself, horrified. "She didn't touch them at all. That was you—"

Chasm nods, laughing again.

Panic crashes over Adora like a rockslide. The potion failed. Chasm is in the city. She could attack at any moment. Worse, she could find the Sorceress, and find whatever it is she still needs to repair the sword.

But no. Catra will see what's happened to Adora. She'll find Adora unconscious, alert the Sorceress of Chasm's impending attack. If Adora is in this dream, Chasm couldn't have possibly given her Essence of Oblivion. But of course that doesn't mean that Chasm's other hosts aren't dangerous—

"Catra is going to stop you," claims Adora, forcing confidence into her own voice. She believes in Catra. She does. "She'll warn everyone—"

Again, Chasm releases a laugh. A loud, gleeful one that pours liquid nitrogen down Adora's spine.

"She'll try to stop me, certainly," says Chasm, smirking. She leans down, inching close in a way that makes Adora's skin crawl. But Adora cannot move away. There is nowhere else to go in this dreamworld, no way to escape Chasm's touch, for it has already swallowed her whole.

Chasm's fingers find the spot beneath Adora's chin, clutching it with painful tightness. Illusory nails carve crescents into Adora's

skin.

"But that's exactly what I'm counting on," Chasm murmurs—practically whispering the taunt into Adora's ear.

Catra does Adora the courtesy of knocking on the bedroom door before entering. She could just barge in, really—they share the quarters, and Adora really was being a special kind of rude downstairs.

Catra isn't just talking about how Adora treated her family. Really, Catra couldn't care less about that. Adora's parents haven't done much to earn Adora's kindness. No. It's something else. It's the way Adora was acting with Catra, in particular...like she was purposely trying to make Catra uncomfortable…

It's just not like Adora. Adora will tease Catra, maybe even fight with her on occasion, but it's never done with the specific purpose of causing Catra distress. And especially after their last conversation in their bedroom—the one where Adora expressed just how grateful she was to Catra…

It just doesn't make sense for Adora to lash out. Adora isn't one to lash out at anyone. And Catra is usually the last person that Adora wants to direct her frustrations toward.

But then again, it wouldn't be the first time that Adora has acted unexpectedly when confronted with an anxiety-provoking situation. She's spent plenty of diplomatic events rambling or boasting or blurting out embarrassing things about herself. This excessive confidence could be Adora's way of coping.

Though Adora's stress has never manifested itself quite like this.

But in the case where Adora really is just suffering some extreme amount of stress, Adora likely retreated to the room for some privacy—regardless of what she claimed downstairs, about needing to grab a shawl.

Which means that Catra should knock.

Which is exactly what she does. The guards in front of the door part at the center so that she can step forward, fist raised to the surface of the door.

"Adora?" Catra calls, amid the soft rapping of her knuckles against the crystal. "Can I come in?"

There's no answer, not even after several moments. Catra grunts to herself, then begins to knock again.

"Adora?" Catra says. "Please?"

Again, Catra is answered by silence, and only silence.

Catra sighs and steps back, crossing her arms. There's no way that Adora already grabbed the shawl and returned to the courtyard—Catra would have passed her in the hallway. Which means that Adora must still be in there...or she's run off somewhere else, and Catra should likely track her down.

It might be time to just barge in, if Adora's choosing to be uncooperative.

One of the guards shifts in discomfort and clears their throat.

"Uh...Your Highness?"

Catra starts at the words. Never before has anyone referred to her as *Your Highness*. She-Ra's wife, on a few occasions. Horde soldier. Horde *scum*. Force Captain. But *Your Highness?* Adora is the princess, not Catra.

But then again...Catra is married to Adora. And royalty extends through marriage.

Which means that technically…purely by definition...Catra is some sort of royalty.

The thought makes Catra want to scream.

“Um. Yeah?” Catra replies carefully, straightening her posture on instinct. She’s just never thought of herself as a royal before, and she’s almost certain that she doesn’t *look* like a royal.

“We’re worried about the princess, your highness,” the guard says. Their voice is hushed, cautious. Like they’re trying to keep someone from beyond the door from listening. “She hasn’t come out since you departed for the ball.”

Catra blinks, slow to process the words. “She hasn’t...what?”

“She hasn’t left. And we haven’t heard anything from inside—”

But of course that doesn’t make sense. Catra *saw* Adora. She saw Adora at the ball, danced with her, spoke with her. Surely the guards must be mistaken, for Adora would’ve been forced to leave to make such a...well...*controversial* entrance at the ball.

“What do you mean, *she hasn’t left*?” Catra demands, eyes pulling wide. “She was just in the courtyard. I saw her. She came back here and—”

But the guard’s stunned expression and shaking head breaks off the rest of Catra’s sentence. They look as though Catra has spouted pure impossibility—a hypothesis on how people can fly without wings, or breathe underwater without gills.

“No, Your Highness,” the guard says. “She hasn’t left since you did. The princess has been here the whole time.”

“But that’s not…” Catra protests, eyes flitting to the door. *That’s not possible*, she wants to say. But really, how can Catra begin to guess what’s possible anymore, after everything she’s been through?

So the thought trails to nothing, and instead, Catra sets her jaw and grasps a firm hand over the door handle. With a jerk of her wrist, the door clicks ajar, and Catra utterly thrusts it all the way

open, forcing the hinges to turn at their highest possible momentum.

The door gapes. And there, from the threshold, Catra can see the impossible truth.

Adora, sprawled out on the bed. Her eyes closed. Her body limp. Her hair and robes splayed out beneath and behind her, coloring the bedspread in some strange mixture of green and gold.

And there...on her forehead…

...is a glowing red spiral.

The palace really isn't very well-guarded—not when so many distinguished guests are concentrated in the ballroom. They must be the priority when it comes to protection, Chasm assumes. And really, why would they worry about a trap when Eternos hasn't been threatened in thousands of years?

And that's their mistake, of course. Leaving the rest of the palace so largely unattended. It's worse than Chasm imagined—these empty, easily-conquerable hallways, made all-the-more easy to conquer by the many missing Eternian soldiers. Soldiers sent out into the barren Lenarian wastelands on Adora's request, and Teela's approval. Sent out in search of Chasm herself, somewhere in the wilderness.

And it's an especially fruitless search now, with Chasm walking their halls.

Walking their halls...with their leader in tow.

Teela is unconscious in the arms of one of her hosts, her mind smothered within a dreamworld of Chasm's creation, her body limp beneath Chasm's signature sleep spell. They drag her forward, forward, *forward* until they step into a hallway made of stone rather than crystal, and keep walking.

Chasm never anticipated how easy it would be. She assumed that she'd be forced to do something extreme—perhaps threaten to destroy all of Eternos—in order to get her way.

But as soon as she learned about Teela—about Teela's origins—through Adora…

Well. The path forward became clear.

It's not long until they reach the end of this stone cave of a hallway. The guards see them coming, unfortunately—the ones stationed outside the tower. But they're not well-trained enough to recognize a potential threat within the face of a friend. They hesitate, fail to draw their weapons because they are so occupied with staring.

And why wouldn't they stare? It's a strange but not unwelcome sight. Three of their comrades, the unconscious figure of their leader. The guards' first instinct, if anything, would be to ask what's wrong—not to attack.

And that's their downfall, ultimately. Chasm has more than enough time to weave two fire runes into the air—deadly ones, powered almost to excess with the misery of millions of Etherians and stolen fragments of She-Ra's magic. Within moments, a wall of fire has enveloped all opposing guards—blasting them to dust before they have even a moment to scream.

Chasm clears the fire with a swipe of her hands through the rune—dissipating the flames like it's smoke from a candle, rather than what was once a raging, body-disintegrating inferno. Her hosts smile as she easily sidesteps the charred remains of the other guards' armor, now scattered and half-melted upon the ground.

Chasm now finds herself facing a thick stone door. One that is shoved tightly into the wall—unmoving.

It'd be a formidable obstacle for anyone who relies purely on physical strength. That stone would be nearly impossible to break with fists, or axes, or battering rams.

But Chasm is swimming in power at the moment. And she itches to destroy this barrier just as she decimated those guards.

So Chasm steps forward and carves her most powerful fire rune into the stone door. It's a slow burn, at first. A gradual heating of the rock, an ember-like glow at the center of the slab. But slowly...the glow transforms into red-hot brimstone. Then golden magma. And then blinding white-blue liquid. Liquid that melts down, down, down, eating away at the floor but falling still, until it is nothing but a puddle of once-stone on the ground. A puddle that gradually hisses and steams and fades into solid stone yet again, de-transformed by the cool air, and the completed spell.

So much for the door, Chasm thinks, as she steps calmly onto the now-cool platform of previously melted stone. The other hosts—and Teela in their arms—follow her unquestioningly. Not that any of them have minds left to question her with.

Though, *technically* Teela still has a mind. For now. But not one that can argue with Chasm—or keep Chasm from dragging Teela up all these stairs to the top of the tower.

There's a raving, screaming, utterly *senseless* part of Catra's mind—one whose attention is fully devoted to staring at Adora's sleeping form and the spiral that poisons the center of her forehead. A part that is panicking and hopeless and devastated.

But there's another part that remains frighteningly calm. Because really, Catra should have known. She should have known that Chasm would find some way to get to Adora, no matter how protected that symbol or those city walls or these *useless* guards were supposed to keep them.

Because Chasm can't be hidden from. She can only be defeated, destroyed. And Catra doesn't know how to do that yet...but she'll figure something out if it's the last thing she does.

Because now...now Catra is just *furious*. She's furious that Chasm pretended to be Adora, that she made a fool of Adora, that she took the memory of the person Catra loves most (and frankly, the dress Catra loves most on Adora, a dress that is special to their relationship and their honeymoon) and twisted and stained such memories forever.

If Double Trouble back on Etheria could magically shapeshift, Catra should have realized that Chasm could likely do the same. No magic is off-limits to a sorcerer as powerful as Chasm. She knows probably every spell in existence

And illusions—illusions like the one that allowed Chasm to appear as Adora? Those were always Chasm's specialty.

"You!" Catra calls, finally fearing her eyes from Adora's sleeping form. She directs the words—and a pointed finger—at one of the guards that stand just outside the room. "Go get help! Tell Teela. Tell the King and Queen, tell everyone you can—"

"Tell them what?" the guard demands. "That the princess fell asleep?"

"She's not just asleep!" Catra growls. "She's been attacked. Put under the spell by an intruder. And if you don't get help, everyone in this palace will be in terrible danger."

The guard doesn't look convinced. And Catra understands that it must be hard to believe with Adora right there, her chest rising and falling in a peaceful, sleeping rhythm. Only Catra understands that Adora's mind is what's truly in danger, trapped in Chasm's illusion as it is. She still doesn't know how Chasm managed to circumvent Essence of Eternity's effects...but Catra knows it's no use dwelling on it now.

"Well?" Catra demands, making a shooing motion at the guard. "Go!"

Finally, the guard budges—peeling off from the rest of the group to sprint down the hall, their armor clanging dully with every step.

“You too,” Catra says with a jerk of her head at another guard. “The more people spreading the word, the better.”

“What about us?” the other two guards ask, in startling unison.

Catra briefly grasps at Adora’s wrist, holding it tightly. If Chasm is here, in the palace...she is after two things, and two things only: Adora. Who she more or less already has. And the Sorceress—the only person who knows how to repair the sword. And the only person in Eternos who could possibly brew more Essence of Eternity for Adora.

Which means that Catra has a choice. A difficult one. A choice to stay here, with Adora...or go protect the Sorceress.

She doesn’t want to leave Adora’s side. There’s no way to guarantee that Chasm won’t come to this bedroom and snatch Adora away, stealing her from Catra’s arms forever.

But there’s also a very real chance that Chasm will get everything she came here for—and leave Catra helpless to stop Chasm’s control of She-Ra—if Catra doesn’t act *right now*.

So really that choice...isn’t much of a choice.

Catra’s fingers are already stiff when she releases Adora’s wrist. Her body feels brittle, empty. But somehow brimming with tension and on the verge of cracking, like a glass jar filled with pressurized air. The way she turns toward the door is robotic, stilted.

“Stay here,” Catra tells the guards. “Keep her safe. Chasm might come back for her. You can’t let her.”

Though Catra doubts that these ridiculous guards will do much to stop Chasm.

“And what about you?” one of the remaining guards asks.

Catra rests a hand on the door frame to steady herself. She sucks in a breath—lets that breath sizzle and expand and fester within her lungs...then releases it. Releases it, as though she can breathe out her panic like a dragon might breathe fire.

"I'm going to stop her," Catra murmurs. "I'm going to stop Chasm from getting what she wants."

And then she's off, sprinting down the hallway. Sprinting to that place that Catra has only visited twice. Sprinting to Tower Grayskull, to the Sorceress, to *Chasm*.

She has no idea how to stop Chasm. But if she waits any longer, it might be too late to even try.

"Sorceress," calls Chasm, smirking. "Surely you won't leave an old friend waiting outside your door?"

Specifically, the door at the top of the stairs, the one that leads to the tower's highest—and only—room. The room where the Sorceress resides, and has always resided.

Even now she keeps herself barricaded inside, the door shut tightly in Chasm's face. Unmoving. Opaque.

Chasm very much wishes that she could melt this door, just like the one on the lowest floor. Blast it to sludge and step over the remains like they're nothing at all, nothing more than some minor frustration in Chasm's path.

But sadly, Chasm cannot work her usual tricks. Not in the case of this door. The Sorceress's magic is most concentrated here, at the tower's highest level, and that magical power extends to the protections the Sorceress has laid in the stones that surround the room. The door is utterly *covered* with runes—runes against Chasm, against trespassers, against anyone who would seek to enter without permission. Runes everlasting, the kind that will not fade until the Sorceress herself (the spirit, not the body) has ceased to exist.

Chasm doubts she can so much as step foot beyond that door—not without being magically flung back by the Sorceress's protections. Chasm is powerful, yes—especially with a supply of Etherian misery and *She-Ra's* magic at her disposal. But she's not powerful enough to overcome the Sorceress's magic in Tower Grayskull.

This is the Sorceress's home territory, after all. Each stone that comprises this tower only powers and focuses the Sorceress's magic. If the Sorceress challenged Chasm to a fight here...Chasm is not foolish enough to anticipate a win. It's risky enough to come here, when the Sorceress helped banish her to the plane between worlds in the first place.

The plane where Chasm was left trapped. Alone. Helpless. Tortured by silence and loneliness and near-nonexistence…

She recalls the hard expression on the Sorceress's face as she carved the runes that opened the portal to that wasteland. She, and so many other sorcerers and magical beings, all working in tandem to send Chasm into lonely *nothingness.* Into a future that promised bodily nonexistence and voicelessness.

The Sorceress could do it again, if she wished.

But that's a risk Chasm must take, to get what she wants. And Chasm...Chasm *knows* how to get what she wants. Even from a rival as powerful as the Sorceress.

And even from She-Ra, eventually.

The door remains tightly shut and solid. Chasm makes a tsk-tsk sound. She doesn't much appreciate being ignored.

"Still won't answer the door?" Chasm taunts, crossing her host's arms. "That's too bad. Here I thought you'd enjoy the opportunity to catch up, after everything."

She waits for a response. But still, even after several moments, there's not so much as a sound. The Sorceress knows the power

of her own protection spells. She isn't stupid enough to revoke them, not even to answer Chasm's taunts.

"What a shame," Chasm says, and has her other host lift Teela—unconscious, red spiral glowing atop her forehead—higher into the air. A smirk spreads across Chasm's lips. "I was so hoping to see the family resemblance between you and your daughter."

More silence in reply. But somehow it feels tenser than it did mere moments ago.

"Of course, she's not really *your* daughter," Chasm continues. "She's your vessel's daughter. Your host's." Chasm raises both eyebrows. "Which means you probably wouldn't care if I tossed her unconscious body down the stairs—"

The host carrying Teela lifts her even higher, as if prepared to make the throw that would end Teela's life. It would be so easy too. Just a simple thrust and the release of some fingers, and Teela's body would break upon the stone—

She wonders, for a moment, if the Sorceress will simply let it happen. It would surely be a miscalculation on Chasm's part. She knows enough about the Sorceress to figure that *some part* of Teela's mother's mind is alive, cohabitating that body with the Sorceress. The question is...how much does Teela's mother care? And is she willful enough to defy the Sorceress's wisdom—wisdom that surely compels the Sorceress to keep that door shut?

Another moment passes, and Chasm's smirk falters. No. She couldn't have miscalculated. The Sorceress—or rather, the Sorceress's body—must cooperate.

But then the door seems to flicker. It becomes transparent—a non-solid door, a hologram by all appearances...though one without any evident projector.

Beyond the transparent surface of the door, Chasm can see the Sorceress. She is older than the last host Chasm saw, back before Chasm was banished to the prison dimension. That host was

young, lovely. Chasm remembers that there was a time when Eternians would give anything, *anything* to be the Sorceress's next host. It was something that once made Chasm jealous, forced as she is to scrounge and trick and murder for a single a body to occupy.

But Chasm supposes that times have changed. If Teela's memories are any indication...being the Sorceress's host is hardly the honor it once was.

The Sorceress stares at Chasm with wide, pale eyes. Her chest heaves slightly with panic—Chasm can see that quite clearly, even through the half-gray distortion of the door.

"Chasm," the Sorceress says, voice wavering slightly with some mixture of horror and disbelief.

Chasm smiles at her. "It's been quite a long time since we last saw each other, hasn't it?"

"I must say I wish it were longer," bites out the Sorceress, each word clipped and *furious.* "I quite hoped our parting would be permanent."

"Yes, well," Chasm begins, casually, "I got lucky, it seems. Your long-lost princess stumbled upon my prison—and brought the power of She-Ra with her."

The Sorceress sets her jaw.

Chasm, meanwhile, rearranges her hosts. She has Teela lowered just slightly within her host's arms, low enough that the other host can draw a sword and angle it just beneath Teela's throat, threatening a deadly cut. One that Teela will not notice in her sleeping state...but the Sorceress surely will.

"Surely, you remember how my magic works," Chasm says, tapping at the spiral on Teela's forehead with a thumb. "You know that I could have your daughter live the worst deaths imaginable.

Hundreds of them, over and over again, before I finally slit her throat in the real world.”

She sees the Sorceress swallow heavily. Chasm remembers the Sorceress of old. That Sorceress never took hosts with families. Never ever, specifically to avoid situations such as these. The Sorceress’s hosts were supposed to be young, unattached, free to devote themselves to the Sorceress’s power, and nothing else.

Chasm didn’t realize that the Sorceress would grow so foolish with time, while Chasm only grew wiser.

“So...if you want your daughter to live,” Chasm continues, “you’ll give me what I came here for.”

“And what’s that?” demands the Sorceress, with forced calmness.

Chasm chuckles. “I think you know. Adora must have told you.”

Again, the Sorceress swallows. “You want to know how to repair a runestone.”

Chasm taps her host’s chin. “Not just that, I’m afraid,” Chasm says. “The Sword of Protection—it was meant to control her. She-Ra’s magic and body. But that wasn’t enough. She broke free.” Chasm’s smile slips just slightly. “I want a way to control She-Ra. Absolutely."

Chapter End Notes

please remember to comment! i've been running around all weekend and it'd be good for me to hear what y'all think!

Chapter 25

Chapter Summary

Chasm and the Sorceress strike a deal.

Catra attempts a little murder.

And Adora screams and cries kinda a lot.

Chapter Notes

Hey all! I'm busy again so sorry for being early/late (I am writing this author's note in advance). Here's chapter 25.

Please know that there will be a one week hiatus between this chapter and the next. I need extra time to edit/rework the final chapter, as it's just really uh...not great. I wrote it in a huge rush and boy does it show.

Anyway, enjoy this chapter for now! sorry for any agony i cause :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra runs. She runs as fast as her legs will move, jump, *leap* across these empty Eternian hallways.

Vaguely, she can hear the pounding music of the ball, just outside the palace. The courtyard that swarms with formally-dressed bodies, ones that likely wonder where Adora went. Adora, the ball's guest of honor. The one who disappeared so close to the ball's start and never returned.

Until Catra discovered her unconscious on their bed, eyebrows creased and eyes sealed shut—the glowing mark of Chasm's magic glowing atop her forehead.

And now Catra must do this. She must reach the Sorceress—the only person who can brew more Essence of Eternity for Adora, as well as the only person who can explain to Chasm how to repair the Sword of Protection.

Her feet practically blur as they smack across the floor. She wrestled off her shoes some number of hallways ago, she doesn't remember exactly. She wears them as a courtesy for formal events, but right now, Catra needs speed. More than that, she needs a combat advantage—one that her feet will provide. More likely than not Catra will need to kill all of Chasm's hosts before they have the chance to cast a spell against her. Which will be a nearly impossible feat.

But still, Catra will try. Chasm is not getting control of She-Ra. Not today.

"I cannot give that to you," says the Sorceress, though Chasm can detect the trembling beneath her voice. She is referring to the knowledge of runestones—how they're built, maintained, repaired. "It is forbidden."

Chasm gives Teela's cheek a quick pat. Unconscious as she is, she does not react—though her head swings slightly from side-to-side within the grip of Chasm's other host.

"Whether it's forbidden will not stop me from killing your daughter," Chasm says breezily. She bounces the sword beneath Teela's chin without truly cutting into the flesh. "I've already trapped her in a particularly torturous dream. Do you know your daughter is afraid of heights? She's been falling to her death, screaming her head off, for the last five minutes. Though to her, it feels like five days."

At that statement, the Sorceress pales. Chasm wouldn't have thought such a thing possible, pale and sun-starved as the Sorceress already appears.

“S-She…” the Sorceress stammers, and her voice sounds somewhat different now. More human, rather than the air of a wise mage that the Sorceress always assumes. “She won’t let me. But please don’t…” A hand outstretches, as though she seeks to tear Teela from Chasm’s grasp. “...don’t hurt Teela—”

But still, she does not step beyond the transparent ghost of the door. So long as she remains in that room, the Sorceress is more powerful than Chasm. That is the nature of the Sorceress’s binding to the tower.

But Chasm has Teela. And the Sorceress cannot cast a spell to hurt Chasm without hurting Teela as well.

“Look at that,” Chasm laughs, and again bounces her sword against Teela’s throat. “Teela spent so long convinced that you didn’t care. And yet here you are…ready to give up sacred knowledge to save her life. She’d be touched if she wasn’t still falling to her death within the confines of the dream.”

The Sorceress’s face collapses. She’s conflicted, certainly. Teela’s mother. Caught between her devotion to the Sorceress...and her duties as a mother. She may have abandoned Teela for the honor of hosting the Sorceress, but Chasm supposes that allowing herself distance from her daughter is entirely different from letting Teela die.

The Sorceress is frozen in place, unanswering. Decisions, decisions.

Chasm merely scoffs. “She’s not like me, you know. The Sorceress. She doesn’t gain complete control of her hosts—you share your body with her. She shares her knowledge with you. That’s the way she works. So—” Chasm rolls her hand in a gesture that clearly says *get on with it*. “Search those centuries of knowledge and tell me what I need to know.”

“I need you to promise me first,” the Sorceress—or rather Teela’s mother—demands. “Promise me that if I give you what I want,

you must promise to release Teela. Promise to release her healthy, and safe, and free from harm or your magic. And that you will not seek to hurt her once the transaction is complete."

Chasm raises an eyebrow. "Do you not trust me?"

"Absolutely not," Teela's mother says. "I've seen enough of the Sorceress's memories to know that."

Chasm gives a chuckle. "Fine," she says, with a short shrug. "I promise."

"No," says Teela's mother. "Do a *binding* promise. A promise bound to your magic, one that you cannot break."

That wipes all humor from Chasm's face. She hasn't sealed a binding promise in centuries. Once made, Chasm will not be able to revoke it—not for anything. If she tries to hurt Teela in any way, her magic will fail her.

Chasm's magic will part around Teela like a river parts around a rock. And it's a risky thing to do, to leave someone so invulnerable to Chasm's magic.

"If you do not make the promise," Teela's mother says, "I will have no way to guarantee her safety. And you'll forgive me if I don't trust your honor."

For a moment, Chasm merely grumbles to herself, resenting the terms of the deal. And then, finally—

"Fine," agrees Chasm. "I will take the oath. But you...you will have to take one as well."

Teela's mother raises her eyebrows. She did not expect to be similarly bound.

"You must promise to give me the complete truth about runestones," Chasm says. "You must not lie, or withhold any relevant information."

Because Chasm is all too aware of how the Sorceress might seek to feed Chasm falsities—ones intended to trick her into casting a non-working spell. Worse, she could trick Chasm into gravely injuring herself. Or breaking her hold over her hosts.

Even despite all her years of existence, Chasm has no knowledge of how runestones truly work. Whatever the Sorceress tells her, Chasm will have to believe. So really it's all the better that Chasm protects herself from any sort of destructive lie.

"I will," says the Sorceress, finally—after a few seconds of hesitation. And it's evident by her tone that this *is* actually the Sorceress talking, and not just Teela's mother. Bound as the Sorceress is to the will of her hosts, she cannot deny Teela's mother what she is determined to do, or protect. "But only on one remaining condition."

"Do not get greedy now, Sorceress," Chasm warns, turning the sword just slightly within her grasp.

"You must swear not to use the knowledge I give you to attack what remains of Eternia," says the Sorceress. "You must leave everyone within the city unharmed, and untouched by your magic."

Chasm's eyes narrow. "That's far too tall of an order."

The Sorceress's gaze is unyielding. "I know you, Chasm. Spare Teela as you might, nothing will stop you from laying waste to the rest of our kingdom—destroying everything I hold dear. If I am to give you this knowledge...the *potential* ability to control She-Ra...I need to know that you will not use it against my people."

Chasm hesitates. It's a risky promise to make—promising not to harm such a large group of people. Especially when they can pose such an enormous threat to her. To Chasm as well as her plans.

But then again, the Sorceress only demanded protection for those inside the city limits. That's something that Chasm can quite easily

avoid in the future. And besides. Chasm has a fairly good idea how to work this little *wrinkle* to her advantage.

"Fine," says Chasm, with a smirk. "Let's swear the oath then. And get on with it."

The Sorceress nods and holds up her hands, preparing to cast the spell that will seal the promise.

Chasm has her other host claim the sword, keeping it poised beneath Teela's chin while Chasm mimics the Sorceress's posture with both hands raised. Though Chasm, by comparison, is grinning with a feral sort of triumph.

"I swear on my magic," says the Sorceress, tracing a rune in the air as she speaks, "that should Chasm withhold her end of the oath, I will provide her with whole and truthful knowledge on how to repair and construct runestones. Runestones that might permit her control over other magical entities, such as She-Ra. And I will keep no secrets on the matter to myself."

"And…?" presses Chasm.

"And what?"

"Say that you will not interfere," Chasm says. "With my attempt to repair the sword."

The Sorceress's expression hardens, but with one last lingering look at Teela, she relents to Chasm's demands.

"And I will not prevent it," echoes the Sorceress. "I will not prevent Chasm from repairing the sword."

The rune completes just as the oath does. In the end, it looks like some cross between an infinity sign and a chain—the visual representation of being bound for eternity. It hovers there, just in front of the Sorceress—waiting for its twin to be born, just beyond the translucent ghost of the door.

It is not an agreement that Chasm enters into lightly. Any oath bound by magic is serious—potentially deadly, even, if she breaks such a promise. But sparing Teela, and being forced to ignore the existence of Eternos...those are small prices to pay for full control over She-Ra.

So Chasm begins to trace the same rune into the air.

"And I swear on my magic," Chasm says, "that so long as the Sorceress withholds her end of the bargain, I shall commit no physical harm against Teela, nor harm against the Eternians who stand within the current confines of this city."

The Sorceress opens her mouth to protest. Evidently, she has deemed some part of the oath insufficient, but Chasm is ready. She knows what to say next.

"I will also infect no additional Eternians' minds with my magic," Chasm adds, with a pointed look at the Sorceress, "so long as they are within this city—where they can pose me no danger."

The Sorceress's mouth snaps shut, satisfied by the addition. She watches impassively as Chasm finishes the rune. Once both runes are drawn and completed, they glow a bright blue, followed by red...then fade entirely.

And then Chasm merely stands there with a raised eyebrow—expectant. Expectant of the knowledge that she has traveled all this way to retrieve.

The Sorceress exhales deeply...then turns towards one of her bookshelves.

"Chasm!" Adora screams, spinning around—seeking an exit that she knows she will not find. "Let me out of here or I swear I'll—"

But the illusory bedroom has since dissolved, washed away like color caught in a flood. She sits in darkness now. Complete darkness. And Adora scrambles to her feet, feeling as though

stillness poses a danger to her. That if she sits in this darkness for too long, she too will join the void that surrounds her.

It's not real, she reminds herself. It's just an illusion. And beyond it, in the real world, Chasm is planning to do something to Catra. Something to hurt her—

Chasm has since disappeared—though Adora can hear her laughing gleefully from all corners of the darkness. A disembodied echo that bounces off nonexistent walls and ceilings.

"Chasm!" she yells. "If you hurt Catra—"

But Chasm simply keeps laughing. Laughing, until she finally materializes from the darkness, her body looming impossibly large—a giant that towers over Adora's small frame. Her hair is a floating, glowing cloud of pure white, and her eyes gleam pale and monstrous.

"I'm sure you're missing her—your wife," Chasm says, leaning her chin on her hand. Her elbow balances upon the stretch of darkness that somehow qualifies as a floor. "Would you like to see her?"

Adora can feel her heart utterly *spasming*, raging in her own chest. If Chasm is willing to show Catra to Adora, then surely that promises only pain, only suffering for Catra. And Adora will be trapped in this illusion, *in sleep*, meaning that there will be nothing Adora can do to protect her, *save her*—

But then Chasm is laughing again, an illusory finger trailing through the air—colors spilling from long claw-like fingernails as she traces a circle. A circle that, once complete, fills with images. A window to the outside world beyond this place of dreams.

She sees Catra running across a hallway of stone, sprinting at an unstoppable speed.

"Catra!" Adora cries.

But of course Catra does not hear. Not from outside the confines of this dreamworld.

From the bookshelf, the Sorceress carries forward a particular book. An ancient one, it seems, the pages frayed and yellowed beyond belief, their number collectively strung between thick leaves of faded leather. Though by the intactness of the spine, it appears to Chasm that the book has not been opened in quite a long time.

An old book...but one rarely used.

The Sorceress turns to Chasm, then splits open the pages between her hands. Chasm is somewhat stunned to discover that the open pages are completely blank, unmarked by a single letter or scrawl of a pen.

The Sorceress then thumbs through the remaining pages, revealing that every page is identical in its blankness. Almost as though someone bound the book without first writing content within it.

It's hardly an amusing sight. Chasm has limited time to act. And an impending interruption. Or rather, an impending *guest*—

"Hilarious," says Chasm. "But I have no time for jokes, Sorceress. You are bound by an oath, remember?"

The Sorceress nods. "Watch closely," she says. "I am not finished."

The Sorceress again shuts the book, then places her finger atop the cover. "The book's contents are enchanted to appear only to someone who knows a particular rune. A difficult one."

"Hm," says Chasm. "A protection against thieves?"

"Ones who were, thankfully, less resourceful than yourself," remarks the Sorceress. "You are not the first to break into my

tower. But like I said: the rune is difficult. I made it that way on purpose. So...watch me closely."

Chasm rolls her eyes, retorting, "I'm quite sure I'll manage."

But nonetheless, once her eye roll is finished, Chasm watches closely as the Sorceress's fingers trace intricate circles and symbols across the cover. Chasm memorizes every movement, every curve, every winding line and spiral.

When the rune is complete, the book glows in its entirety—with every page and inch of cover radiating bright blue light. Chasm nearly has to avert her host's eyes, so brilliant is that light...but she resists the animalistic urge. She refuses to let herself get caught off guard. Not again.

All that is left is a simple book, same as before, as the glow finally fades. Unchanged by the rune by all appearances.

Unchanged...until Sorceress again brushes a thumb between the pages, fanning them out before Chasm's eyes. And where there were blank pages before, there are now endless pages of diagrams, instructions, *spells.* All of it, printed across the pages so close within reach—

"Our sacred knowledge of runestones," the Sorceress says, "is contained within this book. If there is a way to repair the sword...it will be in here."

The Sorceress speaks as though the words are fighting to remain in her throat, rather than escape into the air—where Chasm can hear them.

"Why bother writing it down?" asks Chasm, genuinely curious.

"I thought I'd record my findings, should any future sorcerer need them."

"I thought your existence—and your knowledge—is eternal."

The Sorceress sighs. “Nothing is truly eternal, Chasm. There may come a day when Eternia destroys my tower and launches it into the void of space. And I, bound to it forever, will cease to exist in any way that matters.”

Chasm scoffs at the words. It sounds familiar, *ceasing to exist in any way that matters*. Painfully familiar.

“Much like you did to me,” Chasm bites out, her host’s face utterly twisted by bitterness,“when you sent me to that empty place between dimensions.”

“Yes,” admits the Sorceress. “I took great pains to leave no trace of you—of your magic, or your presence—within scrolls or books.” The Sorceress's fists clench. “But I should have realized that you’d worm your way back someday, insect that you are.”

Chasm chuckles. “That is the difference between you and I, Sorceress,” she says. “I am bound to nothing, and no one. And therefore impossible to trap forever. And now…” Chasm grins and outstretches an impatient hand. “The book.”

Finally. Victory is within sight—

The Sorceress still does not emerge from her tower. Instead, she gently lowers the book to the floor and then, with a light kick, she pushes the book across the ground, through the door...until it is sitting right there. Nestled against the feet of Chasm’s hosts.

With a pleased laugh, Chasm dips down to retrieve her prize. She takes a moment to scoop the book into her arms and split open the pages, examining the contents for herself.

And it’s all there, as far as Chasm can tell—instructions on how to construct a runestone, how to activate one, and even how to repair one.

She smirks. It’s everything Chasm needs. Everything except…

Well. Chasm will have that too, soon enough.

“I held up my end of the bargain,” says the Sorceress, indignant. “Now hold up yours.”

“Yes, yes,” says Chasm, flapping a free hand. “Teela will be returned to you, safe and sound.”

And as she completes the sentence, her other host releases Teela —lowering her to the floor. Placing her just outside the door, practically leaning her against it.

Immediately, the Sorceress—or more likely, the Sorceress’s mother —sends two hands searching for Teela, sprawled on the floor as Teela is. Chasm watches with some amusement as the Sorceress drags Teela’s unconscious body into the room, where she will be protected by the Sorceress’s magic.

“Aren’t you going to revoke the spell?” demands the Sorceress as she cradles Teela in her arms. The spiral has not yet disappeared from Teela’s forehead.

Chasm waves a careless hand and the spiral fades before their eyes.

Several minutes pass. No one moves. Not the Sorceress, not Teela, and not Chasm’s hosts.

“Shouldn’t she wake?” asks the Sorceress, after Teela’s consciousness *still* fails to return.

“I have relinquished my attachment to her,” Chasm says. “The sleep spell is harmless, though. And will last for only a few more minutes. Well within the rules of the oath.”

“Then why would you—?”

“I can’t have her keeping me from escaping, can I?” Chasm explains. “And besides...I can’t have her interfering in the fight.”

“The fight?” asks the Sorceress, bewildered.

"Well," says Chasm, "I really don't imagine it will be *much* of a fight, in the end."

"I do not understand—"

"It doesn't really concern you," Chasm tells the Sorceress, grinning. "It's between myself and I—"

She finds her sentence cut off by a snarl, a shadow, a slashing of claws. A razor-sharp pain erupts across the face of Chasm's host, blood pouring from the now-gaping wound—splattering the cover of the book.

But Chasm is ready. She expected this, of course. Planned it.

A snarling Catra is clawing at Chasm's host, trying to wrestle the book from their hands. Her rage is incandescent, eyes near-bulging from her head, fangs bared as though she intends to tear out the host's throat.

And she's certainly *trying* to do that last part, if the snapping of her jaws is any indication.

"Catra," Chasm greets, in the mouth of another host. This other host is prepared—their hand raised and waiting, finger poised to add the final touch to a rune. Specifically, a binding rune. Though this spell will be far more *comprehensive* than the one Chasm last used against Catra.

She knew it was only a matter of time before Catra reached that hallway, climbed these stairs. Chasm is done underestimating Catra—underestimating her ability to utterly dissolve Chasm's carefully laid plans. Catra always manages to barge in at the last moment and ruin *everything*.

So instead….Chasm has devised a way to use that—Catra's tendency to barge in, to interrupt—to her advantage. And all it took was a little baiting, a little illusion of Adora acting not quite normally, and Catra came running at Chasm's command—

So, with the flick of that finger it is done. The rune is complete, and chains erupt from empty air—flying toward Catra in a glowing, metallic arc.

Catra should've known that she can't protect herself in such a small, enclosed space. The staircase is cramped, and Catra is outnumbered. She has nowhere to dodge, to jump, to hide as the chains wrap around her, binding her legs, her arms, her wrists, her ankles.

But Chasm knows Catra. She knows that Catra had little interest in winning the fight, in keeping herself safe or holding the advantage. Her main priority was and continues to be keeping the Sorceress's knowledge of runestones out of Chasm's clutches. At any cost.

All to protect Adora. To protect Adora from Chasm's control. So bound are they together, made vulnerable by their attachment to one another.

As if Catra can even protect *herself* from Chasm.

Within moments of Catra's straining and shrieking, she is fully immobilized. Held bound by magically-produced chains, chains of Chasm's making. Captured and incapacitated at last.

She falls to the floor, struggling fruitlessly. Rolling from side-to-side, claws flexing at anything within reach. A growl rumbles from deep in Catra's throat, promising a threat that she cannot actually deliver on.

"Uh oh," Chasm smirks, looking right back down at Catra's glowing, angry, *fearful* eyes. "Looks like there's no sorcerers to save you this time, Catra."

"Let Adora go!" Catra yells. "Free her from the dream, or I swear —"

"Ah-ah," Chasm replies, wagging a finger on her host's right hand and casting another rune with the other. Within moments, another

magical chain flies out—this one wrapping around Catra's mouth, rather than her limbs. "There's no need to yell. I'll wake Adora when it suits me."

Catra shrieks against the gag, but it's no use. Her voice is too muffled.

"Desperation has made you sloppy," Chasm remarks. "And this time...restrained like this…"

Chasm's hosts all grin. The grin is particularly gruesome on the face of the host that Chasm clawed, the blood from their wounds dribbling down toward their spread lips.

"I think you'll make a perfectly cooperative hostage."

Adora can do nothing but *watch* as one of Chasm's hosts slams the butt of their sword against Catra's forehead, knocking her limp and unconscious.

"No!" Adora screams, desperately trying to reach through the window before her. This window to the real world, rendered within the dream.

But as her hands fly out, the colors simply *dissolve* around her hands. Like sand, yes, but somehow finer—particles of color that blow away like wisps of smoke rather than beads of rock. And of course she knows it's just an illusion, that Adora can't actually travel through the window, but *dammit*, Adora will lose her mind if she doesn't at least *try*—

The window appears again, now several feet away. Still close enough to see but more difficult to touch. And Adora continues to be assaulted by these images of Catra's kidnapping—

"You swore you would not harm anyone within the city—!" the Sorceress yells, half concealed by that transparent door. She appears appalled by this attack on Catra, eyes wide and face drained of its already-waning color.

But Adora also wants to scream. Scream, and scream, and *scream*. Because it's not enough. Not nearly. Because if the Sorceress were truly appalled, she would defend Catra. She would do what Adora cannot, and *attack* Chasm with her magic—

"*I swore I would not harm any Eternians within the city,*" Chasm's host calmly replies, while one of the others hoists Catra over their shoulder—carrying her. Abducting her while Adora watches, helpless. "*But Catra, you see...is not Eternian."*

The Sorceress moves as though she intends to take action—and Adora's heart flutters with brief hope.

Hope that is just as quickly extinguished.

"*You swore you would not prevent me from repairing the sword*," a horrifically smug Chasm reminds the Sorceress. "*And capturing Catra is quite critical to that effort."*

At that, the Sorceress is left speechless—and unable to act.

Leaving Catra in Chasm's clutches.

"Stop it!" Adora shrieks again. "Leave her alone!" Within her dream, she finds herself glowing—burning. Her transformation into She-Ra searing a fiery path through her veins. When it completes, she stands taller, transformed—but there is nothing she can do. No one she can fight. Despite how she swings her sword through the window, it simply reforms.

Because Adora is not truly transformed into She-Ra. The illusion of Adora is transformed, but not her body.

She tries to wake. Truly, she does. She tries *so hard*, screaming "*wake up, wake up!*" within her own mind, over and over again. But she does not. No matter how she wills herself to open her eyes, to push beyond this place, she does not budge. She remains trapped. Asleep. *Dreaming*. Just as Chasm wants her to.

There's no waking up this time. Chasm is simply too strong.

And Adora is forced to keep watching.

Chasm's host keeps descending those stairs with Catra slung over their shoulder. Descending, descending, until they are making their way down the hallway. And there is no one in sight, no one to stop them—

And then the window dissipates, leaving Adora in complete darkness.

"I once told Catra that there are multiple ways to control a person," comes Chasm's voice, from all sides. From within the dreamworld, rather than the now-disappeared window. "And I told you that Catra would suffer, should you fail to comply."

And then the voice fades, just as the window does. And Adora can do nothing but sink to her knees in silence, in darkness, with no means to escape.

Chapter End Notes

please comment! see you in two weeks!

Chapter 26

Chapter Summary

Chasm gives Adora instructions.

Adora gives the Queen a piece of her mind.

And Adam gives Adora an idea.

Chapter Notes

i know i'm late. im sorry. im dumb and bad at keeping track of time.

anyway, enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora doesn't know how long she waits there, in the darkness. It could be minutes. It could be hours. Days. Years, even. Chasm's dreamworld bends time. When Adora was last trapped in this dreamworld, three years' worth of illusions were crammed into three days.

But Adora knows that the opposite is just as likely, where Chasm is concerned. The longer Adora is trapped here, sunk to her knees, the more misery Chasm can pull from her.

And Chasm is doing this just to torment Adora. Leaving Adora to dwell, to fear, to *panic* over Catra's safety. Adora knows that Chasm hates Catra, hates her deeply. Which means that Chasm likely won't hesitate to torture Catra, maim her, *kill* her. Truly, it must be misery and fear unparalleled, what Adora is producing.

By the time Adora emerges from this place—*if* she ever emerges from this place—Catra could already be dead for years.

Dead. And Adora will have failed to act, to protect her. Trapped and outsmarted as she is in this empty dreamworld.

All throughout her waiting, Adora's heart never slows. It continues to gallop at something close to a lethal speed. Hammering in her chest, in her head—a throbbing pain. One that pulses endlessly as tears drip from Adora's eyes onto the nonexistent floor below.

Fear bends Adora's spine, forcing her to curl in on herself. She can't stop herself from remembering Chasm's first illusion. That first horrific illusion. The one where Chasm tricked Adora into thinking that Catra had been killed.

Adora had been utterly *destroyed* by the knowledge that Catra—and their future together—had ceased to exist. Adora was devastated, near-incoherent in her grief, half brain-addled by pain. She leaned so close to self-destruction that a mere breath of Chasm's could have pushed Adora over that edge.

It was Catra that saved Adora, in the end. Because it wasn't real. It wasn't real that Catra was dead...

But Catra isn't here now. She isn't coming. Adora is all alone in this illusion, in this blanketing, opaque darkness.

And soon enough, Catra's death may be very, very real.

Panic continues to crush Adora's lungs together. She can't stop thinking of losing Catra, losing her to tortures unnamed. Losing her to Chasm—not even knowing how, or when. Chasm knows so many terrible spells. So much dark magic—

She also can't stop thinking of Bow, back on Etheria. Now doomed to a life of sleeplessness. He will remain infected by Chasm for the rest of his life—until either Chasm destroys him, or exhaustion does.

Because with Adora trapped here, who will save them? Who will save Etheria? Who will save all the people Chasm infected? Who will apologize on Adora's behalf, begging everyone's forgiveness

for Adora's mistake—the mistake she made when returning from that dreamworld with Chasm welded to her mind?

Adora can't fix it. She can't fix anything.

She can only sit here, in darkness. Unable to escape. Unable to wake.

Unable to save anyone, including herself.

"Adora."

She has grown so accustomed to the silence, Adora jumps at the sound of that voice.

She stares, wide-eyed, as Chasm materializes above and in front of her, again occupying her most enormous size. A size that towers over Adora, making Adora feel small and trembling and insignificant. Small, even though she remains transformed into She-Ra within the dream.

Adora has never seen Chasm grin so wide. So triumphantly.

The sight swarms Adora with irrepressible *rage*.

Adora raises her sword and, with a mighty yell, charges at Chasm. It's really no surprise when Chasm dissolves around the blade, reappearing unharmed only a couple feet away, her cloak and hair flapping in an imaginary wind.

But still, as Adora again stumbles to her knees...she is glad that she tried.

"Good," says Chasm, with an overexaggerated yawn. "Looks like you're still more-or-less sane."

"Let me—!" cries Adora.

"—go? Why would I bother?" interrupts Chasm. She examines her fingernails to express her disinterest. "Any moment now, the

Sorceress will finish brewing a dose of Essence of Eternity, and you'll be allowed to wake without my help."

Adora blinks, confused. "The Sorceress?"

"When the King and Queen were notified of your…" Chasm flaps a hand, "*unconscious* condition, they had you brought to her. And of course she, of all people, knows how to counteract my sleep spell." Chasm scoffs. "Though Essence of Eternity takes time to brew, as you know."

"I…" Adora stammers. "Why are you telling me this?"

"Because," says Chasm with a sigh, "this will be our last chance to talk before this little conflict of ours comes to a close."

Chasm leans in close over Adora, uncomfortably so. Adora's whole body twists to move away from her. "It's a lucky thing I didn't destroy your mind when I had the chance," says Chasm. "Turns out I will need it for the time being."

Adora gulps. "What do you mean?"

"I have read the Sorceress's book on runestones," Chasm says. "I always guessed I would need you to repair the sword, somehow. But I did not realize to what extent."

Another sigh, from Chasm. Like she is greatly aggrieved.

"But that's no matter. It's fundamentally the same, in the end."

"What are you talking about?" demands Adora.

"Catra," says Chasm. "I have Catra trapped. I could kill her at any moment—and I will, should you fail to cooperate."

Chasm waves a hand. And from the motion, Adora sees a vision of Catra pour into the air. She is still tied up—bound by magical chains. Though she is awake now, glaring at one of Chasm's hosts with a murderous but fearful sort of rage.

There is a sizable bruise across her forehead, a deep red-purple welt that might accompany a concussion. The sight of it makes Adora's blood feel *molten* within her veins. Furious, but also utterly incinerated from the inside.

"And not just kill her," Chasm adds, swiping a hand through the illusion for added effect. It dissolves around her hand, fading back into the darkness. "I will *destroy* her. Slowly. Painfully. Use my magic to inflict the most horrifying tortures upon her until she remembers agony and nothing else."

Adora's lip trembles, but she can say nothing. Say nothing and do nothing except picture the tortures Chasm alludes to in these threats, and feel herself grow faint at the very thought.

"But there is a way out," Chasm says. "A simple one—one that will allow Catra to walk free."

Adora struggles to swallow. And that doesn't make sense, does it? That Adora struggles to swallow. This isn't Adora's real mouth, her real throat, her real *spit*, so why does she have such difficulty—?

She takes a deep breath. "She-Ra," Adora says, and the words feel dry and scratchy in her mouth. Her *illusory* mouth. "You want She-Ra."

Chasm nods. "She-Ra can only be bound to the sword if her current host renounces their bond."

"Renounce our bond?" Adora says. "What does that even mean?"

"By allowing She-Ra to occupy your body, you are afforded power over her," Chasm says, explaining the matter with a sort of sadistic glee. "Power to direct her magic. Power to wield her strength. Power to bring her forth, or force her back."

Chasm's hands trail in the air, this time summoning the image of a giant, vaporous-looking sword. The Sword of Protection, formed seemingly from fog.

"That power must be transferred to the sword, once I repair it," Chasm says, tracing her fingers around the illusion's edge. "Only She-Ra's host can do this. Only you can give She-Ra permission to depart from your body, and attach herself to the runestone."

"And that's what you want me to do?" Adora asks, quietly. Brokenly. "If I give She-Ra to you, you'll let Catra go?"

Chasm nods.

Adora's lips keep trembling uncontrollably. "But even...even if I *do*," Adora says, her voice wavering in every syllable. "It'll backfire, someday. Someday, She-Ra will turn against you. Just as I turned against Light Hope, and broke the sword—"

Chasm merely chuckles. "I do not have the blind faith that the Sorceress did, when she first constructed the sword. She only enacted limited control of the sword's wielder—control over her muscles, her magic—and only when it was absolutely necessary."

Chasm's grin broadens into something wicked, something crueler than Adora has ever seen before.

"My control will be far more complete. There will be no room for rebellion where *my* magic is concerned. Whoever wields my sword will do whatever I say."

Adora stares, allowing the silence to swallow them up. She can't imagine it. She can't imagine giving Chasm control of She-Ra. Worse, she can't imagine giving Chasm control over the sword's next wielder. Adora remembers how much she suffered under Light Hope's control—how it felt to be used, her body thrown about like a puppet's.

And she remembers Mara. Mara, who died so that no one would suffer like she did—or Adora did—ever again. Mara, who died to protect the universe from those would misuse She-Ra's magic.

Chasm is exactly the type of person that Mara died to keep the sword *from*.

"And it'll be forever?" Adora says. "I'll never have She-Ra again?"

And of course Adora is afraid of that, too. She has lost She-Ra before, yes. But that was a split-second decision—one where the universe would have ended, had she not acted. But now that so much of Adora's identity—her legacy—is defined by She-Ra...she can't imagine suddenly *not* being She-Ra. She can't imagine losing She-Ra forever.

She-Ra has been a part of Adora for so long...it would be like losing one of Adora's oldest friends. Not to mention the danger it would put the universe in, to give Chasm control over the most powerful magical entity in existence. What type of hero would Adora be if she even allowed it?

But losing Catra...Adora cannot even stand the *thought*—

"Well," says Chasm, with a short shrug. "It depends. If you wish to be free of the burden of She-Ra, I can grant that wish to you. But…" Chasm raises an eyebrow. "If you'd like to be the first wielder of my new sword—"

And at that, Adora wants to scream. Light Hope's control was horrifying enough. That, along with Chasm's infection of Adora's mind, will likely haunt Adora for the rest of her life. But to willingly give Chasm that power…

No. It'd be worse than that. It'd be more complete control over Adora than Chasm or Light Hope ever managed in all the times before—

"I see you don't much like that option," Chasm sighs. "But I'll admit, I'd much rather have an experienced She-Ra on my side. A new wielder will require time. Training. But you...you have that already—"

"No, please," Adora says, eyes wide—head shaking frantically. She can't. She can't do that, anything but that—

But *Catra*...

“What if I made it worth your while?” says Chasm, smirking. “What if I released all your friends back on Etheria?”

Adora loses a second to shock. Shock, because it seems too good—but also too horrifying—to possibly be true. She can save everyone, truly everyone…

If she dooms herself to a life of Chasm’s control.

“Y-you’ll release everyone…” Adora stammers. “Catra...my friends—”

A terrible sound escapes Adora, some cracking of emotion within her lungs. A sound of horror. A sound of despair. Some cross between a whimper and a sob. And she can’t finish it. She can’t even finish the sentence. She can only clamp a hand over her mouth and strangle a scream.

“If you become *my* weapon,” Chasm says. “Though I will give you the choice. I will release Catra so long as you relinquish She-Ra. But I will give you Etheria if you surrender yourself as well.”

Lost. That’s how Adora feels. Completely and utterly lost. She can’t do this. She can’t agree to this. But then again...how can she *not*?

Catra wouldn’t want her to. Adora knows that. She’d never forgive Adora for pledging She-Ra—or herself—too Chasm. If Chasm lets Catra go after the deal is struck, Catra will probably spend the rest of her life hunting Chasm down, trying to find some way to free Adora.

They worked so hard to stay together. Suffered through multiple lifetimes and endless tortures to do it—

And what about Mara? Mara died to ensure that She-Ra’s power didn’t end up in the wrong hands. And doing this...it will mean that Mara’s sacrifice was truly for nothing.

But Adora can't lose Catra. And Adora can't lose Etheria, either. She can't doom Bow and the other princesses and innocents to a life of sleepless misery. Adora would never be able to live with herself. She'd probably spend the rest of her own life wishing she had taken Chasm's deal.

This might be the only way to fix things. But it also might *destroy* everything. There's no telling what Chasm will do with She-Ra's magic.

"What do I have to do?" Adora whispers. She doesn't meet Chasm's eyes. Instead, she stares at the darkness where the floor should be, wondering if it would be better if she had never existed —if she had never brought about such pain—in the first place.

Chasm just smiles at her. Smiles as though she's already picturing what she'll destroy with Adora's own hands.

Adora wakes with a gasp, body jolting upright—lungs pulling down air like they'll never be truly filled.

Panicked eyes comb her surroundings. It takes her a moment to recognize it. The bookshelves, the instruments, the light from that single window. She's within the Sorceress's tower, sprawled out on some sort of dilapidated chaise.

The Sorceress is kneeled at Adora's side, brow furrowed in concern. The silver feathers in her hair gleam eerily, almost like they're winking at Adora, and a fresh chill plunges down Adora's spine.

Adora notices, belatedly, that the Sorceress's hand is curled around Adora's wrist, holding it tightly. But there's something there. Something that *burns* the skin just slightly. Something that isn't right—

With a yelp, Adora yanks her wrist out of the Sorceress's grasp. She repositions it in front of her own eyes, examining for the source of the pain. And sure enough, there's some sort of rune

there, on Adora's wrist. One that's small and shimmering. It looks almost like a crosshatch to Adora's eyes, though far more intricate.

"Wha—" Adora begins, struggling to arrange the words. "What is __"

"That rune will protect your mind from Chasm's eavesdropping," the Sorceress says. "She's still in there but...trapped in her own little corner, where your thoughts will not reach her."

The Sorceress rises to her feet. Her expression appears neutral at first glance. Though as Adora stares, she notices several edges to it. An edge of sorrow. An edge of annoyance.

"Had you told me sooner that she had infected you," the Sorceress says, "I might have been able to cast it sooner. And prevent what just transpired. And I could have personally supplied enough *Essence of Eternity* to keep you awake."

Adora glances to the side. Immediately, she spots an empty vial sitting on a table—a recently-emptied bottle of *Essence of Eternity*, no doubt. One that the Sorceress just administered to Adora, just as Chasm said the Sorceress would.

And if that's true...then does that mean…?

"Catra—?" Adora begins, voice half-cracked, like pavement under some enormous weight. Like a fool, she hopes that Chasm was lying about that part, even if she wasn't lying about the Sorceress —

"Gone," says the Sorceress, and Adora's heart plummets. "Chasm took her. She stole one of your spaceships—used it to travel back out into the Lenarian deserts."

Every muscle in Adora's body tenses. She feels like a wire pulled so taut, she will snap—break—at any moment. But for now she trembles. Trembles, and tries to carry as much as she is able, until she no longer can.

“She gave me coordinates,” Adora murmurs, mostly to herself rather than the Sorceress. “Coordinates where she wants me to meet her, so I can surrender myself—and She-Ra—to her.”

“You will do no such thing,” a voice interrupts.

Adora’s head swivels to see three other figures standing behind her—behind the chaise, where she couldn’t immediately see. The King and Queen and Prince Adam. The King and Adam are seated, crouched in chairs that Adora suspects were brought into the room, they are so ornate and out-of-place compared to the rest of the Sorceress’s assorted old furniture.

Adam is watching Adora with a genuine sort of sadness. He must know—or at least guess—how devastated Adora must be, with Catra kidnapped. He shares a sympathetic look with her...which is more than she can say for the King, whose eyes are affixed to the hands within his lap.

The Queen, meanwhile, is standing. Standing upright and *furious*, shoulders pushed back, her whole body enveloped in a commanding, queenly air.

She was the one who spoke. She was the one who forbade Adora from meeting with Chasm.

Chasm did tell Adora that her family brought her here, to the Sorceress.

Adora squints at her. “Look,” she says slowly—and tersely. Because Adora really did not expect to argue with her *parents* on top of having just been mentally tortured by Chasm. “This doesn’t really involve you—”

“Of course it involves me,” huffs the Queen. “This talk of surrendering yourself to this...this *Chasm*…” the Queen shakes her head. “You must have lost your mind. In no way am I losing my daughter *again*.”

“It’s not your choice.”

“There is no choice to make,” says the Queen. “The Sorceress told me about the deal she struck with Chasm. So long as you are here, within the city, you will be protected from harm from Chasm. That is why the Sorceress made the deal in the first place.”

Adora’s head swivels toward the Sorceress in outrage. “Is it?” Adora demands. “Is that all you wanted? To keep me here?”

Shaking her head, the Sorceress says, “My priority was to protect my people. But, obviously, *you* are a member of my people. So it was my hope that you would be protected. And so long as you were, she would be unable to bind She-Ra to the sword.”

“But you didn’t think to protect Catra,” Adora mutters bitterly. “And now Chasm has her. Chasm could be doing all sorts of horrible things to her—

“And if you go out there,” the Queen interrupts, “if you agree to her terms, you will be exposed to the same dangers—”

“And that’s what you’d have me do?” Adora demands, incredulous. “You want me to hide here for the rest of my life, and just let Catra die?”

“You claim that Catra loves you deeply,” the Queen says. “If that were truly the case, she would not want you to risk yourself for her. She would want you to be safe. And if you stay here, in Eternia, you could be just that. The Sorceress might even be able to grant you short periods of sleep—”

Adora swings her legs over the side of the chaise, refusing to listen. “Like I said,” Adora grits out. “This *doesn’t* involve you.”

“It most certainly does. You are my daughter,” says the Queen, as if that explains it. As if Adora will understand how blood or genetics could possibly create some sort of bond between this cold, sheltered woman before her, and the tragedy-forged woman that Adora has been forced to become.

As if giving birth to Adora grants the Queen any sort of ownership over Adora's life and decisions.

And that's when Adora decides she can no longer stand it. She can no longer stand *appeasing* these people. These parents who've caused Adora nothing but grief and fear in the short time that she's known them.

Adora is so tired of people trying to manipulate her, control her, *shape* her into something that they can use or claim. It happened with Shadow Weaver, with Light Hope, with Chasm…

She won't tolerate it here, now. Not when she can stop it.

"You are a *stranger*," Adora bites out. "You are not my mother. And I'm *not* your daughter."

That takes the queen aback at least. She gapes, jaw fallen slightly open. The King finally looks up from the floor, startled by Adora's tone and evident *rage*. Only Adam seems unsurprised. He knows that with nothing left to lose, Adora no longer needs to pretend to be the obedient daughter.

"You act like you lost me to some great outside force," Adora continues furiously. "Someone who snatched me from my bed. But it wasn't. It was Light Hope—an *Eternian* computer program—that took me. Kidnapped me. All so she could use me as her weapon of mass destruction. I suffered things that you can't *imagine*, because of her. Because of you all. And now you say you can tell me what to do, despite everything. Despite all the hurt you caused me and the rest of the universe. "

Adora looks away, at the floor. A biting scoff blusters past her lips. That lone sound seems loud as an explosion in the complete silence of the room.

"But maybe that was a good thing, in the end," Adora mutters. "Being taken by Light Hope. Because if she hadn't—if I stayed here…" Adora looks back up at the Sorceress, then at the Queen.

"I would've ended up just like the rest of you. Hiding from our mistakes. Sheltered from the consequences of everything we did."

Adora gestures to herself—but not proudly. Indignantly. Desperately.

"So at least I got to do something about it. At least I got to right some of your wrongs. But now?"

Adora's gaze is icy-hard on the Sorceress. She sees the Sorceress's features soften a bit. In guilt, perhaps. But more likely it's some calculated expression of sympathy.

"Now I have to do it again," Adora snarls. "You made the sword in the first place. You made the Heart of Etheria. You trapped Chasm in the plane between worlds and didn't tell anyone. And now…"

Adora swallows a sob. She doesn't want to appear weak now, in front of her parents. In front of the King and Queen of Eternia.

And suddenly, her mind is filled with the memory of Mara. Mara, who died alone. Who died slowly and in terrible pain, alone in the Crimson Waste amid the debris of shattered a spaceship. Mara, who gave her life to keep anyone else from wielding the sword.

Mara knew that nothing but evil could come from that sword. She paid the price of its construction, of its misuse…

And now Adora is going to have to do the same thing. She'll have to doom herself to a different but equally terrible fate.

"I'm not going to let Catra suffer for my mistakes. Or yours," Adora says. "So yes. Unless someone else has an idea that won't result in Etheria being doomed, or my wife dying, I'll be surrendering myself to Chasm."

Chasm. Adora can still recall Chasm's voice, within the dreamworld. That gloating *triumph* within her words as she gave Adora instructions on how, exactly, to surrender. When and where. And what she could and could not do.

"I will give you 24 hours since waking to make your decision," Chasm says. "*That will be midnight, tomorrow. Meet me at exactly then. Fail to meet that deadline, and...well…"* Chasm smirked. "*Catra will meet hers. But hopefully, if you make the smart choice, you will come to these coordinates alone."*

Chasm shot Adora a forbidding look.

"*And I will know if you do not come alone. Catra will pay the price for that, and any other mistakes you make."*

Adora stands. She needs to find Teela—figure out where the other spaceship is stored. She'll use that to go to Chasm, even if no one else in Eternos is willing to help or provide her transportation.

And even if Teela refuses to help...it's no matter. If Adora needs to turn into She-Ra and fight her way out, she'll do that. Adora's time spent beneath Chasm's spell renewed her energy somewhat, thanks to the deep sleep she was in. She can transform. She can fight. She'll do whatever it takes—

Her mind is speeding forward at an unstoppable momentum, her legs moving just as quickly as they carry her from the tower, down the stairs, into the hallway so many feet below. The world blurs around her. She's surrounded by smudged hallways that somehow lead her to the bedroom she shared with Catra—the one filled with the boxes that Catra and Adora were supposed to take to Sutera.

She stumbles inside. Stumbles to the bed, which she allows herself to sink into—if just for a moment to collect herself.

Tomorrow at midnight. That's when the exchange will take place.

Adora will need to pack her things. Or really, Catra's things. Adora will give Catra the other ship once the exchange is made. That way, Catra will have the means to go home to Etheria.

Catra will go home...even when Adora cannot.

The thought utterly pulverizes Adora's heart. Will that be the last time Adora sees Catra—when she makes the exchange of herself and She-Ra for Catra and Etheria's safety? There's no telling where Chasm will force Adora to go, and Adora has a hunch that it won't be back to Etheria. Adora could be separated from Catra forever—

But no. Adora knows that won't really be true, so long as Catra is still alive. Catra will never stop trying to track Adora down, or trying to save Adora from whatever control Chasm enacts over her. She'll follow Adora across the universe if she has to.

Momentarily, the knowledge fills Adora with a sort of hope. Catra won't give up. She'll do anything, anything at all, to protect Adora. And it's a sweet idea that Catra might someday succeed...that Adora might someday be freed from the consequences of this horrible decision.

But Adora knows it's more likely that Catra will only get hurt. Worse, Chasm might use *Adora* to hurt Catra.

And so it would be better, Adora realizes, if Catra just moved on. If Catra let Adora go.

And that's when Adora starts crying. Because she doesn't want that. She doesn't want Catra to let her go. She doesn't want to leave her, doesn't want to have to sacrifice herself *again* to please Chasm or any other monster that plagues the universe.

She just wants to return to Etheria and live out a few years of peaceful existence with Catra. She wants to go back to that happy, loving universe—the one that Catra and Adora occupied before entering that second portal. Is that so much to ask for?

But there's no other way. There's no going back.

Adora barely notices the knock at the door. She just continues sitting on the bed, mentally paralyzed by recent events. Images of Catra's kidnapping flash across her eyelids whenever she blinks.

Though far worse are the images of how Chasm might torture Catra, should Adora fail to comply with Chasm's terms.

At most, she tries to will herself up, back to her feet. She needs to pack, after all. She needs to pack Catra's things.

But somehow she never manages it.

It's several long minutes before another knock. Then another. Adora answers none of them. It's only when the door clicks open —and a figure slips inside the room—that Adora realizes that she failed to lock the door behind herself. She must have been too overwhelmed by panic.

But it's just Adam, Adora realizes with some relief. If it were anyone else...Adora would turn into She-Ra and toss them back into the hallway. And not gently, either. She'd be half-tempted to throw them right through the crystal wall.

"I'm sorry for coming in," Adam says. Whispers, really. As though the bedroom is some place of mourning. "I just...I don't think you should be alone right now."

And maybe it is a place of mourning. Adora has run out of good options, and only tragedy awaits her.

Adora gives another half-strangled scoff. "It won't matter whether I'm alone or not. I'm still going to make the same bad decision."

And it is a bad decision, Adora knows. Morally. Objectively. Giving Chasm power over She-Ra...it could destroy most of the universe. More people may die than will be saved. And worse...Adora could be the one carrying out the killing.

But Adora can't even contemplate the alternative. Catra, tortured and dead. Etheria's populace, permanently infected with Chasm's magic. If Adora doesn't do this, Adora fails everyone she loves.

It may be selfish. But after everything, Adora is entitled to some selfishness.

Adam sits beside Adora on the bed. He sits slowly, carefully. Like Adora is an animal that could be startled away by any wrong move.

"I'm sorry we didn't take Chasm more seriously," he says. "Our people haven't been threatened in a thousand years. It's made us complacent. Our parents, especially. If they had known Chasm was powerful enough to breach the city...they wouldn't have interrupted your search. Not even for a second."

"I don't know if it would've mattered," Adora murmurs, and wraps both arms around her stomach—trying to stop the awful churning there. The churning that evidences Adora's growing dread. "I think that maybe this was inevitable."

His brow creases. "What do you mean?"

"I didn't tell you before but...Chasm is in my head. She has been for months. Ever since I went into the portal where she was trapped—"

"Yes," says Adam with a nod. "The Sorceress told us. But that—" He points to the symbol on Adora's wrist. The rune that the Sorceress placed there. "That should keep her from reading your thoughts. The Sorceress said Chasm could still put you under a sleep spell, but your waking thoughts are safe."

"It doesn't matter," Adora hisses. "She already knows too much about me, about Catra. She knows exactly what I'll do and how I'll do it. And then she *calculates*. She plans. And her plans always work because they're based on how she *knows* I'll act and react and I—"

Adora gasps. It's a trembling inhale, one that doesn't seem to acquire Adora any more air. She still feels just as panicked, just as breathless.

It's a small comfort, Adora supposes. Knowing that Chasm isn't watching from behind Adora's own eyes. But it's made worse by the knowledge that Chasm doesn't *need* to watch. Chasm knows

she has Adora pinned. There's no way out of this. There's no real alternative. Adora will have to comply or lose everything she cares about.

"It doesn't matter if she no longer has access to my thoughts," Adora manages between a few more shaky breaths. "She knows enough. Ever since she first entered my head, she's known enough to outsmart me at every turn. And I'm not smart enough to come up with anything that could possibly surprise her, *beat her.* Catra is the one who's good at that. And she's not here, and I have no choice—"

"So you're going to do it?" Adam asks. "You're just going to give She-Ra to her?"

Adora sighs, head dropping into her hands. "I don't want to," she sobs. And she can't quite restrain the tears that plunge from her eyes, cutting cold stripes down her cheeks. "But if I don't...she's going to kill Catra."

There's a heavy pause from Adam, one that demonstrates how at a loss he is—completely unable to give advice. From her periphery, Adora can see Adam staring at his hands. Searching, as though they might somehow tell him the answers.

But then he murmurs, "You also said something about surrendering yourself. Back there, in the tower." He shoots Adora a nervous look. "What did that mean?"

Adora gulps and swipes her wrist across her eyes. "She needs me to give her She-Ra," Adora says. "I'm She-Ra's host. Which means that I have to kick She-Ra out of my body before She-Ra can be attached to the sword. And once Chasm has She-Ra in the sword…"

Adora rubs her own wrist, remembering the way the sword-turned-bracelet used to chafe against her skin. "She can give the sword to whoever she wants. Turn whoever she wants into a weapon that only Chasm can control."

“So she’ll let you go after you surrender?” Adam asks. And the hope in his voice is something devastating. “She just wants you to surrender so she can bind She-Ra to the sword, correct?”

Adora shakes her head, struggling to swallow more tears. “She could give it to anyone, yes...but she wants it to be me.”

Another dense pause—one that’s filled with terror. A terror shared by the both of them.

“Why?” says Adam, horrified.

Adora shrugs—resigned to the truth of the matter. “Learning She-Ra’s magic takes practice. Time. And if I take the sword…Chasm will have a fully-trained She-Ra at her disposal.” She gives another bitter scoff. “Not to mention the opportunity to see me suffer for the rest of my life. I imagine that’s probably a real attractive bonus for her too.”

“So what?” Adam demands. “You’re just going to follow her for the rest of your life, destroying whatever she tells you to?”

“That about sums it up, yeah,” grumbles Adora. And she doesn’t mean to sound so flippant. But thinking about her future in any sort of depth...it terrifies Adora beyond expression.

Adam gives a sharp exhale. His eyes affix to Adora’s face in a way that frightens her—like she's a corpse-to-be sitting beside him. And maybe he’s right to look at her that way. As soon as Adora takes that sword from Chasm, she’ll cease to exist in any way that matters. She’ll simply be an extension of Chasm’s will and cruelty.

“I can’t believe I just found my long-lost twin sister...only to lose her just as quickly,” Adam whispers. “It doesn’t seem fair. To you, especially.”

“Yeah,” mutters Adora. “It never does. But if it means anything...” She faces Adam directly. “I’m not so sure about everyone else here but...I’m glad I met you, at least. You’re the kind of brother I hoped I’d have.”

Adam musters a bit of a smile at that. Though it falters, after a few moments. The weight of their situation is far too great.

"I wish I could do something to help. I wish I could bind Chasm to that stupid sword instead, force *her* to take orders for a change," Adam says bitterly. "Give her a taste of her own medicine."

Adora gives a short chuckle in response. It would be nice, certainly. To turn the tables on Chasm. Get revenge for the control she tried to enact over Adora.

But then she remembers—

"*By allowing She-Ra to occupy your body, you are afforded power over her*," Chasm said, when talking about how Adora will turn over control of She-Ra.

And doesn't…

Doesn't Chasm occupy *Adora's* body? Isn't Chasm a magical entity too, just like She-Ra?

Adora's hand flies out, grasping at Adam's shoulder with an almost painful grip.

"I need to talk to the Sorceress again," Adora says. Half-gasps, really. She glances at her wrist, at the rune there, glad that Chasm can't eavesdrop on her thoughts at this very moment. "There might be a way to beat her yet."

Chapter End Notes

hmm...hmm.....

anyway, comment please!

Chapter 27

Chapter Summary

Adora asks the Sorceress a question.

Adam receives a gift.

And Teela makes a choice.

Chapter Notes

sorry this is so late! i was busy all day saturday and busy for most of today, and then forgot to post because i was trying to get my life in order.

Anyway, enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Sorceress stares at Adora, narrow chin clutched within her pale hand. Adora, meanwhile, can only stand. Shifting her feet. Glancing occasionally at Adam, who grants her an encouraging smile whenever he can.

Adora can *feel* the gears turning in the Sorceress's head, contemplating whether Adora's theory is sound—and whether it can be executed realistically.

Adora was relieved to find her parents already gone from the tower. She didn't need to suffer their judgement as she explained her near-insane idea. She feared that the Sorceress's judgement would be bad enough. Because Adora honestly expected the Sorceress to laugh Adora out of the room—

But the Sorceress didn't. She merely sat down on a nearby chair...and began to think.

Finally, the Sorceress looks up at Adora. She has seemingly arrived at a conclusion.

"I'm not certain if I am even allowed to discuss this with you," the Sorceress says. "Not after I made my oath to Chasm—"

"You swore you would not prevent Chasm from repairing the sword," Adora insists. "And we don't want to stop her from doing that. The sword *needs* to be repaired, if this plan is going to work."

The Sorceress pauses. "It is a loophole, most definitely. And I do not like being dishonest—"

"That didn't stop Chasm from using a loophole of her own," Adora half-growls. "The one that let her attack and kidnap Catra. If it wasn't for that, I wouldn't be in this situation at all."

That silences the Sorceress. With guilt, Adora hopes. Guilt and a willingness to help.

"So will it work?" Adora asks again. "What I'm suggesting. Will it work?"

The Sorceress grunts and taps her chin. Her reply is slow, like she still hasn't quite decided, even as the words leave her mouth. "Yes…" she says. "Hypothetically...it *could* work. But there are so many variables—"

"Which ones?" Adora demands, hope—and fear—roiling within her chest. "What will it take? What do I need to do to make it happen?"

"Too much," the Sorceress says, solemn. "There's so much you would need to do, and I'm not entirely sure all of it is possible. And much of it would involve tricks, tricks that Chasm might not even fall for, she is so clever. But it *could* be—"

"Tell me," orders Adora, stepping forward. "Whatever it takes, I'll do it."

The Sorceress sizes Adora up with her eyes, as though examining whether she could possibly be up for the task. This task of defeating Chasm once and for all.

"Chasm will draw runes upon the sword," the Sorceress says. "Magical runes. You will have to redraw them. Change them, so that they bind Chasm rather than She-Ra."

Adora nods. "Okay. I can do that."

But the Sorceress is still watching. Watching Adora warily, like the Sorceress is not finished—and that what follows will only be bad news for Adora to learn.

"But that is not all," the Sorceress says, just as Adora expects. "If this is to work, you will need to sever Chasm's connection to all her other hosts. She will need to relinquish control of everyone back on Etheria. And you will need to kill the hosts she has acquired here in Eternos."

Adora's jaw clenches. "That's...tricky…" Adora says. "But I might have a way to achieve that."

The Sorceress simply raises an eyebrow.

"I could make Chasm swear a deal," Adora says. "The same way you and her did. Tell her I'll only take the deal if she swears that everyone on Etheria will be *immediately* set free."

"But how will you keep from being actually bound to the deal?" Chasm says. "How will you prevent yourself from actually completing her bidding?"

Adora glances at Adam, and they exchange another smile. "I'm going to give her a taste of her own medicine. Use a loophole, just as she did."

"She might not fall for it," the Sorceress warns. "Chasm has always been too clever."

“But that’s why this is going to work,” Adora says. “I’ve learned not to underestimate her by now. But Chasm...she thinks I’m an idiot. That I can be manipulated at every turn. She doesn’t think I’m smart enough to outsmart her. Maybe she thought better of Catra, but not of me.”

Adora smirks.

“And that’s why she’s going to be caught off guard when I outsmart her this time. She thinks she’s already won. And she won’t know what hit her when I use her own tricks against her.”

That seems to intrigue her, at least. The Sorceress. She regards Adora with a bit more belief now, rather than skepticism. Though she still sighs, like there’s still one more obstacle forthcoming. And there is.

“There is one last thing,” the Sorceress murmurs. “And this will be the hardest part. Harder than I can even imagine.”

Adora stiffens. There’s still hope there, in Adora’s chest. But it runs for cover at the Sorceress’s words, fearful that this news will skewer right through Adora’s plans.

“You can trick her, and destroy her bond to all her hosts,” the Sorceress says. “But that will not change the fact that she is bonded to you. Bonded, in a way that no normal person can break. That is where Chasm is different than She-Ra. The bond isn’t mutual. Chasm is the one who creates it, secures it. And so long as that bond is in place, there is no way to attach Chasm to the sword instead.”

Adora gulps, and sure enough, the dread carves its way back inside.

“Why wouldn’t you mention that earlier, then?” Adora demands. “That basically means this won’t work—”

The Sorceress holds up a hand, silencing Adora. “I said no *normal* person could break the bond. But you...you are not normal. You

are She-Ra. You are one of the most powerful magical beings in the universe."

Adora's mouth snaps shut, then opens again.

"What does that mean?" Adora says. "You're saying I could've just kicked Chasm out this whole time?"

"No," says the Sorceress. "Truthfully, I cannot be certain about any of this. We are now dealing with a situation beyond my experience, beyond my magical knowledge—and certainly beyond yours. But here is what I know to be true."

Adora fists clench at her side. She just wants answers. A sure way to defeat Chasm, and save Catra, and rescue Etheria—

"Chasm's bond to her hosts is secured by the strength of her magic," the Sorceress says. "If she is weakened—if she loses access to misery or other forms of magic to feed on—she cannot attach herself to them in any permanent manner. Her hosts can cast her out."

"Yeah, that's why Catra was able to break Chasm's spell, back when we first found Chasm," Adora says impatiently. "I knew that already. If she absorbs enough magic, though—like she did with me—she can hold on. No matter what I try."

"But that's where you might be wrong," says the Sorceress. "Chasm's victims cannot usually break her attachment *because* her magic is stronger than theirs. But you…" The Sorceress gestures to Adora. "Your magic rivals Chasm's. You are She-Ra. You are imbued with the magic of the Heart of Etheria."

But still, Adora doesn't understand. "What are you saying?"

"I am saying," the Sorceress continues, "that if you focus your full magic—the magic at the deepest core of yourself—on severing Chasm's attachment...it might just work."

"I've tried," Adora says. "Back there, in the portal. When she was siphoning magic from me. It didn't work. She held on no matter how hard I tried to force her out—"

"It will take much," the Sorceress says. "It will take more magic than you've ever tapped into before. More magic than repairing broken magical artifacts, more magic than summoning bursts of destructive energy, more magic than rescuing someone from the edge of death."

Adora takes a shaky breath at that. She can't imagine anything taking more magic than healing does. Healing leaves Adora exhausted beyond description.

"I believe you have the power to shatter Chasm's control," the Sorceress says. "But it might take more of yourself than you've ever had to give."

"But…" Adora swallows, willing her voice to remain steady. "But you think it's possible?"

The Sorceress nods. "I do. But there are many risks. If you fail to trick Chasm into freeing Etheria...if she sees your oath for what it truly is...she will likely kill Catra."

Adora's whole body tenses. She can't stand that thought—the thought of Catra dying. But Adora is confident. This will work, it *has* to. And worse case, if it doesn't...Adora will just try her best to rescue Catra the old-fashioned way. Using a sword and her muscles.

But she hopes it won't come to that. Not when that option poses so many risks to Catra, and will still leave Etheria doomed.

"We'll be convincing," Adora assures the Sorceress—as well as herself. "If anything, she'll think we're securing her victory."

The Sorceress raises an eyebrow. "We?"

Adora smirks. “All part of the plan. We’ll fill you in the exact details in a little bit.”

The Sorceress makes a curious noise, but doesn’t press further. Not yet.

“The next risk, though...is also significant,” the Sorceress continues. “If you fail to redraw Chasm’s runes correctly...you may end up still binding She-Ra to the sword, rather than Chasm.”

Adora exhales sharply. “And then Chasm will have exactly what she wants?”

The Sorceress nods. “Everything except you as her weapon, yes. She will have the ability to control the next She-Ra.”

Adora nods. Then nods again. Then keeps nodding. “I’ll just have to memorize those runes *really* well,” Adora half-jokes. But internally, she is utterly *screaming* at herself to get those runes right. The prospect of failing, of making some small mistake that essentially *gives* Chasm control over She-Ra...utterly terrifies Adora.

But she’ll have to push through it. For everyone else’s sake, she needs to try. She needs to defeat Chasm for good.

“And there is the risk that you fail to summon the magic and fail to shatter Chasm’s control. As her only host...we may need to send you into the prison dimension. And leave you there to prevent Chasm from infecting anyone else.”

Adora gulps. And wouldn’t that be some terrible irony—that Adora would end up trapped in another portal, just as Angella was. Just as Adora should have been, when she first failed to push Chasm out of her head.

“So…” the Sorceress says. She folds her hands over her stomach. “With all that in mind...do you still wish to try this plan of yours?”

“Yes,” replies Adora, with no hesitation.

Because if Adora can pull this off…

It might save everyone. Catra, Etheria, the rest of the universe...

And even Adora herself.

That night, rather than pack, Adora occupies herself by tracing the runes over and over. The runes the Sorceress showed her, the ones she'll need to draw in order to bind Chasm to the sword.

The Sorceress herself cannot leave Tower Grayskull to help them. She is powerless beyond the Tower walls. Such is the limitation of her runestone.

So Adora can't get these runes wrong. The Sorceress made that clear. If she does, she might lose She-Ra—and Chasm might still win it all.

And since Adora cannot sleep—not while Essence of Eternity is in her system—she sits at her desk to draw, and keep drawing. Teaching herself every curve, every line, every dot without fail. She'll need to be perfect, absolutely perfect. Catra can't afford Adora's screw-ups. Neither can Etheria. And neither can *Adora*, if she wants to keep She-Ra out of Chasm's clutches.

Earlier, Adora tried her best to meditate. It was important that Adora rest in some way, especially with what tomorrow will entail. She'll need to pull so much power from deep inside herself, more than she's ever summoned in the past.

But the meditation served another purpose too. Adora needed to have one last conversation with Chasm.

She wasn't sure it would be possible, what with that new rune on Adora's wrist. But the Sorceress had assured Adora that she could still communicate with Chasm if Adora cleared her mind enough. Chasm can still be granted access to specific thoughts or conversations—but only if Adora chooses to share them first.

So that's exactly what Adora did, when she invited Chasm into that meditation session. She granted her permission to speak, and be spoken to. But not much more than that.

"*So the Sorceress found a way to shield your thoughts from me*," Chasm sneered as she slithered from the shadows, bearing down upon Adora with eyes glowing bright white. "*Let me guess—an Eavesdroppers' Ward? I didn't think anyone would remember that old spell. But then again...the Sorceress is as old as they come. And I'm hardly the first person to listen to another person's thoughts."*

Adora didn't answer because...truthfully? She didn't know. The Sorceress never told Adora the exact name of the spell. Just that it would keep Chasm from watching from behind Adora's own eyes.

Chuckling, Chasm added: *"It won't change what will happen tomorrow night. Surely you know that*."

"*You said you gave me a choice, and time to make it*," Adora replied. Again, without moving her mouth, as she never does in these shared visions with Chasm. "*And it doesn't feel like much of a choice if you're watching every thought that crosses my mind while I'm considering*."

"*Well, if avoiding my 'supervision' is so important to you,*" Chasm said. *"Then why seek me out now?*"

Chasm smirked. Smirked, like she knew Adora was trapped, and inescapably so. "*Unless you wish to tell me your answer early?"*

"*I'm speaking to you to let you know that I won't be alone tomorrow, when I arrive at the coordinates*," Adora told Chasm calmly. Or really, as calmly as she could manage.

Chasm scoffed—though the sound lacked actual amusement. Her outrage shone plain across her features. "*And what makes you think you have the right to make such a decision*?"

"If I don't bring someone," Adora said, "*and I agree to serve as your She-Ra...Catra will be left alone in the desert. She's hurt. Maybe even concussed. I need someone to bring her back to the city for medical treatment—*"

"*I said come alone*," Chasm hissed—and truly, nothing could upset Chasm more than this. This display of disobedience right when Chasm thought she had complete control over Adora. "*And you will do as I say—*"

"*It's just my brother*," Adora argued. "*He's the only person I'm bringing. No one else*."

"*I told you—*"

"*I'm not going to give you She-Ra if Catra is just going to die in the desert anyway!*" Adora half-yelled, furious. Determined. Immovable in this demand, even to her own ears. "*So either you let me bring my brother...or you let your carefully laid plans fall apart. I'm not going to give you the power to destroy the universe for nothing in exchange.*"

Chasm's fists clenched at her side.

"*Fine*," Chasm conceded, between gritted teeth. "*You may bring your brother. But no one else. No one at all. If I detect another lifeform accompanying you...Catra will be—*"

Chasm dragged a finger across her throat. Slowly. Deliberately. And Adora could not quite keep herself from imagining a knife really swiping across Catra's throat like that—

"*Tomorrow at midnight*," Chasm reminded Adora. "*Don't be late*."

And then Chasm dissipated into thin air. And Adora broke the meditation, leaving her mind once again protected from any ear of Chasm's. It was only then that Adora decided to practice the runes that the Sorceress showed her. The one she'll need for tomorrow, when (or if) she binds Chasm to the sword.

So now Adora sits here, at her desk. Tracing, tracing that rune until Adora can draw it perfectly, even with her eyes closed.

Tomorrow. Tomorrow, Adora beats Chasm.

Or it all goes wrong.

The next morning, the Sorceress gives Adora and Adam what they asked for—a pair of magical amulets. Adora doesn't have the time nor the skills to learn a lifetime's worth of magical spells in the span of 24 hours. So these amulets will cast the crucial spells that neither Adora nor Adam have the skills to complete—or maintain—on their own.

But only so long as they are wearing them.

Though the Sorceress is not finished after she gives them the amulets. She has something else to give. An additional means for Adora to protect herself and Adam, should the need arise. Should it come to a physical fight against Chasm's powerful magic.

Or at least, that's what the Sorceress *says* it is. Just a tool. Just a means of protection. And Adora believes her, until she actually sees it.

It is a parcel, wrapped in leather. One that she places within Adora's own hands. Nothing fancy, nothing impressive. Just simple animal skin around something heavy and hard.

Carefully, Adora unfolds the parcel's wrappings. She doesn't need to fully unwrap them to recognize what is beneath. She has seen such a thing before, after all. Or at least something similar.

The sight of it disgusts her.

"Why did you keep this?" Adora demands. "After everything that happened, everything that Mara and I told you—"

“I kept it as one last means to defend ourselves, should we find ourselves threatened by an adversary in battle,” the Sorceress says. “I am not proud of it. But I thought it was necessary, as a last resort. This one was created to protect Eternia and its people, and for that purpose alone.”

Adora doesn’t care about excuses. With one look inside, Adora determined that the parcel contained something wrong, something unnatural—

“I’m not taking this,” Adora says, thrusting the parcel back into the Sorceress’s arms. “Why would I even need it—”

“It will help you, yes,” replies the Sorceress. “But mostly, it is for him.”

The Sorceress’s eyes slide to Adam, beside Adora. And Adora stiffened.

He blinks, taken aback. “Me?”

“You saw what Chasm did to those guards at the foot of my tower,” the Sorceress says. “We cannot risk losing both the crown prince and the crown princess in a single battle. Adora has She-Ra. But I would be remiss if I did not provide you both with suitable protection—”

“No one’s ever trusted me with anything,” Adam whispers, wide eyes affixed to the parcel. “And you’re trusting me with something like this?”

“If you are brave enough to face Chasm to help your sister,” the Sorceress says with a pride that makes Adora’s skin crawl, “you are brave enough to carry this.”

“But it’s wrong,” Adora argued. “It shouldn’t exist at all—”

“Would you prefer he died trying to help you?” the Sorceress demands, an eyebrow raised.

That shuts Adora up. Because *of course* Adora doesn' want that. She still can't believe that Adam agreed to help her in the first place, and she'd never forgive herself if he got hurt because of *her* plan.

And Chasm really might kill him. She has the power. And someone like Adam has never seen battle, true battle, and can't possibly understand the dangers it poses—

"Fine," Adora agrees, but furiously. She yanks the parcel from the Sorceress's hands and drops it into Adam's, where it feels just slightly safer. "Come on," she urges him, steering him away from the Sorceress and toward the stairs. "I'll show you how to use this thing."

"The words are different for this one, you know," the Sorceress calls to Adora, before she and Adam can leave. "They are not the ones you were taught."

Adora rolls her eyes and stops short, shooting a glare over her shoulder at the Sorceress. "Then what are they?"

The Sorceress's stare is steady. Impassive. "For the *power* of Grayskull. Not honor."

Adora snorts and rolls her eyes. The change...it's fitting. In the worst way.

"Of course it is," is Adora's only response, before she shoves Adam from the room.

And she resolves to destroy the damn thing before giving it back. Before letting the Sorceress hide it in her tower again, concealed from the consequences of its very existence.

Adora finds Teela in the medical wing of the castle. She is bedridden. Nervous, shaking, *trembling* as Adora sits down beside her, pulling the closest chair beside the thin white cot that serves as Teela's bed.

Adora wouldn't necessarily call Teela her friend, but she at the very least respects Teela. She respects her authority. Her confidence. Her desire to help her people. And seeing her like *this*...stripped of her armor, curled in on herself, body shaking, eyes staring blankly at the ceiling…

She looks small. Small, and broken, and not at all like herself.

Chasm did this. She did this to Teela. She cast her sleep spell on Teela, trapped Teela in one of her torturous illusions. And Adora knows better than any other that *this*, whatever this is...it may never truly be healed. She knows that once Chasm plants her roots within a person, she leaves some part of them permanently broken.

"Teela," Adora says, and Teela jumps at the sound of her voice. She spends several moments eyeing Adora like she might not be real at all.

"How do I know you're really you?" Teela asks through gritted teeth. "How do I know you're you and not *her*?"

Her. Chasm. The word is spoken like a curse, much like how Adora would normally utter it.

Adora doesn't answer. She only outstretches a hand. With a few hours of sleep in her system, Adora is able to summon She-Ra with relative ease. She allows the sword to appear between her fingers—as proof of her identity—then dissolves it into the air like dandelion seeds.

Teela merely raises an eyebrow. "And Chasm could not simply create the illusion of a sword?"

Adora chuckles, despite herself. "Not without drawing a rune first. Which you would've seen me do."

Teela considers this for several moments, and then, reluctantly, she hums as though convinced.

“So why are you here?” demands Teela. “As you can probably tell, I am in no position to help you search for Chasm.” Adora watches as Teela seems to curl even deeper into herself. “Not that I was much help to begin with,” adds Teela, muttering. “She found us long before we found her.”

“I’m not looking for Chasm,” Adora says. “I know where she’s going to be. I just need the means to get there.”

“The ship?”

Adora nods. “I need to know where it is. And how to access it.”

Teela shoots Adora an appraising glance. “I take it that the King and Queen don’t approve of your plan to meet with her?” Teela asks, though her tone implies that she already knows the answer.

“How’d you guess?”

“I suspect you’d already have it if they *wanted* you to have it,” says Teela, groaning slightly as she pulls herself upright, her back propped against the wall. “So. You are here to ask me to betray my King and Queen. The people I have sworn to serve.”

“Yes,” says Adora, unflinchingly.

“I cannot,” says Teela. “I swore to protect my people—”

“If you want to protect your people so badly, you’d help me. I have a way to beat her. To beat Chasm. The last thing I need is that ship—”

And that seems to get Teela’s attention, at least. The fact that Adora has a plan. One that Adora seems to believe in, however absurd it might be in reality. Teela’s eyes widen and her eyebrows shoot up in interest—though she is quick to compose herself. To shake her head and deny Adora’s request.

“I have been told that we are safe from her here,” says Teela. “So long as we stay within the city.”

“Do you really think that Chasm won’t find a loophole to that deal?” Adora asks. “She already found a loophole in the ward that was *designed* to protect against her. She found a loophole that allowed her to enter the supposedly *impenetrable* city walls. And she’ll do it again, if she really wants to.”

Adora can see Teela’s jaw tightening. Tightening in horror at what Adora is describing.

“And then everyone here will suffer what you and I have suffered, within those illusions of hers.”

Teela falls silent for a long time at that, studying the sheets that drape over her legs. Seemingly searching for answers in the blank whiteness that sheathes her body. Or, better yet, maybe she is just looking for an excuse to avoid looking Adora in the eyes.

Adora leans closer to her, lowering her voice to a whisper. “Teela,” she pleads. “You experienced what it’s like to be in her illusions—how awful it was. We can’t let her go free. We can’t let that happen to anyone else. And I can *stop* her, if you help me—”

“She showed me terrible things, yes,” admits Teela, voice tense and trembling as an over-coiled spring. “Things that terrified me. Things that nearly made me wish for death. But that…” She sighs. “That was not the worst part. Not to me.”

Teela’s hands curl into fists and burrow into the sheets, wrinkling them.

“I have always been afraid of it,” Teela says. “Of losing control of myself. Of my own body. Of being the host of some…” She gulps visibly, almost painfully. “Of some *entity*. People have told me my whole life that I am destined for it. That I am destined to be the Sorceress’s next host, just as my mother was. That I am unimportant, save the greater purpose I could serve to magic.”

Yes, Adora remembers this. She remembers the hatred with which Teela regarded the Sorceress’s power and spirit. She remembers how Teela blamed the Sorceress for stealing her mother.

“And I always claimed,” Teela continues, “that I would die before that happened. Before I let something use me as a puppet.”

Teela shakes her head. Shakes it wildly, as though trying to toss such an entity from her mind.

“But I was *helpless*,” Teela murmurs, voice cracking so audibly that Adora winces. “I was helpless as she used me, as she wormed her way into my brain and used it as she pleased. And use me she certainly did. She used me to barter. To manipulate the Sorceress. To capture your wife and escape into the desert.”

Adora reaches out and clasps Teela’s shoulder. It’s not much of a comfort, Adora knows. The squeeze of Adora’s hand around Teela’s shoulder. But it is all that Adora can offer.

“And what was I, in that moment,” demands Teela, “except the exact thing I feared becoming? A mindless thing at the mercy of some magical monster.”

Adora knows how she feels. She has experienced these exact same emotions for herself—is still experiencing them right now, in this moment—and knows just how overwhelming they can be. This feeling of helplessness, this sense of failure, this terror of having her worst fears realized.

And there’s only one way to make it stop. She must do this. Teela must help Adora stop Chasm.

“We can stop that from ever happening again,” says Adora, quietly. “To you, or to anyone else. All I need is the location of my ship.”

Teela glances up at Adora. And for the first time ever, Adora sees a few cracks in Teela’s resolve. In her loyalty to the crown. Her whole face seems to tremble beneath the weight of her indecision, like every feature is being pulled in a thousand different directions.

And then, finally, it all seems to relent. Teela's face goes slack. Not relaxed, exactly, but more at peace than Adora has ever seen.

"I will tell you," says Teela, with a sigh. "So long as you beat her. So long as you make her hurt. So long as you make her *pay* for what she put us through."

Adora nods. She nods and nods, unable to suppress a smile. She is somewhat incredulous that she managed to convince Teela to do it—to reveal the ship. But she supposes there are responsibilities that transcend all oaths, all loyalties. The danger that Chasm poses cannot be ignored. It cannot be avoided. It must be defeated, dealt with, kept from hurting another soul—

Teela knows this. She knows that the right thing to do—the *Queenly* thing to do—is to allow Adora a chance to eliminate the threat.

"That's the plan," Adora tells her.

It's nightfall. Adora and Adam are about to board the remaining spacecraft when the King and Queen try to stop them.

They're there, in the hangar, waiting for them. Arms folded over their chests, faces reddened in their outrage. With all their ornaments and medallions and crowns, they appear completely out-of-place among the working people and heavy machinery of the hangar.

Teela is there too, standing beside them.

Adora didn't expect her to be standing and back on duty as Captain of the Royal guard so soon. Not after what she went through. But Adora suspects that the King and Queen didn't give Teela much of a choice.

"Where do you two think you're going?" the Queen demands, in that signature indignant way of hers.

Adora and Adam just keep approaching the ship, refusing to so much as respond.

"There is no way I am letting both my children get *slaughtered* in the hope of saving someone who may already be dead—" the Queen continues. "You are adults. You are the prince and princess. You have a responsibility to stay and serve your people —"

"I don't care," says Adora. "I'm going to save Catra. And you can't stop me."

"Adam!" the Queen pleads helplessly, looking to her son—as though he might see sense where Adora does not. "Surely, you must realize this is suicide—"

"We have a plan. A good one," says Adam, and he provides something that Adora did not—a note of apology to his words. "So I'm going to help her. That's what family does, when it's a good family. Or what people do in general, when they're good to one another. They help each other."

"Helping your sister destroy herself is hardly a selfless act," the Queen spits.

"I'm helping her save the people she loves," says Adam. "And I'm helping her save herself too."

"And what about you?" the King demands. And Adora is almost startled to hear him speak, she is so used to the Queen leading the arguments. "What if you get killed? What if you both do? Who will rule?"

Adam shrugs. "I supposed you two will, for as long as you can. And once you're gone—" He grins at Adora and shrugs again. "I guess you'll have to find someone who's best suited for the job. Someone who actually wants it."

"I am not hearing this," the Queen snarls. "Not from my own children—

And this time, she makes the mistake of stepping directly into Adora's path—blocking their entry to the ship. The King mimics her just as immediately and together, they create a formidable barrier in Adora's way.

Though it's not one that Adora cannot handle.

Magic washes across Adora's skin as she transforms into She-Ra. Her height grows, allowing her to tower over the King and Queen until they are entirely bathed in her shadow.

"Stand aside," Adora orders, in her most commanding *She-Ra* voice. The one Catra sometimes makes fun of, the one that Adora uses to mediate conflicts and end interplanetary disagreements.

And the King and Queen seem frightened enough to consider, for a moment.

But they don't consider it hard enough, unfortunately.

"You do not give us orders," the King bellows. "We rule this place, and since both of you refuse to accept your roles—"

He does not finish. Not before Adora simply thrusts her arms between them, and swipes to the side—essentially pushing the King and Queen apart and allowing herself forward. The King and Queen are left stumbling to Adora's left and right, unbalanced by her strength.

Adora and Adam begin walking up the ship's ramp.

"Teela!" the Queen yells, pointing wildly at Adora and Adam behind herself. "Stop them!"

But Teela doesn't charge, doesn't raise her sword. Not even after a pause. She remains unmoving, watching Adora and Adam with deep circles beneath her eyes. Evidence of a sleepless night. Adora would know. Adora would know the cause, too.

“Make sure she can’t hurt anyone again,” Teela says, eyes affixed to Adora’s. Her voice is genuine. “Beat her. Hurt her back. And contact me, if you require help. I will find people to aid you.”

Adora nods. That’s the hope, after all. To beat Chasm. To save the universe and enact some sort of revenge. And while it’s a sweet sentiment—especially after all the bickering between Adora and Teela—Adora hopes that she won’t need Teela’s help. If all goes to plan, the only aid she will need is from Adam and Catra.

Teela turns from the ship and marches from the hangar. Her sword clatters sharply to the floor behind her, tossed there upon her exit.

The King and Queen are left staring, dumbstruck, after her. Too stunned by so many acts of disobedience at once.

They do not stop Adam and Adora as they board the ship and take off, determined to fulfill Teela’s request: to beat Chasm, and make her hurt.

Chapter End Notes

please remember to comment!

Chapter 28

Chapter Summary

One last oath is made.

Chapter Notes

Hi all! An important announcement. I have decided to be nice (for once) and post chapters 29, 30, and a surprise epilogue all at once next week. So yes. Next week will be when the story ends—the last time I ever update the chasm saga. Please tune in at 6:30pm EST next week as we close out this series after OVER A YEAR of near-continuous posting.

I hope you enjoy this chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chasm waits.

Any moment now, this fight will finally be over—and Chasm will have won. Any moment now, and Adora will arrive. Arrive, and agree to the deal that Chasm has laid before her, the deal that will grant Chasm control of a fully-trained She-Ra.

She-Ra. An endless source of magic and power and protection. Never again will Chasm be chased off, imprisoned, threatened with destruction. The universe will be hers for the taking

...or for the breaking.

But for now, she waits. It is not midnight quite yet.

She has outfitted a space in the desert for her purposes. A circle of land surrounded by magic torches, ones that burn bright red against the cold desert sky. And, with more magic, she shaped and raised the rock, forming a dais and a table upon it. A place for

Chasm to place the sword and encircle it with the proper runes, the ones needed to complete the spell once Adora arrives.

One of the Chasm's hosts stands upon that dais now. Placed there, to greet Adora. The others are guarding Catra—placed on either side to prevent any escape attempts from Catra, or rescue attempts from Adora. Should the deal go wrong, Chasm will use those hosts to kill Catra, just as she promised she would.

Though they're hidden from sight—Catra and Chasm's other hosts—as an added precaution. Made invisible to the eye and soundless to the ear by a powerful concealment spell.

Chasm knows Adora. She knows that Adora might plan to swoop in and rescue Catra without giving Chasm what she wants. That's always been a signature move of Adora's—barreling in, hoping for the best.

But Chasm will not give her the chance. Adora will complete the terms of Chasm's deal, or Catra will die. Those are the only options.

Time ticks closer to midnight. Chasm waits. And waits. Until, finally, a light emerges from the darkness—the distant beam of a floating spaceship, growing larger by the second.

Chasm smirks at the sight. It's just as she expected.

The ship shoots forward and forward until, finally, it is hovering just outside the circle of torches, above the ground but sinking lower, lower, sweeping dirt into a veritable dust storm as it lands.

The ship drops onto the desert floor with the shifting of a rock and the dying whir of a switched-off engine. Chasm continues smirking as all lights from the ship extinguish, one by one. A ramp extends. A door opens. And there she is—Adora, striding down the ramp, followed by her brother.

Adora and Adam both appear to be unarmed. Not, of course, that Adora couldn't simply *summon* a sword from thin air. Such is the

benefit of wielding She-Ra's power.

A benefit that will soon be at Chasm's command.

Adora storms her way to the circle of torches, then steps within it. Her fists are clenched tightly at her sides. She is sweating—her face gleaming in the torchlight. But Chasm should hardly find that surprising. It's a stressful situation, having one's wife held for ransom.

Adora nods to her brother, who stops walking—instead choosing to wait at the edge of the circle. Standing between the torches. And that, if anything, is above Chasm's expectations. It's good, yes. To ensure that Adora's brother will not interfere. But Chasm was so certain that having Adam in attendance would present some sort of interruption, or cause an argument—

But he's behaving just as she'd want him to. Sticking to the perimeter, not drawing close enough to cause a problem.

Adora, meanwhile, reaches the center of the circle. She appears poorly-rested, as usual, with dark circles beneath her eyes. But she is standing upright and steady, facing Chasm directly on the dais before her.

"Welcome, Adora," says Chasm, smug. "You're right on time."

She sees Adora swallow. Swallow hard, and then—

"Can we skip the pleasantries?" Adora says, terse. She shifts between her feet. "I just want to get this over with."

Her voice is...hesitant. Wavering. Like she's not sure how to sound, in a situation like this. If her intention was to come across as confident, or angry, she has succeeded at neither.

"Fine," says Chasm. "I will also be pleased to finish this. But first thing's first…" She has her host drop a single foot from the dais, so that she's standing more level with Adora. Eye-to-eye. "You

need to tell me your answer. The choice you have made. Will you save only Catra? Or all of Etheria? Or perhaps..."

Chasm contemplates for a moment, then throws back her head and laughs.

"Well, I was going to say, '*perhaps you'll save no one at all*.' But that hardly seems your style."

Adora's jaw clenches. "Where is Catra?" she demands, glancing around. "I refuse to take any deals until I know she is safe."

"She's here," Chasm says, with a vague wave of her hand. "But I will not reveal her until you make your choice. There'll be no premature rescues. Not today. Only after you give me what I want will I show her to you. And release her."

"That isn't fair," complains Adora. "You could have killed her already. How am I supposed to know whether she's alright?"

Smiling, Chasm replies, "You'll have to take it on faith, I suppose."

"No," says Adora, shaking her head. She shoots an uncertain look over her shoulder, directed at her brother, but receives only an encouraging nod. "If you won't show her to me...then I want a deal. A promise. Like the one you made with the Sorceress."

Chasm raises her eyebrows. "You're making an awful lot of demands for someone who holds no power in this situation."

"I do have power, actually," Adora says. "I will be trading you the most powerful magical entity in the universe for Catra's life. I will not take that deal unless I am *sure* that Catra is going to be alright. You could turn around and kill her at any time, and all this would be for *nothing*—"

Chasm snarls in frustration. "Fine," she hisses. "So what, exactly, did you have in mind?"

“Make an oath,” says Adora. “Swear on your magic, swear on the same terms as your deal. If I do what you say—if I carry out this binding spell as you instruct—you let Catra go. And you swear not to harm her *ever*, even after I have completed my part.”

Chasm hums, tapping her chin. The terms are nothing too demanding. Nothing beyond what she is comfortable with. But still. She does not like to be told what to do, or be beholden to the terms of any oath.

And she especially does not wish to extend any sort of special protection to Catra.

“And what if I refuse?” Chasm asks, an eyebrow raised.

“Then you will receive nothing,” Adora tells her, calmly. “And I’ll destroy your hosts.”

“I’ll destroy Catra first,” Chasm counters.

“That is not much of a threat if you’re only going to kill her anyway,”

Chasm hums again. It’s a good point, even if she hates to admit it.

“The same goes for Etheria,” Adora continues. “If I agree to wield the sword once the spell is done...if I submit myself to your control...you must swear to free Etheria in return. Everyone there must be left uninfected by your magic. Because without an oath… without a guarantee that Etheria will be safe,” Adora shakes her head. “There is no way that I will wield that sword for you. No way at all.”

Chasm continues tapping her own chin. The terms are not entirely disagreeable. And it’s not unexpected, really—that Adora would want insurance. A way to *make sure* that Chasm carries out her side of the deal. Chasm merely hoped that Adora would be more gullible.

But...Chasm supposes it's not much to be concerned about. There are plenty of other planets besides Etheria, plenty of other people to terrorize besides Catra. And while Chasm resents that she can't carry out proper revenge against the Etherians who wronged her...gaining control of She-Ra is far more valuable.

"Fine," Chasm agrees. "I will swear it. But know this." Her host takes another step down from the dais. "If you fail to adhere to your side of the bargain...I will be beholden to nothing. Neither Catra nor Etheria will be safe from me."

Adora nods like she understands.

"I just want to make sure they will be safe," Adora says, with a nervous glance at her brother—still at the edge of the circle. "Safe, no matter what."

And so, with an exasperated eye roll, Chasm begins the spell that will provide Adora with the insurance that she craves. Chasm raises her hand, then begins drawing the oath rune into the air. "I swear on my magic," says Chasm, with red light spilling from her fingertips, "that I will free Catra, and leave her unharmed, should you carry out the binding spell as I instruct."

"And?" Adora presses. And Chasm grimaces to hear her own words thrown back at her.

"And…" Chasm continues, still tracing the rune. "I swear to free those on Etheria from my magic, so long as you wield the sword after the spell is carried out."

With a final swerve of her finger, the oath completes. Chasm's eyebrows shoot up. "Happy now?" she huffs at Adora.

"Not exactly, no. But it's enough," Adora sighs, briefly looking at her feet, then at Chasm before her. "What do I have to do next?"

Chasm reaches forward and grabs Adora's wrist. Roughly, she yanks Adora forward, forcing her to stumble onto the dais. She

can do little but follow the guide of Chasm's hand as she leads her to the hilt of the sword, sitting upon the stone table.

Chasm spent the last day piecing the shards together—reforming the Sword of Protection from the fragments in that box Adora saved. Chasm used magic to do it, of course, otherwise it might have taken months to reconstruct.

Though while it is now a whole weapon, a whole sword, not a single physical piece missing...it is still incomplete.

"Grasp the hilt," Chasm whispers into Adora's ear, and squeezes her host's hand around Adora's, forcing it to clutch at the sword's base. "And stay there."

Adora does as she's told. She goes stock-still, arm frozen outstretched, fingers curled tightly around the hilt.

And then Chasm gets to work.

She traces her fingers along the sword's face. This is a necessary part—to imbue it with the magic that was lost during the sword's shattering. To turn a simple collection of crystal and metal and gems into a runestone once more. When the spell is finished, every particle of the sword should be changed. Filled with magic, filled with power—

She traces and traces, glowing runes trailing from her fingers. Chasm took great care to memorize the spells from the Sorceress's book. In particular, she committed to memory the exact process of creating the runestone so that it can be replicated here, now.

Eventually, the runes aren't the only things that glow. The sword begins to glow from the inside out. It glows bright, and brighter, bright as can be. So bright that Adora can hardly stand to look at it. She averts her eyes, then closes one, the sword's glow is so unbearable.

But Chasm does not look away. Not even if it causes her host pain. She keeps carving the many necessary, intricate runes. And it is only through the process that Chasm learns just how difficult the spell is, the one described in the Sorceress's book. There are so many runes, so many pieces to connect and carve. It is no wonder that no one has deciphered this process over the years. Really, it is something of a miracle that the Sorceress came up with it in the first place.

Chasm keeps going. Keeps tracing runes, keeps making the sword glow brighter. It's a dozen long minutes before she reaches the end of the first part—the part that involves turning the sword into a runestone. Though the sword doesn't stop glowing once it's finished. Its radiance steadies, but it does not stop. It merely shines invitingly, as though awaiting something.

The next step, of course, is to bind She-Ra to it.

Adora jumps when Chasm grasps Adora's wrist. Chasm begins to trace runes onto it, onto the wrist, the symbols extending from the back of Adora's fingers to the small bump of her elbow. She is stiff and trembling slightly between Chasm's touch, but Chasm does not let it distract her.

Soon, the glow from the sword extends up Adora's arm—enveloping her sleeve in the brightest of lights. Adora makes a noise of fear, but doesn't move.

Chasm keeps tracing the runes, drawing them up the arm, over the shoulder, tracing and backtracking and retracing again until, finally, Chasm is tracing the symbols over Adora's sternum, where the collarbones meet. Where the heart beats beneath, raging against Adora's ribcage.

And then, with the final rune, Chasm hisses to Adora, "Repeat these words after me, and mean them."

Frantically, Adora nods—eyes wide and fearful as they affix themselves to her now-glowing chest and arm.

"*I call upon the entity known as She-Ra. The one who shares this form alongside me,*" Chasm whispers.

"I-I call upon the entity known as She-Ra," Adora recites as loud as she can muster, after first clearing her throat. "The one who shares this form alongside me."

"I reject my role as her host."

"I reject my role as her host."

"And cast her from my body into the ether."

"And cast her from my body…" Adora says. "Into the ether."

Chasm smiles, and adds the finishing touch. The final stroke of the spell—a glowing line that runs from Adora's chest, along her arm, over her finger, and back to gem at the sword's hilt. The path that She-Ra will follow, when she is thrust from Adora's body.

As soon as Chasm's finger makes contact with it, the gem glows. It glows and glows, brighter than anything Chasm has ever seen, brighter than the rest of the sword, brighter than a star in close vicinity. Adora shuts both eyes and looks away. Even Chasm is forced to do the same, so bright is the light of the spell's completion.

Only when the light ceases to stream white through her host's eyelids does Chasm reopen her eyes.

The sword still sits there on the table, glowing only faintly now. Evidence of its magic. Adora is breathing heavily as she stares at it, hand still clutched around the hilt. She looks up at Chasm with wide eyes.

"I did what you said," Adora says. "Now show me Catra."

Chasm smirks and waves her hand. There's no use in hiding Catra now—not now that the spell is complete. And besides, Chasm is *bound* to do so.

So, with the wave of that hand, Catra and the rest of Chasm's hosts shimmer into view. She's still restrained in chains—gagged across her mouth, arms and legs tugged together. Catra's expression is rage-filled, her eyes wide with intense outrage.

Though it seems that outrage is not directed at Chasm. Not this time. Instead, Catra's wide-eyed, furious gaze is affixed to Adora's face—like she cannot believe that Adora agreed to such a foolish deal. And certainly she heard the terms—heard what Adora promised Chasm. Chasm recited it only moments before.

"Bring her to Ad.." Adora's voice cracks, and she takes a deep breath before speaking again. "Adam. Bring her to Adam. Please. So she's safe. You swore you would set her free."

And again, Chasm cannot resist. Not while she is bound to release Catra. So Chasm's hosts drag her—drag Catra—over to the edge of the circle, where Adam stands. Catra struggles the whole time, writhing against her chains, but that doesn't stop the hosts from carrying her forward.

Eventually, they drop her at Adam's feet. Not ungently, of course. Chasm can do no harm to Catra now that the deal is complete. But the hosts do not treat her particularly kindly as they lower her to the ground, then make their way back to the center of the circle.

As soon as they're several steps away, the chains around Catra's body dissipate—fading like smoke into the night air.

For a moment, Catra only stares at her wrists. Staring, like she cannot believe they are finally free after being restrained for so long. She does not move while she continues to stare.

But it does not last.

Because soon she's snarling, leaping, springing to her feet—claws unsheathed and lunging right toward Chasm's hosts.

“Catra, no!” Adam cries, wrapping both arms around Catra’s middle, trying to hold her back. And at first, he seems to succeed. She is trapped within the prison of his arms. Held there as she lurches forward, to the sides, trying but failing to break her arms from his grip.

But Catra won’t be denied, not forever.

“Let go!” she snarls, squirming, elbowing, trying to fight her way out of his grip. When she fails to find success, she resorts to a baser tactic—leaning down so that she can sink her sharp incisors into his arm.

Adam cries out and, on instinct, drops his arms. Catra springs free with a triumphant yell, then bounds forward—running on all fours at an incredible, furious speed. Seemingly ready to claw Chasm to pieces—

But Chasm is quick to trace a rune. She cannot harm Catra now, of course. Not now that the oath has been made. But Chasm can *stop* her.

A wall of pure magic springs up around Chasm, her hosts, and Adora. Catra yells as she misses her chance, beating her fists and scratching her claws across that solid wall of magic, only to have them bounce off, unable to pass through.

“Adora!” Catra screams, still pounding on the wall. “Don’t do it! Don’t you dare!”

She is talking about the next part of Chasm’s deal. Adora’s agreement to wield the sword...and act under Chasm’s orders.

Adora glances at Catra, then at Adam. Their eye contact is intense, lingering just a few moments too long. Chasm can’t quite decipher it. Perhaps Adora is pleading for Adam to come get Catra? Pleading for him to restrain her before she hurts herself against that wall?

And Chasm won't be responsible if Catra does that—if Catra shatters her bones in the futile hope of reaching Adora on the other side. She won't have Catra interfere. Not now. Not when Chasm is so close to winning. Winning *completely.* So much of what she wants will be achieved in one fell swoop. Power. Protection. Revenge. All of it will be hers, so long as Adora picks up that sword and activates it.

Chasm's suspicions are proven right when Adam strides forward, wrapping both arms around Catra yet again. His hold is tighter this time, his fingers latched together. Catra can't break it. No matter how she tries—and certainly she *tries*, she fights as hard as she can—she can't wriggle free. No matter how she bites and scratches and screams, Adam does not let go.

"It's okay, Catra," Adam says to her, over and over. "It's okay. Really, I promise."

"No! Stop!" Catra cries. Sobs, really, with tears streaming down her cheeks, legs kicking out from under Adam's grip. "We can't let her do this! It's not worth it, please, *Adora!*"

Her voice is scraped raw in its desperation. She is screaming at the top of her lungs, so desperate is she to prevent Chasm from gaining control of Adora.

"What next?" Adora asks, quietly. Whispering the words to Chasm.

Chasm smirks, still watching Catra struggle. "Next...you accept your role as the new She-Ra. *My* She-ra."

"*No!"* Catra bellows, still struggling from the other side of that wall. "Adora, *please*—"

But it doesn't change Adora's mind.

Calmly, Adora asks, "What do I do?"

"Lift the sword," says Chasm. "And I will give you new words to say."

Adora nods, then does as she's asked. With a shaking hand, she lifts the sword into the air, pointing the gleaming sword-tip toward the star-strewn sky.

"Say this," Chasm orders, smiling so broadly that her host's cheeks begin to hurt. "*For the Power of Chasm."*

"And that will trigger the transformation?" murmurs Adora. It's so quiet, that question. So quietthat Chasm barely hears it over the sound of Catra's screaming.

"Yes," says Chasm. "Once you say the words, your connection with the sword will be forged. And I will be given control."

Adora hesitates. Hesitates, then nods again.

Catra screams, cries, sobs.

Adam whispers meaningless assurances to her.

And then, after lifting the sword even higher, forcing Adora onto her tiptoes...she yells—

"For the Power of Chasm!"

Another bright light appears, emanating from the sword. Catra is screaming as it happens, and while it's an overwhelming addition to her host's senses, Chasm doesn't look away. Not this time. The light is bright but not bright enough to warrant that. And Chasm is too eager to see Adora transform, to see one of her greatest enemies transformed into her greatest weapons—

Chasm waits, watching the light.

She waits.

And she waits.

But even as the light dies down...even as Chasm keeps waiting, keeps watching…

Nothing happens.

Adora doesn't transform. Not even as the last of the light is extinguished. She is left standing there, same as before. No taller. No stronger. Just an unremarkable young woman holding a sword much too big for her frame.

Adora blinks and lowers the sword, twirling it in her hand.

And then, worst of all…

She smiles. She smiles at Chasm.

"B-but…" Chasm stammers, stumbling forward. Seeking to examine the sword, to see what went wrong. As soon as she is close enough to reach, she tears the sword from Adora's hand, scrutinizing every inch of its face. A simple spell reveals the runes that Chasm just cast and there's no flaws in them, none that Chasm can detect.

"The spell," Chasm breathes out. "It should have worked. I did everything right. Everything—"

"You did," says Adora, though the words hardly sound comforting. "The problem is...I just don't have a She-Ra to give you."

Chasm glances up at Adora, bewildered. What could she possibly mean by that? Of course Adora has She-Ra, She-Ra is bound to Adora—

"Which means that you're still missing a key ingredient for your little spell."

But then she sees. She sees Adora reaching for something just beneath her shirt, yanking on some sort of chain that dips just below the high neckline. She pulls. And pulls. And there, hanging from her hand—

Is an amulet. A magical amulet, one whose face is carved with, of all things, a shapeshifting spell. The same one that Chasm used

on herself while infiltrating Eternos. The one that allowed Chasm to disguise one of her hosts as Adora.

Chasm gapes. No. It can't be. There's no way that Adora thought to—

But sure enough, when she glances back at Adam, she sees him smirking there, just outside the magic wall—with an equally dumbstruck Catra freed from his embrace...and an amulet hanging from his finger, same as Adora's.

Chasm can only keep gaping as both siblings yank the amulets from their necks, dropping them upon the ground. And without those necklaces, the illusions begin to fall away. Melting like wax down a well-burnt candle. Chasm is helpless, absolutely helpless as her head swivels between the siblings, watching as Adora becomes Adam, and Adam becomes Adora.

(Though they're perfectly identical in their expressions of absolute smugness.)

"The spell may not have worked, but I did everything you instructed to complete it," says Adam. "Which means that I held up my end of the bargain. So Catra should remain safe from your magic—"

"You...*you—"* Chasm seethes, rage boiling through every part of her magical being.

"And now...to complete the second part of the deal, and free Etheria..." Adam continues, "all I need to do is wield '*the sword*.'"

He puts that last part in air quotations, much to Chasm's rage. She is prepared to attack him, to fry him where he stands with a lightning bolt of destructive magic...but she is distracted by another bright light, one in her periphery, as Adora (*the real Adora)* transforms into She-Ra.

She-Ra smiles and raises her sword, aiming it for the magic wall before her. And Chasm knows enough about She-Ra's power to

predict that it will not hold—

But she is distracted again by Adam. Adam, reaching behind himself—for something strapped to his back, beneath his shirt.

“The problem remains,” he says, as he pulls a sword from what must have been a sheathe tucked beneath his clothes. A sword that Chasm has never even seen before. Never even heard stories of. “Is that you never specified *which* sword.”

He raises his sword up. Up, as high as he can, and then yells—

“*For the Power of Grayskull*!”

There’s sound and light and sensation from all sides. With a cry, She-Ra brings down her own sword and shatters the magical wall. Adam is enveloped in some sort of glowing magical transformation.

And like the shattering of glass, Chasm feels her connection to the people on Etheria completely and utterly *break*.

Chapter End Notes

> Take comfort in the fact that this is the last time I'll torture you with a chasm-related cliffhanger.
>
> See you next week for the last installment! Remember to comment!

Chapter 29

Chapter Summary

The battle comes to a close.

Chapter Notes

Well. Here we are. At the end.

As you hopefully have noticed, there are 31 chapters now posted. 29, 30, and the epilogue. Which means that this story is now complete.

These are the last chapters I'll ever post of this saga. I meant to make a cover for this book, but I just didn't have time. Hopefully someone out there will do it in my stead.

Anyway, I really hope you enjoy, and have enjoyed. This story has been a pleasure to write, and your feedback has been an even greater pleasure to read. I'm really going to miss this story.

Please read onward for the FINALE of the chasm saga...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

As the wall breaks into a million magical shards, Adora turns to Catra and clutches her shoulders tightly.

“Catra,” is her urgent plea, hands shaking Catra just slightly. “I need you to listen. Are you listening to me?”

Catra is still wide-eyed and very obviously lost. She sways a bit in Adora’s grasp. “But you were there...and Adam—”

“We used a spell to pretend to be each other,” Adora says, trying to explain as quickly as she can. “It’s all part of the plan, but Catra...I really need you to listen to me. There’s no time.”

A glance ahead tells Adora that Chasm is screeching her outrage, already casting deadly runes in Adam's direction.

But the Sword of Power has provided him protections, as the Sorceress said it would. The sword allows Adam to essentially *cut through* Chasm's spells as they're cast at him. And his transformation is certainly...different. He is taller, more muscular, just as She-Ra is when Adora transforms. Whatever spells touch him don't seem to cause him much pain.

But still. It won't take long for Chasm to try another tactic. And if Adora wants to keep Adam from getting hurt...

Adora shakes Catra again and, finally, Catra's eyes seem to focus. There's still a bruise there, on Catra's forehead. One that probably indicates a concussion, so Adora can't really blame her for any trouble concentrating. But at least she's looking at Adora properly now.

"Chasm can't do anything to hurt you," Adora says. "Not now that she's made the deal. Which means you're my ace in the hole, okay? You can hurt her as much as you want, and she can't hurt you—"

Catra's lip quivers. She grasps at Adora's arms. "I-I thought I was going to lose you, Adora—"

"I know," Adora says. "And I'm sorry. But this was the only way to trick her. Now...do you feel up to fighting her?"

Catra nods, but in an imbalanced way that Adora doesn't quite trust. And Adora knows she shouldn't do this...she shouldn't waste any energy that she might need to overcome Chasm. But she can't leave Catra unhealed when such a terrible injury is *right there*, staring Adora in the face.

So Adora closes her eyes and imagines. She imagines Catra's bruise healing, fading from her skin. She imagines Catra's head clearing, her focus returning.

And Adora summons it. Her healing magic, the one that sits so deep inside of herself. She allows it to spread to Catra through her arms and travel up, up, *up*. To Catra's forehead and the injury beneath it.

When Adora opens her eyes, the bruise is gone, and Catra is rubbing at the skin where it once sat. A marrow-deep exhaustion settles within Adora's spine now that the healing magic is complete, but she elects to ignore it.

"How are you feeling now?" Adora asks.

"Ready to kick her ass," says Catra, with a smirk.

"Good," says Adora. "Because I need you to kill her hosts. Do whatever you need to, just get it done."

"Wait." Catra raises an eyebrow. "Do you actually have a plan to defeat her? Like...defeat her for good?"

Adora smiles. "I do. But you need to kill her hosts first—and keep her busy while I go for the sword."

Catra chuckles. "I think I can manage that."

"Good," says Adora, and leans down to press a kiss to Catra's forehead. But Adora is somewhat startled when Catra grabs her by the shirt and transforms the intended forehead peck into a real kiss, one with their lips fully connected and Catra's arms wound around Adora's neck.

Adora is forced to break to kiss, much to her own displeasure. It's not that she wants to, not at all. But there just isn't time—

"Sorry," Catra says sheepishly as she's forced to release Adora. "It's just…" She shrugs. "You're really hot when you're coming up with plans and stuff."

Adora laughs. "Am I?"

“Oh yeah,” says Catra, with a wink. “The hottest.”

But then she’s off, running to join Adam in the fight against Chasm’s hosts. And it’s something miraculous, the way Chasm’s spells simply *cease* to work when they come within the vicinity of Catra’s body. Such is the binding nature of the oath Chasm made.

Chasm releases a cry of frustration as one particularly deadly looking spell utterly *fails* on delivery, dissolving as it comes too close to Catra. Too close to touching her, harming her, which Chasm’s oath cannot allow her to do—

Adora takes Chasm’s distraction as her window of opportunity. Still transformed into She-Ra, she sprints forward—toward the host still holding the Sword of Protection. It’s a perfect sort of irony when Adora outstretches her sword, the *true* sword of She-Ra, and thrusts it into the host’s back from behind.

The Sword of Protection falls from their hand with a clatter.

Adora wastes no time, stifling her fear at the sight of that weapon —that sword. The Sword of Protection. She remembers when the sword nearly destroyed the universe, and almost used Adora to do it. She remembers how Mara *died* to keep this sword from falling into another pair of hands.

This sword killed Mara. Manipulated Adora. And nearly destroyed Etheria.

But maybe...maybe Adora can use it to *save* lives, rather than destroy them. Maybe the lives it saves can even include her own.

So instead of letting the fear paralyze her, she scoops the Sword of Protection from the ground and allows her *other* sword to dissolve within the now-dead host’s body. It will only slow Adora down to carry multiple swords at once.

One host down. Three more to go.

And then, of course, there’s Adora herself.

Sword of Protection in hand, she climbs the dais and drops the sword back onto the stone table—where it originally sat. Chasm roars from somewhere in the distance, and Adora summons a shield just as a wave of pure *fire* is sent Adora's way, conjured by one of Chasm's spells. She's left unharmed, thankfully—the flames parting around her shield like they're nothing. But if Adora had failed to react quickly enough—

"Hey!" yells Catra. "Leave her alone!"

And then Catra is lunging at the host that attacked Adora—leaping at them with extended claws. The fire stops instantly as Catra jumps into the flames' path. Which leaves them defenseless as Catra's nails make vicious contact, clawing deep into the host's throat, and Adora doesn't need to watch to know that the host won't recover from that injury.

Two hosts down. Two more to go.

Adora summons her sword again. Her real sword. And then, just as quickly, she transforms it into a lasso. With a twirl and flick of her wrist, she sends it rotating toward one of the remaining hosts. They try to fend it off, of course—firing magical bombardments at it. But Adora's magical weapons are largely indestructible.

They find themselves bound and trapped beneath that lasso as Adora pulls the rope taut. The force of her tug pulls the host off their feet with a breathless *oof*.

But now the other host is turned to Adora, hissing curses as Chasm fires spells in Adora's direction. Ice spells, fire spells, spells that conjure sharp shards of metal. And it's difficult for Adora to hold a lasso *and* a shield against such an onslaught.

"Adam!" Adora calls to her brother, who has now found himself without anyone to fight. "Take her out!"

Adam stares, wide-eyed, at the host on the floor. The one bound by Adora's lasso. She jerks her head, urging for Adam to attack—

"B-but…" he stammers. "I've never killed anyone before—"

"You're not killing anyone," Adora calls back, through gritted teeth. The free host is only increasing her attacks, firing spells at Adora with mounting fury. And Adora cannot fight back properly, not while holding the shield. "The hosts are already dead—"

But Adam still hesitates. Unsure what to do.

Luckily, Catra acts when he fails to.

"I got it!" she calls, and leaps from the dead body of one host to the still living, trapped body of another.

Though they are only still living for a few minutes more, thanks to Catra.

Adora is finally able to release the lasso, devoting her full strength to the shield instead.

"I'm sorry," Adam yells to Adora, but Adora doesn't blame him. It's a hard thing to accept—this idea that they're not *really* killing anybody when taking out Chasm's hosts. She understands why he might struggle with it, especially when he's so unaccustomed to violence in general.

But then, as if trying to make up for it, he barrels toward that last host—sword extended. He gives a battle cry as he goes, swiping almost blindly at the host. It's a dangerous move, Adora can see that before *it* happens.

It being the tongue of pure fire that Chasm sends in his direction. He tries to swipe his sword through it, just as he has before...but this quantity of fire is far too great to be fully avoided. It licks across his arms, his shoulders, his legs, setting his clothes alight. And Adam screams as it burns across his skin, dropping to the ground to stifle the flames.

"Adam!" Adora screams, stepping forward. Prepared to intervene, *save* him—

“Don’t!” yells Catra, to Adora. “I’ve got this! You do whatever it is you need to do.”

And then Catra is sprinting to the spot directly in front of Adam, shielding him with both arms outstretched. Chasm releases a truly vicious snarl as her magic fails yet again—unable to continue its attack with Catra in its way.

Catra is all smiles as she lunges forward, prepared for one final attack—

And Adora is relieved to see Adam alright, after a few moments. Breathing, staggering to his feet. Readying himself to help Catra despite his injuries. And Adora notes that, for someone supposedly so selfish and childish, he is displaying quite a lot of bravery. To fight with so little experience against such a terrifying adversary—

But he’s doing it. And doing it well, side-by-side with Catra.

And Adora wills herself to pull her attention away. She needs to do the next part. She needs to recast Chasm’s spell, change the runes so that it does what *Adora* wants, instead of what Chasm intended—

It’s not easy for Adora to do magic like this—magic from runes, rather than her sword. She remembers the first time she did, at Glimmer’s encouragement. That was a simple spell. One meant to change the color of a shirt, but somehow resulted in the shirt bursting into flames.

Glimmer said that the fire resulted from Adora drawing the wrong rune. Drawing an incineration spell, instead of a color-change one.

Adora cannot afford such a mistake now. This spell must be perfect, absolutely perfect. If it goes wrong, if she draws the wrong thing...she may end up trapping She-Ra in the sword, rather than Chasm.

So she lets her transformation fall away...and then lets the world outside fade to nothing. Nothing except the tracing of her finger over the surface of that sword. Only vaguely is she aware of Catra attacking the final host. They seem to be putting up a fight—trying to trap Catra in all sorts of non-lethal prisons—only for a limping Adam to break through those prisons with his magic sword, cutting through them like they're nothing at all.

But Adora ignores it. She ignores it all. Instead, she traces the runes she memorized. She does not need to do the whole spell, thankfully. Chasm repaired the sword, outfitted it as a runestone. The only thing left to do is bind a magical entity to it. The *right* magical entity, controlled by the *right* person.

She traces. Traces and traces. The sword begins to glow again as she does. Brighter and brighter does it glow, but Adora will not look away. She traces those familiar runes, spilling them across the sword's face like it's a canvas, and she is the master painter. She outlines every necessary stroke, swerves every curve, pokes every needed dot.

"What are you—" she hears Chasm's last host gasp, glancing at Adora from over their shoulder—eyes drawn by the bright light. Though she can't look for long. Not before Catra swipes a truly bone-shattering punch across the host's jaw, one that sends them reeling and stumbling backward.

Adora smiles at the sight, but only briefly. She needs to focus. She needs to finish this.

Now that the sword is ready to be bound, Adora grasps the hilt and begins to draw runes across the back of her own hand. It is difficult to be steady while doing this, especially with Adora's own hands trembling so uncontrollably. But still she manages. She traces the runes from the fingernail, to the back of the palm, to the wrist. Then higher still, to the forearm, to the biceps, to the shoulder. A curve, and then more runes. A set of them running from Adora's shoulder to the center of her chest.

And then, with one last spiral, one last line, Adora is ready to say the words.

"I call upon the entity known as Chasm," Adora calls out, loud as she can. Because she wants Chasm to know. She wants Chasm to know what she's doing, and how Chasm will *lose* because of it. "The one who shares this form alongside me."

And Chasm does hear. The remaining host's eyes widen comically, all blood draining from their face. "You wouldn't—" Chasm's host gasps, staggering forward. Staggering to her host's feet. "There's no way. My bond is unbreakable—"

"I *reject* my role as her host," Adora continues, undeterred. She makes full eye contact with Chasm as she utters the words. Staring as Chasm stares back. And that's the mistake Chasm makes. She's looking at Adora, and not at Catra.

Catra...whose claws are at the ready.

The last host doesn't see it coming when Catra delivers the killing blow. Catra takes great relish in it, yelling triumphantly as she does so.

And Adora finds the bravery to crack a smile, even if this last part fails. Even if Chasm is right.

"And cast her from my body," Adora breathes out, "into the ether."

And that's when Adora senses it...the stretching of what feels like...she doesn't know. Some cord deep inside herself. A chain of metal, maybe. Something that is trying to break, but can't quite manage to. It's trying, it's trying so hard to break. But it just can't. Not without help—

Chasm. Adora knows that it's the magic tying her to Chasm, trying to dissolve. Dissolve, despite the way that Chasm seeks to hold it in place. And Chasm is desperate, certainly. Adora can feel it. She can feel the way that Chasm layers what feels like steel onto the connection, trying to secure it, solidify it against Adora's straining.

Adora is Chasm's last host on this plane, after all. Catra is immune. The Etherians are freed. The Eternians are protected. Adora is all she has left. And while Chasm may someday find a host in some unsuspecting traveler, it's not the same as having a body right now. Eyes with which to see, hands with which to feel —

But Adora refuses it. Chasm will not have Adora's body. Not in any way, shape, or form. Chasm is going to leave. Chasm is going to *lose*. She's not going to have any body ever again, as she deserves—

So Adora reaches deep inside herself. Deeper than the magic she uses to fight. Deeper than the magic she uses to heal. She finds something at her absolute core, something that burns hot as a star, maybe even hotter, and uses it to melt that connection down. Melt it to nothing, burning it to liquid metal and ash.

But Chasm is fast. She can hear Chasm screaming, somehow. Screaming as she frantically rebuilds the broken links. And she's so fast, so powerful, Adora cannot melt the chain fast enough. It's almost entirely repaired now, and Adora is helpless, tired. She just wants to sink to her knees—

I'm not strong enough, Adora thinks. *I'm still not strong enough to break free of her*.

But no. She is. She *is*. Adora is She-Ra. And not just She-Ra's host. But *bound* to She-Ra. Adora is She-Ra, and She-Ra is Adora —two parts of a whole. And She-Ra is more powerful than Chasm. That's the whole reason why, isn't it? That's why Chasm wanted to control her. Because She-Ra is all the power that Chasm will never have—

And She-Ra's power isn't separate. It's Adora's power, made visible, made stronger. It's Adora's to take, to *use*.

So she does. She reaches even deeper. Even deeper than she ever imagined. And within herself, she finds something even warmer.

Something even brighter. It is hot beyond description, hotter than a star and six times as destructive. But it's also something good, Adora knows. Something that feels as creative as it does destructive. It's everything Adora's ever cared about, everything she's ever loved, concentrated into a pocket of pure fire, of pure magic within herself. It's her love for Catra and Glimmer and Bow and Etheria itself—

Adora's knees buckle as she pulls that magic from deep within herself, a hoarse cry tearing itself from her throat as she falls. It's hard. It's *so* hard tearing that magic from a place so deep. And there's a voice—Catra's—calling Adora's name. The voice of the person Adora loves most.

Adora holds onto that sound, uses it to buoy the magic up, into the higher planes of herself. Where the connection still sits, solid as ever. Where it needs to be, if she's to love and be with Catra like she wants to.

Somehow, she maintains a grasp on the sword, having dragged it down with herself as she met the ground. Her grip on it is an anchor as she lets that terrible but wonderful magic fill her body. And in her mind, she imagines that she's letting it incinerate *everything* within her body except herself. The chain of Chasm's connection. The self-doubt and the grief and the fear.

Because those aren't parts of her, not really. They're just infections. Just things to remove.

And remove them, she will.

I am stronger, she tells Chasm, within her mind. *I am stronger than you, stronger than anything you could ever do to me—*

And finally, in the face of such strong magic, such unconquerable magic, Adora starts to feel it. She feels the chain start to dissolve faster than Chasm can rebuild it. And Chasm is screaming, of course. Screaming and shrieking her displeasure, her outrage. But it doesn't stop Adora. It doesn't even scare her.

It’s almost there. Almost dissolved, that chain—

And then, finally, the link breaks. Breaks, completely. Dissolving into nothing as Chasm gives one last shriek. A shriek of fear. A shriek of defeat.

Exhaustion drops onto Adora with immeasurable gravity. Unconsciousness is coming for her, she can feel it even as Catra runs toward her, calling her name. But she can’t let it take her. Not yet. Not until this is finished.

Adora holds on to wakefulness just long enough to complete the final stroke of the spell—a glowing line that runs from Adora’s chest, along her arm, over her finger, and back to the gem at the sword’s hilt. The path that Chasm will follow, when she is thrust from Adora’s body.

The sword glows. A signal of the spell’s completeness. Of Chasm’s defeat. Of her entrapment within the sword.

And as the sword grows brighter, Adora’s vision grows darker. Darker, darker, until there’s nothing at all. Until Adora drops into a sleep so deep and dreamless, it reminds her of *Essence of Oblivion.*

Chapter End Notes

Finally, Adora gets some sleep!

Chapter 30

Chapter Summary

The end.

Adora wakes to the soft rumble of Catra's purring. It is, and continues to be, one of the best sounds Adora has ever heard. Adora shifts in her half-slumber, pulling herself closer to the sound. As close as she can, practically trying to bury herself in it.

She's so warm. So warm, and so comfortable—nestled into the soft bedding and pleasant heat of Catra's body, curled against hers. A part of her feels as though it should wake fully, open her eyes...but another part keeps her eyelids determinedly closed, dragged down by an impossibly heavy weight.

"Hey, princess," Catra murmurs, and Adora feels fingers brush across her cheeks. "How are you feeling?"

"M'tired," she mumbles in reply. And that's all she can manage to say.

"Okay," Catra says. "Go back to sleep for a little longer, then."

"Stay?" Adora murmurs, grasping tight to what Adora assumes is the fabric of Catra's shirt.

"Of course," says Catra, and Adora feels lips brush against her forehead. "For as long as you want me to."

Adora hums in contentment, then allows sleep...deep, dreamless sleep...to claim her again.

There are other brief moments of consciousness. Flashes of colors, murmurings of voices. Catra's, most notably. But a few others on occasion. She remembers being coaxed to sit

somewhere at a certain point, then carried back to bed. She remembers being asked a question but being unable to muster her voice to speak beyond a questioning groan.

But always, she slumps back beneath the covers. Her eyes just won't stay open. And Catra is always there, beside her. Whispering that she loves Adora into Adora's ear. And that's really all Adora wants, all she needs. Because for the first time in a long while, Adora feels safe. Feels like she can sleep without the risk of a nightmare to frighten her. Or something even worse.

And she's right, on that front. For the first time in a long while...she is right to consider herself safe.

She hardly remembers the many times she wakes. Because, in the end, each instance is blanketed by an exhaustion far more powerful than memory, and she lets herself get buried beneath it.

Adora never thought it'd feel so good to be buried. She had always dreaded being buried, in the past. Buried after some heroic sacrifice, buried beneath an enemy's heel after a crushing defeat.

But this is a different kind of *buried* . The kind that promises a beginning, rather than an end. The rest before a sun-soaked dawn.

When Adora wakes next, wakes for real, it's to the flushing of a toilet.

Her whole body feels cold. Cold, and uncovered. Blindly, she reaches for Catra beside her on the bed, but all she finds is lukewarm mattress and scattered sheets. An empty bed, uncluttered of any body but Adora's own.

A childish part of her resents Catra's absence, remembering that Catra said she would *stay* , not that long ago. Back when Adora last hoisted herself from the cemetery of deep sleep.

But a part of her realizes, slowly, that the flushing of the toilet, as well as the running of the sink, is probably evidence that Catra had good reason to leave and will be returning shortly.

This time, her eyes squint open. As she glances around, she is greeted by the sight of a largely dark bedroom. Not a familiar one, really. Though not an entirely unfamiliar one either. It's the room that Adora and Catra were given in the Eternian royal palace, same as she left it.

The same as she left it...save a stack of dirty trays on the nightstand, trays that Adora *guesses* once carried food.

The sink turns off, and the bathroom door opens. Catra is yawning and stretching as she returns to the main bedroom—though she abruptly stops when she sees Adora awake, both eyes open.

"Of course you wake up now," Catra says, with an eye roll. "Three whole days of sleep, and you choose to wake during one of the few times I go to the bathroom—"

"Three days?" Adora gasps, eyebrows shooting up in shock.

Though she's even more shocked to discover that her voice escapes as a rasp. Her throat is dry beyond belief, like the flesh within has been replaced by sandpaper. She clutches at it in fear of the sound, worried that her voice is something irrecoverable—

Only to notice that there's something *attached* to her arm. A tube embedded into the spot opposite Adora's elbow, one that travels from a packet of fluids that sits, suspended, on some sort of metal pole.

An IV. Adora has seen them often enough in wartime.

Catra notices her panic and drops back onto the bed, immediately taking Adora's hand. "Like I said," Catra continues. "You were out for three days. And we couldn't keep you awake long enough to eat or drink on a regular schedule. So…" She gestures to the IV drip. "The doctors put you on this. Just in case."

Adora pales. “I can’t believe I was out for *three days* ,” she murmurs. And it’s still frightening—how hoarse her voice is from disuse. “What happened?”

“Well, according to the Sorceress,” Catra says, “you used magic. A ton of it. More than you’ve ever used before. And after being sleep-deprived for so long on top of that...you just kinda passed out for a long while. A much-needed rest to help you restore your strength.”

Adora’s eyes feel like they’re bulging from her face.

“You weren’t comatose or anything,” Catra assures her. “I was actually able to drag you to the bathroom to do your business a few times—you’re welcome for that, by the way. I literally had to carry you.”

Adora makes a humiliated noise, her face falling into her hand. Thankfully, Catra is kind enough to continue like it’s nothing.

“So yeah. You were just tired. Really, really tired. Unable to stay awake. Not that anyone can really blame you, after everything.”

“Chasm?” Adora asks, quietly. “Is she...is she really gone?”

Catra presses her lips together. “Gone? No.”

Adora’s heart sinks down to her toes.

“But she *is* trapped,” Catra says quickly, when she notices Adora’s mounting panic. “Trapped, and unable to hurt anyone. Not to mention that all her hosts on Etheria are free, thanks to you and Adam.”

“B-but…” Adora stammers, “where?”

Wordlessly, Catra extends a pointed finger toward the desk. A desk that was once mostly-empty, save a few random trinkets of Adora’s. But now, poised across the tabletop...is a gleaming

sword. One that Adora recognizes instantly, thanks to the fear it summons within her.

The Sword of Protection. It's unmistakable with that wide-faced blade and thick hilt.

Shakily, Adora tries to stumble to her feet. It's not easy. In fact, she fails on the first try, nearly toppling to the floor thanks to legs now-unaccustomed to holding Adora's weight.

She's lucky that Catra anticipated some sort of accident. She crawled across the bed so that, when Adora began to sway, Catra was already there, arms coiled around Adora's middle to hold her upright.

"Sorry," Adora mutters, ashamed.

Laughing, Catra says, "Don't be. You've healed me so many times, it's kinda nice to play nurse for a change."

Adora leans back to plant a kiss on Catra's cheek. It takes some twisting and bending to do it, but finally her lips hit their mark, and she holds herself there for as long as she can without hurting herself. "Thank you," she says. "I really appreciate it. You know that, right?"

Catra rolls her eyes. "Of course I know that, dummy. I love you and you love me. End of story."

There's a pause that's oddly tense as Adora notices that Catra is avoiding her gaze. And then—

"Adam did tell me that, before you came up with your master plan," Catra murmurs, "you were originally going to trade She-Ra for my safety." Her eyes harden. "You do realize I would've *killed* you for that."

Adora gives a helpless shrug. “You would’ve done the same for me.”

“Yeah,” grumbles Catra, and then *truly* lifts Adora to her feet—holding her there until she’s certain of Adora’s steadiness. “We’re both annoying that way, aren’t we?”

Adora reaches out for the metal pole that suspends her IV, using it to maintain her balance as she drags it and herself forward, toward the desk. It takes far too many trembling, slow steps. But eventually, Adora staggers her way there, to the spot just beside that sword. Close enough to touch it.

She finds herself wincing as the light reflects off the blade in a certain way. She outstretches a finger as if she’s considering doing it—touching the blade, brushing the pad of her index finger over the gem at the hilt—but then retracts her hand just as quickly.

By now, she’s learned that it’s too risky to hold a sword like this one.

It looks no different than the sword did when it held She-Ra’s magic. But if Adora executed that spell correctly...if she truly expelled Chasm from her body—

The sword should hold an entirely different form of magic now.

“And is she really in there?” Adora whispers, her eyes tracing the length of the sword over and over again. “Chasm?”

Her head swivels around to see Catra nodding.

“According to the Sorceress, she is, in fact, bound to the Sword,” Catra tells her. A smirk quirks the corner of her mouth. “She checked. Your plan worked. So long as she’s bound to that sword, she can’t infect anyone else.”

“But she’s not gone,” Adora says.

"No," says Catra. "She's not gone. The Sorceress says she'll never be *truly* gone. She can just be...imprisoned for a bit. But hopefully this prison lasts even longer than the last."

"And I'm guessing destroying the sword will just set her free?" Adora says, speaking from her own experience with She-Ra.

Again, Catra nods. "Best we can do is hide it somewhere and hope that no one ever stumbles on it."

"Well," says Adora, turning briefly back to the sword. "I'm hoping it will take a bit more than that for Chasm to wriggle free of it. Chasm's spell would've given her control of She-Ra. But when I cast *my* spell...I changed it. Reversed it."

A moment passes as Catra processes that. A moment before Catra hums, and says, "So now She-Ra would control Chasm, if the sword were ever used?"

Adora gives a nod of her own. "No one can use the sword without She-Ra's permission. Me, right now. Or a future She-Ra. The sword will only activate when I say so."

Catra chuckles. "I'm sure that drives her nuts—the fact that you control her now, rather than the other way around."

Adora shrugs. "I don't really want control of her, to be honest. But if I'm the only one who can keep her from wreaking havoc again —" Another shrug. "I'll do what I have to."

"So if you did, for some reason, want Chasm free…" Catra says, after a pause. "How would that even work?"

"Well, I suppose the first option is for me to break the sword," Adora says. "Just like you said. That's something only She-Ra can really do. A sword like this is magically protected against most destructive forces. It can't be melted down or broken by just anyone. But, of course, She-Ra's strength…" Adora shoots Catra a small smile. "It's different. It's a bit of an exception to most rules."

“And the other option?” Catra asks. Her curiosity is genuine. Genuine, but also morbid.

Though Adora can’t blame her. Catra likes to have all the facts—likes to be aware of every contingency. If something goes wrong, if Chasm has even a chance of escaping, Catra must know how it’s possible. And through that knowledge, she’ll plan. Plan ways to keep Chasm imprisoned at all costs, strategize to keep the sword intact and out of dangerous hands.

“The other option is that I give the sword to a chosen wielder,” Adora says. “And they have to accept. If that happens, Chasm will infect the body of the wielder. But only them. That’s a small consolation, at least.”

“And it’s the same process for them as it was for you?” Catra asks. “You have to raise the sword, say the magic words, and bam—” She mimes a small explosion with her fingers. “They’re Chasm’s new host?”

“Well, not exactly,” says Adora. Sheepishly, she adds, “I changed the magic words a bit. It’s my sword now, so I figured...well...that I should make it specific to me.” She snorts. “And maybe piss Chasm off in the process. I’m sure she won’t like them very much. They’re too mushy.”

“And what are they?” Catra says. “The new words?”

Adora turns to Catra, unable to help the way her features soften—eyebrows scrunching together and her eyelids falling low. It’s something unbelievable that they’re both here now, largely intact. Safe. Healthy. Free from Chasm’s control.

And not just that...but Etheria should be free now too. All of Adora’s friends back home should be able to sleep without worry, now that Chasm is gone. They’re safe. Bow, the princesses, Sea Hawk, Melog, *everyone* —

Because somehow, Adora managed to do it. She managed to keep Chasm from destroying the things that Adora loves. Catra,

Etheria…

Even Adora herself.

"For the Love of Etheria," Adora murmurs, just loud enough for Catra to hear. Her eyes are affixed to Catra's face, drinking in the sight. Imagining how it will feel to go back home, to wake up in Bright Moon next to Catra every morning, just as she's always wanted to. "Those are the words. Those are the words I choose."

Silence conquers the room for several long moments. It hangs there, contemplative rather than awkward, before Catra finally speaks—shattering the silence with a voice that dances with laughter.

"Wow," she says, with an enormous eye roll. "You really are *such* a cheeseball—"

"Shut up," Adora complains, not really meaning it, and hobbles her way back to the bed. The IV drags behind her, tugging at her skin. "Now help me get this thing out of my arm so I can get some real food—"

Catra doesn't argue, extending her hands toward Adora's arm, awaiting it within her grasp. As soon as Adora places it there, Catra begins the careful process of removing gauze and the catheter, muttering, "As you command, oh mighty She-Ra. Slayer of Horde Prime and Chasm—"

Adora snorts and ignores the pinch of the needle as it's pulled from her arm.

Finding food isn't an easy feat. It's not a normal mealtime, so Adora and Catra cannot visit the usual dining room to acquire something to snack on.

And, of course, Adora isn't too keen to share a room, or a meal, with the King and Queen again. Not after their last argument.

"I'm surprised they didn't kick us out," Adora tells Catra as they walk the hallways, searching for Adam's room. "I thought they would hate me after I last talked to them. Or really, *stormed past* them—"

Catra shrugs. "I think they would've been angrier if I hadn't dragged your lifeless body from the ship and yelled for a medic. For the last few days, they've been mostly focusing on making sure that you recover."

Adora scoffs, hand hovering over Adam's door before giving it a knock. "I didn't think they cared that much about my well-being."

"I don't know if they do," Catra says, folding both arms over her chest. "As much as I *hope* they do care...they could've helped you recover for an entirely different reason."

Adora lowers her knuckle onto the crystal door and knocks. "Which is?"

"Adam never would've forgiven them if they didn't," Catra says. "And I doubt they want to lose both royal kids."

And as Adam opens the door, Adora suspects that Catra is right.

"Well, look at that!" Adam exclaims with a broad smile, his eyes alight with joy. Adora doesn't quite manage to stop him before he envelopes Adora in a crushing hug, one that has her groaning and trying to wriggle free. He lifts Adora off the ground just slightly. "The sleeping princess finally awakens!"

"Yeah, yeah, I'm awake," Adora complains. "Now put me down!"

The Eternian royal kitchens don't really compare to the ones back inBright Moon, but Adora won't be picky. Not when she's *this* hungry.

Apparently Adora hasn't eaten solid food in three whole days, and it can be easily seen in Adora's ravenous appetite as Adora scarfs down pastries, fruits, vegetables, and whatever else she can get her hands on. Her appetite especially feels much more restored now that she's slept enough to calm her once-churning stomach.

"I haven't seen you eat like this since our honeymoon," Catra jokes.

"I haven't seen you eat like this *ever* ," Adam grumbles. Jokingly, of course.

"On second thought," he adds, mock-gagging as Adora nearly swallows some sort of small pit fruit whole. "Maybe I don't want to be related to you."

Adora gives him a playful shove and pulls another sweet pastry off a nearby tray, one that a very scandalized-looking cook just pulled directly from the oven. A tray that, if Adora has her way, will soon be empty. Just like any other foods within Adora's vicinity. She pops it into her mouth and, with great relish, chews open-mouthed so that Adam can see her mashed up food and grow disgusted once again.

"I never should have brought you here," Adam says, shielding her from his sight with a hand.

When Adora's through tormenting him—and sufficiently full—they congregate in the hallway just outside the kitchen to talk.

"Have our parents been giving you a hard time?" Adora asks, concerned.

He blinks like he's somewhat surprised by the question, and then, to Adora's confusion, he hunches his shoulders in what appears to be sheepishness. "Not really, actually," Adam admits. "They've been stunningly civil toward me since we returned. I think that, for once in my life, they might actually be proud of me."

Adora gives a few confused blinks of her own. “Oh.”

“I suspect they are mad at you for leading me to rebellion,” Adam continues, “and they are irate at Teela for disobeying them. But me?” His smile is bitter. “I’ve disappointed my parents my whole life. By helping defeat Chasm, I suppose their opinion of me could only improve.”

Adora hums and leans against the wall. “Yeah, that’s…” She exchanges a meaningful glance with Catra, and her eyes are just as suspicious. Just as speculating. “...interesting.”

“Adam,” Catra says, acting on those very suspicions. “I haven’t left Adora’s bedside much in recent days. Now that the fight is over...do you know where the sword went? The one the Sorceress gave you?”

Adam’s mouth falls open, shuts, then opens again. He nods like he’s trying to assure them that a risky gamble will pay off. “It’s somewhere safe,” he tells them. “Somewhere it will not be misused, I promise.”

“Adam—”

“Speaking of the Sorceress,” Adam interrupts, and the interruption is a bit too pointed for Adora’s liking. “She asked to see you, once you were awake. I suspect she wants to check that you’re alright —that Chasm didn’t leave any lasting damage.”

Adora and Catra share a nervous glance. Adora feels fine at the moment...but is there some sort of looming side effect that Adora should be worried about? One that she didn’t consider?

“She said it was important,” Adam tacks on, since he can probably see Adora’s fear and hesitation. “But I doubt it’s anything *that* serious.”

Adora gulps.

She hopes so too.

"So…" Adora asks. "Am I going to be okay?"

The Sorceress hums and steps back, examining the rune that she just finished tracing on Adora's back. Adora wishes she could see what it looks like—that rune. But according to what the Sorceress claimed, it's nothing to be worried about. A diagnostic rune of some sort, meant to gauge Adora's health, as well the levels of magic within Adora's body.

The *reason* such a rune is necessary, though…

That might warrant some concern.

The fact is...Adora was forced to use an immense amount of magic to break Chasm's connection. More magic than she has ever used in the past. Or maybe even collectively throughout her life. And while She-Ra has a great deal of magic at her disposal thanks to the leftovers from the Heart of Etheria...there are limits to even that power.

Before Adora actually executed the binding spell...before she actually *thrust* Chasm from her body...the Sorceress had no idea whether Adora would succeed. Never before had anyone pulled free of Chasm's infection while Chasm was at full power.

And now that Adora has accomplished such a feat, the Sorceress is curious about the aftereffects. Curious...and worried. To pull that magic from oneself at once...it cannot be without its costs. Even Adora knows that.

"Your magic is greatly depleted," the Sorceress says, as though the rune has broadcasted those words to her. "That much is true, but not unexpected."

"But is *Adora* okay?" Catra interrupts, impatient.

She stands in Adora's periphery, facing the Sorceress as she conducts her examination. She's in her *protective* mode, hand

curled tight around Adora's—as though their fingers are links in a chain that refuses to be pulled apart.

"Because, really, we can deal with the magic stuff later," Catra continues, grumbling. "Our main concern is whether there's going to be a impact on her health—"

The Sorceress grunts in annoyance. "I would have mentioned if her health was impacted. As far as I can tell, Adora is quite intact—save the effects of long-term sleep deprivation. Effects that you are already recovering from, thanks to recent days of rest."

And Adora can't disagree. She feels fine, physically. She supposes she's still a little tired, but that's to be expected after all those days of sleeplessness and rest. So unlike Catra...Adora is a bit more concerned by the state of her magic.

"So if my magic's depleted, like you say," Adora begins, "Does that mean I can't turn into She-Ra anymore?"

The Sorceress makes a contemplative noise. "I doubt that," she says. "But you may not be able to do so immediately."

"Meaning?"

"She-Ra's magic will recover itself, with time. She is a *regenerative* magic. The embodiment of healing and power. But it may be a slow process. Which means that if you attempt the transformation at this very moment...I imagine it will be something of a struggle."

"How long until I'm able to transform again?" Adora demands.

"I can't say," replies the Sorceress. "Weeks, perhaps."

"So in a few weeks I'll be back to normal?"

Adora cranes her neck to glimpse the Sorceress's face. Her expression is solemn...and her head swings from side to side.

Hardly a good sign.

"I did not say that," the Sorceress sighs. "I said you would be able to transform. Perhaps even summon a weapon. But when you do manage a full transformation...I suspect that She-Ra's strength will be greatly diminished. It might be many months before she is at full strength. And your healing ability...that could very well take years to return. Perhaps you could attend to small injuries sooner than that but—"

Adora exhales sharply. "I can't heal at all?"

"She-Ra's healing ability is borne of pure, concentrated magic. But you don't have sufficient magic to concentrate at the moment, and you may not for a long time. So yes. You will be unable to heal for the near future."

"Well, how do I…" Adora searches helplessly for the right words. "I don't know. Absorb magic faster—"

"She-Ra's magic comes from the opposite sources that Chasm's does," the Sorceress says. "Rather than fear and misery, She-Ra's power comes from love, joy, and hope. And, as Etheria's protector...she draws power from the planet itself. So if you surround yourself with those things, and refrain from using magic excessively...perhaps She-Ra's full abilities will return at a faster pace."

Slowly, Adora processes the words. "So what you're saying is…"

"We should go home," Catra interrupts, smirking a bit in disbelief. "Go home, and relax. Let Etheria and married life heal you up. And stop transforming into She-Ra unless you absolutely have to."

Again, Adora cranes her neck—only to see the Sorceress nodding.

"B-but—" Adora stammers. "What if people *need* She-Ra?"

“They’ll have to figure out their own problems for a change,” is Catra’s dismissive—and smug—response. She places her free hand on Adora’s shoulder. “Besides, we just took down one big bad. Hopefully it’ll be a long time before we’re forced to face another one.”

“What are we even going to do, though?” Adora asks. “Planets call for our help all the time. And I…if I can’t be She-Ra for Etheria-knows-how-long...If I don’t have anything to offer—”

Catra gives Adora’s hand an encouraging squeeze. “Whatever we want, dummy. That’s what we’ll do.”

“But I can’t—”

“Relax to save your life?” Catra finishes for her. “Yeah, I know.”

Adora feels the Sorceress swipe through the rune at Adora’s back, effectively dissolving it. She is probably fine to stand and leave now...but Adora cannot stop panicking. There’s no telling whether an intergalactic disaster will break out in the coming days. What if She-Ra’s aid is needed for that? Or worse...if Adora stops being She-Ra for an extended period of time...will the rest of the universe and Etheria start to resent her? For doing nothing, for resting on her laurels from past battles rather than helping those in need—

But Catra must see the fear building in Adora’s eyes. She moves her hand from Adora’s shoulder to the spot just beneath Adora’s chin.

“You don’t need to offer anyone *anything* , okay?” Catra says seriously, guiding Adora’s gaze directly into her own. “You don’t need to be She-Ra to matter. Especially to me.”

Adora gulps. Then forces herself to nod. Catra is right. Adora doesn’t owe any part of herself to the rest of the universe. She needs to remember that. If anything, Catra will be happy to find Adora free of the added responsibility. And shouldn’t Adora be happy too…?

I don't need to be She-Ra to matter .

That's what she tells herself, over and over again. Even as Catra helps Adora to her feet and guides her toward the tower door.

"I wish you the best in your journey home," the Sorceress says. "I suspect we will meet again. Somehow, someway. Though it may not be for a long time."

Adora simply sends a nod over her shoulder. She has no particular desire to see the Sorceress again. Adora can't quite shake her resentment for the Sorceress, especially when she remembers what Mara and Etheria went through as a result of the Sorceress's magical explorations. The Sorceress may have helped Adora defeat Chasm...but that doesn't mean that Adora forgives her.

Adora begins the long descent from Tower Grayskull, hoping to never return.

"Prince Adam! Please tell the story again!"

Adora and Catra have searched all over the palace for Adam, still certain that *something* is not right. The way he dismissed her concerns about the sword...it makes Adora nervous. Nervous that Adora's brother—her naive and reckless and perhaps too-selfless brother—may be falling into the same trap that Adora tumbled into, once upon a time.

"Alright, alright," comes Adam's laughing voice. "One more time. Then I really must retire to my quarters—"

Adora and Catra finally find him in the throne room, of all places. A place where Adam has never lounged before—not as far as Adora has seen during her short time in Eternos. Not that Adora can really *see* Adam at the moment. Judging by the direction of his voice, he must be somewhere near the thrones themselves, but the crowd blocks her line of sight to him.

And that's the most startling fact. That the throne room is actually populated with people. The hall is near-bursting with Eternian nobles and guards, all of whom are milling about, staring straight ahead. Watching and listening to someone. Adora assumes it's Adam that they're listening to, but she can't really be sure.

"It began at the ball," Adam recounts, each word booming with theatricality. "We were all unsuspecting, ready for a night of drinks and food and celebration. Little did we know that a threat was walking among us, wearing the clothes and the faces of our people—"

Adora has always figured that the throne room was an eternally empty place. When Adora first arrived in Eternos, the throne room's doors opened with such an enormous creak, it seemed to Adora that the royal family did not entertain guests very often. But perhaps, with Adora's recent return and Adam's recent heroism, that fact has changed.

Adora must shove her way through the crowd, Catra hot on her heels. No members of the crowd spare her a glance. And they don't seem too keen to let her through, not when they're so enthralled to hear what Adam is saying.

Adora suddenly wishes for the power of She-Ra to return to her. This would be so much easier if she could transform. With She-Ra's immense height, Adam would be forced to look at her, and the crowd would surely part around her.

But right now, Adora is simply Adora. And she must find a way to reach Adam by herself, without magic's aid.

"The monster laid careful plans to steal from us. To steal the princess, to steal She-Ra's power, to steal our knowledge from the Sorceress. And until we intervened, it seemed she would succeed, killing all who stood in her way—"

Adora finally elbows her way to the front row, pushing between bodies like a corpse crawling out from a grave. She is ready to call Adam's name, to demand a moment alone with him, but is rendered speechless by what she sees.

"Shit," says Catra, beside Adora. She is likely just as stunned by his appearance—and his behavior.

It is Adam, yes, but not the Adam she is accustomed to. The Sword of Power is grasped in one hand, swinging and pointing with every word of his story. And Adam...Adam is very clearly transformed. He is muscular and taller beyond belief, as tall and muscular as She-Ra, his skin shimmering with residual magic.

Adam is standing with one leg upon his throne, the other stomped upon the ground. A hero's pose. Adora knows it well because she used it often, in the past. Back before she knew what it truly means to be She-Ra.

And that thought forces Adora into action.

"Adam!" she hisses. "Adam!"

It takes several minutes for her to get his attention. The crowd is a terrible distraction, cheering and gasping at key moments in his too-long story. Their noise drowns Adora out.

"Adam!" she yells, finally growing fed up. Her voice cuts through the part of the story where Catra is taken hostage by Chasm—something that Adora certainly does not wish to relive. "Listen to me!"

He cuts off mid-word to look down at her, his eyes wide as the crowd falls utterly silent. Now that they've noticed her presence—and her identity—everyone near Adora turns to stare at her. She steals the attention in a way she does not desire, not in the least, and slides her attention back to Adam in the hope of offering an apologetic smile.

It is only then that Adora notices that Adam is not alone on that dais. Her parents are also there, sitting on their respective thrones, adorned with even finer robes and more numerous medallions than usual. Almost like they're rewarding themselves for winning the battle that Adam and Adora fought.

The King and Queen eye Adora with great distaste from where they sit. Teela's father, the Man-at-Arms, shifts into view beside them, like he intends to shield them from Adora's wrath. She supposes that caution is earned. Adora manhandled her parents quite a bit the last time she saw them.

Teela is notably absent.

"Princess Adora," the Queen snarls. "What reason do you have to interrupt your brother in this manner?"

"I…" begins Adora, unsure how to reply. She most definitely cannot tell the Queen why she is really here. Not now that the situation is so clear. The King and Queen are celebrating Adam's newfound power and heroism. They'll surely disapprove of Adora's attempts to...well…

Remove it. She wants to remove that power from Adam's grasp.

Adam's face splits into a wide, ecstatic smile. "I'm not offended, mother," Adam says, and he grasps a hand around Adora's wrist. He effortlessly tugs Adora onto the dais, forcing her to wobble and gasp as the sudden relocation leaves her searching for balance. "Adora was the real hero in this battle. She deserves to tell the story."

He smiles down at Catra and, before she can protest, tugs her up beside Adora. "As does the mighty Catra, who saved my life!"

Catra and Adora both blush profusely while facing the expectant crowd. Their postures grow stiff with discomfort as Adam shows them off, allowing the Eternians to view and admire each and every member of their team. The team that finally defeated Chasm, the first enemy to attack Eternos in a thousand years.

And it's not like the Eternians have much else to celebrate. Not when so little happens in this isolated pocket of the universe. They are rabid, absolutely rabid, for their heroes. And for any trace of power they can claim.

Adam soaks in every cheer, every starstruck stare, waving and smiling all the while. He has been so diminished, so *trampled* by the faithlessness of those around him, he must be truly unaccustomed to this—the glory of winning a fight and being celebrated in the aftermath.

It's intoxicating. Adora knows that from firsthand experience.

And it can also be poisonous.

"Adam," Adora grits out, speaking only from the corner of her mouth. "I need to talk to you."

"Yes?" says Adam, quite innocently. He is ready to have this conversation here, now, in front of this enormous audience—and in front of their parents. And of course that's something Adora cannot do. None of these people (save Catra) will approve of anything Adora has to say. And they may even try to stop her.

" *Alone* ," amends Adora. "I need to talk to you alone."

This information seems to greatly disappoint him. He glances between his crowd of fans, their parents, and Adora's face—as though weighing them against each other. "Can it wait?" he asks, likely so that he doesn't have to upset any invested party.

Adora shakes her head. "Now, Adam. Right now."

He hesitates visibly, still glancing between Adora and the crowd.

"Please," she near-begs. "This is more important than you understand."

Adam contemplates her for several moments more. Then, with a mighty sigh, he turns to the crowd.

“We shall have to finish this story tomorrow,” Adam announces, slinging his sword into his belt. His transformation falls away with the motion, rendering him shorter and far skinnier. “I must speak with my sister in private. A good night to all of you.”

Disappointed grumblings echo all across the throne room. Adora catches occasional glares directed her way—a result of Adora ruining the fun—but she pays them no heed. This is not the time for fun. Chasm may be defeated, but other dangers loom.

Just as he turns to leave, the Man-at-Arms grabs hold of Adam’s wrist and lifts it into the air.

“One last cheer for the hero of Eternos!” the Man-at-Arms shouts. “And our future king!”

There is a roar of agreement, of appreciation. Even the King and Queen clap, their eyes affixed to Adam with great pride. It’s like they’ve suddenly forgotten every doubt they’ve ever held in him, and not for the reasons that Adora—or anyone—should want.

Adora grabs Adam’s other wrist and *yanks* , breaking any other hold upon him. As she walks swifty from the room, she shoots a single glance at Catra—one that trails briefly to the King and Queen, communicating to Catra that she should keep an eye on them. If they pursue, or eavesdrop, it could spell trouble for all of them.

Catra nods in response. She’ll distract the King and Queen, if necessary.

And this is more necessary than anyone—Adam, in particular—understands. She doesn’t want him to fall for the same tricks. Doesn’t want him turned into a weapon for the First Ones to use at their leisure.

They decide to talk in Adam’s room. It’s the closest location with a lock on the door, and Adora does not wish to be overheard.

He leads her outside, to the balcony that juts out from the far wall. The balcony that overlooks the courtyard where the ball was once held. Adora is somewhat stunned to realize that she never actually *saw* the ball for herself. Chasm did that for her.

Adora supposes it is yet another Eternian tradition she will miss out on, same as all the rest. And again she is instead forced to look at the left behinds. On Etheria, those were the books and scrolls and temples that the First Ones left behind. In the case of the ball...it's the tables that have yet to be cleared away, or the sculptures yet to be demolished or relocated.

Adora supposes she can't really complain, though. She didn't want to go to the ball anyway.

"So," Adora says, leaning her elbows on the railing. "Seems like you're the most popular guy in Eternia these days."

Adam nods, blushing his embarrassment.

"The news of what happened traveled fast," Adam explains. "It's been a long time since an Eternian has defeated *anyone* . Horde Prime devastated us so thoroughly, and we've been cooped up for the years since. Once Chasm came around and killed all those guards, the people demanded retribution. Retribution that I—" He glances at Adora and corrects himself. " *We* provided. It makes sense that they want to celebrate us."

"Still. Must be a pretty big changeup," remarks Adora. "Last I checked, you were convinced that no one wanted you to be king. Now it seems like they can't wait for the day to come."

Adam clasps one hand around his other, holding it tightly. "Well. I won't lie. It is nice to be believed in, for once."

Adora hesitates for a moment before asking her next question.

"But it does make you wonder," Adora says, an eyebrow raised at him. "Do they believe in you? Or do they believe in that sword of yours?"

She reaches out and flicks the sword slung through his belt. The resulting *ping* reverberates for an unnaturally long time, causing the whole hilt to vibrate until silence once again reigns.

Adam's knuckles are stark white—a result of his fingers being clasped together too tightly. Adora just barely detects the way his arms shake, like he's crushing his hands into each other.

"Do you even want to be king, Adam?" asks Adora, voice soft and patient. At this point, even she doesn't know. All she can say with certainty is that Adam wants to help people. Everything she has learned about him has proven that fact.

And the Eternians are planning to use him. That much is clear.

Finally, Adam seems to cease the battle with himself—releasing the hold on his own hands in favor of slumped posture and eyes closed in defeat.

"I'm not sure," he admits. "Sometimes I think I do. But sometimes I think I just want to do what my parents ask of me. And do it in a way that'll make them respect me."

His eyes slide downward, toward the floor.

"But I know what I *do* want," he mumbles. "Whatever happened three days ago…" He sighs. "I want that. I want my future to look like that. I want to help save the universe from danger."

Adora exhales. She really shouldn't be surprised. Adam's finally enacted a positive change in the universe. He's helped people—Adora, Catra, Etheria, even Eternia itself. And now he can't go back. He can't go back to being helpless, meaningless, in this magical bubble.

"It's not always something fun, you know," Adora argues. "You can't save the universe without it first being in terrible danger. And you make so many enemies along the way—"

"I know."

"And the sword," Adora continues. "There's a magical entity trapped in that sword—one that never be asked to have its magic siphoned and stolen. It may just be a weapon to you, a tool to help people with. But to the entity in that sword, it's something else entirely. It's a *prison* ."

Adam nods slowly, like he couldn't be more disgusted with himself.

"I know it's selfish of me," he says. "But it's just...I can't get it out of my head. The way I felt holding that sword, fighting alongside you and Catra. Fighting to save the universe and whatever else—" He sighs and looks up at Adora pleadingly. "It just felt right. I can't explain it. It just felt *right* ."

Adora allows the words to hang for several moments as she considers them—and what to say next.

"It's selfish, yeah," Adora replies. "To want to keep the sword. But...if you do this right...it doesn't have to be."

Judging by his flashing eyes and furrowed brow, her words have only confused him. He probably expected Adora to berate him—to demand that he destroy the sword, lest she take it from him and destroy it herself.

But Adora is not going to force Adam to do anything. She has faith in Adam to do the right thing all by himself.

And besides...it's not like Adora can turn into She-Ra at the moment. She won't be destroying much of *anything* magical in the coming days, let alone a near-indestructible magic sword.

"I know what you're feeling," Adora says. "Believe me, I do. It may not be the same but...I was raised to be the next leader of the Horde, back on Etheria. It wasn't until I found the sword that I realized how evil the Horde was. I couldn't lead it. And so, suddenly… the sword became everything to me. My destiny. My identity. The sword gave me something to aspire to. I thought the sword was the thing that freed me from the Horde's control."

She shakes her head.

"But it's no good—letting a *thing* decide your destiny. Or your identity. You decide who you are. What you do. And if you let the sword decide...that's not freedom from control. That's just another flavor of it."

Adora outstretches her hand, placing it over Adam's on the railing. "I know you've never wanted to be King. I know you've felt trapped by what people say your destiny is—and given how many people have doubted you...you probably feel even more trapped by fear that you won't be able to do it. You're afraid you won't be a good king."

Adam's whole body seems to deflate in concession. An acknowledgement of the truth of what Adora has just said, accompanied by a frantic sort of nod.

"And the sword feels like a calling, doesn't it? When you use it. It makes you think you're destined to be a big hero, a savior of the universe. It makes you feel *chosen* , worthy—"

"Yes, of course it does," Adam sighs, and then gestures fiercely to himself. "How am I ever supposed to believe myself qualified to be *anything* now, compared to my parents, or Teela, or *you* ? I need to do something to prove myself, something to show that I'm capable, that I can be great—"

"Well...I'm going to let you in on a secret," Adora says. "One that I learned from experience. You ready?"

Adam stares at her, expectant. Waiting.

"A sword can't make you great," Adora says. "That's it. That's the whole truth. You want to be great? Decide to be great. You want to be capable? Practice whatever it is that you want to be capable of. Want to prove yourself? Set goals for yourself, and meet them. The sword has nothing to do with it. Nothing at all—"

"B-but," he stammers. "The sword's power—"

Adora shakes her head. “Power’s just a crutch,” she says. “But if you don’t have the inner strength to do great things, the resolve...all that power just goes to waste.” She smiles at him. “She-Ra didn’t make me a hero, in the end. What made me a hero, in the end...was my ability to love. To love my planet. My people. My friends. That was what drove me to great things. And I think that’s why She-Ra chose to come back to me, after I broke the sword. That’s why she stuck with me when she didn’t have to.”

“Sounds like you’re being too humble.”

Again, Adora shakes her head. “I’m not. It’s the truth. At the end of the day, if you want to be a hero...it’s up to you to find a reason why. It’s not a magic sword you need to find. It’s a *choice* you need to make.”

Adam hesitates. And then, tentatively, he removes his hand from Adora’s grasp.

And that’s when Adora thinks she’s lost him. That he’s just going to keep the sword despite her warnings.

But then he brings his hand to his waist, fingers momentarily hesitating above the sword slung there, through one of his belt loops. It seems to take several stalled attempts to find the resolve, but he finally secures his grasp around the hilt and pulls the whole sword loose—angling it upward toward the sun.

He twirls the sword within his grasp.

“If I destroy it,” he says, “what will happen to it?”

“The magical being within the sword will be freed,” Adora tells him. “Instead of trapped and bound, like it is now.”

“And what will it do after that?” Adam asks. “Where will it go?”

Adora shrugs. “I don’t know, exactly. Bind itself to the host of its choice.”

“Like Chasm?” Adam gasps, eyes wide.

“No,” Adora assures with a head shake. “I don’t think the entity in your sword is like her. I think it’s a being of physical power, just like She-Ra is. Which probably means it will need to join with a willing host, just like her.”

He inhales. “So does that mean...that there’s a chance, even a small one…?”

Adam looks up at Adora just as he finishes trailing off, the words fading into silence. His expression betrays a strange mixture of emotions. Hope, but also humiliation.

Adora raises both eyebrows. “You’re hoping the entity will pick you, aren’t you?”

“Is that wrong?” he asks. “To hope for it?”

“Hm,” hums Adora. “I don’t *think* so. As long as you want the power for a good reason.”

“I do,” he says, nodding vigorously. “I *do* want to help people. Just like you do. And not just to be great, or to prove a point, but to make a real difference—”

Adora smiles as she holds up a hand to stop him—silence him. “I think that’s a good enough reason,” she tells him. “And while I can’t make any promises...I think the entity in that sword would be pretty dumb not to pick you.”

He stares at her for several moments, contemplating.

And then his grip tightens on the sword.

“ *For the Power of Grayskull* ,” he whispers, right before his whole body is enveloped in a golden glow.

Within moments, he is taller, broader, more muscular than Adora is accustomed to where Adam is concerned. He is normally at the

exact same height as Adora is. But now, he towers over her, and is probably twice her width thanks to all that muscle.

She can't help but resent it a bit, especially now that Adora will be unable to transform into She-Ra for so long. She'll very much miss her ability to tower over others in the way Adam now towers over her. Not, of course, that Adora *likes* to look down on people. Eight feet of height is simply more awe-inspiring.

And Adora is certainly awestruck now, having to crane her neck to look at Adam above her.

"If you do end up the host for this thing," Adora says. "I could probably use your help. It might be a long time before I'm able to be She-Ra again, thanks to all the magic I used while severing Chasm's connection. Maybe you could be She-Ra's stand-in in the meantime, if that's what you want."

"Does that mean…" His eyes grow wide. "You want me to come with you?"

Adora gives another shrug. "I mean. You keep saying you want out of this place. And we *do* have two spaceships that need to be flown back to Etheria, and Catra and I would rather not split up for the flight back."

"And you're certain?" Adam presses. "You really want me to come with you?"

"Well, yes," Adora says. "If you want." She rubs the back of her neck. "You're really the only family I want to keep. And I'd rather not have to come back here to visit you."

Adam gapes at her for a moment.

And then, before she can react, he is sweeping her into yet another crushing hug. Though this one is spinning. Spinning quickly and forcefully enough that Adora must swallow some degree of nausea. And his grip on her is so tight, he clearly must not properly understand his strength in this form—

He is laughing. Laughing giddily, and irrepressibly. And while it's a contagious sort of laughter, Adora's ribs are *really* starting to bruise. She is forced to wriggle her way out, worming her way beneath Adam's arms and dropping onto the ground below.

"Thank you!" he beams. "I don't know what to say—"

"I mean, don't thank me yet," Adora says. "Our parents probably won't be too keen on the idea."

"They'll have to be!" Adam says. "Who better to train me to be a magical hero than you?"

"Well. That might not be true," Adora cautions. "You might just have to be a *regular* hero, if the entity picks someone else." She smiles encouragingly, nonetheless. "But I think destroying that sword is a good first step to becoming a regular hero, anyway."

And Adam is again studying the sword in his grasp.

"And there's really no way to know for sure?" Adam asks, clutching the hilt in both hands. "There's no way to guarantee that it'll be me?"

Adora shakes her head once more. "That's just not how it works. But...I *promise* that it's better this way. It's better if the bond goes both ways—if the entity chooses you, and you choose it back. It'll be a part of you, rather than something you carry. "

Adam nods. Nods, like he understands. Over and over again he nods, breathing deeply as though preparing himself.

And then, with a grunt, he raises the sword high above his head—

—then brings it down, shattering the blade against the crystal floor of the patio. It *smashes* into a thousand shards and a thousand rays of light, each of them bright and sharp enough that Adora must shield her eyes. The sound is deafening. The breaking of glass, the smashing of stone, the splintering of prison bars—

It takes Adora far too long to locate Teela.

In the end, they meet entirely by accident. Adora almost misses the moment—the moment where Teela brushes past her, heading *somewhere* with her head ducked down toward the floor. She seems determined not to meet Adora's eyes, but Adora nonetheless spins around, a hand flying out to grasp at Teela's shoulder.

"Teela?" she gasps. "Where have you been?"

Adora has not seen Teela since the confrontation with the King and Queen in the hangar. She's not sure what happened to her—and is especially unsure of how Teela is recovering from her rather traumatic encounter with Chasm.

Teela shrugs in Adora's grasp, still refusing to raise her chin and meet Adora's eyes. "Here. There. Everywhere."

Adora's eyebrows knit together. "Are you avoiding me?"

Teela scoffs. "Hardly. I've had little time to think, let alone speak with Adam or yourself." She taps pointedly at a space on her armor—one where a medal once sat, if Adora remembers correctly. "I've been demoted," says Teela, with a sigh. "Which means I'm fully occupied with the worst chores imaginable."

"They *demoted* you?"

They , being Adora's parents. Teela nods.

"For what?" demands Adora. "For doing the right thing? For not being a coward, like they were?"

"The King and Queen do not like to be wrong," Teela reminds her. "And because they cannot punish you for their foolishness, and they are too proud of Adam to even accuse him of disobedience...they have instead used me as an outlet for their rage. I did not keep you both in check, so I am to blame."

"That's ridiculous. You couldn't have stopped us either way."

Teela shrugs yet again. "It is not about what is true. It is about what they feel. And it is not my place to argue, either—I am here to serve Eternia's royals. So if this is what I must do to protect my people's future, then so be it. I will suffer the consequences and work my way back to a position of trust. Perhaps someday they will even realize that I was in the right."

Adora doesn't quite succeed in stifling a disbelieving snort. "Knowing my parents, I wouldn't count on it."

Teela cracks a smirk. "Believe me. I am not holding my breath."

They laugh together, for a moment. And Adora almost wishes that she had met Teela elsewhere. On Etheria perhaps, as one of the Bright Moon guards. She thinks Teela would like it better there. And she thinks Teela would have made a far more agreeable bodyguard than someone like Cleo, someone who wasn't prepared for the dangers that constantly befall Etheria and Adora herself.

Well, okay. *Agreeable* might be the wrong word to use when describing Teela. But Teela would certainly be wiser. More mature.

Someone Adora can count on.

And Adora almost suggests it—she almost suggests that Teela come with her. That she accompany Adora to Etheria.

But in the end, Adora does not do it. And it's not because she doesn't want to. Adora simply knows that the offer will not be accepted—that Teela considers her place to be here, alongside her people. She would rather suffer a thousand demotions than let this city fall apart in her absence. She wants to be here. She wants to do everything she can to secure a bright future for the Eternian future.

And Teela will do what's right when it counts. Even at a cost to herself.

"Teela," Adora says, stepping closer. Her voice lowered to a whisper. "I need to ask something of you. Well. Two things, really."

Teela raises an eyebrow. "Will this get me into further trouble?" she asks, though she doesn't seem particularly worried by the prospect. Adora is face-to-face with a woman who has little to lose, and has already tasted something like righteous rebellion. It's probably difficult for her to go back to following orders as perfectly as she once did.

Adora smiles. "Probably."

In the end, Adora and Adam leave a note.

In most situations, she would have preferred to talk face-to-face—discuss the matter like adults. But she knows the King and Queen will object to their impending departure. Perhaps they will even try to sabotage the ships and keep Adora from leaving.

And if they hate the idea of Adora leaving Eternia behind, they will certainly despise the idea of Adora taking Adam with her. Who knows what they'll do if Adora even *suggests* the idea of leaving the King and Queen with an empty nest?

No. It's most definitely for the best that they'll discover the truth long after Adam, Adora, and Catra are gone.

They write the note together—Adora on the front of the paper, Adam on the back. Adora explains that she must return home—that she must travel to Etheria and ensure that everyone is recovering from Chasm's control. She admits to them that she's not cut out to be royalty (well, not *that* kind of royalty, anyway) and that her future lies on Etheria, not on Eternia.

It's not exactly a heartfelt few paragraphs. Just a perfunctory explanation of why she's leaving so abruptly. Adora doesn't feel like she owes them more than that, and she doubts she'd be able to satisfy them anyway. By the end of her note, all she can offer is

a suggestion—a suggestion regarding how Eternos should move forward, and who might be best to take the next throne.

Adam, meanwhile, writes a far more detailed description of his feelings. He tells his parents that he's uncertain of his destiny—that he needs time to explore his options amidst the wider universe. Only then can he decide whether he's meant to be a king, a hero, or something else entirely.

He also does what Adora does not. He promises to return home someday. To return to his people on Eternos. Adora can't blame him for feeling more attached to this place than she does—even if she doesn't share the sentiment. She can only hope that his parents don't *murder him* the second he steps foot on Lenarian soil.

But he doesn't promise to be king. And Adora is proud to see him forging his own destiny.

Teela agrees to deliver the note on Adam and Adora's behalf. In fact, it is Teela who leads them back into the hangar that stores their ships, who stocks their cargo bays with supplies. Adora is glad for help—and is especially glad that many of the guards still regard Teela as their captain. The other guards don't seem inclined to stop them, not in the least. They likely figure that if Teela is helping them, it is the right thing to do.

"Finally," Catra sighs as she begins to climb the ramp of the nearest ship—near sprinting in her eagerness. "We're going *home*."

"And I'm leaving the planet," Adam breathes, like he still cannot believe the words he utters. He hasn't started climbing the ramp of his ship yet, but he stares at it like it beckons to him. "I never thought—"

Teela, who stands beside them, flicks Adam's shoulder. "I expect you to behave while off-planet, Prince Adam. No pranks. And I

certainly hope you give less headaches to the royal guards on Etheria than you do here."

"No promises," Adam says. "Though it'll be far less fun to prank the guards if you're not there to yell at me."

"How devastating it must be for you."

He smirks at her, and she grins back. She's joking, Adora realizes. Teela is actually cracking a joke.

"Good luck," Teela says, more seriously. "It's always been hard to imagine you as a king, I'll admit. But...it is surprisingly easy to imagine you as a hero. You've always cared more for people than for politics. And it is for that reason that you'll change the universe for the better."

He wraps Teela in a hug—one that surprises Adora, but doesn't seem to surprise Teela. She leans into him as though holding him here, beside her, for as long as she can. Keeping him from leaving so soon. The embrace lasts and lingers for quite some time.

"As your oldest friend, I hope you will listen when I say this," he murmurs into Teela's hair, squeezing her tighter on the last word. He then extends his arms out—holding her in front of himself, instead of against. They are able to look each other in the eye.

"Please, for the love of the Goddess, *stop being so uptight* ."

He releases her. She tips her head back and laughs.

"I'm breaking all these rules for you, aren't I?" she retorts. "You should be more than satisfied."

Adam gives an enormous roll of his eyes. Saying, without words, *I suppose* .

"Speaking of which…" Teela gestures to the ship that Adam is supposed to pilot. "Shouldn't you board? Meet your destiny?"

Adam grins. “I suppose I should.”

He shoots one last glance at Teela before jogging up the ramp. When the hatch hisses open, he surveys the interior like it’s a foreign planet—utterly enthralled and delighted by what he sees. Adora can only imagine how he’ll react when visiting an *actual* foreign planet, and not just the ship that carries him there.

With Adam and Catra both settling into ships, Adora and Teela are all that remain. Adora clears her throat, trying to defuse the awkwardness that sits between them. She is leaving Teela with a mighty burden to manage. And it’s left Adora feeling quite guilty—this determination to push the responsibility on someone else, for once.

“I recommended that the King and Queen name you their successor,” Adora says. “In the note.”

She pulls the note from her pocket and hands it to Teela. It’s enclosed in an envelope, but not sealed. She doesn’t really mind if Teela reads it. Teela likely should read it, since Teela will be most likely to inherit the consequences of that note. Whether her parents choose to punish someone for letting Adam and Adora leave, or actually follow Adora’s advice, Teela will bear their ire or expectations.

“I still do not really know what to say,” Teela replies, blushing.

“You don’t need to say anything. As far as I’m concerned, you’d be a far better ruler than either of them. You know how to draw the line. How to do what’s right, rather than what’s convenient.”

Teela gives a soft laugh. “That’s high praise, coming from She-Ra. Savior of the Universe.”

“I probably wouldn’t have saved the universe without your help. Without Adam and Catra’s too. Being She-Ra...it’s never enough. Not without people willing to do right. To help me when it counts.”

There's a heavy pause. Teela clutches the note close to her chest, as though it is some precious gem left in her care.

"Do you think you will ever come back?" asks Teela, and Adora is surprised that she sounds hopeful. Like she wants Adora to return someday.

Adora shakes her head. "Not to become Queen, no."

"That is not what I mean," says Teela, with a head shake of her own. "I am asking whether you will come back, in general. I just…" Teela sighs. "I think we could have been friends. Under different circumstances, of course. If I hadn't been so determined to follow orders—"

Adora smiles. "We're already friends, Teela. We had a rocky start, sure. But when it mattered...you helped me. I won't forget that."

Teela returns the smile, seeming pleased.

"And who knows? Maybe I'll come back someday," Adora says, placing a hand on Teela's shoulder. "To visit Queen Teela, hopefully. I'm sure she'll make Eternos a much better place to visit."

Teela puffs her chest out, seemingly inspired by the words—and made all the more determined to do that which Adora says. To become Queen and make Eternia a better place than it is now.

"Adora!"

Catra pokes her head out from the ship's hatch. She jabs a thumb backward, indicating that Adora should board as soon as possible.

"Let's get a move on!" Catra shouts. "With every second we're still here, we risk an interruption from the *other,* less-friendly royal highnesses."

And Adora knows that Catra is right. Best they leave before any unexpected obstacles present themselves. It is not often for Adora that things go as planned, and so far, this plan has been far too smooth. She better take advantage of their rare luck.

"Goodbye, Teela," Adora says as she takes the first steps up that long ramp—the ramp that will lead her home. "Good luck."

"And good luck to you, She-Ra," Teela calls back, her volume dissipating with every step up that ramp that Adora takes. "Slayer of Horde Prime, Vanquisher of Chasm. I hope you find the peace you deserve."

So do I , thinks Adora. She can't turn into She-Ra right now. She can't even heal a papercut, or summon a weapon. All she can do is wish, desperately, that no further dangers present themselves in the meantime.

But maybe that's something of a relief too. That Adora can't control what happens, can't change the course of a disaster. She can only live—and let the universe happen to her.

It's not long before Adora is at the top of the ramp, where she turns around to face the hanger. Her eyes find Teela's face, so similar to the Sorceress's, one last time. A face that might soon represent all that remains of Adora's people. A face that may break a royal bloodline and bring Eternia into a new age.

Adora can only hope that this is the future that everyone wants: Adora and Catra are going home. Adam is seeing the universe. Teela is next in line for the throne. Perhaps, if she's truly lucky, only her parents will be disappointed by this course of events.

Maybe there really is such a thing as a happy ending.

Adora keeps her eyes on Teela as the ship's hatch slides shut, hissing as it seals itself closed. Catra is there, just inside the door. She wraps her arms around Adora's middle and tugs her in for a kiss, one that Adora returns with hungry enthusiasm. It's the best

feeling in the universe. Being alive, and well-rested, and free to kiss Catra as she pleases.

"Let's go home," Catra whispers into her lips. And Adora can't think of a single thing more wonderful than that word.

Home . Etheria.

The flight back to Etheria is long. Three days long, to be precise. With Adam's ship occupying the same lane of hyperspace alongside them.

Normally, Adora would resent the length of the trip. She's always been impatient. Fidgety. Nervous. She likes to face the destination as soon as possible, without much care for the journey between. And according to Catra, it's that tendency that makes so many of Adora's plans fall apart.

" *You're so focused on the end goal—on getting to point A, then B, then C* ," Catra once said, " *You miss all the details between the points. All the little half-seconds where a shoe goes from dropping to dropped. Because that's where things always go wrong, in my experience. In the in-between.* "

And Catra was right. Adora always anticipated big things, big events, but never anticipated or made time for the small ones. For her, it really was always about the end-goal. The next step. The win to be worked toward.

But now that Adora doesn't have one of those—an end-goal, a plan beyond getting back to Etheria—Adora cannot help but love the in-between. The aimless, innumerable moments that separate the starting point and destination.

She spends the three day trip sprawled on a cot with Catra, tangled between and within Catra's warm arms. She lets Catra whisper jokes into her ear. She kisses her way across Catra's body, then vice versa. And then sinks back into a comfortable sleep with Catra's back snuggled tightly into Adora's chest.

They probably sleep *more* than eight hours a day during that three day trip. And maybe it's unhealthy. Maybe it's lazy. But it's also far too enjoyable to do that—to oversleep together. Especially when the general act of falling asleep has only *recently* ceased to be a rarity for Adora.

"I love doing this," Adora tells Catra, once. Or twice. Or five billion times. In this particular instance, though, she has just woken up from a nap at Catra's side, nestled into a too-small cot in the spaceship's quarters together.

And while that nap contained a few unavoidable nightmares...they were nothing Adora could not conquer, even within the confines of the dream. Knowing that Chasm is gone, truly gone, has filled Adora with a confidence that persists even while sleeping.

Because she won, in the end. She broke free of Chasm. She is strong enough, and will be strong enough again, should she need to be. A nightmare cannot change that knowledge. And it cannot make her forget it, either. Not for long.

"I love waking up next to you," Adora continues as she brushes a stray hair from Catra's face. "I really don't think there's anything better."

"Wrong," mutters Catra, groggy-eyed and sleep-slurred. One of her eyes is still fully closed. The blue one. Adora wants to kiss her eyelashes, count them with her lips and measure the way they fall over Catra's cheeks.

"Oh yeah?" asks Adora, nuzzling closer to Catra's face. "And what could possibly be better?"

"Waking up next to *you* ," Catra answers, without hesitation.

Adora snorts and presses even closer, kissing that still-closed eyelid. Beneath the sheets, she weaves her legs between Catra's, tying them together. "Sap."

"So are you," Catra retorts. "And your feet are cold."

“Good,” replies Adora with a smirk.

“Jerk.”

“Uh-huh,” agrees Adora, and then she settles back under the covers, arms braced beneath her body. “I’m gonna go back to sleep now.”

“Seriously?” Catra asks, laughing. “Why’d you wake me up if you were just going to pass out again?”

“If I fall asleep again,” Adora says, “I’ll get to wake up next to you again. Which is, as I mentioned, is *basically* the greatest thing in the world. To me, at least. Especially after everything.”

Catra hums and strokes Adora’s hair.

“Yeah, well. I guess you have a point,” Catra murmurs. “Sweet dreams, princess. See you in a few more hours.”

“Sweet dreams,” Adora agrees, with a nod. And then she’s emptying her head of words and thoughts beyond *warmth* and *love* . Emptying, emptying, until she’s light enough to float when the waters of sleep wash over her, pulling her back into an ocean of dreams that no longer scare her.

Adora and Catra are greeted by the world’s tightest group hug when they return to Etheria. Glimmer and Bow practically tackle them as soon as Catra and Adora descend from the ship’s ramp. Even Micah and Angella indulge in a quick embrace—though they leave the spine-crushing hugs to Glimmer and Bow alone.

“What happened?” Glimmer demands. “You just stopped calling us and we were worried sick—”

“Sorry!” says Adora. “Lenaria had planetary interference, so we couldn’t call you until we were back in space. The good news is that we beat Chasm—”

“We know,” Bow says.

“What?” Adora asks. “How?”

“There were a few people who kept forgetting to take their potion,” Bow explains. He is excited beyond belief, beyond description, as he crushes his arms around Adora and Catra both. “When they stopped falling back under Chasm’s spell...we knew something must have changed. That you must have destroyed her.”

“Not destroyed, exactly,” Adora says. “Just...trapped. Trapped where she won’t be able to cause more damage for a while.”

“Unfortunately the bitch isn’t easy to kill,” Catra mutters. “If she can be killed at all.”

“Still,” says Bow. “I am so, so, *so* proud of you both. You’ll need to tell us all about it. In fact, we’re going to have a celebration. A celebration for Chasm’s defeat, and your return, and—”

“Can we maybe wait on the celebration?” Adora pleads. “It’s been a pretty eventful last few days—

“Wait,” Glimmer says, stepping back for a moment. She points her finger between the two ships that just landed, then points the finger between Catra and Adora. “If you’re both on this ship…” she begins, slowly, “...then who’s flying the other one?”

Adam must take that as his cue to emerge. The hatch to the second ship opens with a sharp hiss of air, one accompanied by a thick but brief cloud of steam. There’s a clattering as the ramp pushes forth, extending from the hatch. Making a path to follow.

And, then, with the thump of footsteps on metal...Adam begins his descent toward the ground. It’s clear by his posture that he’s embarrassed. Self conscious. It is, after all, the first time that Adam has ever encountered people from another planet besides his own.

Well, the *second* time if you count meeting Catra—

"Uh, hello?" he greets, from the ramp. A hand waving from side to side. "My name is Adam."

"Adam," Bow repeats, like the name is something strange and incomprehensible.

"Yup," says Catra with a smile. "Like Adora said, we had a pretty eventful trip. Including—"

"Meeting my family," Adora finishes for her.

"Your…" Glimmer can't seem to arrange her words into any semblance of a logical sentence. "Your *family* ? The First Ones?"

Adora nods.

"Queen Glimmer...King Bow…" she says. "I'd like you to meet my twin brother: Adam, Prince of the Eternians."

Adam just gives another wave. His smile is wide and utterly *ecstatic* .

For a moment, everyone simply stares at him in silence. They are too stunned to truly react. Too stunned, at least, until Glimmer gasps and smacks a hand into her own forehead.

"Holy shit," Glimmer exclaims, after a pause. "You mean to tell me there are *two* of them?"

There was so much to tell. About Eternos. About Adora's family. About what Chasm had planned, about how Adora, Adam, and Catra ultimately stopped her.

They're all listening to the story—Bow, Glimmer, Angella, Micah, the princesses. Staring at Adora in a way that she has now become unaccustomed to. She's no longer used to being seen as

this . Savior of the universe yet again, rather than the sleep-deprived, trembling mess she became for so many months.

Though Adora won't be saving much of anyone in the near future. Her friends are quite startled to hear about the depletion of She-Ra's magic and the loss of Adora's ability to transform and heal. They gasp; demand to know when the power will return. But Adora simply shrugs as Catra glares daggers at them all.

"It doesn't matter right now," says Adora, looking directly at Catra as she says the words. "I'm taking a vacation. The universe will have to sort out its own problems right now, without me."

There's some murmurings and grumblings, but no one argues. It's a frightening thought—to be without She-Ra for an indefinite period of time. Frightening for Adora, most of all. But they'll all have to adjust. They'll all have to learn how to live without her.

At least they're not in the middle of a war this time.

Angella folds her hands in front of herself and proceeds to scrutinize the center of the conference table—the center of the table where they all sit, all these princesses and queens and kings and special guests. Even Adam has received his own chair at the table's circumference. He gapes at every pastel piece of architecture, every article of clothing, every word that leaves an Etherian's mouth.

"And what of the sword?" asks Angella. "We must ensure that it is never used. But we must also ensure that it is never destroyed."

Adora nods. "We'll have to hide it," she says. "And guard over it as best we can."

"We may not be able to guard it forever," remarks Micah, voice low with foreboding. "All things have a way of re-emerging with time."

"That's Chasm's curse as well as ours," Adora says, her hands curling into fists. "She never goes away. She can't die. Can't be

destroyed. Her magic can only be moved from one place to the next."

Just like the magic at the Heart of Etheria , thinks Adora. Though she doesn't say it aloud.

Adora looks up, directly into Micah's eyes. Though she allows her gaze to sweep the face of every person in the room.

"But things have been hidden and protected on Etheria before," continues Adora. "If we can keep the Horde and Horde Prime from taking this planet from us, surely we can keep someone from stealing one lousy sword."

"We'll need to be very careful on the way out," says Glimmer, running her hands along the wall, feeling the moisture that clings to the cool, underground earth. "I'll be laying every magical booby-trap imaginable. We won't be able to backtrack, not at all __"

"We won't be backtracking," Catra interrupts her, shoulders shifting in agitation. She glares at the sword held in Adora's hand, swaddled in a blanket. Though that sword is nothing close to a baby, Adora thinks. That's for sure. It's something that could end a planet—end a universe.

And it's now Adora's responsibility to keep it safe.

"Let's just get this over with," Catra grumbles, glancing at the caverns all around them, half-collapsed and burned in some places. "I really don't like being here."

They traverse the cavern, determinedly approaching the green mountain in the distance. And by mountain, Adora means *body* —the long-dead, dismembered, utterly *scorched* body of the Guardian that once protected the Heart, its corpse left half-disintegrated by Shadow Weaver's fiery final defense against the beast.

“I can’t imagine why,” says Bow, voice pitched high with fear as he looks upon the long-defeated monster. He nocks an arrow and points it at the body—just in case the monster somehow springs back to life and attacks.

But it doesn’t move as they walk past. Not at all. It remains still, and silent, and very much *dead* . Eventually, Bow is able to return his bow to his back and shake off his trepidation. Though Adora and Catra both can’t help glancing back at it—at the monster that almost ended their very lives.

But it’s gone now. Same as the woman that killed it. Same as the many *other* threats they’ve battled.

These caverns to the planet’s core haven’t housed anything in years. Not since Adora deactivated the Heart of Etheria and claimed all the magic it siphoned from the planet. Since then, the tunnels have sat empty. Dilapidated. Adora had no intention of visiting them again, but fate has a funny way of defying Adora’s expectations.

Rather than attempting to *free* a type of magic at the planet’s core, Adora is now trying to trap magic there. The most dangerous magic she has ever encountered.

Chasm’s magic, trapped within what was once the Sword of Protection.

“Why didn’t you want Adam to come?” Glimmer asks. “He said he wanted to help.”

“If the magic of He-Man returns to him someday,” Adora says, “he’ll be one of the few people who can fight his way past any traps we set. His magic is just as powerful as She-Ra’s.”

Bow raises a disapproving eyebrow. “You’re saying you don’t trust your own brother?”

“I’m saying that my brother has a lot to learn,” Adora replies. “I don’t think he’d try to free Chasm on purpose, but he’s new to the

wider universe. He could be tricked. Manipulated. It's best that he simply doesn't know where we put the Sword. The fewer people who know, the safer we'll all be."

They keep walking. Eventually, they see it—the platform where Adora lay dying, poisoned by Horde Prime, cradled in Catra's arms. The magical Heart that once illuminated the whole cavern is extinguished—nothing but a darkened, long-dead prism overhead, providing them no light.

Catra slips her hand into Adora's. Adora squeezes it tightly. She can see the tension in Catra's shoulders—a side effect of returning to such a trauma-tainted locale.

But Adora remembers more than just the terrible things that happened here. She remembers being tugged back from the cusp of death by Catra's confession of love. She remembers her own trembling breaths, made unsteady by euphoria, as Catra leaned down to kiss her. She remembers turning into She-Ra, powered by love, and welcoming the Heart's magic into herself.

"This place isn't all bad, you know," Adora whispers, to Catra. "I mean...it's where you and I—"

"Had our first kiss?" Catra finishes for her, smiling broadly. "Yeah. I definitely remember that."

Though the wistfulness in Catra's expression wavers noticeably as she considers her surroundings, examining them for additional dangers. Her eyes find the sword yet again, staring at its blankets with a murderous sort of accusation—

"I-it's also where Chasm..." Catra stammers, seeming too choked up to speak. "Where she tried to convince you—"

The sword seems to grow colder, and Adora swears that it's radiating ice through the blankets. Infecting her hand with frostbite.

With her other hand, Adora gives Catra's fingers another squeeze. Her attention focuses, quite purposely, on the warmth of her touch.

"It was just a dream," says Adora. "One that we don't need to think about anymore."

Eventually, they reach the end of the platform. For this next part, Adora and Glimmer will need to separate from the others. Only Glimmer can raise Adora up toward where the heart used to be, and only Glimmer can secure the sword in place with magic.

Adora leans in and kisses Catra's forehead before releasing her. She then turns to Glimmer, who is already tracing a rune beneath their feet. A rune that glows and forms a circle beneath them, a solid circle that immediately begins to rise—levitating them upwards like one of the Fright Zone's prison lifts. It raises them higher, higher, rendering Bow and Catra increasingly smaller within her vision.

And then they stop. Glimmer and Adora stand, suspended by a spell, at the very center of where the planet's magic was once stored.

Adora raises the sword, freeing it from its blankets. She doesn't utter the words that activate it—she'd rather die than do that. But she does give the sword one last grip of her fingers before she lets it go forever.

"Ready?" asks Glimmer.

Adora nods.

Glimmer begins tracing runes. A rune to take the sword from Adora's hand, levitating it midair and keeping it there. She releases it; steps back to examine the spells that Glimmer casts next. A rune for a backwards containment spell—one that should keep the sword separated from *most* people who'd enter this place, seeking its power. Though there might be a few gifted

sorcerers (or magical beings) who could break the containment with concentrated effort.

Glimmer casts more spells. More layers of containment. A circle of eternal fire. A sphere of solid diamond. She casts shining warnings into the air—warnings that speak of unspeakable, unstoppable danger to the whole universe, the kind of danger that will only grant devastation, not power.

"That's it," says Glimmer, breathing heavily from all her hard work. "That's the best I can do."

Adora takes a moment to examine just how trapped the sword is, utterly contained by magic, before she places a hand on Glimmer's shoulder. "You did great. Thank you, Glimmer."

Though, of course, the fear is not whether the sword will escape. The fear is that someone someday will come here, blast past the protections, and free the magic that lies within.

But Adora cannot dwell on that at the moment. She cannot dwell on a future that does not yet—and may not *ever*— exist. She can only do what she can. She can protect the sword in every way that she can think how, and forgive herself for any protections they might forget.

Glimmer just nods—and continues to manipulate the rune that controls their magical lift. They are soon floating downwards—back to Catra and Bow, who wait patiently beneath them.

"Don't thank me yet," says Glimmer. "I still need to lay plenty of traps in the hallways on our way back."

They land at the platform and make their way back from where they came. Before they leave for good, Adora shoots the sword one last glance. Glimmer's magic glows brightly around it—illuminating the whole cavern. And it pains Adora somewhat, to know that there is yet another terrible power at the core of her planet.

Glimmer does exactly as they planned upon their walk back to the surface—she sets traps. She lays trap after magical trap upon the floors and walls: nets, quicksand, paralyzing darts, doors that magically lead to the Whispering Woods, tongues of flame, trapdoors that will drop people in reverse, flinging them to the aboveground. She even casts an eternal *confusion* spell—a spell that will render most people unable to navigate the caverns without completely turning themselves around.

Which means the sword should be safe from almost everyone.

Almost everyone. Adora is sure that there may someday be a powerful sorcerer, or perhaps even a future wielder of She-Ra or He-Man's powers, that will break through these defenses like they're wet paper. If Adora and Catra broke through to Chasm's first prison, surely someone will someday break through this one too.

She can only hope that *someday* will not arrive for a long, long time. And if it does...she hopes there's someone strong enough to keep Chasm at bay. Someone as strong as She-Ra. Maybe someone even stronger.

But it won't be Adora, that is for certain. Adora will keep this sword trapped and safe until her dying breath. She won't live to see Chasm returned.

Though, as she stares at Catra, residual sunlight from the exit reflecting and streaming across Catra's freckles... she thinks about this. The exit. They're exiting this cavern, yes, but it's more than that. They're exiting the realm of Chasm's manipulations, the prison of this extended nightmare, the guilt that has haunted Adora for so long. It is an exit from all the things that kept Adora from a happy future.

It only takes a few small steps—to leave the Crystal Castle and walk out into the sun.

epilogue

Chapter Summary

The after.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora and Catra build themselves a cabin in the woods.

Razz is getting older. Adora thinks that, at one point, Razz must have possessed some form of immortality. But with the destruction of the Heart of Etheria all those years ago, that immortality must have finally abandoned her. Razz's wrinkles grow more defined. Her hands shake and ache with arthritis. She sometimes forgets what she's doing or who she's talking to (though, thankfully, she continues to tell the difference between Adora and Mara).

Adora and Catra are more than happy to provide Razz help and company. While they love living with Glimmer and Bow in Bright Moon, it carries its own annoyances. Annoyances that continue to weigh on them as the years drag on. They're constantly gawked at by guards and staff and pretty much anyone who doesn't know them well. They inevitably get roped into political affairs that they *don't* want to be involved in.

And with She-Ra's power still not fully recovered, Adora doesn't like the pressure that comes with staying in the castle. She can transform into She-Ra, maybe even summon a sword on occasion. But her powers are still enormously weakened—she can't heal, she can't even maintain the transformation for more than a half-hour. One of Entrapta's lesser bots could probably defeat her in a fight.

The truth is, Adora is just not some big hero anymore. She's not the universe's continued savior. She's someone smaller. Someone

more insignificant to the universe. Someone who owes nothing to anyone but herself. She doesn't need to be at the center of anything—doesn't need to be involved in every little political or peace-making decision.

But maybe that's how Adora likes it. It's nice, in fact. To not be personally responsible for keeping the world—and the universe—spinning on its axis.

So Catra and Adora build the cabin. It's not far from Bright Moon—within a short walk—and of course Glimmer can teleport there instantly in any sort of emergency. And perhaps it's nothing all that fancy, but Catra and Adora like it quite a lot. They love living at the center of the Whispering Woods's splendor, and they especially like sharing their company with Razz.

Razz, whose shack abuts theirs. Razz, who loves to listen to their stories and recite exciting tales of her own. Razz, who never judges or gawks at them, who never asks more than what she absolutely needs. Razz, who only wants to share the wonders of Etheria's magic with someone, with *them.*

They make a point to never eat Razz's cooking but instead offer theirs to her. And Razz is all too happy to join them for meals—it's a miracle what some proper nutrition (nutrition beyond pies and cookies that are *maybe* rocks) can do to improve an old woman's health.

Adora never expected Catra to want to do this—to help her take care of Razz. But Catra seems to love the old woman even more than Adora does. It's still something novel and wonderful to them both: that adults (well, adults older than themselves) can actually be kind. That they can ask for help without ultimatums, and provide it in turn.

On more than one occasion, Adora and Catra wonder what it would have been like—if things had been different. If Razz had raised them here, in the woods, instead of Shadow Weaver hoarding them in Bright Moon. What would their world have

looked like without constant fear, without endless struggle? Who would they have been with a constant source of love in their lives?

But it's no use. There's no changing the past. Chasm taught Adora that, if nothing else.

Adora and Catra's cabin is modest, but beautiful. Less luxurious than the Bright Moon bedrooms but replete with furniture and memorabilia and plants they grow and gather from the woods all around them. They're happy there. Happier than they've ever been.

And it's certainly something wonderful when they have their friends over for dinner—Bow, Glimmer, Angella, Micah, Castaspella, Sea Hawk, all the princesses and Razz herself gathered around their table, sharing stories and food and their continued gladness at being well and whole.

(And it's far cozier to have these meals in the cabin, Adora thinks, rather than in that echoing, too-fancy dining room in Bright Moon.)

It's been three years since Chasm was defeated. The sword hasn't been touched since. Adora sometimes wanders there, to the Crystal Castle, just to make sure all the defenses are in place. Just to make sure there's no sign of a recent intruder. But there's always nothing. The Castle—and the tunnels beneath—still look the same as they have since the day Adora hid the sword there.

Adam remains a massive part of Adora's life. The power of He-Man returned to Adam shortly after he arrived on Etheria—a sudden reemergence spurred by his need to help some villagers during a forest fire. He had been trying to single handedly hold up a collapsing building when, lo and behold, he transformed. No sword. No runestone. Just the power choosing him, just as Adora figured it would. It was all that allowed Adam to keep that building upright.

It’s a story Adora knows. And though it’s not the one Adora wants for herself anymore, she is happy for him.

Since then, Adam spends most of his time off-world. While he loved staying with Adora on Etheria, receiving He-Man’s power made it clear that his destiny lay elsewhere.

He answers many of the calls for help that are intended for She-Ra. The universe has come to appreciate him in the same ways they once appreciated Adora. He battles space pirates and solves diplomatic disputes and battles the occasional megalomaniac. He keeps the peace in the universe, much in the way that Adora used to. He is busy, endlessly busy.

Though he always makes time to stay in contact with Adora and Catra.

He calls Adora frequently—seeking advice on his latest missions and complaining of his latest heartache from his many romances throughout the galaxy. His visits are less frequent than his calls, but they’re often nonetheless. Etheria is a much-needed respite from his many exhausting adventures. When he visits the cabin, he is always quiet and contemplative—soaking in the peace that seems to exist exclusively in this stretch of the woods. Enjoying the company of family that doesn’t expect quite so much of him.

Adam, unlike Adora, does visit Eternia from time-to-time. He keeps Adora updated on the state of affairs there. Their parents hold the vain hope that Adam or Adora will someday claim the throne, but after years of refusal from Adam and Adora both, they’ve finally relented and named Teela as next-in-line.

Teela accepted, of course. Just as Adora knew she would.

“*It is something interesting, certainly,”* Teela once wrote to Adora, in a letter. “*I do not plan to have children, so it is unclear what might happen after me. Perhaps they will elect someone to the following throne*.”

Adora smiled at that. Wouldn’t that be something?

Overall, the universe is more peaceful than Adora has ever known it to be. Peaceful, save a single warning from Adam.

"I keep butting heads with this one space pirate," Adam tells her during one of his visits. "Strange individual. Wears a mask that looks like a skull. He's actually quite the fighter, though his crew is probably the worst, most incompetent group in the galaxy."

Adora laughs at the mental images. This person—he certainly *sounds* strange, if that description is any indication. A mask that looks like a skull? It's tacky, if you ask Adora.

Though Adora is startled to discover concern—real, genuine concern—creasing Adam's features.

"But he keeps trying to force me to tell him where Eternia is," continues Adam, in a low voice. "I don't like it. Not one bit."

"He knows you're from Eternia?"

Adam nods. "I did not tell him. But yes. Somehow...he just knows." His jaw clenches. "And I think he wants something from our people."

Adora squints. "And what do you think he wants?"

Adam shrugs.

"I suppose I'll find out, won't I?"

It's Thursday. Which means, invariably, that it is berry-picking day.

Adora and Catra are out in the woods with Razz, stripping the vines and the trees of their fruit. Razz is fully occupied with this task, hardly paying attention to either of them. She's too enthralled by the question of how many pies they will make, and what different varieties they might choose.

Adora and Catra, meanwhile, linger several steps away. Adora's arm is slung around Catra's waist, holding her close. They whisper jokes and stories to one another, reveling in each other's company.

The sunlight hangs low in the sky, its rays slanted and warm as they trickle through the canopy above. A particular ray stripes across Catra's face, illuminating those perfect freckles of hers, and this time Adora kisses every one while Catra mockingly insists that she knock it off—that they have berries to pick. A very important task.

It's hard to believe that they're here. That they finally made it to this—to years of uninterrupted peace, to long hours of uninterrupted happiness. She has Catra, her friends, her family (the one that she made for herself). It's more than Adora could ever want.

She's afraid, still. Afraid that something will come and threaten the universe. That something will demand that Adora sacrifice this bliss, or perhaps attempt to steal it from her.

But Adora has made peace with that fear too. Perhaps something will arrive someday. Perhaps something will send Adora back into the fray, back into battles and quests and tug-of-wars between good and evil. Perhaps someday Chasm will return, or she'll be plagued with some other form of evil.

But today is not that day. Today is Thursday—the day she picks berries with Catra and Razz. And tomorrow is Friday, the day they bake those berries into pies. She's getting older. Too old, perhaps, to dwell on *somedays* while ignoring this precious time passing right before her eyes.

Adora hears Catra curse and turns from the bush she was just clearing of berries. Catra is standing beside her, one hand clutched around a single finger. Adora can see the blood beading there—right on the fingertip. Catra must have caught it on a thorn.

Still cursing, Catra prepares to wrap her finger in her shirt, hoping to stifle the budding blood flow, but Adora steps forward and stops her. She wraps Catra's hand in hers.

"Let me," says Adora.

And Adora closes her eyes. It's the first time Adora has attempted this in a long while.

Adora reaches deep inside herself, searching for the magic to right all things. She imagines that little cut closing, the blood restoring itself, the thorn falling away. She hears Catra inhale sharply, senses the glow as the magic spreads from Adora's body into hers.

It's harder than it's ever been—pulling this magic from herself. There's so much less of it than there used to be. But for Catra, Adora will try. For Catra, Adora will always try.

"Adora," Catra gasps. Adora opens her eyes to see Catra's finger fully healed—the skin unblemished and uninjured. Catra's eyes are wide on Adora's face, gaping in disbelief. She knows as well as Adora does that Adora hasn't healed anyone in years.

Adora just smiles and drags Catra's finger to her lips, kissing it softly.

"Come on," Adora says, releasing Catra's now-healed hand and jerking her head toward the fruit-laden bushes. "These berries aren't going to pick themselves."

END.

Chapter End Notes

endings are hard. but they're inevitable nonetheless.

It's difficult to believe I started writing anachronism in June of 2020, and now we're here, over a year later, at the end of the second book with nearly 270,000 words written. This story

gave me joy all throughout the pandemic. I've been working nonstop on it from the moment I opened up google docs on June 27, 2020 to the moment I hit post on this epilogue. An endless cycle of writing, editing, summarizing, editing again, posting. It's hard to believe that, after everything, it's truly, finally *done*. A part of me worried I'd never finish it. But a stronger part of me was determined to do so, and so here it is. Posted for the world to see. I somehow managed to crank this shit out while finishing college and working a job and struggling through a pandemic.

I want to say thank you to everyone who's stuck with the story as it was posted (and especially those who have been following since anachronism). I know it wasn't easy. I know this book was very different from the last. I hope you know I wouldn't have been able to write over 250,000 words in such a short time without your continuous support. This is the first plot-oriented series, (fanwork or otherwise) that I've been able to complete. That means a lot to me. I never expected the chasm saga to be as well received as it was and am still stunned that even the sequel seemed to hold people's attention. That usually doesn't happen in fanfic and I'll forever be grateful.

The next thing I want to announce is that I'm going to be taking an indefinite break from writing She-Ra fic. I know that makes this ending more bitter than sweet, but I'm working on a original novel now. I've worked on other original novels in the past, but I've never finished them, and I want that to change. I'm hoping that the endless writing exercise I've gotten from the chasm saga will actually push me into completing an original story of my own.

Speaking of original characters, I remain touched that y'all were so accepting of Chasm as an OC. OCs can be so tough to introduce in fanfics, but people really seemed to love her presence and her personality and her machinations (and her sexiness, apparently). It really means a lot to me. I hope you all continue to be confused when people remind you that she

isn't actually a canon villain but a MILF made up by a fanfic author. I know I'm still confused about it.

Anyway, if you want to stay in touch or say goodbye, head over to my twitter! I also invite you to read my other fics. Or don't. Up to you.

As always, remember to comment! Tell me what you think! I can only hope I succeeded as Noelle's stand-in by attempting to continue this series.

End Notes

my catradora playlist (songs are organized by the events in the series).
my tumblr
my twitter

Also—please consider helping a **BLM-related cause**

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!